

HISTORICAL COMMENTARY ON THE OLD TESTAMENT

Genesis 1-11

by Jan Christian Gertz

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GENESIS 1-11

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PEETERS
LEUVEN – PARIS – BRISTOL, CT
2023

A catalogue record for this book is available from the Library of Congress.

Cover design by Dick Prins.

ISBN 978-90-429-5157-0
eISBN 978-90-429-5158-7
D/2023/0602/64

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CONTENTS

PREFACE AND ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS.	IX
BIBLIOGRAPHY	XI
ABBREVIATIONS	XXVII

INTRODUCTION

§ 1 Content, Structure, and Delineation of the Biblical Primeval History and Its Position in the Book of Genesis and in the Pentateuch	1
§ 2 The Formation of the Biblical Primeval History	6
2.1 The Priestly Writing in Genesis 1–11	8
2.2 The Non-Priestly Texts in Genesis 1–11.....	11
2.2.1 The Formerly Independent Primeval History of the Scholarly Narrator	15
2.2.2 The Post-Priestly Redaction	18
§ 3 The Biblical Primeval History in the Context of Ancient Near Eastern Literature	19

GENESIS 1:1–2:3

Translation	29
Bibliography	31
Text-critical and Philological Notes.....	34
Essentials and Perspectives	36
Scholarly Exposition I: Introduction to Exegesis	40
Scholarly Exposition II: Exegesis	45

GENESIS 2:4–3:24

Translation	92
Bibliography	95
Text-critical and Philological Notes.....	97
Essentials and Perspectives	99
Scholarly Exposition I: Introduction to Exegesis	102
Scholarly Exposition II: Exegesis	108

GENESIS 4:1–26

Translation	175
Bibliography	176
Text-critical and Philological Notes.....	178
Scholarly Exposition I: Introduction to Exegesis	180
Gen 4:1–16.....	184
Essentials and Perspectives	185
Scholarly Exposition II: Exegesis	187
Gen 4:17–26.....	206
Essentials and Perspectives	207
Scholarly Exposition III: Exegesis	209

GENESIS 5:1–32

Translation	221
Bibliography	222
Text-critical and Philological Notes.....	223
Essentials and Perspectives	223
Scholarly Exposition I: Introduction to Exegesis	227
Scholarly Exposition II: Exegesis	231

GENESIS 6:1–4

Translation	239
Bibliography	239
Text-critical and Philological Notes.....	240
Essentials and Perspectives	240
Scholarly Exposition I: Introduction to Exegesis	243
Scholarly Exposition II: Exegesis	247

GENESIS 6:5–9:17

Translation	258
Bibliography	263
Text-critical and Philological Notes.....	265
Essentials and Perspectives	268
Scholarly Exposition I: Introduction to Exegesis	270
Scholarly Exposition II: Exegesis	283

GENESIS 9:18–29

Translation	345
Bibliography	345

Text-critical and Philological Notes.....	346
Essentials and Perspectives	346
Scholarly Exposition I: Introduction to Exegesis	348
Scholarly Exposition II: Exegesis	351

GENESIS 10:1–32

Translation	359
Bibliography	360
Text-critical and Philological Notes.....	361
Essentials and Perspectives	362
Scholarly Exposition I: Introduction to Exegesis	366
Scholarly Exposition II: Exegesis	371

GENESIS 11:1–9

Translation	396
Bibliography	396
Text-critical and Philological Notes.....	397
Essentials and Perspectives	398
Scholarly Exposition I: Introduction to Exegesis	400
Scholarly Exposition II: Exegesis	404

GENESIS 11:10–26

Translation	417
Bibliography	417
Text-critical and Philological Notes.....	418
Essentials and Perspectives	418
Scholarly Exposition I: Introduction to Exegesis	419
Scholarly Exposition II: Exegesis	419

PREFACE AND ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

The biblical Primeval History is one of the central texts of the Bible and has a centuries-long history of interpretation and research to look back on. In the words of Bernard of Chartres, this commentary, too, joins the ranks of those who “stand on the shoulders of giants,” perhaps seeing more and farther than the ancients—though not for better eyes and sharper vision but because we are carried by them and their greatness is imparted to us. For the present commentary, this could have easily been documented through a myriad of literature citations, but there would be little to gain by tracing the origins of each individual argument and noting the first mention of each textual observation. For the commentary to achieve its goal of offering readers both inside and outside the field a readable synthesis of previous research in a limited space while at the same time presenting its own position, the number of references and the discussion of research statements had to be limited to only what was absolutely necessary. Where I agree with a broad consensus, I have merely cited particularly important studies and further works and have noted citations or factual borrowings. The discussion of dissenting opinions serves to clarify my own position; where I hold a minority opinion, this is also indicated in the references.

The present volume is a translation of my commentary on Gen 1–11, which was published in 2018 (2nd ed. 2021) in the German series *Das Alte Testament Deutsch* (ATD) by Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht. For the English translation, however, the commentary was again revised and adapted to the form and conventions of the *Historical Commentary on the Old Testament* series. Although the bibliography has been adapted for an English-speaking readership, I must admit that the commentary remains a work based on the German-speaking academic tradition. For the convenience of the reader, quotations from non-English texts have been translated into English.

I have many to thank: The work on the commentary was generously supported by the Israel Institute for Advanced Studies at the Hebrew University in Jerusalem and the German Research Foundation. I had the great fortune and pleasure to be able to discuss many aspects of the commentary over and over again with, by name, at least Erhard Blum, Walter Bühner, David M. Carr, Christoph Koch, Ann-Kathrin Knittel, Matthias Köckert, Konrad Schmid, Friederike Schücking-Jungblut, Dirk Schwiderski—who assisted me with Hebraic expertise—and Markus Witte. My very sincere thanks go

to John Will Rice for preparing the translation of this volume. I would also like to thank Konstanze Kupski and Hannah Lichtinger for their active support in the preparation of the volume.

Heidelberg, spring 2023

Jan Christian Gertz

BIBLIOGRAPHY

1. SOURCE TEXTS

1. *Bible*

- | | |
|------|---|
| MT | Masoretic Text: <i>BHS = Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia</i> , Ellinger, K., and W. Rudolph et al., eds. 1976/1977. Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelstiftung; <i>BHS</i> . Editio quinta emendata opera. A. Schenker et al., eds. 1997. Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft; <i>BHQ = Biblia Hebraica Quinta</i> . Editione cum apparatu critico novis curis elaborato. A. Schenker et al., eds. 2004ff. Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft. |
| SP | Samaritan Pentateuch: <i>The Samaritan Pentateuch, Edited According to MS 6 (C) of the Shekhem Synagogue</i> , Tal, A., ed. 1994. Texts and Studies in the Hebrew Language and Related Subjects 8. Tel Aviv: Tel Aviv University Press. |
| LXX | Septuagint: <i>Septuaginta: Vetus Testamentum graecum auctoritate academiae scientiarum Gottingensis editum</i> . 1926ff. Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht; <i>Septuaginta, Id est Vetus Testamentum graece iuxta LXX interpretes edidit Alfred Rahlfs: Editio altera quam recognovit et emendavit, Rahlfs, A., and R. Hanhart</i> , eds. 2006. Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft. |
| Pesh | Peschitta: <i>Vetus Testamentum Syriace: Iuxta Simplicem Syrorum Versionem</i> . Institutum Peshittonianum Leidense, ed. 1977. Praefatio. Liber Genesis – Liber Exodi I/1. Leiden: Brill. |
| Vulg | Vulgata: <i>Biblia Sacra iuxta Vulgatam versionem</i> . R. Weber et al., eds. 2007. 5th ed. Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft. |
| Lat | Vetus Latina: <i>Die Reste der altlateinischen Bibel nach Petrus Sabatier neu gesammelt und herausgegeben von der Erzabtei Beuron</i> . B. Fischer, ed. 1951–1954. 2. Genesis. Freiburg i.B.: Herder. |
| NRSV | <i>The Holy Bible: New Revised Standard Version</i> . Containing the Old and New Testaments With Apocryphal or Deuterocanonical Books. Standard text ed. 2005. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. |

2. *Ancient Judaism, Rabbinica, Ancient Christianity and Medieval Exegesis*

- | | |
|-------|--|
| 1 En. | 1 Enoch (Ethiopic Apocalypse). Translated by E. Isaac. 1983. "1 (Ethiopic Apocalypse of) Enoch." Pages 5–89 in vol.1 of <i>OTP</i> (Aram. fragments of 1 En. from J.T. Milik. 1976. <i>The Books of Enoch: Aramaic Fragments of Qumran</i> |
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- 3 Bar. 3 Baruch (Greek Apocalypse). Translated by H.E. Gaylord Jr. 1983. "3 (Greek Apocalypse of) Baruch." Pages 653–680 in vol.1 of *OTP*.
- 4 Ezra. 4 Ezra. Translated by B.M. Metzger. 1983. "The Fourth Book of Ezra." Pages 517–570 in vol.1 of *OTP*.
- Apoc. Mos. Apocalypse of Moses. Translated by M.D. Johnson. 1985. "Life of Adam and Eve." Pages 249–295 in vol.2 of *OTP*.
- Aug., *Gen.lit.* Augustine. *De Genesi ad litteram*. Translated by E. Hill. 2002. Pages 155–506 in *On Genesis: On Genesis – A Refutation of the Manichees, Unfinished Literal Commentary on Genesis, and The Literal Meaning of Genesis*. The Works of Saint Augustine 13.1. Hyde Park, NY.
- b.Yebam./Yoma/
Pesah./'Erub./Sanh. The Babylonian Talmud, Yebamot/Yoma/Pesahim/'Erubin/Sanhedrin. Translated by I. Epstein. 1935–1952. *The Babylonian Talmud: Translated into English with Notes, Glossary and Indices*. 18 vols. London: Soncino Press.
- Cav. Tr. Cave of Treasures. Translated by A. Toepel. 1983. "Cave of Treasures." Pages 531–584 in vol.1 of *OTP*.
- DJD* Discoveries in the Judean Desert. E. Tov, ed. 1955–2009. *Discoveries in the Judean Desert*. 40 vols. Oxford: Clarendon Press.
- DSS* The Dead Sea Scrolls. J.H. Charlesworth, ed. 1994–2018. *The Dead Sea Scrolls: Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek Texts with English Translations*. Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck.
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- Frg. Tg. Fragmentary Targum (Targum Yerušalmi II). Translated by M.L. Klein. 1980. *The Fragment-Targums of the Pentateuch: According to their Extant Sources*. 2 vols. AnBib 76. Rome: Biblical Institute Press.
- Gen. Rab. Midrash Rabbah, Genesis. Translated by H. Freedman. 1951. *Midrash Rabbah: Genesis*, 2nd ed. London: Soncino Press.
- Ibn Ezra Abraham Ibn Ezra's Commentary on the Pentateuch (*Perush ha-Torah*). Translated by H.N. Strickman and A.M. Silver. 1988. *Ibn Ezra's Commentary on the Pentateuch: Genesis (Bereshit)*. New York: Menorah Publishing Company.
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- JSHRZ* *Jüdische Schriften aus hellenistisch-römischer Zeit*. 1973ff. Edited by G.W. Kümmel and H. Lichtenberger. Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus.
- Jub. Jubilees. Translated by O.S. Wintermute. 1985. "Jubilees." Pages 35–142 in vol.2 of *OTP*.
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- Philo, *QG* Philo, *Questiones in Genesim*. Translated by R. Marcus. 1953. "Questions on Genesis." *Philo: Supplement I*. LCL 380. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- PRE *Pirke de-Rabbi Elieser/Sefer Pirke Rabbi Eli' eser*. Translated by G. Friedlander. 1981. *Pirkê de Rabbi Eliezer (The Chapters of Rabbi Eliezer the Great): According to the Text of the Manuscript Belonging to Abraham Epstein of Vienna*. 4th ed. New York: Sepher-Hermon Press.
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a. *Collected Volumes*

- AEL *Ancient Egyptian Literature: A Book of Readings*. Edited by M. Lichtheim. 1973–1976. 2 vols. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press.
- ANET *Ancient Near Eastern Texts Relating to the Old Testament*. Edited by J.B. Pritchard. 1969. 3rd ed. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
- COS *The Context of Scripture*. Edited by W.W. Hallo. 1997–2017. 4 vols. Leiden: Brill.
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- TUAT.NF *Texte aus der Umwelt des Alten Testaments: Neue Folge I–VIII*. Edited by B. Janowski and G. Wilhelm. 2004–2015. 8 vols. Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus.

b. *Single Volumes*

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2. GRAMMARS AND LEXICONS

1. Grammars

- GKC Gesenius' *Hebrew Grammar*. Edited by E. Kautzsch. Translated by A.E. Cowley. 1910. 2nd ed. Oxford: Clarendon. Translation of *Wilhelm Gesenius' Hebräische Grammatik völlig umgearbeitet von E. Kautzsch*. 1962. Rev. and enl. 28th ed. Hildesheim: Georg Olms Verlagsbuchhandlung.
- HS Brockelmann, C. 1956. *Hebräische Syntax*. Neukirchen: Verlag der Buchhandlung des Erziehungsvereins.
- Joüon/Muraoka Joüon, P., and T. Muraoka. 2006. *A Grammar of Biblical Hebrew*. SubBi 27. Rome: Pontifical Biblical Institute.

2. Lexicons

- ABD Freedman, D.N., ed. 1992. *The Anchor Bible Dictionary*. 6 vols. New York: Doubleday.
- BRL2 Galling, K., ed. 1977. *Biblisches Reallexikon*. 2nd ed. HAT 1/1. Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck.
- DDD van der Toorn, K., B. Becking, and P.W. van der Horst, eds. 1999. *Dictionary of Deities and Demons in the Bible*. 2nd ed. Leiden: Brill.
- DNWSI Hoftijzer, J., and K. Jongeling, eds. 1995. *Dictionary of the North-West Semitic Inscriptions*. Leiden: Brill.
- EBR Allison, D.C., H.J. Klauck, and C. Helmer, eds. 2009ff. *Encyclopedia of the Bible and Its Reception*. Berlin: de Gruyter.
- Ges¹⁸ Gesenius, W. 2013. *Hebräisches und Aramäisches Handwörterbuch über das Alte Testament*. 18th and rev. ed. Edited by U. Rüterswörden. Heidelberg: Springer.
- GGG Keel, O., and C. Uehlinger, eds. 2012. *Göttinnen, Götter und Göttersymbole: Neue Erkenntnisse zur Religionsgeschichte Kanaans und Israels aufgrund bislang unerschlossener ikonographischer Quellen*. 7th ed. = Repr. of the 6th ed. Freiburg (Schweiz): Bibel+Orient Museum.

HAE	Renz, J., and W. Röllig, eds. 1995. <i>Handbuch der althebräischen Epigraphik</i> . Darmstadt: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft.
HAL	Köhler, L., and W. Baumgartner, eds. 1967–1996. <i>Hebräisches und Aramäisches Lexikon zum Alten Testament</i> . 3rd, rev. ed. Edited by W. Baumgartner et al. Leiden: Brill.
LÄ	Helck, W. ed. 1975–1992. <i>Lexikon der Ägyptologie</i> . Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz.
NBL	Görg, M. ed. 1991–2001. <i>Neues Bibel-Lexikon</i> . Zürich: Benzinger.
odb	Gertz, J.C., and E. Gaß, eds. 2017ff. <i>Ortsangaben der Bibel</i> . http://www.odb.bibelwissenschaft.de .
RGG	Betz, H.D., ed. 1998ff. <i>Religion in Geschichte und Gegenwart</i> . 4th ed. 8 vols. Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck.
THAT	Jenni, E., and C. Westermann, eds. 2004. <i>Theologisches Handwörterbuch zum Alten Testament</i> . 6th ed. 2 vols. München: Kaiser.
TWAT	Botterweck, G.J., and H.-J. Fabry, eds. 1973ff. <i>Theologisches Wörterbuch zum Alten Testament</i> . Stuttgart: Kohlhammer.
TRE	Krause, G., and G. Müller et al. eds. 1977ff. <i>Theologische Realenzyklopädie</i> . Berlin: de Gruyter.
WiBiLex	Alkier, S., M. Bauks, and K. Koenen, eds. 2007ff. <i>Das wissenschaftliche Bibellexikon im Internet</i> . http://www.wibilex.de .

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ABBREVIATIONS

Bibliographic abbreviations are according to *The SBL Handbook of Style for Biblical Studies and Related Disciplines*, ed. B.J. Collins, B. Buller, and J.F. Kutsko, 2nd edition, Atlanta, GA, SBL Press (2014). For ease of use, abbreviations for text editions, lexicons, grammars, etc. are listed specifically in the bibliography.

The following abbreviations are used in the text of the commentary or in the footnotes:

cons.	consecutivum
D.N.	divine name
encl. part.	enclitic particle
esp.	especially
fem.	feminine
Fig.	Figure
fn.	footnote
Fragm.	fragment
hi.	hiph'il
hithp.	hithpa'el
hithpalp.	hithpalpel
hithpol.	hithpolel
ho.	hoph'al
ibid.	ibidem
imperf.	imperfect
impt.	imperative
inf. abs.	infinitive absolutus
inf. cstr.	infinitive constructus
inf.	infinitive
ln. (ll.)	line(s)
masc.	masculine
MS	manuscript
ni.	niph'al
non-P	non-Priestly
P	Priestly Writing
P.N.	personal name
pass.	passive
perf.	perfect
pers.	person
pi.	pi'el
pl.	plural
po.	po'al
prep.	preposition
ptc.	participle
pu.	pu'al
q.	qal
R	Redaction

repr.	reprint
sg.	singular
SN	Scholarly Narrator
st. abs.	status absolutus
st. cstr.	status constructus
suff.	suffix
v(v).	verse(s)
Vol.	volume

PRESENTATION OF THE BIBLICAL TEXT

In the translation of the biblical passages at the beginning of each chapter, the origins of the various texts are indicated as follows:

bold	Priestly Writing (additions in smaller font)
<i>italic</i>	Scholarly Narrator (additions in smaller font)
roman	Redaction and further supplements

Explanatory additions and text corrections are indicated through brackets (“[]”). In the commentary, divisions of the verses are indicated by letters. The Latin letters “a” and “b” indicate the two halves of a verse as divided by the Masoretic accent *etnachta*, while Greek letters indicate smaller units within such partial verses, typically demarcated through the Masoretic accent *zaqef qatan*. A “*” at the end of a verse citation indicates that only part of the respective verse is meant.

TRANSCRIPTION AND PERSONAL NAMES

With some exceptions noted in the commentary below, Hebrew words are typically rendered with the traditional Aramaic letters and Masoretic vocalizations. In cases where a Hebrew word is transcribed into the Latin alphabet, the transcription is generally phonetic and follows the conventions of the field, with some simplifications: No distinction is made between hard and soft pronunciation (the so-called “*begadkefat*” sounds) or between plene and defective spelling. Short vowels are not marked separately, reduced vowels are given in superscript, and long vowels are marked with a macron (ˉ). Hebrew roots are marked with a “*” before the respective consonants. Akkadian and Sumerian are transcribed following R. Borger, *Mesopotamisches Zeichenlexikon* (AOAT 305), Münster 2003. Other transcriptions follow RGG⁴. The rendering of biblical personal names generally follows, with some exceptions, the traditional English renderings as reflected in the KJV/NRSV.

“Joyfully did I embark on the tale of Paradise – a tale that is short to read but rich to explore.”

(Ephrem the Syrian, *Hymns on Paradise* 1.3)

INTRODUCTION

§ 1. CONTENT, STRUCTURE, AND DELINEATION OF THE BIBLICAL PRIMEVAL HISTORY AND ITS POSITION IN THE BOOK OF GENESIS AND IN THE PENTATEUCH

The Hebrew Bible’s Primeval History is a reflection upon the origins of the world and how it is ordered, the dawn of humanity, and the emergence of civilization. Its stories of Adam and Eve, Cain and Abel, Noah’s Ark, and the Tower of Babel have shaped our view of ourselves and the world like few other works of literature. Over the centuries, their cosmological and anthropological ideas have served as our culture’s most important point of reference for understanding the natural history of the world. Of course, the Primeval History has gradually given way to modern science as an explanation for the origin of the cosmos and the development of life and as a record of the history of early humanity. So to us today, it may seem at first glance like a culturally powerful but nevertheless outdated cosmology and historiography that compensates for scientific and historical ignorance with beautiful stories. This is certainly true. But understood correctly, it is primarily the expression of a fundamental belief that the essence of everything present and future was created at the Beginning – an idea widespread in ancient cultures and formulated in full accordance with the knowledge of its time. In this sense, the biblical Primeval History is, from the outset, not only an explanation of the world but also an attempt to understand the human experience in an interpretative way. This was expressed through the language of a myth of the primordial beginnings, telling that “all this did not happen at any one time but always is so.”¹

The myth of the primordial beginnings combines exemplaric narratives with explanations of natural history, genealogy, and geography that already reflect on the myth and seek to harmonize it with the early form of a scientific

¹ Sallustios, *De diis et mundo*, 4.9.

worldview. Standing at the heart of this reflection is humanity and its manifold relationships with its fellow people, with nonhuman creation, and with God. Even the report about the origin of the world and its temporal and spatial order (Gen 1:1–2:3) is oriented completely around the world of human experience. Claims about the world before Creation, about the heavens above the visible sky or about the depths of the sea are reduced only to what is absolutely necessary. Conversely, the commissioning and empowering of humanity to rule over the world and over non-human Creation stand prominently at the end of the creationary works and take pride of place. The etiological orientation towards the basic conditions of human experience is even more evident in the stories about the Garden (Gen 2:4–3:24) and about Cain and Abel (Gen 4:1–16) as well as the genealogical notices about Cain's descendants (Gen 4:17–24). Against the contrasting background of a garden of paradise as the lost location of an effortless and unthreatened way of life and of naïvely untroubled relationships between man and woman, human and God, they describe the ambiguity [*Ambivalenz*] inherent to human existence: Humanity's essential connection to the soil from which it was taken (Gen 2:7), from which it is nourished through hard labor and to which it returns in death (Gen 3:17–19); the closeness and simultaneous enmity between human and animal as fellow creatures (Gen 2:18f.; 3:15); the joy of childbirth amid pain (Gen 3:16); the distortion of humanity's intimacy into a dominative imbalance between man and woman (Gen 3:16); the fateful experiences of advancement or impairment independent of one's performance, and the deadly violence among brothers that comes about through this experience (Gen 4:1–16); progressive cultural development (Gen 3:21; 4:17, 20–22) through the discovery of practical knowledge (Gen 3:7) with a simultaneous waning closeness to God (Gen 3:24; 4:11, 14) and waxing propensity for violence (Gen 4:8, 14–15, 23–24); the possibility for the passing on of life (Gen 3:20; 4:1) and the boundaries of life and death set for humanity with their expulsion from the Garden (Gen 3:22, 24). Alongside the ambiguous experience of the world, the boundaries of life and death touch on another defining characteristic of human existence as well: the distinction between the divine and human spheres (Gen 3:22). This is taken up again in the episode of the sexual union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man (Gen 6:1–4) and is unfolded from a spatial perspective in the Tower of Babel narrative (Gen 11:1–9). Finally, fundamental statements about the nature of humanity also frame the extensive Flood narrative (Gen 6:5–9:17). Humanity's inexorable propensity for evil and its excessive violence provoke God's decision to annihilate all life almost completely (Gen 6:5–7, 11–13) and guide the Creator God's resigned judgment of humanity after the Flood (Gen 8:21). As a countermyth to the story of creation that leads Creation to the brink of the abyss and complete

annihilation because of its “corruption,” the Flood narrative marks a decisive turning point as the end of the origins of both the world and the conditions of human existence. At the same time, it is a prelude to the current epoch of world history, which reaches up to and beyond the present of its intended readers and in which there is no return to the world of the primordial beginnings. This twofold perspective symbolizes how the Creator God’s fundamental questioning of his own Creation is overcome once and for all – even if at the price of a new universal order with regulated violence that does not align with the original will of its Creator (Gen 8:21–22; 9:9–17).

The biblical Primeval History is structured by the so-called “*toledot* formula”: “These are the *toledot*/generations of P.N.” This formula, from the Hebrew *tōl’dōt* “family history,” “genealogy,” separates the Creation account as a prologue from the history of humanity beginning with the Garden narrative (Gen 2:4a). As it progresses, it divides the sequence of events into the “*toledot*/generations” of Adam (Gen 5:1), Noah (Gen 6:9), the sons of Noah (Gen 10:1), and Shem (Gen 11:10). In this structure, the Primeval History ends with the descendants of Shem, son of Noah. The history of the ancestors of Israel begins immediately thereafter with the “*toledot*/generations” of Terah that lead to Abraham (Gen 11:27). However, there is also a second demarcation that is recognizable. Analogous to other literary works from the ancient Near East in which the myth of the primordial beginnings covers the epochs of Creation and the Flood, the Hebrew Bible’s depiction of the beginnings of the world also reaches its (preliminary) goal with the end of the Flood narrative. The events immediately following the Flood narrative, on the other hand, are characterized as a time between the primordial era and the earliest history of the people of Israel. This intervening period is still “primeval” insofar as the Table of Nations and the Tower of Babel narrative both refer to all humanity, who even appear as the acting subject of the Tower narrative (Gen 11:1). Furthermore, the conclusion to the Table of Nations and the opening to the genealogy of Shem each build an “event history” chronology and take the Flood as their starting points (Gen 10:32; 11:10). At the same time, the antagonism between “Israel” and “Canaan” is foreshadowed in the narrative of Noah and his sons. This antagonism shapes the subsequent presentation of the history of Israel over large stretches and, like the distribution of humanity into the ethnically and geographically divided world of the peoples of the ancient Near East, becomes more than a strictly “primeval” theme.²

² For discussion, see Baumgart, 1999, 34–37; Witte, 1998, 48–50.

Structure of the Biblical Primeval History and Its Constituent Parts		
Overall Text	P Primeval History	Non-Priestly Elements ³
Creation		
	The <i>Toledot</i> of the Heavens and the Earth (Gen 1:1–2:3)	
		Garden Narrative (Gen 2:4–3:24)
		Cain and Abel (Gen 4:1–26)
	The <i>Toledot</i> of Adam: The Genealogy from Adam to Noah (Gen 5:1–32*)	
The Flood		
		Angel Marriages (Gen 6:1–4)
	The <i>Toledot</i> of Noah: The Flood Narrative (Gen 6:9–9:29*)	Flood Narrative (Gen 6:5–9:29*)
Intervening Period		
	The <i>Toledot</i> of the Sons of Noah (Gen 10*)	
		List of Peoples (Gen 10*)
		Tower of Babel (Gen 11:1–9)
	The <i>Toledot</i> of Shem: Genealogy from Shem to Terah (Gen 11:10–26*)	
Patriarchal Period		
	Genealogy from Terah to Abram (Gen 11:27–32*)	

The question of the delineation of the biblical Primeval History raises the further question of its position in the book of Genesis and the Pentateuch as a whole.⁴ As a description of primordial happenings that precede all history, it is a self-contained unity and has been continuously conceived as such. Yet, even though it addresses topics common to humankind and tells of the origins of the human condition, it is not about “the world” or “humanity” in general

³ Parts of the previously independent Primeval History of the Scholarly Narrator are presented in bold. For this and the distinction between the Priestly (P) and non-Priestly passages, see below, § 2. The Formation of the Biblical Primeval History.

⁴ “Pentateuch,” Greek/Latin “the five-part [book],” is the common scholarly designation for the Torah (Eng. “Instruction”), the so-called “five books of Moses”: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy.

but always about the concrete manifestations of these general concepts, i.e., the world and humanity of the present. For the Primeval History, this means working from the perspective of “Israel” – however this entity may be defined. Even the six-day creation of the world with God resting on the seventh day is based on the structure of the Sabbath, even if the Sabbath itself is a privilege of Israel and therefore not explicitly mentioned (see below on Gen 2:1–3). Noah’s ark is a rescued “Creation” on a much smaller scale and, at the same time, modelled after the later temple in Jerusalem (see below on Gen 6:14–16), which in turn reflects the cosmic order presented in the Creation account (see below on Gen 2:1–3). Shem, Ham, and Japheth are the sons of Noah who, with their father, their nameless mother, and their likewise nameless wives, survive the Flood and are the subjects of the following statement after the Flood: “These three are the sons of Noah, and from them the whole earth was populated” (Gen 9:19). This is unfolded in the Table of Nations (Gen 10:1–32) and ultimately leads to the genealogy of Shem reaching to Terah and Abraham (Gen 11:10–26). Thus, standing at the end of the Primeval History is a particular story of the ancestors of Israel leaving Ur of the Chaldeans, and in this way, the primordial beginnings lead to a history of the origins of Israel beginning with Gen 12. This perspective is particularly clear in the *toledot* formulae. They structure not only Gen 1–11 but also the story of the ancestors of Israel (Gen 25:12, 19; 36:1, 9; 37:2), with the history of the people of Israel being integrated into the “*toledot*/generations of Jacob” (Gen 37:2), insofar as Jacob is given the name “Israel” (Gen 32:29; 35:10) and becomes the father of the twelve tribes of Israel. Furthermore, the theme of multiplication and blessing, which begins in the Creation account, serves as the leitmotif of both the Primeval History and the following history of the ancestors and the foundation narrative of the people of Israel: After the creation of humanity, God blesses humanity and appoints them as his representative to rule over the earth and its inhabitants (Gen 1:28). After the Flood, he blesses humanity again and establishes his covenant with them (Gen 9:1–17). The motif of “blessing and covenant” is then taken up and expanded in regard to Abraham and his descendants. God reveals himself to Abraham and establishes his covenant with him and his descendants. Abraham becomes the father of many nations, but above all he becomes the ancestor of the people of Israel, who are given the covenantal promise and the assurance of God’s presence and the gift of the land (Gen 17). Jacob is also promised fertility and blessing (Gen 35), which is then realized for Israel in Egypt (Exod 1:7). Finally, there are also the linguistic allusions to the exodus in the Tower of Babel narrative (see below on Gen 11:1–9) that, in connection with the “call of Abraham” (Gen 12:1–3), characterize Abraham’s departure from Mesopotamia as an anticipation of Israel’s exodus from Egypt.

§ 2. THE FORMATION OF THE BIBLICAL PRIMEVAL HISTORY

In light of the connections outlined above, it is already clear that the formation of Gen 1–11 cannot be discussed completely independently from that of the following chapters of Genesis and the following books of the Pentateuch. It should also be taken into account that research on the literary history of the Pentateuch began with the study of the Primeval History and that it often still serves as a guiding paradigm in more recent research for the composition of the entire Pentateuch. However, this goes beyond the scope of an introduction to a commentary on Gen 1–11, and it is therefore best to stay confined to a few passing remarks. This is also justifiable from a functional standpoint, since the current research discussion understands Gen 1–11 to have been written in large part relatively independently from the rest of the Pentateuch. The same can be said for the Ancestral History and the narrative of Moses, the exodus, and Sinai, as well as the conquest of the land and parts of the Pentateuchal legal collections: The overall design of the Pentateuchal narrative running from the creation of the world to the conquest of the land is much more recent than its individual blocks of tradition. These generally have their own independent beginnings, and only through their respective formational processes were they brought together into larger compositions and into the Pentateuch as a whole.⁵

In its beginnings in the seventeenth and early eighteenth centuries, research on the Pentateuch was dominated by the question of its literary unity and, even more so, by Moses's role in its composition. The question of how Moses was able to tell of events in the book of Genesis that took place before his lifetime, which was a natural question from a historical point of view, was answered with the since-influential assumption that Moses had access to earlier written sources. Scholars ultimately abandoned the question of Mosaic authorship of the Pentateuch in the nineteenth century and moved to a literary history involving anonymous writings from much later periods of Israel's history. Even still, the "discovery" of two sources in Gen 1–11 due to literary tensions or duplications as well as linguistic and stylistic differences laid the foundation for a basic consensus in research that is still alive today. Accordingly, there are two groups of texts in the Primeval History that are distinguishable from each other based on their respective linguistic and thematic profiles as well as their respective internal cross-references. Since the groundbreaking analyses by Hermann Hupfeld (1796–1866), Eberhard

⁵ For an outline of my present position, see Gertz, 2012. On Pentateuchal research and its history, see Houtman, 1994; for specifically Genesis and the biblical Primeval History, see Ska, 2012; Gertz, 2022^b; Witte, 1998, 1–52; for detailing of recent discussion, see the contributions in Dozeman, Schmid, Schwartz, 2011; Gertz et al., 2016.

Schrader (1836–1908), Karl Budde (1850–1935), and Hermann Gunkel (1862–1932), their delineations have been largely undisputed (except for a few details), even for the passages in which they have been artistically interwoven into a new text.⁶

The first group begins in Gen 1:1 with the Creation account. It also includes the Register of the Generations of Adam, a version of the Flood narrative, the main part of the Table of Nations, and the genealogy of Shem. The texts in this group are structured through the *toledot* formula and are thus clearly designed to be continued in the Ancestral History of Israel. This also applies for the Creation account, whose claims about the spatial and temporal ordering of the world are taken up at Sinai in the depiction of the establishment of the tent-sanctuary. Also beginning here is the leitmotif of “multiplication and blessing,” running from the Primeval History through the subsequent Ancestral History and into the narrative of the foundation of the people. Finally, the texts of this group, and the references to them throughout the rest of the Pentateuch, are characterized by particular language, a definitive style, and an interest in chronological and genealogical matters. Together, they develop a universal historical perspective reaching from Creation to the establishment of the cult at Sinai. From this, the various models for the formation of the Pentateuch are unanimous in assuming the formation of the passages in question in Gen 1–11 as being connected to the accordant passages in the following books of the Pentateuch. Given their linguistic and theological profile, these texts are referred to across the various models as “Priestly” or as the “Priestly Writing.”⁷ There is also a widespread consensus that they date to the first half of the sixth century BCE. The texts about the construction of the tent-sanctuary at Sinai are functionally connected with the Second Temple in Jerusalem, which was consecrated in 515 BCE as the successor building of the First (“Solomonic”) Temple destroyed by Nebuchadnezzar II in 587/586 BCE. Of course, this does not exclude the possibility that the intellectual precursors of this literary work go back to the time before the Babylonian Exile.

The second group includes the Garden narrative, the story of Cain and Abel, the genealogy of Cain and Seth, the episode of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man, a second version of the Flood narrative, the story of Noah and his sons, a few verses of the Table of Nations, and the Tower of

⁶ Hupfeld, 1853; Schrader, 1863; Budde, 1883; Gunkel, 1997 [1910].

⁷ The symbol “P” for “Priestly Writing” traces back to Abraham Kuenen (1821–1891); see Kuenen, 1880. Due to its designation of God as “Elohim” (“God”), older works speak of the “Elohim epic” or the “base text” [*Grundschrift*], judging the Priestly texts to be the earliest foundations of the Pentateuchal narrative. The designation “Priestly Writing” hits at the idea of a formerly independent literary work, while the designation “Priestly Redaction/Composition” is preferred within the context of models that see the P texts as an editorial layer.

Babel narrative. The Documentary Hypothesis, as principally formulated by Julius Wellhausen (1844–1918) and later modified by Martin Noth (1902–1968), long held a near-unquestioned authority in the field. It assigned the aforementioned texts to the so-called “Yahwist” (or “J,” from the German “*Jahwist*”).⁸ The Yahwist, owing its name to the use of the personal name of God, “Yhwh” (German “*Jhwh*”),⁹ is considered to be a formerly independent literary work from the early monarchic period. It encompasses the main themes of the Pentateuchal narrative, just like the Priestly Writing (“P”), which comes from the exilic or early postexilic period, and the Elohist (“E”), which begins with the Abraham narratives and is seen as a product of the Northern Kingdom of Israel. According to the multistaged redactional process reconstructed by the Documentary Hypothesis, the Yahwist was first connected with the Elohist into the “Jehovist” work (“JE”), and later with the Priestly Writing and the book of Deuteronomy, whose core originated in the late monarchic period.¹⁰ The hypothesis of an Elohist has largely been abandoned in the current academic discussion, while virtually everything concerning the Yahwist is under dispute: its literary and theological coherence, its literary delineation and extent, its age, and its theological profile. For this reason, the Yahwistic texts, including those formerly attributed to the Elohist, have increasingly been termed in recent scholarship as “non-Priestly” (or “non-P”). Although this designation is relatively vague, its accuracy lies in how it identifies the *one common feature* of these texts and avoids all further definitions. There is current controversy around whether the majority of the non-Priestly texts were part of an overarching narrative work before their connection with the Priestly Writing, and around whether individual texts are older than the Priestly Writing or if they already presuppose and supplement it. Each case must be examined individually, and this is also true for the Primeval History – which is where the aforementioned consensus ends.

2.1 The Priestly Writing in Genesis 1–11

According to the analysis presented in this commentary, the following texts in Gen 1–11 belong to the Priestly Writing: Gen 1:1–2:3 (creation of the

⁸ Wellhausen, 1899; Noth, 1972.

⁹ According to certain witnesses from late antiquity, the pronunciation of the four letters *yhwh*, which designate the name of God in the Hebrew text, was “Yahweh.” Out of respect for the holiness of the name (see Exod 20:7), its pronunciation was avoided in Judaism from relatively early on and was instead read as ⁹*dōnāi* “(my) Lord.” The Septuagint accordingly renders the name as κύριος “Lord.” This was followed by most English translations of the Bible, which read “the LORD.” In academic contexts, the use of the tetragrammaton “Yhwh/YHWH” is widely common.

¹⁰ For a brief presentation, see Gertz, 2012, 252–258.

heavens and the earth); 5:1–27, 28*, 30–32 (*toledot*/generations of Adam); 6:9–22; 7:6–7, 11, 13–16a, 17a*, 18–21, 24; 8:1–2a, 3–5, 13a–19; 9:1–18a (19?), 28–29 (*toledot*/generations of Noah); 10:1–7, 20, 22–23, 31–32 (*toledot*/generations of the sons of Noah); 11:10–26 (*toledot*/generations of Shem). Within this, Gen 2:1; 7:24; 8:3b are secondary Priestly additions, and the attribution of Gen 9:19 to the Priestly Writing is uncertain.

The Priestly Writing has been a comparatively stable feature in contemporary Pentateuchal research. Since Theodor Nöldeke (1836–1930), there has essentially been a consensus about the delineation of the texts that, in a broader sense, belong to the Priestly Writing.¹¹ However, there is controversy around how to understand the stages in the literary history of the Priestly Writing itself as well as around the related questions of its scope and original literary character. For the purposes of the present commentary, there is no need to get into the discussion around whether the Priestly Writing originally ended in Deut 34* with the death of Moses and a preview of the conquest of the land or – more probably – whether it ended earlier, in Exod 40* with the construction of the tent-sanctuary at Sinai and Yhwh's entry into the sanctuary. In any case, according to the perspective of the Priestly sections of Gen 1–11, the events at Sinai appear as the climax and goal of the Priestly narrative, while the other presumed ending in Deut 34* has no demonstrable references back to the beginnings with the Primeval History.¹²

The debate over its original literary character, on the other hand, is especially important for understanding the Priestly texts. Can the Priestly texts in Gen 1–11 be read as an independent design, or have they always been related to the Primeval History's non-Priestly texts? Even though the scholarly majority still holds that the Priestly Writing was an independent literary source, the intense debate of recent years has resulted in a few adjustments:¹³ For the Priestly portions of Gen 1–11, the validity of the theory of a self-standing Priestly thread can be seen in the commentary below.¹⁴ The same can be said for the Exodus narrative. In contrast, the situations in the Ancestral History and the Joseph story look completely different, and it must be considered in these cases whether or not the Priestly Writing, which in any case is only

¹¹ Nöldeke, 1896, 1–144.

¹² This is also true for the observations in Lohfink, 1988, according to which the Priestly Writing reaches into the book of Joshua. See further Knauf, 2007, 219. Evidence cited for this includes the similarities in the languages of Gen 1:28 and Josh 18:1; 19:51 as well as the fact that only the possession of the land was still missing from the blessings in Gen 1:28. However, the possession of the land in Gen 1:28 describes the domain of humanity, who is empowered to rule over the animals. This is a separate issue from the Israelites taking possession of the land of Canaan and subjugating its previous inhabitants.

¹³ See further the contributions in Shectman/Baden, 2009; Hartenstein/Schmid, 2022.

¹⁴ For justification, see the following commentary on the passages assigned to P. See further Gertz, 2022^b; for a contrary position, see Blum, 1990, 278–285.

sparsely present, integrated the non-Priestly components from the outset. If so, the Priestly Writing would need to be treated in Gen 12–50 as an editorial layer or compositional layer that, following after an independently composed Primeval History, continued with stories of the ancestors and Joseph that it edited and expanded with its own account of the emergence of the people of Israel in Egypt and their time under the leadership of Moses.¹⁵ Regardless of however the situation in Gen 12–50 should be evaluated, the Priestly texts in Gen 1–11 form the opening to a large, previously self-standing literary work from the early postexilic period attempting “to retell the origins and foundation history of the people from the ground up, in order to convey guidance and hope to the people of [its] generation once again.”¹⁶ Within the framework of this self-confirmation amid the continual experience of crisis, the special contribution of the Primeval History lies in its emphasis on the sovereign action of the transcendent Creator God, who announces his universal will for salvation in his covenant with Noah and his descendants and who, over the course of the Salvation History [*Heilsgeschichte*], ultimately reveals himself to be the God of Israel.

The Priestly Primeval History is largely a literary unity; additions to the (still self-standing) Priestly Writing are limited to a few (sub-)verses.¹⁷ Of course, this does not exclude the possibility that the texts had a much longer literary history beforehand. It can thus be assumed that the Creation account was based on a list enumerating God’s works at Creation, even though an exact delineation of this literary predecessor [*Vorlage*] within the present text is not possible. It is quite likely that it originated already from priestly circles and is thus an indication that the Priestly Writing, drafted in the early postexilic period, is based on older priestly traditions and ideas. The same is probably also true for the genealogies in Gen 5 and 11 as well as the Table of Nations in Gen 10. The heading “This is the register of the *toledot*”

¹⁵ See Wöhrle, 2012; Gertz, 2022^b.

¹⁶ Jeremias, 2015, 244 [translation JWR; emphasis in original].

¹⁷ For evidence, see the commentary sections in the following chapters. Two quite different counterpositions are worth mentioning here as examples: In addition to an earlier text and Priestly revision, Levin, 1994 sees in Gen 1:1–2:4a (!) very extensive secondary Priestly reworkings. Arnold, 2017, on the other hand, assigns Gen 1:1–2:3 to the so-called “Holiness School,” which was primarily concerned with further developing the legislation of the Holiness Code in Lev 17–26 and adapting other traditions, chiefly those of the Priestly Writing, to the conceptions and intentions of the Holiness Code. Per Arnold, it is the Holiness School that was responsible for the connection of P and non-P in Gen 1–11, prepending the Creation account to both works and, moreover, subjecting the Priestly Writing to a more or less extensive revision. Furthermore, he sees the Priestly Writing as beginning with Gen 5:1 and in the Primeval History comprising only the genealogies, the Table of Nations, and a kernel of the Flood narrative (without its prologue and epilogue in Gen 6:9–22, 9:1–17, which are usually attributed to P but are assigned by Arnold to the Holiness School). Carr, 2020, in turn, sees a redaction in Gen 1:1–2:3 that is interested in the Sabbath, and he associates this with the Holiness School.

generations of Adam” and the recognizable literary seams in Gen 5:1–3, 11:10–11 indicate that the Priestly Writing wrote its narrative materials within an older “Book of the *Toledot*.” The Table of Nations may have conceivably come from a list of trading partners or the like. Moreover, the Priestly Writing stands in a broad line of tradition of the religious and literary history of the ancient Near East, taking up and developing the world of ideas therein for its own. However, it is entirely unclear whether the Priestly Writing knew the presumably older non-Priestly texts in Gen 1–11 and sought to write in reaction to them. In any case, the “dialogical character” of the biblical Primeval History occasionally noted by scholars is not demonstrable for the Priestly texts in relation to the non-Priestly texts; it is rather the result of redactional activity.

2.2 The Non-Priestly Texts in Genesis 1–11

Since the mid-1970s, the Documentary Hypothesis has been increasingly called into question. Although it still plays just as important a role in exegetical discussion, it can differ so greatly in its details from one scholar to the next that it is nigh impossible to speak of a uniform model. Additionally, other models of formation were able to be established in connection with and in contradiction to the Documentary Hypothesis. Particularly controversial in this sometimes-confusing state of research is how the literary history of the non-Priestly texts is understood. The main reason for this is that they are much more disparate in linguistic and theological respects than the Priestly Writing both inside and outside of the Primeval History and exhibit a decent amount of incoherence. This was long explained for Gen 1–11 within the framework of the Documentary Hypothesis through the assumption of multiple stages of revision by the Yahwist.¹⁸ More sustainable were explanations assuming later revisions of a basic Yahwistic layer as well as Yahwistic editing of pre-Yahwistic sources.¹⁹ The fact that the texts attributed to the Yahwist do not form a coherent narrative is most commonly attributed to the redactional connection with the Priestly Writing, which the Redaction used as its base text.²⁰

The fundamental differentiation in the present material between a core set of texts and later, partially also post-Priestly additions is frequently observable

¹⁸ See Budde, 1883; Gunkel, 2–4 and *passim*.

¹⁹ Even Wellhausen, 1899, 7–14, reckoned with the revisions of a basic Yahwistic layer, which was only later supplemented by the Flood and its related sections. The assumption that (mostly oral) sources were available to the Yahwist was recently transformed by Levin, 1993, 48, 82–132, into a redactional model understanding the Yahwist as a redactor, but of course without excluding extensive post-Yahwistic revisions.

²⁰ See Noth, 1972, 11–13.

with different accentuations and interpretations even in the present discussion. However, what has been particularly striking is the shift in the relative chronology between the Priestly Writing and most of the non-Priestly texts in Gen 1–11. According to the Documentary Hypothesis, the non-Priestly parts of Gen 1–11 are almost all older than the Priestly Writing, which dates to the late exilic or early postexilic period. However, this view has recently experienced a fundamental shift. Several recent studies have argued that the non-Priestly passages in Gen 1–11 were conceived from the outset as supplements to the Priestly Writing.²¹ In this view, the post-Priestly Redaction drew on preexisting, partially also pre-Priestly traditions and was designed as a programmatic prefiguration of Gen 12ff. Thus, for example, the Garden narrative in Gen 2:4–3:24 was characterized as a midrashic reflection on the Priestly Creation account in Gen 1:1–2:3, correcting the optimistic view in the Priestly Writing from a skeptical, Late Wisdom perspective and against the background of negative historical experiences during the postexilic period. It is primarily concerned with explaining how the “very good” Creation (Gen 1:31) could have been so corrupted that Yhwh felt the need to drive it back into the primordial chaos.²²

This fundamental reversal of the relationships between the different layers in the formation of the texts should be differentiated from the various explanations that adhere to the thesis of a non-Priestly version of the Primeval History that was only later combined with the Priestly texts. These cases usually reckon with extensive editing of a non-Priestly core by a (post-)Priestly Redaction, which may also include the addition of one or more narratives, but without extending such assessments to the entire set of non-Priestly texts in Gen 1–11.²³ The results of such analyses can sometime differ quite considerably in their details and in their overall pictures. Generally speaking, the basic set of non-Priestly texts in the Primeval History includes at least the Garden narrative, Cain’s fratricide of Abel and the genealogy of Cain and Seth, and a non-Priestly version of the Flood narrative.²⁴ The point of

²¹ See Blenkinsopp, 1992, 54–97; idem., 2002; Otto, 1999, 87–89, 91f. fn. 21; Bosshard-Nepustil, 2005, 187–246; Schüle, 2006; de Pury, 2007, 113–118; Arneith, 2007.

²² So Otto, 1996.

²³ On Gen 6:1–4, see Vervenne, 1995^a, 37–40; Witte, 1998, 71–74, 293–297; Blum, 2002, 443; Bühner, 2011; on the non-Priestly portions of Gen 6:5–8:22, see Ska, 1994; Krüger, 1997, 73–76; Kratz, 2005, 251f., 256–258; Schmid, 2002, 38f. and fn. 81; on Gen 9:20–27, see Witte, 1998, 102–105, 185–187; Gertz, 2010; on Gen 10*, see Witte, 1998, 105–114, 187–189; Knohl, 2008, 47f.; Bühner, 2017; on Gen 11:1–9, see Witte, 1998, 87–99, 189f.; Gertz, 2009^b.

²⁴ Cf. especially Kratz, 2005, 254–259, who takes up Wellhausen, 1899, 7–14 in seeing a “Yahwistic” Primeval History (Gen 2:5–4:26; 6:1, 4*; 9:19; 10:2–31; 11:2–8a) that does not know of the Flood narrative, but unlike Wellhausen, he attributes the non-Priestly passages of the Flood narrative and other texts to a post-Priestly redaction. See similarly Schmid, 2012, 155–159.

departure for this view, which this commentary also shares, is the well-known observations on the source distinction in Gen 1–3: The Priestly Creation account and the non-Priestly Garden narrative are two self-contained texts that have distinctive linguistic profiles and address the divine act of creation in their own distinctive ways but are contradictory in their overall settings and in their sequencing of the works of creation. Neither text in its basic content shows any knowledge of or reference to the other. A few harmonizations that are often cited for the redactional origin of the entire Garden narrative are actually easily detached from the narrative structure as postscripts. The tensions arising from the canonical sequence of the Creation account and the Garden narrative also extend to their secondary features and cannot be explained by the supposed intent of a midrashic commentary on Gen 1:1–2:3, and for this reason, the assumption of a redactional connection of two formerly independent texts should still be considered the simpler explanation and, therefore, the most favorable one. The situation is similar for the partially parallel genealogies in Gen 4:17–26* and Gen 5:1–32* and the Flood narrative in Gen 6:5–9:17 and is detailed in the commentary below.

For the aforementioned reasons, various models of formation maintain the thesis of a literary work opening with the Garden narrative. However, its scope and, thus, the interpretative horizon are a matter of dispute: An original affiliation of the non-Priestly texts in the Primeval History with those in the Ancestral History is one of the foundations of the classic hypothesis of a Yahwist. With von Rad's *Genesis* commentary, it became the key for identifying the Yahwist source's literary and theological profiles.²⁵ According to von Rad, the Primeval History being prefixed before the "Salvation History" that begins with Gen 12:1–3 was the original work of the Yahwist, since "there are no indications that the Yahwist was here following a received tradition. This view is thus unique, and one may still be able to sense the boldness of the first draft in this loosest part of the whole composition."²⁶ The theological conception of the composition, which itself is composed of quite disparate elements, is found in the interplay of two contrary movements: the "increase in sin to avalanche proportions"²⁷ on the one hand and the "secret increasing power of grace"²⁸ in God's forgiving act of salvation on the other. Only in the Tower of Babel narrative that concludes the work does judgment seem at first glance to have the last word. However, this points to the characteristic interlocking of the Yahwistic Primeval History with the Ancestral History. In this, the call of Abraham in Gen 12:1–3 would provide

²⁵ von Rad, 23f., 152–155. See further idem, 1938, and among the more recent studies Van Seters, 1992, 202f.; Levin, 1993, 134.

²⁶ von Rad, 23–24.

²⁷ von Rad, 152.

²⁸ von Rad, 24.

the answer to the open question of “God’s future relationship to his rebellious humanity, which is now scattered in fragments.”²⁹ At the same time, it would also open up a particular history of blessing with a universal orientation. This idea of an “increase in sin to avalanche proportions” has, however, been increasingly met with opposition.³⁰ In particular, the Flood narrative does not fit well with the larger composition that is presented. The totality of sin established in the prologue to the Flood narrative in Gen 6:5–8 and the severity of the judgment, which almost leads to the total annihilation of humanity, as well as the merciful disassociation between human guilt and divine response that is promised at the end of the Flood in Gen 8:20–22 defy this supposed logic of increase.³¹ Furthermore, compared to the Flood narrative, it is difficult to see God’s final “judgment on mankind [with] no word of grace”³² in the Tower of Babel narrative.

The thesis of an original independence of the non-Priestly Primeval History was thus developed under consideration of von Rad.³³ It is based primarily on the larger thematic and closed compositional nature of the work. While the non-Priestly Primeval History is permeated by a finely woven network of cross-references, these do not extend beyond its own textual core. This corresponds to the fact that none of the core non-Priestly ancestral narratives make any reference to the Primeval History. Especially conspicuous is the absence of any such references in Gen 12:1–3, the supposed end goal and point of contact for the non-Priestly Primeval History. Furthermore, the “conceptions of the world and its range of problems”³⁴ differ: The Primeval History personifies the whole of humanity as a tiller with existential ties to the soil (so Gen 2:5; 3:23). In contrast, the ancestral narratives paint seminomadic existence as the ideal, which must likewise appear as a cursed existence from the perspective of the Primeval History (so Gen 4:11f.). Moreover, the promises to the patriarchs were not designed to counter the impaired existence of human life as presented in the Primeval History. Even the goal of the exodus, the settlement within a “land flowing with milk and honey” (Exod 3:8; Deut 26:9; *passim*) is not characterized as an overcoming of the curse aspect of Gen 3–4.

Accordingly, the non-Priestly Primeval History is better understood when read as a composition in and of itself rather than as a dependent antecedent

²⁹ von Rad, 152.

³⁰ See already Westermann, 73f., 85f., as well as Crüsemann, 1981, 22–26.

³¹ See further Gertz, 2007.

³² von Rad, 153.

³³ For the fundamental aspects, see Crüsemann, 1981. See further Blum, 1990, 349–361; idem, 2002, 438f.; Köckert, 1988, 264–266; Carr, 1996, 234–248; Witte, 1998, 192–205; Gertz, 2009b, 10–16. See each also for the following.

³⁴ Blum, 2002, 439 [translation JWR].

to the stories of the ancestors of Israel. What remains is the question of its scope. The typical delineation, based on the final, canonical text and the traditional interpretations, sets the ending of the non-Priestly Primeval History at the Tower of Babel narrative in Gen 11:1–9.³⁵ However, given that the most important statement is usually at the end of biblical narrative texts, it is difficult to imagine that a Primeval History composed in Judah, Israel, or the Babylonian diaspora would have ended with the note, “Therefore, its name was called ‘Babel,’ because there Yhwh jumbled the language of all humanity. And from there, Yhwh scattered them over all the earth.” (Gen 11:9). This is reinforced by the difficulties in finding an analogy to the assumed sequence of “Creation – Flood – Tower Construction” in ancient Near Eastern literature, with which the non-Priestly Primeval History otherwise shows clear affinities. In contrast, the concentration on the themes of “Creation” and “Flood” are well attested.³⁶ Like the compositional coherence of Gen 2:4–8:22*, this speaks for an ending with the conclusion to the Flood narrative.³⁷ This assumption is confirmed by the results of literary analysis. As indicated in the following commentary, the cross-references within the section framed by Gen 2:4b and Gen 8:20–22 lie on a different (specifically, older) literary level than those that integrate the texts after the Flood narrative, which probably presuppose the connection with the Priestly Writing. Inside this basic outline, this commentary differentiates within the non-Priestly text between a formerly independent Primeval History and a post-Priestly “Redaction.” The author of the non-Priestly Primeval History is referred to here as the “Scholarly Narrator” [*Weisheitlicher Erzähler*].

2.2.1 *The Formerly Independent Primeval History of the Scholarly Narrator*

The following texts can be assigned to the formerly independent Primeval History of the Scholarly Narrator: Gen 2:4b–3:24* (the Garden narrative, without the harmonizations with P in Gen 2:20*; 3:14* and the expansions of the name of God from “Yhwh” to “Yhwh-God,” and also without the Paradise Geography and the motif of the Tree of Life); 4:1–5, 8b–26a; 5:28*, 29 (Cain and Abel; the Cainites and the Sethites); 6:5–7a*, 8; 7:1a, 2, 3b–5, 10a, 12, 16b, 17b, 22*, 23*; 8:2b, 6, 8–12, 13b, 20–22

³⁵ For exhaustive justifications, see Carr, 1996, 235–240; Blum, 2002, 439f. For criticism, see Gertz, 2009^b, 13–15.

³⁶ So in the Sumerian Flood Story (Introduction and Translation: J. Black, G. Cunningham, E. Robson, and G. Zólyomi. “The Flood Story.” Pages 212–215 in *The Literature of Ancient Sumer*. Edited by J. Black, G. Cunningham, E. Robson, and G. Zólyomi. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005) and in the Old Babylonian Epic of Atrahasis.

³⁷ See Witte, 1998, 184–205; Baumgart, 1999, 385–398, and further the references in Rendtorff, 1961, 74; Zenger, 1983, 35–54; Clark, 1971; Uehlinger, 1990, 339f.

(the Great Flood). Genesis 2:7αα*, 9(b*?), 10–15; 3:19b, 22, 23a*, 24; 4:6–8a; 8:7 are secondary passages, and their place in the formation of the Primeval History and their relationship to the Priestly Writing are, at parts, rather unclear.

The literary work delineated thus far comprises the themes of “Creation” and “Flood” and forms a Judean counterpart to the Mesopotamian myths of the primordial beginnings. Its compositional outline is easily presentable: It is essentially a story of a crisis and how it is overcome, as well as a description of an experienced reality perceived as ambiguous and understood as the result of a guilt-induced degradation of human existence. This story begins with the ability of humanity, acquired against the will of the Creator God, to decide between good and bad – between that which promotes life and that which is detrimental to it. The narrative then illustrates humanity choosing the bad through the example of the story of Cain and Abel, as is consolidated in the Song of Lamech regardless of any civilizational advancements. The crisis reaches its uppermost climax with the judgment pronounced upon humanity in the opening of the Flood narrative and the decision justified therein to fundamentally question the creation of life. This is then followed by the resolution in which the Creator God promises humanity’s survival after the Flood: The existence of the earth is dissociated from human action, and the ambiguity of human life is integrated into the order of Creation rather than being abolished. As a story of the fundamental questioning of Creation and the overcoming of this crisis, the Flood narrative offers both the untopped climax of and the conclusion to a narrative work that begins with the creation of human life and the basic situation of its inherent ambiguity. Moreover, this conclusion and its promise for the continuation of existence is formulated in a way that is committed to the lived reality of its authors and readers without the need for any further development.

The attribution to a Scholarly Narrator with a sapiential background takes up the frequent assessment of the non-Priestly Primeval History, and the Garden narrative in particular, as being sapientially oriented:³⁸ In Gen 2:4–3:24, the eating of the fruit from the Tree of Knowledge opens up the ability for humanity to distinguish between the good that promotes life and the bad that is detrimental to it; according to 1 Kgs 3:9, 12, this is “nothing other than practiced wisdom.”³⁹ Furthermore, the topic of human knowledge, developed in various ways, is a specifically sapiential issue, together with the question of whether and how a successful life is possible given the ambiguity of the world. So too is the reflection on human life and action in relation to

³⁸ See the overview in Schmid, 2002, 21–24, who argues alongside Otto, 1996; Witte, 1998, 201 and *passim* for locating it within the Late Wisdom tradition.

³⁹ Albertz, 1992, 16 [translation JWR]. See also Schmid, 2002, 28.

God and the world, as it pervades the entire non-Priestly Primeval History. Nevertheless, the ascription to a Scholarly Narrator should not be understood too narrowly in the sense of “Wisdom tradent circles” or a genre-specific attribution of the non-Priestly Primeval History. The participation in Wisdom themes and the Wisdom thought world can also point less specifically to the context of the learned world of the scribes.⁴⁰ The masterful use of ancient Near Eastern literary material also points in this direction. It shows an intellectuality and a textual knowledge that was especially at home in scribal education. Of particular interest is the non-Priestly version of the Flood narrative. It not only betrays a general familiarity with Mesopotamian material; it also most likely attests to a concrete knowledge of texts from Mesopotamia that served as inspiration and examples for the Scholarly Narrator as he formulated his own conception of God. However, unlike Deuteronom(ist)ic literature, which was strongly influenced by Assyrian texts, the Primeval History is not characterized by a dissociation from the foreign. Rather, its reception of Mesopotamian traditions is consistently positive, no matter the distinctiveness of the Judean reading. The origins of such textual knowledge may tentatively be linked with the court scribes during the long reign of King Manasseh of Judah (694–640 BCE) or their successors. In addition to the aforementioned manner of reception, the intensive contacts of the Jerusalem court with its Neo-Assyrian overlords also speak in favor of this.

This raises the difficult, if not unanswerable question of how to date the non-Priestly Primeval History. Recently, reference to its sapiential character has crystalized to the effect of it showing a special proximity to the “Late Wisdom” tradition.⁴¹ However, the Scholarly Narrator accents the text in other ways. In contrast to the main Late Wisdom voices, the non-Priestly Primeval History is by no means about a theological reevaluation of wisdom as revelation. It is just as little about the limitations of human knowledge, which according to Job 28 and Eccl 3:11; 8:6f., 17 deny humanity access to divine wisdom. The capacity for knowledge is not connected to piety, nor is knowledge equated with observance to the Torah. Rather, according to the Garden narrative, with the eating of the forbidden fruit, humanity acquires a general and unrestricted ability to distinguish between the good that promotes life and the bad that is detrimental to it. What is problematized, however, are the consequences of this ability, which is evaluated positively in and of itself, and of the freedom of choice that comes with it.⁴² Thus appearing is

⁴⁰ Bühner, 2014, 304f. On the fundamental importance of sapiential themes and genres for scribal education, see Carr, 2005, 126–134.

⁴¹ A detailed discussion can be found in Bühner, 2014, 290–305, who especially examines the leximatic, thematic, and stylistic similarities shared between Gen 2:4–3:24 and (Late) Wisdom texts and concludes negatively. See there also on the following.

⁴² See Schellenberg, 2002, 240–254.

a primary theme of the non-Priestly Primeval History: the ambiguity of experienced reality. The classification of the non-Priestly Primeval History within the Late Wisdom tradition therefore remains uncertain.

A proximity to Deuteronom(ist)ic theology derived primarily from the narrative arc of the transgression of the divine commandment is likewise of no help in classifying the text in terms of its literary history. The combinations of motifs mentioned in the discussion, such as listening to God's voice, the fear of God, the threat of punishment for disobeying the divine command, and the vocabulary cited are all too general and vague to serve as evidence of Deuteronom(ist)ic influence.⁴³ It is also difficult to imagine that an author influenced by Deuteronom(ist)ic texts would have refrained from adding an extensive sermon on obedience and disobedience to God's good commandments to the grandiose interrogation scene after the transgression of the divine commandment had been discovered, thus spoiling the scene.

A certain orientation of its literary history is, however, made possible by the allusions to doom prophecy in the Scholarly Narrator's Flood narrative. The idea of God's repentance and the unillusioned view of humanity presuppose the doom prophecy of the eighth and seventh centuries BCE, although not primarily through concrete textual knowledge (see Hos 11; Jer 18) but rather in terms of conceptual correspondences.⁴⁴ Fundamentally, the image of God in the non-Priestly Primeval History is quite complex and must be considered accordingly for historical classification, in both literary and theological terms. There are very different perceptions of God that are conceived together in the one God, Yhwh: the good Creator God, the punishing and caring God, the God who saves out of mercy, and the God who divinely restrains himself in the face of human wickedness. The coexistence of the different perspectives is absolutely inconceivable in the very early epochs of the religious history or literary history of ancient Israel.

2.2.2 *The Post-Priestly Redaction*

The Redaction is responsible for the connection of the Priestly Writing with the Primeval History of the Scholarly Narrator. The harmonizations of the Garden narrative with the Priestly Creation account through the expansion of the divine name "Yhwh" to "Yhwh-God," and through insertions into Gen 2:20*, 3:14*, as well as the reconciliatory notes in the Flood narrative in Gen 6:7α*βγ; 7:1b, 3a, 8–9, 10b, 17a*, 22*, 23a* should be seen in this context. The sections of Gen 6:1–4 (the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man); 9:18b (19?), 20–27 (Noah and his sons); 10:8–19, 21, 24–30

⁴³ See more specifically Blum, 2004, 15; Bühner, 2014, 305–313.

⁴⁴ See Gertz, 2007.

(expansions of the Priestly Table of Nations), and 11:1–9 (the Tower of Babel) have been written for their present context and presuppose the other non-Priestly texts and their connection with the Priestly Writing. Of course, this does not exclude the possibility that individual cases were based on older traditions, even if such traditions can no longer be clearly delineated. Additionally, further insertions into the Scholarly Narrator's Primeval History can be found in Gen 2:7aa*, 9(b*?), 10–15; 3:19b, 22, 23a*, 24; 4:6–8a; 8:7. As mentioned above, both their place within the editorial history of the Primeval History and their relationship to the Priestly Writing are, at parts, rather unclear.

The texts assigned to the Redaction are undoubtedly not the product of one author or a singular editorial process. On the one hand, a few of the sections that can be labeled as “redactional” still show traces of even later editing. Such is the case with, for example, the addition of further geographic material to the Table of Nations in Gen 10 after it had already undergone earlier redactional reworking. On the other hand, some of the redactional texts provide their own distinct emphases, causing them to stand out from the rest of the redactional texts regardless of the recognized cross-references. The profiles of the redactional texts come in each case through the references to their immediate context as well as the inclusion of problems that lie far outside the Primeval History. This is explained in detail in the commentary below. For the profile of the redactional final form of the Primeval History, see again the first section of this introduction above.

3. THE BIBLICAL PRIMEVAL HISTORY IN THE CONTEXT OF ANCIENT NEAR EASTERN LITERATURE

The structure and content of the biblical Primeval History are not unique to the narratives of the Hebrew Bible. For a few of the narratives and motifs, this was recognized already in antiquity and would have almost been considered completely natural and expected. How could a universal incident like the Flood not have made its way into the memory of all humanity, descending from Noah? But it was only with the rediscovery and decipherment of the original cuneiform documents beginning in the nineteenth century that it became clear how closely the biblical Primeval History is connected to Mesopotamian traditions. When George Smith presented the original text of a Mesopotamian flood story for the first time in 1872, it became a scientific and societal sensation.⁴⁵ The similarities to the biblical Flood narrative were so striking that the assumption of a historical connection between the two

⁴⁵ Smith, 1873/1874, 213–234.

compositions was unavoidable. This was something of a return back to the Judeo-Roman historian Flavius Josephus, who already in the first century CE recognized Noah as the Flood hero from Mesopotamian tradition (Josephus, *A.J.* 1.93). With the discovery of more and more Mesopotamian texts, it quickly became clear that the Flood narrative and other content of Gen 1–11 known from the Mesopotamian traditions were not genuinely Israelite traditions. Incidentally, the biblical text itself also suggests this, since the biblical Primeval History locates most of its narratives in the area around the Tigris and the Euphrates. However, the question of which texts the biblical authors knew and used for their own writings is just as difficult to answer in the individual cases as that of how and why such foreign traditions were received and incorporated.

There are three great Mesopotamian epics that are generally mentioned as parallels and precursors of the biblical Primeval History: The Epic of Gilgamesh, the Epic of Atrahasis, and Enuma Eliš, the epic of Marduk.

1. The Epic of Gilgamesh was known throughout the ancient Near East into the Hellenistic period.⁴⁶ Using the example of the outstanding ruler and hero Gilgamesh, it reflects upon humanity's search for life in the face of death and mortality. Certain individual features of the epic have repeatedly been connected with the Garden narrative of the Scholarly Narrator in Gen 2:4–3:24, including the serpent wresting the plant of immortality from the hero, or the creation of the wild man Enkidu from clay and his "humanization" in stages from "wildling" to "civilized human being." Deserving of special attention is the story of the Flood in Tablet XI of the epic, which is itself an excerpt from the Epic of Atrahasis. The similarities with the biblical Flood narrative extend even to its details. This is difficult to explain through simply the inclusion of a broadly known plot about the Great Flood and is most likely based on a direct knowledge of the text.

2. Apart from the biblical Flood narrative, the Old Babylonian Epic of Atrahasis is also of particular interest, because it also presents the sequence known from the biblical Primeval History of "Creation (of Humanity) – Flood."⁴⁷ According to the Epic of Atrahasis, humans are created in order to relieve the gods of their work and to provide for their sustenance. However, humanity's multiplication leads to conflict with the gods, who then seek to annihilate humanity first with plagues and then, ultimately, with the Great Flood. By the end of the Flood, the gods' relationship to each other and to

⁴⁶ For translation and commentary, see Maul, 2014 and George, 2020. For introduction, see further Sallaberger, 2008.

⁴⁷ Translation and short introduction: von Soden, W. "Der altbabylonische Atramchasis-Mythos." Pages 612–645 in *TUAT III*. A translation of the Late Babylonian version with a synoptic comparison can be found in Hecker, K. "Atra-ḫasīs." Pages 132–143 in *TUAT.NF VIII*; Foster, *Muses*, 227–253, 256–267. See further van Koppen, 2012.

humanity has basically been resolved: The gods are dependent upon provisions from humanity, making a renewed attempt to destroy them unwise.

3. The Babylonian epic of Marduk, *Enuma Eliš*, probably dates from the reign of Nebuchadnezzar I (ca. 1125–1104 BCE) and is attested by numerous textual witnesses from the first half of the first millennium BCE. It tells of the origins and ordering of the world and extols the accession of the Babylonian city god, Marduk, to king of the gods.⁴⁸ The depiction of the world before its creation echoes several motifs of the Priestly Creation account in Gen 1:1–2:3.

These three texts are some of the best-known literary works of the ancient Near East by number as well as temporal and geographic dispersion of their textual witnesses. Fragments of the Epic of Gilgamesh were found at Israelite Megiddo and at Emar on the mid-Euphrates, and a Middle Babylonian recension of the Epic of Atrahasis was found at Ugarit, attesting to these two epics being known to the Levant.⁴⁹ Passages of *Enuma Eliš* and the Epic of Gilgamesh are attested on so-called “school tablets.” Copying and memorizing these two works was obviously part of the curriculum of scribal education in Mesopotamia. It therefore follows that Judean scribes, who had to learn the language and script of the political and cultural hegemonic power in order to pursue diplomatic careers, would have also been familiar with them, at least to a certain extent. Additionally, these are literary compositions based on older narrative material and traditions, which is why the biblical authors may have come to individual narrative tropes and motifs by other modes of transmission.

Regardless of the Judean scribes’ possible and, in the case of the Flood narrative, even highly probable familiarity with the Mesopotamian texts, each individual case must be examined very carefully for the extent to which the similarities can be explained by knowledge of the text or material, or whether they are simply based on a similar view or experience of the world. To anticipate the commentary below, this can be illustrated by a few examples: The Priestly Creation account in Gen 1:1–2:3 shares ideas, motifs, and linguistic forms with a whole range of Mesopotamian, Egyptian, and Greek texts. Furthermore, there is a close proximity to the cosmological ideas in the book of Ezekiel, which in turn has close connections to Mesopotamian texts. Thus, the Priestly Creation account stands within a whole network of texts with which it shares demonstrable relations or similarities. For example, its strict systemization of living beings like a biological taxonomy according to species

⁴⁸ Translation and short introduction: Lambert, W.G. “*Enuma Eliš*.” Pages 565–602 in *TUAT III*; idem., 2013; Hecker, K. Pages 88–132 in *TUAT.NF VIII*.

⁴⁹ On Megiddo, see Hecker, K. “Das akkadische Gilgamesch-Epos.” Pages 646–744, 670 in *TUAT III*; Goren et al., 2009; on Emar, see Arnaud, 1987; on Ugarit, see Kämmerer, 1993.

and genus is clearly reminiscent of the natural philosophy of the Pre-Socratics, who themselves show contacts to Neo-Assyrian commentaries on the classic mythical texts of Mesopotamia. This speaks against a unilinear derivation of the Priestly Creation account from *Enuma Eliš*. Instead, the authors of the Priestly Writing should be located in principle in an Eastern Mediterranean/ Near Eastern cultural and intellectual milieu that drew significant inspiration from Mesopotamia.⁵⁰

In contrast, the idea of the creation of both Adam and Gilgamesh's companion Enkidu from clay might be based on a comparable experience of the world (Gen 2:7; Gilgm 1.101–112). Like the corresponding assertion of humanity (once again) becoming dust or clay in death (so Gen 3:19; Gilgm 10.68f., *passim*), it can be sufficiently explained by the practice from across the ancient Near East, including Israel, of burying the body of the deceased rather than cremating it. Likewise, no adoption of Mesopotamian material need be assumed for the serpent in Gen 3, which scholars repeatedly connect to the Epic of Gilgamesh. The appearances of the snake in the two texts differ quite clearly in their details. Furthermore, snakes are considered to be particularly clever across cultures and, moreover, appear frequently in the iconography of ancient Israel in connection with sacred trees. Thus, the snake is destined, even without recourse to the Epic of Gilgamesh, to seduce humanity into eating the forbidden fruit from the Tree of Knowledge – although this by no means excludes the Scholarly Narrator's potential familiarity with the Epic of Gilgamesh.

These examples should already make clear that the biblical authors would generally draw from the whole wealth of ideas attested across ancient Near Eastern literature and only in isolated cases borrow directly from a particular text recognizable to modern readers. Although the authors of the biblical Primeval History were doubtlessly familiar with the Mesopotamian material, this should not be cast against an explanation of the texts from within their own historical context, which was influenced by ancient Near Eastern culture more generally. This applies not only to the origin of the material but also and primarily to the problems addressed in them.

The comparative view of the traditions of other peoples was and is frequently connected with the question of the claim of validity for the biblical tradition. For some, the existence of parallel traditions is a guarantee of the biblical account's historicity. For others, it serves as proof that the biblical tradition cannot lay claim to originality, with its recognition as a testimony to revelation being fundamentally called into question in many cases. The controversy about the relationship of the biblical Primeval History to the other

⁵⁰ See Gertz, 2009^a.

literature of the ancient Near East became particularly heated in the so-called “Babel-Bible Controversy” triggered in 1902 by a lecture from the Assyriologist Friedrich Delitzsch (1850–1922) in the presence of Kaiser Wilhelm II and leaders of the court, academia, and church. This caused an animated debate within the German public about the relationship between “Babel” and the “Bible” for a good two years.⁵¹ Delitzsch argued that the Hebrew Bible, and especially the biblical Primeval History, was an unoriginal adaption of Mesopotamian traditions, and he increasingly asserted throughout the controversy the cultural, moral, and even religious superiority of Babylonian-Assyrian culture over the Hebrew Bible. He ultimately denied that the Hebrew Bible was of any use for Christianity.

Far more sophisticated and nuanced was the judgment from the research influenced by Wellhausen and from the so-called “History of Religions School.” Both also emphasized the integration of the Hebrew Bible within the world of the ancient Near East, but in contrast to Delitzsch and other supports of “Panbabylonism,” they also accentuated the individuality of the religion and culture of ancient Israel. Karl Budde, as one example, raised the question of how Mesopotamian materials and traditions were mediated, and he stated that a massive influence of Mesopotamian culture on Israel was demonstrable only for the period of Assyrian hegemony over Syria-Palestine in the eighth and seventh centuries BCE and during the Babylonian Exile in the sixth century BCE. The inclusion of the Flood narrative within the biblical Primeval History was, to Budde, a product of the Assyrian period and is characterized by how the narrative, taken up from their Assyrian conquerors, was received under the auspices of their own religion and their idea of the one and only, just God.⁵² According to Hermann Gunkel, Israel was never in direct contact with Mesopotamian myths; instead, they were mediated through the Canaanite city-state culture during the process of Israelite settlement and state formation.⁵³ Over time, Israel accepted this inherited property as its own and, in an inner-Israelite process of reformation, transferred it into an increasingly more prudent way of thinking about God and the world. Accordingly, per Gunkel and unlike Delitzsch, understandings of the Primeval History should not come from reading it against the contrasting background of Mesopotamian texts. Yet, this independence of the biblical texts is based on a thesis with many assumptions about the early history of Israel and the beginnings of the Hebrew Bible’s literary history that are difficult to reconcile with the present state of research. For this reason, the older assessment by Budde

⁵¹ See Lehmann, 1994; Liwak, 1998.

⁵² Budde, 1903.

⁵³ Gunkel, 1894. See further his commentary on the Creation account and the Flood narrative (Gunkel, 67–74, 117–122, 151).

is more appropriate, as it connects the knowledge of genuine Mesopotamian material with the Neo-Assyrian and later Neo-Babylonian hegemony and the cultural contacts that came with them. This, however, puts the spotlight on the question of why the Mesopotamian traditions were received by biblical authors.

One common explanation has tried to understand especially the Creation account in Gen 1:1–2:3 as an anti-Babylonian polemic.⁵⁴ However, even just the completely nonpolemical tone of the Priestly authors contradicts this proposal. The oft-cited designation of the sun and moon as “luminaries” (Gen 1:14–19) is not actually aimed at devaluing the Babylonian astral deities. Rather, it stands in the context of an attempt observable across the entire Mediterranean from the seventh century BCE onwards to integrate the insights from a new conception of observing nature with older, traditional ideas (see the Exegesis of Gen 1:14–19 below).

More recent studies have adjusted this polemical reading, understanding parts or the whole of the biblical Primeval History, following postcolonial literary theory, as a “countertext” that has subversively appropriated the literature of the hegemonic powers through mimicry and inversion.⁵⁵ This interpretation also presupposes that the biblical authors consistently referred directly to the Mesopotamian texts and sought to distinguish themselves from them. However, neither assumption is without problems, and it remains difficult to demonstrate for each individual case that the biblical texts were conceived as “countertexts.” Is it actually clear that the biblical authors located the expulsion from the Garden of Eden in Mesopotamia in order to compensate for the stigma of being a politically inferior latecomer among the ancient civilizations?⁵⁶ Is this interpretation in line with the etiological orientation of the Garden narrative of the Scholarly Narrator, who leaves the Garden of Eden “mythically far away, in the land of delight [גֶּדֶן, Eden]” (Gen 2:8) even after the expulsion and whose assertions about the ambiguity of human life and humanity’s propensity for evil (Gen 6:5; 8:21) apply to all people? Also questionable is whether the concept of humanity as the image of God (Gen 1:26–28) is meant as a critique of the great kings of Mesopotamia’s claims to sovereignty.⁵⁷ Here, too, the immanent explanation is far more convincing: The concept of humanity’s likeness to God and its commission to rule over the earth is an example of the transformation of religious ideas produced by the reflection upon the loss of king, land, and temple in exile. In this case, it is monarchic ideology that the kings in Jerusalem

⁵⁴ For a critical assessment of this thesis, see Gertz, 2009^a.

⁵⁵ See Hendel, 2005; Frahm, 2013, esp. 115f. Assessment in Carr, 2020, 8–15.

⁵⁶ So Hendel, 2005, 24.

⁵⁷ See *ibid.*, 27.

would have shared in one way or another with the entire ancient Near East and that was transferred into anthropology by the authors of the Priestly Writing. There is no doubt that the result of this transformation can also be read as a critique of authority, but this critique plays no role in the Priestly Primeval History itself. Also of interest is the counterexample to this. The story of Noah and his sons in Gen 9:18–29 is clearly polemical in nature. Of course, the polemic of this text, which was added into the Primeval History rather late, is directed not against Babylon but against the “Canaanites.” The basic sense of this polemic and that of comparable passages in the Table of Nations is entirely for the sake of the contrast between “Israel” and “Canaan” developed widely throughout the Hebrew Bible.

However, despite these critical questions, it cannot be ruled out from the outset that the biblical authors, with their myth of the primordial beginnings, related themselves both positively and negatively to the Mesopotamian traditions known to them, and, thus, to the leading intellectual culture. Therefore, it can be assumed with good reason that the Tower of Babel narrative traces back to a derisive poem against Babylon and its temple-tower. On the other hand, the story of the Great Flood, the only section of the Primeval History that betrays a clear, direct textual knowledge of Mesopotamian tradition, shows that its authors were concerned not with a critical debate with its foreign predecessor but with clarifying their own conceptions of God, the world, and humanity. The choice of the Mesopotamian myth of the Great Flood for this internal clarification may simply have resulted from the fact that, due to the political circumstances, Mesopotamian culture was quite in vogue in Israel for a time.

Few texts of the Hebrew Bible show as close of an interweaving with other ancient Near Eastern cultures as does the Primeval History. Its authors were doubtlessly familiar with the traditions of Mesopotamia. They knew its motifs, narrative materials, and, in specific cases, also certainly its texts. But even if the biblical authors frequently share certain conceptions with the other cultures of the ancient Near East and repeatedly arrive at similar answers for comparable questions about life, the world, and human existence, the historical distinctiveness of the biblical Primeval History (like all other literature from the ancient Near East) is indisputable in its aesthetics and theology. The fundamental questions about the origins of the world and how it was ordered, the dawn of humanity, and the emergence of civilization are all considered against a genuinely “Hebrew Bible” background and are unfolded with a view to the later Israel and the history of its God, as is shown clearly in the Priestly texts through the increasing focus of the *toledot* on the ancestors of Abraham and the correspondences between Creation and the tent-sanctuary. In short: The biblical Primeval History is the highly individualized expression of the ancient Near Eastern myth of the primordial beginnings.

COMMENTARY

THE CREATION OF THE WORLD

- 1:1 In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth.
2 And the earth was an empty void, and darkness lay over the deep, and the breath of God hovered over the waters.
3 Then God said, “Let there be light!” And there was light.
4 And God saw the light as good. And God divided between the light and the darkness.
5 Then God called the light “day,” and the darkness he called “night.” And there was evening, and there was morning: one day.
6 Then God said, “Let there be a firmament in the midst of the waters to separate the waters from the waters.”
7 And God made the firmament, separating the waters under the firmament from the waters above the firmament. And so it happened.
8 Then God called the firmament “heaven.” And there was evening, and there was morning: a second day.
9 Then God said, “Let the waters under the heavens gather themselves to one place, so that dry land appears.” And so it happened.
10 Then God called the dry land “earth” and the collection of the waters he called “sea.” And God saw it as good.
11 Then God said, “Let the earth green with young greenery: plants yielding seed and fruit trees bearing fruit, according to their kind, in which their seed is upon the earth.” And so it happened.
12 And the earth brought forth young greenery: plants yielding seed according to their kind, and trees bearing fruit with its seed according to its kind. And God saw it as good.
13 And there was evening, and there was morning: a third day.
14 Then God said, “Let there be lights on the firmament of heaven to separate between the day and the night. And let them serve as signs, for seasons and for days and for years.
15 And let them serve as lights on the firmament of heaven in order to light the earth.” And so it happened.
16 Then God made the two great lights, the greater light for dominion over the day and the smaller light for dominion over the night, as well as the stars.
17 And God set them on the firmament of heaven in order to light the earth

- 18 and to rule over the day and the night and to separate between the light and the darkness. And God saw it as good.
- 19 And there was evening and there was morning: a fourth day.
- 20 Then God said, "Let the water teem with the teeming of living beings and let flying animals fly over the earth, all along the firmament of heaven."
- 21 Then God created the great sea serpents and all living beings with which the waters teem according to their kind, and all winged flying animals according to their kind. And God saw it as good.
- 22 And God blessed them, saying, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the waters in the seas, and let the flying animals be vast upon the earth!"
- 23 And there was evening, and there was morning: a fifth day.
- 24 Then God said, "Let the earth bring forth living beings according to their kind: livestock and crawling animals and the wild animals of the earth according to their kind." And so it happened.
- 25 Then God made the wild animals of the earth according to their kind and the livestock according to its kind and everything that crawls upon the earth according to its kind. And God saw it as good.
- 26 And God said, "Let us make humanity as our image, like an image akin to us, so that they may rule over the fish of the sea and over the flying animals of the heavens and over the livestock and over all [of the wild animals] of the earth and over all crawling animals that crawl upon the earth."
- 27 Then God created humanity as his image. As the image of God he created them. Male and female he created them.
- 28 And God blessed them, and God said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth and take possession of it and rule over the fish of the sea and over the flying animals of the heavens and over every living being that crawls upon the earth."
- 29 Then God said, "Behold, I give you all plants yielding seed that are upon the face of the whole earth, and all trees with fruit that produce seed. It shall be food for you.
- 30 And to all living beings and all flying animals of the heavens and all crawling animals upon the earth in which there is the breath of life, [I give] every green plant as food." And so it happened.
- 31 And God saw everything that he had made, and behold, it was very good. And there was evening, and there was morning: the sixth day.

- 2:1** So were the heavens and the earth completed, and their entire host.
2 And on the seventh day, God completed his work that he had done, and on the seventh day, he rested from his work that he had done.
3 Then God blessed the seventh day and sanctified it, because during it he had rested from all his work that God had created by doing it.

Analysis: This section comes from the Priestly Writing. Gen 2:1 is a secondary Priestly insertion.

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TEXT-CRITICAL AND PHILOLOGICAL NOTES

1:1 בְּרֵאשִׁית (*In the beginning*): For the lack of article in בְּרֵאשִׁית “In the beginning,” see the Exegesis below. Verse 1 functions as an epigraph, while the content of v. 2 describes the state from before v. 1.

2 מְרַחֶפֶת (*hovered*): The root רָחַף is attested elsewhere only in Deut 32:11 (concerning the flight of an eagle) and Jer 23:9 (“my limbs shake [רָחַף; q.]”). For the above translation, see also the Ugaritic attestations of the root: “And may Anat fly, may the kite soar (*rhpt* [**rhṗ* D]) [in] the hig<h> [heav]ens” (*KTU* 1.108, 8f = Wyatt, 1998, 397). Far less likely is the translation suggested by Gunkel, “and the Spirit of God brooded” (see Gunkel, 106). Gunkel’s reference to the Syriac **rhṗ* is problematic, since in the D stem, the verb likely means simply “to fly” and not, as noted in older lexicons, also “to brood.” In turn, Gunkel’s translation has inspired considerations about a connection with cosmological ideas of a cosmic egg hatched by the primordial goddess, as attested in Egypt among other places.

5 יוֹם אֶחָד (*one day*): For the use of the cardinal number and how its contexts require understanding it as an ordinal number, see *GKC* §§98a, 134p. According to Rashi, the cardinal number was chosen in order to emphasize the uniqueness of the first day.

6 The Creation account in Gen 1:1–2:3 is particularly carefully constructed and structured through the recurrence of certain formal elements. See further in the Exegesis below. The LXX follows the scheme and in v. 6 has the

event formula “And so it happened” immediately following the command (see vv. 9, 11, 15, 24, 30). Conversely, in the MT, the formula deviates from the scheme but stands appropriately between where the function of the firmament is defined (v. 7) and where it is named (v. 8). The LXX, standing alone against the main textual witnesses, provides a harmonizing translation. This is also true for the addition in v. 8 of the typical approval formula “And God saw it as good” (see vv. 4, 12, 18, 21, 31).

7 וַיִּבְדֵּל (*separating*): It is not completely clear whether God or the firmament is the subject of the “separating.” Where God is the subject, he is otherwise always explicitly named (e.g., v. 8a). This and the verse’s correspondence to v. 6 indicate that it is a subordinate clause to the first verbal clause in v. 7, which takes the firmament as its subject (see Jacob, 38–41; Steck, 1975, 78–81, 256).

9 Here, the LXX provides the missing execution notice: “And the water [sing.] under the heavens was gathered to their [pl.] gathering place, so that dry land appeared.” The MT should be maintained as the better attested, more difficult, and shorter reading (see also the text-critical notes in the *BHQ*, and cf. Hendel, 1998, 120f.). The LXX is possibly based on an earlier Hebrew version, given that the plural form of the personal pronoun (αὐτῶν) does not fit the singular form of its reference, “water” (ὕδωρ) and possibly presupposes the plural form of the Hebrew (הַמַּיִם). In this case, already the Hebrew original of the LXX provides a harmonizing reading (Wellhausen, 1899, 184).

11 דֶּשֶׁא ... תִּדְשֵׂא (*green with young greenery*): Contra the LXX (βοτάνην χόρτου), “greenery” and “plants” should not be translated together as a single term.

וְיָרֵךְ [וְ] (*and fruit trees*): The copula is missing in the MT. The reading with the copula is well attested (LXX, SP, Pesh, Vulg, some MS of Tg. Ps.-J.); see v. 12.

14 יְהִי (*Let there be*): On the singular verb form, see *GKC* §145o.

“The firmament of heaven”: The LXX and SP provide here an expanded text based on vv. 15, 17.

וְשָׁנִים (*for years*): The MT lacks the preposition לְ attested in 4QGen^k, Frag. 2 (DJD XII, 77), Pesh and LXX (εἰς).

16 הַמְּאֹר הַגָּדֹל (*the greater light*): The sequence of two opposite adjectives with the definite article is a way of expressing the comparative form. See *GKC* §133f.

20 עוֹף (*flying animals*): עוֹף is commonly translated collectively as “birds,” but the term actually designates all flying animals, including bats and insects (see Lev 11:19, 20–24). See also the explanatory כְּנָף “wings” in v. 21 as a generic term for all winged animals (עוֹף).

The MT lacks the event formula “and so it happened.” The deviation from the pattern is unexplainable and the LXX does not provide any text-critical solution to the problem. Moreover, the LXX understands the command as analogous to vv. 11, 25: The water is to bring forth crawling animals and birds (so also Ibn Ezra). The formulation of the second sub-verse speaks against this view.

26 [*wild animals*]: Despite the rather weak attestation from the Peshitta, חַיָּה “wild animals” can probably be added in light of vv. 24, 25 and the mention of the commission to rule the earth (MT: וּבְכָל-הָאָרֶץ “over all the earth”), which is strange and otherwise too incidental within the listing of the animals. The MT וּבְכָל-הָאָרֶץ may have also resulted from a haplography from the fuller rendering that follows, וּבְכָל-הָרֶמֶשׂ ... עַל-הָאָרֶץ “over all crawling animals... upon the earth.” The error must have been made quite early in the textual tradition.

27 בְּצַלְמוֹ (*as his image*): The LXX leaves בְּצַלְמוֹ untranslated, because of a reading error (homoioarcton) or for stylistic reasons (see Rösel, 1994, 50).

28 וַיֹּאמֶר לָהֶם אֱלֹהִים (*and God said to them*): Based on v. 22, the LXX formulates this phrase more appealingly and reduces the second verbal clause to simply λέγων.

חַיָּה (*living being*): חַיָּה actually refers to wild animals in contrast to domesticated animals (בְּהֵמָה; see v. 26, where the “wild animals” should be added, following Pesh). However, it is used here as a collective term for all animals living on the earth, including crawling animals. Verse 30 probably uses חַיָּה more as a generic term for “wild animals” and “livestock” while the crawling animals are specifically mentioned separately. The LXX and Pesh harmonize the subdivided listing of the animal kingdom with v. 26.

30 [*I give*]: This should be added corresponding to v. 29.

31 On this construction, see Joüon/Muraoka §138b.

2:2 בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי (*on the seventh day*): Contra the LXX, SP, and Pesh as well as most manuscripts of Lat (see further Jub 2:1, 16, 25), which read “sixth day” in v. 2a. The MT should probably be maintained as the *lectio difficilior*. See the Exegesis below (contra Hendel, 1998, 122f.; Krüger, 2009, according to whom the MT reading is based on a scribal mistake caused by the near-identical endings of vv. 2a and 2b).

ESSENTIALS AND PERSPECTIVES

The Priestly Writing’s account of the creation of the world in seven days in Gen 1:1–2:3 is one of the most well-known and impactful texts of the

Hebrew Bible. Over the centuries, it has shaped understandings of the origin and ordering of the world. Although it has been superseded by scientific models for explaining the cosmos and the development of life, it is more present than almost any other text of the Bible, even in postsecular cultures, because of not only the significant impact of its reception but also its linguistic power. The first sentence of the Creation account has one of the most incisive openings of literature. In biblical literature, it is at best equalled by the prologue of the Gospel of John (1:1–5). The description of the original state of the world as an empty void, Heb. “*tohu wa-bohu*,” is proverbial. Moreover, the chapter’s importance can hardly be overestimated for any anthropology shaped by Judeo-Christian tradition. The doctrine of humanity having been created in the image of God (*imago dei*), which classifies humanity in between visible Creation and invisible Creation due to it possessing both body and soul, is based on Gen 1:26f. The commission in Gen 1:28 for humanity’s dominion over the earth (*dominium terrae*) has contributed significantly to the “disenchantment of the world” (Max Weber), providing a crucial prerequisite for humanity’s formative interaction with the world. The idea of humanity’s likeness to God and its commission to rule originated in ancient Near Eastern royal ideology, in which the king was seen as divinely appointed. In Gen 1:1–2:3, this idea is transformed into a basic anthropological statement, thereby gaining emancipatory significance. This, in turn, gives it great significance for contemporary theological justifications for human dignity. The theological doctrine of creation from nothing (*creatio ex nihilo*) underscores how divine action in Creation has no prerequisites and invokes the report of the creation of the world in seven days. Contrary to a long interpretative tradition, however, this idea originated in Hellenistic thought and was not yet present in Gen 1:1f. At most, the earliest biblical evidence for it can be found only in 2 Macc 7:28 (see also Rom 4:17; Heb 11:3). It should be noted, however, that the idea of the universalism of the transcendent Creator God is unquestionably one of the conceptual presuppositions of Gen 1:1–2:3.

The literary shape of the Priestly Creation account is difficult to characterize. Already Johann Gottfried Herder had noted that the text defies any sort of genre classification due to its potency and uniqueness.¹ Even if it is firmly integrated down even to its details within the conceptual and linguistic world of the ancient Near East, no analogy has yet been found for the work as a whole. Designations as “myth” or even “narrative” are inadequate, since the text, unlike the Garden narrative, has no plot, develops no tension arcs, and, strictly speaking, offers no resolution to any problem presented at its beginning. Although the act of God’s creation is narrated, it is still a “narrative

¹ See Bultmann, 1999, 149f.

that is not actually a narrative.”² It neither depicts the divine battle against chaos nor stages Creation itself. Rather, the text presents its theologically interpreted knowledge of the world, developing the single idea of God as being the Creator. Insofar as this theological doctrine and the knowledge of the world that comes with it are presented through a temporal sequence of acts of creation, it seems best to speak of a Creation “account,” as also suggested by its matter-of-fact, just-the-essentials reporting style. However, the clear, detached, almost monotonous structure is not only a matter of style; it also serves an unmistakable purpose in terms of its content. During a time of crisis, when Israel had lost its king, land, and independence and was exposed to the unassailable culture of its Babylonian (or Persian) overlords, and all seemed hopeless and ephemeral, the language of the Creation account alone emphasized “how well-ordered, constant, reliable, and rhythmically recurring God made Creation.”³ Thus, behind the scientific prose stands an affirmation of the reliability of the one God and his order of Creation, which in turn found linguistic expression in the hymnic elements of the text.⁴ In this sense, it is a theological treatise on the fundamental order of the world.

The Creation account in the Priestly Writing is the result of centuries of (priestly) scholarship. Verse by verse, it shows its close connection with the cosmological beliefs of the ancient Near East, less through the reception of specific, identifiable texts and more through participation in a broader stream of tradition. Compared to other accounts of the creation of the world, the Priestly Writing’s Creation account possesses distinct features explainable through the stipulations of its own tradition and the historical context of its authors. Contrary to a popular interpretive tradition, the Priestly Creation account is not characterized by any polemical differentiation from its environment.⁵ Genesis 1:1–2:3 is not a counter to a specific text of high Mesopotamian culture such as the oft-mentioned epic of Marduk, *Enuma Eliš*.⁶ Rather, it is the specific contribution of late-exilic or early post-exilic Israel to a debate being conducted beyond its own borders. In this, for very different reasons and under very different conditions, a new mentality emerged in which the mythical tradition was combined with the beginnings of a worldview best described as “technical” and “scientific” in its approach to nature. The worldview that emerges is equally “exact” from the perspectives of both mythology and natural science. The most well-known proponents of such are certainly the Ionian natural philosophers, whose proximity to Gen 1 has long been

² Westermann, 112 [translation JWR from German original].

³ Seebaß, 62 [translation JWR].

⁴ See Janowski, 2012, 506f.

⁵ See Gertz, 2009^a, there also with individual references for the following.

⁶ So again Frahm, 2013.

noted.⁷ Like the authors of the Priestly Writing, they oriented themselves towards the leading Mesopotamian scholarship of their time,⁸ which also explains the similarities between the two. This is especially clear in the account of the creation of the heavenly bodies, where, by the pure chance of transmission, a Neo-Assyrian commentary on *Enuma Eliš* has been preserved whose cosmology shows equally close proximity to the Pre-Socratics and to Ezek 1 and Gen 1. One example of the introduction of a new mentality into the inherited tradition, besides the taxonomy of the works of creation, is the prominent use of the creation verb *ברא* at the beginning and end of the Priestly Creation account as well as in the creation of humanity. Of all the verbs used in the Hebrew Bible for acts of divine creation, it has the highest degree of theological abstraction. It is reserved exclusively for God, has no analogy in manual labor, and is never connected with any mention of material. The verb removes the act of creation from any possible human conceivability (see below, Scholarly Exposition II on v. 1). In contrast, the Priestly Writing also reports traditionally of “God doing” something or “making the earth sprout,” since it must resort to figurative ideas when describing God’s acts of creation. Finally, reference can also be made to the literary shape of Gen 1:1–2:3. The new mentality found a new form of expression through scientific prose, as with the case of Anaximander of Miletus. The work of Anaximander is considered to be the first Greek book written in prose, just as the Priestly Writing has no classic precedents within the Hebrew Bible for the form of its Creation account.

Needless to say, the authors of the Priestly Creation account drew on the knowledge of their time concerning natural science. Like their contemporaries in Ionia or Mesopotamia, they sought to mediate this through preexisting mythological ideas. However, their knowledge of natural science has proven without a shadow of a doubt to have been a product of their time and has been overtaken by the modern natural sciences – which are also on their part a product of their time. At first sight, this inescapable conclusion is difficult to reconcile with the normative claim of the biblical texts in their current religious use. Thus, it is easy to explain why supporters of Creationism (or its variants, such as *Intelligent Design*) have sought to position the biblical natural science against modern geology and evolutionary biology.⁹ The Priestly Writing is based on the knowledge of natural science from its time and successfully endeavors to mediate it. Yet, it is for exactly this reason that the invocation of timeless, revelatory knowledge for the sake of upholding

⁷ See already Wellhausen, 1905 with reference to Thales of Miletus (ca. 640–562 BCE) and his successors Anaximander of Miletus (ca. 610–546 BCE) and Anaximenes of Miletus (ca. 580–528 BCE).

⁸ For the Ionian natural philosophers, see Burkert, 2004, esp. 49–70.

⁹ See Schwöbel, 2010.

outdated, ancient understandings of natural science against the insights of modern natural sciences actually contradicts the intent of the Priestly Writing itself. Nor can the Priestly Writing be used to justify using the biblical texts in order to crusade against scientific explanations of the origin of the world and challenge them despite better insights. On the other hand, those who declare the biblical claims about the world as God's Creation to be obsolete in light of modern understandings of the scientific errors in Gen 1:1–2:3 miss the fact that the Priestly Writing is not primarily about cosmology (otherwise, the underworld and the heavens above the firmament would not be missing from the narrative). Instead, it is an interpretation of the living, experienceable world that draws on contemporary natural science. In this respect, the Priestly Creation account is more "enlightened" than many of its modern critics. Although the professional distinction between *explaining* the world and *interpreting* it should be expected for antiquity only rudimentarily at best, it is nevertheless present in its basic form. The Priestly Writing does not demand any sacrifice of rationality or the renunciation of a progressive, scientific theorizing or explanation of the world. Rather, it demonstrates how a world understood through natural history can be interpreted through the idea of the universality and transcendence of God.

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION I: INTRODUCTION TO THE EXEGESIS

Structure: The Priestly Creation account in Gen 1:1–2:3 is one of the most carefully and thoughtfully formulated texts of the Hebrew Bible. The continual repetition of individual formal elements and the clear temporal structure of the one week of creation gives the impression of a well-planned and highly reflected composition. Every single act of creation begins with God's command: "And God said..." (Gen 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26). This is typically followed by the formulaic declaration of the correspondence between command and realization, "And so it happened" (Gen 1:7, 9, 11, 15, 24, 30; also LXX v. 20) and a concise report about the implementation of the command as well as the divine approval of the act: "And God saw it as good" (Gen 1:4, 10, 12, 18, 21, 25, 31; also LXX v. 8). Each day of creation ends with a count of the days: "There was evening, and there was morning: a second day," etc. (Gen 1:5, 8, 13, 19, 23, 31; 2:2–3). The seven-day scheme follows a strict logic:¹⁰ The state of the world before Creation is characterized by the absence of order through time and space (Gen 1:2: darkness and the primordial deep). Time is established on the first day of creation with the fundamental alternation of night/darkness and day/light (Gen 1:3–5).

¹⁰ See Zenger, 1987, 71–80, 200; Janowski, 2004, 200. Sceptically: Steck, 1991, 288–292.

The separation of the undivided waters of the deep into sky, sea, and land on the second and third days establishes space (Gen 1:6–8, 9–13). Furthermore, time and the steady passage of day and night are even more finely structured on the fourth and seventh days. The creation of the heavenly bodies on the fourth day enables a rhythmic organization under the solar and lunar calendars and the observance of special festivals (Gen 1:14–19). God’s rest on the seventh day of creation establishes the counting of weeks and the distinction between days of work and days of rest (Gen 2:2–3). Spatial order still defines the fifth and sixth days of creation, insofar as it involves populating the three spatial spheres through sea creatures in the waters, flying creatures in the sky (Gen 1:20–23), and land animals (Gen 1:24–25) and humanity on the earth (Gen 1:26–31). This results in an overall structure in which the days belong to the categories of either “time” or “space”: Time (Day 1) – Space (Days 2 and 3) – Time (Day 4) – Space (Days 5 and 6) – Time (Day 7), with the phrase that concludes the seventh day of creation (אֶשְׁרֵי-בָרָא אֱלֹהִים; Gen 2:3) simultaneously connecting back to the opening of the chapter (בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים; Gen 1:1). “Time” is the defining category throughout; both the frame and the middle of the Creation account concern this category. The fundamental order of the world and earthly life thus follows the (Priestly) temporal structure of the seven-day week established at Creation:

Gen 1:1	Epigraph – Heading			
Gen 1:2	The Timeless and Spaceless Primordial World			
Gen 1:3–5	Day 1	Light and Darkness	Foundation	Time
Gen 1:6–8	Day 2	Heavens	Establishment	Space
Gen 1:9–13	Day 3	Earth and Sea		
Gen 1:14–19	Day 4	Sun, Moon, Stars: Festival Times	Rhythmization	Time
Gen 1:20–23	Day 5	Creatures Living in the Water and under the Heavens	Population	Space
Gen 1:24–31	Day 6	Creatures Living on Land		
Gen 2:1–3	Day 7	Ending: God Rests on Seventh Day	Rhythmization	Time

Delineation: In contrast to the text delineation presented here, the *toledot* formula of Gen 2:4a (“These are the *toledot* of the heavens and the earth when they were created”) has been regarded since Carl Ludwig Ziegler (1794) as the conclusion of the Creation account. This position has even made its way into the printed image of the *BHS*, which differs here from the Leningrad Codex on which it is based (as opposed to the *BHQ*, which faithfully reproduces the text layout of the Leningrad Codex). However, this thesis is untenable:

1. The *toledot* formula is otherwise found exclusively as a heading (see Gen 5:1; 6:9; 10:1; 11:10, 27; 25:12, 19; 36:1, 9; 37:2; outside of Genesis: Num 3:1; Ruth 4:18; 1 Chr 1:29), and Gen 2:4a should accordingly be understood as a heading for the Garden narrative that follows. As such, it forms a (redactional) bridge between the Priestly Creation account and the Garden narrative of the Scholarly Narrator in Gen 2:4b–3:24. For this, it adopts as usual the content and formulations of the preceding section of the text (see the Exegesis on Gen 2:4 below). 2. The Creation account of Gen 1:1–2:3 has its own conclusion in Gen 2:3 corresponding to Gen 1:1. 3. The singular speech of the “Book of the *Toledot*” in Gen 5:1 is a strong indication that within the Priestly version of the Primeval History, the series of *toledot* probably opened with Adam in Gen 5:1, and the Creation account immediately preceding it was, like in the present text, a prologue to the history of the *toledot* (of Israel). Furthermore, the repeatedly suggested assumption that Gen 2:4a originally came before Gen 1:1 and was redactionally moved to serve as the heading of 2:4bff. (or the conclusion of the Creation account in Gen 1:1–2:3, 4a)¹¹ is hardly plausible. The epigraph in Gen 1:1 is a completely valid heading for the Creation account.¹²

Formation: The meticulous structure of the Priestly Creation account testifies to the highest level of thoughtful concentration and “mediates aesthetically the impression of restrained power and lapidary greatness.”¹³ Nevertheless, there are small flaws that show themselves in the final form of the text. Occasionally, parts of the standard formulae are missing, or their placements deviate from the overall scheme, which already prompted the ancient translations to add or rearrange elements for the sake of standardization (see LXX Gen 1:6, 8, 9, 20). Furthermore, the number of eight works does not at first glance fit into the temporal framework of a week with six days of creation and one day of divine rest. Yet, it is not only the numerical difference that seems peculiar. It is also striking that the sixth day is not reserved for the creation of humanity alone as the culmination of all the previous works of creation. One can also ask why the division of the waters in addition to their distinction from land, which should really belong together, are split between two days. The heavenly ocean is created on the second day, while the sea and land are created with the plants on the third day. Lastly, the creation of the heavenly bodies on the fourth day is a strange repetition of the creation of light on the first day, and it happens only after the creation of plants. Even if the aforementioned irregularities fit well to the general inclination of the text, they

¹¹ See Gunkel, 103.

¹² On the *toledot* formula and its function, see Carr, 1998.

¹³ von Rad, 64. Similarly already Wellhausen, 1905, 297; Gunkel, 118.

nevertheless indicate the need to take seriously that the authors of the Priestly Writing could not exercise their full creative will. Rather, the Priestly Creation account is based on a larger religious tradition and represents the result of centuries of (priestly) scholarship. Both have left their traces in the present text.

The most important indicator for distinguishing the earlier material from its Priestly interspersions is generally considered to be the juxtaposition of creation through the divine word (the “word report”) and through God’s creationary action (the “deed report”). In the present text, the combination of “word” and “deed” should be understood as follows: The arrangement of Creation through the word points to the permanent state of each respective act, while the report of divine action focuses on the creating.¹⁴ Given the aforementioned unevenness of the Priestly Creation account, it can be assumed for the account’s genesis and formation that the acts of creation through the divine word presuppose the corresponding account of the divine deeds. Conversely, the descriptions of divine action do not require the preceding speeches. Furthermore, “creation through the word” within the biblical texts about Creation seems to be an innovation of the exilic/postexilic period, in contrast to the older conception of Creation as a divine act.¹⁵ These texts stand at the beginning of an increasingly pronounced theology of creation through the spoken word, developed especially in the late postexilic period.¹⁶ For these reasons, the earlier material is to be found within the parts that recount the divine creationary actions. The delineation and nature of this earlier material – various traditional material, fixed oral traditions or written sources – have been the subject of much controversy. According to W.H. Schmidt, standing behind Gen 1:2, 4b, 7, 9 (LXX), 12, 16, 21, 25, 26–27a; 2:2f.(?) is older traditional material that has been interpreted critically by the Priestly Writing.¹⁷ This proposal has some merit, but with the following caveats: Generally, it needs to be considered that the tradition itself was part of Priestly tradition. Juxtaposing an ancient Near Eastern tradition against a critical interpretation of it in the Priestly Writing is hardly a sufficient explanation for the origin of the present text. For example, the widespread Near Eastern “separation” myth is only distantly discernible in the divine commands involving division (Gen 1:4b, 6, 7, 14, 18). The verb used for these commands, *בדל* *hi.*, is attested exclusively in Priestly contexts. Most uncertain is whether the LXX should be followed in v. 9, as Schmidt suggests (see the Text-critical and Philological

¹⁴ Steck, 1975, 70.

¹⁵ This is at least suggested by the other explicit evidence for a “creation through the word” (see Ps 33:4, 6, 9; 148:5; Isa 48:13; Lam 3:37; see also Schmidt, 1973, 175–178).

¹⁶ See 4Q381, Frgm. 1 [DJD XI, 87–172]; 4Q422, I 6 [DJD XIII, 417–441]; John 1:1; Bührer, 2014, 320–322.

¹⁷ Schmidt, 1973, 161.

Note on v. 9). Additionally, for the creation of humanity, the genuine Priestly material may be larger than proposed and the older material may be limited to the statement “and God ‘made’ humanity” (see 1:27aα* – without the creation verb “ברא” typical of the Priestly Writing). Concerning the attempts for a source-critical differentiation between “word report” and “deed report,” as well as the assumption that the older material is to be found in the word reports, already C. Westermann had commented that “it only confuses the issue when one wants to divide Gen 1 into a ‘command-account’ and an ‘action-account.’”¹⁸ A list of seven or eight works of creation was probably available to the author. In the context of the Priestly Creation account, this list would have provided a phenomenology of the existent world, whose habitats were created by differentiating between them and naming them and were filled according to the classification of living beings by habitat, species, class, and sex. It originated from Priestly circles and stands in the tradition of the ancient Near Eastern scribal lists, which catalogue the individual environments and their designations. They are often multilingual and are sometimes accompanied by little explanation, but they should nevertheless be regarded as an early version of a “natural science” approach to the world.¹⁹

Inseparably connected with the idea of creation through the word are the emphasis on the creationary power of God alone in the introductory verse in Gen 1:1, the event formula “And so it happened” (Gen 1:7, 9, 11, 15, 24, 30), and the approval formula “And God saw it as good” (Gen 1:4, 10, 12, 18, 21, 25, 31). The event formula provides the actualization of each corresponding command, which is why it can replace the execution report in certain cases (e.g., Gen 1:9) or be subordinated to it when the command and the execution differ more clearly in their details.²⁰ Behind the approval formula is the idea of a responsible craftsman who finishes his work by examining what he has made and only releases the work that he finds “good.”²¹ Accordingly, the approval formula concludes its respective act of creation with the praise and appreciation of the Creator, who delights in the beings that he has created. This analogy notwithstanding, the inseparability of the approval formula from the “creation through the word” can be seen in how the former first occurs during the creation of light because of the divine command (Gen 1:4).

¹⁸ Westermann, 86.

¹⁹ See 1 Kgs 5:12f.; Ps 148. For the rest of the ancient Near East, see von Soden, 2006, 138ff.

²⁰ See Gen 1:7b, 30b; for discussion concerning the “event formula” [*Geschehensformel*] or “execution formula” [*Ausführungsformel*] attested further in Judg 6:38; 2 Kgs 7:20; 15:12, see Bühner, 2014, 48–78.

²¹ Schmidt, 1973, 62.

In addition to these two definitive aspects of the text, namely 1) both the earlier list of the works of creation and the idea of separating and naming them, and 2) the Priestly interpretations thereof, there is also a third: the currents of ancient Near Eastern conceptions of the creation of the world. However, the “high degree of abstraction ... leaves its predecessors to be guessed at rather than convincingly identified.”²² Moreover, even a certain tradition or epoch is difficult to ascertain. The only recognizable aspect is its wide imaginative space.²³ This generally offers more or less extensive correspondences for individual aspects and for contexts of certain statements discussed below; it also makes clear how much the authors were at home in the thinking of ancient Near Eastern cosmology. The text’s unevenness can thus be explained largely in how it is rooted in this tradition, having been expanded only in Gen 2:1 (see the Exegesis on the verse below).

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION II: EXEGESIS

1:1–3

- 1 *In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth.*
- 2 *And the earth was an empty void, and darkness lay over the deep, and the breath of God hovered over the waters.*
- 3 *Then God said, “Let there be light!” And there was light.*

The syntactic structure of the first three verses of the Bible has been the subject of much controversy, as has how to translate and interpret them.²⁴ The ancient translations have recognized three independent sentences here (“In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth. And the earth was desolate and empty... And God said...”). Many, including the author of the prologue to the Gospel of John (see John 1:1), have followed them, but there have also always been objections. The reason for this is the lack of a definite article in the famous בְּרֵאשִׁית (“In the beginning”). Contrary to what the *BHS* apparatus suggests, the reading with the article that is sometimes proposed (בְּרֵאשִׁית) is “complete conjecture supported by neither the Greek transcription by the Church Fathers nor the Samaritan material.”²⁵ The classic translation tradition understands it as a nominal expression of time for an independent sentence spanning v. 1. However, it is problematic that the nominal expression in v. 1 is indefinite, while the translations simply assume that it

²² Levin, 1994, 128 [translation JWR].

²³ For an overview, see Kratz/Spieckermann, 1999, 258–283; Keel/Schroer, 2002.

²⁴ Bauks, 1997.

²⁵ Rütterswörden/Warmuth, 1993, 175 [translation JWR].

must be definite; the world can only have one beginning, which leads to the presumption that it must be a definite beginning rather than an indefinite, arbitrary one. Linguistically, in addition to the possibility of having a definite article (which is missing here), the definiteness could also be expressed by a noun to which the “In the beginning” would refer. In fact, the Hebrew *רֵאשִׁית* (“beginning of [something]”) normally functions as a *nomen regens* in a genitive construction (*status constructus*), which designates it as definite (see, e.g., Jer 26:1). The lack of an article in this case conforms to the rule, since the *nomen regens* cannot bear an article while in the construct state. Admittedly, in v. 1, a noun connected to the “In the beginning” (*nomen rectum*) is missing and the *רֵאשִׁית* stands by itself (*status absolutus*). Therefore, it has been variously suggested, following the two major medieval Jewish commentators, Rashi (1040–1105) and Ibn Ezra (1092–1167), that the remainder of v. 1 should instead be understood as a genitive attributive clause for the introductory *בְּרֵאשִׁית*.²⁶ This suggestion understands the *בְּרֵאשִׁית* to be the *nomen regens* of a genitive construction encompassing the entirety of v. 1. Accordingly, v. 1 would not to be understood as an independent clause but as a temporal subordinate clause. As long as this is not understood as an incomplete sentence (or *anacoluthon*), the main clause of v. 1 is then found in v. 2 or, more likely, v. 3a. The passage would then be translated as follows: “In the beginning of God’s creating the heavens and the earth, [it was] while the earth existed as an empty void, with darkness [lying] over the surface of the deep and a strong wind ‘buffeting’ over the surface of the waters that God said, ‘Let there be light!’”²⁷ The most important shift in emphasis compared to the typical translation is that the “In the beginning” does not refer to the absolute, requisiteless beginning of the world but to the beginning of God’s creationary action. Syntactically, there is nothing precluding the proposed solution of vv. 1–(2,)3a being one sentence structured by subordinate and superordinate (sub-)clauses. There is also no lack of analogies for this (e.g., Gen 2:4b–7 and, from ancient Near Eastern literature, Atr 1.1–7; EnEl 1.1–9, 29f.). However, speaking against this solution is the fact that in the Hebrew Bible, a verbal clause serves as a substitute for a *nomen rectum* within a genitive construction only in a few exceptional cases and only under special conditions.²⁸ Therefore, the more apparent solution is to consider *בְּרֵאשִׁית* as one of the cases in Biblical Hebrew in which, in the case of certain nouns indicative of time, the definiteness is not specified by an article.²⁹ Accordingly, the lack of the article cannot speak against the traditional view of *בְּרֵאשִׁית*

²⁶ See Weippert, 2004.

²⁷ Weippert, 2004, 14 [translation JWR].

²⁸ See Stipp, 2007.

²⁹ Stipp, 2004–2007, with reference to the “article-shy” antonym קֵץ (“end”).

signifying a definite beginning and being understood as a nominal expression of time for v. 1, with the first three verses of the Bible each being independent sentences.

Completely unrelated to the discussion of the lack of an article in בְּרֵאשִׁית (“In the beginning”) is the question of the relationship between the three independent sentences in vv. 1–3 concerning their content. Traditionally, the three sentences have been understood as a sequence of actions and mostly interpreted with v. 1 speaking of the creation of matter (*creatio immediata*), from which, as vv. 2ff. report, everything that exists was formed and shaped (*creatio mediata*). According to this understanding, this provides the classic evidence for the doctrine of creation from nothing (*creatio ex nihilo*). However, the implication of this doctrine is that God in his omnipotence would not have needed any preexisting material, which would have limited the freedom of the creationary action by constraining it to the material. However, this conception would have been completely foreign to the pre-Hellenistic Near East. It developed only in confrontation with Neoplatonism and in argumentative rethinking of the biblical texts. Accordingly, the first appearance in the biblical tradition of the formula of God creating “not out of things that were” (οὐκ ἐξ ὄντων) is only in the book of Maccabees, written in the Hellenistic period. Even still, there, it does not (yet) mean anything other than that the world did not exist previously (2 Macc 7:28; cf. Rom 4:17; Heb 11:3).³⁰ Furthermore, the understanding of vv. 1 and 2 as a sequence of actions or events is difficult from a linguistic point of view: The expression “the heavens and the earth” (v. 1) is a merism – a stylistic device juxtaposing two mutually exclusive but interrelated terms to express the intended wholeness between the two extremes (“young and old” = “everyone”; “good and evil” = “everything”; “day and night” = “always”). Likewise, the phrase “the heavens and the earth” denotes what the Greek κόσμος or the Latin *universum* combine into one term. When read as a separate sentence, v. 1 therefore states, “God created all things,” and certainly not, “God created unformed matter.” Were vv. 1–3 to be understood as a sequence of actions or events, the description of the unordered world in v. 2 would clearly come too late. Additionally, v. 2 and its three nominal clauses provide the background of the aforementioned action and in this respect remove themselves from the supposed sequence. Therefore, it seems best to distinguish between three independent sentences as (v. 1) a heading or epigraph, (v. 2) a description of the conditions before Creation, and (v. 3) a prelude to the creationary action.³¹ Speaking in favor of this solution is how it corresponds to the conventions of ancient Near Eastern literature and accords perfectly with the overall structure of

³⁰ See Groß, 1999; May, 1978; also Schmuttermayer, 1973 especially for 2 Macc 7:28.

³¹ See Schmidt, 1973, 73–76; Steck, 1975, 223–228.

the Priestly Creation account. In the ancient Near East, the use of an epigraph summarizing what follows was a common method of opening a text, akin to modern headings. The description of the conditions before Creation, following the epigraph, presents what preceded the events of vv. 3ff. in a way that fits with the rigid sequencing of the Creation account. As an analogy, reference can be made to the descriptions of the primordial world from ancient Near Eastern creation myths. These, as a rule, describe the state of the world before Creation contrastingly as in a state of “not yet” (v. 2aα; see Gen 2:5) or as a negation of the existing world (v. 2aβ; cf. Gen 2:6).³² *Enuma Eliš* offers a wonderful example of a detailed description of the primordial world. This epic of the Babylonian god Marduk, which probably dates to the reign of Nebuchadnezzar I (ca. 1120–1098 BCE), is often described as an “epic of creation.” However, this designation is due to the comparison with Gen 1 and 2 and is somewhat misleading, insofar as what stands at its center is not the creation of the world and humanity but the ascension of Marduk to king of the gods. This is also the fundamental difference from the biblical Creation account, in which the question of the universal Creator God’s claim to dominion over that of other gods is not (or, no longer) raised. The epic, originally probably “secret knowledge of the Babylonian priesthood of Marduk,” has numerous attestations across the first half of the first millennium BCE³³ and also served in scribal curricula.³⁴ It begins with, “When the heavens above did not exist / And earth beneath had not come into being – / There was Apsû, the first in order, their begetter, / And demiurge Tiāmat, who gave birth to them all; / They had mingled their waters together / Before meadowland had coalesced and reed-bed was to be found – / When not one of the gods had been formed / Or had come into being, when no destinies had been decreed, / The gods were created within them” (EnEl 1.1–9).

1:1 *In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth.*

The epigraph of v. 1 forms a frame with Gen 2:3 around the Priestly Creation account (see above) while at the same time summarizing the events that are to unfold in what follows. Through this, the verse provides important aid for understanding the whole text, whose main assertion is established at the outset: God is God through being Creator. God is the lone creator of all that is, and as their creator, God is separated from heaven and earth and contrasted to them.

³² See the compilation of the material in Bauks, 1997. For its literary function and the epistemological interest of such claims about the state of the world before Creation, see below on v. 2.

³³ See Gabriel, 2014, 101–106.

³⁴ See Gesche, 2001, 177–178.

Even the choice of the designation אֱלֹהִים (“God” or “divine being”) expresses a special claim.³⁵ Strictly speaking, it is a generic noun; the plural can either denote multiple gods or, functioning in the *pluralis majestatis*, mean “God.” The latter is the case here, as evidenced by the singular verb forms throughout Gen 1 and the rest of the Primeval History within the Priestly Writing (the only exception is the Priestly mention of the “gods of Egypt” in Exod 12:12). In polytheistic contexts, the generic designation requires an indication of which deity is being referenced. The Priestly Creation account deliberately refrains from specifying such, instead using it as an individual term. The Creator, who is initially nameless, reveals himself throughout the course of history first as El Šaddai, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and then as Yhwh, the God of Israel (see Gen 17:1; Exod 6:2f.), and is the *one* universal and transcendent God. Even if this Creator is not yet explicitly named as Yhwh in Gen 1, there was never any doubt for the authors and readers of the Priestly Writing that the Creator be identified with the God of Israel. Nevertheless, the openness of the formulation enables remarkable avenues for understanding the text. The Priestly Writing makes the claim in Gen 1 that the God of Israel is the *one* universal and transcendent God. Yet, this exclusivity is not exclusionary, as the depiction of the world at the Beginning would have been recognized by anyone familiar with the cosmology of the ancient Near East and its religious context.³⁶

The universality and transcendency of the one God are underlined by the use of the verb בָּרָא (“to create”). The verb is attested exclusively in exilic and postexilic texts, particularly in Deutero-Isaiah and its editorial additions as well as in the Priestly Writing. In the book of Isaiah, the verb is used both for past and present (Isa 40:26, 28; 42:5; 45:12, 18) as well as future creationary activity by the deity (Isa 41:20; 45:8; 65:17; cf. Jer 31:22). In the Priestly Writing, it is consistently limited to God’s creationary activity at the Beginning (Gen 1:1, 21, 27; 2:3f.; 5:2). Crucial for understanding its usage in the Priestly Writing is that בָּרָא has the highest degree of theological abstraction of all the verbs that the Hebrew Bible uses for God’s creationary action. The verb עָשָׂה (“to make/do”), which is also used for divine creationary activity in Gen 1, denotes any human or divine action. For the other verbs for creation in the Hebrew Bible, like בָּנָה (“to build”), יָצַר (“to form/shape”), קָנָה (“to buy/acquire”), and כָּן (“to establish”), as well as יָסַד (“to erect/found”), the concrete and (generally) artisanal usage tends to predominate. In contrast, בָּרָא is reserved exclusively for God and is never associated with any material specifying what God creates from or with. Even an unsecure reference to בָּרָא “sculptor” (?) in a Phoenician text³⁷ does not change

³⁵ See de Pury, 2002.

³⁶ See Schüle, 2006, 62–65.

³⁷ COS 1:347, 4; see also DNWSI 196 s.v. *br’*.

this, since this usage was omitted in the Hebrew Bible, if the biblical authors were even familiar with it to begin with. The use of the designation **ברא** – the noun form **בְּרִיאָה** “creation” is attested first at Qumran and thereafter in rabbinic literature – prevents any ability to actually imagine the creationary action. This is not consistently maintained across what follows, as the Creation account in vv. 3ff. must necessarily resort to figurative ideas in order even to begin to describe the divine creationary action at all. Yet even then, the figurative illustration is remarkably broken by how the divine command precedes any divine action. Thus, the Priestly Creation account describes an event that, strictly speaking, defies any description. The knowledge of the origin of the world, pulling from older traditions and certainly being state of the art for its time, was not handed down for its own sake but for expressing the core theological statement in the opening verse. This is summarized by Psalm 148, which is a late text: Cosmos and Creation are to praise Yhwh, “for he commanded, and they were created [**ברא** ni.]” (v. 5a). The “how” is of only ancillary interest here. The universal character of the Creator God, the “tendency to think of the whole comprehensively as God’s work,”³⁸ ultimately finds fitting expression in the merism “heavens and earth” also attested in Mesopotamian cosmologies.

1:2 *And the earth was an empty void, and darkness lay over the deep, and the breath of God hovered over the waters.*

The description of the state before the created world takes up the “heavens and earth” merism through the use of “earth” but concentrates on humanity’s experienceable environment. Heaven is addressed only as a “firmament” separating the heavenly ocean from the sea (cf. v. 8). Thus, the description of the primeval world already makes clear that what follows is about the lived-in world of humanity, which is the defining perspective of the Creation account. Insofar as v. 2 deals with the “uncreated” earth, the mention of it does not contradict the “creation” of the earth on the third day as the habitat for plants, land animals, and humans (v. 9f.). The state of the “uncreated” earth is characterized, apart from the proverbial “empty void,” Heb. “*tohu wa-bohu*” (תְּהוֹ וּבֹהוּ), through the use of “darkness” (חֹשֶׁךְ), “(primordial) deep” (תְּהוֹמִים), and “the breath of God hovering” (רוּחַ אֱלֹהִים מְרַחֶפֶת). Functioning as a negation, the phrase “The earth was an empty void” is a “not-yet” statement about the state of the earth as the world of living beings. The bipartite, rhyming “*tohu wa-bohu*” is also attested in Isa 34:11 (“void”) and Jer 4:23 (“emptiness”). Like the “duper” in the English “super-duper,”

³⁸ Schmidt, 1971, 339 [translation JWR].

the “*wa-bohu*” is the result of rhyming reduplication and has no meaning of its own; it only provides emphasis. The etymology of the first part, “*tohu*,” is connected to the Arabic *tīh* “waterless desert” (cf. Deut 32:10; Job 6:18; Ps 107:40). Otherwise, תהו predominantly carries the meaning “nothingness” or “that which is not.” In a cosmogonic context, there is a parallelism with the “that which is not” in Job 26:7: “...who spreads out the Zaphon over the תהו, who hangs the earth upon that which is not.” In Isa 45:18f., תהו signifies the living space that is not yet present: “Not a תהו did he [Yhwh] create it [the earth]; he formed it for habitation.” Similarly, the expression is also found in reference to the historical situation around the loss of the land in Jer 4:23. Given the cosmic dimensions of the disaster described there (“the heavens were dark”), Jer 4:23 is not concerned with a concrete description of the ravaged land but with the reversal of the intended order, with the cultivated land, deprived of its original function, becoming uninhabitable. The description of the primordial world in Gen 1:2 should be understood accordingly: The “nothingness” is intended as an inversion of what does concretely exist. In other words, as a realm for creatures, the earth did not (yet) exist; it was “desolate and empty.” It is important for understanding the description of the previous state of the created world that it does not derive from any “speculative” interest, strictly speaking. Furthermore, its proximity to modern cosmologies and their associated metaphors is not based on any naturalistic intuition by the biblical authors. Rather, the description of the primordial world is limited from the outset to the internal logic of a report and the range of possible knowledge: The account describes how all recognizable order and realities came into being through a series of events, which necessarily requires a starting point that is beyond human experience and therefore does not seem describable any way other than as a negation or a “not yet.”

The following nominal clause (v. 2aβ) substantiates the *tohu wa-bohu* by ascribing to it the qualities of the primordial deep (תְהוֹם) and darkness (חָשֶׁךְ), as also known from similar descriptions of the primordial world from Mesopotamia, Egypt, Phoenicia, and Greece. From this plethora of comparative material, it is worth mentioning a few for illustration: The conception of Creation at Hermopolis, which emerged in the Ramesside period (thirteenth–eleventh centuries BCE) and is attested even in Hellenistic texts, speaks of the primordial world as an “eight-ness” formed by four pairs of primordial gods, representing four categories of the primordial world: Nu and Naunet (the primordial abyss), Heh and Hauhet (infinity), Amun and Amaunet (concealment), and Kek and Kauket (darkness).³⁹ A bilingual Sumerian/

³⁹ See Bauks, 1997, 162–173.

Akkadian creation myth text from the sixth century BCE says about the original state of the unstructured cosmos that “all the lands were sea.”⁴⁰ From Philo of Byblos, who was writing in the first century CE, we read about Phoenician mythology: “[The priest Sanchuniathon] supposes the beginning of everything to have been dark and windy air, or a breath of dark air, or a breath of dark and a foul, black chaos.”⁴¹ The Babylonian priest Berossos, who lived in the third century BCE, tried to bring the culture of his homeland to the Greek world with a history of Babylonia from the primordial beginnings to the time of Alexander the Great. In so doing, he connected Greek and Phoenician traditions with Mesopotamian ideas and spoke of the primordial world as a condition “when the universe was only darkness and water.”⁴²

Just as multifaceted as the texts are the ideas connected to the aforementioned characteristics of the primordial world. For the text of the Hebrew Bible, the unrestricted darkness and the boundless deep are the characteristics of the primordial world that symbolize the absence of the two constitutive categories of the experiential and living order of the world: time and space. The fact that they are not yet present designates the primordial world as being in a state of utter unlivability. Darkness (חָשֶׁךְ) as “non-light” marks the absence of “time,” which is established in vv. 3–5 with the institution of the alternation of night/darkness and day/light needed for dividing time. Unlike what is emphasized in Isa 45:7 (“He who forms the light and creates the darkness”) and Ps 104:20 (“You send darkness, and it becomes night”), the darkness is no work of creation. It is merely set within the world order as “night” when evoking its counterpart, light. As it is a purely negative condition for the not-yet-created light, “darkness” is hardly conceived as any independent power of chaos. Moreover, the latter is already precluded by the emphasis on God’s sole creationary action in v. 1.

Alongside the darkness, the undivided waters of the deep (תְּהוֹם) are another aspect of the primordial world in which divine creationary action takes place. The mention of the deep points ahead to the introduction of the category of “space” on the second and third days: The creation of the firmament/heavens in the midst of the waters divides what was previously undivided into the waters above the firmament/heavens and the waters below (vv. 6–8). The

⁴⁰ Foster, *Muses*, 488. See also Horowitz, 2011, 129–132.

⁴¹ Longer excerpts of Philo of Byblos’s *The Phoenician History* were preserved only by Eusebius of Caesarea (ca. 260–339/40 CE; Eus., *Praep.* 1.10.1–14a [quotation: translation JWR from German translation]). Philo refers to the work of a priest Sanchuniathon who lived before the Trojan War. The historicity of this claim is disputed, although this hardly speaks against the age of the recorded traditions; see Ebach, 1979.

⁴² Berossos 1.6; the work of Berossos known as *Babyloniaca* is known only from fragments, specifically citations and excerpts by other ancient authors. A compilation and translation of the fragments can be found in Verbrughe/Wickersham, 2001 (here 45).

gathering of the latter then enables the dry land (i.e., the earth as a habitat) to become visible during the third day of creation (vv. 9f.).

The history of the tradition behind the term *תְּהוֹם*, translated here as “deep,” is disputed. Scholars have repeatedly asserted a direct or indirect etymological and factual connection with the primordial Mesopotamian goddess Tiamat as the embodiment of chaos.⁴³ Besides the similarities of the words themselves and their contexts in accounts of the primordial world, justification for this is also readily available in the lack of a definite article with *תְּהוֹם* in v. 2. Since *תְּהוֹם* would need to be defined according to its status and singularity, it could only be an already-definite proper name. There is also the common interpretation in which the original primordial goddess is polemically reduced to the status of mere matter in order to emphasize the sole effectiveness and superiority of the one God. Less considered in this assumed connection between *תְּהוֹם* and Tiamat and, with it, the polemical juxtaposition of Gen 1 and Enuma Eliš is the fact that, in Enuma Eliš, Tiamat is usually written *without* the determinative for deities and with a case ending, thus focusing less on the deity and more on the element of creation. Thus, this Hebrew Bible “polemic” would merely be following in the footsteps of Enuma Eliš.

However, there are philological and motific grounds arguing against the aforementioned etymological derivation of the word *תְּהוֹם* in Gen 1:2 from the name of the primordial goddess and embodiment of chaos, Tiamat: Unlike its presumed progenitor, the Hebrew word *תְּהוֹם* is not feminine in form and the “h”-sound in *תְּהוֹם* compared to the Akkadian “Tiamat” defies any phonetic explanation. Moreover, Gen 1:2 seems to lack any allusion to the myth of the sea battle that should be associated with Tiamat and can be detected in other Hebrew Bible texts (mostly without mention of *תְּהוֹם*; see Ps 74:13–15; 89:10–13; 93 and with *תְּהוֹם* in Ps 104:5–7). It has been suspected that standing behind the *רוּחַ* of God mentioned in v. 2b is another tradition from Enuma Eliš about creator god Marduk, in which he uses the winds as weapons against Tiamat. Yet, speaking against this is the lack of any martial connotations in v. 2b. Thus, the polemic would at best be found in the omission of these motifs, assuming that the expression *תְּהוֹם* would have at least evoked an association with the goddess Tiamat. Given these uncertainties, the quest for the history of the tradition behind the *תְּהוֹם* in Gen 1:2 (and other attestations across the Hebrew Bible) should not focus on Tiamat as the embodiment of chaos. The conceptions that the term would have evoked in its readers might have been much broader and may have also included at least the Egyptian idea of Nun, the dormant primordial sea, or that of a (primordial) sea attested in the aforementioned bilingual creation myth from the Neo-Babylonian period. In any case, fitting with these conceptions is the connotation of *תְּהוֹם* elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible of a subterranean freshwater ocean that functions as a kind of primordial spring in watering the land and making it fruitful (see Gen 49:25; Amos 7:4; Ezek 31:4, 15; Job 38:30; Ps 78:15). In the spaceless primordial world, this *תְּהוֹם* is still undivided from the later heavenly ocean above the firmament.⁴⁴ Nevertheless, the expression *תְּהוֹם* would have indeed carried some connotations for its intended audience about the mythic primordial chaos rather than primarily designating a “purely ‘natural phenomenon.’”⁴⁵ For its

⁴³ So first Gunkel, 1921, 115, and now also Schüle, 2006, 72. Cf. Tsumura, 2005.

⁴⁴ Note also the “water” referenced by the determination of *תְּהוֹם* in v. 2b and its parting in vv. 6–8; see also Gen 7:11; 8:2; similarly, Ps 29:10.

⁴⁵ Waschke, 1995, 566 [translation JWR].

use in Gen 1:2, this is already evident from the fact that when the Great Flood comes upon the earth according to the Priestly Writing, the springs of the deep (תְּהוֹם) and the heavenly floodgates break open (Gen 7:11; see also 8:2). The waters once set into order by God become active once again during the Great Flood. Psalm 104 also attests to the threat of chaos being implied with the mention of תְּהוֹם (see also Ps 148:7). The psalm, which is reliant on Gen 1, also incorporates a mythological theme from the Baal myth in describing how the deep (תְּהוֹם) covered the earth like a garment over even the mountaintops but then fled before the thundering voice of Yhwh (Ps 104:5–7).

Verse 2b mentions the רוּחַ of God hovering (מְרַחֶפֶת) over the waters as the final characteristic of the primordial world. The range of meaning of רוּחַ (lit. “blowing away”) includes all forms of moving air, from breath to storms. Figuratively, the word can also mean “spirit,” “life,” and “nothingness.” Accordingly, the translations of the term “רוּחַ of God” range from the creationary “spirit of God” to the chaotic “storm of God.” The only thing not under dispute is that the participle מְרַחֶפֶת denotes a state of constant motion comparable to a bird of prey standing still in the air and flapping its wings back in forth, as per the second attestation in the Hebrew Bible of the root רָחַף in the pi. (Deut 32:11). Fundamental to understanding the verse is its connection to v. 2a’s description of the primordial world, as further underscored by the parallel construction of the two sub-verses: Like the darkness, the רוּחַ lies over the surface (עַל-פָּנָיו) of the waters of the deep. Additionally, the description of the creationary acts in vv. 3ff. does not speak of the רוּחַ of God as a creationary force. Thus, v. 2b does not yet describe any divine creationary action but, like the two nominal clauses in v. 2a, the circumstances prior to creation. At first glance, this suggests an understanding of the רוּחַ of God as a “wind of God,” as is frequently attested as a primordial phenomenon in other ancient Near Eastern texts about Creation.⁴⁶ Yet, although this interpretation is fundamentally possible, speaking against it is an understanding of the apposition of אֱלֹהִים more or less explicitly as a superlative expression (the “wind of God” = a divine wind, i.e., a particularly violent wind, a primordial hurricane, e.g., קֶלֶת אֱלֹהִים “mighty thunder” in Exod 9:28). However, in light of the two other instances of אֱלֹהִים in vv. 1–3 (and the 35 total instances in Gen 1:1–2:3), which clearly and emphatically designate the deity, such a tempered use of אֱלֹהִים as a superlative is unlikely. Also, unlike the darkness and the waters of the deep, a “storm of God” is not included in the creationary process and, unlike the deep, is not mentioned in the Flood narrative (see 7:11; 8:2). Although Gen 8:1 (P) mentions a wind (רוּחַ) sent from God (אֱלֹהִים) that causes the waters of the flood (תְּהוֹם; v. 2) to sink down, it explicitly does not mention the רוּחַ אֱלֹהִים. Furthermore,

⁴⁶ See Schmidt, 1973, 81–84, and recently again Weippert, 2004, 14 and fn. 33, as well as Rechenmacher, 2002, 13ff.

consideration that the *tohu wa-bohu*, darkness, and the deep depict the pre-existing world as not yet capable of supporting life then raises the question of whether the *רוּחַ אֱלֹהִים* may also reflect this “not-yet” inhabitable state of the primordial world, in this case with regard to the Creator God. This Creator God is “already present in the primordial world, but not yet active.”⁴⁷ The instance of hovering (*מְרַחֵף*) back and forth above the water may reflect the “not-yet” of the resting that God achieves at the completion of Creation (see 2:2f.). On the other hand, the mention of the *רוּחַ אֱלֹהִים* indicates the “not-yet” of God’s speaking. This guides the presentation of the divine creationary action from the verse immediately following until when God rests, and it marks the decisive difference between the primordial world and Creation. It therefore seems more appropriate to translate *רוּחַ אֱלֹהִים* as “breath of God” (see Ps 33:6), with the phrase not yet indicating creationary speech itself but only its (yet) unrealized possibility.⁴⁸ Thus, the hovering of the *רוּחַ אֱלֹהִים* over the waters describes a negative equivalent to the present, inhabitable world, just like the timelessness and spacelessness discussed above. However, v. 2b is less concerned with emphasizing the “presence” of God prior to creation in terms of a latent power for “creation through the word,” which was probably not of interest to the Priestly Writing. The mention of the “not yet” of God’s creationary speech rather takes into account the main theological insight of the Priestly Creation account, in which God is God only as Creator. Only in relation to his Creation is it possible to speak of God in any way other than what God is “not.” In this respect, the speech about God changes fundamentally with the beginning of the creationary action in v. 3.

1:3–5

- 3 *Then God said, “Let there be light!” And there was light.*
- 4 *And God saw the light as good. And God divided between the light and the darkness.*
- 5 *Then God called the light “day,” and the darkness he called “night.” And there was evening, and there was morning: one day.*

Standing at the center of the first day of creation is the establishment of the ordering category of “time” through the creation of light and the resultant alternation between light/day and darkness/night. Moreover, “light” held a symbolic function in ancient Near Eastern thought, standing for “truth,” “order,” “life,” and “justice” and thus defining the position opposite to the

⁴⁷ Bauks, 1997, 140 [translation JWR].

⁴⁸ See Steck, 1975, 233–237.

primordial chaos: Whoever seeks to create order within a dark room must first procure a light.⁴⁹ Corresponding to its basic function, the creation of light differs from the works of creation that follow; as with the other works, the divine command stands at the beginning, but in the case of the first work, there is no action corresponding to God's speech. There is also a sharp contrast to the immediately preceding description of the primordial world. Light is spoken into existence only by the creationary word of God, which goes forth out into the darkness of the primordial world (v. 3).

The idea of creation through the word, also inspired by kingly authority, has analogies in the cosmological conceptions of the world around the Hebrew Bible. Frequently mentioned is the "Memphite Theology," whose dating is controversial. The text is recorded on a basalt stone from Pharaoh Shabaka (716–702 BCE) that claims to be a newer version of an old papyrus. Most scholars tend to date the original to the Ramesside period (thirteenth–eleventh centuries BCE), though seeing this claim as a "discovery legend" would correspondingly lead to a date in the eighth century BCE.⁵⁰ According to the text, the creator god Ptah created the world through "heart and tongue," by communicating through the tongue the knowledge of things formed in the heart, thus bringing them into existence. The account of the creation of the world closes with the following notice: "So is it found understood that his physical strength is greater than the gods'. So has Ptah come to rest after his making everything and every divine speech as well."⁵¹ According to *Enuma Eliš*, the Babylonian epic of Marduk, the gods demand from their (designated) king, Marduk, that the constellations disappear and reappear at his command, as proof of his authority (EnEl 4.19–24). It is unmistakable that the use of "creation through the word" is supposed to emphasize the sovereignty of the creator deity in question. The phenomenological similarity is unmistakable, but in light of the (naturally limited) repertoire of adequate forms of expression, it is hardly possible to posit identical conceptual content – much less direct dependency. For example, *Enuma Eliš* emphasizes Marduk's assertion of power over the other gods, who are represented by the constellations, and the Memphite Theology secures the local primordial god's primacy over the other gods. Conversely, Gen 1 focuses on determining the relationship between God and the world. Like the Creation account as a whole, the use of "creation through the word" serves to juxtapose God as Creator from the world.⁵² Moreover, the Priestly use of "creation through the word" is also indebted to prophetic theology, in which the efficacy of the divine word

⁴⁹ Cassuto, 1:25, following Gen. Rab. 3.1.

⁵⁰ Cf. Peust/Sternberg-el Hotabi, *TUAT* III. Erg., 166–175; "From the 'Memphite Theology'" (Allen, *COS* 1.15:21–23).

⁵¹ "From the 'Memphite Theology'" (Allen, *COS* 1.15:23).

⁵² See Kaiser, 1998, 263.

mediated through the prophets is increasingly brought to the center of attention: “For just as the rain and the snow fall from heaven, and do not return there again until they have watered the earth and made it fruitful and let it grow, that it gives seed to the sower and bread to the eater, so shall be the word proceeding from my mouth; it shall not return to me empty without having done what pleases me, and it shall prosper in that for which I sent it” (Isa 55:10f.).⁵³ In a time of crisis, when this very efficacy was often enough and merely a matter of belief against all appearances, the reference to creation through the word represented the strongest possible assurance of the validity and power of the divine word. Among the biblical conceptions of creation, the creation through the word is a theological innovation compared to older conceptions of how gods acted when creating.⁵⁴

Only with the creation of light does the approval formula (v. 4a) again explicitly mention the work that is found to be “good.” This is explainable through the fact that God created light alone from the pair of opposites on the first day of creation. In contrast, darkness was one of the aspects of the primordial world that were seen as having already existed before God arranged them into Creation. The difficulty in classifying the light created by the divine command and the darkness of the primordial world also guides the rest of the section about the first day of creation. In the representation of the primordial world, darkness appears as a force without potential of its own. On the first day, it is associated with light by being separated as its counterpart (v. 4b) and is integrated into the new temporal order of the world by being named “night” (v. 5a). The naming of light and darkness is thus more than a mere identification with day and night; it is an act of exercising dominion (see Gen 2:9) and claiming ownership by the one who assigns its name (see Ps 74:16). Above all, it involves an ascription of the essence of what was named and thus brings the act of creation to its conclusion. This is obviously necessary when the work is, at least in part, due to a transformation of the previous properties of the world, as is the case not only with light and darkness but also with the creation of the heavens, the earth, and the seas, which all result from a division of the deep (see Gen 1:8, 10). In this sense, the darkness, dry land, and water are not “created” but are “called” into their purposes by being named “night,” “earth,” and “seas.”

The threatening nature of darkness is a basic, cross-cultural motif. In the Hebrew Bible as well, darkness carries almost exclusively negative connotations. As with its neighboring cultures, it is the sphere of demonic terror (Exod 12:23; 1 Sam 28) and death (see Job 17:13; Ps 88:7) and it is feared

⁵³ On the relationship between the word’s uses in the priestly and prophetic theology of the (divine) word, see Levin, 1994, 131–133.

⁵⁴ See Schmidt, 1973, 175–178 and Bühner, 2014, 320ff.

as a destructive reality that endangers the order of the world.⁵⁵ Accordingly, Gen 1 is often understood as depicting the darkness, although incorporated into the order of Creation and thus stripped of its power, as nevertheless remaining an underlying threat. However, it is not certain whether this is actually the case in the Priestly Writing. In the Flood narrative, it thematizes a fundamental threat to the order of Creation but, unlike with the deep, at no point mentions darkness. Far removed from any dualistic conceptions, the darkness in Gen 1 is denied any power from the outset. A close analogy and good illustration of the underlying conception of order is provided by Ps 104:20–23, with its picture of the daytime separation of the nocturnal predators, whom God nourishes, from humanity, who must work during the day.

In the Priestly Creation account, light and darkness are put into relationship with one another through their prior separation as well as their naming (v. 4b). God's speech separating (בדל *hi.*) them is somewhat reminiscent of the separation myth widely attested in Mesopotamian and Egyptian texts, such as in the cosmology of Berossos,⁵⁶ EnE1 4.135–140, and the epithet of Atum, who is called "the great god, who separates the heavens from the earth."⁵⁷ However, this generally describes the separation of heaven and earth. Genesis 1, on the other hand, depicts the formation of the earth not as process of separation but as the emergence of landmasses through the confluence of the waters (v. 9f.). In addition, the description of the primordial world tells nothing of a chaotic mixture of light and darkness, which would be the preconditions for a supposed act of separation. Rather, it is the darkness alone that is primordial, while the creation of light is what begins God's creationary activity. While it cannot be completely ruled out that there is an older tradition preserved in v. 4b that could (or even should) still be detected, this is of only secondary interest for understanding the Priestly Creation account. As with the other attestations of the verb בדל *hi.* ("to divide"; "to separate") in the Priestly Writing (see, e.g., Exod 26:55; Lev 10:10), it deals here less with unmixing substances than with an ordering and a spatial distinction (see Job 26:10; 38:19f.): Light and darkness form a related pair of opposites whose distinguishing classification establishes the turning of day and night and thus the category of "time."

The end of the first day of creation also begins the counting of days, which structures the account and leads to the final day of rest. Again and again throughout the ages, this has been interpreted metaphorically. Thus, even early Jewish exegesis looked to Ps 90:4 ("For a thousand years in your sight

⁵⁵ See Isa 5:30; 13:9f.; Jer 4:23; Joel 2:1–10; see also *DDD*, 624.

⁵⁶ See Verbrugge/Wickersham, 2001, 45f.

⁵⁷ See Schmidt, 1973, 21f., 24f., 29f. with further evidence.

are like the day that passed yesterday, or like a watch in the night”) to think of “days for God” as being much longer periods of time than normal days. Others have denied that they are any sort of physically measurable, chronological unit and speak instead of the “day ‘as such.’”⁵⁸ At first glance, such interpretations may temper some of the objections to the “creation in seven days” that arise when considering the time frames with which scientific cosmologies reckon. Yet, they do not sufficiently account for how much the text is concerned with the fact that the experienceable order of space and time is based on the action of creation. Just as the firmament of heaven created in v. 7 is the heaven that humanity sees from below, so is the counting of days, established with the alternation between night and day leading to the day of rest, the system familiar to the authors and readers of the Creation account.⁵⁹

With the naming of night that concludes the present work of creation, it becomes (!) evening, and the new day begins on the next morning (v. 5b). Like with Creation as a whole, each day begins with the emergence of light. In the Hebrew Bible, “day” refers first to the “bright daytime” and only thereafter to the calendrical unit comprising day/light and night/darkness. As a rule, the 24-hour day includes the subsequent nighttime (see Gen 19:33f.; 1 Sam 19:11), so that the calendrical day begins with the morning. However, the beginning of the calendrical day in the evening is also attested in the regulations for the observance of Sabbath and other holidays, which begin already with the preceding evening (e.g., Exod 12:18; Lev 23:32). This would later become normative for Judaism.⁶⁰

1:6–8

- 6 *Then God said, “Let there be a firmament in the midst of the waters to separate the waters from the waters.”*
- 7 *And God made the firmament, separating the waters under the firmament from the waters above the firmament. And so it happened.*
- 8 *Then God called the firmament “heaven.” And there was evening, and there was morning: a second day.*

The second day of creation begins the introduction of the ordering category of “space” via a twofold distinction. First, with the erection of a firmament (רָקִיעַ masc.), the waters of the deep are divided and demarcated from each another, giving structure to the spaceless state for the first time (v. 6; the article attached to “water” refers to the previous mention of water in v. 2b,

⁵⁸ See Grund, 2011, 212 [translation JWR].

⁵⁹ See Gunkel, 107f., as well as Steck, 1975, 175 fn. 746.

⁶⁰ See Sæbø, 1982.

which in turn is identified with the deep, תְּהוֹם, in v. 2a through a definite article). On the subsequent third day of creation, the landmass emerges through the gathering of the waters under the firmament to one place (vv. 9–10). The term רָקִיעַ, translated as “firmament,” is related to the verb רָקַע “to pound on something” (2 Sam 22:43) or “to hammer (a metal) thin” (Exod 39:3; Jer 10:9). Accordingly, רָקִיעַ is probably rooted in the idea of a solid plate. Thus, the later instance in Job 37:18, which has an eye back to Gen 1, compares the רָקִיעַ to a bright mirror, which in antiquity were made of polished metal. According to Ezek 1:22, the רָקִיעַ resembles the translucent surface of ice (see Exod 24:10, with floor panels of lapis lazuli). The רָקִיעַ serves as a horizontal division (מַבְדִּיל) between the separated waters and permanently shields the living space created on the third day from the life-threatening waters of chaos above the firmament. Additionally, the sun and moon are fixed to it on the fourth day of creation (v. 17). Outside of Gen 1, the motif of the horizontal separation of the heavenly ocean can be found only in *Enuma Eliš*, where the skin of the slain primordial goddess Tiamat, the embodiment of chaos, serves as a protective roof like a tent of animal skin (EnEl 4.135–140). Analogous to the function of the רָקִיעַ is the conception of an upwardly (!) curved metal bowl holding the heavenly waters, as is known from Egypt.⁶¹ However, contrary to a widespread traditional interpretation, the Priestly Writing provides no indications of a domed shape of the firmament, which is also unlikely in light of the other attestations of רָקִיעַ and the references within Gen 1 to other traditions, detailed below. Genesis 1 connects the motif of horizontal separation (known also from *Enuma Eliš*) with the fixed, straight plate of the רָקִיעַ, as attested in the contemporary Ezek 1:4–28 as well as a Neo-Assyrian commentary on *Enuma Eliš* (KAR 307).⁶² This commentary is part of a group of texts seeking to mediate mythical tradition with a perception of the world oriented around natural science, and it shows a great similarity to the conception of heaven in Ezekiel, which in turn probably influenced Gen 1.⁶³ However, unlike Ezek 1, the Priestly Writing does not provide a more detailed description of its appearance (or the way that it was made) and instead contents itself with a description of its function. Accordingly, it gives no information about how the heavenly firmament is affixed. The idea of mountains supporting the heavens (Ps 90:2; Job 26:11; 2 Sam 22:8) and zoomorphic bearers of the heavens (Ezek 1:22–25) are known from Egypt and Mesopotamia in addition to elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible but have no equivalents in

⁶¹ See Hornung, 1977, 1215–1218.

⁶² Text and translation: Livingstone, 1989, 99–102; for interpretation, see Horowitz, 2011, 3–19; Halpern, 2003; Gertz, 2009^a; Koch, 2017, 156–168, 195–202.

⁶³ See Koch, 2017, 156–168, 195–202.

Gen 1. In this respect, Gen 1:6–8 resembles the cosmological commentary KAR 307, which, in contrast to its reference text (see EnEl 5.59; 7.95), also refrains from such details, giving the impression of a free-floating solid plate. In general, the overall text is characterized by its extreme sparsity regarding details. The Priestly Writing, in contrast to the many texts from its surrounding cultures as well as elsewhere in the biblical tradition,⁶⁴ never provides a clear presentation of the heavens, nor does it thematize the ever-present threat of the divided deep (see Gen 7:11; 8:2) or what lies under the earth. Only in later reception of the Priestly Creation account, such as in the visions in the book of Ezekiel (1:22–26; 10:1) is the world above the רָקִיעַ (so also the plates of lapis lazuli under the enthroned God of Israel according to Exod 24:9–11) further developed and populated with heavenly beings (see also Ezek 1:22–26; Ps 19:2; 150:1; Dan 12:3).⁶⁵ All of this is not (yet) of interest to Gen 1, which is primarily oriented towards humanity's living space.

The divine command creating the firmament and setting its function (v. 6) is followed by the corresponding execution of the command (v. 7a): God makes the firmament, and the firmament sets a division within the waters from that point onwards. The event formula (v. 7b) confirms the exact correspondence between the command and the execution, although, strictly speaking, this can refer only to the orderly parting of the waters by the firmament (cf. the LXX; see the above Text-critical and Philological Note on v. 6). This verse is missing the typical approval formula, since the parting of the waters and the accompanying establishment of space is completed only with the creation of land (see v. 10). This work of creation ends with naming the firmament “heaven” (v. 8a) and with the day count (v. 8b). Naming the firmament (רָקִיעַ) that divides the waters (מַיִם) as “heaven” (שָׁמַיִם) seems to echo a popular etymology of the word שָׁמַיִם as “the place of the waters (the relative pronoun שׁ + מַיִם).”⁶⁶ As the formulation “firmament of heaven” in Gen 1:14, 15, 17, 20 shows, naming the firmament “heaven” is not a statement of its complete semantic correspondence – similar to the naming of light as “day” and darkness as “night.” Behind the unexciting notice about the naming of the firmament stands a notion central to the Priestly Creation account: the transcendence of the Creator God. Unlike in Babylonian cosmology, in which the heavens are at least already materially present for the creator god Marduk,⁶⁷ the heavens that humans see from below are considered in the Hebrew Bible to be one work of creation among others. They are only of

⁶⁴ For the detailed geography of the heavens in Mesopotamian texts, see Horowitz, 2011.

⁶⁵ See Koch, 2015.

⁶⁶ See Soggin, 1976, 966.

⁶⁷ See Hartenstein, 2013, 396f.

interest with their function in dividing between the waters of the deep and thus providing the basic structure to space and protecting human living space (Gen 7:11). The conception elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible of the heavens as the dwelling or domain of God and the heavenly beings (e.g., Isa 40:22; 66:1f.; Ps 104:1–4; 150:1; 2 Chr 30:27) does not come into view. According to Schmid, this is fundamental to the Priestly Writing: “In Gen 1, the heavens are therefore not the dwelling place or domain of God, as becomes particularly apparent in the religious-historical comparison with the three-fold conception of the heavens in ‘*Enuma eliš*.’ Rather, God as Creator stands *fundamentally beyond* the creative works of heaven and earth.”⁶⁸ This assessment must be contextualized within the entire work of the Priestly Writing. At other points, the Priestly Writing knows other things to report about the heavens (so Gen 1:26; 5:24; 17:22). Furthermore, according to the Priestly conception, the creator god Yhwh is present in the Jerusalem sanctuary, where heaven and earth meet and where God clearly dwells in the background.⁶⁹

1:9–10

- 9 *Then God said, “Let the waters under the heavens gather themselves to one place, so that dry land appears.” And so it happened.*
- 10 *Then God called the dry land “earth” and the collection of the waters he called “sea.” And God saw it as good.*

The emergence of the landmasses on the third day concludes the formation of “space.” Its combination with the creation of plants, the second work of the day (vv. 11–13), is the result of the day being centered around the earth as habitable land – that is, around the green earth (Gen 2:5). Earth and seas are not “created” in the proper sense but are made visible through the command to concentrate all waters under the heavens at one place (v. 9). This conception is not entirely coherent; standing in the background is probably the idea native to the river cultures of Mesopotamia and Egypt of a floodplain, whose fertile land reappears after the floodwaters drain away. Once again, the Priestly Writing refrains from going into any detail. It is probable, but not addressed directly, that it shares the “ancient Near Eastern” worldview in which the sea stretches like a circle around the dry land while also lying beneath the earth’s surface, which itself rests on “pillars of the earth” (see Ps 24:1f.; 18:16; 75:4; Job 9:6; 26:7).

⁶⁸ Schmid, 2005, 133 [translation JWR; emphasis original].

⁶⁹ See further Koch, 2017, 191–228.

The three-tiered concept of “heaven – earth – sea” can also be found in Ps 69:35. A pictorial representation is provided by a boundary stone from Elamite Susa (ca. 1180 BCE), which distinguishes between an upper heavenly sphere, the surface of the earth, and the underworld.⁷⁰ For the idea of an ocean stretching around the habitable land, there is a Late Babylonian “world map”⁷¹ as well as Herodotus’s (ca. 484–424 BCE) mockery of such maps (Herodotus, *Hist.* 4.36). In general, it needs to be considered that broader statements about “the ancient Near Eastern worldview” as well as “the biblical worldview” are based on constructs that combine quite disparate conceptions from various media and genres from a large temporal and geographic span in order to illustrate perceptions of the world that are presumably quite different from those of modern times. This applies not least to the typical graphic representations.

Just like in the previous works of creation, the concentration on the generality and the completely undramatic nature of the creation of the landmasses and seas is striking: “[There is] no imaginative attempt to describe the course of events in further detail [but] everywhere thoughtful consideration that shies away from going beyond the most general of reflections.”⁷² Especially with the creation of the seas, this provides a counterpoint to the widespread idea of the Creator God’s struggle against the chaotic flood (see Ps 104:6f.). This may also explain the plural form “seas” in v. 10. The singular, which is what would be expected, could have possibly evoked associations with the sea god of the same name, who was the opponent of the Creator God in the battle against chaos (see Ps 74:13; Job 7:12; 26:12). However, the Hebrew Bible refers to bodies of water of various sizes as “seas,” and so it is conceivable that they were understood, analogous to the botanical (vv. 11f.) and zoological (vv. 20–23) systems, as expressions of the same “gathering of the waters.” In any case, it is clear that, as with the heavens, it is not the mythical dimension of the sea but its physical dimension that is in focus here. With the naming of the “dry land” and the “gathering of the waters” as “earth” and “sea” (v. 10a), the constitution of “space” that began with the creation of the heavens on the second day is now completed. Accordingly, only now does the approval formula appear (v. 10b) that was absent following the creation of the firmament.

1:11–13

11 *Then God said, “Let the earth green with young greenery: plants yielding seed and fruit trees bearing fruit, according to their kind, in which their seed is upon the earth.” And so it happened.*

⁷⁰ Keel/Schroer, 2002, 106 Fig. 84.

⁷¹ BM 92687: See Unger, 1970, Pl. 3; Horowitz, 2011, 20–42 and Pl. 6; also Pongratz-Leisten, 2001, 274–276.

⁷² Wellhausen, 1905, 297 [translation JWR].

- 12** *And the earth brought forth young greenery: plants yielding seed according to their kind, and trees bearing fruit with its seed according to its kind. And God saw it as good.*
- 13** *And there was evening, and there was morning: a third day.*

The second work of the second day concerns defining the function of the earth as an inhabitable space: The earth is to produce plants as the basis for human and animal life (v. 29f.). According to the system presented in the Creation account and like elsewhere in antiquity, flora is not categorized as (organic) life, which the view from the Hebrew Bible associates with the “breath of life” (נִפְּחַיִּם; see below on v. 20) and blood as the “seat of life” (so Lev 17:11, 14). Thus, plants have no autonomous vitality and are regarded as closely connected with the earth – even if they had already been symbols of vitality in many contexts because of their regenerative power and therefore probably would not have been seen as inanimate matter.⁷³ The formulation of the command also indicates that the second work of the day is less about any autonomous participation of the earth in God’s creation than about setting its function. Rather than addressing the earth directly, the command prompts it via the jussive, as with the creation of the land animals: “Let the earth green with young greenery” [אֲדָא] אֲשֶׁר (תִּדְשֵׁן). The phrase, like the mention of the plant seeds, is meant for the constant recurrence of plant growth. The creationary command lays it out already for all times in the future.

Therefore, unlike with the other works of creation, there is a separate work dedicated to setting the function of the earth, even if it happens on the same day (cf. vv. 6f.). Together with the differences in wording between the command and the execution (especially “the earth brought forth young greenery” in v. 12a instead of “Let the earth green young greenery” in v. 11a), these indicate the inclusion of a prior tradition as the basis of v. 12. When considered on its own, this verse seems to allude to the idea of a “Mother Earth” who brings forth plants and, to an extent, also the humans and animals. This idea need come merely from observing the natural order; in any case, it is not completely foreign to the ancient Near East, and traces of it can be found elsewhere in the biblical tradition. It is present in the Priestly Creation account with the creation of the land animals in v. 24 (see below) as well as in Job 1:21 and Sir 40:1, which each present the earth as a mythological womb (see also Ps 139:15) from which humanity is born and to which it will return: “Naked I came out of my mother’s womb, and naked shall I

⁷³ See Riede, 2007. For the plants and their symbolism, see Neumann-Gorsolke/Riede, 2002.

return there” (Job 1:21).⁷⁴ Meanwhile, the Priestly Creation account is clearly dominated by the divine command (v. 11a). This provides a beautiful example of early natural science, which seeks to order the diversity of the world through classification and to define it conceptually. The first mention of the “green[ery]” (דָּשָׁא) designates the entire plant kingdom. This is evident from the lack of specific “greens” and that the term does not occur in the assignment of the individual plant groups as nourishment (v. 29). The plant kingdom is structured into two groups: plants of wood (עֵץ) and plants not of wood (עֵשֶׂב), with “plants yielding seed” (מְזַרֵּעַ זֶרַע) and “plants bearing fruit” (פֹּרֵי עֵשֶׂה) serving as further distinguishing categories (v. 11; also v. 12). The plants of wood (vv. 11, 12) and not of wood (v. 12) are again said to be differentiated “according to their kind” (לְמִינֵהוּ). In its generality, the list seeks to be comprehensive and, similar to the domesticated animals (vv. 24f.), likely includes cultivated plants. The possibility of cultivating new plants is not mentioned, lying beyond the interest of the text and likely beyond the experiential knowledge of its authors. The command is followed by the event formula (v. 11b) and a concise report that differs slightly in wording (v. 12a) as well as by the approval formula (v. 12b). The day count ends the second day of creation, which, with its two works, was meant for the creation of the earth as a living space (v. 13).

1:14–19

- 14 *Then God said, “Let there be lights on the firmament of heaven to separate between the day and the night. And let them serve as signs, for seasons and for days and for years.*
- 15 *And let them serve as lights on the firmament of heaven in order to light the earth.” And so it happened.*
- 16 *Then God made the two great lights, the greater light for dominion over the day and the smaller light for dominion over the night, as well as the stars.*
- 17 *And God set them on the firmament of heaven in order to light the earth*
- 18 *and to rule over the day and the night and to separate between the light and the darkness. And God saw it as good.*
- 19 *And there was evening and there was morning: a fourth day.*

The fourth day of creation is dedicated to the heavenly bodies, which are assigned to the category of “time.” The scope and complexity of the passage

⁷⁴ On the mythological presentations of Mother Earth as giving birth, see Keel/Schroer, 2002, 52–58 (with iconographic references).

as well as its points of contact with the appearance of light on the first day have led to a controversial debate over the formation and interpretation of the passage. The stars of v. 16, which are necessary for the astronomical calculations (v. 14), have repeatedly been judged as an “appendage.”⁷⁵ However, there is no reason for this. As opposed to the two “great lights” (v. 16a), they have no governing function and should be distinguished in this respect from the sun and the moon. Nevertheless, they are still part of the “lights on the firmament of heaven” (v. 14a) mentioned in the passage’s introduction. Thus, at first glance, the description of the first day of creation seems somewhat redundant, but closer examination reveals a well thought-out structure:⁷⁶ The command for creating the heavenly bodies assigns them the tasks of (A) distinguishing between day and night (בְּדֹלֵל hi.; v. 14a); (B) providing orientation throughout the course of the year through the (festival) calendar (v. 14b); (C) lighting the earth (v. 15a). The subsequent event formula establishes the correspondence between the command and the execution (v. 15b), which then unfolds in two parts. The first specifies that the “lights on the firmament of heaven” are the sun, moon, and stars (v. 16), with the sun and moon being assigned dominion (מְמַשְׁלָה; v. 16baβ) over the day and night, respectively, drawing on v. 14aβ (the differentiation between day and night). It next tells of God fixing the heavenly bodies to the firmament as they were destined to be (vv. 17–18a). This passage partially takes up the wording of the divine command but reverses the order: (C') The heavenly bodies light the earth (so v. 15a); (B') sun and moon govern over day and night (v. 16baβ; also v. 14aβ), enabling calendrical orientation for the very first time;⁷⁷ (A') they separate (בְּדֹלֵל hi.) light and darkness (so v. 14aβ). The section concludes with the approval formula and the day count (vv. 18b–19).

The statements about the tasks of the heavenly bodies are conspicuously extensive, which should lead to the question of what they emphasize in their structure and what, in all of their detail, they do *not* say. The fact that the heavenly bodies are to distinguish (בְּדֹלֵל hi.) day from night (v. 14a), or light from darkness, marks the beginning and the end of how their functions are defined. This underscores the unmistakable connection to the appearance of light and its distinction (בְּדֹלֵל hi.) from darkness, as well as the naming of light and darkness as “day” and “night” on the first day (vv. 3–5). The two works belong together but are spread out over two days. The resultant temporal rearrangement of the creation of the heavenly bodies to *after* the appearance of light and the emergence of the plant kingdom is only troublesome when demanding that the Creation account conform to modern natural science. The

⁷⁵ See, among others, Westermann, 131.

⁷⁶ See Steck, 1975, 95–118.

⁷⁷ See further Steck, 1975, 107–110.

structure of the account and the cosmology presupposed by its authors follow a strict logic: The fastening of the lights onto the firmament of heaven (v. 17a) presupposes its creation on the second day. This, in turn, cannot be separated from the “completion” of “space” on the third day. Since “space” is understood as the inhabitable “living space,” the emergence of the plant kingdom must then belong to the first creation of space and must therefore be placed before the creation of the heavenly bodies. The intent behind the Priestly Writing’s structure of the account, according to which the category of “time” guides its beginning, middle, and end, would have been further cause for putting the creation of the heavenly bodies on the fourth day. A nice parallel for the biblical chronology can be found in a Sumerian text from the Ur III period (ca. 2100–2000 BCE), which, however, is only poorly preserved: “In the beginning, darkness held sway, until the heavens and earth were separated. While the heavens were already illuminated, the earth, still in darkness, produced plants.”⁷⁸ Nevertheless, the question arises of how, according to the view of the Priestly Writing, the statements about the appearance of light on the first day and the creation of the lights on the fourth day functionally relate to each other. Since vv. 3–5 speak quite generally of “light” (אור sg.) in contrast to darkness, and vv. 14–18 speak of “lights” (מאורות pl.) that shine upon the earth (על־הָאָרֶץ), it seems most obvious to think of perceptions of diffused daylight on the one hand and the concentrated rays of the sun and moon on the other; even the phenomenon of twilight can give the impression that they are two different things. Yet, given the linguistic connections, the Priestly Writing clearly draws a connection between the two perceptions of light, even if it is unclear in its details. It may be that the Priestly Writing, akin to the somewhat older but still contemporary Pre-Socratic Anaximander of Miletus (ca. 610/09–547/46 BCE), conceived of light windows in the heavenly firmament, through which the primordial light – located above the heavenly ocean after the separation of darkness (cf. v. 5, and Ibn Ezra on v. 3) – can shine through.⁷⁹ However, the idea of a rotating heavenly wheel directing the course of the heavenly bodies, which is presupposed by the astronomical model, cannot be convincingly shown to be in the Hebrew Bible. Furthermore, other Hebrew Bible texts describe how Yhwh assigned the sun to its place, from which it passes through the heavens from one end to the other (Ps 19:5–7). Like the winged sun disk also attested in Judean iconography⁸⁰ or the (condemnatory) mention of the solar chariot (2 Kgs 23:11f.), this may speak for the conception of heavenly bodies common across the ancient Near East. Whether imagined as autonomous sources

⁷⁸ NBC 11108, ln. 9; text and translation in Horowitz, 2011, 138f.

⁷⁹ See Halpern, 2003. On the cosmology of Anaximander, see Rapp, 2007, 44–46.

⁸⁰ See Keel/Uehlinger, *GKG*, 299 Fig. 263b; *BRL2*, 305 Fig. 78:28, 29.

of light, or as entities that focus the diffused light of the first day of creation like a convex-cut crystal or reflect it like precious stones or metal (cf. Ezek 1:26f.; Exod 24:10), there is still the problem that, strictly speaking, the idea of orbiting heavenly bodies cannot be reconciled with the statement that God placed them at fixed points in the heavens (v. 17). In any case, even if the underlying astronomical conceptions cannot be clearly identified, the geocentric and anthropocentric perspectives of the text are unmistakable: The entire point of the heavenly bodies is for them to light the earth (vv. 15, 17), structure the course of the day (vv. 14aβ, 16baβ, 18a), and provide humanity with a calendrical system (v. 14b). The last of these clearly reveals the special viewpoint of the Priestly authors. The division of the calendar with its emphasis on (cultic) feasting times (מוֹעֵד pl.; see Num 10:10; 15:3; 29:39) and the smooth flow of time (days and years) via the heavenly bodies (see Ps 104:19) were authentic priestly duties. The use of the term מָאֹר (“light”) for the sun and the moon points in the same direction. In Priestly contexts, the term is otherwise used only for the lights of the seven-armed lampstand (so Exod 25:6; 27:20; 35:8, 14, 28; 39:37; Lev 24:2), underscoring the internal connection of the temporal structure of Creation and sanctuary.⁸¹ In light of their specific significance for the division of time, the heavenly bodies fall under the term “signs” (אוֹת pl.).⁸²

There has always been special attention paid to the sun and moon not being called by their names but instead awkwardly being described as the “two great lights, the greater... and the smaller” (v. 16). Naturally, the authors of the Priestly writing knew, like any three-year-old, that the greater light of the daytime was called “sun” and the smaller one of the nighttime was called “moon.” Avoiding these designations would have been, so it goes, because of their religious connotations unrelated to the functions themselves: The Hebrew word יָרֵחַ denotes both “moon” and “the moon god,”⁸³ and שֶׁמֶשׁ “sun”⁸⁴ is easily identified with the sun god of the same name who was widespread throughout the entire ancient Near East. Especially Deuteronomistic and related texts attest that the ever-visible, and therefore ever-present, celestial deities put severe strain on the requirement for the exclusive worship of Yhwh well into the postexilic period (see Deut 4:19; 17:3; 2 Kgs 23:5; Jer 8:2; 19:13; Ezek 8:16).⁸⁵ Against this background, it makes sense that a Creation account focusing so much on the universality and sovereignty of the one Creator God would try to avoid any allusions to the celestial deities.

⁸¹ See Ruwe, 1999, 324f.

⁸² See Westermann, 130f. Cf. recently Seebaß, 74, understanding “sign” as the first element of a list and presuming that standing behind it is a reference to astrological omens.

⁸³ See Schmidt, 1999.

⁸⁴ See Lipiński, 1999.

⁸⁵ On the iconographic evidence, see Keel/Uehlinger, GGG⁶, 327–369.

Instead, it emphasizes the created nature of the heavenly bodies as well as their limited function compared to their environment. This is often seen together with the subordination of the heavenly bodies after the appearance of light on the first day and their designation as “luminaries” being a polemical degradation of the astral deities of Babylon. Yet, the lack of any polemical tone (cf. the discussion of Marduk theology in Isa 40:12–17; 44:25; 47:9–13) speaks against this widespread interpretation.⁸⁶ Furthermore, there is the fact (only rarely considered) that the assertions of Gen 1:14–19, presumably formulated as a sort of polemical detachment, consistently have parallels in extrabiblical texts: In the Egyptian cosmogony of Esna, the sun god is born only after the creation of the first light.⁸⁷ In *Enuma Eliš*, the stars were created by Marduk as the creator god (EnEl 5.1–46). The consequence of Marduk’s power over the heavenly bodies is the subordination of the gods that they represent to “astral sheep” (EnEl 7.130f.) and the relegation of the heavenly bodies to their calendrical function. Furthermore, in Egyptian and Mesopotamian texts like the aforementioned commentary on *Enuma Eliš* (KAR 307), the sun and moon are by no means assigned the labels “luminary” or “lamp” disrespectfully. A good example of this is the Assyrian king Assurbanipal’s (668–626 BCE) invocation of Sîn, the moon god of the northern Syrian city of Haran: “For Sîn, the lamp of heaven [and the earth] / who is covered with the ruling cap of the heavenly divinity / who dictates day, month, and year / who reveals the enemy’s snares / who performs judgment and decides the purpose of the gods.”⁸⁸ Against this background, the lamp metaphor in Gen 1:16 should not be evaluated as a polemic against the heavenly bodies but as a demonstration of Babylonian learnedness that also found its way into the Priestly Creation account with its taxonomy of all the works of creation. The designation of the heavenly bodies as “lights” is due to them being subsumed under a collective term. In contrast to the hymns praising Creation in the Psalms (so Ps 8:4; 19:5; 74:16; 104:19; 136:7–9), this is meant to be scientific prose. The hymns follow Gen 1 in praising Yhwh as the god “who made the great lights... the sun [!] to rule over the day... the moon [!] and stars to rule over the night” (Ps 136:7–9), while the scientific prose runs exhaustively through its systemization of Creation.⁸⁹ In the latter case, the focus is on the theological redefinition of astronomical phenomena and the avoidance of unintended connotations that go against the intention of the Creation account.

⁸⁶ See Gertz, 2009^a.

⁸⁷ Introduction and translation: Sternberg-el Hotabi, *TUAT* III, 1078–1086; “Cosmogonies at the Temple of Esna,” trans. by Clagett, 1989; Sauneron, 1962, 247ff.

⁸⁸ Perry, 1907, 29 ll. 1–5 [translation JWR from German].

⁸⁹ So already Wellhausen, 1905, 296f.

The dominion (מְשִׁלָּה) of the sun and the moon is limited to distinguishing and marking day and night (vv. 16, 18) and does not include guiding the fates of all people (ancient Near Eastern astrology was in any case initially concerned exclusively with the destinies of ruling houses, states, and larger groups; the fate of individuals became a concern only in the Seleucid period). Nevertheless, the numinous significance of the heavenly bodies was widespread throughout antiquity and influenced the thinking of the Priestly authors. This can be seen in the talk of the dominion of the sun and moon over day and night (vv. 16, 18),⁹⁰ which clearly stands on more than just an old tradition. Even though the tradition has been tempered, it still conveys the power and magnitude of the two great lights.

1:20–23

- 20** *Then God said, “Let the water teem with the teeming of living beings and let flying animals fly over the earth, all along the firmament of heaven.”*
- 21** *Then God created the great sea serpents and all living beings with which the waters teem according to their kind, and all winged flying animals according to their kind. And God saw it as good.*
- 22** *And God blessed them, saying, “Be fruitful and multiply and fill the waters in the seas, and let the flying animals be vast upon the earth!”*
- 23** *And there was evening, and there was morning: a fifth day.*

The fifth day of creation begins the populating of the created space with living beings. First, the areas more distant from the human perspective are populated: the sea and the area between the heavens and the earth (vv. 20–23). This is followed by the earth’s surface, which land animals and humanity share (vv. 24–25, 26–31). In ancient Near Eastern creation texts, the creation of the animals usually plays only a rather minor role.⁹¹ The detailed nature of its presentation here, even in comparison to the Garden narrative, was certainly motivated by the statements about humanity’s dominion over the animals and the provision of food to humans and animals alike that concludes this part of Creation. However, regardless of the anthropocentric perspective, it is still noteworthy that the animals are initially “taken into consideration as creatures of God no differently than humanity (and still independently from the question of their relationship to them).”⁹²

⁹⁰ See Perry, 1907, 29 ll. 1–5.

⁹¹ See Schellenberg, 2011, 38f., with a few exceptions on pg. 314.

⁹² Schellenberg, 2011, 38 [translation JWR].

The filling of heaven and earth as a “house of life” (Erich Zenger) marks a watershed moment in the course of the Creation account, indicated by the twofold *figura etymologica*, lit. “Let the teeming creatures teem” (... יִשְׂרְצוּ שָׂרָץ) and “Let the flying animals fly” (עוֹף יְעוּפֶה) in the divine command and underscored by the text’s use of the creation verb בָּרָא (“to create”). This is the first use of the verb following the epigraph to the account in Gen 1:1; in v. 27, its use then emphasizes the special significance of the creation of humanity. The twofold *figura etymologica* encountered here illustrates the abundance of life, which is the focus of what follows. The hallmark of animals being alive (vv. 20, 21, 24, 30; 9:10, 12, 15 [P]) and humans being alive (Gen 9:16 [P]; also 2:7, 19) is the “breath of life” (נֶפֶשׁ). Here, however, the term is used in connection with the attribute “living” as a collective term for the “living creatures” of the seas rather than as a general term for “life.” The living space of the flying animals, encompassing all winged animals including bats (see Lev 11:13–19), is the area above the ground (עַל-הָאָרֶץ) and up to the firmament of heaven, which they nearly brush up against in flight (עַל-פְּנֵי רִקְיעַ הַשָּׁמַיִם). This encompasses the entire air space, for which, unlike with moving air, Biblical Hebrew has no specific expression.⁹³ Additionally, the mention of the great sea serpents in the execution report has long caused a stir in readings of the text: The Hebrew expression תַּנִּין “sea serpent” was thought to be an allusion to a mythical sea monster that the Priestly author ironically placed among the multitude of creatures, thereby depriving it of its ungodly power. The word undeniably has a mythological meaning in some texts about the battle against chaos (so Isa 27:1; 51:9; Ps 74:13; Job 7:12). However, it can also mean “serpent” (Exod 7:9, 10, 12 [P]; Deut 32:33) or “crocodile” (Ezek 29:3; 32:2), although the exact zoological meaning is always uncertain. Its appearance here in the Priestly Creation account being a personification of the chaos dragon can fundamentally be ruled out in light of the plural form, the approval formula, and the subsequent blessing. Even though sea serpents and crocodiles are considered to be monstrous and, in a broader sense, “mythical” even up to the present, it is for exactly this reason alone that the account illustrates the astonishing abundance of life created by God. Accordingly, the LXX does not translate תַּנִּין with the usual δράκων “dragon” and instead uses κῆτος, which can mean, in addition to “sea monster,” any kind of large fish or marine mammal. In this sense, Luther’s classic translation as “the great whales” is zoologically inaccurate but functionally quite appropriate – akin to the mythological connotation of the whale in Herman Melville’s *Moby-Dick*. The approval formula (v. 21b) is followed by the blessing as a new element, aimed at the preservation of the created beings. Insofar as the process and the consequences

⁹³ See Jacob, 53.

performatively coincide with the blessing, the blessing gifts the living beings with the capacity for self-preservation according to their kind. Like the “word” of creation, the speaking of the blessing directly changes the world. The formulation of the blessing in the grammatical imperative may be surprising to our language sensibilities, but it is not a communicative imperative that commands the addressee to action. Rather, it pronounces the blessees to become or experience what the blessing proclaims upon them (so Gen 24:60; 27:29aβ).⁹⁴ For the marine animals (including the “great sea serpents”!), the blessing is pronounced in the tripartite form also common elsewhere in the Priestly Writing: fruitfulness – multiplication – propagation (Gen 1:28; 9:1). The propagation goes unmentioned for the winged animals, possibly due to the difficulties evident in v. 21 around naming their habitat. The fact that the animals are ultimately deprived of the possibility of realizing the blessing’s gift of life, especially as the result of human violence, comes into view only with the Flood and its consequences (see Gen 9:1–7).

1:24–25

- 24** *Then God said, “Let the earth bring forth living beings according to their kind: livestock and crawling animals and the wild animals of the earth according to their kind.” And so it happened.*
- 25** *Then God made the wild animals of the earth according to their kind and the livestock according to its kind and everything that crawls upon the earth according to its kind. And God saw it as good.*

The sixth day of creation again involves two separate works: the creation of the land animals (vv. 24–25) and humanity (vv. 26–31). Both works take place on one and the same day, since their shared living space calls for creationary clarification of the relationship between the two co-inhabitants.⁹⁵ This clarification comes explicitly through the empowerment of humanity to rule over the entire animal kingdom (vv. 26, 28) and to take possession of the land (v. 28), as well as through the provision of food for humans and animals (vv. 29f.). It is also implied in the differences between the description of the creation of the land animals versus all other living creatures. Unlike humans and the creatures of the sea and sky, the verb **ברא** (“to create”), used exclusively for the divine act of creation, is not used for the land animals (see its uses once in v. 21 and three times in v. 27). Instead, the account uses the neutral **עשה** (“to do/make”; v. 25). Nor are the land animals given a blessing of multiplication and the associated capacity to fill their habitat

⁹⁴ See Müller, 1990, esp. 9f.

⁹⁵ See further Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 161–166.

(cf. vv. 22, 28). This differentiated consideration is due to how humanity competes with the animals of each habitat for resources quite differently:⁹⁶ The entire animal kingdom, including the animals of the sea and sky, is subject to the promise to humanity of dominion. On the other hand, the instructions for food refer only to the creatures that, like humanity, feed on the plants of the earth. For this reason, the sea creatures are not explicitly mentioned in v. 30, but the birds, who also seek their sustenance on the ground, are.⁹⁷ In the Priestly Writing's conception, marine animals and humans do not compete with each other for nourishment. Finally, the possession and division of the land through multiplication is addressed only through humanity's relationship to the land animals (the competition with animals for living space is threatening to humanity and thus stands behind the motif of a wild animal takeover of [depopulated] land, as attested in various contexts [e.g., Lev 26:22; 2 Kgs 17:25; Jer 9:10]).

The blessing for multiplication, which always also involves the capability for self-preservation, is thus missing for the land animals for conceptual reasons. Nevertheless, the Priestly Writing holds the opinion that the conservation of the land animals according to their kind is also guaranteed as part of the creationary order. Therefore, in the divine command creating the land animals, it takes up the traditional motif of the earth as the bearer of life but, unlike some other texts, does not apply it to humans and uses it instead exclusively for the land animals (v. 24a).⁹⁸ As shown already in the divine command for Noah to bring a male and female of each species into the ark (Gen 6:19f.; 7:15, 16a), the Priestly authors were able to reconcile mythological and scientific knowledge of reproduction (see also Ps 139:13–15). Rather than arguing biologically, Gen 1:24 endeavors to define humanity's relationship to land animals through a theology of Creation. Similar to the plants, it is the lifegiving power of the earth that at God's command enables the continuation of life, which then perpetually renews itself. For this reason, the command already distinguishes between the land animals "according to their kind," as was the case previously with the plants (v. 11). On the other hand, if the capability for self-preservation is granted in the blessing – as is the case for the animals of the sea and sky as well as for humanity – the differentiation according to kind (v. 21) or sex (v. 27) would need to be mentioned only in the execution report. Following the event formula (v. 24b) is the concise report of the execution of the command. Its wording emphasizes the action of God alone in the initial creation of the land animals. For this reason, there is only mention of God "making" the animals rather than the

⁹⁶ Schellenberg, 2011, 46–49 (with further literature).

⁹⁷ See Schellenberg, 2011, 48.

⁹⁸ See Seebaß, 77f. (with reference to Schmidt, Westermann, Steck).

earth bringing them forth (v. 25a). The land animals are divided into wild animals (חַיֵּי הָאָרֶץ), domesticated animals (livestock) such as herd animals and beasts of burden (בְּהֵמָה), and all animals that crawl upon the earth (רֶמֶשׂ הָאֲדָמָה) – whether reptiles, small mammals, or insects, whether quadrupedal, multipedal, or apedal (so Lev 11:2, 42). These three groups of land animals are, in turn, structured by species. Even though wild animals precede domesticated animals within the execution report, the mention of the “livestock according to its kind” leaves no doubt that the authors of the Creation account thought all species were present from the beginning in their present forms. Evolutionary biology lies beyond the imaginative capabilities of the time, and there is no sense here of the long-past historical process of the domestication of wild animals. Even the breeding of new varieties, which was already familiar to the animal husbandry of the time, does not come into view, since the main focus is on emphasizing the sovereignty and universality of the Creator God.

In retrospect, especially for the creation of the land animals, it should be emphasized that the Priestly Writing by no means overlooked internal tensions that were probably caused by the inclusion of older traditions. Instead, it skillfully used these tensions – in the case of the land animals, the command to the earth to “bring forth living beings” versus their actual creation directly by God himself – to express a multilayered but still internally coherent conception of the creation.

1:26–31

- 26 *And God said, “Let us make humanity as our image, like an image akin to us, so that they may rule over the fish of the sea and over the flying animals of the heavens and over the livestock and over all of the wild animals of the earth and over all crawling animals that crawl upon the earth.”*
- 27 *Then God created humanity as his image. As the image of God he created them. Male and female he created them.*
- 28 *And God blessed them, and God said to them, “Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth and take possession of it and rule over the fish of the sea and over the flying animals of the heavens and over every living being that crawls upon the earth.”*
- 29 *Then God said, “Behold, I give you all plants yielding seed that are upon the face of the whole earth, and all trees with fruit that produce seed. It shall be food for you.*
- 30 *And to all living beings and all flying animals of the heavens and all crawling animals upon the earth in which there is the breath of life, I give every green plant as food.” And so it happened.*

- 31** *And God saw everything that he had made, and behold, it was very good. And there was evening, and there was morning: the sixth day.*

The second work of the sixth day is the creation of humanity (vv. 26–31). It concludes not only the creation of the living beings but, in a stricter sense, also the entire sequence of creationary works. This positioning emphasizes the special significance of humanity's creation within the Priestly Creation account, particularly since it has considered the preceding works primarily from the point of view of the human world and its needs. The description of the creation of humanity accords with the basic scheme found across the Creation account, with the divine command (v. 26) and subsequent execution (v. 27). Deviations in the details and expansions of the basic scheme serve to specify humanity's relationship to God and the rest of Creation. The necessity of determining such is the result of the prominent position of humanity within the whole of Creation. It is both the point of departure and the end goal of the section about the creation of humanity.

One of the most striking features of the passage is that the divine decision to create humanity is formulated as a plural cohortative (v. 26). This obviously sets the creation of humanity apart from the other creationary works, but the exact meaning of the plural form is a matter of dispute. It is most likely a communicative plural, meaning that God explicitly includes his court as taking part in his actions. Against this explanation is the oft-raised objection that the Priestly Writing otherwise makes no mention of the divine court. However, this should not be given too much weight, since God's taking up of Enoch (Gen 5:24 [P]) suggests that the Priestly Writing knows more about the heavenly world than it reports. In any case, outside of the Priestly Writing, the concept of the divine court is widely attested across the Hebrew Bible: God is surrounded by his heavenly court (Ps 29:1f.; 89:6, 8); he consults with the heavenly beings as his council (Ps 82:1; 1 Kgs 22:19ff.); he was already praised by the "Sons of God" during Creation (Job 38:7). Most significant, however, is the Garden narrative by the Scholarly Narrator. In Gen 3:22, Yhwh justifies the expulsion of Adam and Eve from the Garden through the fact that humanity "has become like one of us [!], according to its knowledge of good and evil." The "us" here should clearly be understood as the heavenly beings, who, in addition to the aforementioned knowledge, also possess eternal life (v. 22b). Interestingly, there is a strong tradition in Jewish interpretation recognizing how the use of the cohortative in v. 26 includes the angels (Ibn Ezra). Already the Jewish/Hellenistic philosopher Philo of Alexandria, active in the first century CE, attributed humanity's moral virtue to God's contribution to the creation of humanity and humanity's moral faults to the contribution of God's servants (Philo, *Opif.* 24.72–76). Speaking

in favor of a communicative plural are also a few ancient Near Eastern texts that likewise report of the resolution among the divine to create humanity. Thus, a Neo-Babylonian fragment from the first millennium BCE documents the “Myth of the Creation of Man and King,” which states: “Let us create a figure [*ṣalmu*; see Heb. *צֶלֶם* in vv. 26f.] of clay and impose toil on it... [the goddess] Bēlet-ilī pinched off clay for him [humanity].”⁹⁹ Thus, it would not be without religious-historical parallels if God requested his court to join him in creating humanity in Gen 1:26. However, in contrast to the aforementioned texts and interpretive traditions that can be cited for a communicative plural in v. 26, Gen 1:26f. reports of neither angels nor other heavenly beings or deities being involved in the creation of humanity. This is clear from the execution report: Unlike v. 26, it does not use the general עָשָׂה “to do/make” but instead uses בָּרָא “to create” three times, with God as the sole subject. In this respect, the plural exhortation in v. 26 maintains a certain amount of suspense in its meaning – perhaps “to prevent one from referring God’s image too directly to God the Lord.”¹⁰⁰

The alternative proposals for explaining the plural form are not convincing: 1) The trinitarian reading has a long ecclesiastical tradition but comes from a dogmatic rereading of the text. 2) The evidence cited for a *pluralis deliberationis* (Gen 11:7; Isa 6:8; 2 Sam 24:14), a plural of self-deliberation (see GKC §124g), cannot withstand the burden of proof,¹⁰¹ especially since self-deliberation in the Hebrew Bible is formulated differently (such as “he said in his heart”; e.g., Gen 17:17 [P]). 3) The *pluralis majestatis* has been used by the great rulers of history since the time of the Persian court and has included their subjects under the power of the ruler (!) and consequently presupposes an audience. Yet, it is documented in the Hebrew Bible only in two recent texts (Ezra 4:18; Dan 3:24) and does not occur in divine speech. 4) Also unconvincing is the claim that the roots of the plural form lie entirely in the conventions of creation myths from the rest of the ancient Near East, in which the creation of humanity sometimes begins with a cohortative by the creator god or an announcement in the divine assembly. Such an adaptation of a stylistic device with no consideration for the communicative structure assumes a rather unusual carelessness on the part of the Priestly Writing. If the adaption was instead the result of a polemic against the Mesopotamian myths, with the creation of humanity now appearing as a free decision by the one God, the singular would have accomplished this (more effectively) as well (cf. Marduk in EnEi 6.1–8).

The subject of God’s reflexive call (“Let us...”) is the creation of humanity. The Hebrew word אָדָם is a collective term designating the class “human.” Its use as the proper name “Adam” is dependent upon this, and the Priestly Writing employs this usage exclusively during the transition from the creation of humanity to its genealogical history (Gen 5:1a, 3, 4). Consequently,

⁹⁹ Text and translation from Pongratz-Leisten, 2015, 208–209 (ll. 8', 14').

¹⁰⁰ von Rad, 58. Similarly Ps 8:5f.

¹⁰¹ See further Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 168f. and fn. 40, which tends towards solution #4.

the following statements about humanity being created as the image of God, the differentiation of the sexes, and the empowerment for dominion all apply, without exception, to the entire class of “human” (אָדָם). Nevertheless, the complicated process of individualizing humanity at the beginning of the genealogy of the descendants of Adam (see below on Gen 5:1–3) suggests that, for the creation of humanity, the Priestly Writing assumed an initial human couple from which all other people descended. Obviously, there is no other way to conceive of all individuals belonging to one species while functioning in a genealogical mode of thinking – one that has significantly shaped the texts of Genesis as a whole. In contrast to the Garden narrative, here, no story of the first human significant for humanity as a whole is told. Instead, it is simply reported that it had been created, specifically (1.) as the image of God (vv. 26a, 27a), to whom (2.) dominion is promised over the earth and animal kingdom (vv. 26b, 28), and (3.) as the only being for whom a sexual differentiation is announced (v. 27b).

The fundamental importance of these statements for biblically influenced anthropology is undeniable.¹⁰² Yet, does this also already apply to the Priestly Writing itself? Claus Westermann stressed that it is less concerned with a statement about humanity than about the process of creation. Even the Hebrew Bible, according to the sparse history of inner-biblical reception, did not recognize in the statements of Gen 1:26f. a “general and universally valid statement about the nature of humankind.”¹⁰³ This qualification is not convincing. “Primeval histories” of all kinds draw their purposes from how they establish the nature of all things by telling of how they came to be. In this respect, it is difficult to separate the “statement about... nature” from the “primeval event” itself.¹⁰⁴ Additionally, the claims and validity of the Priestly Writing concerning the image of God cannot be measured by its reception within the Hebrew Bible alone. In other words, all three claims indicate the Priestly Writing’s intent to communicate something fundamental about humanity.¹⁰⁵

(1.) The Priestly Writing’s discourse about humanity being created as the image of God (*imago Dei*) is almost unique within the Hebrew Bible (see also Gen 5:1; 9:6 [both P] as well as the allusions in Ps 8:5ff.): Compared to its wide reception and consequences outside of the Hebrew Bible and the intense theological debate over its meaning, the evidence is surprisingly clear in regard to philology, history of religion, and tradition history. The statement of the creation of humanity as being “as our image (בְּצַלְמֵנוּ),

¹⁰² Westermann, 147–158; Groß, 1993; Groß et al., 2016.

¹⁰³ Westermann, 155.

¹⁰⁴ Westermann, 155f.

¹⁰⁵ See Groß, 2000; Stipp, 2001; Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, esp. 136–315; Janowski, 2004; Waschke, 2009; Schellenberg, 2011.

like an image akin to us (כְּדִמוּתֵנוּ)” is a bipartite comparative construction. There is a strong tradition going back to Irenaeus of Lyon (second century CE) that reads the pair of terms as conveying both the (permanent) creationary endowment of humanity with reason and will (לִצְלָם: LXX εἰκόν; Lat. *imago*) and also humanity’s original conformity (דְּמוּת: LXX ὁμοίωσις; Lat. *similitudo*)¹⁰⁶ to the will of God that is lost through the Fall (Gen 3). However, this is almost certainly not the original, literal sense of the comparison. Since, in the Hebrew, the two elements stand alongside each other but are still unconnected, they are not two independent qualities of the divine creation. Rather, as in the translation chosen here, the second element of the comparative expression (כְּדִמוּתֵנוּ) serves to further specify the first element (בְּצִלְמֵנוּ). The translation further assumes that the preposition *beth* before לִצְלָם, the noun of the first element, is a so-called *beth essentiae*, which equates the identities of the two referents – here “לִצְלָם” and “humanity.”¹⁰⁷ Conversely, the understanding of the *beth* as a *beth normae* has been predominant in readings of the verse. According to this exegetical tradition, which began already with the LXX (κατ’ εἰκόνα ἡμετέραν καὶ καθ’ ὁμοίωσιν; see also Sir 17:3; Wis 2:23), humanity would have been created “in the image” (= following the plan/archetype/pattern) of the heavenly being(s). This again presupposes in principle that before the creation of humanity, an image of the heavenly being(s) would have been made as a model to be followed. Here, one might think of the “Sons of the Gods” or the “Elohim” beings (e.g., Ps 8). Comparable uses of the *beth normae* are quite scarce (Exod 25:40; 30:32).

The noun לִצְלָם has a quite general meaning of “statue,” “statuette,” or “stele,” ranging from (wall) reliefs to full sculptures, depending on context: statues and pillars with images (e.g., Num 33:52; 2 Kgs 11:18), Nebuchadnezzar’s dream of a statue made of four metals (Dan 2:31–35), effigies of mice and physical infirmities (1 Sam 6:5, 11), carvings (Ezek 23:14), or standards and symbols of gods (Amos 5:26).¹⁰⁸

How should the identity of human and image be understood in its details? Regarding the relationship between the depiction and the depicted, there is less emphasis on the “moment of exact reproduction” within the highly stylized art of the ancient Near East.¹⁰⁹ More important is instead the aspect of the potent “representation of the depicted.”¹¹⁰ The statue of a victorious king placed in enemy territory guarantees his powerful presence in the conquered land. The statue of someone praying erected in a temple makes the depicted person stand in eternal adoration before the deity, which in turn is

¹⁰⁶ See Rösel, 1994, 48ff., 123f.; Groß, 2000, 35ff.

¹⁰⁷ See Jenni, 1992, 84; Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 187–197.

¹⁰⁸ See Schroer, 1987, 322–332.

¹⁰⁹ Schroer, 1987, 324 [translation JWR].

¹¹⁰ Schroer, 1987, 324 [translation JWR].

present in its image in the temple. Since *צֶלֶם* refers to the Creator God, as evidenced by the object suffixes (“our,” “his”; vv. 26, 27a), humanity is thus created as a “powerful representation,”¹¹¹ “representative depiction,” or “representative image”¹¹² of God (*צֶלֶם אֱלֹהִים*; v. 27a). The noun of the second element, *דְּמוּת*, is derived from the root *דמה* “to be like; to resemble.” The word can denote any form of reproduction or likeness, up to the accuracy of an architectural sketch (e.g., 2 Kgs 16:10 [the sketch of the altar in Damascus]; Ezek 1:22, 26; 8:2; 10:21; Dan 10:16 [physical and figurative likeness]). The word *דְּמוּת* forms a pleonasm with the preposition *kaph*, which is also comparative. This construction expresses a relation of correspondence between two entities: “Like something similar to us.”¹¹³ Beyond the assertion of similarity, *דְּמוּת* may also put emphasis on the substance. If *צֶלֶם* accents the actual realization of what is being depicted, the use of *דְּמוּת* is primarily concerned with the corresponding relationship (see Isa 40:18). This is the case at least when *דְּמוּת* is used by itself (so 5:1) or with the preposition *beth* prefixed as the first element in the comparison (so 5:3). However, the interchangeability of the nouns in the word order of the comparison (so 1:26 and 5:3, but without the prepositions *beth* and *kaph*) and the use of only one of the two nouns (1:27; 5:1, 3; 9:6) speak against too strong of a delineation between the meaning of the two nouns in the context of (God’s) likeness. This pair of terms is also attested in Ezek 23:14f. and in the Aramaic section (*dmw* and *šlm*) of a bilingual Assyrian/Aramaic text from the ninth century BCE.¹¹⁴ There are occasional assumptions that the second element, introduced with *kaph*, should immediately relativize the preceding identification of the “statue of God” and “humanity,” but this is difficult to justify.

It follows from all of this that, according to Gen 1:26f., humanity was created both male and female as animated statues of God, representing God on earth in their outward form and in their essence – at least according to the literal meaning of the text. The meaning of this mythological theme of the “image of God” is found in its historical context within ancient Near Eastern royal ideology. The clearest and most numerous evidence for the idea of the king being an image and, therefore, earthly representation of the highest god comes from Egypt.¹¹⁵ There, it can be found primarily in texts from the 18th and 19th Dynasties (ca. 1550–1190 BCE), but it survived into the Late

¹¹¹ Groß, 2000, 19 [translation JWR].

¹¹² Schroer, 1987, 324 [translation JWR], with reference to Wildberger, 1976, 558; see also Janowski, 2004, 190 and fn. 28.

¹¹³ See Janowski, 2004, 194f., based on Jenni, 1997.

¹¹⁴ Tell Fekheriye. Text and translation: Abou-Assaf 1981; “Hadad-Yith’i” (Translation and Introduction; Millard, *COS* 2.34:153–154).

¹¹⁵ Ockinga, 1984.

Period. Concerning the historical context of the Priestly Writing, it is of particular interest that the Persian king Darius I (549–486 BCE), who ruled over almost the entire Jewish population whether in the motherland or in the diaspora, adopted this Egyptian concept and integrated it into Achaemenid imperial ideology in order to justify his claim to universal rule.¹¹⁶ However, the designation can also be found sporadically across Mesopotamia from the thirteenth century BCE onwards, and, from then, especially in Neo-Assyrian texts. It is not clear whether the conception was also shared by the royal ideology of Jerusalem.¹¹⁷ There is evidence of the royal titulature including “Son of God” (e.g., Ps 2:7; 2 Sam 7:14; Ps 89:27f.) but not of the king as the “image of God.” Regardless of any temporal, regional, or cultural differences, these texts still focus on the legitimation of royal rule. The royal dominion is privileged with the dignity of acting on behalf of the deity: “The perfect god, lord of joy, lord of the crowns, who has seized the crown of Upper Egypt, who has united the two powers in life and welfare, the image of [the god] Ra, his offspring, whom he has appointed to rule the Two Banks”;¹¹⁸ “[Darius] engendered by Atum, living image of Ra, who has placed him on his throne in order to complete what he has begun here below”;¹¹⁹ “the king, the lord of the lands, the statue/image of [the god] Šamaš is he.”¹²⁰ As its image, the king is ordained by the supreme god to rule; royal dominion is derived from the deity’s power to bring order to chaos. “When the Assyrian king appeared to the people in the front court of the temple to Aššur, donning the crown of the god Aššur, it became clear to the Assyrians that Aššur’s ‘terrible glory’ fused with the figure of the king.”¹²¹ These statements inevitably recall the divine summons in Gen 1:26 and the consequences mentioned there resulting from humanity being made as the image of God and qualifying it in terms of its content: “Let us make humanity as our image, like an image akin to us (v. 26a), *so that* they may rule over the fish of the sea and over the flying animals of the heavens and over the livestock and over all [of the wild animals] of the earth and over all crawling animals that crawl upon the earth (v. 26b).” It is thus clear that the Priestly Writing’s conception was tradition-historically dependent upon the aforementioned conceptions of the king justifying his rule through being the image of God. At the same time, the fundamental difference is unmistakable: In the texts from ancient

¹¹⁶ See further Rütterswörden, 1993, 81–130.

¹¹⁷ So Waschke, 2009, 246f.

¹¹⁸ From an inscription of pharaoh Thutmose III (1490–1436 BCE) from Serabit el-Khadim [translation JWR from German; Ockinga, 1984, 109].

¹¹⁹ From the Egyptian version of an inscription on a statue of Darius from Persian Susa (translation: “Persia holds Egypt” [Khurt, *Sources*, 3.11A:478]).

¹²⁰ From a letter by an exorcist to the (sick) Assyrian king Esarhaddon (681–669 BCE). Text and translation in Angerstorfer, 1997, 50 [translation JWR from German].

¹²¹ Maul 1998, 77 [translation JWR].

Egypt and the ancient Near East, talk of the “image of God” was generally reserved for the king, although among the many kings was also the queen Hatshepsut, who reigned as pharaoh (!) during the 18th Dynasty.¹²² One of the few exceptions to this is the Egyptian Teaching for Merykara,¹²³ in addition to a few Neo-Assyrian texts.¹²⁴ In contrast, the Priestly Writing contextualizes the expression “image of God” within the primeval era and extends it to all humanity. In this context, it is popular to speak of the democratization of a monarchic conception. Although it is true that the transformation of the expression “image of God” presupposes the end of the Davidic dynasty, such characterization is anachronistic and misses the intent of the text. There is no fundamental rejection of kingship as a form of rule demonstrable in the Priestly Writing (Gen 17:6; 35:11). Also, contemporary (Attic) democracy in no way involved all people in governance, women as well as men, but only the full male citizens. In contrast, the Priestly Writing explicitly excludes such differentiations in its statement about the image of God. Thus, with its statement about humanity being made as the image of God, the Priestly Writing does not aim at replacing the ideological foundations of monarchy by democratizing it. The transformation of the conception of kings as the earthly representatives of the deity into humanity being as the image of God entails the integration of the royal ideology into anthropology and can therefore be appropriately characterized as the “‘royalization’ of the image of humanity.”¹²⁵ It is of course indisputable that the idea of the royal humanity can serve as the biblical basis for a theological demand for political and civil rights, which are due to every person regardless of origin, gender, or social status.¹²⁶ Also incorporated into the idea of the image of God being in humanity is the insight that no person needs a “royal” intermediary in relation to the Creator. However, it first and foremost concerns the function of humanity as God’s representative on earth and the exercise of its dominion over the rest of nature (vv. 26b, 28), which is simultaneously made possible and legitimized by the image of God within humanity.¹²⁷ It is this dominion that stands at the center of the statements about the image of God rather than an unreflective anthropomorphism asserting the comparability in the substances of God and humanity or the characterization of certain human characteristics as “divine” – notwithstanding the idea of God and humanity sharing similarities in figure, which is also widely attested throughout the Hebrew Bible.¹²⁸

¹²² See Ockinga, 1984, 146f.

¹²³ Speaking of all people; translation: Lichtheim, *COS* I, 61–66.

¹²⁴ Speaking of a few priests; see Angerstorfer, 1997, 54.

¹²⁵ Janowski, 2004, 193 [translation JWR].

¹²⁶ For a description of the problem, see Barth, 2003; Frevel, 2009.

¹²⁷ See Groß, 2000, 21.

¹²⁸ See Wagner, 2010; Marksches, 2016.

(2.) Humanity being created in its substance as the image of God also results in its empowerment to rule over the earth and the animal kingdom (*dominium terrae et regnum animalium*; v. 26a). This statement is realized through a fivefold promise of blessing (v. 28). The prelude corresponds to the blessing of multiplication for the sea creatures (v. 22) but differs in how God directly addresses humanity; its somewhat awkward formulation serves to emphasize the address. According to the conception of the Priestly Writing, it marks an essential difference between human and animal. In the address, humanity appears as the opposite of God. Consequently, throughout the Priestly Writing, the course of events is accompanied by divine speeches to (distinguished) people (Noah in Gen 6–9; Abr[ah]am in Gen 17; Moses in Exod 6, 25). Contrary to the long-standing interpretive tradition, the “imperatives,” as in the blessing of the sea creatures and flying animals (v. 2), do not express a command to multiply (see above on v. 22) but an enablement and empowerment to be fruitful, given through a word of blessing. Therefore, already Ibn Ezra noted quite rightly that the rabbinic command to be fruitful cannot rely on Gen 1:28. The fulfillment of this promise is unfolded in the “Register of the *Toledot* of Adam” (Gen 5:1), which immediately followed the Creation account within the Priestly Writing. For Israel, the Priestly Writing sees the promise of multiplication as fulfilled with the emergence of the people in Egypt (Exod 1:7). Of course, the Priestly authors did not yet have in mind the overpopulation of the earth and the resultant threat to humanity’s earthly existence; they lived in a comparatively empty world in which an abundance of offspring primarily meant military security and economic strength.¹²⁹ This view also underlies the blessing in v. 28. In it, the promise of multiplication forms the demographic basis for the subsequent promise of dominion over the earth and the animal kingdom.

The *dominium terrae et regnum animalium* as the commission for humanity to rule over the earth is often separated from the promises of multiplication, but there is no linguistic support for this since the chain of the five “imperatives” is never interrupted. Rather, the two parts of the blessing are tightly connected by the explicit reference to the earth: The word “earth” concludes the blessing of multiplication, which is formulated typical of the Priestly Writing. It is taken up by the feminine referential object suffix (“it”) in the *dominium terrae* and is repeated at the end of the tripartite *regnum animalium*. The two “imperatives” for possession and dominion thus continue those for fruitfulness, multiplication, and propagation, describing an empowerment given in the blessing rather than a command.

¹²⁹ For Judah, see Lipschits, 2003, who sees a population of 108,000 for the late Iron Age and 30,000 for the Persian period, the time of the Priestly Writing (compared to the current population of about 2.7 million in the West Bank, including East Jerusalem).

The verbs כבש (“to take possession”) and רדה (“to rule”) denote activities performed with the foot that often serve as imagery for rulers’ acts of violence or power: to tread, to stride, to trample (underfoot), to rule/lord over.¹³⁰ Humanity is empowered *prima facie* to fulfill its functional purpose formulated in v. 26, traversing the earth, trampling down the animals, and thus ruling over them. Hence, there are two acts of dominion (for the *ius gentium*) that can be discerned: the subjugation of the earth as a habitat for humanity and the dominion over the animals that compete with it for this living space.¹³¹ Humanity can and should be superior to all of the animals, but the readings of “power politics” are relativized by the empowerment’s immediate context. Following in v. 29f. is an assignment of food that presupposes a universal peace between human and animal as well as among the animals themselves. If humans are explicitly permitted to kill animals for food after the Flood (Gen 9:1–7) with a view towards a regulated violence between creatures, the original command patently presupposes a complete ban on killing. With fruit and plant seeds being assigned to humans and the greens of the field being assigned to land animals and birds seeking food on the earth, there are even measures taken to ensure that the animals will not only not be food for humanity (and not among themselves) but also not even competitors for food.¹³² Additionally, the dominion also extends over the two living spaces of the created world that (at least ancient) humans had little or no ability to shape: the sea and the air (v. 28b). In vv. 26, 28, the physical connotations of the aforementioned verbs thus play less of a role than their designations of universal royal rule, with “dominion” carrying positive connotations in the Hebrew Bible as well as in the ancient Near East as a whole. According to the self-depiction of ancient Near Eastern royal ideology, a ruler’s most noble duty is safeguarding the lives of its subjects, ensuring internal and external peace, and thereby fending off chaos. Just as evident is the use of “dominion” throughout all of antiquity as an exercise of power backed by (just) force. Accordingly, humanity is charged with providing for the welfare of the realm entrusted to it. It is – from humanity’s perspective – not about an arbitrary rule but a powerful establishment of boundaries and humanity bringing nature into its service. As the recipient of the Creator God’s commission, humanity is called upon and empowered to uphold and enforce God’s claim to rule on earth.¹³³ In this sense, the

¹³⁰ On the controversial discussion over the semantic range of הדר and its violent or peaceful connotations, see the overview in Schellenberg, 2011, 49–59 and further Barr, 1972; Janowski, 1999; Rütterswörden, 1993, 81–130; Weippert, 1998; Stipp, 2001, 113–148; Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 10–17, 207–229.

¹³¹ See Rütterswörden, 1993, 103, 115; see further Schellenberg, 2011, 56f. and there also on the following.

¹³² See Stipp, 1999, 169.

¹³³ See von Rad, 59–60.

passage about the creation of humanity legitimizes its just and, on its religious basis, limited dominion over the world. How humanity's associated responsibility should be understood is shown by the Priestly Writing in the Flood narrative, which should always be read alongside and as a corrective of the bold assertions in Gen 1:26–30 about the image of God being in humanity and about humanity's empowerment to rule. God entrusts humanity with the task of ensuring the maintenance of the God-given order on earth. As shown by the corruption of the earth by violence from all flesh, i.e., human and animal, humanity fails in this regard (see pp. 293–98 on Gen 6:9–12). This reveals the Priestly authors' sense of reality, living like their addressees under conditions "after the Flood." Possible conceptions of a strongly idealized and stylized figure of a king as a program of rule run up against limitations in deriving how and what humanity is as a historical being. Humanity's ideal monarchic rule turns into a rule by force with limitations. If the violence from all flesh permanently disrupted the primeval order (Gen 6:12), then after the Flood, the Creator God who now knows better reacts accordingly: A renewed blessing of multiplication regulates the violence by allowing the killing of animals for food and prohibiting the killing of humans in a world that no longer corresponds to the original will of its creator (Gen 9:1–7). Using the example of the killing of animals – a tricky question in all pre-modern cultures – a distinction is thus made between antediluvian times and historical times. What was not foreseen for the primeval age and therefore implicitly forbidden is commanded, or rather, tolerated after the end of the Flood and thus at the beginning of history.

For over three decades, readings of the promise of dominion have fluctuated between indictment and apology. The point of departure for this is the influential thesis in which the "Subdue the earth!" has served as ideological fodder in significantly promoting the rampant overexploitation of natural resources in Western-style industrial societies.¹³⁴ Genesis 1 was certainly one of the beginnings of the "disenchantment of the world" (Max Weber) through its quasi-scientific tone and its sober treatment of the sea, earth, stars, and other entities to which many cultures have attributed a religious dignity. This was emphasized already by Julius Wellhausen: "The destruction of the mythical way of seeing the world by the autonomy of morality is closely connected to the rational view of nature, the beginnings of which we find in the Priestly Code; its prerequisite is that humanity places itself as people above and beyond nature and regards it simply as a matter of fact. It can perhaps be claimed that without this dualism of Judaism, the mechanical natural sciences would not exist."¹³⁵ In this respect, Gen 1 is also part of the basis in the history of thought for humanity's scientific approach to nature (including humanity itself). Even still, this relationship

¹³⁴ See White, 1967; Amery, 1972. The discussion is summarized in Baranzke/Lamberty-Zielinski, 1995.

¹³⁵ See Wellhausen, 1905, 315 [translation JWR].

to the world does not necessarily lead to self-destructive human treatment of nature, just as a “non-disenchanted” relationship to the world does not automatically protect against environmental destruction: Humans have permanently transformed their natural environment since the transition to sedentarism and have exploited natural resources with considerable consequences. Thus, Gilgamesh and Enkidu’s exploits in the Cedar Forest are a literary reflection of early forest depletion in the Levant.¹³⁶ Likewise, there does not seem to have been a demonstrable role of the *dominium terrae* in the establishment of the economic practices of the Industrial Age, including the environmental destruction of unprecedented proportions that it has caused – notwithstanding the fact that certain processes defy any verifiability, such as the assumed internalization of a relationship to the world that was shaped by the Bible and adapted for secular contexts. Whatever the actual influence of the *dominium terrae* on the workings of the Industrial Age, and prompted by the charges that have been raised against it, the biblical text has in return frequently been reread apologetically as a testimony for the demand of a responsible treatment of creation. This has occurred through the etymological connection of the Hebrew רדה “to rule” with the Akkadian *redû(m)*, which, in addition to “to rule” and “to trample down,” can also mean “to accompany,” “to bring along,” and “to guide,” and can be used to describe shepherding activities, which had positive connotations throughout antiquity. Thus, stripped of its brutal metaphor, the commission for humanity to rule over the earth would be aimed instead at protecting Creation, which has been entrusted to humanity.¹³⁷ Admittedly, this use of רדה would be unique within the Hebrew Bible, and the role of a shepherd (including over the birds and fish?) is not mentioned, at least explicitly. Better support for a positive reading of the commission would come from stronger consideration of the commission’s historical context and its connection with the tradition of ancient Near Eastern royal ideology, as has been argued here, building upon a series of relevant studies: The depiction of humanity as an image of the Creator God, sanctioned for royal dominion and intended in antediluvian times to be vegetarian, does not fit with a tyrannous relationship to Creation. According to Gen 1:26, 28, the “royal” humanity bears an active responsibility for the whole of Creation. Undoubtedly, this is not incorrect and would be attractive politically as well as ecologically and economically, but it quickly loses sight of the fact that humanity’s experience of nature up to the Romantic period differed from that of the present day. Animals were seen as competition for food and living space (see above on v. 24). Incidentally, this is still true of modern (post-)industrial societies, as shown in the lamentations of the fishing industry concerning their natural competitors, such as dolphins, whales, and cormorants, or the discussions around the reintroduction and protection of predators that were previously wiped out, such as wolves and lynxes. Furthermore, the biblical hope for an eschatological peace with the animals would first and foremost mean humanity no longer being threatened by wild animals (see Hos 2:20, where Yhwh’s promise of a covenant with the animals stands alongside

¹³⁶ Gilg. 5.300–323; see George, 2020; see further Tringham, 1971, 41. For the ancient Near Eastern environmental history, see the contributions in Frey/Uerpmann, 1981, as well as the notes in Keel/Schroer, 2002, 39–44.

¹³⁷ See Barr, 1972, esp. 22, as well as Lohfink, 1988; Zenger, 1987, 84–96. Often, this reading is made in connection with Gen 2:15. However, this is not about the larger project of “preserving Creation” but rather simply about gardening. See below on Gen 2:15.

the future breaking of the bow, sword, and war). In this respect, it cannot be completely dismissed that the aforementioned interpretations read current ideas into the text in order for it to aid, under completely different circumstances, in orienting through a present experienced as a time of crisis. It should also always be kept in mind that for the ruled, especially “pacified” peoples (or in the present text, the animal kingdom), kingship bears not just positive connotations but also tyrannical ones, as sufficiently demonstrated in the case of ancient Israel with, e.g., the *Pax Assyriaca* and the *Pax Romana*. In this respect, even the peaceful reading of the “dominion” metaphor is ambiguous. Nevertheless, despite all necessary qualifications, there remains the idea of humanity being given a special responsibility and being empowered to rule as the earthly representative of the Creator God. Since echoes of it can also be found in the Priestly prologue to the Flood narrative (see Gen 6:9–13), it should therefore be seen as a reading that is in accordance with the text. Moreover, it can be expressed in secular language without emptying itself of (political) meaning.

(3.) The account of the creation of humanity in v. 27 comprises three sentences, each formed with the exclusively creationary verb בָּרָא “to create,” again emphasizing the particular importance of this work of creation. The first two sentences are arranged chiastically: “[A] Then God created humanity [B] as his image // [B'] As the image of God [A'] he created them.” The chiasm emphasizes the designation of humanity to be the image of God as its core statement. Humanity’s status as being the image of God is given fundamental, “nearly definitional” (Karl Barth) specification by sentences two and three, which share a parallel construction: “[B''] As the image of God [A''] he created them. [B''] Male and female [A''] he created them.” In this way, the Priestly Writing emphasizes that it does not distinguish between male and female humans when speaking of the image of God, which is central to humanity’s creation. Both are created in God’s likeness and are thereby vested with the power to rule. At the same time, there is no differentiation according to species that would be typical of the animals, indicating that the biological differentiation between male and female among the humans is the only differentiation worth mentioning. Likewise absent are differentiations according to geographic variants such as skin color, body type, or even differences between people that are cultural in nature (see also Gal 3:28). It should also be noted that male (זָכָר) and female (אִשָּׁה) are biological terms that are accordingly applied to animals as well (see Gen 6:19; 7:16 [P]). Yet, the widespread translation as “man” and “woman” also bears implications of gender, but this should not hastily be adopted as the predominant reading and thereby “read into” the text. While there is certainly the widespread idea of an original couple from which all humanity descends (so Gen 5:1–3, 4ff.) standing behind the formulation “Male and female he created them,” the meaning of the statement is not restricted to a derivation from this tradition.

The Priestly authors were already drawing very practical consequences from the claim of humanity's being the image of God: For example, the prohibition against killing, which is based on humanity's likeness to God, does not differentiate between the killing of a man or a woman (see Gen 9:5f.). Convergences in this regard with the Hebrew Bible's depiction of God can be seen in the fact that God can be ascribed attributes traditionally seen as female and defies any fixation on attributes traditionally seen as male (e.g., Deut 4:16). Finally, the lasting importance of the text becomes apparent in how its theological level is often undermined throughout its (inner-biblical) reception, which had commensurate theological and social consequences. This is especially true for the exegetically untenable narrowing of the "image of God" to applying only to men (so 1 Cor 11:7: "The man should not trim his hair artistically, since he is the image and reflection of God [εἰκὼν καὶ δόξα θεοῦ]; but the woman is the reflection of the man").

The description of the sixth day of creation concludes with the approval formula and the day count (v. 31). Of course, the approval given on the evening of the last workday of the week of creation applies to the entire enterprise across the six days and the various orders set in place as part of it. The latter are also why the approval formula does not immediately follow the creation of humanity (and the animals) and instead appears, unlike with the sea creatures and winged animals, only after the blessing and the subsequent provision of food. The reference to the work as a whole explains the variation of the formula in its celebratory form and the addition of the intensifier *ᾗ* "very." The motif of praising the Creator is quite common. Thus, in *Enuma Eliš*, the gods praise Marduk with his fifty names (EnEl 6.99–7.148). Of course, this is not possible for the Priestly Writing, but it also does not take up the motif common in the Hebrew Bible of praising the Creator through his works (e.g., Ps 148). Rather, even the praising is fitted completely to the basic assertion of the acts of creation being by God alone and is brought back into the Creator's appreciative judgment of his work.¹³⁸ The Creator's enthusiasm ("very good") for his entire creation permanently binds him to his work. Admittedly, weighing all the more heavily are the Creator God's judgment concerning the corruption of the earth before the Flood, which followed shortly thereafter in the original text of the Priestly Writing (Gen 6:12), and the reformulated, postdiluvian commission for humanity to rule over the earth as a reign of terror over the animals (Gen 9:1–7). Speaking in terms of a theology of Creation, the present world is a world "after the Flood." It may be the best of all possible worlds, but it is no longer the world that enjoys the unreserved praise of its Creator.

¹³⁸ Westermann, 166.

2:1–3

- 1** *So were the heavens and the earth completed, and their entire host.*
- 2** *And on the seventh day, God completed his work that he had done, and on the seventh day, he rested from his work that he had done.*
- 3** *Then God blessed the seventh day and sanctified it, because during it he had rested from all his work that God had created by doing it.*

The seventh day of creation is characterized entirely by its blessing and sanctification of the seventh day, which concludes by addressing once again the category of “time.”

The literary-critical analysis of the passage is disputed. The point of departure for the discussion is the doubled notice about the completion of Creation in Gen 2:1 and 2:2a. The two notices can hardly both be original. Scholars often see a second hand in v. 2a, which takes up the verb “complete” from v. 1 and adds the dating “on the seventh day.” The consequence of this assumption is that the day count in the Creation account and, with it, the unmistakable orientation towards the Sabbath are considered secondary additions. This classic thesis, developed by Werner Carl Ludewig Ziegler (1794) and Johann Philipp Gabler (1795), was vigorously defended most recently by Christoph Levin.¹³⁹ Yet, the day count is the only continuous feature structuring Gen 1:1–2:3 besides the divine command at the beginning of each work. Were it to be written off as redactional, the Priestly Creation account would lose its cohesive overall structure. Additionally, concerning the distribution of eight works over six days (often cited in support of the secondary origin of the day count), the functional coherence shown above of how the works are divided speaks against a literary-critical solution. It can be further argued in support of 2:2a (and thus of vv. 2b, 3) being original that the Creator God’s rest after completing his work is a motif attested elsewhere.¹⁴⁰ However, the decisive factor for the literary-critical evaluation is the conspicuous features in v. 1:¹⁴¹ The supposed summary is constructed passively and makes no mention of God. In contrast, all of the other sections, including the frame of the account, begin with a sentence explicitly setting God as the subject. It is therefore difficult to conceive of Gen 2:1 as an original summary or brief recapitulation of the works of creation before the establishment of Sabbath, especially when compared to the opening of the account. In any case, the passive formulation is not explainable by looking to the creationary power of the earth or the intrinsic might of the waters.¹⁴² Such linguistic attentiveness would turn upside down the central statement of God being the universal, transcendent, and sovereign Creator, as seen in 1:1 and the inclusion of the idea of the earth giving birth (see above on Gen 1:11f.). Likewise, the idea that both verses describe different aspects of the completion – Gen 2:1 is about the works of creation while Gen 2:2 is about the Creator – and are therefore

¹³⁹ Levin, 1994.

¹⁴⁰ See EnEl 6.51–54 in addition to “From the ‘Memphite Theology’” (*COS* 1.15:23, ll. 58–61); see further Schmidt, 1973, 158f.

¹⁴¹ See Zenger, 1987, 69–71; Witte, 1998, 120f.

¹⁴² So Bühner, 2014, 114.

of the same origin¹⁴³ does not explain the conspicuousness of Gen 2:1. There are also difficulties regarding its content: Were it intended as a brief summary, “heavens and earth” would need to be understood as a merism like in Gen 1:1, which causes problems in accounting for the additional element “and their entire host” compared to 1:1. The typical explanation is that “host” (צְבָא) signifies either the totality of living beings filling the air, seas, and earth or all of the works mentioned up to that point. However, the other uses of the word speak against this. Insofar as the expression is meant metaphorically, even the singular form refers mostly to the “celestial host” (so Isa 40:26 [likewise with a suffix without a clear referent]; Isa 45:12) or, more generally, to God’s heavenly surroundings (see 1 Kgs 22:19; Neh 9:6). Therefore, the verse is not aimed at providing an overview of all of Creation but rather recounts what has been missed. Presumably, it seeks to flesh out the idea of the heavenly court that is recognizable in Gen 1:26. If it may seem that the beings surrounding God were already there before Creation according to Gen 1:26 (and also Job 38:7), then Gen 2:1 ensures in a concise manner that they too are creations by God, without needing to extensively intervene within the Creation account in order to clarify this. The verse fits in line with the book of Jubilees, which was written ca. the middle of the second century BCE and knows to report of the creation of the heavenly beings on the first day of creation (see Jub. 2:2f.).

Since no actual work happens on the seventh day, there is no divine command. Instead, God declares his work to be finished (v. 2a; see also Exod 40:33).¹⁴⁴ Immediately following the approval formula, which itself already indicates the “very good” completion of all of the works (Gen 1:31), there is thus a clear caesura between the first six days and the seventh day of the week of creation (see also Exod 20:11). Therefore, it is at the very least misleading when the divine rest on the seventh day is called the most important and concluding work of creation, in anticipation of the Sabbath.

The history of the text attests to the fact that it is prone to misunderstandings. There are important textual witnesses that read “on the sixth day” in v. 2a, thus ensuring that the seventh day is kept free from any work (see the above Text-critical and Philological Note on v. 22). One reason for this may have been that the verb כלה pi. “to complete” does not always have a purely declarative meaning and can very well also mean “to finish a task” (so Exod 5:13). In any case, the MT must be understood such that v. 2b, which is nearly identical – the sub-verses differ only in their verbs – equates the declaration of the completion of Creation (לה כלה pi.; v. 2a) with God’s rest (שבת; v. 2b) on the seventh day. God’s rest is unfolded in the following verse as God’s blessing and sanctification of the seventh day (v. 3a), as the explanation recalling the divine rest makes clear (v. 3b). This concluding explanation modifies the relative clause “that he had done” (עשה) that refers to “his work (v. 2a, b)” and once again takes up the verb used exclusively

¹⁴³ Grund, 2011, 225f.

¹⁴⁴ On the declarative character of the verb, see Cassuto, 1:61f.; Ruppert, 98.

for creation, בָּרָא (“to create”), from Gen 1:1. This reference back to the first verse of the Creation account is unmistakable. Furthermore, God’s attainment of rest, together with the creationary speech of the preceding works, forms the antithesis to God’s “not yet” in the description of the primordial world. Furthermore, the conclusion of the Priestly Creation account also points ahead to the goal of the Priestly Writing as a whole:¹⁴⁵ The beginning of the Priestly Sinai pericope, oriented around the foundation of the Second Temple, reciprocally incorporates the six/seven-day schema of the week of creation that is established through the separation of the seventh day. The God of Creation, who speaks for six days and is silent on the seventh day (Gen 1:1–31; 2:1–3) is shown to be the God of the revelation at Sinai, who speaks on the seventh day after six days of silence (Exod 24:15b–25:1). Likewise, Gen 1:31; 2:2f. provides the structure for the depiction of the completion of the tent of meeting/temple in Exod 39f., in which the establishment of the sanctuary, like the creation of the world, is concluded with a blessing (see Gen 1:31 and Exod 39:43; Gen 2:2a and Exod 40:33b: כָּלָה “to complete”; Gen 2:3 and Exod 39:43b: בָּרַךְ “to bless”; Gen 2:3aβ and Exod 40:9b: קִדֵּשׁ “to consecrate/sanctify”).¹⁴⁶ In this way, Creation and the foundation of the temple are placed in a corresponding relationship, just as in the great number of ancient Near Eastern creation texts: At Sinai, “God’s orientation established at Creation towards the world/humanity reached its goal with *community of the Creator with Israel*, while, in terms of Creation theology, the secret was revealed to Israel of the ‘seventh day,’ on which Yhwh called Moses into the cloud in order to commission him to build the sanctuary.”¹⁴⁷

The “seven scheme,” with a special emphasis on the seventh day, is widely attested across the ancient Near East but is otherwise never found in the context of a cosmogony.¹⁴⁸ It should already be recognizable from this that God’s rest is aimed at the special, long-term significance of the seventh day. The seventh day is to be sanctified, i.e., to be separated from the six “work-days” of creation. The Priestly reworking of the Decalogue already recognized the anchoring of the postexilic weekly Sabbath (Exod 20:11) in this theology of Creation.¹⁴⁹ The absence of the term “Sabbath” and the universalizing character of the Creation account, which is at odds with the introduction of the institution of “Israel” at this point, are variously cited against connecting the Creator God’s rest on the seventh day with the weekly Sabbath.

¹⁴⁵ Zenger, 1987, 170–175; Blum, 1990, 287–332; Janowski, 1990, 46–67; Gertz, 2012, 293–296.

¹⁴⁶ See Jacob, 67; Zenger, 1987, 171.

¹⁴⁷ Janowski, 1990, 66f. [translation JWR; emphasis original].

¹⁴⁸ See Grund, 2011, 194f. (attestations on pp. 32–34).

¹⁴⁹ For the history of the Sabbath, see Grund, 2011.

Yet, the allusions to the Sabbath are too clear for this objection to be convincing: Verses 2–3 explicitly connect the elsewhere-attested motif of the Creator God resting with the seven-day week and link God’s rest to the seventh day. Furthermore, rather than the typical verb *נָח* “to rest” (e.g., Exod 20:11), the account explicitly uses the rather unusual verb *שָׁבַת*, which evokes the word “Sabbath” (*שַׁבָּת*). This consonance exists whether or (as seems to be the case) not the two words are etymologically related. Finally, the seventh day is blessed, ensuring its perpetual significance. This in turn suggests the establishment of an institution. Conversely, the lack of any mention of the Sabbath can be explained precisely through the universalizing orientation of the Creation account. This would forbid any explicit reference to such institutions belonging to Israel alone. Even though the Sabbath is grounded in the order of the world, it is still a privilege of Israel. Accordingly, its first canonical mention is in the context of the wilderness wanderings, in the miracle of the manna in Exod 16. The narrative of Exod 16 is structured according to a scheme of six and seven days, and it establishes a frame around the Priestly Sinai texts in combination with Lev 9,¹⁵⁰ which is why the Sabbath as an institution of Israel cannot be separated from God’s revelation at Sinai. Regardless of whether Exod 16 is part of the core of the Priestly Writing¹⁵¹ or is a later elaboration,¹⁵² the Sabbath, like the construction of the Temple, is already established within the temporal structure of the order of Creation. However, the historical realization of the establishment of the temple and the ordering of Sabbath occurs only at Sinai. This look towards Sinai concludes the Priestly Creation account, which was originally followed by the “Register of the Generations of Adam” in Gen 5:1ff.

¹⁵⁰ See Grund, 2011, 267f.

¹⁵¹ Ruprecht, 1974: Köckert, 2004, 96f.; Hartenstein, 2003/2004, 119f.; Grund, 2011, 240–247.

¹⁵² See esp. Levin, 1993, 352–355; Pola, 1995, 134–143.

THE GARDEN NARRATIVE

- 2:4** This is the history of the origins of the heavens and the earth when they were created.
When Yhwh-God made earth and heavens
- 5** *(all the bushes of the field were not yet on the earth, and all the plants of the field had not yet sprouted, for Yhwh-God had not made it rain on the earth and there was no Human to till the soil,*
- 6** *although a stream of water would spring up from the earth and water the entire face of the ground),*
- 7** *then Yhwh-God formed the Human from dust of the soil, and he breathed the breath of life into his nose, and the Human became a living being.*
- 8** *And Yhwh-God planted a garden in Eden in the days of old, far in the east, and there he placed the Human whom he had formed.*
- 9** *And Yhwh-God made sprout from the soil every tree, tempting to behold and good to eat, and the Tree of Life in the midst of the garden, and the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad.*
- 10** And a stream goes out from Eden in order to water the garden, and from there it divides and becomes four new rivers.
- 11** The name of the one is “Pishon.” This is the one flowing around the entire land of Havilah, where the gold is.
- 12** And the gold of this land, it is good. There is bdellium and shoham-stone there.
- 13** And the name of the second river is “Gihon.” This is the one flowing around the entire land of Cush.
- 14** And the name of the third river is “Hiddekel” [*Tigris*]. This is the one that runs to the east of Assur. And the fourth river, that is the Perat [*Euphrates*].
- 15** Then Yhwh-God took the Human and put him in the Garden of Eden, for him to till and to guard.
- 16** *And Yhwh-God commanded the Human as follows: “You may absolutely eat from all the trees of the garden,*
- 17** *but from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad – from it you may not eat, for as soon as you eat from it, you must inevitably die.”*
- 18** *Then Yhwh-God said, “It is not good that the Human is alone; I shall make for him a help that corresponds to him.”*

- 19 *Then Yhwh-God formed from the soil every animal of the field and all the birds of the heavens and brought [them] to the Human in order to see what he would name each, and what the Human named each as a living being, so would it be called.*
- 20 *And the Human gave names to all the livestock and the birds of the heavens and all the animals of the field, but for the Human no help was found that would have corresponded to him.*
- 21 *Then Yhwh-God made a deep sleep fall over the Human, so that he fell asleep. Then he took one of his ribs and closed its place with flesh.*
- 22 *And Yhwh-God built the rib that he had taken from the Human into a Woman. And he brought her to the Human.*
- 23 *Then, the Human said, "This is finally bone of my bone and flesh of my flesh; she shall be called 'Woman,' for she was taken from Man."*
- 24 *Therefore a man will leave his father and his mother, and he will cling to his woman, and they will become one flesh.*
- 25 *And they both were naked, the Human and his Woman, and they were not ashamed of each other.*
- 3:1 *But the serpent was cleverer than all of the animals of the field that Yhwh-God had made, and it said to the Woman, "Should God really have said that you may not eat of any of the trees of the garden?"*
- 2 *Then the Woman said to the snake, "We may eat from the fruit of the trees of the garden;*
- 3 *only of the fruit of the tree standing in the middle of the garden did God say, 'You may not eat from this, nor touch it, lest you die!'"*
- 4 *Then the snake said to the Woman, "You will certainly not die!*
- 5 *Rather, God knows full well that as soon as you eat from it, your eyes will open and you will be like God, knowing of good and bad."*
- 6 *Then the Woman saw that the tree was good as food, and it was a pleasure to the eyes, and that the tree was tempting for attaining understanding; then, she took from its fruit and ate, and she also gave to her Man next to her, and he ate.*
- 7 *Then the eyes of the two were opened, and they realized that they were naked. Then they wove fig-tree leaves together and made skirts for themselves.*
- 8 *When they heard the sound of Yhwh-God as he strolled through the garden during the evening breeze, the Human and his Woman hid from Yhwh-God among the trees of the garden.*
- 9 *Then Yhwh-God called to the Human and said to him, "Where are you?"*
- 10 *Then he said, "I heard a sound from you in the garden, and I became afraid because I am naked, and I hid."*

- 11 *Then he said, “Who let you know that you are naked? Have you eaten something from the tree from which I forbade you to eat?”*
- 12 *Then the Human said, “The Woman whom you had to join me, she gave to me from the tree, then I ate.”*
- 13 *Then Yhwh-God said to the Woman, “What have you done?” Then the Woman said, “The snake tempted me, then I ate.”*
- 14 *Then Yhwh-God said to the snake, “Because you have done this, cursed are you away from all the livestock and from all the animals of the field; you shall crawl on your stomach, and you will eat dust all the days of your life.*
- 15 *And I will cause enmity between you and the Woman and between your offspring and her offspring; she will kick at your head, and you will snap at her heel.”*
- 16 *To the Woman, he said, “I will make your hardship boundless, especially during your pregnancy; you shall bear children in pain, and your desire shall be after your Man, but he shall rule over you!”*
- 17 *And to the Human, he said, “Because you listened to the voice of your Woman and ate from the tree that I commanded of you, ‘You shall not eat from it’ – cursed is the soil on your account; under hardship shall you eat from it all the days of your life.*
- 18 *And it will sprout thorn bushes and brush for you, and you shall eat the plants of the field.*
- 19 *You shall eat bread in the sweat of your face, until you return to the soil, for from it you were taken, for you are dust and you shall return to dust.”*
- 20 *Then the Human named his Woman “Ḥavvā” [Eve], for she was the mother of all living.*
- 21 *Then Yhwh-God made clothing for the Human and his Woman from hide, and he clothed them.*
- 22 *And Yhwh-God said, “See! The Human has become like one of us, recognizing good and bad; but now, lest he reach out his hand and also take from the Tree of Life and eat and live forever –”*
- 23 *And Yhwh-God sent him out of the garden of Eden, so that he would till the soil from which he was taken.*
- 24 *And he banished the Human, and he made the cherubs and the flame of the darting sword dwell to the east of the Garden of Eden in order to guard the way to the Tree of Life.*

Analysis: The Garden narrative largely comes from the Scholarly Narrator (with smaller additions in Gen 2:5b_a, 19b*). Redaction: Gen 2:4a; expansion of the divine name “Yhwh” to “Yhwh-God” (see Gen 2:4b, *passim*) as well as harmonizations with Gen 1:1–2:3 in 2:20* [“all the livestock and”]; 3:14* [“from all the livestock and”]. The larger context of the Redaction also probably includes the “Paradise Geography” and the inclusion of the Tree of Life motif: Gen 2:7a_a* [“dust”], 9(b*?), 10–15; 3:19b, 22, 23a* [“Eden”], 24.

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TEXT-CRITICAL AND PHILOLOGICAL NOTES

2:4a תולדות אלה (This is the history of the origins): The LXX reads Αὔτη ἡ βίβλος γενέσεως ("This is the book of the genesis"), thus giving the first book of the Bible the name *Genesis*. The Greek noun γένεσις denotes the world's or humanity's coming into being, while the תולדות of its Hebrew

original means “family history,” “family tree,” “genealogy,” or also “produce.” The additional ἡ βίβλος comes from Gen 5:1 (סֵפֶר תּוֹלְדוֹת) and attests to the LXX understanding v. 4a as a heading rather than a closing, in agreement with the current state of scholarship (see Scholarly Exposition II). The translation “history of the origins” for תּוֹלְדוֹת was chosen since the expression is being applied to all of Creation.

2:4b בְּיוֹם (When): For this temporal translation, see Scholarly Exposition II.

יְהוָה אֱלֹהִים (Yhwh-God): Elohim/God is grammatically best understood as being in apposition to “Yhwh,” with the generic term being used as a proper name, like in Gen 1:1–2:3, and therefore lacking an article: “Yhwh-Elohim,” or “Yhwh-God.”

2:7 עָפָר מִן־הָאֲדָמָה (from dust of the soil): On the translation of עָפָר מִן־הָאֲדָמָה, see GKC §117hh.

2:8 מִקְדָּם (in the days of old, far in the east): On this translation of מִקְדָּם, see Scholarly Exposition II.

2:9 רָע (bad): On this translation of רָע (“evil/bad” or “the evil/the bad”), see Scholarly Exposition II.

The editorial classification of v. 9bβ is uncertain (cf. Scholarly Exposition II).

2:15 לְעֹבְדָהּ וּלְשָׂמְרָהּ (for him to till and to guard): The feminine suffixes of the verbs “to work/till” and “to guard” refer to the masc. גֶּן (“garden”), which, in connection to Eden, is understood as the feminine toponym “Garden of Eden.” See HS §16g; B. Jacobs-Hornig, Art. “gan,” TWAT II (1977) 35–41, 39.

2:19 מַה־יִּקְרָא־לוֹ (what he would name each): The singular suffix in לוֹ refers to the whole series and has a distributive function. See GKC §124s.

נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה (as a living being): The LXX understands חַיָּה נֶפֶשׁ as being in apposition to לוֹ: “exactly what the Human named it [לוֹ], namely, [every] living creature [חַיָּה נֶפֶשׁ], that was its name” (καὶ πᾶν, ὃ ἐὰν ἐκάλεσεν αὐτὸ Ἀδὰμ ψυχὴν ζῶσαν, τοῦτο ὄνομα αὐτοῦ). The understanding chosen here of חַיָּה נֶפֶשׁ as an adverbial accusative to הִאָּדָם is made clear from the word order. It is possible that this was a marginal gloss that made its way into the text. For discussion, see Schellenberg, 2011, 298–303; Bühner, 2014, 222–224.

2:20 לְאָדָם (but for the Human): MT: “for Adam.” Throughout the Garden narrative, the Heb. אָדָם, with the exception of Gen 2:20b; 3:17, 21 (each time with the prep. לְ), is determined with a definite article and is therefore clearly understood as the generic term “human” and not the proper name “Adam.” In Gen 2:20; 3:17, 21, the reading as a personal name is only indicated through the Masoretic vocalization and is only possible at these three places in the Garden narrative without intervening in the consonantal

text. The Masoretic reading corresponds to a tendency observable in the LXX and the Targums of individualizing the generic term “human” (אָדָם, ἄνθρωπος, אָנוּשׁ) by reading it as a proper name “Adam” (see Gen 5:1–5 [P]). This comes from taking a larger, overall view of Gen 1–3. According to this “overall view,” Gen 1:26f. reports the creation of the human species, while the Garden narrative reports of the fate of Adam and Eve as the first human couple. The LXX chooses God’s first speech to humanity (Gen 2:16) as the transition from the species to the individual. However, this interpretive tendency emerged only in later reception of the passage. Instead, the consonantal texts in Gen 2:20; 3:17, 21 should also be read as the generic term, in agreement with the rest of the attestations of אָדָם in the Garden narrative.

2:23 The Hebrew wordplay “woman (אִשָּׁה) – man (אִישׁ)” functions similarly to the folk etymology of English “woman” as coming from “wife of man” (although the Old English *wifmann* actually meant “female [*wif*] person [*mann*]”).

2:25 וְלֹא יִתְבַּשְׁשׁוּ (they were not ashamed of each other): The hithpoel of בִּזְיוֹן (“to be ashamed”) is simultaneously factitive and reciprocal. See Sasson, 1985, 420. Cf. Grund, 2008, 118.

3:1 אָף (Should): Instead of אַף, it should be read as הָאָף (see 4QGen^k [DJD XII, 78]). Even when maintaining the MT as the *lectio difficilior*, it is still a rhetorical question.

not ... of any: See GKC §152b.

3:6 לְהַשְׁכִּיל (for attaining understanding): See Müller, 1990, 167 fn. 2.

3:16 אֶל-הָאִשָּׁה (To the Woman): The SP, Tg. Neof., LXX, Pesh, and Vulg connect v. 16 (see v. 17) with a copula to the preceding declaration of punishment. Despite the strong attestation, the MT should be maintained as the *lectio difficilior*.

הָרְבָה אֲרָבָה (boundless): Emphasizing the “vast” with the inf. abs. See GKC §113n.

וְהָיָה (primarily): See GKC §154a fn. 1b.

3:17 לְאָדָם (to the Human): MT: “to Adam”; see the Note on 2:20.

3:21 לְאָדָם (for the Human): MT: “for Adam”; see the Note on 2:20.

ESSENTIALS AND PERSPECTIVES

The Garden narrative of the Scholarly Narrator, who is the second of the main voices in the Primeval History (see the Introduction), is one of the most well-known and powerful texts in world literature.¹ Adam and Eve began

¹ For an overview, see Wallace et al., 2009; Böttrich et al., 2011.

from early on being depicted in paintings, with the oldest known attestation being in the Catacombs of San Gennaro in Naples (third century CE) and later portrayals coming from, among countless others, Hugo van der Goes (1470), Albrecht Dürer (1504), Lucas Cranach the Elder (1526), Tintoretto (1550), and Peter Paul Rubens (1628). Depiction of the Garden itself also attained significance (e.g., Hieronymus Bosch, 1503/04; Jan Brueghel the Elder 1610; Jacopo Bassano ca. 1570). One of the earliest literary adaptations and reinterpretations is the *Life of Adam and Eve* (“*Vita Adae et Evae*”), which probably dates to the first century CE. It tells of the Fall, the expulsion from the Garden, and the resultant consequences such as sickness, the threat of wild animals, loss of original glory, and death. However, it also knows to report of God’s forgiveness of Adam after his death (JSHRZ 2:737–870). In his letter to the Romans, Paul presents an Adam-Christ typology that contrasts Adam as the originator of sin and death with Christ as the new Adam, who is to make humanity righteous and reconcile it to God (Rom 5). The early church fathers understood Gen 3:15 as prophecy of Christ’s victory over Satan (the “protoevangelium”). Scenes of the Garden and the Fall were an integral part of medieval liturgical dramas. In the peasant revolts of the Middle Ages and the early modern period, the social aspect of the narrative became increasingly important. Thus, during the Peasants’ Revolt of 1381, the preacher John Ball produced the couplet “When Adam dalf and Eve span / who was thanne a gentilman?”, which is also attested in Dutch and German variants. Conversely, in John Milton’s *Paradise Lost*, it is the problem of free will that comes to the fore.

Even more than in other biblical texts, the perception of the Garden narrative consists in an interweaving of the biblical texts and the history of its reception. One example of this is the apple that Eve gives to her man. This motif has been repeatedly taken up in paintings and literature, and even in advertising – the location of the famous apple as a fixture in the Garden narrative is taken for granted even though it is not even mentioned in Gen 3 itself. Similar could be said for the traditional theological readings, which have seen in the Garden narrative a (pre-scientific) explanation of how the human species came into being, a description of the primordial state of humanity before the Fall widely discussed in doctrinal tradition, or an answer to the question of the origins of evil. More than almost any other biblical text, such traditional readings – which have been mediated by interpretations within the church and have shaped the reception outside of the church even to the present day – are best set aside in explanations of the narrative as much as possible.

An important approach to understanding this magnificent text is provided by the Garden narrative’s association with the myth of the primordial beginnings, which is attested all across the literature of the ancient Near East. These

myths are “traditional narratives of an origin event that mediates the present experience of reality.”² Essential for understanding such myths of the primordial beginnings is the insight that they are to be read “backwards” from their ending point, that is, from their own contemporary experience of reality: “By telling how everything emerged, they proclaim how everything is.”³ It is by no means focused on a naïve historiography in this matter but a narrative elaboration of the basic conviction widespread across the entire ancient Near East that the essence of everything can be traced back to the Beginning. Accordingly, the Garden narrative is interested in the basic conditions of human life and their primordial foundations. The main theme of the narrative is the basic insight of religious construal of the self and is, simply stated: Humanity is human and not God. This theme is unfolded in a way that depicts the ever-ambiguous human experience. Thus, the narrative of the beginnings seeks to answer the existential questions and needs of (not only) its present: Why is human nature defined by both deficiencies and capabilities? Why must we work, suffer, and die? Why are we capable of both good and bad? Why do we experience ourselves as both independent and dependent agents? As with many other myths of the primordial beginnings, the Garden narrative draws on the narrative pattern describing the emergence of the present world as a transformation of a “Before” in order to answer these questions.⁴ It thus differentiates between an unreal mythical past without plants, water, and people, a hardly less-mythical intermediate period in the Garden, and the “beyond Eden” of the present time, in which humanity, now left to its own devices, has been tilling the field since time immemorial. With this, the unreal, mythical state of the world in the Beginning is abolished and the time of humanity’s blissful immaturity in the Garden comes to an end. Like the man and woman driven out of Paradise, the readers now arrive into reality. However, this occurs under the omen that the soil is cursed, meaning that work can be successful only under toil, if at all. Childbirth furthermore means hardship and danger for the woman. The transformation of the mythical “Before” into the experienced “Now” unmistakably results in an impairment of human existence, as can be seen in the “paradisiacal” conditions of the Garden, where work is not yet defined by toil and communal life is not yet defined by superiority and inferiority. The fact that the present is described as an impaired existence compared to the lost Paradise is, in the chronological structure of the myth, the appropriate form for deriving the basic mood of a lived reality that, from its beginnings, is seen as ambiguous.

² Hartenstein, 2005, 280 [translation JWR], following Burkert, 1982, 63; Stolz, 1988, 82ff. See further *ibid.*, 1993.

³ Perlitt, 1980, 10 [translation JWR].

⁴ See Stolz, 2004.

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION I: INTRODUCTION TO THE EXEGESIS

The Creation Account and the Garden Narrative: The Scholarly Narrator's Garden narrative signals the voice of another author following the Priestly Writing's Creation account. In addition to the completely different narrative styles, this shows itself in a number of factual inconsistencies between Gen 1:1–2:3 and Gen 2:4–3:24. Both texts have God's creationary action as a major theme but contradict each other in their overall setting and sequence. Genesis 1:1–2:3 describes the primordial and preliminary state of the world with the image of a flooded plain in which the earth disk emerges, sprouts vegetation, and becomes populated, first by animals and then by humanity. Thus, God creates humanity at the end of the works of creation, and with both male and female specimens of one species at the outset, just like the animals. In contrast, according to Gen 2:4–3:24, the world in its primordial and preliminary state resembles a dry steppe. Only after the soil is watered does Yhwh-God form a human being out of the topsoil. For this one person, a garden is then created and the animal world is brought into being. Following clearly later is the creation of the woman. Furthermore, contrary to the initial impression given while reading, the Hebrew בַּיּוֹם (lit. "On the day") in the opening of Gen 2:4b cannot be identified with the sixth day of the Priestly Creation account, which is the day that humanity is created (Gen 1:26ff.; see also Gen 5:1). This בַּיּוֹם as a chronological notice refers to the merism "earth and heavens" (cf. Gen 1:1) encompassing the entirety of Creation. Like elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible (Exod 6:28; Num 3:1; Isa 11:16; Ezek 28:13) and comparable to the beginnings of Mesopotamian narratives (EnEl 1.1), the בַּיּוֹם only marks here a temporal beginning rather than a specific point in time ("When Yhwh-God..."⁵). In addition to the factual differences, there are terminological deviations, such as their designations for God. The Priestly Writing uses the generic term אֱלֹהִים ("God" or "divine being"). In the Garden narrative, this is combined with the personal name "Yhwh" into "Yhwh-God." The tensions within the present text resulting from the two texts' linguistic and factual peculiarities concern especially the less-important aspects and do not altogether seem to have come from an editor, whether out of carelessness or from any specific intent. This can hardly be interpreted in any way other than having two texts in Gen 1–3 that were previously handed down independently and were connected with each other only redactionally. Therefore, the following must be maintained against both newer and older denials of a two-source model:⁶ Genesis 1:1–2:3 is not a prepended Priestly reworking of the Garden

⁵ See Westermann, 181.

⁶ For this discussion, see Gertz, 2004, and the opponents listed therein.

narrative. Nor is Gen 2:4–3:24 a post-Priestly reflection that corrects the optimistic view of the Priestly Creation account (“And God saw everything that he had made, and, behold, it was very good.”; Gen 1:31) from a Late Wisdom perspective explaining why the “good” Creation could have been so corrupted that God felt compelled to subject it to the Great Flood and bring it face-to-face with the abyss of the primordial chaos.

The connection of the Priestly Creation account with the Scholarly Narrator’s Garden narrative occurred through the redactional *toledot* formula in Gen 2:4a, taking up the most important structural feature of the Priestly Writing and transferring it into the present text. Other formulations reminiscent of the Priestly Creation account likely come from the same Redaction or later harmonizing efforts. These include the expansion of the Tetragrammaton to “Yhwh-God” and (presumably) the two-part addition to include “all the livestock and” (לְכָל/מִכָּל הַבְּהֵמָה וּ) in Gen 2:20; 3:14. In Gen 2:20, the mention of the livestock, which go unmentioned in v. 19, is quite reasonable (see Scholarly Exposition II below), but this is not the case in Gen 3:14. In Gen 3:1, the snake is listed among the animals of the field, while the curse in Gen 3:14 banishes it from this fellowship. The improper, and stylistically difficult, mention of livestock at this point therefore almost certainly traces back to a redactional hand prompted by Gen 1. The mention of the livestock in Gen 2:20 should probably also be attributed to this editor even though it fits better into its literary context. Remaining uncertain is whether this is also true for the “living being” (נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה) of Gen 2:7b, which is an important expression in the Priestly Primeval History. The expression נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה seems to have been added later into Gen 2:19, but the intention behind this expansion is unclear, and so it is difficult to identify its exact place within the redaction history of the text.

Structure: Even when setting aside Gen 2:4a and the related traces of later editing, the unity of the text of the Garden narrative as well as its constituent traditions has been repeatedly contested. However, easily forgotten among the various different suggestions for how to stratify Gen 2:4b–3:24* are its literary quality and artful arrangement in its final form. Notwithstanding the wealth of richly evocative motifs and multifaceted developing of its subject matter, the disposition of the Garden narrative is as clear as could be desired: It is oriented around the final and, thus, most emphasized element of the emergent world in Gen 2:5: There was not yet a man (אָדָם; v. 5bβ) to till the soil (אָדָם; v. 5bγ). Following the principles of (not only) ancient Hebrew narration, it would be expected that, at the end, exactly this mythical state is abolished, with the narrative giving the explanation for the origins of humanity (אָדָם) from the soil (אָדָם) and its reliance on the soil. Indeed, Gen 2:3 states that humanity, now created from the soil, goes forth

to till it. Moreover, the final part of the description of the primordial world in Gen 2:5 also sets the internal structure of the Garden narrative, insofar as it deals first with the creation of humanity (v. 5bβ: 2:7–25) and then with the origins of its destiny to work the field (v. 5bγ: 3:1–24).

The explanations about the creation of humanity and its (agrarian) environment in the first part of the Garden narrative begin with the formation of the human from the soil (Gen 2:7) and lead, after various detours, to the creation of the woman (Gen 2:21f.). Only with her is humanity complete (Gen 2:18). Accordingly, the first part of the Garden narrative ends with the male human (אָדָם) rejoicing over the successful completion of the creation of humanity (Gen 2:23) and an etiological digression about the relationship between man and woman (Gen 2:24f.). The beginning of the second part of the Garden narrative is marked by the emphasized and detailed introduction of the snake (Gen 3:1). Its appearance opens a story arc stretching all the way to the cursing of the ground on humanity's account. Standing at the end is the announcement of humanity's return to the soil after a hard and laborious life (Gen 3:19) and his immediate dismissal from the Garden to work the field (Gen 3:23). This reversed repetition of the essential determination and material origin of humanity from Gen 2:5, 7 ("so that he would till the soil from which he was taken"; Gen 3:23) closes the second part of the Garden narrative; Gen 2:15 mentions that humanity is to till and guard the Garden (!), but v. 5 is not aimed at this notice, since here, there is no mention of the correspondence between humanity and the soil.⁷

The two parts of the Garden narrative are related to each other by a whole network of cross-references, with the motifs of humanity's nakedness and the trees in the Garden standing out in particular: If the first part of the Garden narrative concludes with Adam and Eve's unburdened and unconcerned nakedness (Gen 2:25), this motif is turned on its head in the second part, when the first human couple become aware of their nakedness after eating the forbidden fruit, feel ashamed, and from then on need clothing (Gen 3:7; 21). Moreover, the sound and consonantal order of the word "naked" (pl. עֲרוּמִים from עָרוֹם) in Gen 2:25 foreshadows the immediately following characterization of the snake as "clever" (עָרוֹם), which in turn comes into play in the consequential dialogue between the snake and the woman. Since humanity's cognitive ability, provoked by the snake's cleverness, is first expressed in the knowledge of its own nakedness, these events are like an echo, so to speak, of the succinct characterization of the snake as "clever" (עָרוֹם) that comes beforehand. Quite similarly, the motif of the trees in the Garden marks the climaxes and turning points of the narrative. The initial establishment of a garden of trees (Gen 2:8f.) is followed first by the general allowance for

⁷ Spieckermann, 2001, 52.

consuming the fruits of the trees and the prohibition against eating from the Tree of Knowledge (Gen 2:16f.). Even just the wording of the prohibition suggests that there will be a crucial turning point marked by its transgression. Accordingly, in the second part of the Garden narrative, both the transgression of the prohibition and the consequences thereof are reported in detail (Gen 3:1–24).

Formation I – “Creation and Fall”: The prohibition against eating from the Tree of Knowledge is only reported in order to tell of its transgression.⁸ This transgression necessarily presupposes the formulation of the prohibition itself. In this respect, making a separation in the formation of the two parts of the Garden narrative – the creation of humanity and its world in Gen 2 vs. the transgression of the divine prohibition and humanity’s banishment from the Garden in Gen 3 – can come only at the price of completely redefining their messages. Prominent in this regard has been the distinction in the editorial and/or transmissional history of Gen 2–4 between an older narrative about the creation of humanity and a later theological reworking focused on “sin.”⁹ In addition to the narrative of the “Fall” in Gen 3, all earlier references to Gen 3 in Gen 2 are considered part of this reworking. This supposition is grounded above all else in the change of the basic tone of the narrative. On the one hand, the creation of humanity as well as the beginning of its cultural achievements are described positively throughout. On the other hand, like the subsequent episode of Cain, Abel, and Cain’s descendants, the Garden narrative counterbalances the advancements in human civilization with an increasing distance from Yhwh-God, which is in turn based on humanity’s first sin and the resultant expulsion from Paradise. This ambiguity is understood as indicative of a multi-staged formational process, with an original anthropogony being distinguished from its later sin-oriented theological reworking within the non-Priestly Primeval History. As a further argument, there has been the assumption that the positive naming of the woman as “mother of all living” (Gen 3:20) is inappropriate following the punishments in Gen 3:14–19, and that it had originally followed immediately after the creation of the woman (Gen 2:22f.). Proponents for this therefore see the intervening narrative of the transgression and its consequences as a later insertion. However, anticipating the Exegesis section below, the following points should

⁸ Levin, 1993, 85f.

⁹ See Levin, 1993, 82–102 with recourse to a corresponding tradition-historical differentiation in Humbert, 1940. On the reception of this proposal, which has proceeded with great variation in the details, see Kratz, 2005, 252–254; for a Late Wisdom influence on the Redaction, see Witte, 1998, as well as Spieckermann, 2001. Carr, 1993 sees an “anti-wisdom” reworking of the “Early Creation Narrative” in 2:4b–24*. A tabular overview is provided by Blum, 2004, 27.

be raised: The postulation that the two namings of the woman in Gen 2:23 and 3:20 once stood side by side scarcely maintains the original narrative progression and is thus hardly more suitable than the place of Gen 3:20 in the present text. The juxtaposition and succession of the two namings of the woman as “Woman” (אִשָּׁה; Gen 2:23) and as “Eve, the mother of all living” (חַוְוָה; Gen 3:20) only makes sense within the same text if there is a fundamental change in the woman (and the man) that takes place in between – exactly what the story of Adam and Eve transgressing the divine prohibition is about. In the punishments, Yhwh-God impairs the woman’s existence so that only the woman is subjected to desire, the man is to rule over the woman, and the reproduction of life is associated with pain and peril (Gen 3:16f.). With the man’s naming of the woman in Gen 3:20, this becomes a reality. Thus, unlike with the assumed earlier layer, the second naming of the woman in the present text is in its appropriate place.¹⁰ Finally, concerning the aforementioned ambiguity within the Garden narrative, it hardly provides any sufficient reason for distinguishing between an earlier optimistic anthropogony and a later theological reworking that is pessimistic and focused on sin. In any case, the anthropogony isolated in this assumption would not be a self-standing unit and, moreover, would have no analogy in the literary works known from the ancient Near East, which never have the creation of humanity as an independent theme. Considering the both artful and coherent structure of the Garden narrative, the depicted ambiguity should, like in other ancient literary works, be inherent from the outset. Or, to put it more clearly: The ambiguous experience of human existence is the primary theme throughout the Garden narrative, and the criticized change in its basic tone is actually the primordial means for justifying the arrival at this experience.

Formation II – “The Tree of Life”: More difficult of a decision is the oft-discussed question of whether the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad has the same origin as the Tree of Life. Although prominent at the beginning (Gen 2:9) and end (Gen 3:22, 24) of the narrative, the Tree of Life plays only a minor role in the narrative’s plot, leading to receptions of the narrative even tending to equate the two trees (see Michelangelo’s portrayal in the Sistine Chapel; the Quran also only speaks of one tree, see Surahs 2:35; 7:19f., 22). Indicative of this is the conversation between the snake and the woman in Gen 3:1–3: Sticking strictly to the text, the two know of only one specific tree in the middle of the Garden (Gen 3:3, “the tree [עֵץ] in the middle of the garden”), which, given the context, can only be the Tree of Knowledge (Gen 3:5, 7, 11). Moreover, the Tree of Life and the Tree of Knowledge standing next to each other in the middle of the Garden, as described

¹⁰ Gertz, 2004, 232f.

in Gen 2:9b, is widely considered difficult in both its syntax and its meaning. However, these observations should not be overstated. In the present text, the temptation scene has a special narrative tension since the readers know more about the situation than do the actors. Likewise, for Gen 2:9b, there is nothing syntactically objectional about the wording, which itself leaves enough room for both trees.¹¹ Nevertheless, there are still indications that the Tree of Life is a later addition to the Garden narrative: The Tree of Life is part of the same literary-historical context as the so-called “Paradise Geography” in Gen 2:10–15, which is widely seen as a later addition, and the banishment notice in Gen 3:24 that is inseparable from it. This verse is presumably a supplement meant to intensify the banishment notice in Gen 3:23 (see on Gen 2:9–17 and 3:22–24 below). Next, the motif of human mortality associated with the Tree of Life led to a clear and obvious expansion in Gen 2:7, where the word “dust” (עָפָר) slightly disrupts the clear structure of the verse (see on Gen 2:7; 3:19 below). A similar observation can be made for the reference in Gen 3:19b back to the word “dust” in Gen 2:7. It is furthermore striking that the Tree of Knowledge is explicitly called such only during the introduction of both of the trees in the middle of the Garden and in the formulation of the divine prohibition (Gen 2:9b, 17), while all other references to this tree are limited to referring to it as the *one* tree different from all other trees in the Garden. This is also the case for the reference back to the prohibition in Gen 3:11 (“the tree that I commanded of you”). The latter may too support Gen 2:17 also having originally spoken merely of the “tree in the middle of the Garden,” whose secret is revealed only through the snake in Gen 3:5. This change would have been prompted by the addition of the Tree of Life, which would have made the situation unclear.¹² Very much along these same lines is an even later harmonization in the Samaritan Pentateuch that changed the “the tree in the middle of the Garden” in Gen 3:3, the first mention of the tree in the conversation between the snake and the woman, to “*this* tree in the middle of the Garden,” thus giving the impression that the woman is pointing at the tree, which establishes the desired clarity for the scene. Finally, it must also be taken into account that the two trees are rooted in the same tradition, that being the conception of the “World Tree” known across the entire ancient Near East.¹³ This was taken up in the ideas of a Tree of Knowledge and a Tree of Life, each in a quite different way. However, it is quite unlikely for the “tree” motif to have been

¹¹ See Gese, 1973, 78 and fn. 4 and recently Michel, 1997: The locative בְּתוֹךְ הָגֶן “in the midst of the Garden” refers to the two trees and, conforming with the grammatical rules, stands between the two coordinating objects (here: the two trees), specifically after the shorter of the two words.

¹² See Gese, 1973, 77f.; Witte, 1998, 81.

¹³ See Pfeiffer, 2001, 4–7.

both duplicated and doubly reformulated all at once. The mention of the Tree of Life, which, a few literary gaps notwithstanding, fits in quite well within the present literary context, was therefore probably part of a reworking comprising Gen 2:9(b*?), 10–15; 3:19b, 22, 24 and the word “dust” in 2:7. It is possible that this reworking explicitly identified the forbidden tree in Gen 2:17 as the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad in order to clearly distinguish it from the Tree of Life. This nearly midrashic commentary puts to question the conditions and possibilities of the original state, thus bringing a deeper reflection on human mortality into the Garden narrative. At the same time, it symbolically correlates the Paradise Geography with the Jerusalem temple, thus conflating the mythical primeval times with the present, experienced world of the original addressees (see on Gen 2:10–14; 3:24 below).

Formation III – Further Additions: Finally, the explanatory notice “for Yhwh-God had not made it rain on the earth” (Gen 2:5b α) and the identification of the Garden as the “Garden of Eden” in the original closing notice (Gen 2:23) are later additions. The rationalizing explanation of the conditions of the world as it is coming into being interrupts the syntactic structure of the three nominal clauses in Gen 2:5 and names the subject, “Yhwh-God,” before the action even begins. Determining an exact classification for the addition is difficult. The identification of the Garden as the “Garden of Eden” is connected with the Paradise Geography (Gen 2:10, 15); originally, the narrative spoke only of a garden *in* Eden (Gen 2:8) or simply of “the Garden” (Gen 2:16, *passim*).

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION II: EXEGESIS

2:4a

This is the history of the origins of the heavens and the earth when they were created.

In the present text, the Garden narrative is introduced by the so-called *toledot* formula. The formula “These are the *toledot*/generations of P.N.” takes its name from the Hebrew word for “family history,” “family tree,” or “genealogy” (תולדות from ילד “to bear”). It marks the beginning of a new section, as evidenced by its other uses (see Gen 5:1; 6:9; 10:1; 11:10, 27; 25:12, 19; 36:1, 9; 37:2 [beyond Genesis: Num 3:1; Ruth 4:18; 1 Chr 1:29] and above on Gen 2:1–3 for the delineation of Gen 1:1–2:3), and always follows

as a summation of the preceding text.¹⁴ This is done in Gen 2:4a through the *nomen rectum* of the *toledot* formula (“the heavens and the earth”) and the temporal specification (“when they were created”). Both phrases unmistakably take up Gen 1:1–2:3 and closely resemble Gen 1:1 in their wording. Particularly noteworthy is the immediate sequence of the temporal specifications in 2:4a and the opening of v. 4b, which also has a temporal aspect and once again addresses the creation of “earth and heavens.” Therefore, in the context of the retrospective actualization of an event already reported in Gen 1, the present text of 2:4 should be understood as forming a transition from the creation of the world to the Garden narrative. The text’s repetition of the time designation draws a fermata in the middle of the sequence of events. This marks what follows as an explication of the creationary event that has in principle already been reported. In this sense, the formulation “when they were created” also clearly emphasizes that the following explanations about the coming into being of humanity, the animals, and the plants are likewise still part of the previously described creation of the world. Thus, v. 4a enables the texts of the Priestly Creation account and the Scholarly Narrator to be understood as complementary to each other. The aforementioned inconsistencies within the present text of Gen 1–3, which certainly did not go unnoticed to the ancient readers, thus appear now as different perspectives on one and the same event, of which the most important part, the creation of humanity, is now examined separately and in detail. This reading is also supported by how the *toledot* formula, based on the structure of the formerly independent Priestly Writing, sets off the preceding Creation account as a prologue to the history of humanity that begins with “Adam and Eve” (see Gen 2:4a and 5:1). This may seem at first to modern readers merely like an attempt to harmonize two conflicting texts with each other. Crucial to understanding this complementary understanding is, however, the conviction that both texts, the more cosmologically oriented Creation account and the more anthropologically oriented Garden narrative, report on the actions of the one and the same Creator God, regardless of their differences.

There are several factors speaking for the old assumption that Gen 2:4a and Gen 2:4b go back to different hands.¹⁵ Among the terminological differences of the sub-verses on the creation of the heavens and the earth, which are nearly identical in their meaning, particularly striking is the lack of determination of the two entities in v. 4b in contrast to v. 4a. In principle, their reversed order could still be explained

¹⁴ See already Wellhausen, 1905, 330.

¹⁵ See, among many, Witte, 1998, 55f.; Pfeiffer, 2000, 495. Most recently, Otto, 1996, 185–188, und Arneth, 2007, 131f. have argued emphatically for the literary unity of 2:4, following Stordalen, 1992.

as a chiasm taking up v. 4a (“the heavens and the earth”) for v. 4b (“earth and heavens”), and the changes from the passive construction in v. 4a (“when they were created”) to an active one (“God made”) in v. 4b and the creation verb *ברא (“to create”) in v. 4a to *עשה (“to make/do”) in v. 4b could be evaluated as stylistic variations.¹⁶ Nevertheless, such an evaluation can still be ruled out simply from the lack of determination of the “earth and heavens” in v. 4b. It is also not possible to point to the undetermined use of “earth and heavens” in Ps 148:13, since this does not attest to a shift from determined to undetermined speech within a single syntactic unit.¹⁷ Next, the *toledot* formula, which should be understood as a heading, stands in opposition in both content and function to the very complex heading of the Garden narrative in vv. 4b–7 – the sensibleness of the present literary complex notwithstanding.¹⁸ Unlike what is repeatedly claimed, the *toledot* formulae in Gen 5:1 and Num 3:1 are no evidence for v. 4a being an original part of vv. 4b–7. The feature shared by the three attestations cited for the literary unity of Gen 2:4 is the *toledot* formula being followed by a phrase introduced with בַּיּוֹם (“on the day”). However, it is in this point that there is a characteristic difference between Gen 2:4 and Gen 5:1; Num 3:1. In Gen 2:4, the context is actually broken, specifically by the temporal specification dependent upon the *toledot* formula, which itself stands in opposition to v. 4b. Consequently, and with all certainty possible in these matters, Gen 2:4a and 2:4b do not go back to the same author. The resultant editorial evaluation of Gen 2:4–7 is clear: Already due to the lack of determination in “earth and heavens,” Gen 2:4b–7 cannot be evaluated as a continuation of 2:4a. Conversely, it is quite possible that a redactor coming from Gen 1 kept the determination typical of the two entities (see Gen 1:1, 15, 17, 20, 26, 28, 30; 2:1) for the formulation of v. 4a. Accordingly, Gen 2:4a should be distinguished from v. 4b in its origin, but also, unlike the other *toledot* formulae in the Pentateuch (see above on Gen 2:1–3 for the delineation of Gen 1:1–2:3), it does not come from the Priestly Writing. It is therefore a purely redactional construction that transforms the original opening to the Garden narrative in Gen 2:4b into the transition from the first Creation account to the story of the fate of the first two humans and their descendants. In terms of redaction history, the origin of Gen 2:4a is thus beholden to the connection between the Priestly material and the Scholarly Narrator’s Primeval History that begins with Gen 2:4b.

What remains to be considered for the postscript “when they were created” is whether, alongside the temporal purpose, it is also meant to temper the idea of heaven and earth having creationary powers, echoes of which can also be found with the *toledot* formula, and emphasize instead that these are not active on their own but rather depend upon the power of the Creator working in them.¹⁹

¹⁶ See Wenham, 46; Stordalen, 1992, 174f.; Otto, 1996, 187.

¹⁷ Witte, 1998, 55f.; Pfeiffer, 2000, 495 and fn. 34. Cf. Stordalen, 1992, 175; Otto, 1996, 187.

¹⁸ So Stordalen, 1992, 171ff.; Tengström, 1982, 54f.; Otto, 1996, 187.

¹⁹ See Koch, 1999, 185.

2:4b–7

- 4b** *When Yhwh-God made earth and heavens*
5 *(all the bushes of the field were not yet on the earth, and all the plants of the field had not yet sprouted, for Yhwh-God had not made it rain on the earth and there was no Human to till the soil,*
6 *although a stream of water would spring up from the earth and water the entire face of the ground),*
7 *then Yhwh-God formed the Human from dust of the soil, and he breathed the breath of life into his nose, and the Human became a living being.*

The original beginning of the Garden narrative spans three and a half verses. Syntactically, this strikingly long introduction should probably be understood in such a way that the temporal clause “When Yhwh-God made earth and heavens” (v. 4b), which itself is incomplete, is continued and completed only with the action beginning in v. 7, “then Yhwh-God formed...” Conversely, the circumstantial clauses following v. 4b in v. 5 and v. 6 describe the conditions prevailing during the action fixed temporally by v. 4b and described in v. 7 – that is, the conditions before and during the creation of humanity. In the English translation, this construction can be reproduced as a parenthetical remark.²⁰ The structure and wording of the opening are clearly reminiscent of the beginnings of Mesopotamian creation myths. Frequent reference is made to the beginning of the Babylonian epic of the god Marduk, Enuma Eliš, mentioned above (see p. 48), which practically imposes itself as a parallel because of its sequencing of a temporal clause, a description of the accompanying circumstances, and an introduction to the action, in addition to its artistic interweaving of the negative and positive descriptions of the conditions. Even still, it must be emphasized that there is no specific piece of literature that can be identified as the basis for the beginning of the Garden narrative, although it is otherwise linked by numerous motifs to the literature

²⁰ See Groß, 1987, 49–55. Others designate v. 4b, following Dohmen, 1996, 37ff., as a kind of expository superscript that should be distinguished from the description of the primordial world in v. 5f. and the beginning of the action in v. 7. Verse 4b would then be a temporal clause whose main clause (“Then the following happened”) is suppressed (so-called “aposiopesis”; see GKC §167a). This explanation, although fundamentally possible, is unnecessarily complicated and has against it that aposiopesis typically occurs in conditional clauses. However, it correctly recognizes that v. 4b is presupposed by vv. 5–7, which, moreover, speaks against the repeatedly made supposition that v. 4b is a redactional transition from the Priestly Creation account to the Garden narrative (see, e.g., Schmidt, 1973, 196f.; Westermann, 199; Levin, 1993, 86, 89). A narrative beginning with the present form of v. 5 is hardly possible. The claim that the beginning in v. 5 has probably been “garbled” (Levin [translation JWR]) can be rejected on account of the current form of the Gen 2:4b–7 text, which is syntactically unobjectionable and is well-derived from within the tradition history.

of the ancient Near East. One example among many is the beginning of an Akkadian myth, recited during the restoration of dilapidated temples, that is especially interesting with regard to the beginning of the action in v. 7: “When Anu [the sky god and king of gods] had created the heavens, Nudimmud [Ea, the freshwater god] had built the *Apsû* [the freshwater ocean], his dwelling, Ea nipped off clay in the *Apsû*; he created Kulla [the brick god] for the restoration of (the temples)...”²¹ Just as in this text, the time reference in v. 4b, whose literal translation is “on the day when Yhwh-God...”, should be understood as a temporal conjunction. Thus, the oft-asked question of an exact identification of the day mentioned in the Hebrew formulation, or a precise determination of the chronological sequence of the creation of the world and humanity, is unnecessary. With the subsequent merism “earth and heavens” (cf. Gen 1:1) describing the whole of Creation, it is in any rate clear that, like in the Priestly Creation account, this is about the primordial creation of the world. There is a common reading that seeks to harmonize the two by seeing the beginning of the Garden narrative as telling, after the creation of the world in Gen 2:4a, of the creation of humanity on the sixth day of the creation week. However, this hardly corresponds to the original intent of the verse – even if, from the outset, the account is concentrated on the creation of humanity and how its agrarian way of life, oriented around the soil, came to be. Unlike the Priestly Writing in Gen 1:1–2:3, the Scholarly Narrator does not even remotely address “cosmological questions,” even in a broader sense. Instead, the narrative action begins in v. 7 immediately with the creation of humanity. This disinterest in cosmological questions may also explain why v. 4b, in contrast to the sequence “heavens and earth” that dominates in the Mesopotamian sphere and is also more commonly found across the Hebrew Bible, names the earth first, thereby emphatically placing humanity’s own habitat first among to the two elements of the merism (see also Ps 148:13).

2:4b *When Yhwh-God made earth and heavens*

The designation “Yhwh-God” or “Yhwh-Elohim” in v. 4b is conspicuous.²² Grammatically, אֱלֹהִים (“God” or “divine being”) is best understood as being

²¹ “When Anu Had Created the Heavens” (Heidel, 1951, 65–66); “Kosmologie des *kalû*-Priesters,” (Hecker, *TUAT III*, 604–605). See Horowitz, 2011, 149f.

²² For discussion, see Witte, 1998, 57–61 and 232–237, there also on the epigraphic evidence for the combination of “D.N. + generic term,” including “the god Yahu” in the Aramaic papyri from the Judean military colony on the Nile island of Elephantine from the fifth century BCE. This type of designation for God is rooted in contexts concerning the identification of a specific god among multiple gods. This is hardly a problem for the Garden narrative’s Scholarly Narrator. Confusions could arise at most from the redactional synthesis with the Priestly Creation account and its use of the generic term “God” almost as a proper name, or from the plural formulation in Gen 3:24 (“like one of us”), which is a later insertion.

in apposition to Yhwh, with the generic term “God” being used as a proper name, like in Gen 1:1–2:3, and therefore not bearing an article. Generally, the only place where this formulation is found in the Pentateuch is in the Garden narrative, where it is used throughout. There are two exceptions to this: First is the dramaturgically justified exception of the dialogue between the woman and the snake (see on Gen 3:1 below); second is the text-critically unclear Exod 9:30 (MT). Outside of the Pentateuch, it occurs just one more time in a narrative passage (Jon 4:6). The remaining attestations are limited to prayers and confessional statements (2 Sam 7:25; Ps 72:18; 84:12; 1 Chr 17:16f.; 28:20; 29:1; 2 Chr 1:9; 6:41, 42; 26:18). This concentration in the Garden narrative of such a rare phrase for the Pentateuch calls for explanation: Even though the Cain and Abel story and the passages of the Flood narrative that do not belong to the Priestly Writing are closely connected with Gen 2:4–3:24, they use the divine name “Yhwh” throughout, which is why the combination “Yhwh-God” can hardly be original to the Garden narrative. Since it is not possible to reconstruct an earlier stage of Gen 2:4–3:24 that, like the Priestly Writing, exclusively uses the generic term “God,”²³ the redactional “Yhwh-God” must have come into the Garden narrative only after it was written. In this case, the clearest answer is that the formulation is a later attempt to harmonize the Garden narrative with the Creation account in the Priestly Writing. Through the redactional phrase “Yhwh-God,” the Redaction identified the God of the Priestly Creation account with that of the Garden narrative. The Septuagint has taken up this concern in its own way: It translates the divine name “Yhwh-God” as κύριος ὁ θεός (“Lord, the God”) and renders the divine name as such throughout the rest of the Primeval History, even in places where it is used in the Hebrew without the appositional אֱלֹהִים. On the other hand, in the places in the Garden narrative where it speaks exclusively of Yhwh’s creationary action (Gen 2:4, 5, 7, 9, 19, 21; 3:22), it conforms with the Priestly Creation account by using ὁ θεός (“God”) instead of the expected translation κύριος ὁ θεός.²⁴ Thus, in its own way, the Septuagint anticipates the obvious objection to this proposal, that the Redaction would have hardly limited itself to the Garden narrative if it wanted to harmonize the names of God.²⁵ However, this seems like a convincing counterargument only at first sight. The Redaction was probably concerned primarily with the confessional identification of the unnamed Creator God of Gen 1:1–2:3 with Yhwh.²⁶ This concern is consistent with

²³ Cf. Levin, 1993, 82f.

²⁴ Rösel, 1994, 58. Gen 2:22 is an exception; here, the LXX reads κύριος ὁ θεός.

²⁵ See already Budde, 1883, 234.

²⁶ The insight that this conspicuous name for God can be explained by the connection of the Creation account and the Garden narrative is older than the source division in Gen 1–3. Thus, as an example, Johannes Clericus (*Genesis sive moysis prophetae*. Amsterdam: Janssonio-Wesbergios 1693, 16) explains the tetragrammaton, which is first used in Gen 2:4, as being

the other use of the phrase, which emphasizes Yhwh's universal power in the aforementioned prayers and confessions. The single attestation in the Pentateuch outside of the Garden narrative points in a similar direction. In Exod 9:30 (MT), the "Yhwh-God" from the mouth of Moses serves to make Yhwh's divinity clear to the Egyptians. Furthermore, most of the attestations also suggest a connection with the Jerusalem temple cult, for which similar constructions are also attested (so אֱלֹהִים יְהוָה in Josh 22:22; Ps 50:1; עֲלִיּוֹן [אֵל] יְהוָה in Gen 14:22; Ps 7:18; 47:3; 97:9). If such usage is the background for the expansion of "Yhwh" to "Yhwh-Elohim," then it is also entirely in line with the Paradise Geography in Gen 2:10–14, which is also an addition and also seeks to establish a connection between the Garden of Eden and the temple in Jerusalem.

2:5

(all the bushes of the field were not yet on the earth, and all the plants of the field had not yet sprouted, for Yhwh-God had not made it rain on the earth and there was no Human to till the soil,

The description of the world before and during the creation of humanity begins in v. 5 with a sequence of "not-yet statements" concerning the bushes of the field, the plants of the field, and humanity. The two statements about the lack of vegetation are closely related to each other through the parallel structure of the statements themselves and through the reference explaining them via the still-absent rain. Here, it is noticeable that the description of the still-plantless earth is not oriented around the laying out of a (tree) garden (see v. 8f.) but rather already around the post-Paradise existence of the farmer. Thus, the emergence of the aforementioned plants goes unmentioned in the context of the Garden being laid out, while the lack of the trees in the description of the earlier state of the primordial world is not specifically addressed. Instead, the "plants of the field" (עֲשֵׂב הַשָּׂדֶה) mentioned second reappears only in the punishments of Gen 3:18, specifically as humanity's post-Paradise nourishment. The "plants of the field" therefore refers to crops that require human attention, which the following statement mentions as being absent (v. 5bγ). Moreover, "field" (שָׂדֶה) denotes the open country, as opposed to the enclosed Garden as it is established for humanity later in the narrative (v. 8). In contrast, the expression "bushes of the field" (שִׁיחַ הַשָּׂדֶה), whose exact botanical meaning is unclear, is not taken up again throughout the rest of the Garden narrative. The other attestations of "bush" (שִׁיחַ; Gen 21:15;

connected "per appositionem" (emphasis in original) with the word *God*, so that the reader recognizes the identity of the Creator God as the God worshipped by the Israelites.

Job 30:4, 7) suggest steppe vegetation. In light of the parallel structure of the two statements in v. 5, the obvious solution is again to connect the absence of “bushes of the field” with the punishment in Gen 3:18 and to see it as a generic term for the “thorn bushes and brush” mentioned there atop the tilled soil.²⁷ If the description of the “not-yet” state thus establishes the absence of both undesired and desired vegetation of the field, then this also echoes the ambiguity of human existence at the very beginning of the Garden narrative: The rain is sent by Yhwh-God upon the soil, from which humanity is taken and which humanity must cultivate for its livelihood; this then brings forth plants that are both supportive of and destructive to human life. Explaining this fundamental aspect of the human experience from its emergence is the goal of the Garden narrative, rather than painting a picture of life in Paradise. This also applies to the “not-yet” for humanity in the last part of the verse. While it is true that the creation of humanity is described in several steps leading to its completion through the creation of the woman, the interest here also lies entirely in how the present conditions of human existence came into being. Accordingly, the concluding statement “to till the soil” (v. 5bγ) looks ahead to humanity’s life outside of the Garden. The counterpart to this “not-yet statement” is the statement at the end of the Garden narrative that humanity (אָדָם), created from the soil (אֶדְמָה), goes forth to till it (Gen 3:23). Also in its details, this confirms the aforementioned basic hermeneutical insight for understanding mythical narratives of the primordial beginnings: They are interested in the basic conditions of human life that already exist as well as their primordial origins, rather than the actual state of whatever came before. This primordial state is depicted only as a problem or a beginning state whose resolution stands at the end of the narrative and constitutes the actual end goal and connection to reality. In addition to the early primordial world of the “not-yet,” this “before” state also includes the life in Paradise, still untarnished by the transgression of the divine commandment. It describes a place and an intermediate state in which features characteristic of reality are temporarily reversed into their opposite. This narrative trait, in which the conditions of life are fundamentally altered due to the transgression of the divine commandment, is introduced already in v. 5f. The absence of both desired and undesired plants and of humanity’s cultivation of the field refers not only to the post-Paradise acquisition of nourishment; it also contrasts to the depiction of the provision of human life in the Garden that follows this “not-yet” – a garden laid out by Yhwh-God (v. 8) rather than human fieldwork, and an ever-flowing stream (v. 6; also vv. 10–14) rather than the uncertainty of rain.²⁸

²⁷ See Steck, 1982, 26f. and fn. 38, 39.

²⁸ See Steck, 1982, 28.

The statement “and there was no man to till the soil” indicates that, in the Scholarly Narrator’s view, the destiny of humanity lies in work. This sentence is taken up in the punishments and supplemented by the aspects of toil and the uncertainty around the work’s yield (3:17f.). Since humanity was already charged in Paradise with cultivating and guarding the Garden (2:15), the departure from Paradise into reality means humanity’s working of the field (3:23). The Psalmist, understanding humanity’s work as quite characteristic of the well-ordered world, shows through praise of the Creator how natural this conception is: “You order the darkness and it becomes night. In it stir all the animals of the forest. The young lions roar for prey; they demand of God their food. When the sun rises, they retreat and lie down in their hiding places. Humanity goes out to its work, to its toil until the evening” (Ps 104:20–23). As the night belongs to the wild and dangerous animals, so does the day belong to humanity and its work. Both have their place in the order of the created world, but in contrast to the animals, humanity experiences its fate not by being granted a habitat but through its work, the mission of its life.²⁹ The narrators of the Mesopotamian creation myths could not have expressed this any better. They also tell of how humans were created for the work – even if accentuated very differently. A look at the first tablet of the Old Babylonian Epic of Atrahasis can illuminate this.³⁰ The text, which clearly dates to the early second millennium BCE, begins its description of the earlier state of the primordial world with one of the most remarkable sentences in the history of literature: “When gods were man” (Atr 1.1). As the continuation of the sentence shows, the mythical state of the gods’ humanity comes in their obligation to work in a humanless primordial era. The gods “did forced labor, they bore drudgery” (Atr 1.1). To alleviate the hardship for at least the higher gods, a group of lesser gods are forced into canal construction and, therefore, probably also do agricultural work. This goes over well for a time before the oppressed gods react by striking and rebelling, after which the god of wisdom, Enki, and the mother goddess create humanity upon the decision of the assembly of the gods, so that they work in the gods’ stead. As in the Garden narrative, the Babylonian epic unfolds a constellation of problems through its description of the primordial world. Its resolution stands at the end of the myth and is its actual end goal as well as the connection to reality. Humanity is created for the sole purpose of relieving the gods of their work and providing for the material needs of the gods (and their temples). It is at this last point, however, that the Garden narrative differentiates itself quite clearly

²⁹ See Spieckermann, 1989, 38f.

³⁰ Translation and short introduction: Foster, *Muses*, 227–253. A translation of the Late Babylonian version is offered by Foster, *Muses*, 256–267. For this interpretation regarding the biblical Primeval History, see Albertz, 1980.

from its ancient Near Eastern parallels. In its view, humanity was not created to work for or in the place of Yhwh; it works in the world that was created for it. Humanity works for its livelihood (Gen 3:17f.). This fundamental insight by the Scholarly Narrator also has consequences for social ethics and the history of mentalities. Estrangement and economic hardship are not rooted solely in the god's relationship to humanity and are thus clearly describable as consequences of economic causes, thereby enabling sociopolitical action.

2:6

although a stream of water would spring up from the earth and water the entire face of the ground),

After the negative statements of v. 5, the following v. 6 contains a positive description of an ever-rising stream of water (נָחַל). Because of this shift, v. 6 is often thought to be secondary.³¹ However, the juxtaposition and interpenetration of the “not-yet statements” and the positive descriptions of the early primordial world are not unusual, as evinced by the beginning of Enuma Eliš (1.1–9). Moreover, the omission of v. 6 and, therefore, of the hydration necessary for the formation of humanity out of the soil can already be ruled out for logical reasons.

The exact meaning of the expression נָחַל, here translated as “stream of water,” is unclear. The only other time the word appears in the Hebrew Bible is in Job 36:27, where the context suggests a “cloud” (see the corresponding translation of Gen 2:6 in the Targums with עָנָן) or “mist,” which is reflected in prominent translations of Gen 2:6 as “fog” (Luther 1545) and “mist” (KJV) and also influenced medieval Jewish commentaries. However, these translations do not fit with what v. 6 actually says, which is that the נָחַל rises from an otherwise dry earth (see 1 Kgs 18:44), especially considering how the verb, “to well upwards” (*עלה), is elsewhere used for water in connection with a well (Num 21:17) or the sea (Jer 47:2; Ezek 26:3) and its imperfect conjugation describes continuous action (GKC §107b). The context and syntax thus suggest continuously rising water. This is probably why the LXX and the Vulgate render it with “spring” (πηγή; *fons*). The author of the later Paradise Geography in vv. 10–14 may have also understood the text in this way. In any case, his conception of a river flowing out from the Garden matches well with this understanding of Gen 2:6, and it is conceivable that with this insertion, this author also sought to explain the rare word נָחַל with the more common נָהָר “river” (v. 10). The etymology of the former expression,

³¹ See Westermann, 200; Levin, 1993, 92; Pfeiffer, 2000, 490.

which has been the subject of much controversy, points in the same direction.³² A connection with the Sumerian/Akkadian *Īd/id* “river (god)” has been discussed, as has the Akkadian *edû* “flood/stream of water,” which is more likely for philological reasons and has in turn been connected with the Sumerian A.DÉ.A. The Akkadian *edû* is also connected with the conception, compatible with the setting of the Garden narrative, of bodies of water that, like the fertility-bringing spring floods of the Tigris and Euphrates, burst forth from the ocean that lies under the earth. Finally, also regarding the creation of humanity depicted in the following verse, it must be considered whether the use of אֲדָמָה, which is rare and points to the Mesopotamian sphere, may preserve a distant memory of the Sumerian and Akkadian creation myths. In these, the construction and maintenance of artificial irrigation systems are the responsibility of the lower gods, until humanity is formed from the fertile clay of the subterranean freshwater ocean, *Apsû*, in order to relieve them.

2:7

then Yhwh-God formed the Human from dust of the soil, and he breathed the breath of life into his nose, and the Human became a living being.

Verse 7a continues the temporal clause from v. 4b, which was broken up by the description of the world before it came into being and begins with the actual creation event: Yhwh-God forms the first human from the loose topsoil and breaths into him the breath of life. At first sight, the description of humanity’s creation seems almost laconic and understandable by itself: The soil (אֲדָמָה) and the human (אָדָם) formed therefrom and brought to life by Yhwh-God are bound together by their very essence; the human being is a “lump of earth” (Luther). However, for its earliest readers, the verse would have also evoked a trove of images and texts on the creation of humanity and its world. These the biblical account shared with the other cultures of the ancient Near East, even though the Garden narrative was formulated as a very individual expression of the traditions that shaped it. Later readers, coming from an intellectual environment in changed historical circumstances, read the verse within the context of Gen 1’s assertions about humanity being formed in the image of God, which influenced its further reception significantly. It therefore seems best to go through the account word by word in order to provide at least a brief sketch of the most important traditions and how the definitive courses were set for the text’s later reception in the early expansions of the text as well as its ancient translations.

³² See Tsumura, 1989, 94–113, 159–161.

In the ancient Near East, the creation of humanity and its world was told in various different ways. The two basic types are creation as *emersio* – mainly attested in the Sumerian tradition – and creation as *formatio*. In the former, humanity springs forth from the earth like plants (see on Gen 1:11–13 above) and achieves civilization only at a second stage. Conversely, creation as *formatio* describes the formative action of a deity, as is the case in the Garden narrative. The verb “to form” (*יצר) chosen for the divine creation in v. 7 signifies a craftsman-like or artistic shaping of clay (חמר) or similar material, which is primarily reminiscent of the work of a potter (see Isa 29:16; Jer 18:1–12; Isa 64:7). A graphic parallel can be found in a relief from a temple of the pharaoh Amenhotep III (1391–1353 BCE) at the Egyptian city of Luxor in which the creator god, Khnum, forms the later pharaoh and his personified life force (the *Ka*) on a potter’s wheel.³³ In Gen 2:7, however, the focus is less on the crafting process than on the statement about the material, in which humanity is formed out of the “dust of the soil” (עפר מן־הָאֲדָמָה) – neither dust nor soil are genuine materials of the potter.

The word עפר, translated here as “dust,” has a basic meaning of “loose earth.” In the literature of the Hebrew Bible, however, it repeatedly serves as an image for humanity’s lowliness and transience. For the current passage, this meaning is affirmed through the punishment in Gen 3:19, which refers back to Gen 2:7: “You shall eat bread in the sweat of your face, until you return to the soil [אֲדָמָה], for from it you were taken, for you are dust [עפר] and you shall return to dust [עפר]” (see also Ps 103:14; 104:29; Job 4:19; 10:9; Eccl 3:20; 12:7). The talk of humanity’s return to dust likely corresponds to practical experience in ancient Israel, where the dead were mostly interred in burial chambers or caves that could be used multiple times, and the decay of the bones into dust was unmistakable during later interments. According to the present literary state of Gen 2:7, the first characteristic of humanity is, alongside its creatureliness, its transitory nature. This is not only the consequence of transgressing the divine prohibition from eating from the Tree of Knowledge; it is also inherent to the very substance of humanity and therefore accords with the order of Creation. Humanity’s being conceived as mortal from the very beginning takes up a perspective of the Garden narrative, but it was probably not originally emphasized. Rather, the word “dust” in v. 7 and the corresponding statement of humanity being dust and returning to dust (3:19), like the Tree of Life (2:9; 3:22, 24), stem from an initial commentary overlaid upon the Garden narrative. This shifted the emphases in the Garden narrative so that from the outset, the tone in the description of humanity’s ambiguous experience of its existence was set on the עפר as symbolic

³³ See Keel, 1997, 250 with Fig. 334.

of transience, while the “fertile [...] potency of the אֲדָמָה”³⁴ was almost marginalized, causing the narrative to lose much of its dynamism.

In 2:7, עָפָר “dust” is conspicuous in both its language and its meaning: The term is best understood as an accusative that names the material out of which something is made (see *GKC* §117hh) and is further elaborated in v. 7 with מִן־הָאֲדָמָה “from the soil.” Thus, humanity is formed from the dust, particularly from the soil. While the phrase מִן־הָאֲדָמָה עָפָר “dust from the soil” is uncommon, the construct עָפָר הָאֲדָמָה is comparable in meaning and widely attested. The conspicuous connection of עָפָר with הָאֲדָמָה in v. 7 can be explained merely through the desire to express (the transient) humanity’s essential bondage to the soil. What is then inexplicable, however, is why the close phonetic and functional connection of אָדָם “human(ity)” and אֲדָמָה “soil” (see already v. 5) is disrupted by the עָפָר. Also conspicuous concerning its meaning is how, contrary to the logic of the narrative, the material parallelism to the animals is abandoned, despite 2:19 saying that Yhwh-God formed them from the soil (*יִצְרָא + מִן־הָאֲדָמָה, as in v. 7*). The additional mention of the material used in forming humanity, which consequently remains completely irrelevant to the account of creation in Gen 2, is taken up again only in humanity’s punishment in 3:17b–19 (in v. 19b). However, the line in question is a doublet of 3:19aβγ, which, unlike the main parts of the Garden narrative, uses the pointed statement “for you are dust” to make death itself the object of the narrative reflections (also Job 10:9: “Consider then that you have made me like clay and that you have let me return to dust!”). Genesis 3:19aβγ certainly also speaks of human mortality, but this is neither the actual subject of the sentence nor even the punishment that is handed down. The impairment of existence that is inflicted as punishment comes rather with the fact that human livelihood is obtained only through a struggle, until death (which was already part of the created order), from the soil from which humanity was taken and that it is destined to till. It is therefore most likely that the word “dust” in Gen 2:8 as well as 3:19b as a whole are later additions.³⁵ It was probably prompted by the curse upon the snake, which assigns it dust as food while at the same time bringing it close to death and ruin (3:14).

According to the original version of the Garden narrative, Yhwh forms humanity (אָדָם) from the soil (אֲדָמָה) so that humanity can work it (v. 5; see also 3:23). In its material substance, humanity is no different from the animals (v. 19), but its destiny is assigned especially to the soil. The terms אָדָם and אֲדָמָה may have both come from the root *אִדַם “to be red” (Ges¹⁸), which may be related to the reddish-brown tint of human skin and the soil, the ferrous *terra rossa*. Of course, more important than the etymology is the view widespread in antiquity of the convergence between something’s name and its essence, and the phonetic resemblance in this case expresses an inner

³⁴ Spieckermann, 2001, 60 [translation JWR].

³⁵ See, e.g., Pfeiffer, 2000, 491f. Cf. most recently Bührer, 2014, 208f. He concludes that the present text is original based on the fact that, as proven by its mere existence, the present text is linguistically “possible.” This argument has repeatedly been used, but it is problematic since “possible” and “original” lie on two different categorical planes. In other words: Even the redactors and glossators knew Hebrew and thus produced “possible” texts.

accordance in essence.³⁶ In this sense, the wordplay between אָדָם and אֲדָמָה discloses the essence of humanity and its creationary connection to the soil (see 2:5b; 3:19a, 23). The word אָדָם is determined through the use of the definite article. Thus, it is not the proper name “Adam,” first used by the Scholarly Narrator in a genealogical context (Gen 4:25; see 5:1 [P]; also the Text-critical and Philological Note on v. 20 above), but the designation of the “human” species initially represented by a single individual. This usage is maintained even when the “Human” is spoken of in relation to the “Woman” after her creation (see הָאָדָם וְהָאִשָּׁה “the Human and his Woman” in 2:25; 3:8; הָאָדָם in, e.g., 2:23; 3:9). Consequently, conjectures about the sex of the first human as being yet undifferentiated, which appeared even in rabbinic interpretation, are unnecessary.³⁷ The first human is thought of as male – regardless of the fact that he only perceives himself as a man in relation to the woman (Gen 2:23) and, like the woman, becomes aware of his sexuality only after eating from the tree (Gen 3:7).

The creation of humanity from earthen material is a widespread motif in the ancient Near East. Thus, Mesopotamian myths frequently report of the creator deities having “pinched off” the clay or mud from the depths of the *Apsû* (Sumerian: *Abzu*), the freshwater ocean that sits below the earth and is the seat of the god Ea (Sumerian: Enki). The material obtained in this way has no creative power of its own; nevertheless, there is an unmistakable mythical connotation in this origin that is not found anywhere in the biblical text, shared motifs notwithstanding. Genesis 2:6 merely hints at the moistening of the soil by an ever-rising stream of water (מַיִם). Especially with the addition of the word “dust,” the statement in Gen 2:7 about the material origins of humanity is of a “nearly banal unsacrality.”³⁸ Admittedly, even this aspect is not without analogy. Particularly prominent in this regard is the Epic of Gilgamesh, which was known throughout the ancient Near East, telling of the creation of the wild man Enkidu:³⁹ “[The mother goddess] Aruru washed her hands, she took a pinch of clay, she threw it down in the wild. In the wild she created Enkidu, the hero, an offspring of silence, knit strong by Ninurta. All his body is matted with hair, he is adorned with tresses like a woman: the locks of his hair grow as thickly as [the goddess of grain] Nissaba’s, he knows not at all a people nor even a country. He was clad in a garment like Šakkan’s, feeding on grass with the very gazelles. Jostling at the water-hole with the herd, he enjoyed the water with the animals” (Gilgm 1.101–112).

³⁶ See Seeligmann, 1953, 150–181, 157ff.

³⁷ Cf. Tribble, 1978, 79–82. On the androgynous interpretation of Gen (1:27 and) 2:7 in Hellenistic and rabbinic Judaism, see Zimmermann, 2001, 215–219. For criticism, see Lanser, 1988, 71–74; Clines, 1990.

³⁸ Müller, 1972, 272 [translation JWR].

³⁹ See further George, 2020; Maul, 2014; Sallaberger, 2008.

The Epic of Gilgamesh has no report about the creation of humanity in a strict sense, but the figure of Enkidu takes up traditional creation myths and traditions of primordial humanity. Thus, the creation of Enkidu takes place in a world that has long been inhabited by humanity but, simultaneously, a world in which, “*over a quick time lapse, the becoming of humanity takes place over again.*”⁴⁰

The human being, formed from the soil, is now brought to life by the breath of life (נְשַׁמַּת חַיִּים) being breathed into it. The closest analogies to this second act of the creation of humanity can be found in Egyptian sources. Part of the pictorial repertoire of the depiction of the (divine) procreation and birth of the pharaoh is a deity, generally Hathor, holding the sign of life, the “ankh,” in front of the nose of the newborn or his mother. As in the aforementioned relief from the temple of Amenhotep III, the motif is connected even into the Roman period with the formation of humanity out of clay. The motif of something created by the hand of the gods being brought to life is less prominent in Mesopotamian texts, even though these too speak of humanity as “living beings with the breath of life” (*šikitta napšu*; EnE1 6.129). This motif plays an important role in the context of making images of the gods. In the “opening of the mouth” ritual, the cultic images are, after being artfully created out of wood, stone, metal, and jewels, brought through the wild steppe to the river, and from there into the garden of the gods. Here, before it is transferred into the sanctuary, the opening of the mouth takes place among the circle of the gods. After the ritual, the figural depiction of the deity can communicate and breathe, thus becoming a living representation of it. The ritual procedure, which has numerous correspondences across the ancient Near East, is somewhat reminiscent of the structure of Gen 2–3. This has in more recent times led to considerations that the Garden narrative, drawing on the Mesopotamian ritual, problematizes the claims about the image of God in Gen 1:26–28. In this view, the Garden narrative reports of the “opening of the mouth,” so to speak, of the image mentioned in Gen 1:26–28. However, after its completion in the divine garden, this image needs a companion, and its path out of the garden leads not to a temple but to working the soil.⁴¹ Nevertheless, the divergences are too great to consider Gen 2–3 to be intended as a criticism of Gen 1 through disassociation with a Mesopotamian blueprint, especially since this interpretation imputes to the authors and intended readers of the Garden narrative a neigh-impossible “peek behind the curtain” about a ritual that would have been familiar only to those directly involved; plus, an appearance of the problematized term “image of God” (צֶלֶם אֱלֹהִים) would be expected somewhere in Gen 2. Moreover, explaining the biblical

⁴⁰ Hartenstein, 2009, 106 [translation JWR; emphasis original].

⁴¹ Schüle, 2006, 161–165. For criticism, see Bühner, 2008, 78–82; *ibid.*, 2014, 343–346.

references to the “breath of life” through the (uncertain) reception of a particular text is unnecessarily complex. Besides the heartbeat, breath is the most evident characteristic of life (see 1 Kgs 17:17). In this respect, the biblical references, along with the Mesopotamian ritual and the Egyptian bringing to life through the sign of life, are most likely based on the shared view of the manipulation of the mouth or nose being able to bring an inanimate object to life (see 2 Kgs 4:34f.; Ezek 37:9f.; Ps 104:29f.).

The intimate moment of breathing the human being into life expresses its special connection with God – no more and no less. The breath of life (נְשֵׁמַת חַיִּים) is no privilege of humanity (Gen 7:22; see Ps 150:6; Eccl 3:19–21), but no breathing into life by Yhwh-God is reported for the animals. This has time and again led to the hearing of faint echoes in Gen 2:7 of the idea, widespread in antiquity, of humanity’s special status between God and the world being described through the earthly and the divine as being combined within humanity: Prometheus is reported to have brought humans, formed from earth and water, into their humanity through a spark of fire stolen from the gods (Apollodorus 1.45; see Plato, *Prot.* 320c–322d) or to have endowed humanity with the spirit of life himself (Ovid, *Metam.* 1.363ff.), or even Athena having animated his work by breathing the breath of life into it (Lucian, *Prom.* 3). According to the Orphic anthropogony, Zeus formed humanity from the smoke and ashes of the slain Dionysus and those sentenced for his murder, the Titans (Orph. Frag. 220). In some Mesopotamian texts, the creation of humanity is preceded by the killing of a god, with humanity being formed out of the blood and bones of the slain god (EnEl 6.5f.) or its blood being mixed with the clay from which humanity is formed (Atr 1.189ff. [2.68ff.]). Aside from humanity’s special status, the characteristics of its essence can thus be explained by its material substance. Either the slaughtered god is part of a group of instigators, which thus entangles the human destiny with a tragic state of guilt (EnEl 6.21ff.), or humanity’s substance comes from a deity attributed with the ability to plan, which is a quality that serves as a distinguishing marker of humanity and which humanity unconditionally needs (Atr 1.233f. [2.115f.]).

In comparison to the aforementioned Greek and Mesopotamian texts, the Garden narrative is remarkably restrained. The entanglement of guilt and humanity’s capabilities for understanding and for civilization are connected entirely with Adam and Eve’s transgression of the divine prohibition. Likewise, humanity receives neither a part of the divine soul nor a divine spark when it is breathed into life. Genesis 2:7a does not even explicitly state that it is *God’s* breath of life that is breathed into humanity (so only Ps 104:30; Job 27:3). Verse 7b is much the same. Yhwh-God’s breathing turns the lifeless body into a “living being” (נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה; KJV: “a living soul”), but no נֶפֶשׁ is given to it. Accordingly, the praise of the Creator in the Psalter both extols

God's life-giving breath and equates the revocation of the *human* breath with dying: "When you hide your face, they are terrified; when you take away their breath, they die and turn back to dust. When you send your breath, they are created, and you renew the face of the earth" (Ps 104:29–30). Therefore, this distinction between the lifeless body and the living human being does not result in a dichotomous image of humanity that strictly divides the body from the soul in terms of which does the animating. Rather, like in the Hebrew Bible as a whole, humanity is conceived as a psychosomatic unity, which, especially as seen in the Primeval History, includes a differentiated perception of aspects of vegetation as they relate to the body, noetic aspects, and volutative aspects of being a person. Correspondingly, the Hebrew שָׁנָה, which bears a basic, concrete meaning of "throat" and "neck," can encompass each of these aspects depending on context. In v. 7b, the connection with חַיָּה "living" concerns human vitality.⁴² Even if the expression חַיָּה שָׁנָה, rendered here as "living being," plays a prominent role in the Priestly Primeval History and the construction of v. 7b is somewhat reminiscent of the execution formula in Gen 1 ("And so it happened"; see 1:7, 9, 11, 15, 24, 30), the similarities are still too faint to identify clearly a redactor concerned with harmonizing the language here with that of Gen 1. Whether redactional or not, the expression has been chosen well, since in other places, it is used only for animals (see also Lev 11:10, 46; Ezek 47:9). This clearly emphasizes with a desirable clarity that Gen 2:7 describes the creation of humanity as beings of nature.⁴³ Even if the need for communitization is an inherent part of human nature (so Gen 2:18), the Garden narrative does not yet at this point speak of humanity as a being with society or civilization. As an analogy, reference can be made to the quotation above from the Epic of Gilgamesh, in which, throughout the progression of the events, Enkidu becomes human through several stages after the actual act of creation (from clay and without any divine attributes).

The fact that, even up to the present, readings of the passage have time and again connected Gen 2:7 with the idea of an immortal soul is related to the translation into Greek by the LXX.⁴⁴ The Septuagint has promoted a Platonizing understanding of Gen 2:7, even though this was not a necessary consequence of its translation of שָׁנָה חַיָּה "living being" as ψυχὴ ζῶσα "living soul": According to Plato, during the earthly life of the human being, the preexistent and immortal ψυχή enters into a temporary union with its perishable body, which then dissolves again upon death. The Hellenistic Jewish philosopher and exegete Philo of Alexandria (ca. 20/10 BCE–45 CE) incorporated this conception and the connected dichotomy of the image of humanity into his interpretation of Gen 2:7, relating the breathing of the breath of life to the invisible

⁴² See Seebaß, 1986.

⁴³ See Pfeiffer, 2001, 3.

⁴⁴ See Rösel, 2009.

soul as an immediate gift from God that constituted the immortal element of humanity (Philo, *Opif.* 135). Theologians influenced by Origen (185–254 CE) have interpreted the verse similarly, with God having made Adam and Eve as souls and having only later provided them with an earthly body, the hide clothing, after their banishment (Gen 3:21). Both the translation as שְׁפָנִים chosen by the LXX and the conception of God making souls in a special way, made possible here from the Greek wording of Gen 1:20f. (“And God said, ‘Let the water bring forth reptiles *with living souls*... and God *made* the great fish and *every soul* of the living reptiles’”), are quite open to such a reading. However, this need not have been the understanding of the translators of the LXX. The Greek ψυχή, translated into English as “soul” and Latin as “*anima*,” had a similar semantic range in Homeric language usage as the Hebrew שְׁפָנִים. An intensive reception of Homer in the Hellenistic period suggests that the translators of the LXX were also oriented to such language use, which was familiar to them and their contemporaries. Also pointing in this direction is the relatively unambiguous translation of the Hebrew נְשָׁמָה with πνοή “breath” or “wind,” which also carries no special meaning. In this respect, it is relatively unclear whether the Septuagint translators wanted Gen 2:7 to be understood (exclusively) in the Platonic sense of the ψυχή, which is often identified with the classical Greek view but nevertheless represents only one particular way.

2:8–17

- 8 *And Yhwh-God planted a garden in Eden in the days of old, far in the east, and there he placed the Human whom he had formed.*
- 9 *And Yhwh-God made sprout from the soil every tree, tempting to behold and good to eat, and the Tree of Life in the midst of the garden, and the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad.*
- 10 *And a stream goes out from Eden in order to water the garden, and from there it divides and becomes four new rivers.*
- 11 *The name of the one is “Pishon.” This is the one flowing around the entire land of Havilah, where the gold is.*
- 12 *And the gold of this land, it is good. There is bdellium and shoham-stone there.*
- 13 *And the name of the second river is “Gihon.” This is the one flowing around the entire land of Cush.*
- 14 *And the name of the third river is “Hiddekel” [Tigris]. This is the one that runs to the east of Assur. And the fourth river, that is the Perat [Euphrates].*
- 15 *Then Yhwh-God took the Human and put him in the Garden of Eden, for him to till and to guard.*
- 16 *And Yhwh-God commanded the Human as follows: “You may absolutely eat from all the trees of the garden,*
- 17 *but from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad – from it you may not eat, for as soon as you eat from it, you must inevitably die.”*

This section deals with the laying out, furnishing, and locating of the Garden, which is to serve as humanity's basis for life and its habitat. Verse 8 gives a summarizing preview of what follows. The first part of the preview, the laying out of the Garden, is unfolded in v. 9, while the second part, the locating of the Garden, takes place in vv. 10–14, and the third part, the conditions of humanity's existence in the Garden, is reported in vv. 15–17. Even despite its clear structure, there are indications of multiple stages of literary growth. The small report about the Paradise Geography in vv. 10–14 is largely considered to be a redactional addition, on grounds of both language and content. The sequence of the participial clauses interrupts the flow of the narrative through a static description of the conditions of the narrative. Furthermore, at least with the mention of the Tigris and the Euphrates, the primordial context is abandoned; the Garden's setting mythically far away (מִקְדָּם) in the land of delight (עֵדֶן) is brought into the historical world – only to immediately leave it again. Verse 15 incorporates the addition into the narrative through its redactional resumption of the statement from v. 8 that Yhwh-God had placed humanity into the Garden. The man's function as a guardian from v. 15, which is much more than was intended by v. 8, is also connected with the addition in Gen 3:24, in which this task is assigned to the cherubs after humanity is banished from the Garden. A much-discussed problem is then the mention of the Tree of Life in v. 9b. As already mentioned (see the above "Formation" section), the question of whether it belongs to the earliest material of the Garden narrative is a matter of much debate. The Tree of Life in v. 9b is often written off as redactional, so that originally, only the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad would have been introduced here. However, syntactically speaking, there is nothing incorrect about the construction of v. 9b. Thus, with the Tree of Life being seen as redactional, what needs to be considered is whether v. 9b as a whole was a later addition. If it was, there is of course the problem that the Tree of Knowledge, which is central to the progression of the narrative, would not be explicitly introduced before its first mention in the speech in v. 17. This problem, however, is tempered by the fact that v. 9* does not do a particularly good job of setting up Yhwh-God's later reference to the Tree of Knowledge, since the identifying clause "in the middle of the garden" (so first in Gen 3:3) is not communicated to the man. Furthermore, introducing important objects or facts through speech is a common stylistic device. In any case, had Gen 2:17 originally spoken of the tree in the middle of the Garden, there would be nothing objectionable about the introduction of this *one* specific tree in the formulation of the prohibition (see above on the formation of Gen 2:4–3:24). A clear decision between the two alternatives of v. 9b being redactional, either as a whole or only in part, is virtually impossible.

2:8–9, 15

- 8** *And Yhwh-God planted a garden in Eden in the days of old, far in the east, and there he placed the Human whom he had formed.*
- 9** *And Yhwh-God made sprout from the soil every tree, tempting to behold and good to eat, and the Tree of Life in the midst of the garden, and the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad.*
- 15** *Then Yhwh-God took the Human and put him in the Garden of Eden, for him to till and to guard.*

Yhwh-God takes it upon himself to provide for humanity's nourishment and sets up a garden. It is an orchard, as was typical for especially Babylonian gardens, in which smaller fruit trees and other useful and ornamental plants blossomed under the shade of larger date palms. It seems that the land around the Garden is fertile but uncultivated (Gen 3:23). Verse 9a emphasizes the diversity as well as the aesthetic and culinary excellence of the trees. Ezekiel 31:8 mentions cedars, cypresses, and sycamores in a comparable context, but gives no mention of fruit trees. As added in v. 9b, standing in the middle of the Garden are two special trees: the Tree of Life (see on Gen 3:22 below) and the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad (see on Gen 2:17 below).

The narrative of the arrangement of a beautiful garden, idyllic to the modern observer, is based on conceptions such as those associated with gardens of ancient Near Eastern palaces and temples.⁴⁵ Kitchen gardens notwithstanding, gardens were the privilege of high-ranking personalities. Iconographic sources from Mesopotamia show walled compounds with shade-giving trees, artificial irrigation, and resting places for the royal garden owners and their entourage. Literary sources document the pride of Neo-Assyrian kings, who present themselves as gardeners. This kind of self-description can even be found in the book of Ecclesiastes, a royal parody from the Hellenistic period telling of King Solomon saying, "I laid out gardens and parks for myself and planted within them all kinds of fruit trees. I made pools of water for myself, from which the sprouting tree forest could be watered" (Eccl 2:5f.). Furthermore, the Hebrew Bible mentions a palace garden of the Judean kings in the late monarchic period (2 Kgs 21:18, 26) in the southern part of the Kidron Valley, on the eastern side of Jerusalem (2 Kgs 25:4; Neh 3:15). It was maintained as a prestigious compound even in the Persian period (Neh 2:8). Archaeologically, there is evidence of a palace complex at Ramat Rahel, which lies

⁴⁵ For an overview, see Carroll-Spillecke, 1992; K. Gleason, 2013. See further regarding Gen 2–3: Stordalen, 2000, 81–183; Jericke, 2001, 161–176.

south of Jerusalem and dates from the late monarchic period and was in use into the Persian period. It included a garden area that may have been as big as 16,000 m² with an elaborate artificial irrigation system.⁴⁶ Next, there are references to Jerusalem having a temple garden (Ps 52:10; 92:13f.; Isa 60:13). The Song of Songs, which offers the most attestations for גַּן “garden” in the Hebrew Bible outside of the Garden narrative and in which the “Beloved” is compared to a garden (Song 4:12–5:1), shows that beyond places of rest and presentation, gardens were regarded as places of manifold delight. Above all, according to numerous Mesopotamian texts, the palace and temple gardens, with their animals and plants brought together from all corners of the respective empires or kingdoms, were meant to reflect the order of Creation. The king thus presents himself as a man of the land who takes care of both flora and fauna. In the Garden narrative, this characteristic of ancient Near Eastern royal ideology is transferred to the primeval humanity, with it being given the task of guarding the Garden (v. 15). This is somewhat reminiscent of the Priestly Creation account, in which statements about the king being the image of the god and about his associated sovereignty over the earth and the animal kingdom are transferred from royal ideology to general anthropology (see above on Gen 1:26f., pp. 77–82). However, this privilege is revoked from humanity in the Garden narrative upon their banishment from Paradise into the reality of its authors and readers. For this reason alone, v. 15 is only very limitedly suitable as the foundation for a theology of Creation about humanity bearing special responsibilities within Creation. Presumably, the idea that humanity is called to watch over Creation, which has been repeatedly expressed in later readings of the passage, would have been incomprehensible to the authors of the Garden narrative or may have even appeared as hubris. It should be kept in mind that, according to v. 15, even humanity’s existence in Paradise was connected with work, despite not involving the experience of futile toil (Gen 3:17–19).

The mythical archetype and intellectual counterpart of the palace and temple gardens are the gardens of the gods. The Garden in Eden is an example of this, with its exclusive, delicious-looking trees and tasty fruits (Gen 2:9), the animals of the field and the birds of the sky (Gen 2:19), its continuous watering (Gen 2:6, 10–14), and its enclosure, including guards (3:24; see 2:15). Accordingly, the term “Eden” is equated in the prophetic tradition with the “Garden of Yhwh” (Isa 51:3; see Gen 13:10) or the “Garden of God” (Ezek 28:13; 31:9). The outcome of the Garden narrative also makes unmistakably clear that the Garden, now guarded by cherubs and thereafter inaccessible for humanity, is a privilege of God.

⁴⁶ Lipschits et al., 2017, 63–94, 108–111.

Within the tradition of the Hebrew Bible, the oracle against the king of Tyre in Ezek 28:11–19 boasts the most extensive similarities in motifs and structure to the depiction of humanity’s stay in the divine garden in Gen 2–3. For its announcement of judgment, the oracle against the king of Tyre draws on motifs from a myth of the royal primordial human being (vv. 11–19) who, after being created (vv. 13, 15), is moved to the Garden of Eden, which sits upon the holy mountain (v. 13) and is where he is to live (v. 14). This primordial man is characterized by his beauty and wisdom (v. 4f., 7, 12) as well as – implicitly – his immortality (v. 10). As the “seal imprint and image full of wisdom and perfect beauty” (v. 12), this primordial man has divine features but falls from grace because of his hubris. He is banished from the presence of God and is thrown down from the divine garden to the earth (vv. 16f.) because he sought to be not only godlike but *actually* God. With this, he also loses all of the privileges that came with being near to God: wisdom, beauty, and immortality (v. 17). The oracle also mentions a cherub, which serves a similar guardian function to that of Gen 3:24 (here vv. 14, 16 – in the singular, unlike in Gen 3:24). Even though there are certain similarities, the differences from Gen 2–3 are unmistakable: The Eden material in Ezek 28 is not part of a myth about the creation of the world; the wisdom of the primordial human being is not acquired through the transgression of a commandment but is given by being close to God and is lost because of doing wrong; Ezekiel reports of only one exceptionally active cherub. The hubris of the king of Tyre is thus contrasted with the naivety of Adam and Eve. These and other differences in both language and content argue against any literary dependence between Ezek 28:11–19 and Gen 2–3. Presumably, both texts take up motifs from a well-known myth, which they reproduce in different ways.⁴⁷

According to Gen 2:8, the Garden is “in Eden” (בְּעֵדֶן; see v. 10 and Gen 4:16), from which the toponym “Garden of Eden” (גֶּן עֵדֶן; see Gen 2:15; 3:23f.) developed in the tradition over the course of time. Otherwise, the Garden narrative speaks merely of “the garden” (2:9, 10, 16; 3:1, 2, 3, 8 [2×], 10). The designation of “Eden” as a territory is often associated with the Aramaic kingdom of Bit-Adini, which sat along the Middle Euphrates (בֵּית עֲדִין in Amos 1:5; בְּעֵדֶן in 2 Kgs 19:12; Isa 37:12; Ezek 27:23). Cited for this is the “in Eden, in the east” (בְּעֵדֶן מִקְדָּם) in v. 8 and the rivers Tigris and Euphrates from the later addition of the Paradise Geography in vv. 10–14, although none of the other river and country names that it mentions can be located in northern Syria (see below on vv. 10–14). Philologically, this connection of Eden to the region of the same name on the Upper Euphrates is possible, but the mythical and symbolic character in how the divine garden is located, as is expressed in the prophetic tradition, should not be overlooked. Another argument against directly associating Gen 2:8 with real geographical conditions is that it lacks any reference point needed for identifying the מִקְדָּם, which is typically translated as “in the east” (so the LXX). This statement is thus incredibly vague, especially since the מִקְדָּם can also bear a temporal

⁴⁷ See Saur, 2008, 317–322.

meaning (see Isa 45:21; 46:10; Mic 5:1; Hab 1:12; Ps 74:2, 12; 77:6, 12; 143:5), as is expressed in the numerous ancient translations and paraphrases of the verse.⁴⁸ The difficulties of the ancient translations in committing to either aspect shows how fluid the boundaries were between spatial and temporal terms in Biblical Hebrew. It seems clear that, according to v. 8, the Garden in Eden lies mythically far away both spatially and temporally, exactly “in the days of old, far in the east” (so also Job 1:3).

The fact that the localization of a place in both real and mythical geographies cannot in principle be excluded and that the toponym in question can be named in separate context-dependent systems of reference can be shown for the ancient Near Eastern concepts of Paradise through the example of the island of Dilmun. It is identified with modern Bahrain in the Persian Gulf, a region with which the states of Mesopotamia maintained trade relationships from early on. Alongside this real geographical use, the freshwater-rich Dilmun also signifies a mythical place. Both temporally and spatially, it is a distant land on the other side of the sea connected with Sumerian creation myths. These myths depict the island as where the world began⁴⁹ and, according to the Sumerian flood narrative, the dwelling place of the immortal hero of the Flood, Ziusudra.⁵⁰

More important for understanding the name “Eden” than its similarity to “Bit-Adini” is what the name itself means. According to other derivations from the common West Semitic root *עֲדָן, it is connected with luxuriance and prosperity (jewelry: 2 Sam 1:24; good food and prosperity: Gen 49:20; Jer 51:34; Lam 4:5; Neh 9:25; sexual pleasure: Gen 18:12; spiritual pleasure: Ps 36:9; paternal pleasure: Prov 29:17; see HAL 3.748f.), which would have made it difficult for the first recipients of the text to miss that Eden is the “land of delight.” Its designation as “Paradise,” which is approximate to this, comes from the LXX. The Greek παράδεισος (Latin *paradisus*) chosen as the equivalent to the Hebrew גֶּן “garden” is, like the Hebrew פֶּרֶדֶס “garden” (only Song 4:13; Eccl 2:5 [parallel to גֶּן “garden”]; Neh 2:8), a Persian loanword (Avestan: *paridaēza* “enclosure; that which is enclosed”) and originally denoted a fenced park. In Koine Greek usage, the word means a protected orchard. This is also the meaning of παράδεισος in the translation of v. 8, although this translation for the somewhat unspecific Hebrew גֶּן may have also been prompted by the description of the orchard in v. 9. The word “paradise” becomes the quintessential term for the ideal state of

⁴⁸ As per the Targums (explicitly Tg. Ps.-J., while Tg. Onq. is formulated openly, similar to the MT), the Jewish recensions of the LXX (Aquila, Symmachus und Theodotion), Pesh, Vulg, and the midrashic Gen. Rab. See Stordalen, 2000, 261–270.

⁴⁹ Cf. the myths of Enki, Ninsikila and Ninchursag, with English translation and short introduction in “Enki and Ninhursag: A Paradise Myth,” trans. Samuel N. Kramer (ANET, 37–41).

⁵⁰ English translation with short introduction in “The Deluge,” trans. Samuel N. Kramer (ANET, 42–44).

Creation and the eschatological place of yearning only through the translation of גֶּן עֵדֶן “Garden of Eden” in Gen 3:23f., where the LXX appropriately translates the toponym “Eden” as τρυφή “luxury, pleasure, delight” and speaks of a “garden of delight” (παράδεισος τῆς τρυφῆς). Even if the paradisiacal conditions have been robustly embellished in its later receptions into Judaism, Christianity, and Islam, the designation of the Garden of Eden as “Paradise” is quite appropriate. Even just the impairment of existence alone, accompanying the banishment from the Garden out into the reality of human life, qualifies it as a counterworld distinguished by an unbroken and blissful closeness to God, as the lost place of the salvific origins – indeed, as Paradise. This also speaks clearly against the assumption that scholars sometimes make that the sober description in Gen 2:8 is a polemic against Canaanite garden and fertility cults.

2:10–14

- 10 *And a stream goes out from Eden in order to water the garden, and from there it divides and becomes four new rivers.*
- 11 *The name of the one is “Pishon.” This is the one flowing around the entire land of Havilah, where the gold is.*
- 12 *And the gold of this land, it is good. There is bdellium and shoham-stone there.*
- 13 *And the name of the second river is “Gihon.” This is the one flowing around the entire land of Cush.*
- 14 *And the name of the third river is “Hiddekel” [Tigris]. This is the one that runs to the east of Assur. And the fourth river, that is the Perat [Euphrates].*

The so-called “Paradise Geography” is a later addition that takes up the “irrigation” theme from v. 6. This was presumably also meant to clarify the difficult term אֵדֶן. The water stream rising from the depths and watering all the ground according to v. 6 is interpreted as the mighty headwaters (see Ps 78:16) of four great rivers. The source originates in Eden, waters the Garden (*שֶׁחִי hi., as in v. 6), and then, probably intended as beyond the Garden, divides into the four separate rivers. Like the English “headwaters,” the rivers are called רִאשִׁים “heads” around their sources, a metaphor also known in Akkadian. Thus, this does not concern the dividing of a river as in the formation of a delta. Rather, one stream becomes the beginning of four new rivers. The underlying concept can be illustrated through an Assyrian ivory inlay from the mid-second millennium BCE. It depicts a mountain god with a vessel in his hands, out of which four rivers flow in four different directions.⁵¹ This

⁵¹ See Keel, 1997, 118 with Fig. 153a.

is one of many depictions from the ancient Near East showing the cosmic waters flowing out into four rivers. In some cases, they also make reference to real, earthly geography. The number “four” here is an expression of completeness, as in the Bible⁵² – and has even been preserved in the modern division of four cardinal directions. This aspect of geographic completeness and the fact that the latter two rivers, the Tigris (תִּדְקָל) and the Euphrates, are easy to identify, aim at the conceptual claim that the rivers of the world originate in the stream that waters Paradise.⁵³ That being said, identifying the two other rivers and understanding the cosmological dimensions of its geographic conception have always caused large problems (for the toponyms, see the corresponding entries in odb [D. Jericke]). It almost seems as if the authors of Gen 2:10–14 have also partially entered uncharted territory, since the geographic descriptions all turn out to be quite different from each other. The Euphrates is a well-known quantity in the Hebrew Bible, with 19 references to it, so the mention of merely its name is sufficient. Regarding the Tigris (תִּדְקָל), otherwise mentioned only in Dan 10:4, it simply mentions that it flows to the east of Assur. This accords with the real geography of the city, which lies on the right (western) bank of the Tigris. However, the other 136 references to “Assur” do not otherwise explicitly mean the city (in the Hebrew Bible, Nineveh is always mentioned as the capital of the Neo-Assyrian empire) but always the Assyrian empire as a whole. Since the other references to locations in Gen 2:10–14 refer to countries, it is rather the political entity or – more likely – the entire country, lying on both sides of the Tigris, that is meant in the case of “Assur.” From the perspective of Israel, the Tigris is east of Assyria’s western border, so that here, “Assyria” is depicted as all Mesopotamia, the land between the Euphrates (see Isa 7:20) and the Tigris. In this respect, the geographic conception is halfway coherent.

The two other rivers, the Pishon (vv. 11–12) and the Gihon (v. 13) are described in much more detail. This is the only mention of the Pishon in the Hebrew Bible. The LXX simply transliterates the name, making it seem that, unlike the toponyms in vv. 12–14, it had no possible way of identifying it. If anything, the geographic conception connected with the river name can be ascertained from how it says that the Pishon flowed around the land of Havilah, which was blessed with valuable mineral resources. Since “Havilah” here bears a definite article, the word is being used appellatively and means in general “the land of sand” (so חוּל “sand”). As a toponym, Havilah is found two more times in the Hebrew Bible, specifically in the phrase “From Havilah to Shur.” This phrase describes the area settled by the Ishmaelites

⁵² See Isa 11:12 “four corners of the world”; Jer 49:36, “four ends of the heavens”; Jer 49:36; Ezek 37:9; Zech 6:5, “four heavenly winds”; see Gunkel, 8.

⁵³ See Westermann, 216.

(Gen 25:18) and the Amalekites (1 Sam 15:7). Both peoples are thus characterized as nomadic groups who are at home to the south of the cultivated land of Palestine. Since “Shur” is located around Egypt’s strongly fortified western border in the eastern Nile Delta (Gen 25:18; 1 Sam 15:7), this area likely lies east of the Egyptian border, thereby encompassing the sand-covered regions in the western part of the Arabian Peninsula and the coastline opposite it on the Red Sea. The mention of the eponym “Havilah” in the Table of Nations, listed once as the son of Cush and grandson of Ham (Gen 10:7) and once as the son of Joktan and grandson of Shem (Gen 10:29), fits well with this. This double paternity is conspicuous and speaks for multiple authors with slightly different geographic conceptions, with Havilah being located either to the east or to the west of the Red Sea. This ambiguity within the tradition may have resulted from the close economic and political relationships between the southwestern Arabian Peninsula and the East African areas west of the Red Sea, even to the present day. The statement about the country’s great wealth also fits into this picture, despite the uncertainty: A tempting connection is the mention of the “good gold” in the land of Havilah with the “land of gold,” Ophir. The Hebrew Bible repeatedly extolls the gold from Ophir as particularly valuable, and in the Table of Nations, Ophir appears as the son of Joktan and the brother of Havilah (Gen 10:29). The location of Ophir is, admittedly, no more secure than that of the legendary El Dorado in South America. Nevertheless, it is reported that Ophir gold was imported by sea via the Gulf of Aqaba (1 Kgs 22:49), which in turn points again to the region around the Red Sea (possibly Nubia or the southwestern coast of the Arabian Peninsula?). Alongside the “good gold,” v. 11 mentions “bed-olah” resin and “shoham” stone. The term *בְּדֹלַח* is only elsewhere attested in Num 11:7. Following the ancient translations, it seems to be connected with bdellium, the yellowish resin of the balsam tree (*Commiphora opobalsamum*) from southern Arabia and Somaliland that turns golden-brown after hardening and was used as incense. A mineralogical identification of the *šōham* stone (see also Exod 25:7; 28:9, 20; 35:9, 27; 39:6, 13; Ezek 28:13; Job 28:16; 1 Chr 29:2) is difficult. The linguistic similarity to the Akkadian *sāmtu* “red,” which can also denote a carnelian, may speak in favor of this coral-red gem. It can be found in Egypt between the Nile and the Red Sea, in the eastern parts of the Arabian Peninsula, and in the Sinai, as well as in the Hindu Kush and the Iranian plateau.

It is difficult to distinguish the *šōham* stone from the *’ōdāem* stone of the same color (Exod 28:17; 39:10; Ezek 28:13; so **אֲדָם* “to be red”). The *’ōdāem* may be a ruby, a red corundum, a spinel, or, following the ancient translations, sard, a reddish-brown subtype of carnelian. In Gen 2:12, the LXX renders “*šōham* stone” as *ὁ λίθος ὁ πράσινος* “light-green stone,” which matches its translation as *σμαράγδος* “emerald” (Exod 28:9; 35:27; 36:13) or *βηρύλλιον* “beryl” (Exod 28:20; 36:20) and roughly

agrees with Josephus's (not entirely consistent) description of the breastplate of the high priest following Exod 28:17–20; 39:10–13. However, the LXX also translates it elsewhere as σαρδίον “sard” (Exod 25:7; 35:9) and ὄνυξ “onyx” (Job 28:16).

Thus, the indications of the valuableness of the land at least do not speak against searching for the land of Havilah in the southwest of the Arabian Peninsula and its neighboring regions, following the other evidence in the Hebrew Bible. Decisive for the understanding of the geographic conception in Gen 2:10–14 may be that ancient Israel perceived the east and south of the circumscribed area as only (a single body of) water. The river Pishon, which flows around the land of Havilah, may therefore be identified geographically with the actual seas surrounding the Arabian Peninsula (the Persian Gulf, Indian Ocean, and Red Sea), but it should be seen at the same time as the waters at the southeastern edge of the world. These meanings of “(primordial) streams” and “(cosmic) sea” converge with each other, as attested elsewhere (so Hab 3:8–10). Moreover, they also have a remarkable parallel in a world map from the Late Babylonian period.⁵⁴ This map shows the world from a bird's-eye view with Babylon at the center. The four regions of the world are surrounded by a body of water that, like the Persian Gulf, is called *ḫmarratu* “the bitter river,” a combination of “river” and “(saltwater) sea.”⁵⁵ Of course, with a broadened geographical horizon, the understanding of the “Paradise Geography” changes. Thus, a few Targums (Tg. Ps.-J. and Tg. Neof. on v. 11) identify the land of Havilah with India, which in turn fits with the identification of the Pishon with the Ganges by the Judeo-Roman historian Flavius Josephus, who was active in the first century CE. As another example, Ephrem the Syrian in the fourth century CE thought of the Donau.

The name of the second river, “Gihon,” otherwise signifies in the Hebrew Bible a spring located in the Kidron Valley east of Jerusalem (1 Kgs 1:33, 38, 45; 2 Chr 32:20; 33:14), which is today the Fountain of the Virgin. The LXX makes a distinction here by rendering the name of the river as Γηων and the name of the Jerusalem spring as Γιωβ. The Γηων chosen for Gen 2:13 is found elsewhere as a translation of גִּיחֹן, an eastern branch of the Nile that can also stand *pars pro toto* for the entire Nile (so Jer 2:18; Sir 24:27). If the Γηων is the result of the LXX identifying the “Gihon” with the Nile, then this would also fit with its rendering of גִּישׁ, also mentioned in Gen 2:13, as Αἰθιοπίας. This then agrees with the usage in the Hebrew Bible of Cush consistently referring to Nubia, located to the south of the First Cataract, as well as its inhabitants. From the perspective of the Paradise Geography

⁵⁴ See Unger, 1970, Pl. 3; Horowitz, 2011, 20–42; see further Pongratz-Leisten, 2001, 274–276.

⁵⁵ See Stordalen, 2000, 279.

authors, Cush may have been located at the southernmost end of the world (see Ezek 29:10; Esth 1:1; 8:9). Herodotus expresses similarly that Cush/Ethiopia is located on the “Southern Sea” at the end of the world (*Hist.* 3.17, 25). One of the few controversial pieces of evidence for Cush is found, of all places, in the Garden narrative’s immediate literary context. In the Table of Nations, Cush is listed as the father of Nimrod, the builder of the Mesopotamian cities (Gen 10:8). It has been concluded from this that the “Cush” in Gen 2:13 is meant to designate the settlement area of the Kassites, in the Zagros Mountains to the north of Elam.⁵⁶ However, the “Kassite” reading of Gen 10:8 has been rightfully called into question (see pgs. 380–85 on Gen 10:6, 8–12 below) and should be ruled out for use in understanding the Paradise Geography. Should the connection with Cush speak for identifying the Gihon with the Nile, or – more likely – with one of its headwaters, which were largely unexplored even into the nineteenth century, then the question would still remain of why the authors did not use the typical name of the Nile (נִיְלוֹ). The clearest explanation is that the name was meant to allude to the Jerusalem spring. By paralleling the Gihon Spring with the Nile (but cf. Sir 24:27) and upgrading it to a “river” – which may seem bold from the modern perspective – the city of God (and its temple) is connected with Paradise, entangling Paradise and the mythical primordial times with the present experienced world. The Gihon Spring thus becomes the stream bringing pleasure to the city of God (Ps 46:5; see also Ps 36:9) and expected by the late prophetic texts to gush out eastward from the temple, spread out into a mighty body of water, and even turn the Dead Sea into freshwater (Ezek 17:1–12; see also Joel 4:18; Zech 14:8). The description of Eden as the source of the four world rivers characterizes the Garden as a fertility-bringing middle point of the world. Through the mention of the Gihon, the concept of Paradise is related to Jerusalem and its temple.⁵⁷ This entanglement in symbolic geography between Paradise and Temple (Mount) can be seen even into the Islamic period.⁵⁸ The geographic objections typically raised overlook the symbolic and literary character of the Paradise Geography (as well as related texts and visual representations) and may fail to consider the enormous increase in knowledge that came with “measuring the world” in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries: Alexander the Great considered the Indus to be the source of the Nile (Arrian, *Anab.* 6.1, 3), and the Greek geographer Pausanias, active in the second century CE, referenced the opinion that the Euphrates sinks into the marshland and reemerges in Ethiopia as the Nile (Pausanias, *Descr.* 2.5.3).

⁵⁶ See Dietrich, 2001, 313f.

⁵⁷ See Görg, 1977, 31f.; Witte, 1998, 266–269.

⁵⁸ See Livne-Kafri, 2006.

Time and again, because of the mentions of the Tigris and the Euphrates, there have been attempts at locating Eden in Mesopotamia and its adjacent regions.⁵⁹ The basis for this is the locating of the Garden “in the east” (v. 8; however, cf. above on מִקְדָּם), the Mesopotamian coloring of the Garden narrative, and the order of the Tigris and the Euphrates. This order goes from east to west and could presumably suggest that the two rivers mentioned before them lie further to the east, for example, in Iran or India. However, it is conceivable that the Pishon was mentioned first as the most unfamiliar and furthest away of the rivers, and that the Gihon, pointing to Jerusalem, was to be given a central position in v. 13a.⁶⁰ Most problematic, however, is that all of the “eastern Mesopotamian” solutions that are proposed in the discussion are forced to propose locations for the toponyms “Cush” and “Havilah” (as well as “Gihon”), which are all well attested across the Hebrew Bible, that are not compatible with the other biblical attestations of these names – all without reaching a philologically unambiguous identification of the otherwise unattested “Pishon.” Sometimes, there are conjectures that the authors of the Paradise Geography used the names “Cush” and “Havilah” (and “Gihon”) out of ignorance of the local names, which at the same time “relocated” them. However, such a fix cannot save the “eastern Mesopotamian” solution.

2:16–17

- 16** *And Yhwh-God commanded the Human as follows: “You may absolutely eat from all the trees of the garden,*
17 *but from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad – from it you may not eat, for as soon as you eat from it, you must inevitably die.”*

Verse 15 again takes up the “Garden” theme as a redactional parenthesis, and so it seems that originally, v. 16f. immediately followed v. 9a (or v. 9b*). Following after the establishment of the Garden, this now concerns the conditions of human existence within the Garden. Yhwh-God confers to humanity, whom he created, the privilege of living in his garden and nourishing themselves from the Garden’s trees (Gen 2:16; 3:2), which are “tempting to behold and good to eat” (v. 9a). It is merely the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge (Gen 2:17) in the middle of the Garden (Gen 3:3) that is denied to the human beings, through an unambiguous prohibition (Gen 2:17; 3:3). This juxtaposition is set entirely for the sake of the prohibition and looks ahead to its transgression by Adam and Eve and the consequent progression of the narrative. Given the generous allowance of all fruits, it weighs even heavier that the pair eat, of all things, the *single* fruit withheld from them,⁶¹ especially since the prohibition comes under penalty of death. In the Hebrew Bible, the

⁵⁹ See Hölscher, 1949, 35–44; Dietrich, 2001.

⁶⁰ Görg, 1997, 25f.

⁶¹ von Rad, 80.

Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad is mentioned only in the Garden narrative, specifically in Gen 2:9b, 17. Otherwise, the Garden narrative simply refers to it as “the tree in the middle of the garden.” Since the function and identification of the tree are clear everywhere except where it competes with the Tree of Life, it should also be considered that it was inserted secondarily in Gen 2:9b along with the Tree of Life and was only later made recognizable in v. 17 as the “Tree of Knowledge.”⁶²

There is not yet any evidence of a “Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad” anywhere within the rest of the literature of the ancient Near East. However, the larger tradition of the motif of a special tree in the middle of a garden can be illuminated by the Eden texts in the book of Ezekiel.⁶³ According to Ezek 31:1–9, “all trees in Eden, in the divine garden” are envious of a special tree whose roots reach into the primordial spring (תְּהוֹם; see Gen 1:2) and whose crown reaches into the clouds. This tree, which is the shelter of the birds of the sky, the animals of the field, and the great peoples, is the World Tree attested in the mythological traditions of many cultures. In ancient Near Eastern texts, the World Tree is sometimes depicted as a tree made of gemstones, which in turn is reminiscent of the second text about Eden in the book of Ezekiel, in Ezek 28:11–19, in which the divine garden is described as a garden of gemstones (so Ezek 28:13, 14, 16). One of the closest parallels is a passage from the Epic of Gilgamesh in which Gilgamesh, on his journey to the world beyond, reaches a garden of fairytale-like gemstone trees. The description of the trees displays a clear closeness to the fruit of the tree in the Garden narrative: “A carnelian tree was in fruit, hung with bunches of grapes, *lovely to look on*. A lapis lazuli tree bore foliage, in full fruit and *gorgeous to gaze on*” (Gilgm 9.173–176; see also Gen 3:6). The tradition of a World Tree thus seems to have been an integral part of the Eden texts, which makes it likely that the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad (Gen 2:17) in the middle of the Garden (Gen 3:3) corresponds to this. Other motifs fit well with it as well, specifically the snake that suddenly appears (Gen 3:1) and, according to one part of the Gilgamesh tradition, lives in the roots of the World Tree, just like the idea of the Garden as a living space for the birds of the air and all the wild animals (Gen 2:19f.*; also Ezek 17:23; 31:6; Dan 4:7–9). Conversely, the grasping of the fruits of the World Tree enabling humanity to first recognize good and bad is an entirely independent interpretation of the tradition of the World Tree by the Garden narrative’s Scholarly Narrator. In the literature of the ancient Near East, it is otherwise only attested that (violent) contact with the World Tree

⁶² See Gese, 1973, 77f.; Witte, 1998, 81 and above on the formation of Gen 2:4–3:24.

⁶³ See Müller, 1990; Pfeiffer, 2001, 4–7.

(see Gen 3:3) can lead to royal dominion or the loss thereof.⁶⁴ The connection with kingship is therefore of interest, since the “wisdom of God’s messenger to know all that is on earth” (2 Sam 14:20) and “to hear what is good and what is bad” (2 Sam 14:17) is, even in the view of the Hebrew Bible, primarily a privilege of kings (1 Kgs 3:9).

Yet, what exactly is the “knowledge of good and bad” (הַדַּעַת טוֹב וָרָע)? In readings of the passage throughout history, there have primarily been advocations for a sexual⁶⁵ or – even more frequently – a moral⁶⁶ interpretation. The sexual interpretation can invoke the discovery of nakedness and shame in the fig-leaf scene, which is clearly reminiscent of the processes during adolescence (Gen 3:7). Moreover, the verb *יָדַע “to know” is also used in the immediate literary context for sexual intercourse between Adam and Eve (see on Gen 4:1). Citable for the moral interpretation is Adam and Eve’s manifestly bad conscience in light of the cognitive faculty that they gained from breaking a commandment (Gen 3:8–13). Both aspects are clearly in view, but the “knowledge of good and bad” is limited to neither sexual nor moral knowledge. The pair of opposites in “good and bad” is also not to be understood as a merism in the sense of “omniscience.”⁶⁷ As expressed in the other attestations in the Hebrew Bible (Deut 1:39f.; 2 Sam 19:36; 1 Kgs 3:9; Isa 7:15f.; see also 1QSa 1.10f. = DSS I.112f.), it concerns the ability, stretching throughout all areas of life, to distinguish on one’s own accord between what is conducive to life and what is detrimental to it and to act accordingly.⁶⁸ This idiomatic expression signifies the “power of judgment of the mature person,”⁶⁹ as something that children do not yet have (Deut 1:39f.; Isa 7:15f.; Heb 5:14) and as is threatened to be lost in old age (2 Sam 19:36; also Eccl 4:13; Job 32:9).

The prohibition against eating from the Tree of Knowledge is reinforced under penalty of death. The wording leaves no doubt about the gravity of the prohibition. The stylistic device of the *figura etymologica*, which connects the inf. abs. of the root מוֹת “to die” with a finite form of the same verb (מוֹת תָּמוּת) serves to emphasize the immutability of the threatened punishment. Yet, how should this threat of death be understood? The question is provoked by how the man and his woman do not die after the discovery of the

⁶⁴ References in Pfeiffer, 2001, 9f.

⁶⁵ So most recently Rottzoll, 1990; Müller, 1990, 168–174 (as one of many aspects of the knowledge and with reference to the erotic connotations of the description of the Tree of Knowledge and its fruit in Gen 2:9; 3:6).

⁶⁶ So Budde, 1883, 69f.; *ibid.*, 1932, 41f., 53–55 (in discussion with the interpretation as “pragmatic knowledge” established by Wellhausen).

⁶⁷ So von Rad, 81.

⁶⁸ See Wellhausen, 1905, 299–301; Westermann, 240–248 (with references to the history of interpretation); Alberty, 1992 14–16.

⁶⁹ Blum, 2004, 21 [translation JWR].

transgression but are released into life outside of the Garden (Gen 3:23). The traditional interpretation, which was already around in early Judaism and in the New Testament (see v. 17 in Symmachus's LXX recension: "mortal" θνητός; see further Wis 2:23; Rom 5:12–21; 8:18–22) and predominant in Protestantism even into the nineteenth century, therefore understood the threat of death as the threat of mortality for a humanity that had been created as immortal. In this understanding, Yhwh-God neither bluffs nor takes back his threat. Conversely, in this, by disputing the consequence being death, the snake's deception of the woman lies in how it simply does not tell her the entire truth (Gen 3:4): As promised, humanity does not die after eating of the forbidden fruit, but it still loses its immortality. Alongside the expected correspondence of the divine word with the divine deed, it can be noted in favor of this reading that *בַּיּוֹם*, like in Gen 2:4b, can function as a temporal conjunction and need not designate a specific point in time. Moreover, the punishments end with an explicit reference to humanity's mortality.⁷⁰ Nevertheless, speaking against this reading is the fact that the words of judgment do not characterize death as a consequence of transgressing the commandment. Rather, they justify death through humanity's physical constitution: Formed from the soil (Gen 3:19a) and dust (Gen 3:19b [R]), humanity was from the outset created as a mortal being, like the animals (see Gen 2:7). Accordingly, the reproduction of life, and with it the reverse side of the reality of natural death, is already addressed before the commandment is transgressed and the transgression is discovered (see Gen 2:24f.). Finally, the wording of the threat in Gen 2:17 speaks rather for a death sentence at the time (*בַּיּוֹם*) of the transgression or of its discovery rather than for the threat of mortality.⁷¹ Comparable to this is God's threat to Abimelech, uttered in a dream, that he and his people would come to death (*תָּמוּת מוֹת*) should he not give Sarah back to Abraham (Gen 20:6–7), after which Abimelech obeys, saving himself and his people from death. The situation is different with Shimei, who is placed under house arrest. As soon as (*בַּיּוֹם*) Solomon leaves the area to which he is assigned, Solomon threatens him with death (*תָּמוּת מוֹת*), which is then carried out (1 Kgs 2:46). Accordingly, the formulation *תָּמוּת מוֹת* can also be used to proclaim a death sentence (1 Sam 14:44; 22:26; Jer 26:8), while clauses about death verdicts formulated through the impersonal variant in the 3rd pers. pass. are used to call for the death penalty in cases of particularly serious crimes and breaches of taboos (see Exod 21:12, 15, 17: "The one who ... must absolutely die of death [*מוֹת יוֹמָת*]). Contrary

⁷⁰ Gen 3:19; so recently Blum, 2004, 22–24. On the opposite position, see Schmid, 2008, 58–78.

⁷¹ How a general limitation of the human lifetime can be expressed in Hebrew is shown in Gen 6:3. Cf. Blum, 2004, 23.

to what might be expected with the certain and unconditional wording in Gen 2:17, the death penalty is not exacted. Instead, Yhwh-God reacts to Adam and Eve breaking the commandment by impairing the conditions of human existence (see Gen 3:16–19). In contrast to the death penalty that was threatened, the decreed impairment appears as an act of mercy,⁷² despite the whole existence of humanity thereafter coming to stand under the shadow of falling into death (see Gen 3:19). In light of the transgression of the divine commandment, the “creaturely death”⁷³ becomes a threatening, frightful event that is present throughout a person’s entire life. In this sense, death is the “wages of sin” (Rom 6:23).⁷⁴ With the presumably redactional addition of the Tree of Life (Gen 2:9; 3:22, 24), the emphases are shifted: The banishment of humanity from the Garden of Eden henceforth denies humanity, who is mortal even in the original order of Creation, access to the Tree of Life and, therefore, to godlike immortality; by breaking the commandment, humanity forfeits the possibility of eternal life (see on Gen 3:22, 24 below).

2:18–25

- 18 *Then Yhwh-God said, “It is not good that the Human is alone; I shall make for him a help that corresponds to him.”*
- 19 *Then Yhwh-God formed from the soil every animal of the field and all the birds of the heavens and brought [them] to the Human in order to see what he would name each, and what the Human named each as a living being, so would it be called.*
- 20 *And the Human gave names to all the livestock and the birds of the heavens and all the animals of the field, but for the Human no help was found that would have corresponded to him.*
- 21 *Then Yhwh-God made a deep sleep fall over the Human, so that he fell asleep. Then he took one of his ribs and closed its place with flesh.*
- 22 *And Yhwh-God built the rib that he had taken from the Human into a Woman. And he brought her to the Human.*
- 23 *Then, the Human said, “This is finally bone of my bone and flesh of my flesh; she shall be called ‘Woman,’ for she was taken from Man.”*
- 24 *Therefore a man will leave his father and his mother, and he will cling to his woman, and they will become one flesh.*
- 25 *And they both were naked, the Human and his Woman, and they were not ashamed of each other.*

⁷² Gunkel, 10.

⁷³ Härle, 1995, 488 [translation JWR].

⁷⁴ The statements in Gertz, 2004, 230f. and fn. 42 are to be corrected accordingly.

There is an imperceptible increase in tension with the prohibition against eating from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad. In principle, humanity has the faculties for the knowledge of good and bad, but this remains denied to them for the time being. Instead, the Creator God's knowledge of what is good for humanity takes centerstage. His judgment that it is "not good" for the man to be alone (v. 18) leads to the creation of first the animals (vv. 19–20) and ultimately the woman (vv. 21–23). Only with the creation of the woman is the creation of humanity completed (vv. 24–25). Yhwh-God's solicitous observation that "it is not good" results in good consequences for the man. The scene may seem at first like the positive counterpart to both the immediately preceding prohibition against eating from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Bad and the human knowledge of good and bad, since humanity's first decision between the two ends in fratricide (Gen 4:6–8).⁷⁵ However, the Scholarly Narrator paints a much more nuanced picture, with the man explicitly being involved in deciding on an appropriate counterpart (vv. 20b, 23) and there being ambiguous aspects in the description of human existence even from the outset (v. 25).

2:18

Then Yhwh-God said, "It is not good that the Human is alone; I shall make for him a help that corresponds to him."

As wonderfully equipped as the Garden is, humanity being alone cannot be seen as "good," per the judgment of the Creator God. Humanity is designed as a social being and, therefore, the man needs his equal as a counterpart. Neither in paradisiacal coexistence with Yhwh-God nor – as will be proven – communion with the animals is the man able in the long run to bear his loneliness, nor in the loneliness is he able to bear himself. In Yhwh-God's announcement that he wants "a help" (עֵזֶר) to join the man, the state of being alone is equated with helplessness,⁷⁶ as is explained in the aphorism of Ecclesiastes for the realities of everyday life: "Two have it better than one alone, for they have a good reward for their toil. When they fall, the one can help their companion up. But woe to whoever is alone and falls, and no one is there to help them up. Two are also warm when they lay down to sleep. But one alone, how can they become warm? And if one overpowers someone who is alone, two can withstand them" (Eccl 4:9–12a). In the various interpretations throughout history, the announcement of a "help" has repeatedly been reduced to the perspective of the sexual complementarity in the

⁷⁵ Emphasized primarily by Steck, 1982, 80.

⁷⁶ von Rad, 82, also with reference to Ecclesiastes.

conception of children (Aug., *Gen.lit.* 9.9) or assistance in (field and garden) work. However, such an understanding, which implies the subjugation of the woman as the man's helper, can be ruled out based on both the result (see on Gen 2:23, 24 below) and the wording. In the Hebrew Bible, the term עֲזָרָה denotes the kind of help given mostly during (military) emergencies, with most of the attestations being given through God himself (see only Deut 33:29; Ps 121:1f.; 146:5). Furthermore, the subsequent explication that the help for the man should “correspon[d] to him” (כִּנְגַדּוֹ; from a prepositional noun נֹגַד “opposite, counterpart, face, front”) speaks against an asymmetrical relationship between the man and the help being sought. In the present context, the phrase involves aspects of both difference and completion, thus highlighting that “help” as an equal counterpart brings an end to humanity being lonely.⁷⁷ The man and his help are to face each other on equal terms. In light of and in distinction to how the passage has been interpreted throughout history, this can be read as an objection to the idea of woman being subordinated to man as allegedly written into the order of Creation (cf. only 1 Cor 11:7–12). It cannot be excluded that the explicatory כִּנְגַדּוֹ was originally also intended to level out the actual superiority of the help implicit in the term עֲזָרָה.⁷⁸

2:19–20

- 19** *Then Yhwh-God formed from the soil every animal of the field and all the birds of the heavens and brought [them] to the Human in order to see what he would name each, and what the Human named each as a living being, so would it be called.*
- 20** *And the Human gave names to all the livestock and the birds of the heavens and all the animals of the field, but for the Human no help was found that would have corresponded to him.*

The search for a solution to humanity's loneliness leads to the creation of woman only after a few detours. Yhwh-God working through trial-and-error is a beautiful narrative move, which attests to the narrative joy and dramaturgical faculties of the Scholarly Narrator. Moreover, it provides him the opportunity to answer the important question of humanity's relationship to the animals and to clarify the question of the nature and fate of an appropriate counterpart for the man. God first creates the animals, specifically the land animals and birds. The fish go unmentioned, since, from the perspective of ancient Israel, they are from the outset not considered to be companions of

⁷⁷ See (among many) von Rad, 82; Steck, 1982, 91.

⁷⁸ See Schellenberg, 2011, 193.

humanity. Crawling animals are also missing, since they do not yet exist at this point in the story (see 3:14). The animals are, like the human being, formed (*יצר; see Gen 2:7) from the soil (אֲדָמָה). The fact that, unlike with humanity, the story does not specifically mention them being brought to life does not indicate a distinctive feature in the sense of a hierarchization of the created beings, although the existence of such is indisputable (see below). Due to the economy of the storytelling, like in the listing of the created animals, it tells only of what is relevant for the progression of the narrative regarding humanity: the forming of the animals from the soil. Even if Yhwh-God, in the search for a counterpart for the man, initially resorts to the procedure established when creating him, from the outset, there is never a thought about a second “Adam” as a counterpart, nor does the same original material guarantee that the animals are a fitting counterpart. The biological material makes animals the fellow creatures of humanity, no more and no less (see also Eccl 3:18–21). An equal counterpart needs to be recognized as such by the man. For this reason, Yhwh-God brings the animals to the man, leaving him to name them (v. 19a) and thus possibly to identify them as his counterpart (v. 20a). However, the man refrains from recognizing the animals as such. Rather, it is the naming of the animals by the man that is emphasized, as is the aspect expressed therein of humanity’s participation in the divine exercising of dominion (see Ps 147:4; Isa 40:26).⁷⁹ It receives a special significance in the context of the Creation story, since this is not just the naming of specific individuals but of species and kinds, all of which Yhwh-God then confirms (v. 19b). The classification, appropriation, and empowerment of Creation through humanity addressed therein is illustrated beautifully in a minor oddity in the text, probably caused by a later addition. While it speaks at the beginning of only the creation of all the living beings of the field (חַיֵּי הַשָּׂדֶה) and all the birds of the heavens (v. 19a), after being named by the man, they are subdivided into livestock, birds, and animals of the field (v. 20a). This order is oriented around the human perspective: The mention of the livestock, which was probably a later addition, alongside all of the other living creatures of the field suggests that the latter is intended to signify only wild animals. Following the naming is the statement that no help for the man was found, although this goes unjustified. Even if the animals were formed from the soil from the intention to give the man a counterpart, the judgment in no way marks the creation of the animals as a failed act of creation by a God who is working somewhat helplessly in this respect.⁸⁰ Rather, the judgment about the man naming his fellow creatures and the designations that come with it show “that the man is autonomous within a certain limited

⁷⁹ See Schellenberg, 2011, 197–199 and fn. 68.

⁸⁰ So Schüle, 68; less pointedly Gunkel, 12.

area.”⁸¹ Although the necessary recognition as a counterpart is denied to the animals, it happens in the case of the woman, who was also created by God and brought to the man, to both spontaneous and exuberant jubilation (v. 23). The fate of Enkidu, who was formed out of clay, provides a correspondingly opposite case from the Epic of Gilgamesh. He once lived together with the wild animals, as if he were a steppe animal himself. Through intercourse with the prostitute Šamkat, he is brought into human society and becomes a stranger to the animals, so that they go away from him and expel him from their own society (Gilgm 1.195–198; see also on Gen 3:7 below).

2:21–23

- 21 *Then Yhwh-God made a deep sleep fall over the Human, so that he fell asleep. Then he took one of his ribs and closed its place with flesh.*
 22 *And Yhwh-God built the rib that he had taken from the Human into a Woman. And he brought her to the Human.*
 23 *Then, the Human said, “This is finally bone of my bone and flesh of my flesh; she shall be called ‘Woman,’ for she was taken from Man.”*

With the creation of the woman, not only the search for a suitable counterpart but also the creation of humanity as a whole reaches its goal. God sends the man into a deep sleep (תַּרְדֵּמָה), takes from him a rib (צֵלַע), closes the wound with flesh (v. 21), and, analogous to a craftsman, builds (*בָּנָה) a woman from the rib, whom he brings to the man as he did the animals before her (v. 22). The sleep, which is denoted by תַּרְדֵּמָה, describes a narcotic state that limits one’s cognition (so 1 Sam 26:12). More important than the medical aspect, however, is that the expression is usually connected with a miraculous divine intervention that is meant to stay hidden from the human actors, including the readers (see Gen 15:12; Isa 29:10; Job 4:13; 33:15). Accordingly, the narrative’s presentation of itself is only “realistic” at first glance.⁸² This putative “realism” has been presupposed in various interpretations throughout history, which have noticed that many details were lacking, such as the woman being brought to life or the origin of the flesh needed for the man’s wound or the constitution of the woman, and which have read them into the text accordingly. However, the narrator was hardly interested in such questions, and in any case, there is no traditional conception of “creation” in the creation of the woman from the rib. The extraordinary position of this motif within the biblical tradition can also be seen through the word choice. The term צֵלַע, translated here as “rib” in accordance with the ancient translations, is generally used in the sense of “side” or denotes

⁸¹ Westermann, 228.

⁸² Steck, 1982, 82.

construction materials, like the boards of cedar used in the construction of the temple (צִלְעוֹת אֲרָזִים; 1 Kgs 6:15f.; see also 1 Kgs 7:3). Conversely, the Akkadian *ṣēlu(m)* can also serve as an anatomical term for the ribs of humans and animals. The widely attested verb *בנה is found in the Hebrew Bible only once in a creationary context, where it refers to the construction of the upper chambers of the heavens (Amos 9:6) and corresponds to the rest of its usage. Here too, reference can be made to the Akkadian, where *banû(m)* “to create, build” is typical creationary vocabulary. This terminological evidence has been taken as an indication for a historical connection of both the tradition and the motif to Mesopotamian love songs, in which the poet compares the beloved with a figurine of the finest material. In this, the special vitality of the figurines in the songs are seen as an explanation for why Gen 2:21–22 does not specifically mention the woman coming to life.⁸³ However, this derivation is problematic and unnecessary, since it lacks identifiable steps mediating the naming, and the special features of Gen 2:21–23 specifically cannot be explained with reference to the love songs: The songs allude to the figurines coming alive, but above all, they do not sing about the material for the figurines having been taken from the poet. Rather, this detail, which has no analogy in any of the known creation texts from the ancient Near East, can be explained only from its context. It has been pulled from the “jubilant welcoming, the Song of Adam,”⁸⁴ in which the man identifies the woman as his bone and flesh, and thus as a suitable counterpart (v. 23).⁸⁵ Standing behind the first sentence of the exultation, which is already marked by its rhythmic form as the climax and end point of the creation of humanity, is the so-called “kinship formula,” with which “kinship was affirmed and acknowledged toward a stranger and emphasized toward an acquaintance”⁸⁶ (v. 23a; see Gen 29:14 אָתָּה וּבִשְׁרִי אֶתָּה “you are my bone and my flesh”; further 2 Sam 5:1; 19:13, 14; 1 Chr 11:1). The formula here has been slightly modified. The introductory “This is finally” emphasizes the difference from the animals, which had already previously been created and brought to the man. The doubling of “bone” and “flesh” and the addition of the preposition “of/from” (וּבִשְׁרִי מִבְּשָׁרִי “bone of my bone and flesh of my flesh”) emphasizes both the physical origin of the woman from the man and the fact that they belong together.⁸⁷ The joyful assessment of their physical correspondence is followed by an etiology of the name (v. 23b), recognizing the “Woman” (אִשָּׁה) as the counterpart to the man, which relatedly marks the shift from using the gender-neutral generic

⁸³ Uehlinger, 1988; ibd., 1998; for criticism, see also Bühner, 2014, 228ff.

⁸⁴ Herder, 1827, 47 [translation JWR].

⁸⁵ See, e.g., Steck, 1982, 83; Blum, 2004, 12.

⁸⁶ Reiser, 1960, 3 [translation JWR].

⁸⁷ Levin, 1993, 85.

term “human” (אָדָם) to using “man” (אִישׁ).⁸⁸ The “human” (אָדָם) perceives his counterpart as a “woman” (אִשָּׁה) and thus himself as a “man” (אִישׁ). If the naming of the animals was an act of exercising power, then this aspect is largely nullified through the joyful greeting of the woman as an equal through the wordplay⁸⁹ אִשָּׁה – אִישׁ and the passive “she shall be called” (cf. 3:20). In short, animals are fellow creatures, but they are not seen as equal to humans. Their social nature is not enough to bring an end to humanity being alone. This requires a deep and intimate relationship based on equality and oriented towards reciprocity, as the Scholarly Narrator finds it laid out in the relationship between man and woman.

2:24–25

- 24 *Therefore a man will leave his father and his mother, and he will cling to his woman, and they will become one flesh.*
 25 *And they both were naked, the Human and his Woman, and they were not ashamed of each other.*

Following the man’s shout of jubilation is an etiological explanation by the narrator (v. 24). Introduced through the “Therefore” (עַל־כֵּן) typical of such clauses, it explains the meaning of the woman’s creation from the man. Accordingly, it speaks in a generalizing manner about “a man,” “father and mother,” and “his woman.” Such commentaries that leave the level of the narrative are aimed at the world of the narrator and its earliest readers. In v. 24, however, it is conspicuous that the circumstances described do not correspond with the social realities of ancient Israel: The connection between man and woman in ancient Israel is constituted in a patrilocal, patrilineal, and patriarchal manner. Unlike what is described in v. 24, the woman leaves her own family and marries into the family of the man (see Gen 24), where she initially assumes a comparatively difficult position as an outsider within the circle of women, a position that she can only strengthen with the birth of a (first-born) son. How, then, can the counterfactual statement in v. 24 be explained? The older assumption of Gen 2:24 containing remnants from a stage with a bygone matriarchal culture⁹⁰ has not withstood the test of time and is no longer supported within the current scholarly debate. However, there are two alternatives that have been discussed, and they are not necessarily mutually

⁸⁸ Spieckermann, 2001, 54.

⁸⁹ The similarity of the two Hebrew terms is purely phonetic and, contrary to what the Scholarly Narrator implies, has no basis in an etymological relationship. However, this is completely irrelevant for the idea of correspondence expressed in the naming.

⁹⁰ Jahnou, 1994, 31f.; Holzinger, 30.

exclusive. The first emphasizes the fact that v. 24 does not continue the narrative but rather presents a digression within the plot that is aimed at the present. Understood like this, the explanation is then aimed at the “astonishing fact that in a traditional society in which *kinship* is the absolute most fundamental category for identity and bonds of solidarity between individuals, there is another relationship whose intensity supersedes even the closest of blood relations, those of parents and children: the relationship between man and woman.”⁹¹ If the counterfactual aspect is emphasized more strongly in this interpretation relating to the narrator’s present, the elementary power of love (see Song 8:6) can be emphasized in contrast to the existent institutions, and there are even slight reservations to be heard about the present power relations within a patriarchally organized society. The second alternative recognizes a “pointedly constructed counterproposal to the patriarchal order that is established everywhere”⁹² in the description of the relationship between man and woman. This reading can appeal to the continuation of the narrative, in which the present circumstances in the relationships between God and humanity, between humanity and animals, and between man and woman are explained as an impairment of an originally untroubled society as a result of the breaking of the commandment. In this sense, v. 24 shows the antithesis to the punishment of the woman and the man’s dominion over her that is first established there (Gen 3:16). Understood like this, the Garden narrative does have quite the potential for criticism of the present. As a narrative about the mythical origins of the present realities of life, it does not fundamentally question its conditions. For farming and its toils or the pains of birth, this would in any case make little sense. Likewise for the power relations between man and woman, which were no less natural in the ancient view, a fundamental denial may have been beyond the Scholarly Narrator’s conceptual faculties. Nevertheless, the Garden narrative shows that the experience of the patriarchal subordination of the woman was not intended in the order of Creation. For this reason, the patriarchal structure, which is present and not fundamentally questioned, is depicted as an impairment of human existence. The etiological aspect of v. 24, which relates to the present of the narrator, should then be understood similarly to that of the first alternative, as an enduring promise that the love between man and woman is able to overcome the present order, which is defined by domination (see Song 3:4; 8:2). In this respect, humanity no longer lives in Paradise, but what “was valid there has not simply disappeared but is still just as present as a possibility, although covered and broken through something else, something negative.”⁹³

⁹¹ Blum, 2004, 19 [translation JWR; emphasis original].

⁹² Spieckermann, 2001, 54 [translation JWR].

⁹³ Crüsemann, 1978, 56 [translation JWR].

No matter which alternative, or even a combination thereof, this constitutes an origin narrative (an etiology) of love and not of the institution of marriage (but see already Tob 8:6f.), for which in ancient Israel, as in most other societies, the decisive considerations were in any case familial, social, or economic. The etiological interjection ends with the announcement that man and woman become “one flesh.” There is no question that this statement has sexual connotations (see also the euphemistic use of בָּשָׂר “flesh” in Lev 15:2f., 7, 19; Ezek 16:26 and דָּבַק “to cling to” in Gen 34:3), but it should not be seen as limited to this. Rather, as a result of leaving one’s father and mother, it expresses “spiritual unity, the most complete personal community”⁹⁴ (see also דָּבַק in Ruth 1:14; Prov 18:24) and, thus, the end of being alone, which has been judged as “not good” (v. 18).

Verse 25 again changes the level of the narrative and takes up the theme of the undisturbed companionship between “the Human and his Woman.” At the same time, the verse bridges over to the following scene, insofar as the characterization of the couple as “naked” (עָרֹם, from עָרָם) preempts the snake being “clever,” (עָרוּם; see v. 3:1), and a leitmotif important for the progression of the narrative is introduced (3:7, 21). For this reason, v. 25 should be read less as an original paradisiacal state and more as an unreal “not-yet,” also presented ambiguously and transferred onto the present reality once the prohibition against eating from the Tree of Knowledge has been transgressed.⁹⁵ The emphatic preceding “they both” (שְׁנֵיהֶם) and the following statement that the “Human and his Woman” are not mutually ashamed (וְלֹא יִתְבַּשְׁשׁוּ) even though they are naked highlight the “perfectly whole companionship.”⁹⁶ The ambiguity of even this state is expressed in the nakedness. There is an interpretive tradition that began in early Judaism and was later prevalent in Christianity in which the Garden narrative depicts in v. 25 an original state of sexual innocence and that sensuality comes into the world only later as a consequence and expression of sin. Firstly, it should be noted in this regard that neither of the terms “naked” (עָרֹם) or “to (feel) shame” (בוֹשׁ; hithpol.) have primarily a sexual meaning. Rather, this first and foremost concerns social status and the appraisal thereof. Shame is an expression of a negative (self-)relationship. Likewise, nakedness bears negative connotations throughout the entire ancient Near East as a sign of inferiority, lowliness, and lack of status, while clothing establishes status and orders relationships between people.⁹⁷ Thus, prisoners of war may be depicted

⁹⁴ Westermann, 233 (following F. Delitzsch). See also Steck, 1982, 85.

⁹⁵ So also the majority of the literature. See Westermann, 234 and Seebaß, 119. Schmid, 2002 and Spieckermann, 2001 emphasize the ambiguity that is expressed in the description.

⁹⁶ Steck, 1982, 85 [translation JWR].

⁹⁷ See Winter, 1995; Hartenstein, 2005. The frequent assumption that Gen 2:25, in contrast to the other 19 instances of עָרֹם/עִירָם, has a positive evaluation of the nakedness is

in visual representations as without clothes, in contrast to the victors (see Deut 28:48), with differences in rank on the victors' side being expressed through different outfits and degrees to which they are covered.⁹⁸ Furthermore, there is an ethical requirement to clothe the poor (Isa 58:7; Ezek 18:7, 16), and it is sacrilege if they are unclothed, since the loss of clothing is the equivalent of losing dignity and personhood (Job 24:7–10; Ezek 16:39). Newborns (like the dead) are naked, and their social status is likewise still (or again) undetermined (Eccl 5:14; see also Job 1:12). Accordingly, Yhwh-God's clothing of the human beings, who have now become aware of their nakedness, is a caring act that grants humanity the social status necessary outside of the Garden (Gen 3:12). Verse 25 thus depicts a humanity that has no status and is far from any kind of differentiation. The peculiarity of this "original state" lies in how the human couple does not shame each other (לֹא יִתְבַּשְׁשׁוּ), as they are still ignorant of it. Thus, the reverse side of the undisturbed, whole companionship is that the man and his woman are not yet fully aware of themselves. The ambiguousness of such an existence in the state of "dreaming innocence"⁹⁹ comes into consciousness only with the attainment of knowledge, which is why humanity's first action upon receiving knowledge is the preparation of clothing (Gen 3:7). Nakedness and (the lack of) shame are thus similar to morality, which humanity has from the outset. Like these aspects, those of human coexistence connected with status attain a formative meaning for human existence only through their conscious awareness, and only in this way can their negative significance be realized.

3:1–6

- 1 *But the serpent was cleverer than all of the animals of the field that Yhwh-God had made, and it said to the Woman, "Should God really have said that you may not eat of any of the trees of the garden?"*

inaccurate. Adam and Eve simply do not yet recognize its significance, and so it therefore has no consequences. Since עֵרִים/עָרוֹם otherwise never has erotic connotations, such should not be hastily and unilaterally assumed for Gen 2:25, especially since the root בָּוֶשׁ* additionally "is in no way oriented towards sexual shame" (Seebaß, 1973, 571 [translation JWR]). Schmid, 2018 shows that v. 24, like v. 25, has nothing to do with the question of the couple's sexual activity while in the Garden. Cf. Fischer, 2018, who fails to recognize that v. 24 and v. 25 lie on different levels of communication. She instead takes both verses together as evidence for a sexuality that is not only established in "Paradise" but has already been experienced, which she wants to be understood as an egalitarian sexuality that contrasts with the real lived conditions of the intended (and also the modern) audience. This constricted perspective on the sexuality question overlooks how Paradise, as a "counterworld," is also marked by ambiguities; instead, it presents the conventional distinction of an "innocent" sexuality before and a sexuality corrupted by sin after the "Fall" in a new guise.

⁹⁸ See Hartenstein, 2005, 289f. and Fig. 5.

⁹⁹ Spieckermann, 2001, 54 (following a phrase by Paul Tillich).

- 2 *Then the Woman said to the snake, “We may eat from the fruit of the trees of the garden;*
 3 *only of the fruit of the tree standing in the middle of the garden did God say, ‘You may not eat from this, nor touch it, lest you die!’”*
 4 *Then the snake said to the Woman, “You will certainly not die!*
 5 *Rather, God knows full well that as soon as you eat from it, your eyes will open and you will be like God, knowing of good and bad.”*
 6 *Then the Woman saw that the tree was good as food, and it was a pleasure to the eyes, and that the tree was tempting for attaining understanding; then, she took from its fruit and ate, and she also gave to her Man next to her, and he ate.*

Traditionally, this section is referred to as the story of the “Fall of Man,” describing why, through Adam and Eve, humanity was banished from the Garden, how humanity was increasingly separated from God and its origins through this, and how it was delivered into the power of sin. Standing within this centuries-old interpretive tradition is the reading of “Adam’s fall” being based in “Eve’s sin,” thus theologically legitimizing a social subordination of women. Moreover, the supposed narrative of the Fall was repeatedly read as the answer to the question of the origins of evil. The extent to which previous interpretations have been guiding the perception of the text and have, so to speak, “overwritten” it can be seen in how the terms and motifs that are associated with Gen 3 as a matter of course are actually not mentioned there at all. This goes for the aforementioned apple, concepts such as “sin” and “guilt,” the motif of the “seduction of Adam,” and the *cantus firmus* intoned in the fourth book of Ezra from the first century CE, “Ah, Adam, what have you done?!” (4 Ezra 7:118; see Rom 5:12).¹⁰⁰ Also conspicuous in comparison with the various interpretations throughout history, which have primarily been interested in the doctrine of sin (on this, see on the understanding of sin on pgs. 186f. below) is how much in Gen 3 the Scholarly Narrator and the actors in the story hold back from any evaluation of what takes place.

3:1a

But the serpent was cleverer than all of the animals of the field that Yhwh-God had made,

The snake is introduced with explicit recourse to Gen 2:19 as one of the animals created by Yhwh. As it progresses, the Garden narrative provides an

¹⁰⁰ See Schmid, 2002, 35.

etiology of snakes' distinctive way of life, which is visible in everyday life (see Gen 3:14f.). The snake is therefore seen as the ancestor of all snakes. This renders superfluous the belief widely held throughout the history of the narrative's interpretation that the snake is an ungodly force or personification of evil (see Wis 2:23–25; Apoc. Mos. 7:2; Rev 12:9; 20:2). Why the snake would want to tempt the couple to eat from the forbidden fruit is not stated. The question of its motivation plays no role and, likewise, should not be read into the narrative by, as one example, seeing a rivalry between the snake and the woman because the man had spurned the snake as his counterpart.¹⁰¹ Furthermore, the narrative does not offer an etiology of evil in the world.¹⁰² The snake only appears in order to provide the narrative impetus for humanity's transition from an existence in Paradise to that of reality.¹⁰³ In all of this, the snake is no blank canvas for the Scholarly Narrator and his era. Snakes are ascribed many different meanings in the art and literature of the ancient Near East, symbolizing wisdom, power, life, death, or regeneration, and they appear in mythology in very different forms and contexts.¹⁰⁴

Precisely because of this variety, the explanation should be limited only to that to which the text alludes. There may be echoes of other aspects, but these are not suitable as interpretive keys for understanding the scene, such as is often claimed regarding the snake mentioned in the Epic of Gilgamesh, who steals the "Plant of Immortality" from the bathing hero, eats it, and then sheds his skin as a sign of eternal youth (Gilgm 11.303–307). Even if it can be assumed that the Scholarly Narrator may have been familiar with the Gilgamesh material, and presumably even knew the text (see on Gen 6:5–9:17 below), there is no methodological control when individual traits of the biblical text are explained through motifs that it itself does not mention. The Tree of Life (which is a secondary addition) plays no role in the dialogue between the snake and the woman, the man and his woman are, unlike Gilgamesh, not searching for immortality, and nothing is said about the snake consuming the fruit from the Tree of Knowledge (or the Tree of Life). Above all, the classic motif of the snake smelling the Plant of Immortality, consuming it, and shedding its skin as a sign of its "immortality" is not mentioned whatsoever. Even if the snake motif from Gilgamesh still exerts influence through the (later) mention of the Tree of Life, and even if the theme of lost immortality is still worth considering (see on 3:22 below), other possibilities for the origin of the snake from the religious sphere, such as connections with the chaos dragon (so Job 26:13; Isa 27:1) or the "brazen serpent" (Num 21:8f.), are hardly plausible. When overlooking the individuality of the text itself, the comparisons sought from within the history of religion stand on hardly firmer ground than the venerable Mariological interpretation that understood the curse in 3:14–15 as the protoevangelium (see on Gen 3:15 below).

¹⁰¹ So Spieckermann, 2001, 56.

¹⁰² For the research consensus on this, see Zimmerli, 163f.; von Rad, 87; Westermann, 238f.

¹⁰³ See von Rad, 87; Westermann, 237–242.

¹⁰⁴ See Frey-Anthes, 2008.

In many cultures, snakes are described as clever or mentioned in contexts concerning wisdom (proverbially so in Matt 10:16). The connection with sacred trees is well attested in the iconography of ancient Israel.¹⁰⁵ Thus, among the animals in the Garden, the snake seems like a perfect fit for an appearance centered around the tree in the middle of the Garden and the knowledge that comes from eating its fruit. How the Garden narrative evaluates the snake's cleverness cannot be determined with any certainty. Against the widespread translation of the adjective עָרוּם as "crafty," it is often noted that such imparts a certain deviousness upon the snake that comes from neither context nor concordance.¹⁰⁶ Likewise, it is also worth asking how the verse's use of the comparative should then be understood, according to which the other animals are less "crafty." However, the implications of the evidence of the concordance are not clear. Although the Hebrew Bible generally values the intellectual faculties referenced with עָרוּם positively (so Prov 12:16, 23; 13:16; 14:8, 15, 18), it also knows of the misuse of cleverness for evil and, in particular, the dangers of "clever speech" (so Job 5:12f.; 15:5). Moreover, the subsequent speech by the snake is characterized by a particular ingenuity that the woman and the man next to her (v. 6) are unable to counter and with which, in the woman's view, it has misled (*נִשְׂאָה "to deceive" in 3:13) them both into reaching for the forbidden fruit. Accordingly, the punishment for the snake and its descendants is harsh (3:14–15). However, since nothing is said about any goal that the snake seeks to achieve through its cunning, this indicates the more neutral "clever" as a translation for עָרוּם. Then, with regard to the consequences of the snake's speech, it is rather a "ruse of the reason" (Hegel) that uses the snake's cleverness to lead humanity out of its immaturity. The talking snake assumes the part of the clever fairytale animal (so Num 22, where the talking donkey also turns out to be more insightful than the person) and thus leads the plot to take its most crucial step forward.

3:1b–6

- 1b** *and it said to the Woman, "Should God really have said that you may not eat of any of the trees of the garden?"*
- 2** *Then the Woman said to the snake, "We may eat from the fruit of the trees of the garden;*
- 3** *only of the fruit of the tree standing in the middle of the garden did God say, 'You may not eat from this, nor touch it, lest you die!'"*
- 4** *Then the snake said to the Woman, "You will certainly not die!*

¹⁰⁵ Hartenstein, 2005, 283f.

¹⁰⁶ See, among many, Schmid, 2002, 34.

- 5 *Rather, God knows full well that as soon as you eat from it, your eyes will open and you will be like God, knowing of good and bad.”*
- 6 *Then the Woman saw that the tree was good as food, and it was a pleasure to the eyes, and that the tree was tempting for attaining understanding; then, she took from its fruit and ate, and she also gave to her Man next to her, and he ate.*

The snake gingerly opens the conversation with a harmless-sounding question conveying its interest but not its intention: “Should God really have said that you may not eat of any of the trees of the garden?” It recognizes perfectly correctly that the commandment issued to the man (2:17) applies to both after the creation of the woman. Apart from the context-dependent plural formation, the snake’s question takes up verbatim the first part of the divine speech to the man (Gen 2:16b) but turns it on its head through the combination of permission and prohibition. Thus, the release of all trees with almost no exception (2:16f.) becomes a completely exaggerated demand (3:1b), which is why the woman feels compelled to correct it. In this way, the woman is brought into a conversation in which she is from the start playing from behind, since she has to be on the defensive and is supposed to defend a ban that was issued without reason. The woman’s response reflects this embarrassment (vv. 2–3). Initially, she clarifies that the fruit of the trees is fundamentally released for nourishment. Only “the tree in the middle of the Garden” (הָעֵץ בְּתוֹךְ הַגָּן) was exempt from this release, and even touching it was forbidden in order to save people from accidental death. Thus, in her argumentative distress, the woman changes the wording of the prohibition: She proclaims the tree to be taboo (see Exod 19:12) and the threat of the death penalty as a warning of the mortal consequences of breaking the taboo. The snake denies the impending danger, intentionally leaving open whether this refers only to the touching of the tree that was just mentioned (v. 4). In this case, the snake would simply be telling the truth, since no such prohibition has yet been mentioned. However, should it also be referring to the eating, then the snake would not be telling the truth regarding the prohibition. Nevertheless, the narrative would later prove it right. The fact that the snake can so quickly shrug off the death penalty as invalid is, in any case, also connected with the fact that it reacts to the woman’s curious paraphrase of the divine prohibition. The snake undermines the woman’s confidence by intentionally including the merely suggestive remark about God knowing all of this in order to then enlighten her about the true meaning of the tree (v. 5). Loosely based on the motif of humanity stealing wisdom withheld from them, which is also attested in the Hebrew Bible (see Job 15:7f.), the snake accuses God of having hidden this knowledge from humanity out of malevolence. The accusation is left without comment and is confirmed rather than refuted as the narrative

progresses. The narrator does not distance himself from it and, in fact, proves the snake right: Eating the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge does not lead to death but, as promised, opens humanity's eyes, so that they are able to distinguish between what is conducive to life and what is detrimental to it and can act accordingly (see 3:7).¹⁰⁷ The promise of knowledge is followed by a dialogueless scene describing how the snake's speech changed the woman's view of the tree (v. 6a).¹⁰⁸ Like all other trees of the Garden, the tree is a feast for the eyes (2:9a), but above all, it is desirable because of the knowledge that it brings. Therefore, the woman initially takes a fruit for herself, before giving her man from the tree to eat (v. 6a). In this way, casually brought into the narrative flow is the basic anthropological insight that humans are not only social beings (2:18) but also knowledge-seeking beings.¹⁰⁹ Yet, how should this promise of knowledge and the reaction by the woman be evaluated? According to a powerful interpretative tradition, the snake awakens within the woman the hubristic desire to be like God, and the Fall of Man then consists in the fact that the woman and, with her, her man give in to this desire and fall into autonomous processes of cognition that are detached from God, as has since been characteristic of humanity.¹¹⁰ In more recent times, there have been objections raised against this view, with very good arguments.¹¹¹ In the Hebrew Bible, the "opening of eyes" is always referenced in a neutral or positive way, be it in a literal sense (so 2 Kgs 4:35; 19:16; Job 27:19; Prov 20:13) or a figurative sense about a deeper insight and correct evaluation of a situation (so Gen 21:19; Num 22:31; 2 Kgs 6:17, 20). Likewise, the discernment of good and bad (see on 2:17 above) and the efforts to become clever (*שכל* *hi.*; v. 6;¹¹² see Isa 44:18; Jer 9:23; 23:5) consistently have positive connotations. At best, the negative aspect of temptability can be heard in the expressions of covetousness (see תַּאֲוָה in Num 11:4; Ps 78:29–31 as well as *חמד* in the prohibition of coveting in the Decalogue in Exod 20:17, as well as Isa 1:29; Prov 12:12). However, even this is not clear (so Ps 10:17; 21:3 as well as Gen 2:9; Prov 21:20; Song 2:3). The decisive aspect, however, is whether the announcement "you will be like God" (כִּי אֱלֹהִים) turns the promise of knowledge, which would otherwise have positive connotations, into a negative development, in the sense of the hubris interpretation. This is clearly not the case, as is already evinced in how the statement is not repeated

¹⁰⁷ See already Gunkel, 17.

¹⁰⁸ See Bühner, 2014, 242f.

¹⁰⁹ Following Schüle, 75.

¹¹⁰ For this reformulation of the classic interpretation as the "narrative of the Fall of Man," see Steck, 1982, 34f. and fn. 43, 64, 104, 106; von Rad, 89f.

¹¹¹ On this and the following, see Albertz, 1992. See further Barr, 1992, 13; Schmid, 2002; Blum, 2004, 21; Schüle, 75, but also already Gunkel, 33f.

¹¹² On the translation, see Koenen, 1993, 787.

in v. 6. The woman does not reach for the tree out of a desire to take God's place. She does so out of the pursuit of understanding, which is valued fundamentally positively in the Hebrew Bible (see 1 Kgs 3:5–14). Likewise, the snake does not lure the woman in with the promise of divinization but with the prospect of participating in a knowledge that is thus far reserved for God (see also Gen 3:22). This characterization of the knowledge of good and bad is reminiscent of the innocuous statement that David, with his ability to distinguish good from bad, resembles an angel of God (see 2 Sam 14:17, 20; 19:28; also 2 Sam 16:23 on the counsel of Ahitophel; see further Gilg 1.207). There is no fundamental or implicit difference between this "being like an angel of God" versus the "being like God" of Gen 3:5. Firstly, even the comparison "like God" is not unknown to the Hebrew Bible (so Exod 4:16; 7:1; also Ps 8:6); secondly, these comparisons always use the generic term אֱלֹהִים ("God" or "divine being") and never the personal name of God. In this, they resemble the dialogue between the snake and the woman, where, at the level of the actors (Gen 3:1b, 3, 5; also 3:22) but not of the narrator (Gen 3:1a), the Scholarly Narrator consistently speaks deliberately of אֱלֹהִים and not of "Yhwh" (or the redactional "Yhwh-God").¹¹³ In light of all of this, the "you will be like God, knowing of good and bad" does not result in a "Fall of Man" from the grasping of the Tree of Knowledge. Nevertheless, and notwithstanding the great esteem in which biblical literature holds wisdom, caution is warranted against any anachronistic readings.¹¹⁴ The Garden narrative's description of life in the Garden in Gen 2 is certainly not meant as a realistic alternative to the existing world, in which the capability of making judgments is both necessary and highly valued as a faculty of the mature human being. However, at the same time, it also does not offer an etiology for the "Enlightenment" as "humanity's exit from its self-inflicted immaturity" (Immanuel Kant). The Garden narrative's realism is distinguished by how it clearly names the ambiguities that come with cognitive faculties. The epistemological insights of Late Wisdom are certainly still foreign to the Garden narrative (so Job 28; Qoheleth), but it presents the impairment of human existence as punishment for the forbidden attainment of knowledge (Gen 3:15–19). The ambiguous conditions of existence, like Pandora's Box in the Greek myth of Prometheus, form the reverse side to the human faculty of reason (see Aesch., *Prom.* 2.443f.). Thus, the close entanglement of human tragedy with humanity's utmost capabilities reveals an awareness of the problem further developed over the course of the narrative. The narrative's first instance of free human choice being

¹¹³ See Witte, 1998, 57.

¹¹⁴ Following Blum, 2004, 22. For an overview of the modern interpretations of Gen 2:4–3:24 and the philosophical appraisal of the Fall as the "happiest and greatest incident" (Friedrich Schiller [translation JWR]), see Gestrich, 1989, 102–159, and further Kübel, 2007, 3–22.

applied leads to fratricide (Gen 4:7f.). This is followed by the explicit statement at the beginning and end of the Flood narrative that the “formations of the thoughts of its heart” – in the view of the Hebrew Bible, the human organ for cognition – are bad (Gen 6:5; 8:21). With this statement, the human cognitive faculties (“the heart”) are not themselves disqualified but rather humanity’s autonomy in handling these faculties (the “formations of the thoughts”).¹¹⁵ To the Scholarly Narrator, the ambiguity of human existence and of its use of reason presents itself as the consequence of an autonomous transgression of a commandment, while to a reader influenced by the Enlightenment, it presents itself as the necessary accompaniment of the autonomous use of reason.

3:7–8

- 7 *Then the eyes of the two were opened, and they realized that they were naked. Then they wove fig-tree leaves together and made skirts for themselves.*
- 8 *When they heard the sound of Yhwh-God as he strolled through the garden during the evening breeze, the Human and his Woman hid from Yhwh-God among the trees of the garden.*

As foretold by the snake, the eyes of the couple are opened. The resultant recognition of their own nakedness is sometimes seen as a rude awakening of humanity from its lofty expectations of the knowledge to which it aspired. Instead of the “knowledge like God” for which they hoped, humanity sees itself only as it truly is: naked.¹¹⁶ Some have also heard a subtle irony in the notice about the humans making the skirts from fig leaves, insofar as Yhwh-God even had to help them in preparing proper clothes (see 3:21).¹¹⁷ However, if only because of the great importance of questions of status in ancient societies as they relate to the topic of nudity and clothing, Adam and Eve’s attainment of knowledge should not be undervalued. When the man and his woman recognize that they are naked and they therefore clothe themselves, they then very well know how to distinguish between good and bad according to the cultural parameters of the Garden narrative and, therefore, between the shame that is conducive to life and the shamelessness that is detrimental to life, and they know how to act accordingly.¹¹⁸ Given the question of what alternative to a fig-leaf skirt would have otherwise been immediately

¹¹⁵ See Schellenberg, 2002, 246.

¹¹⁶ See Gunkel, 17f.; Steck, 1982, 95; Witte, 1998, 162; Seebaß, 121.

¹¹⁷ See Albertz, 1992, 20.

¹¹⁸ See Westermann, 251, referencing Julius Wellhausen and Hermann Gunkel.

available to the couple, this question is at least a concrete attestation of the couple's pragmatic resourcefulness. Furthermore, a disparaging evaluation of the knowledge that they attained does not sufficiently account for how the Scholarly Narrator uses the example of nakedness to depict the attainment of cognitive faculties as a step from childlike naïvety and into its self-aware adulthood: The wording of v. 7 harkens back over the snake's speech to 2:25. For the second and final time, it explicitly speaks of "the two" (שְׁנֵיהֶם).¹¹⁹ The grasping for the forbidden fruit and the consequences thereof are the final action and the last experience from within a state of unbroken unity. As the narrative progresses, the two turn more and more into individuals who act for themselves. The realization of their nakedness leads to them making "skirts for themselves." Although nakedness was not yet a reason for the nescient human couple to be ashamed of each other, in this first action by the human beings, each seeks to withdraw from the other's gaze so that they are not subjected to it unprotected. Above all, the two humans – who have now become aware of themselves – no longer dare to step into Yhwh's sight, and they therefore hide from him (v. 8). What seems at first glance to be a joint action is at best a simultaneous decision. The man's statement that *he* heard God, *he* became afraid of coming before God because of *his* nakedness, which is why *he* hid *himself* (v. 10) indicates that each had hidden themselves alone. The separation is executed with the man's blaming of the woman (v. 12). This concerns more than merely the refusal to take responsibility for the joint action. The rejection of guilt is worded as a clear distancing from the shout of jubilation in 2:23. It is only now that the man perceives the woman as an independent counterpart and also becomes aware of himself ("the Woman whom you had to join me"). From the "bone of my bone and flesh of my flesh," the woman has become the woman whom Yhwh-God gave to the man and who finally receives a name of her own (v. 20). As ambiguous as this experience may be, even the content of the attained knowledge does not speak against humanity, in breaking the commandment, actually attaining what constitutes the essence of the mature human being – the ability to distinguish between what is and is not beneficial to life.

If the awakening of the human cognitive faculties is presented through the example of nakedness and the discovery of shame, then the "intellectual phylogenesis of humanity" appears "through the analogy of ontogenesis."¹²⁰ The motif of adolescence shining through here is found across cultures; specific inspiration may have come from the episode of Enkidu and Šamkat from the Epic of Gilgamesh (Gilgm 1.178–202): The wild man Enkidu,

¹¹⁹ See Hartenstein, 2005, 288f., and there also on what follows.

¹²⁰ (Among many,) Blum, 2004, 22 [translation JWR].

created from clay, lives together with the animals in a prehuman, animalistic ignorance (Gilg 1.101–112; see on Gen 2:7 above). The prostitute Šamkat is to bring him to the city of Uruk, the symbol of civilization. She sleeps with Enkidu for six days and seven nights, which awakes his mind. He is thus able to listen to Šamkat, who introduces him to skills necessary for civilization. Enkidu learns to clothe himself, to eat like a human, and to perfume himself, on which Šamkat comments that he has become “wise [?], like a god” (Gilg 1.207; see also 1.202). Elements shared between the two are the two-staged anthropogony, the connection of the awakening of sexuality with the attainment of knowledge, the clothing as a sign of civilization, and the evaluation of knowledge as godlike. The prominent role of the woman in the transition from the prehuman to human state could have also been inspired by its Mesopotamian predecessor. However, the biblical text does not explicitly connect the attainment of knowledge with intercourse or even the woman’s sexual seduction of the man, notwithstanding the recognition of nakedness and the sexual connotations that may be evoked by the garden setting (see Song 2:13; 4:12, 16; 5:1; 6:2) and the Hebrew word for “to know” *יָדַע (see on Gen 4:1 below). Although the forbidden fruit is sometimes assumed to have an aphrodisiacal effect (see Gen 30:14), this is pure speculation, since the tree is not defined in greater botanical detail.

Of course, over the centuries, interpretations of the passage have been preoccupied with the identification of the fruit.¹²¹ The famous apple is a relative latecomer in the history of interpretation; initially, because of the fig leaves mentioned in v. 7, it was overwhelmingly thought of as a fig. This may have been fostered by the retelling in the book of Jubilees, in which the woman makes a skirt of fig leaves immediately after eating the fruit, and only afterwards gives the fruit to the man to eat (Jub 3:21f.). Regardless, to the extent that early Jewish interpretation commented on the question, it determined the fruit to be a fig (Apoc. Mos. 15–30). Following its lead were the rabbis as well as (Greek) Christianity, for which interesting cross-references to New Testament mentions of the fig tree arose (see Mark 11:13f.). In addition, the Jewish interpretive tradition mentions the etrog (Gen. Rab. 15.7) – this citrus fruit, which may be rather boring in culinary terms, plays an important role in the context of the festival of Sukkot – and the grapevine. The apple, predominant in art history and literature, comes from Latin Christianity. It is first attested in a rewriting of the biblical text, the *Heptateuch* of the Gallic poet Cyprianus Gallus (d. 425 CE). Although other attestations in early Christian iconography are often mentioned, evidence for it is actually not clear. The identification with the apple was probably influenced by ancient mythology, where the apple of the Hesperides can be found within conceptions of Paradise. Also common is an explanation of the tradition’s emergence with reference to a Latin wordplay of *mālum* (apple) with *malum* (evil). However, this is dubious, since allusions to such are not found in the Latin theologians of the fourth to seventh centuries. The wordplay probably resulted as a subsequent explanation from the pen of a later scholar.

¹²¹ See Leder, 1961.

Against everything that the interpretations both inside and outside the church read or have read into the text, even up to modern advertising, it should be emphasized that “in the Old Testament, it is not shame, and certainly not sexuality, but shamelessness that is understood as sin.”¹²² Thus, there is nothing speaking for a “a sexual sin” or “deed of the night.”¹²³ For that matter, the latter is therefore even less likely, since the woman can see how beautiful the fruit is. Thus, the “wind of the day” (רֵיחַ הַיּוֹם) is the cool evening breeze that in Mediterranean countries comes after the heat of the day to the delight of both people and gods (see the LXX δειλινόν “towards evening”; cf. Song 2:17; 4:6). Again, the setting is reminiscent of the conception of the garden as the dwelling of the gods, where the god-king now takes his evening stroll. Like in v. 10, the Hebrew קוֹל here is not a voice but the sound of Yhwh-God’s footsteps in the Garden (see 2 Sam 5:24).

3:9–19

- 9 *Then Yhwh-God called to the Human and said to him, “Where are you?”*
- 10 *Then he said, “I heard a sound from you in the garden, and I became afraid because I am naked, and I hid.”*
- 11 *Then he said, “Who let you know that you are naked? Have you eaten something from the tree from which I forbade you to eat?”*
- 12 *Then the Human said, “The Woman whom you had to join me, she gave to me from the tree, then I ate.”*
- 13 *Then Yhwh-God said to the Woman, “What have you done?” Then the Woman said, “The snake tempted me, then I ate.”*
- 14 *Then Yhwh-God said to the snake, “Because you have done this, cursed are you away from all the livestock and from all the animals of the field; you shall crawl on your stomach, and you will eat dust all the days of your life.*
- 15 *And I will cause enmity between you and the Woman and between your offspring and her offspring; she will kick at your head, and you will snap at her heel.”*
- 16 *To the Woman, he said, “I will make your hardship boundless, especially during your pregnancy; you shall bear children in pain, and your desire shall be after your Man, but he shall rule over you!”*
- 17 *And to the Human, he said, “Because you listened to the voice of your Woman and ate from the tree that I commanded of you, ‘You shall*

¹²² Albertz, 1992, 20 [translation JWR].

¹²³ See, among many, Gunkel, 18f. See also Schmidt, 1931, 22. The modern association, which has been promoted and popularized by psychoanalytic biblical interpretation, has a few early Christian and medieval precursors. See Flasch, 2004, 80–85.

not eat from it' – cursed is the soil on your account; under hardship shall you eat from it all the days of your life.

18 *And it will sprout thorn bushes and brush for you, and you shall eat the plants of the field.*

19 *You shall eat bread in the sweat of your face, until you return to the soil, for from it you were taken, for you are dust and you shall return to dust."*

Yhwh-God's appearance and the human couple's frightened reaction form the narrative transition to the interrogation and the sentencing. The section is constructed with a concentric structure.¹²⁴ Reversing the order of their appearances in the previous scene, Yhwh-God first questions the man (vv. 9–12; see v. 7b) and then the woman (v. 13; see v. 2). The snake is mentioned at the end of the interrogation but is not questioned (v. 13b; see v. 1). Following this in the reverse order is the cursing of the snake (vv. 14–15), then the punishment of the woman (v. 16) and then the man (vv. 17–19). The cursing and sentencing take up issues addressed in the questioning and are, moreover, interrelated with each other. Each of the parties involved suffers an individual punishment, which involves an individualized impairment of their existence, and a lasting disruption of the previous community, with the addressees henceforth standing in a relationship of guilt and punishment shaped by enmity (v. 15), domination and subordination (v. 16b), and curse (v. 17b).¹²⁵ The passage is generally characterized by the terms "interrogation and punishment." Since this concerns the elucidation of a transgression and its consequences, this legally oriented terminology is appropriate, but at least the "interrogation" part should not be pressed too much into legal categories. It is rather reminiscent of a paternal questioning of caught children: "Where are you?" (v. 9); "Who told you that? Have you eaten something from the tree?" (v. 11); "What have you done?" (v. 13); "Where is Abel, your brother?" (Gen 4:9). Such questions fit well with the preceding descriptions of the creation of humanity as a coming of age.¹²⁶

3:9–13

9 *Then Yhwh-God called to the Human and said to him, "Where are you?"*

10 *Then he said, "I heard a sound from you in the garden, and I became afraid because I am naked, and I hid."*

¹²⁴ See Gunkel, 20; Holzinger, 33; Witte, 1998, 162f.

¹²⁵ Witte, 1998, 163.

¹²⁶ Gunkel, 18f.; Schüle, 77.

- 11 *Then he said, "Who let you know that you are naked? Have you eaten something from the tree from which I forbade you to eat?"*
- 12 *Then the Human said, "The Woman whom you had to join me, she gave to me from the tree, then I ate."*
- 13 *Then Yhwh-God said to the Woman, "What have you done?" Then the Woman said, "The snake tempted me, then I ate."*

The man's answer to the question of where he is (v. 9) reveals the difficulties into which he has fallen as a result of his newly attained knowledge (v. 10). The provisional clothing may help in making him presentable to his counterpart, but it is not enough for encountering the deity. In this respect, it is completely appropriate for him to hide his nakedness before Yhwh-God (see Exod 20:26). Of course, this insight is indebted to the transgression of the divine commandment, which is why the appropriate behavior at the same time exposes his bad conscience, which stirs for the first time in the encounter with Yhwh-God as a later realization about his own deed. When asked about this (v. 11), the man admits to transgressing the prohibition, but not before shifting the responsibility to the woman (v. 12). Mature action also requires the willingness to take responsibility. This is as undisputed in the Hebrew Bible as the bitter experience that there is often a large gap between this demand and actual reality. And by all means, Yhwh-God's question would have provided the opportunity to take responsibility for the deed. However, the man, and alongside him a history of interpretation that for centuries has been dominated by men (see Sir 25:24: "From a woman, sin has its beginnings; because of her, we all must die"; further Apoc. Mos. 14:2–3; LAE 44; Philo, *QG* 1.43; 1 Tim 2:8–15), prefers to point to the woman "whom you had to join me." This final comment hints at an attempt to assign the initial blame to Yhwh-God and to exonerate himself.¹²⁷ This is brought forward only vaguely and in a side comment, but at the same time, this accusation of Yhwh being the instigator – formulated as a reversal of the jubilant shout in 2:23 – marks not only a distancing from the woman but also from the Creator God. This move is repeated in the questioning of the woman (v. 13). It can be left open whether the question "What have you done?" refers to the entire incident or, less likely, to the man's previous excuse that the woman handed him the forbidden fruit. Regardless, in her answer, the woman identifies the eating of the forbidden fruit as the offense. Furthermore, the woman does not deny the offense; she instead blames the snake, who tempted her (נִשְׂאָה). The verb נִשְׂאָה "to tempt, deceive" is never used in an erotic, sexual sense, ruling out the repeated speculations of the snake having sexually

¹²⁷ Gunkel, 19f.

seduced the woman. This small narrative character study ends with the woman's attempt, like the man before her, to elude her own responsibility. The snake is never questioned, just as the question of the origins of evil is never raised. The narrator is interested only in the man and his woman; the commandment was issued to them. Their process of becoming human through breaking the commandment is the theme of the Garden narrative.

3:14–19

- 14** *Then Yhwh-God said to the snake, "Because you have done this, cursed are you away from all the livestock and from all the animals of the field; you shall crawl on your stomach, and you will eat dust all the days of your life.*
- 15** *And I will cause enmity between you and the Woman and between your offspring and her offspring; she will kick at your head, and you will snap at her heel."*
- 16** *To the Woman, he said, "I will make your hardship boundless, especially during your pregnancy; you shall bear children in pain, and your desire shall be after your Man, but he shall rule over you!"*
- 17** *And to the Human, he said, "Because you listened to the voice of your Woman and ate from the tree that I commanded of you, 'You shall not eat from it' – cursed is the soil on your account; under hardship shall you eat from it all the days of your life.*
- 18** *And it will sprout thorn bushes and brush for you, and you shall eat the plants of the field.*
- 19** *You shall eat bread in the sweat of your face, until you return to the soil, for from it you were taken, for you are dust and you shall return to dust."*

With the cursing and sentencing, the Garden narrative reaches its etiological goal. This reflects the ambiguous realities of life for the Scholarly Narrator and his readership both then and now.¹²⁸ Living, and living on, provides humanity with both joy and hardship. Children are born amid pain. The relationship between man and woman is determined equally by mutual affection on the one hand and a one-sided distribution of power on the other. Cultivation of the soil secures humanity's livelihood, but it extracts a hard and often futile toil. This everyday experience, the overcoming of which is left for the promise of a new heaven and a newer earth (see Isa 65:17, 23),¹²⁹ appears in the Garden narrative as an impairment of existence in which the basic conditions of human life are redefined under the auspices of punishment and

¹²⁸ See already Gunkel, 20.

¹²⁹ See further Steck, 1997^b, 349–365.

curse. Nevertheless, the world beyond the Garden is not merely a “vale of tears,” since the positive reverse side of the life afflicted with punishment and curse should always be read alongside it. With Yhwh-God continuing to grant the possibility of life and the continuation of life to the now-mature humanity instead of punishing it with death as he had threatened to do (Gen 2:17), divine grace is accented even with regard to the impairment of existence. It is true that not all parties involved in the transgression are formally cursed but only the snake as the instigator. Nevertheless, the balance should still be maintained against a reading that is too hopeful as well: The soil (אֲדָמָה) being cursed on account of humanity (v. 17b) irrevocably brings humanity (אָדָם) into the domain of the curse.¹³⁰ Since humanity is taken from the soil and returns to it (see Gen 2:7; 3:19aβ), it could moreover even be asked whether the אָדָם (and likewise the woman with him, who is taken from the אָדָם and, like him, is returned to the אֲדָמָה) is not directly cursed through this.¹³¹ Against this reading, however, is how Cain is explicitly cursed in Gen 4:11 in a way that clearly references the sentencing of humanity here. It is obviously meant there as an intensification, which assumes all humanity existing within a cursed domain to be distinguished from a direct cursing resultant from an offense by an individual.

3:14–15

- 14 *Then Yhwh-God said to the snake, “Because you have done this, cursed are you away from all the livestock and from all the animals of the field; you shall crawl on your stomach, and you will eat dust all the days of your life.*
- 15 *And I will cause enmity between you and the Woman and between your offspring and her offspring; she will kick at your head, and you will snap at her heel.”*

The curse befalls the snake without any prior questioning. The only places in the Hebrew Bible where a curse occurs as a statement by God formulated in direct address are here and in Gen 4:11 (Cain), which underscores the weight of this primeval scene. The snake is banished from the community of the living beings of the field (and the livestock). In a mythological narrative, it should not be surprising when an animal is held responsible for its actions, although this idea is also attested in legal texts (see Exod 21:28). The punishment comes in the snake’s particular way of movement and way of life. Both were evidently regarded as in need of explanation (see Prov 30:19) and – as

¹³⁰ See Spieckermann, 2001, 57f.

¹³¹ Arneth, 2007, 103.

evidenced by corresponding curses seeking to punish breaches of contract through the eating of dust and the drinking of donkey urine¹³² – as particularly humiliating (see Mic 7:17; Isa 65:25). Taken literally, this origin of snakes' particular way of life leads to the assumption that while in Paradise, the snake had moved and eaten differently,¹³³ but such considerations lie outside of the interest of the narrative.¹³⁴ The fact that snakes do not actually eat dust was possibly also known to the Scholarly Narrator. Yet, no matter whether the statement was meant metaphorically or scientifically, it points to a connection of snakes to death and affliction, as is also addressed in the statement about the eternal enmity between the snakes and the woman's offspring. It was probably for this reason that a later editor was stirred by the mention of dust (עָפָר) to add the remark in Gen 2:7; 3:19 that humanity was created from dust (see on Gen 2:7 above). In so doing, the editor shifted the main tone of the Garden narrative to the human immortality forfeited with the transgression of the prohibition (see Gen 3:22; 24). It was therefore natural to understand the eating of the dust as a punishment mirroring the seduction of the woman and to thereby emphasize humanity's becoming dust as a consequence of the transgression. Early Christian and rabbinic exegesis have followed the editor in this (Gen. Rab. 20.5). In addition to snakes' particular way of life, Yhwh-God decrees an abysmal and perpetual enmity (אִיבָה; see also Num 35:21f.; Ezek 25:15; 35:5) between the woman and the snake and between their respective offspring (v. 15). This statement too is taken from the realities of agrarian life. Especially under premodern conditions, snakes in the Near East continuously posed a sudden and unexpected threat (see Gen 49:17; Amos 5:19; Ps 58:5; 140:4; Prov 23:32; Eccl 10:8), which would have resulted in behavior towards snakes accordingly (see Luke 10:19). In the Hebrew text, mutual aggression is expressed by the doubled use of the verb שָׁקַף "to attack [someone]." Thus, the woman and her offspring target the heads of the snake and its offspring, which in turn snap at humanity's heels. In Yhwh's sentencing, this experience is elevated to be a fundamental fact of life and becomes the first instance of communal disruption among the creatures. It cannot be said with certainty whether this message, as a conclusion that moves from minor to major, should be understood as the cursing of the snake leading to an elementary, long-term disruption in the relationship between humans and animals.¹³⁵ Speaking against

¹³² See Schottroff, 1969, 152f.; Seebaß, 125.

¹³³ So Luther, WA 42, 114. One exceptional case in art history is the depiction of the temptation scene by Hugo van der Goes (ca. 1470), which shows the snake with a human face and legs.

¹³⁴ Gunkel, 20; Westermann, 259.

¹³⁵ Steck, 1982, 99f.; Schellenberg, 2011, 202f.

such a reading is the fact that the snake had immediately theretofore been banished from the circle of animals. However, what can be cited for a fundamental redefinition of the relationship between human and animal is the setting from when the man named the animals. It is evocative of an original peace among the animals (Gen 2:19f.), which sharply contrasts with reality, especially under the conditions of ancient agrarian realities of life. In this respect, the cursing of the snake abolishes a mythical state. The living reality is also interpreted in terms of the relationship between human and animal, which is defined by competition and mutual threat, as punishment and an impairment of existence. In the Primeval History of the Priestly Writing, this thought corresponds to the contrast between the original order of Creation and the conditions of reality that were set through the Great Flood (see Gen 1:28f. and Gen 9:2f.).

Throughout Christian interpretation of the passage, Gen 3:15 has played an important role as the first appearance of the gospel (the protoevangelium). Early Jewish exegesis had already developed an eschatological understanding of the verse: The Targums attest to an older tradition of the announced enmity consisting in a series of conflicts between the snake and humanity, descending from the woman, which are expected to be pacified in the messianic end times. In this, the snake is imagined as a beast that will eventually be defeated by those who are faithful to the Torah (see Tg. Ps.-J. on Gen 3:15).¹³⁶ Against the background of the widespread identification of the snake with Satan in the first century CE (see Wis. 2:23–25; Apoc. Mos. 7:2; Rev 12:9; 20:2), the verse, when understood eschatologically, has also been read as announcing an end-time victory over Satan (see Rom 16:20). Irenaeus of Lyon (d. ca. 200 CE) consequently interpreted this line christologically and connected the זרע (“offspring; seed”) to Christ, who was born of a woman (Mary) and whose eschatological victory over Satan is announced immediately after the Fall (Irenaeus, *Haer.*, 3.23.7; 4.40.3; 5.21.1). Although this reading has been widely received throughout the history of both Catholic and Protestant interpretation and has left deep marks in art and poetry,¹³⁷ it hardly fits with the original intended meaning of Gen 3:15. The etiological orientation of the Garden narrative in general and the curses in particular, like the characterization of the woman as the “mother of all living” in v. 20, precludes understanding זרע as an individual. Like in most of its appearances across the Hebrew Bible, the term is used here in a collective sense. Accordingly, the snake and its seed are meant to signify the species of snakes as a whole. Since this clearly has the reproduction of an animal in mind, it cannot mean any timeless force of evil, which in any case would be unclear about how the snake/Satan and the descendants of the snake/Satan are related to each other. From the perspective of form criticism, a promise standing within a curse with an etiological orientation is quite difficult to imagine.¹³⁸

¹³⁶ See Dochhorn, 2007, esp. 205–208.

¹³⁷ So, for example, the fourth verse of Charles Wesley’s “Hark! The Herald Angels Sing”: “Rise the Woman’s conqu’ring Seed // Bruise in us the serpent’s head.”

¹³⁸ Westermann, 260.

3:16

To the Woman, he said, “I will make your hardship boundless, especially during your pregnancy; you shall bear children in pain, and your desire shall be after your Man, but he shall rule over you!”

The translation of the sentencing addressed to the woman was already a problem for the LXX. It translates the hapax legomenon הָרֶוֶן “pregnancy” with στεναγμός “groaning”: “I will make vast your hardship and your groaning.” This translation may have been prompted by the juxtaposition of עֲצָבוֹן “hardship” and הָרֶוֶן, since, regardless of the individual fate, having many pregnancies would hardly have been called a punishment in antiquity.¹³⁹ It is perhaps for this reason as well that the opening of the sentence is more reminiscent of a promise of multiplication (see הִרְבָּה אֲרֵבָה “I shall make vast” in Gen 16:10; 22:17) than of the curse against the snake and the punishment against the man.¹⁴⁰ If וְהָרֶוֶן “and your pregnancy” is not a marginal gloss that entered into the text only by mistake,¹⁴¹ then the הָרֶוֶן will need to be understood, as in the translation chosen here, as expounding upon the preceding עֲצָבוֹן (see GKC §154a fn. 1b). It is announced that the woman will experience much hardship (עֲצָבוֹן like in v. 17!), being plagued by troubles and afflictions especially during pregnancy (v. 16aβ; see Gen 25:22; 1 Sam 4:19f.) and by giving birth only under pain (v. 16aγ). Literally, it mentions only the birth of “sons” (בָּנִים), but in a patrilineally oriented language realm, this can also include daughters (see Gen 21:7; 30:1; 31:17; Deut 4:10; cf. Jer 29:6), which should be assumed here given the fates being described. The pain of the woman during childbirth (per Job 39:1, 3 also for does and ibexes; per Job 26:5 even the inhabitants of the sea) and her crying out in anguish are mentioned many times across the Hebrew Bible and repeatedly serve as a metaphor for divine judgment (see Isa 21:3; 26:17; Jer 4:31; 6:24; Ps 48:7). In the social and historical context of the Scholarly Narrator, the ambiguity in human life experiencing both joy and sorrow probably appears nowhere as clearly as with childbirth. The birth and naming of Benjamin offers an impressive example of this: Called *Ben-Oni*, “child of my misfortune” (for אֹן, see Ps 90:10) by his mother Rachel, who dies in childbirth, he is renamed *Ben-Yamin* “beloved son” (lit. “son of the south” or “son of the right hand”) by his father despite his suffering loss.

The second part of the sentencing is aimed at the relationship of the woman within the community, who is primarily thought of here in terms of her role

¹³⁹ See Gunkel, 21.

¹⁴⁰ For this and the various translation possibilities, see also Diekmann-von Bürnau, 2006.

¹⁴¹ Levin, 1993, 88.

as a mother (v. 16a) and as the wife of the man (v. 16b). As in the first part, it must be kept in mind that this is an etiology for the contradictory experience of existence. Just as the punishment has nothing to do with multiple pregnancies, so too is the desire (תְּשׁוּקָה) of the woman not characterized negatively. Rather, regarding the woman, everything that has been said within the context of the creation of humanity about the close relationship between man and woman (see Gen 2:24) is now taken up. This should be emphasized despite a broad current in the history of interpretation that, starting from the (secondarily added) quotation of the verse in Gen 4:7, has been all too happy to fall back on Gen 3:16 to establish and perpetuate the cliché of the (moral) weakness of women. The idea that “the woman has a stronger libido than the man,” with which her role as his “seductress” is connected,¹⁴² is neither a presupposition nor an intention of the text and, simply, is nonsense. Outside of Gen 3:16 (and the quotation in Gen 4:7), the expression תְּשׁוּקָה is attested only in Song 7:11, as the “repeal” of the sentencing, so to speak, referring there instead to the desire of the man: “I am with my beloved, and his desire (תְּשׁוּקָה) is after me.” Taking this other passage into account when interpreting the present passage shows that it concerns intimacy and affection, including erotic love.¹⁴³ This theme has already been addressed within the Garden narrative, albeit while excluding social realities (see on Gen 2:24f. above). This changes with the punishment placing the woman under the rule of the man. The semantic range of מָשַׁל “to rule” encompasses all forms of authority and therefore has no purely negative nor purely positive connotations. Ruling can be inappropriate and unjust (Isa 3:4; 3:12 [here rule by a woman]; Prov 28:15), it can be the mere exercise of power (Deut 15:6), and it can include, as “righteous rule” (Gen 45:8; 2 Sam 23:3f.), taking care of and protecting those entrusted to one’s care. The last of these is probably the intention of v. 16. Nevertheless, the one-sided assignment of desire to the woman and of rule to the man does mean the ultimate negation of an untroubled communion in favor of a patriarchally structured order.¹⁴⁴ This was undoubtedly a way to legitimize and stabilize existing powers. Nevertheless, it should be maintained that the Scholarly Narrator paints the dominance of man as part of an impaired existence and thus evaluates it similarly to the thorn bushes and brush of the field. It is far less set within the creationary order than is the intensity of the relationship between man and woman, which is said at the end of the creation of humanity to sometimes be able to overcome the conditions of social reality (Gen 2:24).

¹⁴² See, among many, Gunkel, 21.

¹⁴³ See Schüle, 2006, 196. Cf., e.g., Seebaß, 126, who reads the verse in light of Gen 4:7 and speaks of a social desire.

¹⁴⁴ See Spieckermann, 2001, 59.

3:17–19

- 17 *And to the Human, he said, “Because you listened to the voice of your Woman and ate from the tree that I commanded of you, ‘You shall not eat from it’ – cursed is the soil on your account; under hardship shall you eat from it all the days of your life.*
- 18 *And it will sprout thorn bushes and brush for you, and you shall eat the plants of the field.*
- 19 *You shall eat bread in the sweat of your face, until you return to the soil, for from it you were taken, for you are dust and you shall return to dust.”*

The statement about the man, placed emphatically at the end of the sequence, is just as voluminous as the two previous statements combined. While the cursing of the snake was justified merely with brief recourse to the woman’s excuse (“because you have done this”) and any justification in the case of the woman was omitted, the case of the man quotes his confession from the preceding interrogation scene (see v. 17aα with v. 12) and the divine prohibition (see v. 17aβ with v. 11b and Gen 2:17) verbatim. In addition to the justification, the formulation of the punishment is much more substantial and is more clearly related to the previous context. Standing at the center of the punishment is the soil (אֲדָמָה), which is cursed on the man’s account (v. 17b), from which he will nourish himself only with hardship (vv. 18, 19aα), and to which he will return at the end of his days (v. 19aβ). The guiding term, אֲדָמָה, points back to the Garden narrative’s opening exposition (Gen 2:5) and the statement about humanity’s origination from the soil (Gen 2:7*). Furthermore, the “plants of the field” (עֵשֶׂב הַשָּׂדֶה; v. 18b; Gen 2:5aβ) intended as nourishment were mentioned already in the description of the primordial world, while existence of the unwanted “thorn bushes and brush” (v. 18a) was indicated in the expression, used there as a generic term, “bushes of the field” (שִׁיחַ הַשָּׂדֶה; Gen 2:5aα). This extensive recourse to the beginning of the Garden narrative was redactionally expanded with the concluding statement that the man is dust (v. 19b; עָפָר “dust” in Gen 2:7). The extent, justification, and position of the sentencing of the man depict him as the main offender, who, in contrast to the woman, is afflicted by his guilt.¹⁴⁵ Yet, at the same time, it should be maintained that although the impairment of the man’s existence is decreed as a punishment, it is far less (gender) specific than in the woman’s case. The soil of the field, which is now under a curse, will give nourishment to humanity only with hardship, in contrast to its care-free existence in the Garden (see 2:8, 9a). This corresponds to the experience of everyday life especially in Palestine, where agriculture was practiced under far less favorable conditions than in the irrigation economies of Egypt

¹⁴⁵ See Seebaß, 127, 129.

and Mesopotamia. Of course, this experience was not limited to men, since women and children also helped with working in the field. Likewise, women too meet the fate of returning to the earth at the end of a painstaking life (on this motif, see Gilgm 10.68f., in which Enkidu becomes clay again). Even if the narrative fixes man and woman to their primary role assignments,¹⁴⁶ it cannot be overlooked that, like in the exposition in 2:5–7, the sentencing of the man also at least has the woman in view.

The sentencing ends with the reference (redactionally expanded in v. 19b) to human mortality. This is inherent to the physical human constitution and is not the consequence of eating from the forbidden tree or the punishment for breaking the divine commandment.¹⁴⁷ Thus, the death penalty threatened in Gen 2:17 is not executed, and the announced impairment of existence comes in its stead. In formal legal terms, these are the legal consequences that must inevitably follow when there is a criminal offense, but at the same time, they also serve as proof of the deity's grace towards his creatures. Thus, in retrospect, Gen 2:17 shows itself as "a warning, as emphatic as it can be, but this does not prevent God from then putting mercy above justice."¹⁴⁸ This notwithstanding, it cannot be denied that the reference to mortality, just by its position at the end, gives the sentencing as a whole a (even) gloomier tone. It is death alone that limits humanity's hardships (v. 19a). It defines human existence as "being towards death" (Heidegger). Coming as consequences of humanity grasping of the forbidden fruit were not only its capabilities for civilization and its insight into the fundamental conditions of social life but this bitter realization as well.

3:20–24

- 20 *Then the Human named his Woman "Ḥavvā" [Eve], for she was the mother of all living.*
- 21 *Then Yhwh-God made clothing for the Human and his Woman from hide, and he clothed them.*
- 22 *And Yhwh-God said, "See! The Human has become like one of us, recognizing good and bad; but now, lest he reach out his hand and also take from the Tree of Life and eat and live forever –"*
- 23 *And Yhwh-God sent him out of the garden of Eden, so that he would till the soil from which he was taken.*
- 24 *And he banished the Human, and he made the cherubs and the flame of the darting sword dwell to the east of the Garden of Eden in order to guard the way to the Tree of Life.*

¹⁴⁶ See Bühner, 2014, 252 and fn. 368.

¹⁴⁷ See, among many, Steck, 1982, 97f., 102.

¹⁴⁸ Aurelius, 2004, 54 [translation JWR].

The concluding section is not cast from a single mold. The first indications of this are the juxtaposition of the notices about the dismissal and banishment (vv. 23, 24) in addition to the collection of motifs both new and old, which is rather unusual for the conclusion to a narrative. Verses 22, 24 bring the Tree of Life motif, hitherto only insinuated, dominantly into the final chord, noticeably shifting the flow of the Garden narrative. They, with a fair degree of likelihood, are redactional.¹⁴⁹ The Scholarly Narrator, on the other hand, seems to have limited himself to taking up the main strands of his narrative and bringing them to their conclusion. Specifically, these concern the final naming of the woman, through whom all life continues despite all of the hardships of pregnancy and childbirth (v. 20), the caring of Yhwh-God, who does not leave the people with their makeshift skirts from leaves but provides them with clothing (v. 21), and the dismissal of the man to work the field (v. 23). However, the naming of the woman is repeatedly labeled as an unfitting reaction by the man to the preceding punishments and is seen as secondary.¹⁵⁰ This characterization, however, overlooks the transitional function of the verse (see Gen 4:1). Moreover, it does not do justice to the situation in the text, in which an appropriate reaction to the judgments must almost necessarily take place. The etiology for the realities of life would be stopped halfway through if there was not at least a hint at the way out of the Garden and into the aforementioned realms of childbearing and fieldwork that define human existence. John Calvin described the inclination of the text beautifully: “as soon as he had escape present death, being encouraged by a measure of consolation, he celebrated that divine benefit which, beyond all expectation, he had received, in the name he gave his wife.”¹⁵¹ The question of the etymology of the name *חַוָּה* “Eve,” which occurs only here and in Gen 4:1, is subtly expounded upon by Calvin but is difficult to answer.¹⁵² The Hebrew *אֵם כָּל-חַי* “mother of all living” derives the name from the root **חיה* “to live.” The LXX changed the name correspondingly to *Ζωή* “life” in order to maintain the etymological wordplay (*μήτηρ πάντων τῶν ζώντων*), while it transliterated the name in Gen 4:1 (*Ευα*). The perf. in v. 20b is declarative, thus presupposing neither the first human birth described in Gen 4:1 nor any other.¹⁵³ The man does not yet draw his knowledge from his own

¹⁴⁹ See (among many) Budde, 1932, 78–85; Gese, 1973, 78f.; Gertz, 2004, 228f. For the counterposition, which has gained much support more recently, see Blum, 2004, 19–21; Bühner, 2014, 256–261.

¹⁵⁰ Wellhausen, 1899, 10, who sees Gen 3:20f. as a later addition. The tension recognized also serves as an argument for the thesis discussed at the beginning that the punishments and, with them, the entire narrative about the breaking of the divine commandment, and the resultant consequences thereof, were added later.

¹⁵¹ Calvin, 181.

¹⁵² Kapelrud, 1977, 795–797.

¹⁵³ Seebaß, 130.

experience. Rather, he takes it from God's sentencing, the positive reverse side of which, the hope of life, is contrasted with the prospect of death. Conceivably, the Scholarly Narrator is referring here back to the tradition of a primordial mother (see Sir 40:1), which, however, has lost any concrete connotations in the context of the Garden narrative. With Yhwh-God's clothing of the couple, the important leitmotif of nakedness is drawn to a close (v. 21). The clothing is at the same time an act of enduring care by the Creator God, who replaces the makeshift coverings of fig-leaf skirts and gives humanity its dignity with appropriate clothing (see on Gen 2:25).¹⁵⁴ The question of the origin of this "hide clothing" is not addressed. There is an elegant suggestion in the Targums that they were made from the skin of the snake (Tg. Ps.-J. on Gen 3:21). Clothed and equipped with the knowledge of good and bad, the man is dismissed to fulfil his destiny by tilling the soil (v. 23). With this contrasting taking up of humanity's material origin and the determination of its essence again and in a contrasting manner, the Scholarly Narrator concludes his Garden narrative.

Although the dismissal notice in v. 23 establishes that the mythical state described in the primordial "not-yet statements" has been transformed into reality and that the narrative has thus come to an end, v. 24 again describes humanity's departure from the Garden of Eden. The clearly stricter wording notwithstanding (*גרש* "to expel" instead of *שלח* "to dismiss"), this doubling is conspicuous. The relationship between the two verses can easily be understood in terms of an intensification:¹⁵⁵ "God, after having *sent* the Human *away* from the garden – that is, having told him to go away – *drives* him, who hesitates or even stays standing at the gate, *away*."¹⁵⁶ Alternatively, v. 24 could be the "actualization of the expulsion in 3:23."¹⁵⁷ Neither reading is supported by the wording nor sufficiently considers how the new element compared to v. 23 is the protection of the Tree of Life, which then inseparably connects v. 24 with v. 22 and the introduction of the tree in Gen 2:9. The expulsion of humanity from the Garden denies humanity, who is mortal and constituted as such from the ordering of Creation, access to the Tree of Life (v. 24). Thus, the godlike faculties of cognition (v. 22a) are not also accompanied by immortality, which would have otherwise abolished the difference between God and human (v. 22a). Of the two privileges of the divine, wisdom and immortality, humanity attains only one, and at the expense of the other. This motif, like the recurrent mythological theme of squandered

¹⁵⁴ Jacob, 124; Hartenstein, 2005, 277.

¹⁵⁵ Cf. Willi, 1991, 431. The examples that he provides merely prove that both terms can appear in one and the same text. This is not disputed.

¹⁵⁶ Dillmann, 83 [translation JWR; emphasis original].

¹⁵⁷ Bühner, 2014, 258 [translation JWR].

immortality, can be found elsewhere in the literature of the ancient Near East. Worth mentioning are the snake in the Epic of Gilgamesh, who steals the Plant of Immortality from the bathing hero and subsequently sheds its skin as a sign of its eternal youth (Gilgm 11.303–307), and the Babylonian myth of Adapa, whose eponymous hero was brought into the presence of the gods through wisdom and unwittingly turns down “food of life” and “water of life.”¹⁵⁸ Even if the situation is different in both cases from that of the Garden narrative, the Scholarly Narrator or a later redactor could have been inspired by such texts. Speaking in favor of a later redactor is how this important theme is only mentioned in passing in the narrative itself but is given extraordinary importance by its position at the end: Neither the mention of human mortality nor its capability to produce offspring, and thus to preserve life, nor the question of humanity’s capacity for cognition are related to the motif of the Tree of Life or even dependent upon it. In contrast, the Tree of Life motif is prominently emphasized by the two mentions of it at the end of the Garden narrative, which noticeably shifts its message. An etiology of the realities of life becomes a myth of denied immortality – a theme unmentioned in the opening exposition, so it is hardly surprising that it can only be unfolded from beyond the framework laid out by Gen 2:4b–6 and Gen 3:23.

Further observations confirm the idea that the Tree of Life motif is secondary. However, contrary to what older research presumed, the syntax of Gen 2:9 alone does not allow any determination about whether or not the Tree of Life is original. A weightier observation is that, according to the wording, the woman and the snake only know of a single tree in the middle of the Garden (Gen 3:3), the Tree of Knowledge (Gen 3:5, 7, 11). Judgment of this depends on how carefully one weighs the observations about the three appearances of the Tree of Life in the Garden narrative: (1.) In the Garden narrative, אָדָם signifies both the man and the “human” species, but not the first human couple together. Whenever the man and his woman are meant, it explicitly states such. In contrast, the statement about the cognitive faculties of אָדָם in Gen 3:22a refers back to v. 7 and, as opposed to the rest of its usage in the Garden narrative, is used collectively for the couple. (2.) There have been arguments against striking Gen 3:22 as secondary, saying that the 3rd pers. sing. suffix in the dismissal notice (וַיִּשְׁלַחֵהוּ “and [Yhwh-God] sent him”) in v. 23 is dependent upon v. 22 and that a direct connection to v. 21b (וַיִּלְבַּשׁ “and he clothed them”) is syntactically impossible.¹⁵⁹ These arguments, however, do not withstand scrutiny, since there are other attestations of distant references of suffixes to the same, unmoving subject. The reference of וַיִּשְׁלַחֵהוּ to the אָדָם in v. 21a is clear. The choice of a singular suffix is based on its reference back to Gen 2:5, which tells of אָדָם being appointed to work the field.¹⁶⁰ Conversely,

¹⁵⁸ For an English translation with short introduction, see “III.21a Adapa and the South Wind” (Foster, *Muses*, 525–530). For a comparison with Gen 3, see Müller, 1991.

¹⁵⁹ So Bühner, 2014, 256f.

¹⁶⁰ Witte, 1998, 83.

an explicit mention of *מִן־הַגָּדֵן* in v. 23 could very well have led to the question of whether the woman did not have to leave the Garden. (3.) The divine speech, which in Gen 3:22a is in the 1st pers. pl., is singular within the Garden narrative (but see Gen 1:26; 11:7), notwithstanding the instance here being necessary for the comparative statement, which is direct speech from Yhwh-God. (4.) Genesis 3:22b is conspicuous in its elliptical formation, which would actually indicate a connection with a cohortative or consecutive clause. In its present form, v. 22b seems as if it is a later formulation written with v. 23 in view.¹⁶¹ (5.) The cherubs and the darting sword of fire in Gen 3:24 come into view of the Garden narrative only insofar as their functions as guardians were preempted by the man in Gen 2:5 after the redactional incorporation of the Paradise Geography.¹⁶² (6.) Moreover, the close connection to the redactional section in 2:(9b?) 10–14, 15 can be seen in their shared orientation towards the realities of the Jerusalem temple.¹⁶³

As with its references in the Paradise Geography that point towards Jerusalem (see on Gen 2:10–14 above), the Redaction here draws a close connection between the “Garden of Eden” and the Jerusalem temple. In Gen 3:24, this connection and the entanglement coming with it of the mythical primeval times and the present experienced world is evoked through the location of the Garden’s entrance and its guards: The idea of an enclosed sacred space only open to the east is easily explained as being oriented around the architecture of the Jerusalem temple (1 Kgs 7:39; Ezek 47:1). Moreover, the Tree (of Life) protected by the cherubs is also attested within the iconography of the Jerusalem temple (1 Kgs 6:29, 32, 35; see also Ezek 41:17–20, 25). In this, the Jerusalem temple follows the iconographic program of the ancient Near East.¹⁶⁴ The idea of the temple as a representation of Paradise has been maintained throughout history even to the decoration of the Dome of the Rock.¹⁶⁵ In terms of its content, the Redaction draws on the threat of the death penalty in Gen 2:17, which it understands as the threat of mortality or the deprivation of immortality. In this way, it tempers an inconsistency in the deity’s action that has been seen as problematic time and again in interpretations of the passage throughout history. At the same time, the result of this reworking provokes new questions, as proven by the midrash-like paraphrases of the Garden narrative by those who maintain the originality of the Tree of Life motif. This shows itself above all in the obvious question of whether the people in the Garden ate from the Tree of Life and what the consequences of this might have been. The wording of the prohibition in

¹⁶¹ Dohmen, 1996, 148–151. See also the more pleasant formulation in Gen 11:6, which was prompted by Gen 3:22.

¹⁶² See Witte, 1998, 84.

¹⁶³ Gese, 1973, 82; Witte, 1998, 263–275; Pfeiffer, 2001, 14.

¹⁶⁴ Keel, 1997, 142 Fig. 189, 143 Figs. 190–191, 190, 150 Fig. 202.

¹⁶⁵ See Küchler, 2007, 249–251.

Gen 2:17 ultimately leaves no doubt that the Tree of Life was one of the trees in the Garden whose fruit was permitted to be eaten according to Gen 2:16: The most obvious explanation is that humanity had to eat repeatedly from the Tree of Life in order to maintain its immortality, but this interpretation cannot work because of Gen 3:22 and the larger context of the tradition: Eating from the Tree of Life leads directly to immortality (see Gilgm 11.285–286). Is it then sheer coincidence that humanity was able to be expelled from the Garden in time? In its naïvety, did humanity not recognize the significance of the tree, or were they not able to differentiate between the two trees?¹⁶⁶ These are all open questions, and one cannot help but notice that the author of 3:22, 24 had no interest in such questions.¹⁶⁷ Of course, this also speaks against, rather than for, the assumption that the motif of the Tree of Life was firmly anchored in the Garden narrative from the outset.

¹⁶⁶ Schmid, 2002, 31f.

¹⁶⁷ Seebaß, 132.

THE DESCENDANTS OF ADAM AND EVE

- 4:1** *But the Human knew Eve, his wife. And she became pregnant and gave birth to Cain and said, “I have acquired a man with Yhwh.”*
- 2** *And she continued to give birth to his brother, Abel. And Abel became a shepherd of a flock, and Cain became a tiller of the soil.*
- 3** *After some time, Cain brought a gift to Yhwh from the fruit of the soil.*
- 4** *And Abel, he too brought from the firstborn of his flock, from their fatty parts. Then Yhwh looked upon Abel and his gift.*
- 5** *But he did not look upon Cain and his gift. Then Cain became very angry, and his face sank.*
- 6** *Then Yhwh said to Cain, “Why are you angry, and why has your face sunk?*
- 7** *Is it not so that if you let it go, then [it would mean the] lifting up [of your face]; if you do not let it go, then sin is a croucher [coming] towards the door, and its desire is after you, but you shall rule over it?”*
- 8** *And Cain said to Abel, his brother ... And as they were in the field, Cain rose up against Abel, his brother, and killed him.*
- 9** *And Yhwh said to Cain, “Where is Abel, your brother?” And he said, “I do not know; am I my brother’s keeper?”*
- 10** *And he said, “What have you done? The voice of your brother’s blood cries out to me from the soil.*
- 11** *And now: Cursed are you away from the soil, which has opened its maw to receive your brother’s blood from your hand.*
- 12** *When you till the field, it will no longer give you its strength. Restless and homeless will you be upon the earth!”*
- 13** *Then Cain said to Yhwh, “My guilt is too great to bear.*
- 14** *See, today you are banishing me from the soil, and I am withdrawn from your face, and I will be restless and homeless upon the earth, and everyone who meets me will kill me.”*
- 15** *Then Yhwh said to him, “Not so! Whoever kills Cain, he [it] will be avenged sevenfold.” And Yhwh set a sign for Cain, so that everyone who meets him would not slay him.*
- 16** *Then Cain left Yhwh’s presence and settled in the land of Nod, east of Eden.*
- 17** *And Cain knew his wife and she became pregnant and gave birth to Enoch. And he became the builder of a city, and he named the city after the name of his son, Enoch.*

- 18 *And Irad was born to Enoch, and Irad fathered Mehujael, and Mehujael fathered Methushael, and Methushael fathered Lamech.*
- 19 *And Lamech took two wives. The name of the first was “Adah,” and the name of the second was “Zillah.”*
- 20 *Then Adah gave birth to Jabal. He is the father of those who dwell in tents and by the herds.*
- 21 *The name of his brother was “Jubal.” He is the father of all who play the lyre and the flute.*
- 22 *And Zillah, she also gave birth, to Tubal-Cain, a sharpener of metal for all who smith bronze or iron. And the sister of Tubal-Cain was Na’amah.*
- 23 *Then Lamech said to his wives,
“Adah and Zillah, hear my voice!
Wives of Lamech, listen to my words!
Truly, I have killed a man for my wound,
And a young boy for my bruise!*
- 24 *Truly, sevenfold was Cain avenged,
But Lamech seventy-sevenfold!”*
- 25 *And Adam knew his wife again and she gave birth to a son and called his name “Seth,” for “God has given me another descendant in the place of Abel, since Cain killed him.”*
- 26 *And a son was also born to Seth. And he called his name “Enosh.”
In those days, people began to call upon the name of Yhwh.*

Analysis: Gen 4:1–26a comes from the Scholarly Narrator, with additions in Gen 4:6–8a, 17* [Enoch] whose redaction-critical assignment is unclear. Gen 4:26b(?) may be a supplement by the Redaction.

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TEXT-CRITICAL AND PHILOLOGICAL NOTES

4:3 וַיְהִי מִקֵּץ יָמִים (*After some time*): For this formulation, see also 1 Kgs 17:7.

4:4 וּמִחֲלֵבָהֶן (*from their fatty parts*): The plural form in the MT is supported by the SP. On the orthographic variants, see Joüon/Muraoka §94h.

4:7 הֲלוֹא אִם־תִּיטִיב שָׂאת וְאִם לֹא תִיטִיב לִפְתּוֹחַ חֲטָאת רִבֵּץ (*Is it not so that if you let it go, then [it would mean the] lifting up [of your face]; if you do not let it go, then sin is a croucher [coming] towards the door?*): The LXX translates οὐκ ἐὰν ὀρθῶς προσενέγκῃς ὀρθῶς δὲ μὴ διέλης ἥμαρτες (“Is it not so that if you present [it] correctly but divide [it] incorrectly, you have sinned?”). M. Rösel has shown that the translation offers an equivalent to each word in the Hebrew text, but the choice of the Greek equivalents and the rendering of grammatical forms indicate “that the translator has derived the presumed meaning of the verse from its context” (Rösel, 1994, 105 [translation JWR]). The philological problems of the verse are hardly solvable through text-critical means or by free conjectures.

4:8 וַיֹּאמֶר קַיִן אֶל־הָבֶל אָחִיו (*And Cain said to Abel, his brother*): The LXX, the SP, and many translations both ancient and modern feel a need for direct speech here, especially since *אמר (“to say”) is generally not used absolutely (cf. Exod 19:25 [literary-critical seam]; Jon 2:11; 2 Chr 1:2; the case is somewhat different in Gen 22:7 and 2 Sam 21:2f., since the *אמר used absolutely is followed by a second *אמר as an introduction to literal speech). Accordingly, following the LXX, “Let us go to the field” (Διέλθωμεν εἰς τὸ πεδῖον) is often added with slight variation (Dillmann, 94f. and Hendel, 1998, 129). Some manuscripts indicate a textual gap after אָחִיו (“his brother”) via a piska. The omission could be explained as an homoioteleuton. The MT is supported by a fragment from Qumran (4QGen^b, Frag. 3i [DJD XII, 36]) as well as Tg. Onq. and is the more difficult reading, which presumably led to it being smoothed out through the addition of a rather irrelevant speech. Tg. Ps.-J. and Tg. Neof. use the gap to insert a lengthy dialogue between the brothers, in which Abel lectures his brother on the reasons for God’s reaction. A conjecture by Gunkel (44) is particularly appealing: He suggested reading

וַיִּמָּר (“and quarrelling began”) instead of וַיֹּאמֶר (“and he said”). However, *מרה is otherwise constructed with בָּ or עַם. Another possibility, following Gunkel, would also be וַיִּמָּר (“and he became embittered against him”; see Dan 8:7 מרר in hithpalp.). There have sometimes been conjectures of וַיִּשְׁמַר (“and he watched out for [Abel]”), which would result in a “daring play on words” (Holzinger, 48 [translation JWR]) with v. 9 הֲשֹׁמֵר אָחִי אֲנֹכִי; “am I my brother’s keeper?”) because of the shared root. However, there are no textual witnesses to this. Thus, it is best to adhere to the MT (following, among others, Jacob, 140). Yet, it remains unclear how to understand the verse. B. Jacob takes the half-verse as divine speech and translates, “And Kaiyn said such to his brother, Hebel.” It does not state why, and such a formulation would be out of the ordinary. The latter also speaks against the proposal by P.T. Reis, translating: “And Cain spoke *against* Abel, his brother” (Reis, 2002, 107).

4:12 לֹא-תִסָּף תִּתְּכֶחָה לָּךְ (*it will no longer give you its strength*): For this unusual connection of the jussive תִּסָּף with לֹא, see GKC §109d+h.

נָע וָנָד (*Restless and homeless*): The LXX στένων καὶ τρέμων (“sighing and trembling”) imitates the alliteration of the נָע וָנָד.

4:15 לָכֵן (*Not so*): Following the LXX (including the recensions by Symmachus and Theodotion), Pesh, and Vulg, which read לֹא כֵן instead of the לָכֵן (“therefore”) of the MT und SP.

שִׁבְעָתַיִם יָקָם וַיִּשָּׂם (*he [it] will be avenged sevenfold*): Subj. of *נָקָם q. pass. (“to be avenged”) is either Cain or (impersonally) the deed itself (see Skinner, 110; Procksch, 49). Conversely, most of the German-language commentaries assume that, unlike in Gen 4:24; Exod 21:21, the perpetrator is the subject of the *נָקָם q. pass. and translate it as “he [the perpetrator] will experience/suffer vengeance sevenfold.” Aside from the entirely different use of *נָקָם q. pass. in Gen 4:24, this translation fails already because of the logical difficulties in explaining the “sevenfold” vengeance in this case. Yet, it is completely possible to avenge Cain or the deed by killing seven people from the perpetrator’s clan (Gen 4:24). A sevenfold killing of the perpetrator is only possible with the help of further assumptions about the individual experience of collective revenge. According to this, for example, killing the perpetrator’s close relatives would also count as killing the perpetrator himself. There is nothing about this given in the text (or the rest of the Hebrew Bible). The lack of an indicated subject in an oral speech should not be surprising, given the concise language across the whole chapter.

4:18 מְהוּיָאֵל (*Mehujael*): The MT reads מְהִיָּאֵל. The fact that the name appears with two spellings in one verse is hardly original; see the SP and LXX.

4:20 יָשָׁב (*dwel*): On the transitive use of *יָשָׁב (“dwell”), see *GKC* §117bb. The semantically incongruent coordination of “dwell,” “tent,” and “herds” should presumably be resolved through the rhetorical device of zeugma, in which a verb refers to two nouns despite semantically fitting only one of them. See also Ps 34:16. In terms of its meaning, the passage is unambiguous.

4:22 לִטֵּשׁ כָּל-חֹרֶשׁ נְחֹשֶׁת וּבְרָזָל (*a sharpener of metal for all who smith bronze or iron*): The text of v. 22aβ is probably in some state of disarray. The LXX smooths it out and reads “and he was a hammerer who smithed bronze and iron.” The כָּל-חֹרֶשׁ (“all who smith”) is difficult. A translation as a direct object (“a sharpener of every craftsman”) does not work. A proposal by Seebaß, 165f. is appealing: He separates the compound כָּל-חֹרֶשׁ and reads כל as a defective כָּלִי (“tool”), so “a sharpener of utensils; a craftsman of bronze and iron.” The translation offered here takes כָּל-חֹרֶשׁ as the indirect object of לִטֵּשׁ (“to sharpen”), while the direct object goes unmentioned.

4:26 אֶזְזוּ הַיּוֹחֵל (*In those days, people began*): See *GKC* §144k. The Targums understand *חָלַל ho. in the sense of “to profane/desecrate” (see *חָלַל pi.) and recognize in the notice the beginning of idolatry. Already Ibn Ezra remarked on this that, in this case, יִהְיֶה שֵׁם חָלַל would be expected. The LXX reads οὐδὲς ἠλπίσεν (“he hoped”; cf. Scholarly Exposition II).

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION I: INTRODUCTION TO EXEGESIS

Following the Garden narrative, the Scholarly Narrator describes the fate of the descendants of the first human couple, as well as the following generations up to the Flood, through a genealogy of their sons. Woven into the genealogy alongside succinct notices about the history of civilization (Gen 4:20–22, 26b) are a narrative element in the form of the story of Cain and Abel (Gen 4:2–16) and a poetic element in the form of the Song of Lamech (Gen 4:23–24). The origins of the chapter and its constituent parts can be discussed only in connection with each other. The “Essentials and Perspectives” will be detailed separately for each of the two main parts of the chapter, the Fratricide narrative in Gen 4:1–17 and the short civilizational history of the Cainites and Sethites in Gen 4:18–26.

Formation: The story of Cain’s fratricide, and sometimes also the Song of Lamech, is often regarded as a (multistaged) redactional insertion into an older Cainite genealogy (Gen 4:1, 17–22 [23–24]).¹ In addition to the differences

¹ Following suggestions in Wellhausen, 1899, 8–14, this has been the oft-repeated majority opinion since Budde, 1883, 183–209; Stade, 1894, 254–283, despite all differences in details

in form, there are content-related peculiarities within the chapter that can support this. It is surprising in this primeval context that the first descendant of Adam and Eve (v. 1) is born into an already populated world, since the questions inevitably arise as to where Cain's wife comes from (v. 17), who is to avenge Cain's murder of Abel in a world that still lacks other humans (v. 14), and for whom Cain's son Enoch builds a city (v. 17). Furthermore, according to the story, Cain is punished with a restless and homeless way of life (v. 12), while the genealogy mentions the founding of a city at the beginning of the civilization-building achievements of Cain and his descendants (v. 17).² Moreover, only the Sethite genealogy at the end of the chapter (Gen 4:25–26; see v. 25) and possibly the Song of Lamech (Gen 4:24) appear to know anything of the fratricide. Due to these tensions, the Fratricide narrative is often seen as having a formation history separate from the Cainite genealogy, which in turn was separate from the Sethite genealogy. Some scholars see these as formerly independent traditions,³ while others consider the Sethite genealogy to be a redactional addition, either to integrate the narrative of Cain and Abel into an older genealogy of the Cainites⁴ or to serve as a transition to the Priestly genealogy in Gen 5.⁵

In favor of this classification of the Sethite genealogy, it has been argued that it functions in its present literary context as a transition to the “Register of the *Toledot*/Generations of Adam” in Gen 5 (P). Here, Seth is also mentioned, but as the first-born of Adam. Yet, this says nothing in and of itself about the redactional origins of the Sethite genealogy but rather highlights the skills of the Redaction in connecting the given texts. The repeated mention of Seth (see Gen 4:25 and 5:3) and Enosh (see Gen 4:26 and 5:6) speaks more for two variants of one and the same genealogy than for one purely redactional transition.⁶

How can the factual tensions and oddities in form in the chapter be brought together to form a coherent picture of the formation of the text? It makes the most sense to begin the analysis not with the earlier traditions but with the stratum of the Scholarly Narrator, which is much more tangible. For his narrative, it seems that each individual part of Gen 4:1–26 is set within the overall context and cannot be removed from it. The most fundamental

and literary-critical assignments. For discussion, see Witte, 1998, 151–155, 166–169; Gertz, 2004, 221f., 234f. and fn. 58.

² Wellhausen, 1899, 8: “The contradiction is fundamental and involves the entire view; v. 16ff. does not presuppose vv. 1–15” [translation JWR].

³ von Rad, 110; Westermann, 285.

⁴ See Wellhausen, 1899, 14; Budde, 1883, 159; Gunkel, 54f.; Dietrich, 2002, 161. According to Dietrich, the allusions to the Fratricide narrative in v. 25* are redactional, so that the earliest form read, “And Adam knew his wife... and she gave birth to a son and she named him ‘Seth,’ for ‘God has given me a ... descendant’” [translation JWR].

⁵ See Noth, 1972, 12 fn. 26; Witte, 1998, 62–65.

⁶ So first Buttman, 1828, 171.

aspect for the structure of the chapter is the contrast between the Cainites and Sethites leading up to the Flood: The line of descendants for the brother-slayer Cain leads to a steady increase in violence and reaches its climax and conclusion with Lamech and his sons (Gen 4:17–24). In contrast, standing at the end of the lineage of the successor, Seth, is the hero of the Flood, Noah (see on Gen 5:28–29* below), and with him the survival of humanity. This contrast between the Cainites and Sethites thus leads up to the Flood, which also explains the oft-noted differences in the genealogies as well as the repeated mention of the birth of a child by the first man and woman. In order to emphasize the contrast between the two lines, it must be the proper names of the respective fathers at the beginning (Cain in v. 17; Adam in v. 25) and no longer the generic designation “(hu)man” (הָאָדָם in v. 1) like in their earlier, shared history. Furthermore, with the fathering of Cain, “the Human” is no longer the only man, so the individuation of humanity and, with it, the transition to the use of proper names is already laid out in Gen 4:1. Thus, the repeatedly advanced argument that the use of Adam’s proper name in Gen 4:25 is suggested by Gen 5:1, 3, 4, 5 (P) is also invalid. The fact that the name of the woman is not mentioned in v. 25, unlike in v. 1, is also due to the parallel construction to v. 17. The different tone in the justification of the name from the self-confident “I have acquired... with Yhwh” (v. 1b) to the modest “God has given” (v. 25b) can in contrast be seen as a result of the progression of the narrative. After the fratricide, all that remains is the humble designation of the thirdborn son as a gift from God. Unlike v. 1b, the designation אֱלֹהִים “God” is used instead of the divine name, which is sufficiently explainable in the present text through the following notice in which the invocation of the name “Yhwh” begins only a generation later (v. 26).⁷ These variations can therefore easily be explained as having resulted from their present context.

In any case, in terms of its formation history, a common feature of the Fratricide narrative as well as the Cainite and Sethite genealogies should be weighted much more heavily: Only the three birth notices in Gen 4:1, 17, 25 use the verb *יָדַע “to know” within a genealogy to describe sexual intercourse. Obviously, the use of language deviating from the norm serves to emphasize in particular these first begettings in human history. Thus, the guiding term of the Garden narrative, *יָדַע “to know,” was deliberately taken up (see Gen 2:[9] 17; 3:5, 7 [22]). Accordingly, the opening genealogical notices in Gen 4:1, 17, 25 and their related passages were formulated with the Garden narrative and the division of antediluvian humanity in mind.⁸ In

⁷ Should v. 26b go back to a later revision (see below), then the אֱלֹהִים “God” in v. 25b may also come from this. In any case, it can be ruled out that the author of v. 26b would have used the name of God in v. 25b or – if v. 26b is a later addition – would have left it in.

⁸ See further Arneth, 2007, 160f.

their present forms, it is therefore difficult to separate Gen 4:1, 17 and Gen 4:25 from each other and from the Garden narrative and to approach each as the beginning of an original genealogy. The results of the literary analysis of the story of Cain and Abel also fit to this. The Fratricide narrative was not simply inserted into the genealogy but is introduced by v. 1f., which is usually considered to be part of the genealogy. Consequently, the Fratricide narrative cannot be separated from v. 1f.; at the same time, it is presupposed by the beginning of the Sethite genealogy (see v. 25), which is itself connected to v. 1f. Even just this speaks against any literary-critical separation of it from the work of the Scholarly Narrator. Likewise, structural similarities between the interrogation scene and the punishment scene (see on Gen 4:9–15 below) show that the connection with the Garden narrative of the Scholarly Narrator is “not merely redactional but also conceptual.”⁹

Tradition: Consequently, Gen 4:1–26 must come from the Scholarly Narrator and author of the Garden narrative, with only 4:6–8a and possibly 4:26b being secondary (see below). Of course, the inclusion by the Scholarly Narrator of older, partially also written traditional material cannot be excluded for the Fratricide narrative, the Song of Lamech, or the notices concerning the history of civilization. In light of the aforementioned tensions in content, the difficulties around the naming of Cain (see on v. 1 below), the differences in form, the widespread use of the motif of feuding brothers,¹⁰ and the parallel Priestly versions of both genealogies in Gen 5 that make no reference to the fratricide, such an assumption is even quite likely. However, the fact remains that this tradition has been so thoroughly reshaped by the Scholarly Narrator that any reconstruction of an older narrative thread in the non-Priestly Primeval History is impossible. The narrative context comes from the Scholarly Narrator. He is the author of the chapter, which was written within the context of the Garden narrative and the Flood narrative.

Connected with the assumption of older traditional material is the much-discussed question of a historical background of this material being within a tribal context. Was “Cain” originally the eponym of a tribe of “Kenites” from southern Palestine, whose nomadic way of life presented itself from the perspective of the inhabitants of cultivated land as a cursed existence and which, moreover, bore a certain tribal symbol?¹¹ Speaking in favor of this assumption is how, outside of Gen 4, “Cain” is always a tribal name (see Judg 4:11; 5:24; Num 24:21f.). The genealogy of Cain’s

⁹ Seebaß, 161 [translation JWR].

¹⁰ For an overview, see Bremmer, 2003, 77–92.

¹¹ Fundamental for the interpretation as a tribal history is Stade, 1894. See also more recently Dietrich, 2002 as well as Day, 2013, 51–60. On the debate of whether the Fratricide narrative should be understood in terms of “tribal history” or “individually, primevally,” see, opting for the latter alternative, Westermann, 284.

descendants also predominantly points *prima facie* to a nomadic milieu. This is obvious for the tent dwellers (Gen 4:20) but, according to the typical view, also applies to the “traveling companies” of flute and lyre players (Gen 4:21) and the metal-workers (Gen 4:22) (see below on 4:20–22). What remains difficult is how the foundation of the first city is also associated with Cain (Gen 4:17). It is also quite uncertain who would have spoken about the Kenites in this way. In any case, the Kenites would hardly have attributed their specific way of life to a “curse” or even described themselves as “restless and homeless, far from Yhwh.” Even just from the perspective of the Hebrew Bible, this etiology would be conspicuous, since the Kenites appear in the Exodus narrative as worshippers of Yhwh and as guardians of the mountain of God (Num 10:29, also Judg 4:11, 17; 5:24 and Exod 18; further 1 Sam 15:6). Additionally, the authors of the Hebrew Bible always emphasized and valued their own nomadic heritage. Finally, the exact elements about tribal etiologies in the present version of the Cain and Abel narrative have clearly been formulated within the context of the Garden narrative and, thus, with a perspective oriented towards the Primeval History and the beginnings of humanity. Within this, Cain is the prototypical human prone to hatred and violence. The assumption of a background in a tribal history for individual traits of the narrative and the genealogy thus has a certain probability to it, but the transformation of this material was so thorough that an exact historical assignment of its traditions, or even a delineation of its vocabulary, is hardly possible anymore. In any case, in its present text, the Fratricide narrative is to be read both primevally and individually. In other words, “Cain is not an ethnological type but a moral type.”¹²

1. Genesis 4:1–16: Cain and Abel

- 4:1** *But the Human knew Eve, his wife. And she became pregnant and gave birth to Cain and said, “I have acquired a man with Yhwh.”*
- 2** *And she continued to give birth to his brother, Abel. And Abel became a shepherd of a flock, and Cain became a tiller of the soil.*
- 3** *After some time, Cain brought a gift to Yhwh from the fruit of the soil.*
- 4** *And Abel, he too brought from the firstborn of his flock, from their fatty parts. Then Yhwh looked upon Abel and his gift.*
- 5** *But he did not look upon Cain and his gift. Then Cain became very angry, and his face sank.*
- 6** *Then Yhwh said to Cain, “Why are you angry, and why has your face sunk?”*
- 7** *Is it not so that if you let it go, then [it would mean the] lifting up [of your face]; if you do not let it go, then sin is a croucher [coming] towards the door, and its desire is after you, but you shall rule over it?”*
- 8** *And Cain said to Abel, his brother ... And as they were in the field, Cain rose up against Abel, his brother, and killed him.*

¹² Jacob, 156 [translation JWR].

- 9 *And Yhwh said to Cain, "Where is Abel, your brother?" And he said, "I do not know; am I my brother's keeper?"*
- 10 *And he said, "What have you done? The voice of your brother's blood cries out to me from the soil.*
- 11 *And now: Cursed are you away from the soil, which has opened its maw to receive your brother's blood from your hand.*
- 12 *When you till the field, it will no longer give you its strength. Restless and homeless will you be upon the earth!"*
- 13 *Then Cain said to Yhwh, "My guilt is too great to bear.*
- 14 *See, today you are banishing me from the soil, and I am withdrawn from your face, and I will be restless and homeless upon the earth, and everyone who meets me will kill me."*
- 15 *Then Yhwh said to him, "Not so! Whoever kills Cain, he [it] will be avenged sevenfold." And Yhwh set a sign for Cain, so that everyone who meets him would not slay him.*
- 16 *Then Cain left Yhwh's presence and settled in the land of Nod, east of Eden.*

ESSENTIALS AND PERSPECTIVES

The most well-known section of the composition about the descendants of Adam and Eve in Gen 4 is without a doubt the narrative of Cain's murder of his brother, Abel. Standing at its center is the experience of inequality among equals ("brothers") and the appropriate way of handling such. The fateful event is set into motion by how God regards Abel's gift but not Cain's gift. This preference of one gift over the other is given no justification. God's differing reactions to the brothers' gifts is attributed neither to Cain's attitude nor to the way in which he offered the gift; it is just stated, and quite simply so. Like also with Cain's heinous deed, the biblical text offers no explanation for something so incomprehensible. Rather, there are many deliberate gaps and ambiguities with which the Scholarly Narrator drives to the extreme the problem of contingent experience and the overcoming of it. Even in the earliest interpretations, the biblical text's refusal to provide an explanation set into motion a multifaceted process of interpretation. Particularly noteworthy are the ancient Greek translation, the paraphrasing rendition in the Aramaic Targums, and the allusions to the narrative in Christian and early Islamic tradition (see Scholarly Exposition II on vv. 5, 7 below).¹³

Cain's deed is a possible, although not necessary, consequence of transgressing the divine prohibition against Adam and Eve eating from the Tree

¹³ See further Oberhänsli-Widmer, 2004; Erzberger, 2011, 3; 2014.

of Knowledge. With it, humanity attained that which constitutes its essence – namely, the knowledge of what is conducive to life and what is detrimental to it. This is demonstrated in the Garden narrative with the example of nakedness. It presents the attainment of knowledge as a step from childlike innocence into the self-awareness of adulthood. This episode, about transgressing the divine commandment, thus illustrates the transition from the pre-human to human, or from nature to civilization, and thus to experienced reality. The motif, including its sexual connotations, is also attested in extrabiblical texts. Characteristic of the biblical version is how the Scholarly Narrator emphasizes the ambiguity that comes with attaining knowledge and reaching civilization. Fundamentally, knowledge bears positive connotations for the Scholarly Narrator (the ability to distinguish between good and bad is, up to then, a privilege of God). At the same time, however, humanity's first attainment of knowledge also results from the transgression of the divine commandment, which is why the achievements of civilization described in what follows are also turned into the aftereffects of the transgression. With the ability to *distinguish* between good and bad comes the possibility of *choosing* the good or the bad. How this possibility, enabled by the knowledge, can lead to choosing the bad and, therefore, to an act of violence is demonstrated by the story of Cain's murder of his brother, Abel.

The close connection between Adam and Eve's transgression of the divine prohibition and Cain choosing bad over good, as well as God's consequent admonition to give no room to sin that Cain rejects immediately beforehand, raises the question about the understanding of sin in Gen 2–4: In the fifth chapter of his letter to the Romans, Paul explains that sin, and with it, death, entered the world through a human being, Adam (Rom 5:12ff.). This idea has deeply shaped the Christian understanding of sin. Although it is "biblical," it is only to a certain extent based in the Hebrew Bible. As seen above, the concept of "sin" is absent in the Garden narrative. Furthermore, one can only with certain reservations agree with Paul that the transgression of the prohibition against eating from the Tree of Knowledge brought death into the world. According to Gen 2–3, humanity is endowed with mortality from the outset (Gen 2:7; 3:19), and it is true for at best only the redactional final form of the Garden narrative that the essentially mortal human is excluded from access to eternal life via expulsion from the Garden (so Gen 3:22). Terminologically, sin first appears in the story of Cain and Abel. Here, it is mentioned twice, and in two distinguishable ways: first, with a transgression that violates a community relationship and is able to grow into a demon (חַטָּאת "sin" in Gen 4:7); second, with the offense and its inevitable consequences for the perpetrator (חַטֵּאת "guilt" in Gen 4:13). It is tempting, in contradiction to Paul's understanding, to call the story of Cain and Abel the actual narrative of the Fall, given the lack of any mention of sin in the Garden narrative and

its first mention only in Gen 4:7.¹⁴ This is possible, but it is only an incomplete description of how “sin” as a theme is developed between the two narratives. It is particularly noticeable that the Garden narrative and the story of Cain and Abel display great parallels in structure.¹⁵ The exposition and presentation of the initial situations (Gen 2:4–15 // Gen 4:1–5) are each followed by divine warnings (Gen 2:16f. // Gen 4:7), which are each disregarded (Gen 3:1–7 // Gen 4:8). Following are God’s questions of first “Where?” and then “What?” (Gen 3:9, 13 // Gen 4:9, 10), a curse and the explanation of the consequences for humanity (Gen 3:14–19 // Gen 4:11–12), a notice about God caring for the people affected (Gen 3:21 // Gen 4:15), and the expulsion of the people from the location of the incident (Gen 3:23f. // Gen 4:16). Additionally, there are several oft-noted terminological cross-references, all of which refer to the transgression of the prohibition of eating from the Tree of Knowledge, as well as to its consequences. This can hardly be coincidental. It can be explained through how both narratives deal with (among other equally significant topics) the shared question of how sin entered into the world. However, the transgression of the prohibition against eating from the Tree of Knowledge only creates the condition for the possibility of sin, namely, the knowledge of good and bad and the related opportunity for choice. God’s warning to Cain clearly alludes to this possibility with the call to “let it go” (Gen 4:7). Sin is neither intrinsic nor innate to humanity but, with the choice of good or bad, is immediately close to it and a danger to it. As is well known, Cain decides to do otherwise, at which point sin becomes a reality for the first time. Although it is a consequence of the transgression of the divine commandments, the human autonomy to decide between good and bad is not a sin in and of itself but simply a post-Eden reality. It can, however, lead to sin.¹⁶ In light of Gen 4 and the further narratives in the Primeval History, one gets the impression that, for the Scholarly Narrator, humanity is characterized by its tendency to pick the wrong choice (so Gen 6:5).

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION II: EXEGESIS

4:1–2

- 1 *But the Human knew Eve, his wife. And she became pregnant and gave birth to Cain and said, “I have acquired a man with Yhwh.”*
- 2 *And she continued to give birth to his brother, Abel. And Abel became a shepherd of a flock, and Cain became a tiller of the soil.*

¹⁴ For this tendency in more recent interpretation, see Schüle, 2006, 155f., *passim*.

¹⁵ See most recently Heyden, 2003, 103f.

¹⁶ Following Crüsemann, 1980, 69.

The narrative's exposition describes the conditions of the conflict between the two brothers. At the same time, it marks the transition from the history of Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden to the history of humanity. The latter explains the oft-noted conspicuousness of the notice about the fathering and birth in v. 1. The man continues to be called "*the Human*" (הָאָדָם); only with the opening of the second genealogical tier does he receive the proper name "Adam" (אָדָם; v. 25). By this point, in contrast, the woman had already received her proper name "Eve" (חַוָּה) at the end of the Garden narrative (Gen 3:20). This is explicitly taken up with the mention of the woman's name, which generally happens in genealogies only in exceptional cases (so Gen 4:19–23; 11:27–32; cf. Gen 5; 10; 11:10–26).¹⁷ The first begetting and birthing of a human being thus proves to be a practical realization of the insight expressed in the explanation of the name in Gen 3:20, in which Eve is the "mother of all living."¹⁸ The choice of יָדַע "to know" as an euphemism for conception underscores this idea, which closely ties the opening of the Fratricide narrative and the two subsequent begettings (Gen 4:17, 25) to the Garden narrative. Like in other Semitic languages, the Garden narrative's key term יָדַע encompasses the whole conceptual field of knowledge gained mostly through concrete perception, also including sexuality.¹⁹ Accordingly, the relatively few relevant references to יָדַע in the Hebrew Bible refer almost without exception to sexual experience (or lack thereof).²⁰ Likewise, nothing more should be read into the use of the word in Gen 4:1. In any case, "that the bodily relationship of man and woman is not thought of primarily as physiological, but as personal"²¹ is hardly inferable from the other attestations of יָדַע that bear sexual connotations. The use of יָדַע in Gen 4:1, 17, 25, which deviates from the other genealogies of the Hebrew Bible, can instead be explained entirely and exclusively through its reference back to the Garden narrative and the knowledge that humanity acquired there, which also includes the knowledge necessary for procreation and, thus, for the beginning of human history.

The mother names her first son "Cain" (קַיִן). This name is also found in Num 24:22; Judg 4:11, but there, it clearly designates the tribe of the Kenites (see above). The etymology of the name is unclear. Most likely, it is connected to the root attested in Arabic of קִיַן "to shape, form," from

¹⁷ See on this Hieke, 2003, 278–288.

¹⁸ See Bühner, 2014, 250.

¹⁹ See Botterweck, 1982, esp. 490 and the Ugaritic example mentioned there for a paralleling of "to know" and "to become pregnant."

²⁰ Gen 19:8; 24:16; Num 31:18; Judg 11:39; 21:12; 1 Kgs 1:4 all note that (still) no intercourse had taken place, while Num 31:17, 35; Judg 21:11 give the opposite. The exceptions are the references to rape in Gen 19:5; Judg 19:22, 25. 1 Samuel 1:19 is about marital intercourse.

²¹ Westermann, 289.

which the noun “blacksmith, craftsman” derives.²² This would fit well with the genealogical notice in Gen 4:22, which traces the status of particularly skilled metalworkers back to a later descendant of Cain named “Tubal-Cain” (see below). Also suggestive of blacksmithing is the meaning of קֶן in 2 Sam 21:16 as “spear,” which is also attested in other Semitic languages. Here, however, the naming by the mother in v. 1b is free of such considerations. She connects the name with the root *קנה₁ “to acquire” or *קנה₂ “to create,” leading to the explanation אֶת־יְהוָה אִישׁ קָנִיתִי “I have acquired/created a man with/through Yhwh.” With this statement, Eve has caused serious problems of intelligibility for interpretations of the passage. Of the two homophonic roots *קנה₁ und *קנה₂ (see Ges¹⁸, קנה_{1/2} and further literature therein), *קנה₁ is far more commonly attested. Moreover, the rarer root *קנה₂ “to create” always has God as its subject (see Gen 14:19, 22; Deut 32:6; Ps 139:13; Prov 8:22), although the metaphorical statement in Ps 139:13, “For you created (קָנִיתִי) my kidneys, you wove me in my mother’s womb,” does not exclude joint activity between the deity and the mother. It is further surprising that the birth of a boy is mentioned as a אִישׁ “man” (cf. וְרַע אֲנָשִׁים “male offspring” in 1 Sam 1:11). Finally, the expression אֶת־יְהוָה also causes difficulties, since אֶת can be either the definite direct object marker or a preposition. Philologically, the easiest translation is as a double accusative: “I have acquired, as a man, Yhwh.” But what exactly is meant by this remains unclear. In any case, the interpretations that Eve, overwhelmed by giving birth, ascribes to the man the life-giving power that belongs to Yhwh, or that Cain is declared to be the “Son of God,” lack almost any support in the text itself.²³ The ancient translations are not stable but tend towards the translation as a preposition. Thus, the LXX gives διὰ τοῦ θεοῦ “through God,” which suggests divine involvement, as in Ps 139.²⁴ Speaking in favor of this understanding is also the Akkadian name *Itti-Aššur-ašamšu* “From (the god) Aššur I have acquired,” which also shares a similar construction.²⁵ The meaning of the unusual explanation of the name becomes clear in light of its context: The choice of *קנה₁, which is rare in this meaning, is suggested by the phonetic allusion to the name “Qayin” presumably already present in this tradition. At the same time, this provided an opportunity for taking up the man’s shout of jubilation after the creation of the woman (Gen 2:23b), which is also formulated as a name etiology. Just as Yhwh formed the woman (אִשָּׁה)

²² Wellhausen, 1899, 306; Cassuto, 1:197f.

²³ See Seebaß, 148.

²⁴ According to Rösel, 1994, 102, διὰ instead of the expected μετά weakens the idea of participation.

²⁵ Borger, 1959. See also HS §117b. However, the name could also be translated as “With the help of (the god) Aššur, I acquired.” See CAD, *itti*. Already Ibn Ezra had interpreted the etiology as such.

from the man (אִישׁ), so did the woman and mother of all living beings (Gen 3:20) acquire (*קנה) a man (אִישׁ) with Yhwh (אֱת־יְהוָה), namely, the firstborn human, קַיִן. The reference back to the creation of the woman and her renaming at the end of the Garden narrative also includes the announcement that the woman will give birth in pain (Gen 3:16). Against this background, Eve's idiosyncratic formulation could also be understood such that she, with God's help, has rightfully acquired a male being and that she has consciously endured and acknowledged the circumstances of birth that are in effect after the expulsion from the Garden, which, with their pain and endangerment, do not correspond to the original order of Creation.²⁶

Since with Abel (הָבֶל), deviating from the typical formulations, the Scholarly Narrator reports only of the birth and not the fathering, Jewish, Christian, and Islamic traditions discussed already from early on the possibility of a twin birth.²⁷ The phrase וַתִּסְּף לֵלֶדֶת “and she continued to give birth” (see Gen 38:5, and, for a twin birth, Gen 25:24f.) suggests such an interpretation, but it is not entirely clear in this respect. If they are twins, the brotherly conflict would become even more poignant, as with Esau and Jacob or Romulus and Remus. The name of this child is given no explanation. Nevertheless, it is telling: The basic meaning of הָבֶל is “breath (of air),” and in laments of mortality, it circumscribes humanity's short lifespan (Ps 39:6, 12; 62:10; 78:33; 94:11; 144:4; Job 7:7, 16). The choice of the name הָבֶל echoes the idea of the transience of humanity from the preceding Garden narrative (so Gen 3:19). But above all, it anticipates the child's bitter fate (see also the fate of מַחֲלוֹן, the “sickly one” and כְּלִיּוֹן, the “weak one” in Ruth 1:2, 5). The epithet “his brother” (so vv. 2, 8, 9, 10, 11; on this stylistic device, see also “Isaac, his son” in Gen 22:3, 6, 9) underscores the magnitude of Cain's action, since in Israel as well as other ancient cultures, the close relationship between brothers is regarded as a model for solidary behavior. At the same time, like Abel's imitation of Cain in offering a gift, it shows that Abel is only seen through his relationship to his brother. Abel conspicuously remains without any contour; his only importance in the story is being killed by his brother. The exposition closes with a brief notice about the grown sons' occupations (v. 2b). The economically worded notice is often understood in terms of the history of civilization, recognizing the arable farmer, Cain and the shepherd of small livestock, Abel, as founding figures of competing ways of life.²⁸ However, this is contradicted by how the activity

²⁶ See Willi-Plein, 1993, 79f. Similarly Willi, 1983, 100; Witte, 1998, 166f.

²⁷ For discussion of this and other ambiguities and gaps in the text in late antiquity, see Byron, 2011; see further Gertz, 2014. For the history of Jewish interpretation up to modern times, see Oberhänsli-Widmer, 2004.

²⁸ So already Gunkel, 47f. See also von Rad, 104; Levin, 1993, 97.

of the two brothers and the assumed primordial conflict between farming and nomadic ways of life play no role in the narrative. Additionally, the brothers are themselves unsuitable as founding figures, since, with Abel, the pastoralists would be murdered and, with Cain, the farmers would be driven from their land, so that both basic forms of economic activity in a small-scale farming society would be eliminated from human history. The reference to the Garden narrative is much clearer. Cain is an עֹבֵד אֲדָמָה “tiller of the soil.” He performs the activity to which humanity is assigned (see *עבד + אֲדָמָה in Gen 2:5; 3:23; 4:2, 12). If the אֲדָמָה is also under the curse (Gen 3:17), it is clear from the cultic practice described throughout the Hebrew Bible that no judgment is passed on Cain’s vegetal gift (see Deut 26:2).²⁹ Rather, in this context, the reference to tilling the soil is a reminder that humanity can only feed itself from the אֲדָמָה with great toil and that, despite its best efforts, success sometimes fails to materialize. This experience forms the background of the following scene about sacrifice.

4:3–5

- 3 *After some time, Cain brought a gift to Yhwh from the fruit of the soil.*
 4 *And Abel, he too brought from the firstborn of his flock, from their fatty parts. Then Yhwh looked upon Abel and his gift.*
 5 *But he did not look upon Cain and his gift. Then Cain became very angry, and his face sank.*

After some time, both brothers offer Yhwh a gift from their yields – but while one brother and his gift are accepted by God, the other is not. As with the notices about the brother’s births and their occupations, this sequence of the two brothers’ names constitutes a beautiful chiasm: Cain’s birth and Abel’s birth – Abel’s occupation and Cain’s occupation (v. 1f.); Cain’s gift and Abel’s gift – Yhwh’s positive reaction to Abel’s gift and his negative reaction to Cain’s gift (vv. 3–5). The offerings of the two brothers are shaped as parallels, which is emphasized in Abel’s case by the somewhat awkward construction (“he too”), still in view of the fact that Abel’s actions follow his brother’s (v 4). Once again, Cain proves to be the main character of the story. The scene is formulated so succinctly that there has always been a desire to know more than what the text reveals: What kind of offering is it? How did Cain recognize that Yhwh had no regard for him and his gift, unlike with Abel and his gift? Why did Yhwh have no regard for Cain and his gift? Especially for the last question, it has always been a source of some irritation

²⁹ Cf. Rashi, *ad. loc.*, and most recently Spina, 1992 (see on this in the following).

that the account focuses entirely on the mere event, especially since Yhwh's rejection of sacrifice is always the exception in the Hebrew Bible and, in the other two instances, is explicitly justified through the disobedience of those offering it (Num 16; 1 Sam 15).³⁰ It is therefore not surprising that, in various interpretations of the passage throughout history, the gaps in the text have been filled accordingly in search of an answer.³¹

Already in the LXX's translation of v. 7 (see the Text-critical and Philological Note on v. 7 above), the idea appears of Cain not offering his gift correctly. Yet, what ritual guidelines were there to which Cain could have adhered when presenting humanity's first sacrifice? Likewise, the concise account does not even hint at a mistake in the offering. It rather seems that the cultic aspect of the act is pushed into the background as far as possible, which is why it is not possible even to speak of "sacrifice" in the strict sense of the word: Instead of the technical term *קרב hi. "to offer," the account chooses the unspecific *בוא hi. "to bring," and unlike with Noah's offering at the end of the Flood, there is no report of an altar being constructed (see Gen 8:20). Furthermore, *שעה "to look upon" is otherwise not attested in connection with the acceptance or rejection of a sacrifice. Both offerings are called quite generally "homage offerings" (מִנְחָה), for which mainly vegetal offerings were used. This speaks against the suggestion presented in various forms that the offering of crops was what provoked Yhwh's reaction.³² Others have looked for the reasons for Yhwh's reaction in the person of Cain. In the New Testament, Abel is explicitly described as "righteous" ("Because of faith, Abel offered a better sacrifice than Cain, thereby testifying that he was righteous" [Heb 11:4]) and he appears within a broad stream of Jewish tradition as the first pious person in the Tanakh and the first Jewish martyr ("the blood of Abel the Righteous," Matt 23:35; see also T. Iss. 5:4; T. Ab. 13:2; Frg. Tg. on Gen 4:10; Josephus, A.J. 1.53). The explicit mention of Abel's righteousness and, thus, the implicit mention of Cain's unrighteousness comes from inferring Cain's character based on the fratricide (so 1 John 3:11f.), which in turn is recognized to be the reason for Yhwh's reaction. Such an inference is an obvious move, but it turns the sequence of events upside down and has hardly any textual support. At first glance, the reading of Abel offering his gift with greater devotion and, therefore, Cain and his gift not being regarded seems to have better justification.³³ While only the offering of fruits is communicated for Cain, Abel's gift is presented in slightly more detail with a short postscript. Abel "brought from the firstborn of his flock, from their fatty parts (וּמִחֵלְבֵהֶן)" (v. 4a). This refers either to the best animals of the herd (so Gen 45:18; Ps 147:14; 1 Sam 15:22) or to the fattest parts of the animal (so, e.g., Exod 23:18; 29:13, 22; Lev 3:3f., 9, 14f.). Moreover, the use of the personal suffix (*his* flock) ties the gift back to the person offering the sacrifice. In such a sparsely formulated text, this can be seen as an indication of the inner attitude of the brothers when they present their offerings. However, the question of why Yhwh rejected

³⁰ See Heyden, 2003, 90f.

³¹ See further Gertz, 2014 (with literature).

³² See, e.g., Rashi, *ad. loc.* (fruits coming from the cursed soil); Gunkel, 43 (God loves the shepherd and scorns the farmer); Jacob, 137 (animal sacrifices are more worthy).

³³ So Cassuto, 1:205; Willi, 1983, 101 fn. 8; Heyden, 2003, 94. See critically Westermann, 296; Seebaß, 151.

Cain and his offering is not answered by this. If one does not want to reinterpret the scene as some kind of sacrificial contest, then special care on Abel's part may explain, at best, why the younger brother enjoys the special attention of Yhwh. The negative reaction towards Cain, however, would still remain unjustified, especially since Cain was the first person to ever think of giving something back to the Creator from the yields of his work, and his brother had merely followed him in this. Moreover, the assumption that the "inner attitude" should be relevant for the acceptance of a sacrifice seems like a modern concept read into the text. In cases of sacrifices being rejected or the practice of sacrifice being criticized, it is quite specifically either due to disobedience to the (sacrificial) commandments or due to ethical misconduct. Nevertheless, the differences in the offering descriptions should not be overlooked. Presumably, they are meant to evoke sympathy in the reader for the otherwise rather pallid Abel.³⁴

Going against all of the explanations discussed for the rejection of Cain's gift are how they read information into the text that the text obviously does not want to or cannot give. This suggests that the question of "Why?" so widely discussed in interpretations of the text throughout history and the rather understandable interest in accentuating a conclusive causal connection miss the intention of the text: The different outcomes of the sacrificial scene aim at the fundamental experience of inequality among equals. It is quite likely that the מְנִחָה is meant as a firstfruits offering, returning a portion of the Creator's gift to humanity to him as thanks and as a request for a future gift. It therefore appears that acceptance or rejection can be gauged by the yield.³⁵ In this regard, acceptance and rejection of the sacrifice symbolize the support or impairment that is experienced as a matter of fate, so to speak, independent of performance. "God's disregard for Cain's sacrifice does not go back to Cain's attitude nor to a sacrifice that was not right nor to an incorrect way of offering the sacrifice. It is saying something about the immutable; it happens so."³⁶ Thus, the story of Cain and Abel is centered around the experience of contingency and futility. This has already been reflected in the cursing of the אֲדָמָה at the end of the Garden narrative, and it is now intensified towards the experience that religious practice itself is subject to contingency.³⁷ This experience is explicitly not explained in the text, not even by the possible reference to God's freedom.³⁸ Rather, the text's focus is the insight that injustice, whether objectively given or subjectively felt, can lead to "sin," which in turn raises the question of how to appropriately handle this experience of inequality (vv. 5b, 6–7). Thus, immediately upon Yhwh's

³⁴ See Seebaß, 151.

³⁵ See Cassuto, 1:207; Westermann, 295; Ebach, 1998, 22.

³⁶ Westermann, 296. This reading has been met with widespread agreement. See most recently Schüle, 2006, 185.

³⁷ Arneth, 2007, 152f.

³⁸ So von Rad, 104 with reference to Exod 33:19.

dismissive response, Cain's inner experience is communicated accordingly, to the point of changing his bodily posture. "One can literally see how the affection for his brother dies out and hatred takes hold of him."³⁹ Cain is thus inflamed with wrath because of the injustice that he feels (compare the absolute use of *חרה in Gen 31:36; 34:7; 1 Sam 18:8; 2 Sam 13:21; Jon 4:4). His facial expression drifts away (lit. "his face sank"), he seethes with anger, and, at the same time – and herein lies the actual danger – he is permanently crestfallen and frustrated.⁴⁰

4:6–7

- 6 *Then Yhwh said to Cain, "Why are you angry, and why has your face sunk?"*
- 7 *Is it not so that if you let it go, then [it would mean the] lifting up [of your face]; if you do not let it go, then sin is a croucher [coming] towards the door, and its desire is after you, but you shall rule over it?"*

Yhwh reacts by talking to Cain very briefly. Taking up the notice in v. 5b verbatim, he asks him about the reason for his state of mind (v. 6). The continuation of the speech presents philological problems that are practically unsolvable, which is why a century-old comment on v. 7 is also obligatory at this juncture: It is "the darkest verse of the chapter, even of Genesis."⁴¹ This much is sure: It is an admonition from God that opens with a rhetorical question presenting Cain with an alternative. With the phrase "Is it not so?", Yhwh appeals to a knowledge of "good and bad" that is known well enough to Cain (and the readers) without the need for any prior explanation. The use of *טב "to be good/to act well/to find (sth.) good" also indicates that the cognizance of "good and bad" is being put to a severe test.⁴² However, even the very point of reference for the question of "good or not good" is a matter of debate. Does it have in mind Cain's anger about Yhwh's rejection of his gift, or is it looking ahead to the fratricide? It is often translated with a moral undertone: "If you act well [...] if you do not act well [...]." The question would then offer either a subsequent explanation for the rejection of Cain and his gift or a look ahead to the fratricide. Since *טב q. describes a positive judgment about a person, activity, or condition, the causative *טב hi. should more likely be understood as causing oneself or another to make

³⁹ Levin, 1993, 94 [translation JWR].

⁴⁰ See von Löwenclau, 1978, 183.

⁴¹ Procksch, 47 [translation JWR].

⁴² See Crüsemann, 1980, 64–67.

the judgment in question.⁴³ Accordingly, the rhetorical question refers to Yhwh's differing responses to the two brothers' offerings and urges Cain to accept them by "letting it go." Yhwh presents the prospect of "upliftment" (inf. cstr. of נִשָּׂא). This concise expression leaves some room for interpretation. It is most likely an elliptical expression otherwise unattested in the Hebrew Bible in which the missing object to be "lifted" must be inferred based on context. Since vv. 5b, 6 speak of "[Cain's] face falling," v. 7a would then be the abbreviated version of the widely used phrase "to lift up [one's] face." This again can be understood in a variety of ways:⁴⁴ Cain lifts up his own face, i.e., he can act freely and without anger towards God and people (so 2 Sam 2:22; Job 22:26); Cain lifts up Abel's face, i.e., he can look upon him favorably with no regard to his jealousy (so Gen 32:21); God lifts up Cain's face, i.e., Cain looks upon him favorably with no regard to the rejection of his gift (so Job 42:8f.); God lifts up his own face, i.e., he looks favorably on Cain (so Num 6:26). It is difficult to decide on one of these possibilities – but perhaps such was not the point.

What are the consequences, should Cain not "let it go"? According to the widespread translation also chosen here, Yhwh warns Cain that his burning anger about the perceived injustice has so heavily affected him that he is able to become an easy victim of sin, presented as a personified force. Sin is (like) something crouching at the entrance of the house or, figuratively, at the doorway of the heart. His anger is capable of growing into a demon able to destroy every form of community (see הַטָּאָה "sin" in Gen 50:17). In the end, the fratricide happens because Cain does not succeed in resisting the inner change caused by his anger and, therefore, in defying domination by sin, which has come over him like an external force. The fact that a composed attitude is demanded even in the face of perceived injustice is underscored by the cautionary epilogue (v. 7b). It calls upon Cain to have dominion over sin. Cain is called to "self-control, which simultaneously holds down the fatal influence of sin."⁴⁵ Humanity is not only master of Creation (Gen 1:26) but also called to dominate sin.⁴⁶ The problematic part of this reading is how it connects the fem. הַטָּאָה "sin" with the masc. participle of רָבַץ "to crouch" and that it relates the 3rd pers. masc. suffixes in v. 7b (תִּשְׁקָתוֹ "his desire"; בּוֹ "over him") to the content of the fem. הַטָּאָה. Moreover, it has been objected that across the Hebrew Bible, רָבַץ does not otherwise have the meaning of deceitfully lying in wait but describes the quiet crouching primarily of ani-

⁴³ See Willi, 1983, 102 and fn. 11; Heyden, 2003, 97.

⁴⁴ See Willi, 1983, 102 fn. 12.

⁴⁵ Schüle, 2006, 188 [translation JWR] with reference to its proximity to the Stoic "doctrine of the affections."

⁴⁶ See von Löwenclau, 1978, 187.

mals. The translation chosen here attempts to explain the grammatical incongruence by understanding the participle רִבֵּץ as a predicate noun and הַטָּאָת as the subject. What is “crouched” is the personification of sin, to whom the 3rd pers. masc. suffixes then refer. Although generally, *רִבֵּץ neutrally denotes crouching or rest (so Isa 65:10, paralleled with pasture), it can nevertheless receive a negative meaning through its context. This can be assumed in places where “to crouch” is used for fundamentally threatening things such as the primordial Flood (Gen 49:25; Deut 33:13) or curses (Deut 29:19). The ambiguous usage is also explainable through how ancient Near Eastern cultures connected mythical ideas about demons with the animal world. The crouching of animals may have therefore not been perceived as harmless, as it appears to us today when reading or visiting a zoo. This is especially the case for the crouching of predators (e.g., Gen 49:9). In the context of הַטָּאָת “sin,” a negative meaning of *רִבֵּץ is certainly suggested, especially since the door(way), as a transition from the secure inside to the unprotected outside, is a particularly dangerous place (Zeph 1:8f.).⁴⁷ A distant analogy to the רִבֵּץ presumed in v. 7 can be found with the treacherous demon *rābiṣu* attested in Akkadian texts.⁴⁸ Even if any connection is uncertain beyond the etymological relationship, knowledge of an Akkadian demon in the Hebrew-speaking realm should not be dismissed, nor should a semantic shift from a demon attacking its prey from behind to the personification of sin, who lies in wait for its victim and threatens to dominate them.

Nevertheless, there are still some things that remain problematic about the suggested reading, such as the emphatic placement of the adverbial clause “to the door” at the beginning of the sentence, the personal pronoun suffixes in v. 7b referencing back to the masc. predicate noun רִבֵּץ instead of the fem. subject הַטָּאָת, and the lack of determination for הַטָּאָת. Therefore, I briefly present here a possible alternative in which the masc. participle of *רִבֵּץ “to crouch” refers to Abel, last mentioned in v. 4.⁴⁹ In this interpretation, the לַפֶּתַח “to the door,” emphasized by its position in the sentence, is understood together with הַטָּאָת “sin” as a metaphorical expression for “cause for sin.” This, deviating from the Masoretic vocalization, presupposes a st. cstr. לַפֶּתַח הַטָּאָת “to the door of sin” (instead of לַפֶּתַח הַטָּאָת “at the door [is] sin”).⁵⁰ The verse would then be translated as follows: “If you do not let it go: As a cause for sin, he [= Abel] is crouching. But toward you

⁴⁷ See Donner, 1970, 42–54.

⁴⁸ Barré, 1999.

⁴⁹ See, following considerations by Ibn Ezra, *ad. loc.*, Ehrlich, 1908, 21; Jacob, 139; Willi, 1983, 103 and fn. 13, as well as the interpretations that are largely similar in Heyden, 2003, 97–100 and Janowski, 2003, 149–153. In each case, see also on what follows. For discussion of the theory, see Gertz, 2014, 42–44.

⁵⁰ Ehrlich, 1908, 20.

[= Cain] is his [= Abel's] desire. And you shall prevail over him [= Abel]."⁵¹ If Cain does not recognize God's judgment and continues to be jealous of his brother, then his brother is a constant cause of sin for him. In the continuation of the sentence, Abel remains the subject and the 3rd pers. masc. suffixes refer to Abel, which accords with custom: Abel needs Cain, and the latter is supposed to take care of his younger brother. The brothers' relationship should thus correspond with that of husband and wife (Gen 3:16). Cain is reminded of this. Should he give in to indignation, warns God, then the sheer existence of the favored and yet completely unaware brother will become a cause of sin for him.⁵² Yet, even this alternative reading is fraught with significant difficulties: The presumed abstract meaning of *לִפְתָּח* "door" in the sense of "cause" is not attested anywhere in the Hebrew Bible.⁵³ In conjunction with the presupposed double symbolism, such a meaning is a serious problem for this reading: The expression *לִפְתָּח* "towards the door" is first understood metaphorically as "cause for sin." Then, this metaphorical use is in turn related to Abel, who is not mentioned in the verse. This double symbolism is difficult to decipher and arguably has no analogy in the narrative literature of the Hebrew Bible, which gives even more weight to the observation of the double symbolism largely being a new "discovery" with no precedent in any earlier interpretations. Neither the ancient translations, nor the rabbis, nor the Masoretes understood the text like this reading.⁵⁴ The "classical" interpretation proposed here certainly does not solve all the verse's difficulties; it "remains... a less-than-ideal solution"⁵⁵ but still seems to be the more probable one.

Verses 6–7 also raise certain literary-critical questions.⁵⁶ Firstly, the shift from action to divine speech in vv. 5f. and then again from the divine speech to the action in vv. 7f. seems poorly balanced. Furthermore, v. 8a feels incomplete, since the Hebrew word *אמר* "to say" is generally followed by direct speech introduced with another *verbum dicendi*; this already prompted the ancient translations to make additions (see the Text-critical and Philological Note on v. 8 above). In any case, the partial verse in its present form gives the impression of a literary seam. Secondly, the divine speech and the somewhat awkward transition in v. 8a interrupt a sound connection from v. 5 to v. 8b. These observations support the assumption that vv. 6–8a is an addition. This is reinforced by a shift of emphasis in content. Verse 7 quotes Gen 3:16; were v. 7 indeed aimed at the ability for sin to be dominated, this would equate the

⁵¹ See Heyden, 2003, 96; Janowski, 2003, 141.

⁵² Heyden, 2003, 99f.

⁵³ See Schüle, 2006, 199, who rightly speaks of "unusual semantic meanings" [translation JWR]. For discussion of the evidence provided as analogies, see Gertz, 2014, 43f.

⁵⁴ See Erzberger, 2011, 51 and fn. 61. The midrashic reading conforms throughout to the first alternative.

⁵⁵ Levin, 1993, 101 [translation JWR].

⁵⁶ See (with various redaction-critical assignments) von Löwenclau, 1978; Dietrich, 2002, 162f.; Levin, 1993, 100; Witte, 1998, 152; Schüle, 2006, 195–199.

superiority of man over woman according to Gen 3:16 with the controllability of sin according to Gen 4:7. This is an idea that has found some support throughout history in interpretations of the verse, but such a thought would hardly be desirable to impute upon the Scholarly Narrator, who evaluates the relationship between man and woman fundamentally positively.⁵⁷ One possible reason for the inclusion of vv. 6–7 may have been the concern that the narrative would paint Yhwh in a bad light. In the presumed earliest layer, the fratricide immediately followed Yhwh's differing reactions to the brothers' offerings. With vv. 6–7, Yhwh's admonition to Cain is inserted, which, later in the narrative, Cain then disregards. Thus, the fratricide no longer appears as the immediate consequence and reaction to the rejection of Cain and his gift. Additionally, Cain is characterized as unreceptive in the face of God's admonition, which in turn justifies God's rejection in retrospect. However, given its interpretational history, it does not seem that the insertion has really resolved the situation.

4:8

And Cain said to Abel, his brother ... And as they were in the field, Cain rose up against Abel, his brother, and killed him.

Cain's offense is described quite succinctly. Cain rises up against his brother and kills him. For the first time since the birth notice, it explicitly says once, and then again, "Abel, his brother," which underscores the incomprehensibility of the deed. According to the legal principles of the Hebrew Bible, the elements of the offense are insufficient for legal judgment concerning possible intent on the part of Cain (see Exod 21:12f.; Deut 19:4f., 11).⁵⁸ It is only implied that the brothers are alone in the field. As with the legal clauses, the indication of location underscores the absence of witnesses and the helplessness of the victim (see Deut 22:25–27). In the context of v. 7, which is presumably secondary, the offense seems like Cain's response to Yhwh's admonition. Additionally, should v. 8a be read following the LXX as an invitation by Cain to Abel to go into the field with him, it would clearly be a premeditated act. However, such considerations are largely absent in the original narrative. There is no lethal intent to be deduced from the notice "Cain rose up." It can only be said that it was no accident (see further Exod 21:13). Even if v. 8b was originally supposed to follow immediately after v. 5, it still does not mean that Cain commits the deed in his anger and that it is done "in the heat of the moment," so to speak. The wording וַיְהִי בְּהִיטָתָם ("And as they were in the field") is chronologically vague (see, e.g., Jos 5:13; 2 Sam 3:6; 1 Kgs 11:15) concerning its relationship to the preceding event. It is therefore entirely possible that Cain's anger slowly built up within him and was

⁵⁷ Wellhausen, 1899, 10 holds the notion of Gen 3:16 and v. 7 tracing back to one and the same author to be simply "disgusting."

⁵⁸ For the legal aspects, see Noort, 2003.

only later released as an act of violence. In either case, the omission of any intermediate step explaining or evaluating what occurred is a signal that the event had developed a certain momentum of its own that could have been stopped only with difficulty – despite the freedom to escape the inevitability of the event and to act differently, which is never under dispute and is specifically emphasized by a later hand in v. 7. This is precisely what makes the scene so frightening and so timeless: Experiencing setbacks for no reason, the resultant anger, the wrongdoing born of that anger, and the shame felt about it – “I think it is the best-known story in the world because it is everybody’s story” (John Steinbeck, *East of Eden*).

4:9–15

- 9 *And Yhwh said to Cain, “Where is Abel, your brother?” And he said, “I do not know; am I my brother’s keeper?”*
- 10 *And he said, “What have you done? The voice of your brother’s blood cries out to me from the soil.*
- 11 *And now: Cursed are you away from the soil, which has opened its maw to receive your brother’s blood from your hand.*
- 12 *When you till the field, it will no longer give you its strength. Restless and homeless will you be upon the earth!”*
- 13 *Then Cain said to Yhwh, “My guilt is too great to bear.*
- 14 *See, today you are banishing me from the soil, and I am withdrawn from your face, and I will be restless and homeless upon the earth, and everyone who meets me will kill me.”*
- 15 *Then Yhwh said to him, “Not so! Whoever kills Cain, he [it] will be avenged sevenfold.” And Yhwh set a sign for Cain, so that everyone who meets him would not slay him.*

The scene of interrogation and punishment shows great structural similarity to its parallel in the Garden narrative.⁵⁹ The offense, described only briefly (v. 8; see Gen 3:6–8), is immediately followed with an interrogation by Yhwh. His first question, introduced with “Where?” (v. 9a; see Gen 3:9), is answered evasively (v. 9b; see Gen 3:10). The second question confronts the perpetrator with his guilt (v. 10; see Gen 3:11). The punishment for the offense takes the form of sentencing and cursing (vv. 11f.; see Gen 3:14–19). The curse upon Cain expelling him from the community takes up the wording of the curses upon the serpent and the soil (אָרֶר + מִן “cursed [away] from” v. 11; see Gen 3:14 and 17 [without the מִן]). This signifies an intensification of the sentencing of humanity (v. 12; see Gen 3:17–19). At first glance,

⁵⁹ This has been noted frequently. See Westermann, 303; Witte, 1998, 167–169.

Cain's subsequent lament has no parallel in the Garden narrative, but Yhwh's promise of protection prompted by the lament corresponds with his careful preparation of clothing for Adam and Eve (v. 15; see Gen 3:21). Both scenes conclude with a notice of departure (v. 16; see Gen 3:23 as well as the later, redactional notice in v. 24). More clearly than its parallel, the scene is characterized by matters and expressions that come from the legal realm. Nevertheless, it should not be squeezed too much into the framework of various criminal and litigious Hebrew Bible regulations or read as a narrative about legal history. It is clear, merely from the primeval immediacy with which God is involved in the proceedings, that it is no ordinary court case. From all across the Hebrew Bible, it is unique.

4:9

And Yhwh said to Cain, "Where is Abel, your brother?" And he said, "I do not know; am I my brother's keeper?"

Yhwh's question about Cain's brother takes up the "Where are you?" from Gen 3:9. In conjunction with recalling the man hiding from Yhwh, the connotation of the question is that Abel cannot be found, that his corpse may even have been hastily buried. This led to corresponding additions within ancient retellings of the story. Thus, the Quran reports that Cain (not explicitly named) saw a raven sent by God that was burying another, dead raven, which prompted Cain to perform humanity's first burial (Sura 5:31). Inspired by this and other readings, there have sometimes been assumptions of textual omission during revision of an older tradition,⁶⁰ but there is no evidence for such an assumption. The narrative is quite succinct and, like in the offering scene, reports only what it absolutely wants to communicate. Cain's answer, which has become proverbial, is generally understood as a bold-faced lie or impudent evasion.⁶¹ According to a more charitable reading, Cain's answer reveals that he is beginning to realize what his destiny was – that is, to be his brother's keeper.⁶² Speaking against this, however, is how, with the introductory "I do not know," Cain exposes himself as a liar who dismisses any suspicion from the outset.⁶³ Additionally, with the emphasized "I," Cain appears to want to deny any responsibility for his brother when face-to-face

⁶⁰ See von Löwenclau, 1978, 181f.

⁶¹ See Gunkel, 44, among many others.

⁶² See Willi, 1983, 104.

⁶³ Cf. Willi, 1983, 104, where the "original humanity" in its naïvety actually knows nothing about death. The "place of the dead," however, is the subject neither of Yhwh's question nor of the narrative [translations JWR]. Moreover, the original humanity already lost its naïvety in Gen 3:6.

with God. Maybe in Cain's rhetorical retort, "Am I my brother's keeper?", a scornful allusion to the dangers of the slain brother's shepherding existence can even be heard, even if only a few instances of שָׁמַר * "to keep, tend" pertain to the shepherding activity (see Gen 30:31; 1 Sam 17:20; Jer 31:10; Hos 12:13). Compared to Adam's answer, which was given with a recognizably bad conscience and was at least no lie, this situation has become much worse.

4:10

And he said, "What have you done? The voice of your brother's blood cries out to me from the soil."

Yhwh's second question is taken from the legal realm.⁶⁴ The introductory "What have you done?" has more of a rhetorical than interrogative function, which is already evident in how Yhwh does not wait for an answer and instead names the deed with all clarity. In judicial as well as extrajudicial disputes, the addressee is confronted with a question formulated in this way when an accusation is leveled against them (cf. Gen 31:36; 2 Sam 3:24; Isa 45:9; Job 9:12; Eccl 8:4). Cain may choose to deny having committed the offense and feel safe because he killed his brother in the field, i.e., away from possible witnesses (Deut 22:27). However, he is convicted because the spilled blood of his brother testifies to the bloody deed and cries out to Yhwh. Thus, there is no "perfect murder"⁶⁵ before God. The plural of דָּם "blood" generally denotes either blood shed forcibly or a blood guilt. Additionally, צָעַק * "to cry out" with God as the addressee is found in legal contexts, where "shrieking" is the most extreme way for a victim of violence to obtain justice (so 2 Kgs 4:1; 8:5; Gen 27:34; Isa 5:7). The blood of the slain brother (not the soil!) cries out to Yhwh for justice, calling upon him to intercede on Abel's rightful behalf (see also Ps 9:13: "For he who demands blood guilt has remembered it, has not forgotten the shrieking of the lowly"; Job 16:18: "O Earth, do not cover my blood, and let there be no resting place for my shrieking").

4:11–12

11 *And now: Cursed are you away from the soil, which has opened its maw to receive your brother's blood from your hand.*

⁶⁴ See Boecker, 1964, 26–31 (for the accusation formula) and 61–66 (on the howling/shrieking).

⁶⁵ Westermann, 305; see 2 Sam 12; 1 Kgs 21.

12 *When you till the field, it will no longer give you its strength. Restless and homeless will you be upon the earth!*"

Once again, the leitmotif of "soil" is taken up: "Cain cultivated the field, offered the fruits of the field, gave the field his brother's blood to drink. But the blood cried out against him from the field, therefore the field refuses him its fruit and he is banned from it."⁶⁶ This sequence of events has often been understood in such a way that the soil executes the *lex talionis* and reacts "automatically," as it were, to its defilement through the innocently shed blood: Yhwh does not execute punishment by cursing Cain away from the field. Instead, in the curse, he merely identifies powerfully and effectively the consequences of the deed, which Cain himself set into motion through his murder of his brother.⁶⁷

The question of the "punishing" authority, however, is not so easy to answer.⁶⁸ If the soil, desecrated by innocent blood, refuses Cain its nourishing power (v. 12a; see also Job 31:38f.), this becomes reminiscent of the warning that the land will spit out those who defile it (Lev 18:24–28). Conversely, a drought, like other disasters, can also be indicative of an unatoned blood guilt. According to 2 Sam 21, an unatoned blood guilt weighing upon Saul and his house because of the murder of the Gibeonites causes a famine that lasts for several years; in the Ugaritic Epic of Aqhat, the murder of the eponymous hero results in a drought, which is ultimately extended by curses from the victim's father to even the drying up of the water sources; the patricide of Oedipus also brings about a blood guilt and a drought upon the land.⁶⁹ Although such ideas of the automatic consequences of blood guilt have been reflected in elaborations of the Cain and Abel story, they are nevertheless not at the forefront of Gen 4 itself (just as in Sophocles' *Oedipus Rex*). This is clear from the phrasing of the curse in v. 11. It unmistakably takes up the cursing and sentencing from the Garden narrative (אָרֶיר מִן + אָרֶיר only here and in Gen 3:14), which here are intensified. The curse no longer affects only the soil but also the guilty human being, and the toil of the farmer's labor becomes the fruitlessness of the soil. Read in context with the Garden narrative, the cursing of Cain thus appears as an act of judgment by Yhwh, whom the blood of the slain brother approaches for help. Cain does not see it differently, and he expresses in his complaint to Yhwh that *he* has driven him from the soil (v. 14a).

In the legal realm, curses are otherwise found when an offense takes place secretly and therefore cannot be resolved (see Deut 27:24; similarly

⁶⁶ Gunkel, 45.

⁶⁷ See Ebach, 1998, 25; Schüle, 94f.

⁶⁸ See Dietrich, 2010, 202–209.

⁶⁹ For an English translation of the Epic of Aqhat, see "The 'Aqhatu Legend," Pardee, *COS* 1.103:343–356.

Deut 21:1–9). The case is somewhat different in Gen 4, insofar as the blood appears as a witness and invokes Yhwh as judge. This guarantees from the outset what the legal curse seeks to accomplish: the identification and punishment of the perpetrator in order to protect a community from the harm caused by the injustice. The image of the earth's maw being (torn) opened is attested in the context of the rebellion of "Korah and his gang" (Num 16:32f.; see Deut 11:6; Ps 106:17), thus evoking the image of the Underworld craving for the dead and emphasizing its mortal threat to the perpetrator. With the curse in v. 12, the farmer Cain is prevented from continuing to nourish himself from the soil (אֶרֶץ). He is deprived of his livelihood and is left with an existence in which he can no longer find a permanent home on the earth (אָרֶץ). When understanding the narrative as recounting the origin of nomadic tribes, the unique expression נָע וָנָד "restless and homeless" is easily understood as a characteristic of nomadic existence (see pp. 181f. above).⁷⁰ However, it is still at least worth questioning whether this corresponded to the historical conditions or even to the external perception of nomadic tribes by the sedentary population. After all, the later "sedentary Israel" evokes its "nomadic heritage" (e.g., Gen 12ff.; Deut 26:5; 2 Sam 20:1).⁷¹ More importantly, however, is how such considerations about the history of human civilization play at best a subordinate role in the present context. This can be seen in Cain's reaction, seeing himself fundamentally excluded from the human community upon the announcement of his restless and homeless life (v. 14b). Whoever incurs a blood debt stays on the run until their death (see Prov 28:17) and has absolutely no protection from the community. The legal practice behind Cain's expulsion can be seen even in modern times for judicial communities of Arab tribes not organized as states. As a rule, whoever incurs a blood debt is subject to blood vengeance by a close male relative of the victim (see also Deut 19:1–9). However, if the blood debt is within the family, the perpetrator is expelled from the clan rather than killed and is not to be accepted by any other tribe.⁷² Cain represents the first time that a human being is cursed; although he is a primeval prototype, he is nevertheless also marked as an individual through the contrast to Abel (and Seth).

4:13–14

- 13** *Then Cain said to Yhwh, "My guilt is too great to bear.*
14 *See, today you are banishing me from the soil, and I am withdrawn from your face, and I will be restless and homeless upon the earth, and everyone who meets me will kill me."*

⁷⁰ Wellhausen, 1899, 8f.; see also Stade, 1894, 299f.

⁷¹ See on the matter Staubli, 1991; Rosen/Lehmann, 2010.

⁷² See Musil, 1908, 360 (cited in Westermann, 307).

Cain's answer is completely full of terror at the words that he has just heard from Yhwh. It bears the classic form of an "individual lament" and contains the typical elements of the I-lament (v. 13b), the God-lament (v. 14a), and the enemy-lament (v. 14b).⁷³ The element of protesting one's innocence, known from the laments of the Psalter, is missing, and for understandable reasons. There is also no equivalent for the typical plea. Accordingly, it is a lament over suffering, which presumes that the suffering is irreversible.⁷⁴ The intention of the I-lament in v. 13b has been understood in very different manners. The LXX had already recognized within it a confession of Cain's sin and translated it as "My guilt is too great for me to be forgiven" (Μεῖζων ἢ αἰτία μου τοῦ ἀφεθῆναι με). The Greek αἰτία "guilt/offense" is chosen as a translation for עֲוֹן in the Pentateuch only here. It denotes the cause of an accusation in a legal sense.⁷⁵ Corresponding to this in religious parlance is the translation as "sin" (Luther) or "iniquity" (KJV). However, this does not cover the entire semantic range of the Hebrew expression, since עֲוֹן not only means the offense but also includes its inevitable consequences for the perpetrator in the sense of a "punishment."⁷⁶ Translation of this into English is difficult, as the "guilt" of Cain encompasses both the cause of the punishment as well as the consequences of the offense. When Cain says that his "guilt" is too great to bear (*נשא q. inf.), this establishes that both the offense, the fratricide, and its consequences, the curse, are too heavy for him to shoulder. The meaning of the God- and enemy-laments are easily understood. Together, they detail the consequences of the expulsion from the field (vv. 11, 12a and v. 14a) and the fugitive existence (vv. 12b and 14b). Cain's complaint about Yhwh banishing (*גרשׁ) him from the face of the field takes up and exacerbates the dismissal (*שלח) of Adam and Eve from the Garden in order to work the field (Gen 3:23; the intensification is covered by the *גרשׁ in the redactional notice in Gen 3:24). The banishment from the field is accompanied by a spatial distance from God. The two statements should be related to one another. As also indicated by Yhwh bestowing a mark of protection upon Cain, the point is not that Cain is to hide from Yhwh's gaze (so, as impossible, in Ps 139:7–10; Amos 9:3). Rather, Cain is withdrawn from Yhwh's *protective* gaze (see Ps 88:15; 102:3), which obviously does not extend to the place of Cain's exile (for spatial conceptions, see also Gen 46:4; 1 Sam 26:19; Jon 1:3). This idea seems to be important to the author; it is taken up again in v. 16a.⁷⁷ The lack of protection accords with the enemy-lament that Cain is at the mercy of everyone's (*כל־מִצָּאִי) malevolence.

⁷³ See Westermann, 309f.; Golka, 1980, 66 (each with the exception of v. 13b and with different assignments of the components).

⁷⁴ See Golka, 1980, 66.

⁷⁵ See Rösel, 1994, 110f.

⁷⁶ For the fundamental aspects, see Koch, 1962.

⁷⁷ See Gunkel, 46.

4:15

Then Yhwh said to him, “Not so! Whoever kills Cain, he [it] will be avenged sevenfold.” And Yhwh set a sign for Cain, so that everyone who meets him would not slay him.

Rather than seeking amnesty, Cain strives merely to live with the punishment. This (unspoken) request within his complaint is granted to him: The man who was unable to accept Yhwh’s groundless favoritism towards his brother is now groundlessly placed under Yhwh’s protection. Anyone slaying him is to be punished with a sevenfold death penalty. Certainly, this is not meant as a possible perpetrator being killed seven times (analogous to multiple life imprisonment sentences in some modern legal systems) but as a punishment including not only the perpetrator but also the next of kin (see 2 Sam 3:29; 21:1ff.). This idea stands in contradiction to relevant provisions of Hebrew Bible legal texts as well as those of the ancient Near East, including its regulated form of blood vengeance. Presumably, it is thought that the completeness symbolized through the number seven (see Ps 79:12; Prov 24:16) precludes from the outset any possibility of the taboo being broken. Thus, the protection of the law applies even for the fratricide. In this way, the comprehensive ordering of life through law, doubtlessly the most significant achievement of human civilization of all, comes into being as a protective mark of the fratricide.

The story never says what the “mark of Cain” actually is. Presumably, it was assumed to have already been familiar to its ancient audience. It is most commonly interpreted as a tattoo (see Ezek 9:4; Isa 44:5), while a kind of (military-like) standard is also conceivable (see Ps 74:4). There is also a lovely rabbinic interpretation in which God gives Cain a dog as a companion (Gen. Rab. 22.12). The only certainty is that the sign is for the protection of the peaceless and less for the inevitably present stigmatization of Cain as a brotherslayer. This also explains the formulation “And Yhwh set a sign for Cain [לְקַיֵּן]” (instead of “And Yhwh set XY on Cain as a sign” עַל קַיֵּן XY לְאוֹת). It has occasionally given rise to the assumption that Cain himself becomes the sign or that the sign lies in Yhwh’s promise that he will not be killed.⁷⁸ Both were already under consideration in rabbinic interpretation. In it, Cain is regarded as a sign for those who repent, but the mark can also signify the postponement of judgment until the coming of the Flood (Gen. Rab. 22.12). However, the context of the story suggests an individual

⁷⁸ Jacob, 146. See Moberly, 2007. Most recently, Lohr, 2009 has considered that the sign, to be understood abstractly, should not be understood as a mark on Cain’s body but on the city built for Cain’s protection (Gen 4:17). In this case, a clearer reference back to Yhwh’s promise would be expected. Further references on the history of interpretation in Mellinkoff, 1981.

sign that is immediately visible. Naturally, this does not rule out that Cain was also thought of as the ancestor of the Kenites and that a certain tribal sign, now unknown, was the narrator's inspiration for this motif.

4:16

Then Cain left Yhwh's presence and settled in the land of Nod, east of Eden.

Cain accepts his banishment. He leaves and settles in the land of Nod, on the other side of Eden. Cain's departure and his equally coerced and enabled new beginning correspond both with the dismissal notice in the Garden narrative (Gen 3:23) and the renaming of the woman (Gen 3:20), with whom the man responds to the punishments in an optimistic manner. Furthermore, the verse prepares for the city-building notice and the notices about the emergence of civilization in the subsequent genealogy of the Cainites. At first glance, the fact that Cain settles in the land of Nod seems like a stark contradiction to the declaration of his living "restlessly and homelessly," but the name "Nod," coming from the root *נָדַד "to wander about," takes up the phrase נָדַד נֹחַ "restless and homeless." It is a "no man's land" of sorts, both temporally and spatially. Like "Eden," "Nod" is a symbolic name. In this, too, do the Garden and Fratricide narratives correspond with each other. The remark that the land lies east of Eden likewise agrees with the Scholarly Narrator's geographic conception of the Garden *in Eden* (see, e.g., Gen 2:8; otherwise redactionally "Garden of Eden" in, e.g., Gen 2:15). Dismissed from the Garden in order to work the field, humanity at first lives outside of the Garden but still in Eden, while after the fratricide, Cain settles in Nod, far outside Eden, the land of delight.⁷⁹

2. Genesis 4:17–26: The Cainites and Sethites

4:17–26

- 17 *And Cain knew his wife and she became pregnant and gave birth to Enoch. And he became the builder of a city, and he named the city after the name of his son, Enoch.*
- 18 *And Irad was born to Enoch, and Irad fathered Mehujael, and Mehujael fathered Methushael, and Methushael fathered Lamech.*
- 19 *And Lamech took two wives. The name of the first was "Adah," and the name of the second was "Zillah."*

⁷⁹ See Witte, 1998, 169. Contra Gertz, 2004, 235, v. 16b is not a later addition.

- 20 *Then Adah gave birth to Jabal. He is the father of those who dwell in tents and by the herds.*
- 21 *The name of his brother was "Jubal." He is the father of all who play the lyre and the flute.*
- 22 *And Zillah, she also gave birth, to Tubal-Cain, a sharpener of metal for all who smith bronze or iron. And the sister of Tubal-Cain was Na'amah.*
- 23 *Then Lamech said to his wives,
 "Adah and Zillah, hear my voice!
 Wives of Lamech, listen to my words!
 Truly, I have killed a man for my wound,
 And a young boy for my bruise!*
- 24 *Truly, sevenfold was Cain avenged,
 But Lamech seventy-sevenfold!"*
- 25 *And Adam knew his wife again and she gave birth to a son and called his name "Seth," for "God has given me another descendant in the place of Abel, since Cain killed him."*
- 26 *And a son was also born to Seth. And he called his name "Enosh."
 In those days, people began to call upon the name of Yhwh.*

ESSENTIALS AND PERSPECTIVES

Rather than ending with Cain's expulsion, the Fratricide narrative leads into the genealogy of his direct descendants (Gen 4:17–24), into which several notices on the history of human civilization (Gen 4:20–22) and the Song of Lamech (Gen 4:23–24) have been interwoven. This is followed by a genealogical story about Adam and Eve's thirdborn son, Seth, and his son Enosh (Gen 4:25–26).⁸⁰ Genealogies served to preserve and demarcate social claims and kinship affiliations in early societies that were characterized by clan associations. Whether fictional or real, they represent an essential organizing principle that locates individuals and groups within time and space.⁸¹ As such, genealogies have a primarily social function and less a historiographical one. Emphases may shift as soon as a genealogy like the one in Gen 4:17–24 is brought into or conceived for a literary context. However, aside from the indisputable observation that the juxtaposition of the Cainite and Sethite genealogies presents the history of antediluvian humanity and records in it the common origins of all human beings, the function of the two genealogies is difficult to describe. Genealogies in comparable ancient Near Eastern

⁸⁰ On the terminology, see Hieke, 2003, 18–20.

⁸¹ See Wilson, 1992.

texts about primeval times are often associated with legitimizing the political order of the day, and they result in kingship. This is clearly not the case in Gen 4, especially since, according to the narrative, the Cainite lineage ends with the Flood. Therefore, it rather has the function of bridging the time between the fratricide and the Flood.

The Cainite genealogy is often read as telling the history of civilization. One indication of this is the widely attested connection of primeval genealogies with statements about the emergence of civilization. Thus, *The Phoenician History* by Philo of Byblos preserves a primeval genealogy of fourteen bringers of civilization in the spheres of food (agriculture, hunting, fishing), craftsmanship (ships, houses, clothing, medicine, writing), and cult.⁸² A frequently advocated variant of this reading of the Cainite genealogy as critical of human civilization invokes the fact that all cultural progress is attributed to the descendants of the brotherslayer Cain.

It can hardly be denied that Gen 4:17–26 is also about the emergence of civilization, given the basic etioloical orientation of the Scholarly Narrator's Primeval History and in light of cognate literature from the ancient Near East. However, the history of civilization is not at the center of the text, since there are no corresponding deeds handed down about Irad, Mehujael, Methushael, and Lamech, and in the present text, also Enoch. Furthermore, the list makes no attempt whatsoever at being comprehensive. The pessimistic undertone cited for a reading critical of civilization cannot be ignored. However, this has resulted from the final accent provided by the Song of Lamech and less from the enumeration of the civilizational achievements. Moreover, speaking against an emphatically anti-civilizational reading is how Yhwh himself sparked the beginning of this development with Adam and Eve's clothing and their dismissal to agricultural activity (*cultura*). Additionally, negative evaluations of neither tent-dwelling and animal husbandry nor music would probably be expected in the context of the Hebrew Bible. At first glance, the case may appear different for metalworking, given the possibility of making weapons and the ultimate glorification of violence in the Song of Lamech. However, it is striking that any mention of the products themselves is missing. Metalworking can be used for good or evil (Isa 2:4). Incidentally, this also applies to the supposedly harmless arts of music and poetry, as their first example, the Song of Lamech, shows. There is also no indication that the heroes of early human civilization were guilty by association of the deeds of their father Lamech and their ancestor Cain. Rather, the text refrains from any evaluation – whether good or bad – of the cultural features and their

⁸² On *The Phoenician History* by Philo of Byblos, see Ch. 2 on v. 2. On the genealogy of the “bringers of civilization” preserved in Eusebius (*Praeparatio evangelica* 1:10.7–14a), see Ebach, 1979, 90–273.

ancestors. Thus, even in comparison with the corresponding lists in other literature, there is still an emphatically neutral representation of the development of civilization. It is not the achievements of human civilization that are ambiguous; it is their use. This, in turn, fits well into the overall picture of Gen 2:4–4:26.

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION III: EXEGESIS

4:17

And Cain knew his wife and she became pregnant and gave birth to Enoch. And he became the builder of a city, and he named the city after the name of his son, Enoch.

The opening of the genealogy ties back to v. 1 with the sequence *יָדַע “to recognize,” *הָרָה “to become pregnant,” and *יָלַד “to birth.” As mentioned above, *יָדַע is used for bearing a child in Hebrew Bible genealogies only in Gen 4:1, 17, and 25. Through this unusual use of language, the Scholarly Narrator highlights the connection with the Garden narrative (see *יָדַע in Gen 2:[9,] 17; 3:5, 7 [22]) while simultaneously, by means of genealogy, setting forth how, after humanity’s first procreation (Gen 4:1) and the fratricide, antediluvian humanity is divided into two lineages (Gen 4:17, 25). Furthermore, the phrase “he became the builder of a city” takes up the wording of the references to Cain and Abel’s occupations in Gen 4:2 (each *הָיָה + participle). Unlike in v. 1, the name of the woman is not mentioned, and likewise unmentioned is where Cain’s wife comes from. Traditions from even early on thought of her being a sister of his. Standing in the background of this assumption, apart from practical necessity, is an exegetical consideration about the notice of Abel’s birth in Gen 4:2. The doubled direct object marker (אֶת) before both “his brother” and “Abel” is redundant in the second position, which is why it has sometimes been read as “with [אֶת; the basic form of both words is the same] Abel” and interpreted as a reference to the birth of a twin sister (b.Yebam. 62a).

Cain fathering a son after his expulsion (v. 17a) corresponds narratively to the naming of the woman as “Eve” and “mother of all living” in Gen 3:20 after the divine punishment as well as the conception of Cain and Abel after the dismissal from the Garden.⁸³ The building of a city likewise marks a

⁸³ It seems that the LXX wants to emphasize this connection by using καί “and” to mark v. 17 as a conclusion to the Fratricide narrative and letting the break marked by the δέ follow only in v. 18. See Rösel, 1994, 112f.

new beginning (v. 17b). It is often evaluated as the defiant response of the exiled brotherslayer who seeks to escape the curse of a “restless and homeless” (v. 14) existence.⁸⁴ However, the parallelism with the outcome of the Garden narrative, in addition to the two possible readings of v. 17b, speak against such a negative understanding: According to the present text, Cain is the builder of the city (see also 1 Sam 30:29), but he builds it for his son Enoch. It therefore bears the name of the new generation of Cain’s descendants,⁸⁵ which may be meant to be emphasized by the verbal inflection of בִּנְיָה “builder” and בְּנוֹ “his son.”⁸⁶ Thus, Cain himself would not have escaped the curse. The name of his son, “Enoch” (חֶנוֹךְ), is derived from the root *חָנַךְ “to dedicate, consecrate; to found” and accordingly means “founder.” The city named after him would thus be called “foundation” or “consecrated place.” “Enoch” is attested as a personal name in multiple places across the Hebrew Bible (so Gen 5:18, and furthermore as the son of Midian and grandson of Abraham according to Gen 25:4; 1 Chr 1:33 as well as the firstborn of Reuben according to Gen 46:9; Exod 6:14; Num 26:5; 1 Chr 5:3). However, a geographic identification of a city named after Enoch is not possible, suggesting that its use as a toponym is a purely literary construction.⁸⁷ Moreover, another aspect in need of consideration is whether Cain may have been made into the founder of the city only later. According to typical linguistic usage, the notice “he became the builder of a city” would be expected to refer back to the name mentioned previously, consequently meaning Enoch. This is also supported by the correspondence in form to Gen 4:20–22, where the birth notice/naming is immediately followed by a statement about the deeds of the son in question. The fact that this plainly obvious understanding of the text can be ruled out for v. 17b because of the second mention of Enoch at the end suggests textual corruption or revision. Budde had already suspected that an original כְּשֵׁמוֹ חֶנוֹךְ “after his name, Enoch” in v. 17b was rewritten into כְּשֵׁם בְּנוֹ חֶנוֹךְ “after the name of his son, Enoch”⁸⁸. However, it is more likely that the second mention of Enoch was added, either by mistake or because Cain was mistakenly seen as the builder (the gloss must have been entered into the text relatively early, since the MT and the ancient translations all agree on it). In this case, v. 17b would have originally read, “and he [= Enoch] became the builder of a city and named

⁸⁴ So Witte, 1998, 169, although under the assumption that the acknowledgement of life in Gen 3:20 should be understood as “humanity’s defiant reaction to Yhwh’s curse” [translation JWR]. However, this is difficult to reconcile with the fact that, when pronouncing the punishment, Yhwh addresses the continuation of life through the woman himself.

⁸⁵ Following Seebaß, 167.

⁸⁶ See Cassuto, 1:231.

⁸⁷ Jericke, 2016.

⁸⁸ Budde, 1883, 120–123.

the city after the name of his son.”⁸⁹ This would fit well with the meaning of the name “Enoch” (“founder”). Moreover, the name of Enoch’s son, Irad, can be connected without difficulty with the name of the southern Mesopotamian city of Eridu (*Tell Abū Šahrēn*). In Mesopotamian tradition, it is considered the oldest city in the world and was founded (like other cities as well) already before the Flood. Also pointing to Mesopotamia is the idea that urban society and culture are the “mother of civilization,” to which the tent dwellers and nomads are clearly subordinated latecomers.⁹⁰ Finally, the name “Irād” (עִירָד) is also reminiscent of the Hebrew עִיר “city.”⁹¹ Unmentioned, however, is where the inhabitants of a city in already the second or third generation should come from. This has always been a source of concern and has been taken as an indication that Gen 4:17ff. includes a genealogy that did not originally belong to a primeval context. On the one hand, this is certainly possible. On the other hand, it must be considered that, like in the case of Cain’s wife, such “gaps” are almost inevitable when presenting human history as the history of the descendants of a single human couple.

4:18–19

- 18 *And Irad was born to Enoch, and Irad fathered Mehujael, and Mehujael fathered Methushael, and Methushael fathered Lamech.*
 19 *And Lamech took two wives. The name of the first was “Adah,” and the name of the second was “Zillah.”*

Without any further details, the genealogy rushes over the next three generations to Lamech (v. 18). The meaning of the name “Irād” is unknown but allusive (see above), while the names “Mehujael” “God brings alive” and Methushael “man of God” are typical formations of West Semitic names with the theophoric element אֱל “God.” The meaning of the name “Lamech” is again unclear, but the genealogy knows quite a bit about him to report. This underscores the importance of Lamech within the outline of the larger scheme, as with him, the tragic climax of the Cainite genealogy is reached. Yet, the negative judgment is only given with the quotation of the Song of

⁸⁹ See Cassuto, 1:228–231. The fact that in this case, the notice about the birth of the son comes too late, strictly speaking (see Day, 2013, 57 fn. 14), could be due to the close connection between the birth notice and activity on the one hand and the strict genealogical sequence in v. 18 on the other.

⁹⁰ For both, see the beginning of the Sumerian king list: “When kingship was lowered from heaven, kingship was (first) in Eridu” (introduction and translation: “Texts from the Beginnings to the First Dynasty of Babylon,” trans. Oppenheim [*ANET*, 265–266]).

⁹¹ The origin, etymology, and meaning of this and the following names are, generally speaking, completely uncertain. See Hess, 1993, 37–67.

Lamech, even if the mention of Lamech having two wives has been readily interpreted as a sign of moral decay. The idea of Lamech being criticized here because of the introduction of polygamy, however, is far-fetched.⁹² Rather, Lamech is introduced as a substantial figure with two wives (v. 19), three important sons, and a beautiful daughter (vv. 20–22).⁹³ Moreover, the mention of the two wives whose names are presupposed in the Song of Lamech allows for a branching of Lamech's descendants into two groups, so that the linear genealogy of the Cainites becomes a segmentary genealogy at its final tier (as also with Gen 5:1–32; 11:10–26). The name of the first wife who is mentioned, Adah, is related to the root *עדה “to adorn,” while the name of the second wife, Zillah, probably means “[in the] shadow/protection [of the deity].”

4:20–22

- 20** *Then Adah gave birth to Jabal. He is the father of those who dwell in tents and by the herds.*
- 21** *The name of his brother was “Jubal.” He is the father of all who play the lyre and the flute.*
- 22** *And Zillah, she also gave birth, to Tubal-Cain, a sharpener of metal for all who smith bronze or iron. And the sister of Tubal-Cain was Na’amah.*

Adah gives birth to the brothers Jabal and Jubal, while Zillah has a son named “Tubal-Cain” and his sister “Na’amah.” Cultural achievements are assigned to the three sons, while for Na’amah, only her name is mentioned. Jabal is considered the ancestor (“father”) of nomadic pastoralists, whose way of life is characterized by living in tents and the close proximity of human and livestock (see Gen 13:5; 25:27). It follows from the splitting of the Cainite genealogy at the generation of Lamech's sons that not all Cainites practiced this way of life. This is also true for the musicians and minstrels, introduced by their ancestor Jubal, the “ingenious brother of Jabal.”⁹⁴ Although the very beginnings of music are often associated with pastoral life, as with the shepherd god and flautist Pan, the group of professional lyre (כנור) and flute (צנב) players is not limited to itinerant musicians; thus, there must also have been professional musicians around the palace and temple as well.⁹⁵ There is also comparable evidence for metalworkers. Such an anticipation

⁹² See merely Jacob and his wives in Gen 29f.

⁹³ Following Seebaß, 169. Cf. especially the interpretations from the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.

⁹⁴ Jacob, 148f. [translation JWR], there also with reference to Pan.

⁹⁵ This is evident from the listing of the tribute exacted from King Hezekiah in Sennacherib's report of his third campaign (“Sennacherib's Siege of Jerusalem” [Cogan, *COS* 2.119B:303]).

of the conditions of a state is certainly beyond the narrative perspective of Gen 4:22, notwithstanding the Scholarly Narrator having lived during a time with a state system. In any case, it makes clear that, despite the comparative ethnological and iconographic material, the popular reading of the three brothers as typical representations of “desert wanderers” is fraught with uncertainties.⁹⁶ Finally, the etymology of the names “Jabal” and “Jubal” are totally unknown; the phonetic similarity of “Jabal,” “Jubal,” and “Tubal(-Cain)” is doubtlessly intentional. Perhaps, the name of the musician, Jubal, is meant to sound like the *יִבְלָל* “ram’s horn.”

As with his brothers, the genealogical information about Tubal-Cain is supplemented by an indication of his occupation. However, Tubal-Cain is not called the “father” of anything; instead, in what is possibly corrupted wording, there is mention of his occupation as “a sharpener of metal for all who smith bronze or iron.” Such phrasing suggests that, rather than being an ordinary blacksmith, he is a specialist in producing and repairing tools (see 1 Sam 13:20; Ps 7:13). In any case, it concerns metalworking, which the biblical authors understood as a pivotal step in cultural, economic, and military development (so 1 Sam 13:20–22; 1 Kgs 7:14). Also noteworthy is the fact that the son of Zillah also bears the first double name in the Bible. Since the LXX only gives the first part, *Θοβελ*, the “Cain” has repeatedly been thought to be a later addition. The paronomasia of the names “Jabal,” “Jubal,” and “Tubal” could also speak in favor of this. The name “Tubal” can be associated with the Late Hittite kingdom of Tabal, in southeastern Asia Minor on the northern border of the Neo-Assyrian empire (see below on Gen 10:2), which was well-known in antiquity for its metalworking (see also Ezek 27:13; the name of the kingdom may have preserved the earlier Hurrian *tabališ* “smith”). The second part of the name, “Cain,” also points to the field of metalworking (see above on Gen 4:1). The possibility of the name being based on the identification of two formerly independent people has been considered, such as “a Palestinian forefather of craftsmanship and smithing, Cain, with Tubal, the representation of ironworking from the land where the skill first developed.”⁹⁷ However, an explanation less littered with presuppositions and therefore more preferable is its interpretation as an epithet, so “Tubal the Smith.”⁹⁸ Since the use of double names and epithets to distinguish between several bearers with one and the same name is not

⁹⁶ Fundamental to the nomadic interpretation (and the separation of the genealogy from the Fratricide narrative, which comes from a sedentary milieu) is Stade, 1894, 255, 259–262. For comparative material, see Staubli, 1991, 150–158 as well as the depiction there of mining, hunting, and music-making nomads on the northern wall of the tomb of Khnumhotep II (12th Dynasty, ca. 1900 BCE; see *ibid.*, 30–35 with Pl. 15).

⁹⁷ Ebach, 1979, 345 [translation JWR], following Gunkel, 51f.

⁹⁸ Wellhausen, 1899, 306 and recently Seebaß, 170.

attested in the Hebrew Bible, he would have hardly been named with regard to the son of Japheth, who is also named Tubal (Gen 10:2; 1 Chr 1:15). Instead, it can be assumed that, besides its explanatory function, the epithet was chosen for compositional reasons. If the last male descendant of Cain sounds like the name of his forefather, this relates the Fratricide narrative in Gen 4:1–16 and the Cainite genealogy in Gen 4:17–24 to each other all the more closely.

The name of the sister, Na'amah (so also 1 Kgs 14:21, 31), means “lovely one” or “delight.” Unlike with her brothers, nothing is given except her name, and this stirred the imagination of interpreters from early on. According to rabbinic tradition, she is the wife of Noah, or the foremother of all female musicians (Gen. Rab. 23.3). The latter is based on a connection of her name with the Rabbinic Hebrew word נְעִימָה “song” (see Sir 45:9), leading to the explanation in the Targums, “She was mistress of lamentations and songs” (Tg. Ps.-J. on v. 22; also Tg. Neof.). But this symmetry, in which each of Lamech’s wives has two significant children, does not seem to be intended in the biblical text. Since women are usually only mentioned in the Hebrew Bible genealogies when they have certain special significance for, as an example, the portrayal of the lineage,⁹⁹ the mention of the daughter would, like the epithet “Cain” in v. 22, rather indicate that this genealogical note was included into vv. 20–22 from another context. The mention of the daughter can then be explained by a lost context in which she would have played an important role, presumably as the mother of other important members of the tribe.

The small list of cultural achievements has time and again stimulated questions about the actual historical background and possible connections with the traditions from its historical context. This is natural, given the primeval context and its etiological character as well as its analogies in other literature from the ancient Near East and classical antiquity. However, the two verses should not be demanded to provide more information than they actually can. This is especially true for considerations about the relationship between hunting, farming, and city cultures or the Bronze Age to Iron Age relationship supposedly presupposed in the text (Lamech has sometimes been seen as an axe-wielding caveman). Genesis 4:20–22 provides no depiction of primeval and early human history in the modern sense but instead an etiology of the living conditions that were present in the minds of both the authors and their intended readers. However, when criticizing the civilizational-history reading, the fact that, according to the plain wording of the text, there are no notices about the invention of such cultural achievements but only of their practice should not be overvalued.¹⁰⁰ For the present context, the impression that each is happening for the first time results from how nothing concerning the relevant developments is reported beforehand and how

⁹⁹ See further the overview in Hieke, 2003, 278–298.

¹⁰⁰ Cf. Seebaß, 169f.

there are no other people available to identify as the inventors. This does not stand in contradiction to it primarily being an etiology of the way of life. “The first inventors are simultaneously considered progenitors of the circle in which the invention currently exists,”¹⁰¹ which again corresponds to life conditions in which professions pass from father to son. Since the etiologies are aimed at the authors’ present times, the question naturally had to arise of how the crafts of the Cainites were able to survive the Flood. The text does not give an answer to this; in light of his construction of an altar and subsequent sacrifice, Noah could conceivably be seen as a bearer of such cultural techniques (Gen 8:20f.; see, outside of the technical knowledge needed for building the ark, also the episode about Noah as a farmer and winemaker in Gen 9:20f.). In any case, the idea that the basic orders and achievements of civilization originated from the time before the Flood corresponds to the Flood tradition from Mesopotamia. It, however, explicitly addresses how antediluvian knowledge could survive after the Flood. Thus, the Mesopotamian tradition reports that, in addition to the animals, practitioners of all crafts were also brought onto the ark (Gilgm 11.86). Others told of the Flood hero burying clay tablets with such antediluvian knowledge and those tablets then forming the basis of the library of Babylon (Berossos 2.3). This, of course, is less about a solution for a logical problem in the narrative than about the succession of (hegemonic) knowledge that is divinely imparted in primeval times.¹⁰² This aspect is completely absent in the Hebrew Bible tradition, which is why no far-reaching conclusions about its redaction history should be drawn from the supposed incoherence within the flow of the biblical narrative.¹⁰³

4:23–24

- 23 *Then Lamech said to his wives,
 “Adah and Zillah, hear my voice!
 Wives of Lamech, listen to my words!
 Truly, I have killed a man for my wound,
 And a young boy for my bruise!*
- 24 *Truly, sevenfold was Cain avenged,
 But Lamech seventy-sevenfold!”*

The climax and conclusion of the genealogy of the Cainites is the Song of Lamech. The brief introduction (“Then Lamech said to his wives”) names Lamech’s two wives as his addressees. The song itself keeps a concise rhythm of three double verses (bicola), whose respective parts parallel each other in their semantics and content (*parallelismus membrorum*). After Adam and Eve transgress the prohibition against eating from the Tree of Knowledge,

¹⁰¹ Gunkel, 52.

¹⁰² See further Pongratz-Leisten, 1999, 293–301, 312f.

¹⁰³ Cf. Wellhausen, 1899, 8, 10, and most recently Levin, 1993, 98, and Kratz, 2005, 251, who identify a kernel of the non-Priestly Primeval History in Gen 4:17–27 that knew nothing of the Great Flood.

and then Cain commits fratricide against Abel, the Song marks the third turning point in the narrative progression of Gen 2:4b–4:26, to a “story of the increase in sin and the more and more profound disturbance of the original orders of life with which it goes hand in hand ... now the execution of vengeance (which God has reserved for himself!) is claimed by man. It becomes wanton, and in addition man boasts of it.”¹⁰⁴ The song is well integrated into its present context. The names of Lamech’s wives mentioned in the call are a fundamental part of the Cainite genealogy, as they enable its segmentation at the final generation. The concluding bicolon refers back to the Fratricide narrative through its mention of Cain and the verbatim quotation from v. 15 (*נָקַם q. pass. “to be avenged”). These back-references cannot be convincingly demonstrated to be later additions. The mention of Adah and Zillah is not part of the narrative introduction to the song but of the call to listen to it, which is part of the song itself. It is an integral part of the first lyrical bicolon, undermining the literary-critical proposal to eliminate an assumed awkward introduction in which the women are mentioned again by name.¹⁰⁵ Therefore, the oft-discussed question about the incorporation of an older song and its possible historical context can focus in on the second line of the song (v. 23b, “Truly, I have killed a man for my wound, and a young boy for my bruise!”) or, even better, on the song’s genre. It is best described as a boasting song or a victory song that speaks confidently of the hero’s deeds. Comparable songs can be found across the Hebrew Bible, such as the humorous, and bloody, victory song of Samson (“With the jaw of a donkey [I slew] a horde, two hordes; with the jaw of a donkey I slew a thousand men”; Judg 15:16) or the song of the dancing women (!) at David’s return (“Saul has slain his thousands, and David his tens of thousands”; 1 Sam 18:7). The concrete occasion for the contextless “delight over the majestic strength of the hero”¹⁰⁶ can only be a subject of speculation. At any rate, the aforementioned parallels from an urban milieu speak against the exaggerating suggestions of seeing a nomadic,¹⁰⁷ or in particular Kenite,¹⁰⁸ character here. Thus, it must suffice to conclude that the Scholarly Narrator has taken up a traditional song of boasting or of victory (v. 23b), or has merely followed the standards of the

¹⁰⁴ von Rad, 111f.

¹⁰⁵ Cf. Dietrich, 2002, 161; Levin, 1993, 101. On the widespread assumption that a different use of *נָקַם q. pass. in v. 15 (“to incur vengeance”) and v. 24 (“to be avenged”) that would make a common authorship impossible (see Wellhausen, 1899, 9), see the Text-critical and Philological Note on v. 15 above.

¹⁰⁶ Gunkel, 52.

¹⁰⁷ Cf. Wellhausen, 1899, 307: “And, just like the Arabs are particularly fond of boasting to their wives that they are great bullies [*Eisenfresser*], so too here does Lamech” [translation JWR].

¹⁰⁸ Cf. Dietrich, 2002, 166: “The Lamech people boast that they respond even more ruthlessly and harshly than the Kenites claim altogether to do” [translation JWR].

genre, in order to emphasize the prototypical character of the self-assertive and self-indulgent Lamech in the context of the Fratricide narrative.

Already the first of the two statements following the bifurcated call (see also Isa 32:9) testifies to Lamech's exaggerated self-esteem and his hero-esque selfishness. Since it hardly seems that the man in the first part of the verse and the boy in the second part of the verse are one and the same person, the statement is clearly signaled as an intensification. Already the retribution from a flesh wound (פצע) with death invalidates the idea of appropriate retribution, as is the basis of the famous *lex talionis* formula ("A life for a life, an eye for an eye, a tooth for a tooth, and a hand for a hand, a foot for a foot, a wound for a wound, a bruise for a bruise"; Exod 21:23b–25). All the more, the killing of a boy for the sake of a blow or bruise (חבורה) seeks to make a mockery of any sense of justice, not merely from the perspective of the Hebrew Bible. The seventy-sevenfold vengeance breaks from the principles of every legal system that strives for harm limitation and conflict resolution and instead extols retribution taken to the extreme, as shown by comparison with the fate of Cain. In Cain's case, the completeness symbolized by the number "seven" is supposed to exclude from the outset any breaching of the taboo that Yhwh set to protect Cain. To the contrary, Lamech takes his leave of Yhwh as the guarantor of the protection of life and right by claiming elevenfold vengeance compared to that of Cain (v. 24) and exercising it himself against both great and small (v. 23b). At the end of the Cainite genealogy, the Other appears only as an enemy.¹⁰⁹ Within the Primeval History, the reaction to such arrogance, escalated into megalomania, is in turn the excessive punishment by Yhwh through the Flood, which, however, causes a radical conversion within God (see below on Gen 8:20–22) and opens the way for a demand for a seventy-sevenfold, and therefore boundless, forgiveness (Matt 18:21–22).

4:25

And Adam knew his wife again and she gave birth to a son and called his name "Seth," for "God has given me another descendant in the place of Abel, since Cain killed him."

The notice about the conception, birth, and naming of Seth (שֵׁת) marks a new beginning after the Cainite genealogy. The phrasing largely corresponds to Gen 4:1, 17 but is attentively modified: Unlike in Gen 4:17, it explicitly states, like in Gen 4:1, that the naming is done by the mother. Also in contrast to Gen 4:17, the name is explained with a reference to Yhwh/God, also like

¹⁰⁹ Witte, 1998, 170.

in Gen 4:1. Moreover, the mention of Cain and Abel explicitly refers back to Gen 4:1. The thread interrupted by vv. 2–24 is thus resumed, but the conditions have been altered.¹¹⁰ In contrast to the first conception, Gen 4:25 now deals with a second line of descent alongside that of the Cainites. For this reason, the proper name “Adam” (אָדָם) is used instead of the generic term “the Human” (הָאָדָם). This likewise corresponds to the mention of Cain’s name in Gen 4:17. Similarly, as in Gen 4:17 and in contrast to Gen 4:1, the name of the woman is not mentioned. Given this parallelism, the differences between the openings of the Cainite and Sethite genealogies are particularly striking. They emphasize the contrast between the two genealogical lines: The explanation of the name – “God has given/set (*שִׁית) for me another descendant in the place of Abel, since Cain killed him” – brings Cain’s terrible deed back to mind. In this way, the woman characterizes the name of her thirdborn as a replacement, tying it to the widespread custom, rooted in clan thinking, of giving children names “in which, in some way, lives the view that the bearer of the name is a new embodiment of a deceased family member or that they have reappeared or live anew in them.”¹¹¹ Thus, Seth is not merely another son; he is the continuation or taking up of what was begun with Abel in Yhwh looking favorably upon his gift. This line may have been interrupted by Cain and his murder of his brother, but the thread has not been broken. In this respect, it only seems logical that, as according to Gen 4:26b, invocation of Yhwh began at the time of Seth’s son Enosh. In the reference to God in the naming and, thus, the modest tone compared to Gen 4:1, Seth’s birth becomes even more the antithesis of the conceited Song of Lamech.

The etymology of the name “Seth” and its original meaning are unclear. It is possible that “Seth” should be connected with the שֵׁטַן mentioned in Num 24:17. However, admittedly, not much is known about them, either. They are typically assumed to be in Moab and are then connected with the *Sutū* nomads mentioned in Egyptian and cuneiform texts.¹¹² In Gen 4, Seth is indebted to the events recounted in the Fratricide narrative for both the meaning of his name and his genealogical position: This also explains the differences in the genealogical placement of Seth and Cain/Kenan between Gen 4 and Gen 5. The material in both series is identical, but they each give a different sequence, which suggests that they were following the same source. The Priestly Writing in Gen 5 probably preserves the original sequence (Adam – Seth – Enosh – Kenan/Cain). Conversely, the addition of the Fratricide narrative and the associated division of the single genealogy of Adam’s descendants into the Cainite and Sethite lineages are based on the conception by the Scholarly Narrator. This is affirmed by his formulation of the genealogical notes in Gen 4:1, 17, 25, which ties in with the Garden narrative.

¹¹⁰ See Willi, 1991, 433.

¹¹¹ Stamm, 1980, 59 [translation JWR].

¹¹² Görg, 2001.

4:26

*And a son was also born to Seth. And he called his name “Enosh.”
In those days, people began to call upon the name of Yhwh.*

The new line of descent opened by Seth is continued through Enosh (עֲנוֹשׁ). The name “Enosh” is attested as a personal name only here and in the parallel verses of Gen 5:6–11 (see also 1 Chr 1:1). Otherwise, עֲנוֹשׁ, like אָדָם, means “human” or “humanity.” Most attestations of עֲנוֹשׁ emphasize the aspects of mortality and finitude in contrast to God (see Ps 8:5). If the grandson thus bears the name of his grandfather, Adam, then Enosh becomes the ancestor of humanity, which follows down the line of Seth and survives the Flood through Noah. In this sense, Enosh is a “new Adam.”¹¹³ In the Primeval History by the Scholarly Narrator, a birth notice for Noah may have followed Gen 4:25f., with traces of it still surviving in Gen 5:28–29* (see below). If this assumption is correct, then for the Scholarly Narrator, Noah was the son of Enosh.

Genesis 4:26b associates the beginning of the invocation of Yhwh with Enosh. Invoking the divine name means, first of all, cultic veneration more generally (see Gen 12:8; 26:25). In disputes with other religions, it also has a confessional character (1 Kgs 18:24; Isa 12:4; 41:25; Joel 3:5). In Gen 4:26b, the phrasing is puzzling, since the two brothers Cain and Abel have already brought gifts to him (Gen 4:3f.). However, even if their offerings were unmistakably meant for Yhwh, he is not explicitly invoked by name (cf. Gen 12:8: “He built an altar for Yhwh and he called upon the name of Yhwh”). Perhaps the author of Gen 4:26b wanted to explicitly exclude the brotherslayer Cain, who performed the first cultic act, from also being the first to invoke Yhwh cultically. Early interpretations already began with such considerations, which is why it cannot be ruled out that the notice is a later addition from the environment of Jerusalem temple theology and can be attributed to the Redaction.¹¹⁴ On the other hand, it is quite unlikely that Enosh would be characterized as the founder of a civilization in a way analogous to the sons of Lamech. The phrase “In those days, people began” does not refer exclusively to Enosh but more generally to “the time of Enosh” (see Gen 12:6; 13:7).¹¹⁵ Whether a later addition or not, the notice emphasizes the primeval beginnings of invoking Yhwh, who himself is the one Creator God from the beginning of everything.

In the whole of the Pentateuch, the statement that humanity began to call upon the name of Yhwh in the time of Enosh is at odds with a strong tradition

¹¹³ Hess, 1993, 67.

¹¹⁴ See Witte, 1998, 306–309.

¹¹⁵ Following Willi, 1991, 433.

influenced by the Priestly Writing that connects the first mention of the divine name with Moses (Exod 3:14 [post-P¹¹⁶]; Exod 6:3 [P]). It is perhaps for this reason that the ancient translations vary in their readings of the verse. The LXX translates, “He [Enosh] hoped to call upon the name of the Lord God,” thereby attributing the virtue of “hope” to Enosh. In the rabbinic tradition, the statement is applied to the entire era but is read negatively, following the Targums: “In those days, people began to make idols for themselves and call them by the name of Yhwh” (Tg. Neof. on Gen 4:26). This condemnation of Enosh’s contemporaries can be understood as a further reason for the coming of the Great Flood.

¹¹⁶ On the (disputed) literary-historical classification of Exod 3:14, see Gertz, 2000, 281–305.

THE REGISTER OF THE GENERATIONS OF ADAM

- 5:1 This is the Register of the Generations of Adam. On the day that God created a human, he made it as an image akin to God.
- 2 Male and female he created them, and he blessed them and called their name “Human” [*’ādām*] on the day that they were created.
- 3 And Adam lived 130 years, then he fathered [a son] like him, according to his image, and he called his name “Seth.”
- 4 And the time that Adam lived after fathering Seth was 800 years, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 5 So the total lifetime that Adam lived was 930 years, then he died.
- 6 And Seth lived 105 years, then he fathered Enosh.
- 7 And Seth lived 807 years after fathering Enosh, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 8 So the total lifetime of Seth was 912 years, then he died.
- 9 And Enosh lived 90 years, then he fathered Kenan.
- 10 And Enosh lived 815 years after fathering Kenan, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 11 The total lifetime of Enosh was 905 years, then he died.
- 12 And Kenan lived 70 years, then he fathered Mahalalel.
- 13 And Kenan lived 840 years after fathering Mahalalel, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 14 So the total lifetime of Kenan was 910 years, then he died.
- 15 And Mahalalel lived 65 years, then he fathered Jared.
- 16 And Mahalalel lived 830 years after fathering Jared, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 17 So the total lifetime of Mahalalel was 895 years, then he died.
- 18 And Jared lived 62 [162] years, then he fathered Enoch.
- 19 And Jared lived 785 [800] years after fathering Enoch, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 20 So the total lifetime of Jared was 847 [962] years, then he died.
- 21 And Enoch lived 65 years, then he fathered Methuselah.
- 22 And Enoch walked with God 300 years after fathering Methuselah, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 23 So the total lifetime of Enoch was 365 years.

- 24 And Enoch walked with God. And he was there no longer, because God took him away.
- 25 And Methuselah lived 67 [187] years, then he fathered Lamech.
- 26 And Methuselah lived 653 [782] years after fathering Lamech, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 27 So the total lifetime of Methuselah was 720 [969] years, then he died.
- 28 And Lamech lived 53 [182] years, then he fathered [Noah] a son,
- 29 and he called his name “Noah,” saying, “This one will bring us comfort from our work and from the toil of our hands because of the soil, which Yhwh has cursed.”
- 30 And Lamech lived 600 [595] years after fathering Noah, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 31 So the total lifetime of Lamech was 653 [777] years, then he died.
- 32 And Noah was 500 years old, then Noah fathered Shem, Ham, and Japheth.

Analysis: This chapter goes back to the Priestly Writing. Traces of the Scholarly Narrator are found only in Gen 5:28*, 29.

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TEXT-CRITICAL AND PHILOLOGICAL NOTES

5:3 וַיֹּלֶד (then he fathered [a son]): Functionally, בֶּן “son” should be added here (homoioarcton?), especially since the reference for the 3rd pers. masc. suff. in שְׁמוֹ “his name” is otherwise missing. The genealogy’s formula suggests that וַיֹּלֶד “he fathered” should be followed by אָת and the name (see v. 6, *passim*). It can be assumed that the irregularity in v. 3 is due to the reference back to Gen 1:27, possibly because of the inclusion of an older “Book of the *Toledot*” within the Priestly Writing (see Scholarly Exposition II).

5:18 וּמָאָת שָׁנָה וְשִׁשִּׁים וְשָׁתַיִם (162 years): The MT, SP and LXX differ starkly in the ages. The translation here follows the SP (62 years), while the deviating numbers of the MT are provided in parentheses. The ages from the LXX are not indicated in the translation above. For the reasoning behind this, see Scholarly Exposition I.

5:23 וַיְהִי (So...was): Plural here and in v. 31 in the SP as with the other references of the formulation in ch. 5.

5:28 וַיֹּלֶד בֶּן (then he fathered [Noah] a son): See Scholarly Exposition II.

5:29 וְהָיָה לָנוּ יְנוּחָם (This one will bring us comfort): The LXX reads διαναπαύσει ἡμᾶς “he will bring us rest.” See Scholarly Exposition II.

ESSENTIALS AND PERSPECTIVES

The genealogical notices in Gen 4:17–24, 25–26 about the descendants of Cain and Seth, sons of Adam, are followed in Gen 5 by another genealogy of the descendants of Adam. This one, however, was written by a Priestly hand. The genealogy extends to Noah and his sons. Its postdiluvian counterpart in Gen 11:10–26 provides a genealogy of Noah’s son Shem that goes down to Terah, the father of Abraham. Both genealogies follow one line down to and including the penultimate member, running through father and first-born son. They have a strict, schematic structure: (a) the name of the patriarch; (b) his age at the conception of the (c) firstborn son, given by name; (d) how long he lived after conception; (e) the conception of further, unnamed sons and daughters; (f) the total age of the patriarch and (g) his death (Gen 11 does not give the total age or notice of death). The linear genealogy becomes a segmentary genealogy in the final link (v. 32; see Gen 11:26). Genesis 5 concludes with the three sons of Noah, from whom all of the nations of the earth have descended (Gen 10:1, 32). The formula records the return of the everlasting and unchangeable.

The Genealogical Conception of the Text in Its Final Form: On the level of the final text, Gen 5 should be approached within the context of the genealogical notices on the descendants of Cain and Seth, the sons of Adam, in Gen 4:17–24, 25–26. The “Register of the Generations of Adam” (סֵפֶר תּוֹלְדֹת אָדָם) does not distinguish between a Cainite line and a Sethite line. Nevertheless, regardless of the minor deviations in spelling and certain alterations in the order, all of the members of both lines reappear, with the exception of the descendants of Lamech. Thus, there are here two versions of one and the same genealogy.¹

Gen 4:1–2, 17–26		
Adam and Eve		
Cain	Abel	Seth
.		
.		
.		
Lamech	(no descendants)	Enosh

Cainites		Sethites		
Gen 4:1, 17–24		Gen 4:25–26; 5:28b, 29**	Gen 5:1–32*	
Adam		Adam	Adam	
		Seth	Seth	
		Enosh	Enosh	
Cain (קַיִן)			Kenan (קֵנָן)	
Enoch			Mahalalel (מַהֲלָלֵל)	
Irad (עִירָד)			Jared (יָרֵד)	
Mehujael (מְחֻיָּאֵל)			Enoch	
Methushael (מֶתוּשָׁאֵל)			Methuselah (מֶתוּשֶׁלַח)	
Lamech			Lamech	
		Noah	Noah	
Jabal	Jubal	Tubal- Naamah♀	Noah and his house (Gen 7:1)	Shem Ham Japheth
		Cain		

Read synchronically, Gen 5 takes up the notices about the descendants of Adam’s thirdborn son Seth and his son Enosh from Gen 4:25f. (see v. 3 for Gen 4:25 and v. 6 for Gen 4:26). The Register of the Generations of Adam is thus presented through the lineage of Seth, born as a substitute for the

¹ First posited by Buttmann, 1828, 171.

slain Abel, which leads to Noah over the course of ten generations. Regardless of the overlaps between Gen 5 and Gen 4:17–24, it sketches a Sethite genealogy that no longer includes the Cainites. Their genealogy ends after Gen 4 with the children of Lamech, who have no equivalent in Gen 5. Instead, Gen 5 introduces Noah as the son of a Lamech who, according to the present text, is not a descendant of Cain. Rather, the hero of the Flood is listed in the descendants of Seth, the replacement for Abel, for whose offering Yhwh has regard (Gen 4:4), and in those of Enosh, during whose time the worship of Yhwh begins (Gen 4:26). Noah's righteous family tree is moreover characterized by how the line from Seth and Enosh to Noah runs through a series of patriarchs who all enjoy a truly biblical age and – following the ages given in the MT – all die peacefully before the Flood. The two exceptions only highlight this further: Enoch walks with God and is taken up at the age of only 365 years (vv. 21–24), while Methuselah dies the same year as the Flood, but reaches the oldest age of all the patriarchs (v. 27).

The Genealogical Conception of the Priestly Writing: The genealogical conception of the present literary context has already been set through the Scholarly Narrator, the author of Gen 4 who differentiates between the Cainites, who are prone to violence, and the Sethites, who are evaluated positively. Noah (as a son of Enosh: Gen 4:26; 5:28b–29*) is included among the Sethites. Genesis 5, on the other hand, is based in the Priestly Writing (with the exception of vv. 28b–29*; see Scholarly Exposition II). With the Register of the Generations of Adam, it seems to have followed a different understanding. In the Priestly Writing, Gen 5 immediately follows the Creation account in Gen 1:1–2:3 and documents the initial fulfillment of the empowerment and ability to be fruitful, which is blessed upon humanity (Gen 1:28). In addition, the genealogy of Adam forms the opening of ten genealogies titled the “*toledot*/generations of P.N.” The end and goal of these genealogies is marked by the “*toledot*/generations of Jacob/Israel” (Gen 37:2), whose descendants in Egypt become the people of Israel. In this way, the Priestly Writing provides the structure of the narrative flow across the book of Genesis and presents it with a genealogical orientation with an increasing focus on Israel: With the three sons of Noah, the main focus is on Shem (Gen 11:10–26); with the three sons of Terah, it is on Abraham (Gen 11:27), and among his descendants the focus is on Isaac (Gen 25:19) and Jacob (37:2), while Ishmael and Esau are mentioned only peripherally (Ishmael in Gen 25:12–18; Esau in Gen 36). Thus, beginning with the first man, Adam, the *toledot* lead through Noah and Shem over 22 (LXX: 23) generations to the ancestors of Israel.² The background of the interest in genealogies, which is demonstrable for the exilic/

² See Tengström, 1982, 26; Crüsemann, 1998, 181.

postexilic period (so Ezra-Nehemiah and the books of Chronicles, esp. 1 Chr 1–9), might be an effort to safeguard Israel’s identity after the disappearance of the state.

Of course, the system of Priestly genealogies is not limited to the origins of Israel. The differentiation within the human family only begins with the *toledot*/generations of Shem in Gen 11:10–26, forming the postdiluvian counterpart to the antediluvian genealogy in Gen 5. In contrast, Gen 5 clearly emphasizes the *one* humanity coming from Adam, sharing with him the privilege of being made as the image of God (Gen 5:1–3). Its endpoint is marked by the three sons of Noah (Gen 5:32), from whom all peoples after the Flood descend (Gen 10:1).

As also in the preceding statements about the creation of humanity in Gen 1:26–28, the Priestly Writing emphasizes the essential unity of humanity, which Gen 5 also regards as a community of shared destiny and responsibility. Indeed, the counting of the ten generations does not merely serve to bridge the time period between Creation and the Flood: The Priestly Writing does not detail why the Creator’s evaluation of his creation could change so radically from “very good” (Gen 1:31) to “corrupt” (Gen 6:12). Instead, there is such a heavy emphasis in the Priestly opening to the Flood narrative on the negative judgment (see further below, pp. 293–299 on Gen 6:9–12, 13) that any further justification would be superfluous. Nevertheless, there is still a narrative void that Gen 5 fills – should the ages in the SP be preferred over the MT.³ Unlike the MT, the SP clearly differentiates between the first five antediluvian patriarchs and the following five: The dates of the first five’s deaths clearly predate the Flood. In contrast, Methuselah, Jared, and Lamech all die in 1307, the year in which the SP dates the beginning of the Flood. Of the patriarchs in the second half of the genealogy, the only survivors are Noah and Enoch, the latter of whom is taken up by God in the year 887. Since the genealogy assumes an average life expectancy of about 900 years, Jared (847 y/o), Methuselah (720 y/o), and Lamech (653 y/o) all die well before their time. Thus, they are marked as sinners compared both to their two younger contemporaries, Enoch and Noah, and to the patriarchs of the first through fifth generations. For the former, the righteousness of Enoch and Noah is expressly emphasized, and they do not fall victim to the Flood, while the latter grow to a ripe old age and die peacefully. The details concerning Methuselah and Enoch are particularly interesting. According to the MT, Methuselah also dies the same year as the Flood. However, the possible implications of this fate are considerably tempered by how the proverbial Methuselah reaches the age of 969 according to the MT and is the

³ See Gertz, 2022^a, 81–85, with reference to Budde, 1883, 89–116; see further Seebaß, 181–182.

oldest person reported in the Bible. According to the SP, he dies at age 720. At age 785, following the SP, Enoch would have been only slightly older in the year of the Flood. But Enoch, who walks with God, is saved from this “early” death when God takes him up. Enoch’s special destiny casts a dark shadow over the three patriarchs who die relatively “young” in the year of the Flood. This is further emphasized by the fact that according to the SP, all of the patriarchs were witnesses to Enoch being taken up. Finally, since the ages of the patriarchs who die in the year of the Flood continue to decrease, the implication is that sin among Noah’s contemporaries increased from generation to generation (Gen 6:9), with the genealogy clearly leading up to the divine judgment upon the wickedness of all flesh (Gen 6:12). Thus, the SP unfolds the increasing corruption of the “good” Creation genealogically rather than narratively.

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION I: INTRODUCTION TO EXEGESIS

Differing Chronologies in the MT, SP, and LXX: The ages at the conception of the firstborn and the (calculated) total lifetimes enable the calculation of an absolute “biblical” chronology by adding further data, giving the appearance of some order within the course of time.⁴ Since the main witnesses sometimes differ quite considerably (but still systematically!) in their dates, it is clear that the respective biblical chronologies have different end goals. Whether any of these chronological targets can still be identified is still a matter of debate,⁵ but this is of only ancillary interest for understanding Gen 5 (and 11). More important is the question of which of the sets of numbers should be given priority. The following differences should be noted for Gen 5:

	Anno mundi		Age at Conception of the Firstborn			Remaining Lifetime			Total Age		
	MT	SP	MT	LXX	SP	MT	LXX	SP	MT	LXX	SP
Adam	1–930	1–930	130	230	130	800	700	800	930	930	930
Seth	130–1042	130–1042	105	205	105	807	707	807	912	912	912
Enosh	235–1140	235–1140	90	190	90	815	715	815	905	905	905
Kenan	325–1235	325–1235	70	170	70	840	740	840	910	910	910

⁴ See Blenkinsopp, 2011, 107–111; Berner, 2012.
⁵ On this and the following, see Rösel, 1994, 129–144; Gertz, 2022^a, 81–91. Cf. Hendel, 2012. For a critique of Hendel’s reconstruction, see Gertz, *ibid.*, 86–89.

	Anno mundi		Age at Conception of the Firstborn			Remaining Lifetime			Total Age		
	MT	SP	MT	LXX	SP	MT	LXX	SP	MT	LXX	SP
Mahala- lel	395– 1290	395– 1290	65	165	65	830	730	830	895	895	895
Jared	460– 1422	460– 1307	162	162	62	800	800	785	962	962	847
Enoch	622– 987	522– 887	65	165	65	300	200	300	365	365	365
Methu- selah	687– 1656	587– 1307	187	167	67	782	802	653	969	969	720
Lamech	874– 1651	654– 1307	182	188	53	595	565	600	777	753	653
Noah ⁶	1056– 2006	707– 1657	500	500	500				950	950	950

The Flood begins when Noah is 600 years old: in the year 1656 according to the MT; 2242 according to the LXX; 1307 according to the SP.

The chronology for the first five patriarchs is the same in the MT and the SP. In each of these cases, the LXX dates the conception of the firstborn son 100 years later and shortens the remaining lifetime by 100 years. Thus, the lifetime remains the same, while the absolute chronology is lengthened by 400 years. The longer chronology of the LXX leads to Methuselah surviving the Flood by 14 years! Starting with Jared, the MT raises the age at the conception of the firstborn son significantly compared to the SP. While the MT and SP assume an average age of 92 years for the first five patriarchs at the conception of their firstborn, the MT averages 177 years for Jared, Methuselah, and Lamech compared to 61 years for the SP. The numbers of the SP fit better with the average age of the first five patriarchs, and they match the 65 years for Enoch according to the MT and SP and are consistent with the ages that the MT assumes almost universally in Gen 11:10–26. Finally, Noah’s personal acquaintance with Enoch, only possible according to the chronology of the SP, is probably in keeping with the intention of the text. Thus, it appears that the MT, based on an overriding chronological conception, raised the date of the conception of the firstborn by 100 years for Jared, 120 years for Methuselah, and 129 for Lamech, and extended their lifetimes accordingly. In Gen 11:10–26, the case is different. There, the MT provides the more original text compared to the concurring texts of the SP and LXX.

⁶ Taking into account the figures for Noah’s life after the Flood and his entire lifetime according to Gen 9:28f.

Tradition: The lengthy ages in Gen 5 (and Gen 11), which go beyond any measure of experience or biological possibility, have always been a challenge for apologists (see Dillman, 107f. for some attempts of conversion or symbolic interpretation; all are entirely untenable, since the Priestly Writing thought of the ten patriarchs as actual people and the ages as real years of life). Flavius Josephus explains them through the patriarchs eating a healthier diet and having lived much closer to the beginnings of Creation (Josephus, *A.J.* 1.105f.). Moreover, he cites similar statements about the longevity of the earliest generations of humanity among the Greeks, Egyptians, and Phoenicians in support of the biblical account's credibility. Indeed, the Priestly Writing shares the idea also attested elsewhere that people lived longer in prehistoric times and that the total lifespan decreased from one era to the next down to the more familiar amount of 70 to 80 years (see, e.g., Ps 90:10): For the era before the Flood, the Priestly Writing assumes lifetimes between around 700 and just under 1,000 years. In the era between the Flood and Abraham, the range is 148 to 600 years. The period between Abraham and Moses has ages between 100 and 200 years, and only in the post-Mosaic era do the ages drop to those expected of the time of the Priestly Writing and of modern times even a few decades ago.⁷ The Priestly Writing is silent concerning the reasons for such a staggering of human life expectancy. However, it clearly starts from a powerful primordial era characterized by the temporal proximity to the original Creation blessing: "What mighty power – such were the thoughts that underlie such calculations – must the early fathers have had, they who could beget the whole of humanity!"⁸ Worth particular emphasis among the ancient comparanda is the Sumerian King List from the second millennium BCE.⁹ The idealized enumeration of successive kingdoms in various (predominantly Babylonian) cities begins with the programmatic statement, "When kingship was lowered from heaven, kingship was (first) in..." It typically begins "after the Flood" with the dynasty of Kish, located east of Babylon, but text variants with initially eight and later ten antediluvian kings are also attested. This list comes from a tradition of early cities from the Sumerian version of the Flood story, beginning with Eridu (see above on Gen 4:17). Most textual representatives of this variant have the last ruler

⁷ Although life expectancy has increased by an average of 20 years worldwide in the last 50 years according to the WHO, the life expectancy of 78.2 years for men and 83.2 for women in Germany (as of 2021) is still far below the figures in Gen 5.

⁸ Gunkel, 135.

⁹ Introduction and Translation: "Texts from the Beginnings to the First Dynasty of Babylon," trans. Oppenheim (*ANET*, 265–266), with eight antediluvian rulers; "The Deluge," trans. Samuel N. Kramer (*ANET*, 42–44). On the different text variants, see Edzard, 1983. See also the Dynastic Chronicle, whose preserved fragments come from the Neo-Assyrian and Late Babylonian period; see Grayson, 1975.

named before the Flood as the Sumerian Flood hero, Ziusudra. This is reminiscent of Gen 5, as are the long reigns of far over 10,000 years each for the antediluvian rulers.¹⁰ How prestigious the Sumerian King List must have been among scribal schools can be seen in its wide distribution and transmission down into the Hellenistic period. Above all, the Babylonian priest Berossos is worth mentioning here, whose excerpt from a list of ten antediluvian rulers was already used in antiquity as a comparison for the biblical depiction.¹¹ Berossos's list, written in Greek, ends with the hero Xísouthros, corresponding to the Sumerian Ziusudra, and otherwise mentions as the seventh of ten rulers an Enedôranchos, corresponding to the Sumerian Emmeduranki. This king is in turn often associated with the figure of Enoch, who also stands in the seventh of ten positions in Gen 5.¹²

According to Mesopotamian sources, Emmeduranki lived in the city of Sippar, known for its veneration of the sun god. This can be connected to the 365 years of Enoch's life, which are easily linked to the solar year. Emmeduranki is regarded as the father of divination because he was temporarily taken up into the heavenly court. He is also a contemporary of Utuabzu, the seventh and final of the antediluvian sages also mentioned by Berossos and who is said to have ascended to heaven. This is not only reminiscent of what little information is given about Enoch in Gen 5:21–24; it also fits well with the image of Enoch in early Jewish literature, in which Enoch becomes the sage and seer *par excellence* (e.g., Sir 44:16, Jud 14f.).

Since both the Creation account and the Flood narrative show some proximity to the explanations in Berossos (e.g., Gen 1:2, 3–5; Gen 6:5–9, 17), there could actually be some sort of relation “from a very early stage”¹³ with a variant of the Sumerian King List as also preserved in Berossos, but anything more specific about the development of the traditions is difficult to say. The lengthy ages of the earliest generations, the understanding of the Flood as an existential break in the prehistory of humanity also tangible in Gen 5 and 11, and the practice of recording important antediluvian people in lists are all common across the ancient Near East. Unlike the Sumerian King List, however, Gen 5 is not about divine kingship but about a humanity that is ennobled by the image of God (vv. 1–3).

¹⁰ The numbers differ significantly in the individual recensions. In contrast to the years of life in Gen 5, the regnal years in the Sumerian King List follow the sexagesimal system and can be converted into the units *sar* (3,600) and *ner* (600).

¹¹ Text and translation in Jacoby, 1958, 374–378. See further Day, 2013, 61–76.

¹² See VanderKam, 1984, 23–51; idem, 1995, 6–16; Borger, 1974. Emmeduranki appears in other editions of the Sumerian King List as the seventh of eight or the sixth of seven, eight, or ten rulers.

¹³ Gunkel, 135. See also Day, 2013, 61–76.

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION II: EXEGESIS

5:1–5

- 1 *This is the Register of the Generations of Adam. On the day that God created a human, he made it as an image akin to God.*
- 2 *Male and female he created them, and he blessed them and called their name “Human” [’ādām] on the day that they were created.*
- 3 *And Adam lived 130 years, then he fathered [a son] like him, according to his image, and he called his name “Seth.”*
- 4 *And the time that Adam lived after fathering Seth was 800 years, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
- 5 *So the total lifetime that Adam lived was 930 years, then he died.*

The heading in v. 1a stands out from the other Priestly genealogies by the phrase “Register of the *Toledot*/Generations” (סֵפֶר תּוֹלְדוֹת). The Heb. סֵפֶר is a collective term for various forms of writing. Since there is no information given about the nature of the piece of writing, the best way of translating it seems to one be based on the content of the document, such as the “register” chosen here.¹⁴ As a heading, it marks the beginning of a document containing the genealogy of Adam. It continues in Gen 11:10–26 with that of Shem. Its reference only as “*toledot*/generations” (תּוֹלְדוֹת), like the genealogies that follow, seems to suggest a genealogical document starting with Gen 5:1 and structured by the repeated *toledot* formula.¹⁵ The references back to Gen 1:26–28 in vv. 1b–2, 3a then come from the integration of this document into the Priestly Writing; this then led to a deviation from the genealogical scheme and to the slight roughness of the language in v. 3a (see the Text-critical and Philological Note on v. 3 above). The thesis of a “Book of the *Toledot*” is supported by the fact that a separate transmission of traditional genealogical material is highly probable from a historical point of view. Nevertheless, it cannot be completely ruled out that the mention of a “Register of the Generations of Adam” is a literary device of the Priestly Writing emphasizing the prestige of its own genealogies through the supposed citation of an earlier source. Whatever the case may be, through the heading in v. 1a, the history of humanity and, later, of Israel is set off from the prologue about the history of Creation in Gen 1:1–2:3.

Verses 1b–3 lead from the creation of the human species as the image of God (v. 1b, so also Gen 1:26a, 27a), the differentiation of the sexes (v. 2a;

¹⁴ The usual translation as “book” is difficult since this evokes the anachronistic idea of a bound codex. If the intention were explicitly a scroll, the Heb. מְגִלָּה would be expected.

¹⁵ For the fundamental aspects, see von Rad, 1934, 33–40. For the scholarly discussion, see overviews in Bühner, 2014, 156–160; Carr, 2020, 83–114.

so also Gen 1:27b), and the blessing by the Creator (v. 2b; so also Gen 1:28) to the history of individual people in whom the blessing is realized (v. 3). The transition is marked in v. 3 by Adam's (אָדָם) naming of Seth, which functionally parallels God's naming of humanity in v. 2b (אָדָם). The notice of Adam fathering Seth as "like him, according to his image," which deviates from the genealogical scheme, likewise draws on the creation of humanity in Gen 1:26f. through the quotation in v. 1b. It is significant that from this point onward, the terminology of "fathering" (*לָדָה hi.) takes the place of the divine creative action (*בָּרָא), realizing the blessing promise in Gen 1:28. The transition from the creation of humanity to the generational succession of descendants thus occurs in the fathering and naming of the first descendant. By the chaining of generations, all human beings share in the image of God through Adam and Eve and/or by being part of the larger human species. The image of God is thus self-replicating, and so there is no need to mention this specifically with the future generations.¹⁶

Verses 1b–2 are sometimes considered to be an addition aimed at integrating Gen 2:4–4:2 because of the alternating use of אָדָם as a proper name in vv. 1a, 3 and as a generic term in vv. 1b–2, as well as because of its recourse to Gen 1:26–28, which some see as redundant.¹⁷ Yet, this fails to recognize the compositional function of the section. Additionally, a redactional resumptive repetition [*Wiederaufnahme*] aimed at integrating the non-Priestly material would be expected to take up the thread from where it left off, i.e., with a note about the completion of Creation, or to refer in some way to the Garden narrative or to the story of Cain and Abel. However, neither of these occur.

According to Gen 4:25, Seth (for explanation of the name, see on Gen 4:25 above) is the thirdborn son of Adam. The explanation of the name provided there points to him as a replacement for the slain Abel, but this as well as the differences in the order and designation of Cain as a son of Adam have resulted from the Scholarly Narrator's connection of the genealogy to the story of Cain and Abel. The Priestly Writing clearly knows nothing of children born before Seth, since the other sons and daughters are explicitly mentioned only after Seth. The Priestly Writing probably has the original generational sequence: Adam – Seth – Enosh – Cain/Kenan (see pp. 217f. on Gen 4:25).

5:6–20

- 6 *And Seth lived 105 years, then he fathered Enosh.*
 7 *And Seth lived 807 years after fathering Enosh, and he fathered sons and daughters.*

¹⁶ See Dillmann, 113.

¹⁷ See Holzinger, 58f.; Levin, 1993, 100; Seebaß, 180.

- 8 *So the total lifetime of Seth was 912 years, then he died.*
- 9 *And Enosh lived 90 years, then he fathered Kenan.*
- 10 *And Enosh lived 815 years after fathering Kenan, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
- 11 *The total lifetime of Enosh was 905 years, then he died.*
- 12 *And Kenan lived 70 years, then he fathered Mahalalel.*
- 13 *And Kenan lived 840 years after fathering Mahalalel, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
- 14 *So the total lifetime of Kenan was 910 years, then he died.*
- 15 *And Mahalalel lived 65 years, then he fathered Jared.*
- 16 *And Mahalalel lived 830 years after fathering Jared, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
- 17 *So the total lifetime of Mahalalel was 895 years, then he died.*
- 18 *And Jared lived 62 [162] years, then he fathered Enoch.*
- 19 *And Jared lived 785 [800] years after fathering Enoch, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
- 20 *So the total lifetime of Jared was 847 [962] years, then he died.*

Verses 6–8 provide the first complete and unaltered formula of the genealogy. It is also followed by the entries in vv. 9–11, 12–14, 15–17, and 18–20. As in Gen 4:26, Seth is listed as the father of Enosh (for explanation of the name, see on Gen 4:26 above). The name of his son Kenan is a variation of “Cain” and may be a diminutive or affectionate form (for explanation of the name, see on Gen 4:1–2 above).¹⁸ The different spelling eases the reading of the present text, according to which the Cainites are different from the Sethites, who include Kenan. Mahalalel, “Praise of God” or “Praising God” corresponds to the Mehujael of the Cainite genealogy in Gen 4:18, but unlike there, he is the son of Kenan/Cain rather than his great-grandson. The meaning of the name “Jared” is, like its counterpart “Irad” in Gen 4:18, completely uncertain. The various proposals for Jared range from a connection with the Hebrew word for “rose” or “flower” to an etymological connection with the Akkadian (*w*)*ardu(m)* “slave.” More likely, it is derived from the root *יָרַד “to go down; to descend.” Conceivably, the name was originally a sentence name “(The deity) D.N. goes down (to help),” with the theophoric element having fallen out. In early Jewish exegesis, the connection with the root *יָרַד is explained by the mythological fact that in the time of Jared, the Sons of the Gods (Gen 6:2) descended from heaven (see Jub. 4:15).

¹⁸ See Hess, 1993, 67f., as well as *ibid.*, 68–71 for the following names.

5:21–24

- 21** *And Enoch lived 65 years, then he fathered Methuselah.*
22 *And Enoch walked with God 300 years after fathering Methuselah, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
23 *So the total lifetime of Enoch was 365 years.*
24 *And Enoch walked with God. And he was there no longer, because God took him away.*

The genealogical entry for Enoch (for explanation of the name, see on Gen 4:17 above) deviates from the formula. In the element “he lived [X] years after fathering the firstborn son,” the “he lived” is replaced with “he walked with God” (v. 22). Instead of the final death notice, it reads, “God took him [Enoch] away” (v. 24). The “taking away” (*לקח) is certainly not a synonym for “dying.” As is later reported of Elijah (2 Kgs 2:3, 5, 9, 10), Enoch did not die a natural death. He was taken up into the heavenly world in the middle of his life, although the Priestly Writing is silent about the exact circumstances of this and where he went, unlike the Elijah tradition (2 Kgs 2:11). There is only a slight hint of the reason, with the notice being preceded by the repeated statement that Enoch “walked with God.” The phrase “walking with God” (*הלך hitp. + אֶת־הָאֱלֹהִים), like the more frequently attested “walking before God/Yhwh” (*הלך hitp. + לִפְנֵי; see Gen 17:1 [P]; 24:40; 48:15; 2 Kgs 20:3 // Isa 38:3; Ps 56:14; 116:9; see further Mic 6:8; Mal 2:6) signifies a pious way of life and may also bear the sense of a special intimacy with God (see *הלך hitp. + אֶת in 1 Sam 25:15). The phrase “walking with God” otherwise occurs only in connection with Noah, to whose righteousness and perfection the Priestly Writing attests in contrast to his contemporaries (Gen 6:9). The slight variation from the typical formula obviously establishes a connection between the two statements (see Heb 11:5). The evaluation of Noah’s walking with God stands in explicit contrast to the evaluation of his contemporaries and serves to justify the coming Flood and Noah’s salvation. Following the ages in the SP, a quite similar statement is implicitly made for Enoch. Through being taken up by God, Enoch is, like Noah, saved from an untimely death, while the three following generations die in the year of the Flood. The note about him being taken up explicitly emphasizes again how Enoch walked with God, which immediately suggests a causal connection between the two: Enoch, who walks with God, is taken up and saved from death because of how he lives his life. Thus, the taking up of Enoch foreshadows the salvation of Noah. The ways of life and the fates of these two patriarchs are unprecedented among their contemporaries.¹⁹ The great brevity of the notice

¹⁹ See Witte, 1998, 76.

about Enoch's exceptional fate speaks for the assumption that the Priestly Writing was alluding to a broader tradition. The 365 years that Enoch lived on earth also point in this direction. The number "365" is related to the solar year, which may indicate that a background in astral religion or astronomy for the figure of Enoch was already known to the Priestly Writing (see also later Jub. 4:17). In any case, Enoch is one of the most important figures of Jewish apocalypticism and has been connected with an extensive body of literature.²⁰

5:25–27

- 25** *And Methuselah lived 67 [187] years, then he fathered Lamech.*
26 *And Methuselah lived 653 [782] years after fathering Lamech, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
27 *So the total lifetime of Methuselah was 720 [969] years, then he died.*

Enoch's son Methuselah is the counterpart to the Methushael mentioned in Gen 4:18, who is also labeled the father of Lamech but is counted as Enoch's great-grandson. As with Methushael, the first element of the name can be connected to the West Semitic *mutu* "man, hero, warrior." The etymology of the second element is uncertain. Scholars have debated whether it relates to the deified underwater river *Šelah*:²¹ "Man of [the god] *Šelah*." The LXX gives the name as Μαθουσαλα, which became *Mathusalam* in the Vulgate, leading to similar renderings in other languages, such as "Methusalem" in German, "Matusalén" in Spanish, and "Mathusalem" in French. Since, according to the MT version, his lifetime of 969 years was the longest of all the antediluvian patriarchs, who were all distinguished by particularly old ages, the name "Methuselah" has come to signify old age. According to the SP version, Methuselah reaches "only" the age of 720 years and dies in the year of the Flood. As for the meaning of the name of his son Lamech (see above on Gen 4:18f.), there is nothing that can be said.

5:28–31

- 28** *And Lamech lived 53 [182] years, then he fathered [Noah] a son, and he called his name "Noah," saying, "This one will bring us comfort from our work and from the toil of our hands because of the soil, which Yhwh has cursed."*

²⁰ Ego, 2007.

²¹ See Becking, 1999.

- 30** *And Lamech lived 600 [595] years after fathering Noah, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
- 31** *So the total lifetime of Lamech was 653 [777] years, then he died.*

The entry on Lamech deviates in vv. 28b–29 from the general genealogical formula in several respects. As with Adam, there is a distinction between the fathering and the naming of the firstborn, leading here to an explanation of the name, which otherwise does not occur in Gen 5. Moreover, in the context of the Priestly Writing, it is particularly noteworthy that it uses the proper name of God, “Yhwh.” Furthermore, the name explanation points back via Gen 4:11 to Gen 3:17 with the formulation “because of the soil, which Yhwh has cursed” (מִן־הָאֲדָמָה אֲשֶׁר אָרְרָה יְהוָה), while the first part points forward to Gen 6:5–8*; 8:20–21. All of these texts referenced within the explanation belong to the non-Priestly stratum. Therefore, the (sub-)verses in question should be evaluated as a displaced notice by the Scholarly Narrator about the birth of Noah, which originally followed both Gen 4:25f. and a corresponding birth notice.²² In the Primeval History by the Scholarly Narrator, the words put into Lamech’s mouth in the present text would have originally come from Enosh. The remainder of v. 28 probably comes from the Priestly Writing, which also gave a notice here about the birth of Noah and likely formulated it analogously to the other birth notices: “and he fathered Noah.” The name “Noah” (נֹחַ) is probably derived from the root נָח “to rest” (see also נֹחָה in 1 Chr 8:2; מְנוּחָה in Judg 13).²³ This is reflected in the LXX, which reads διαναπαύσεαι ἡμᾶς in v. 29, “he will give us rest” (Heb יְנִיחוּנוּ). The more difficult, better attested, and therefore preferable reading in the MT, “he will comfort us” (יְנַחֲמֵנוּ) associates the name with the root נָחַם “to comfort,” since they sound similar to each other. It is difficult to ascertain what exactly Noah’s “comforting” entails. In the present text, Noah’s invention of viticulture immediately comes to mind given the association between “wine” and “comfort” (Gen 9:20).²⁴ Wine has certainly since served as a frequent source of comfort (Ps 104:15; Prov 31:6f.), but the narrative of Noah as a winemaker came from later redactional activity. Most importantly, the narrative lacks any reference to the comforting provided by Noah and instead ends with a new curse for one of Noah’s descendants (Gen 9:25). In connection with the reference back to Gen 3:16, 17 (עֲצָבוֹן “toil”), it is more likely that the “comfort” motif looks ahead to Yhwh’s promise of never again cursing the earth, given at the end of the Flood in response to

²² So already Gunkel, 55.

²³ For the etymology, see Witte, 1998, 208–210.

²⁴ First by Budde, 1883, 306f. See Gunkel, 55; Jacob, 167; von Rad, 72; Westermann, 360; Seebaß, 184f. Cf. skeptically, e.g., Arneth, 2007, 204.

Noah's sacrifice of thanksgiving (see pp. 288f., 328–331 on the Exegesis of Gen 6:6 and 8:20–21). From the perspective of the *dramatis personae*, the explanation of the name is formulated as an open request, which is realized in the Primeval History in the new beginning set with Noah after the Flood.²⁵

According to the MT, Lamech reaches the age of 777 years. It is conceivable that this number is based on an erudite reflection by a later scribe and alludes to the seventy-sevenfold vengeance of the Cainite Lamech in Gen 4:24.²⁶

5:32

And Noah was 500 years old, then Noah fathered Shem, Ham, and Japheth.

The “Register of the Generations of Adam” concludes with the notice about the fathering of the sons of Noah. This changes the linear genealogy into a segmentary genealogy with three lines, foreshadowing the events to come and heralding the emergence of a postdiluvian world made up of various nations. The only attestation of the name “Japheth” in the Hebrew Bible is in the collection of texts concerning the sons of Noah (Gen 6:10; 7:13; 9:18–27; 10:1–32; 1 Chr 1:4f.). Shem is also found in the “*toledot*/generations of Shem” (Gen 11:10, 11; see also 1 Chr 1:17, 24); for Ham, there are also three mentions of the “land of Ham” related to Egypt and the Exodus narrative (Ps 78:51; 105:23, 27; cf. 1 Chr 4:40). “Shem” (שֵׁם) is probably an artificial name whose meaning, lit. “name,” refers to the posthumous fame of the line opened by Shem. The etymology of the name “Ham” (חָם) is unclear. Possible is a connection with the Egyptian *ḥm* “servant” (“servant of the god D.N.”) Another proposal derives the name from the homonymous Hebrew word for father-in-law, specifically the husband's father (see Gen 38:13, 25; 1 Sam 4:19, 21). Furthermore, the name sounds like the homophonous Hebrew adjective “hot”. However, this adjective is not attested in personal names. It is possible that the Egyptian element underwent a “Semitic” recoding during its transition to the Levant (so also the naming of Moses by Pharaoh's daughter in Exod 2:10).²⁷ The name “Japheth” (יָפֶֿתֿ) is generally associated with the Titan Iapetus, the father of Atlas, Menoetius, Prometheus, and Epimetheus, known from Greek mythology.

²⁵ See similarly Witte, 1998, 215–217, who assigns Gen 5:29 to the final redaction [*Endredaktion*] and sees the realization of this request in the Priestly account of the blessing of Noah and the promise of an “eternal covenant” (Gen 9:1–7, 8–17). However, Gen 8:20–21 is also a possibility for this, since the Scholarly Narrator also saw Noah as the “new Adam.”

²⁶ See Wellhausen, 1905, 309.

²⁷ See Hess, 1993, 30f.

In the Priestly Writing, Gen 5:32 was originally followed immediately by the *toledot*/generations of Noah in Gen 6:9f., which again mention the three sons of Noah. This repetition, like the emphasized repetition of the subject “Noah” in v. 32b, may seem redundant at first glance. However, this is no reason to reject the verse’s affiliation with the Priestly Writing or to cite it as an argument against the assumption of a previously independent Priestly Writing.²⁸ As Gen 11:26 and 11:27 show, it is not unusual for the concluding formulation of one genealogy to point already to the next. In the context of the fourfold mention of Noah in Gen 6:9f., the repetition of his name in v. 32b should not be surprising. Since the three sons of Noah are the final goal of the genealogy and only Noah and his three sons (along with their wives) are saved from the Flood, there is no note about any further sons and daughters of Noah (so also with Terah in Gen 11:26). Appropriately, the remaining lifetime (after the Flood) is added only after the conclusion of the Noah narratives, together with his total lifetime (Gen 9:28–29). Noah’s significantly higher age when fathering his sons compared to the other patriarchs, at 500 years old, results from the timing of the Flood, which is dated to the 600th year of Noah (Gen 7:6), and from the reasoning that Noah’s sons were the final generation before the Flood.

²⁸ On the scholarly discussion, see Gertz, 2022^a, 78–80.

THE SONS OF THE GODS AND THE DAUGHTERS OF MAN

- 6:1** And it came to pass as humanity began to multiply upon the ground, and daughters were born to them,
2 that the Sons of the Gods saw the Daughters of Man, that they were good, and they took wives for themselves from all whom they chose.
3 And Yhwh said, “My spirit shall not be active in humanity forever, for it too, it is flesh. Its lifetime shall be 120 years.”
4 The giants were on the earth in those days (and also later), when the Sons of the Gods went into the Daughters of Man and they gave birth [to children] for them; these are the heroes of old, men of renown.

Analysis: This section comes from the Redaction, with וְגַם אַחֲרָיִיכֶן “and also later” in v. 4 being a gloss.

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TEXT-CRITICAL AND PHILOLOGICAL NOTES

6:3 יָדוֹן (*be active*): The Heb. יָדוֹן is a *hapax legomenon* from a root otherwise unattested in Hebrew *דוּן or *דָּנָן (see, however, the personal name “Jadon” in Neh 3:7), like Akk. *danānu* “to be mighty/strong.” The LXX translates it with καταμένω “to stay,” which likely presumes the Heb. *דוּר “to dwell” (cf. 4Q252 1.2 [4QCommentary on Genesis; DJD XXII, 185–207]).

בְּשָׁנָם (*for it too*): בְּשָׁנָם is a contraction of the preposition בְּ + relative particle שָׁ + גַּם “also.” Similar constructions with שָׁ/שְׁ and two more particles are otherwise attested in the Hebrew Bible only in the Hellenistic book of Ecclesiastes (בְּשִׁכְכָּר in Eccl 2:16; see also שָׁנָם-יָהּ in Eccl 1:17; 2:15; 8:14). שָׁ/שְׁ with one other particle is attested sporadically in earlier texts, but more often only in Eccl and Song. Against other suggested possibilities (“because of their misdeeds”; “because of their shouting”), see the well-founded criticism in Witte, 1998, 67 as well as below in Scholarly Exposition I. Rosenberg, 1993 drew attention to an interesting observation made already by the rabbis (Gen. Rab. 26.6): Per the gematria, the numerical values of “Moses” and בְּשָׁנָם both equal 345. Was this unusual formulation due to the connection of v. 3 with the notice of Moses’s death at 120 years old according to Deut 34:7? (See below, Scholarly Exposition II.)

ESSENTIALS AND PERSPECTIVES

Characterization: The enigmatic episode of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man is often conceived as an foreign element within the Hebrew Bible’s Primeval History, primarily due to its mythological motifs. However, on closer examination, it actually does not differ from its context too much in this respect: The narrative of several divine male beings having sexual intercourse with human women, along with the consequences thereof, is recounted without moral judgment. Although modern readers may find this disturbing, it fits quite well with the mythological world of the biblical Primeval History. Elsewhere, the Primeval History presupposes a plurality of heavenly

beings (Gen 1:26; 2:1; 3:22; 11:7; cf. 5:24), knows of intermediary beings such as the cherubim (Gen 3:24), deals for long stretches with direct interaction between God and humanity (cf. Gen 3:8ff.), and introduces a talking serpent, who, like the giants, is more at home in the realm of fairy tales (Gen 3:1ff.). Nevertheless, the impression of the narrative being unique within the Primeval History is not unjustified: At best, only one other text shares its narration style: the note about God taking up Enoch in Gen 5:24. Furthermore, the present narrative is extremely brief and refrains from elaborating upon its unique themes. It seems to presuppose its intended audience's prior familiarity with its subjects, and it contents itself with allusions that are hardly comprehensible to modern readers, even when including comparative religious material. This has led to it being characterized in academic research as a "fragment" or a "torso."¹

Context: The beginning of Gen 6:1–4 is demarcated by the introductory formula "And it came to pass" (וַיְהִי כֵן; cf. 26:8; 27:1) and its end by the etiology of the "heroes of old." Compositionally, the section serves as bridge between the Register of the Generations of Adam in Gen 5 and the Flood narrative in Gen 6:5–9:17. It shares with the preceding genealogies the theme of humanity's multiplication, except that here, the female offspring are brought to the fore, rather than being mentioned only passively as in the preceding texts (see, e.g., Na'amah in Gen 4:22 as well as the formulaic notice about the birth of further sons and daughters, Gen 5:4 and *passim*). This later addition concerning the female line occurs with clear recourse to the beginning of the generations of Adam in Gen 5:1–3, since the episode itself is located within the time when humanity begins to multiply (v. 1).² Yhwh's reaction to the union between the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man quietly foreshadows the subsequent Flood narrative. In retrospect, the condemnation of humanity, "it is flesh" (v. 3), seems to be the first step towards God's judgment that "all flesh had corrupted its way upon the earth" (Gen 6:12) and the narrator's assessment that "the end of all flesh has come before [God]" (Gen 6:13). The episode is further connected to the Flood narrative in how it describes an antediluvian contrast to the postdiluvian world of the authors, in which, at least according to the stories within the Hebrew Bible, there is no longer any sexual union between the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man.

An Introduction to the Flood Narrative? Genesis 6:1–4, or a core of the passage, is often understood as an (further) introduction to the (non-P) Flood

¹ Gunkel, 59.

² See Schüle, 2006, 220.

narrative in Gen 6:5ff.³ Thus, according to the widely-accepted thesis from Gerhard von Rad, the episode about the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man, alongside those of the forbidden fruit, the fratricide of Cain and Abel, and the construction of the Tower of Babel, is proof that the Yahwistic Primeval History “is characterized on the human side by an increase in sin to avalanche proportions.”⁴ Per von Rad, the emergence of this “super humanity” from the union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man is evaluated by the “Yahwist” as a terrible “deterioration of all creation” and a “rampant spread of sin,” from which God draws the “corresponding conclusion” with the Flood.⁵ However, it is quite questionable whether the episode in Gen 6:1–4 already denounces a general deterioration of humanity, as is explicitly the case in the prologue to the Flood narrative (cf. Gen 6:5 [SN], as well as Gen 6:12f. [PJ]).⁶ The union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man is clearly initiated by the Sons of the Gods, while the women are portrayed as purely passive. Thus, unlike what might be expected for a prologue to the Flood narrative in Gen 6:5, Gen 6:1–4 speaks of neither human guilt nor an increase in sin.⁷ On the other hand, how a possible causal connection between the so-called “angel marriages” and the Flood would look is shown by the early reception history of the passage (see on v. 2 below).⁸ In addition, it makes little sense for God to take the union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man as a reason to limit the human lifespan to 120 years, if God’s judgment and the subsequent extinction of all flesh on earth are a direct consequence of the sexual intercourse between the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man.⁹

A further argument for connecting Gen 6:1–4 to the Flood narrative has been made with reference to the Flood tradition from Mesopotamia.¹⁰ In the Old Babylonian Epic of Atrahasis, which the biblical authors used as a model for their own Flood narrative (see below, pp. 279–283 on Gen 6:5–9:17), the gods react to the excessive human multiplication and their resultant noisiness first by sending severe plagues and then ultimately by sending the

³ See, among others (with very different reasons and evaluations of the supposed connection with the Flood narrative), Jacob, 169–182; Speiser, 46; Scharbert, 78f.; Ruppert, 265–269; also Hendel, 1987, 16–24; Levin, 1993, 104; Kvanvig, 2011, 274–310.

⁴ von Rad, 152.

⁵ von Rad, 115f.

⁶ See Seebaß, 188; Kvanvig, 2011, 277; Bühner, 2011, 508. Cf. Oeming, 1993, 46–50, who sees an understanding of sin as “fate” in Gen 6:1–4.

⁷ This also contradicts Westermann, 368, who characterizes the episode as one of four “examples of offenses and the corruption of humanity” and a depiction of the “variety of ways in which sin is actualized.”

⁸ Day, 2013, 86f.

⁹ Schüle, 227f.

¹⁰ See Kraeling, 1947; Kvanvig, 2011, 279, 303–310.

Flood. After the Flood, human life is reordered to prevent further excessive multiplication from ever happening again (Atr 3.6.46–3.7.11). While the multiplication motif is reminiscent of Gen 6:1a, the “parallels” in Gen 6:1–4 to the Epic of Atrahasis are limited to this very general motif that would be expected within any primeval history. In the Epic of Atrahasis, humanity’s noisiness is what triggers the flood, but this is absent in Gen 6:1–4 (as well as the Flood narrative in Gen 6:5–9:17). Conversely, the union of the divine beings and humanity from Gen 6:1–4 has no parallel in Atrahasis. Furthermore, the noisiness motif should not be read into the text of Gen 6:1–4 by understanding בָּשָׁנָם (“for it too”; see the Text-critical and Philological Note on v. 3 above) as derived from the Akkadian *šagāmu* “to roar, shout.”¹¹ This root is not attested in Hebrew, the proposed translation of בָּשָׁנָם as “with noise” makes no sense in the present context, and the Epic of Atrahasis, although cited in support of this derivation, uses *rigmu* and *hubūru* “noise” rather than *šagāmu* for the people’s noisiness in the passages in question. Next, it has also been argued that Gen 6:5 (“And Yhwh saw that the wickedness of humanity was vast upon the earth”) harkens back to Gen 6:1 and interprets the union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man as evidence for the prevalence of evil among humanity.¹² This interpretation draws on the use of רַב־בָּ “to become numerous/vast” but overlooks the differences in wording that are not explainable through an intentional back-reference (בְּאֶרֶץ “on the earth” in v. 5 rather than עַל-פְּנֵי הָאֲדָמָה “upon the ground” in v. 1). Finally, it must also be considered that there is a conceptual difference in how the impairment of the human condition in the outline of the biblical Primeval History, in contrast to the Epic of Atrahasis, takes place already before the Flood (apart from the limitation of life per Gen 6:3; see esp. Gen 3:16–19, 22). From all of this, it is clear that Gen 6:1–4 should not be seen as part of the Flood narrative. Rather, the episode and the motifs collected herein must be interpreted as independent narrative elements.

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION I: INTRODUCTION TO EXEGESIS

Formation: There is no research consensus on how to classify Gen 6:1–4 in terms of its literary and religious-historical contexts, and so interpretations of the passage can differ greatly from one scholar to the next. The only thing not in dispute is that the passage does not belong to the Priestly Writing. On the other hand, how exactly it should be situated within the non-Priestly texts has been the subject of much controversy: Some understand the text

¹¹ Cf. Clines, 1979, 40; Kvanvig, 2011, 285.

¹² Hendel, 1987, 16f, 23f., and Levin, 1993, 104.

as a literary unity, while others see within it a process of thorough revision, which some even believe to comprise at least three phases of editorial additions. Some see mythological material that is quite old at the basis of Gen 6:1–4, while others locate the text within the Enoch tradition of early Judaism or in the confrontation with the Hellenistic “hero cult.” Within the Documentary Hypothesis, the passage is often understood as part of the core of a “Yahwistic” history, with most detecting a fragment of an old myth about the Sons of the Gods in vv. 1–2 (4), which was taken up by the “Yahwist” and demythologized through the addition of v. 3 and shaped as an introduction of the Flood narrative.¹³ Furthermore, scholars working both inside and outside the Documentary Hypothesis have sometimes evaluated Gen 6:1–4 as a later addition to the “Yahwist”¹⁴ or as a scribal addition that already presupposes segments of Priestly texts.¹⁵

To some extent, the diversity and incompatibility of the proposed solutions confirm an older evaluation by Martin Noth: “Gen 6:1–4 is in every respect so isolated that there is absolutely nothing certain about the source of this passage; it could be J, or J^S, or even an addition to the completed Pentateuch.”¹⁶ Keeping this caveat in mind, the following supports the thesis that, with the exception of the gloss וְגַם אַחֲרֵי־כֵן “and also later” in v. 4 (see below on v. 4), the passage is a literary unity that comes not from either of the two main voices of the biblical Primeval History but rather from sometime during or after the redactional connection of the Priestly Writing with the Scholarly Narrator’s Primeval History.

The classification of Gen 6:1–4’s literary history proposed here has already been indicated in the above description of the section’s relationship to its literary context, and the exegesis of the individual verses reinforces this. The question of whether it is a literary unity hinges ultimately on how one understands v. 3. This verse describes Yhwh’s reaction to the events in vv. 1f., which breaks the conventional connection between the “bride selection” (vv. 1–2) and the “birth of the offspring” (v. 4).¹⁷ However, v. 4 does not connect seamlessly to v. 2: Firstly, the nominal clause at the beginning of the verse, “The giants were on the earth in those days,” does not continue the preceding action. Secondly, although a connection to יְבֹאֵי “they [the Sons of the Gods] went into them [the Daughters of Man]” (i.e., they begat offspring) from v. 4

¹³ von Rad, 115; Westermann, 368. Oeming, 1993. According to Levin, 1993, 103–117, vv. 1f. originated from the Yahwist as an introduction to the Flood narrative, while he identifies four different additions in v. 3f.

¹⁴ See Gese, 1973, 85.

¹⁵ Each with a different overall view of the formation of Gen 1–11: Scharbert, 32, 78–81; Witte, 1998, 65–74, 293–297; Schüle, 2006, 219–246; Bosshard-Nepustil, 2005, 208–210; Arnoeth, 2007, 210f.; Bühner, 2011.

¹⁶ Noth, 1972, 29 fn. 83.

¹⁷ See, rather than many others, Westermann, 365f.

has been repeatedly suggested, this is also impossible since the imperfect form cannot function syntactically as an introductory clause or as a continuation of v. 2. Rather, it is dependent upon the conjunction *אֲשֶׁר*, which refers past the gloss *וְגַם אַחֲרֵי־כֵן* (“and also later”) to the temporal clause “in those days.” The aforementioned problems with trying to connect v. 4 (or parts thereof) to vv. 1–2 significantly qualify the argument of an original connection between vv. 1f. and v. 4 having been interrupted.

Moreover, Rüdiger Bartelmus has cited as “probably the most important argument” for an editorial origin of v. 3 the fact that the verse is missing in the reception of Gen 6:1–4 in the book of Jubilees (cf. Jub. 5:1, 8), while the shared verses were taken up almost verbatim.¹⁸ However, the LXX notwithstanding, the situation is more complex than he describes. Although Gen 6:1–4 is cited in 1 En. 6–11 with v. 3 being omitted (cf. 1 En. 6:1–2a; 7:1a, 2), there are allusions to v. 3 in 1 En. 10:9–10; 13:6; 14:4–7; 15:3–6.¹⁹ This discrepancy resulted from how the texts use the narrative in different ways. Genesis 6:1–4 is about the delimitation of the lifetime of “demigods” (cf. Scholarly Exposition II on v. 3), while 1 En. 6f. describes the culpability of the “angels” in the corruption of the world and, therefore, also in the Great Flood. The latter is also true of Jubilees, which is why v. 3 is quoted only after the beginning of the Flood. Similarly, v. 3 is quoted in a different narrative context by a commentary on select passages in Gen 6–9 stemming from the second half of the first century BCE (4Q252 1.2 [DJD XXII, 185–207]).

Often, however, the complex structure of v. 4 as well as the ambiguous relationship between “giants” and “heroes” within it is seen as sufficient evidence for the editorial nature of v. 3. According to this view, the postulated addition of v. 3 had a massive impact on the original text of v. 4 or caused further problems indicated by the likewise-inserted v. 4.²⁰ The multiple editorial interventions were occasioned by the theological problems that the narrative fragment in v. 1f. caused the biblical authors: “The repeated attempts to explain the mythological torso of Gen 6:1f. as Israelite and to make it acceptable ended in the syntactic chaos of the final form of Gen 6:4... Biblical Israel had no term for the beings that emerged from the sexual union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man, which is why it needed so many words – the later it became, the more words were needed.”²¹ In light of this, the question arises as to why this supposed “narrative fragment” of Gen 6:1f. or Gen 6:1–2, 4* was even included in the biblical Primeval History at all.²² What narrative interest is there in an inconsequential notice

¹⁸ Bartelmus, 1979, 28 [translation JWR].

¹⁹ See Kvanvig, 2005; idem, 2011, 291–294, there with the thesis, however, that Gen 6:3 is an insertion into Gen 6:1–4 dependent upon the aforementioned verse.

²⁰ Skinner, 146; Westermann, 377; Perlitt, 1994, 241–243.

²¹ Perlitt, *ibid.*, 243f. [translation JWR].

²² Gese 1973, 83.

about a sexual union between the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man (vv. 1–2) or in a fragmentary etiology of the giants and heroes of time immemorial, which play no role in the progression of the narrative? Why would the “Yahwist” or a later editor provoke such difficulties concerned only with the tempering of a “mythological torso” that he himself had taken up? In short: There is no likely interest to be found in the biblical Primeval History for the transmission of Gen 6:1–2(4*). The situation is different, however, when including v. 3. This verse occurs between the “bride selection” and the “birth of the offspring,” because it gives Yhwh’s reaction to the preceding event while at the same time showing the consequences of this reaction for the offspring. The “it is flesh” (הוּא בָּשָׂר) in v. 3 refers proleptically to the offspring of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man, who are mentioned in v. 4.²³ Their lifetime is delimited to 120 years, just like the lifetime of all (other) human beings. It seems that this statement provides the explanation for why the union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man was mentioned in the context of the antediluvian world in the first place. Verse 3 is therefore no addition to or tempering of a “mythological torso.” Rather, the narrative of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man was never part of the Primeval History without v. 3. The exceedingly concise narrative style is a clear indication that the author was not only alluding to mythological material but could assume the intended audience’s prior knowledge of the subject and might have even “quoted” it in vv. 1–2.

Tradition: Sexual unions between gods and humans are sporadically attested at Ugarit (the myth of the birth of the divine pair Šaḥar and Šalim through El and two mortal women) and Egypt (the pharaoh as son of the god Amun-Ra and the queen). Deserving of special attention is the figure of Gilgamesh, who was very popular across the ancient Near East even into the Hellenistic period – both the Priestly and non-Priestly passages of the biblical Primeval History repeatedly allude to the Epic of Gilgamesh. The tall and handsome Gilgamesh came from the union of a goddess (!) with a king (Gilgm 1.35f., cf. Maul, 2006, 47), making him two-thirds god and one-third human. Gilgamesh’s name also appears in Qumran fragments from the so-called “Book of the Giants,” which stands within the reception history of Gen 6:1–4. Here, Gilgamesh is the name of one of the giants who emerged from the union of the “angels” with the Daughters of Man (4Q530 Frgm. 2ii.2 [DJD XXXI, 28–38]; 4Q531 Frgm. 22.12 [DJD XXXI, 74–78]). However, by far the most numerous and best-known examples of this kind of divine/human connection come from Greek mythology. This is evidenced simply by the list of Zeus’s affairs and by those between goddesses and mortals in Hesiod’s *Theogony*

²³ Cassuto, 1:297; Gese, 1973, 85; Witte, 1998, 70; Bühner, 2011, 503.

(940ff., 965ff.) or in the “Catalogue of Women” that is attributed to Hesiod.²⁴ According to Hesiod’s *Works and Days*, the union of gods and mortals gave rise to a race of heroes/demigods whose demise is connected “historically” with the Trojan War, which itself, much like the Flood narrative, serves to mark the transition to modern humanity (Hesiod, *Op.* 106–201). The close proximity of Gen 6:1–4 to Greek mythology was noted already by Josephus (*A.J.* 1.73). More recently, it has been interpreted as a reception of the Greek concept of the “hero,” through which the biblical Primeval History was, against a Hellenistic background, integrated into the chronology of Greek mythology.²⁵ However, the points of reference for this are too vague and, similar to those about the figure of Gilgamesh, are better explained through Gen 6:1–4 standing in a stream of Mesopotamian, Greek, and autochthonous traditions.²⁶ In contrast, it is clearly safe to postulate literary references in the “Fall of the Angels” of 1 En. 6–11, since the correspondences between Gen 6:1–2, 4 and 1 En. 6:1f.; 7:1f. are sometimes verbatim (in addition, the events are referenced retrospectively in 1 En. 9:8f.; 10:9–15; 12:4). The version in 1 En. 6–11 is distinguished from its parallel in Gen 6:1–4 by its explication of the events. Thus, “Sons of the Gods” in 1 En. 6:2 become “angels/watchers, the sons of Heaven,” who not only “see” the “good Daughters of Man” but “see and desire the beautiful and good Daughters of Man.” This, alongside the further conceptual development of the episode in 1 En. 6–11, speaks for the priority of Gen 6:1–4.²⁷

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION II: EXEGESIS

6:1–2

- 1 *And it came to pass as humanity began to multiply upon the ground,
and daughters were born to them,*
- 2 *that the Sons of the Gods saw the Daughters of Man, that they were
good, and they took wives for themselves from all whom they chose.*

Verse 1 is a temporal clause linking the events that follow with the beginning of human multiplication (*חלל hi. “to begin,” also in the redactional

²⁴ See the genealogical overview in West, 1985, 173–182.

²⁵ Schüle, 2006, 228–232.

²⁶ So also Bühner, 2011, 512f.

²⁷ See Nickelsburg, 2001, 166–168; Dimant, 2002. Contra Milik, 1976, 30–32, who supports the hypothesis that Gen 6:1–4 is dependent upon the Aramaic version of the book of Enoch and cites from it verbatim. According to Witte, 1998, 293–297, Gen 6:1–4 and the corresponding passages in 1 En. 6–11 come from a common ancestor [*Vorlage*]. For a current overview of the debate, see Bachmann, 2009, 239f. and fn. 340.

texts of Gen 9:20; 10:8; 11:6; *חלל ho. in Gen 4:26). In its substance, this verse leads back to Gen 5:1–3 (P). Thus, the episode disrupts the narrative sequence: According to the Priestly chronology, these beginnings were already a few centuries back, and the Scholarly Narrator already presupposes the multiplication of humanity, as shown by the notice about city construction in Gen 4:17. It is especially noteworthy that Gen 6:1–4 seems to backtrack, while the two main voices of the biblical Primeval History strictly adhere to a chronological narrative sequence. In its final, redactional form, however, this is different: The Garden narrative becomes a flashback once again addressing the creation of humanity, while the addition of the Tower of Babel retrospectively explains the origins of the distributions of the peoples.

The statement about humanity's multiplication is formulated in a way that is reminiscent of the Priestly blessing in Gen 1:28 (which, however, uses the root *רבה instead of *רבב). At the same time, it echoes the notice about humanity's wickedness becoming vast (*רבב) on earth, with which the Scholarly Narrator begins the Flood narrative (Gen 6:5). Unlike there, however, v. 1 says "upon the ground" (על-פני האדמה) rather than "on the earth" (בארץ). Using this phrase, v. 1 takes up the motif of humanity (אדם) being created from the earth/soil (אדמה), which was developed throughout the Garden narrative, thus again returning to the earliest beginnings of humankind. In light of the להם "them" (v. 1b), the expression "humanity" האדם (v. 1a) refers not to an individual, like "Adam" in the Garden narrative and the beginning of the Register of the Generations of Adam, but to a collective, like in the Priestly Creation account.

As the main clause with an imperf. cons., v. 2 follows seamlessly from v. 1. The actual action is introduced with the appearance of the Sons of the Gods (בני-האלהים), who are not mentioned anywhere else in the Pentateuch. The formulation בני-האלהים is grammatically ambiguous. For a possible translation as "Sons of God" (cf. LXX: οἱ υἱοὶ τοῦ θεοῦ²⁸), it can be argued that אלהים is used throughout the Primeval History as a *pluralis excellentiae*.²⁹ However, it is more likely that it is a formulation analogous to the "Daughters of Man" (בנות האדם). In this case, האלהים is used like האדם as a collective generic term with בן "son" signifying the male members of this class.³⁰ Accordingly, בני-האלהים are "divine beings" (see Job 1:6; 2:1; 38:7, as well as בני אלים "Sons of the Gods" in Ps 29:1; 89:7; בני עֲלִיִּין "Sons of the

²⁸ For the LXX's translation and variants (ἄγγελοι τοῦ θεοῦ), see Rösel, 1994, 145–158: The singular translation in the LXX can be explained by the fact that it did not see any independent deities in the בני-האלהים but, quite appropriately, the heavenly court in the vicinity of God. The obvious translation as ἄγγελοι τοῦ θεοῦ was, unlike in Job 1:6; 2:1; 38:7, probably avoided because of the positive connotations of the expression.

²⁹ Day, 2013, 77–80.

³⁰ Gunkel, 56.

Highest” in Ps 82:6). Standing in the background is the conception of Yhwh’s heavenly court. Echoes of it can be found at several places in the Primeval History (e.g., Gen 1:26 [P], as well as the redactional instances in Gen 2:1*; 3:22; 11:7), even without the threat of transgressing the framework of the Primeval History’s “monotheistic” depiction of God. In particular, the two instances in the Priestly Creation account in Gen 1:1–2:3 clearly show that the conception of a heavenly court and the monotheistic conception of a universal and sovereign Creator God were not mutually exclusive to the biblical authors. Thus, according to Gen 6:1–4, there is at least a qualitative difference between Yhwh and the “divine beings” designated as בְּנֵי־הָאֱלֹהִים: It is decidedly *not* stated that they are offspring of Yhwh, and, likewise, Yhwh is without a shadow of a doubt not one of the heavenly beings who had relations with the “Daughters of Man.” His role is that of the “sovereign observer who intervenes at a decisive point in the events but without being affected by them himself in any way.”³¹

Nevertheless, the ideas of multiple divine beings being indicated with בְּנֵי־הָאֱלֹהִים and especially their sexual union with the “Daughters of Man” resulted in certain confusions from an early stage. This explains why interpretations of the passage throughout history have repeatedly understood the בְּנֵי־הָאֱלֹהִים, despite the unambiguous wording, as angels or a special group of humans.³² The “angel” interpretation was very common in Hellenistic Jewish and early Christian exegesis and can first be seen in the reception of Gen 6:2 in the book of Enoch: “The angels (Eth.; Gk.)/watchers³³ (Aram.), the sons of heaven, saw them and desired them” (1 En. 6:2; cf. Philo, *Gig.* 6; Josephus, *A.J.* 1.73). This not only tempers the seemingly problematic mention of בְּנֵי־הָאֱלֹהִים; it also establishes a causal relationship with the Flood narrative, insofar as the “fall of the angels/watchers” provides an etiology for the sin that leads to the Flood (1 En. 6–11). The angels/watchers conspire among themselves and unite themselves with the human women. The giants that emerge from this relationship lay waste to the earth and cause such a bloodbath in their search for sustenance that it provokes divine intervention. Or, at a more recent literary level,³⁴ it is the fatal influence of the angels/watchers upon the human race that leads to the moral degeneration of the world and ultimately to divine judgment (cf. also Jub. 5:1–8). Later, the story was able to be interpreted in such a way that the angels were seduced by the “Daughters of Cain” (PRE 22). However, whether there is already an elaborate “angel doctrine” standing behind Gen 6:1–4 is questionable,

³¹ See Schüle, 237 [translation JWR].

³² For overviews, see Deixinger, 1992; Witte, 1998, 72f.; Schüle, 2006, 222–225.

³³ The text is not preserved in the Aram. fragments of Enoch from Qumran and was reconstructed by the editor using the parallel phrases and older translations. The Greek tradition also has ἐγρήγοροι “watcher” at parts. See Milik, 1976, 165; Nickelsburg, 2001, 174. Originally, the members of the heavenly court may have been labeled as “the watchers, the holy ones” (see Dan 4:10). The Greek translation draws a distinction between them and in 1 En. 6–16 labels only the rebellious heavenly beings as ἐγρήγοροι “watchers” and calls the others ἄγγελοι “angels.” See *ibid.*, 140f.

³⁴ Newsom 1980; Nickelsburg, 2001, 165–173.

and thus a less-specific translation as “Sons of the Gods” or “divine beings” is preferable. Should it mean “angels” in the sense of the divine messengers in the Hebrew Bible, one would expect *מַלְאָכֵי אֱלֹהִים* (cf. Gen 28:12). It was only in the second century CE that the interpretation as a specific group of people emerged, as understandings as “angels” were increasingly seen as problematic. Christian exegesis primarily focused on the Sethites, who would have become involved with the female descendants of Cain (so already PRE 22 within the context of the “angel” interpretation). This would have transferred the corruption from Cain’s fratricide to the morally upright descendants of Seth, thus provoking the Great Flood (or, the Cainites would have seduced the female descendants of Seth to the same result). In contrast, Jewish interpretation developed the understanding that *בְּנֵי-הָאֱלֹהִים* referred to particularly strong and powerful men. However, neither reading is adequate due to the literal sense of *בְּנֵי-הָאֱלֹהִים* as well as the emphasized juxtaposition to the “Daughters of Man.”³⁵

The Sons of the Gods notice the Daughters of Man and find them “good” (*טוב*). This formulation is reminiscent of the approval formula in the Priestly Creation account (Gen 1:4, 10, 12, 18, 21, 25, 31). Just as there, the adjective *טוב* designates people or things that are well-suited to a specific task or function. The Daughters of Man thus seem to be particularly well-suited as wives in the eyes of the Sons of the Gods, which is likely not limited to their physical appearance. The oft-chosen translation as “beautiful” (cf. *טוב* in Gen 26:7; 2 Sam 11:2, although there in connection with *מְרֹאֶה* “appearance”) rashly reduces the assessment by the Sons of the Gods to the sexual aspect and is presumably influenced by the reading of the episode as a “sin narrative.”³⁶ This applies all the more for the eisegetical claim that the Daughters of Man would have deliberately sought to attract the Sons of the Gods in order to provoke the action that is interpreted as sexual assault. The formulation “to take as a wife” (*לָקַח* [+ *ל* + pronominal suffix] + *אִשָּׁה*) is a conventional expression for a marriage ceremony (e.g., Gen 11:29; 24:4; 25:1; 26:34; Deut 21:11; 22:13; 24:1 and *passim*) and only in exceptional cases signifies an act of violence, where it is, however, also clearly marked as such (Gen 34:2; 2 Sam 11:4, 9).³⁷ Furthermore, the marriages are not indiscriminate and do not involve all of the Daughters of Man. The Sons of the Gods only take as wives the women whom they choose, thereby marking them out

³⁵ Cf. most recently Scharbert, 80f.

³⁶ So clearly in von Rad, 114, and, with special emphasis, Westermann, 366f. According to Westermann, standing behind Gen 6:1–2 is a “situation likely to cause strife” typical for the world of the Hebrew Bible, from the “perplexity arising from the beauty of a woman” for a powerful man, with the “Sons of the Gods” symbolizing a “class of beings utterly superior to humans” whose members can do as they please in a primordial situation without differentiations among humanity. As in the comparable narratives about the patriarchs being under threat of sexual assault by foreign rulers (Gen 12:10–20; 20:1–18; 26:1–11) and the story of David and Bathsheba (2 Sam 11f.), this all concerns the question, “What happens when an encounter with beauty goes beyond the bounds that ought not be overstepped?”

³⁷ Cf. Jacob, 172f.; Ruppert, 275. Schmidt, 1967, 245 speaks of “rape.”

from all of the others (*בהר). Thus, the union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man, and with it the transgression of the sexual boundary between the heavenly and mortal worlds, is at first glance reported in an astonishingly neutral and disinterested manner. The fact that the narrative nevertheless has a negative undertone is suggested only by the sequence of actions of “seeing,” “finding good,” and “taking” parallel to Gen 3:6 (the only other passage in the Hebrew Bible in which this formulation is found): Eve “sees” that the tree is “good” because it allows for the attainment of knowledge, and she “takes” from its fruit. She is correct in her judgment, even if the consequences of the “taking” are ambiguous. Notwithstanding the conventional language, the continuation of the episode shows that the actions of the Sons of the Gods are problematic in the eyes of the author of Gen 6:1–4. The expected outcome, the birth of the offspring, is not reported immediately afterwards. What follows instead is an intervention by Yhwh, who reacts to the episode and limits its repercussions.

6:3

And Yhwh said, “My spirit shall not be active in humanity forever, for it too, it is flesh. Its lifetime shall be 120 years.”

Yhwh’s reaction interrupts the expected narrative sequence of “bride selection – birth of offspring” but syntactically is well integrated into the sentence through the imperf. cons. “And Yhwh said.” Because of the relationship described in v. 1f., Yhwh’s spirit (רוח) is not supposed to be active in humanity indefinitely. This is explained through the fact that humanity is also flesh (בשר) as well as the resultant limitation of the human lifespan to 120 years. The “Spirit of God” is the lifegiving power that humanity receives from God at its creation and that God is able to take it back from them so that they die.³⁸ The Spirit of God is only explicitly mentioned in the Priestly part of the Primeval History (Gen 1:2). Further attestations come from the larger sphere of Priestly literature as well as more recent prophetic and wisdom texts (Ezek 37:8, 10; Job 12:10; 27:3; 33:4; 34:14f.; Ps 104:29f.; cf. Num 16:22; 27:16). The idea itself is prefigured in the Garden narrative by the Scholarly Narrator: Yhwh-God breathes the breath of life into the human being that he has formed, thus bringing him to life (נשמת חיים; Gen 2:7). There, however, it does not yet explicitly mention Yhwh’s breath of life. The expression בשר “flesh” designates humanity’s perishable physical existence. It lacks this meaning in the Garden narrative, but it can be found with the inclusion of

³⁸ Cf. Seebaß, 193, who conceives of a charismatic spiritual gift. In this case, however, one would expect a construction with נִפְל instead of בָּ (see, e.g., Judg 11:29).

the animals in the Priestly Flood narrative (Gen 6:12, 13, 19; 7:16, 21; 8:17; 9:4, 11, 15, 16, 17), where there is also the clear distinction between רִיחַ “spirit” and בָּשָׂר “flesh” (Gen 6:17; 7:15). However, as in the Garden narrative, it is not explicitly stated that it is the Spirit of God that gives life to the humans and animals. As a basic anthropological pattern, the animation of perishable flesh through the Spirit of God is only attested in very late texts (Job 12:10; 34:14f.; Ezek 37:5ff.). Finally, the statement that humanity is denied eternal (לְעֹלָם) life coincides with the late addendum to the Garden narrative in Gen 3:22. Thus, Yhwh’s reaction in Gen 6:3 draws on the two main voices in the Primeval History equally, elaborating their claims in the spirit of more recent texts. Further indications of a correspondingly recent origin include the expression בְּשָׁנָם “for it too” (see also the Text-critical and Philological Note on v. 3 above) and the word order of הוּא בָּשָׂר “it is flesh” instead of the classic הוּא בָּשָׂר.³⁹

Yet, considering that neither of the main voices in the Primeval History know any eternal human life before the divine intervention, and that the perishability of flesh is quite banal (Isa 40:6f.; Ps 78:39), how should Yhwh’s reaction and the delimitation of the human lifespan be evaluated? The answer lies in the noteworthy formulation הוּא בָּשָׂר “it is flesh” in connection with the no less noteworthy בְּשָׁנָם “for it too.” Yhwh’s reaction both looks back at the aforementioned union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man and looks ahead to its offspring. The “it is flesh” must therefore be understood in such a way that the life resulting from this union is also transient, human life.⁴⁰ The offspring of the divine beings and human women must belong to the divine sphere, as would be suggested by a distanced and somewhat indiscriminate view from especially Greek mythology, and possibly even be immortal (generally speaking, the Greek heroes belong to the mortal side but could in certain cases attain immortality during their lives or after their deaths). However, through Yhwh’s intervention, they are (perishable) flesh from the beginning, regardless of their semi-divine origins. Even before mentioning the offspring themselves, it says that the sentencing to a perishable human life, so emphasized in the final form of the Garden narrative, also applies to them. According to Gen 3:22, 24, humanity has become “like one of us,” i.e., the divine beings. Therefore, should immortality be maintained as the boundary between the divine and human spheres, they should permanently be denied access to the Tree of Life. This situation is taken up by Gen 6:1–4 and the Tower of Babel narrative in Gen 11:1–9. The Tower of Babel narrative distinguishes between the possibilities of divine and human action, as played out, for example, in the maintenance of spatial delineation

³⁹ Oeming, 1993, 44.

⁴⁰ See von Rad, 114; Zimmerli, 266, and more recently esp. Witte, 1998, 68.

between the human and divine spheres. Genesis 6:1–4, on the other hand, takes up the theme of eternal life from Gen 3:22. There, humanity is deprived of the possibility of overcoming the mortal boundary of death by reaching for the Tree of Life. Genesis 6:3 further excludes a sexual union between divine and mortal beings as a second possibility for a blurring of the strict boundaries of mortality that would provide the human offspring with eternal life. This problem may have resulted from within the text, through the evocation of the heavenly court in Gen 3:22 (as well as Gen 1:26; 2:1*).⁴¹ Especially when reread against the background of Greek mythology and its heroic demigods such as Heracles, they could have prompted reflections on the relationship between humanity and the divine beings (associated with Yhwh) and the possible repercussions of a sexual union between them. It is striking that the transgression of the sexual boundary between the divine and human spheres is narrated comparatively neutrally. A distancing from the process is only insinuated in v. 3, on the one hand paralleling the woman taking of the forbidden fruit, on the other hand in how Yhwh, unlike Zeus, the father of the Greek gods, is not directly involved. It therefore seems as if mythological events like those described in Gen 6:1–2 would have been expected by those familiar with mythological material from their own or other cultures and would have needed to be included in an account of the antediluvian days of yore. In this respect, Gen 6:1–4 accounts for the expectations of its intended audience, who know of Sons of the Gods, giants, and heroes of old, and would have demanded mention of them in any primeval history.⁴² The possible consequences of this boundary transgression for the limitations of human life are, however, averted from the outset – just like the cherubim guarding the entrance to the Tree of Life and in contradiction to the existence of immortal demigods in other cultures.

The statement about the limitation of human life to 120 years therefore applies primarily to the offspring of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man, since they are humans rather than divine beings. Working backwards, it then also applies to all other humans.⁴³ For this reason, the 120 years also cannot be understood as a period of repentance before the coming of the Great Flood, as was commonly suggested in early interpretations of the passage (e.g., 4Q252 1.1, 2–3 [DJD XXII, 185–207]; Tg. Onq.; Tg. Neof.; Tg. Ps.-J.; Ephrem the Syrian; Jerome; Rashi; Luther). Rather, the fixing of human lifetime at 120 years clarifies the statement in Gen 3:22: How long should humanity live if denied eternal life?⁴⁴ Even still, the maximum lifespan of

⁴¹ Seebaß, 130f.; Witte, 1998, 291ff.; Bühner, 2011, 513f.

⁴² Cassuto, 1:300.

⁴³ Gese, 1973, 85; Witte, 1998, 68.

⁴⁴ Bühner, 2011, 509.

120 years raises questions in two regards: 1) It does not accord with the ages given in the Priestly genealogy. The ages of the patriarchs across the Primeval History decreases considerably after the Flood but still far exceed 120 years. 2) The “120 years” corresponds neither to the practical life experience of antiquity nor to that of today. One possible explanation is that, according to the author of Gen 6:1–4, the postdiluvian patriarchs from the line of Shem to Israel – Abraham (175 years old; Gen 25:7f.), Sarah (127 years old; Gen 23:1), Isaac (180 years old; Gen 35:28), and Jacob (147 years old; Gen 47:28) – are specifically chosen to be the ancestors of Israel and are granted a particularly long life. Above all, however, the death of Moses at 120 years old (Deut 34:7; also Deut 31:2) seems to have been the point of departure for the establishment in Gen 6:3 (see already Josephus, *A.J.* 4.177), with the 120 years having their origins in the Moses tradition⁴⁵ and being taken up from there for setting the ideal upper limit for human life.⁴⁶ The arc created from the beginnings of human history in the first book of the Torah to the death of Moses and the closing of the Torah would have been a greater concern for the author of Gen 6:1–4 than chronological coherence to the Priestly genealogies. The latter can also be understood harmonizingly, as described above, as exceptions whose exceptionality fade over time.

6:4

The giants were on the earth in those days (and also later), when the Sons of the Gods went into the Daughters of Man and they gave birth [to children] for them; these are the heroes of old, men of renown.

Verse 4 restarts the narration and locates the events in a time when the נִפְלִיִּם were on the earth. The etymology and meaning of the word נִפְלִיִּם, which is attested only here and in Num 13:33, is not entirely certain. A connection with the root נָפַל “to fall (dead)” and “to fall [in the sense of ‘to be born’]” (cf. Isa 26:18) and, thus, נִפְּלָה “miscarriage” (Eccl 6:3; Job 3:16; Ps 58:9) is possible but not particularly helpful. According to Num 13:32f., the Israelite scouts spread word of the inhabitants of the land being frighteningly large men, which is explained in a postscript that they were נִפְלִיִּם before

⁴⁵ Presumably, the authors of Deut 31:2; 34:7 could have combined the 120 years with the age of 80 years at the call (Exod 7:7 [PJ]) and the idea of a forty-year wandering in the wilderness from the Dtr tradition (e.g., Deut 2:7; 8:2, 4). Similar math led to Aaron dying at age 123 according to a later addition in Num 33:38f. It is less likely that Moses being 120 years old was formulated without knowledge of Exod 7:7 and instead was constructed from the “holy” forty years of wandering.

⁴⁶ See Witte, 1998, 247; Bühner, 2011, 511.

whom the Israelites felt as small as locusts. This suggests a translation of נָפְלִים as “giants,” in connection with the Mishnaic Hebrew נָפִיל “giant.”⁴⁷ It then notes the expected consequences of the union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man. The verb בָּוֵא “to enter” can also denote sexual intercourse (Gen 16:2, 4; Deut 22:13, *passim*), with the imperfect describing an action occurring repeatedly over a certain period of time in the past (GKC §107e; for continuation with the perf. cons. “and they gave birth to” see GKC § 112e). This fits well with the view that the Sons of the Gods chose Daughters of Man to take as wives in a way that was not a one-time (violent) act. Following this is the birth of the offspring. The concluding object clause tells who these offspring are, namely the exalted heroes of yore. In the Hebrew Bible, the גִּבּוֹרִים “heroes” are simply strong (*גִּבּוֹרִי) men who become such through heroic deeds (so also the “heroes of David” according to 2 Sam 23:8–39). In complete accordance with v. 3, the marriages between the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man result not in demigods but in extraordinary men who are, like all others (their fame notwithstanding), mortal. Given the opening to the episode in v. 1, the birth of offspring would be expected to happen. Nevertheless, v. 4 is striking in several respects: It begins rather abruptly with a nominal clause and without simply continuing the action from vv. 1f. Additionally, the relationship of the previously unmentioned נָפְלִים “giants” to the likewise previously unmentioned גִּבּוֹרִים “heroes” cannot be determined with confidence. Finally, the note וְגַם אַחֲרֵי־כֵן “and also later” does not properly fit the syntax of the sentence.

The fact that v. 4 does not immediately continue the action of vv. 1f. can be explained by the intervention of Yhwh in v. 3. This interrupts the narrative sequence at its most decisive point, between the “marriage” of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man and the expected begetting of offspring. In this way, as already discussed, it establishes a stipulation formulated specifically for these descendants but further applying to all people. As a result, the account must reset itself with a temporal clause, with the “in those days” pointing back to the events of vv. 1f. The following verbal clause also takes up vv. 1f. by mentioning the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man.

There is no agreement as to whether נָפְלִים “giants” and גִּבּוֹרִים “heroes” signify beings of different origins or refer to one and the same group of people. Yet, while there are powerful giants and tall heroes, the two terms must fundamentally be understood separately. Even still, not even the ancient translations were consistent with this. The LXX uses γίγαντες “giants/Gigantes” to translate both cases, despite otherwise trying to render different

⁴⁷ See Perlitt, 1994, 236–238.

Hebrew words with different corresponding Greek expressions. In the background of this translation is the myth of the Gigantomachy, the “Battle of the Giants,” which became popular with the spread of Hellenism. This may indicate that, despite translating them with the same word, the LXX differentiated between two groups of “giants.”⁴⁸ More recent interpretations have invoked the personal pronoun הֵמָּה “they” in v. 4b for equating the נָפְלִים “giants” with the גִּבּוֹרִים “heroes,” but this pronoun seems to refer to the aforementioned offspring: “They gave birth [to children] for them: *These* are the heroes of old.” As a result, the giants and heroes should probably be distinguished from one another. However, it is also possible that the הֵמָּה refers to the נָפְלִים “giants” in the sense of equating them with the גִּבּוֹרִים “heroes.”⁴⁹ In this case, the נָפְלִים “giants” are typically understood as the offspring from the union of the Sons of the Gods with the Daughters of Man, while the mention of the “heroes” is understood as an explanatory illustration of the נָפְלִים “giants.” This interpretation still leaves completely unclear why the text does not explicitly state that the נָפְלִים “giants” are the same offspring (cf. in contrast 1 En. 7:2; Jub. 5:1) and why they are instead introduced within the temporal background information about their own conception and birth.⁵⁰ If, however, one sees the נָפְלִים “giants” as separate beings from the גִּבּוֹרִים “heroes” stemming from the union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man, and with the latter not being the referent of the הֵמָּה “these” in v. 4b, then the mention of the giants simply provides illustration to the temporal background of the events that follow.⁵¹ Thus, the recontinuation of the narrative after Yhwh’s intervention provided the author of Gen 6:1–4 with the opportunity to relate other curiosities from the days of yore. He took advantage of this opportunity and, by mentioning the giants, added further traditions to the inventory of the Primeval History, traces of which are also found elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible.⁵² It is already clear from the use of the definite article that the giants were known entities, and another indication of this can be found with וְגַם אַחֲרֵי־כֵן “and also later.” It is very likely that this is a gloss referring to the

⁴⁸ See Rösel, 1994, 150–158. Tg. Onq. und Tg. Neof. each translate it as גִּבּוֹרִין (Heb. גִּבּוֹרִים), which is also the translation for נָפְלִים in Num 13:33. The retelling of v. 4 in 1 En. 7:2 knows of only one group, named as Gk. γίγαντες and Aram. גִּיבּוֹרִין. They are descended from the marriages of the Sons of the Gods with the Daughters of Man and then, according to one part of the tradition, in turn beget the ναφελίμ (a transliteration of the Heb. נָפְלִים). See Nickelsburg 2001, 182f. Jub. 5:1 only mentions the נָפְלִים begotten by the Sons of the Gods.

⁴⁹ Gunkel, 59; Skinner, 147; von Rad, 115; Vervenne 1995^a, 34f.; Bühner, 2011, 505.

⁵⁰ Day, 2013, 82.

⁵¹ Following Bartelmus, 1979, 20f.

⁵² Allusions to the former “gigantic” inhabitants of the land can be found in Deut 2:10, 20f.; 3:11; Amos 2:9. See further Perlitt, 1994.

mention of “giants” in “Mosaic times” (Num 13:33).⁵³ It is along these lines that later tradition knew to report of Noah allowing the giant Og (cf. Deut 3:11) to ride on one of the Ark’s ladders and feeding him through a hole in the wall (PRE 23).

⁵³ Following Skinner, 147 (“though even then the phrasing is odd”); Gese, 1973, 85 fn. 52. Cf. Bühner 2011, 500 and fn. 34; Witte, 1998, 69–71, relating אֲנָשִׁים אֲחֵרִים to v. 3: Even after Yhwh’s intervention, the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man intermingled and bore heroes.

THE FLOOD NARRATIVE

- 6:5** *And Yhwh saw that the wickedness of humanity was vast upon the earth, and every formation of the thoughts of its heart was only evil, all the days.*
- 6** *Thus, Yhwh regretted that he had made humanity upon the earth, and it hurt him to his very heart.*
- 7** *And Yhwh said, “I shall destroy humanity, whom I have created, from the surface of the ground, from humanity to livestock, to the crawling animal and the flying animals of the heavens, for I regret that I made them [it].”*
- 8** *Noah, however, found favor in the eyes of Yhwh.*
- 9** **These are the generations of Noah. Noah was a righteous man; he was blameless in his generations. Noah walked with God.**
- 10** **And Noah fathered three sons: Shem, Ham, and Japheth.**
- 11** **And the earth was corrupted before God, and the earth was filled with violence.**
- 12** **And God saw the earth, and behold, it was corrupt, for all flesh had corrupted its way upon the earth.**
- 13** **Then God said to Noah, “The end of all flesh has come before me, for the earth is full of violence because of them. And behold, I will corrupt them with the earth.**
- 14** **Make for yourself an ark out of gofer wood. You shall make the ark out of reed [?] and you shall coat it inside and out with pitch.**
- 15** **And thus shall you make it: 300 cubits is the length of the ark, 50 cubits its width and 30 cubits its height.**
- 16** **You shall make a roof [?] for the ark and after a cubit, you shall stop it upwards [?], and you shall install an opening of the ark on its side; you shall make a lower, a second, and a third [story].**
- 17** **And I, behold, I am about to let the Great Flood, that is, water, come over the earth in order to corrupt all flesh under the heavens that has the breath of life in it; all that is upon the earth will perish.**
- 18** **With you, however, I shall establish my covenant, and you shall go into the ark, you and your sons and your wife and the wives of your sons with you.**
- 19** **From all living beings, from all flesh, you shall bring two of each into the ark to survive with you; they shall be male and female.**

- 20 **From the flying animals according to their kind, from the livestock according to their kind, from all crawling animals of the ground according to their kind. Two of each shall come to you to survive.**
- 21 **You, however: Take from all that can be eaten and collect it with you, so that it can serve as food for you and for them.”**
- 22 **And Noah did according to all that God had commanded him; he did thusly.**
- 7:1 *And Yhwh said to Noah, “Go, you and your whole house into the ark, for I have seen you as righteous before me in this generation.*
- 2 *From all clean livestock, take with you seven of each, a male and its mate, and from the livestock that is not clean, two, a male and its mate,*
- 3 *[also from the flying animals of the heavens, seven of each, male and female,] in order to secure offspring on the entire earth.*
- 4 *For after seven days, I shall bring rain upon the earth forty days and forty nights, and I shall wipe away all that exists, which I have made, from the surface of the ground.”*
- 5 *Then Noah did according to all that Yhwh had commanded him.*
- 6 **Noah was 600 years old when the Great Flood came – waters upon the earth.**
- 7 **And Noah went, and his sons and his wife and the wives of his sons with him, into the ark, from before the waters of the Great Flood.**
- 8 *From the clean livestock and from the livestock that was not clean, and from the flying animals, and from all that crawls upon the ground,*
- 9 *two of each went into the ark to Noah, male and female, as God had commanded Noah.*
- 10 *When the seven days were over, then the waters of the Great Flood were upon the earth.*
- 11 **In the year in which Noah’s lifetime numbered 600 years, in the second month, on the seventeenth day of the month, on this day, all the springs of the great primordial flood burst forth and the hatches of the heavens opened up.**
- 12 *Then came rain upon the earth, forty days and forty nights.*
- 13 **On this very day, Noah went into the ark, as did Shem and Ham and Japheth, the sons of Noah, and Noah’s wife and the three wives of his sons with them,**
- 14 **they and all wild animals according to their kind and all livestock according to their kind and all crawling animals that crawl upon the earth according to their kind, and all flying animals according to their kind [every bird, everything with wings].**
- 15 **And they went into the ark to Noah, two of each from all flesh that has the breath of life in it.**

- 16a** And those that went in: A male and a female from all flesh, they went in, as God had commanded him.
- 16b** *And Yhwh shut [it] behind him.*
- 17** And the Great Flood was upon the earth for forty days, *and the waters became strong and lifted up the ark, and it was high above the earth.*
- 18** And the waters became mighty and very vast upon the earth, and the ark went upon the waters.
- 19** And the waters were exceedingly mighty upon the earth. And all high mountains that are under the heavens were covered.
- 20** The waters were mighty fifteen more cubits upwards, so that the mountains were covered.
- 21** Then all flesh died that crawls upon the earth, of flying animals, of livestock, of wild animals, and of all teeming creatures that teem upon the earth, and also all human beings.
- 22** *Everything that had the breath of the spirit of life in its nose died – everything that lived on dry land.*
- 23** *Thus, he wiped away all that existed that was on the surface of the ground, from human beings to livestock to crawling animals to the flying animals of the heavens, and they were wiped away from the earth. Noah alone remained, and those who were with him in the ark.*
- [24** And the waters became mighty upon the earth, 150 days.]
- 8:1** Then God thought about Noah and all the wild animals and all the livestock that were with him in the ark, and God let a wind blow over the earth, and the waters sank down.
- 2** Then the springs of the primordial flood and the windows of the heavens were closed. *And the rains from the heavens ceased.*
- 3** Then the waters receded from the earth, gradually but steadily. [After the 150 days had passed, the waters decreased.]
- 4** And the ark came on the seventeenth day of the seventh month to rest upon the mountains of Ararat.
- 5** And the waters steadily decreased until the tenth month. In the tenth month, on the first of the month, the peaks of the mountains became visible.
- 6** *And after forty days had passed, Noah opened the window of the ark that he had made.*
- 7** *And he let out the raven, and it flew out, flying to and fro until the waters had dried away from the earth.*
- 8** *And he sent the dove away from him in order to see if the waters had gone back from the surface of the ground.*
- 9** *But the dove did not find a resting place for the sole of its feet, so it returned into the ark to him, because there was still water upon the*

- whole earth. Then he stretched out his hand and took it and brought it back with him into the ark.*
- 10** *Then he waited another seven days, then he sent the dove out from the ark again.*
- 11** *And the dove came back to him at evening time, and behold, a fresh leaf from an olive tree was in his beak. Then Noah knew that the waters had lessened upon the earth.*
- 12** *Then he waited another seven days, then he sent the dove out, and it did not return to him again.*
- 13a** **And it came to pass in the 601st year, in the first month, on the first of the month, that the waters had dried away from the earth.**
- 13b** *And Noah removed the cover of the ark and he looked, and behold, the surface of the ground was dry.*
- 14** **And in the second month, on the twenty-seventh day of the month, the earth was dry.**
- 15** **Then God said to Noah,**
- 16** **“Go out of the ark, you and your wife and your sons and the wives of your sons with you.**
- 17** **All the animals that are with you, all flesh, of flying animals and of livestock and of all crawling animals that crawl upon the earth, lead them out with you; they shall teem upon the earth and be fruitful and become vast upon the earth.”**
- 18** **Then Noah went out, and his sons and his wife and the wives of his sons with him.**
- 19** **All living beings, all crawling animals and all flying animals, all that crawls upon the earth, they went out of the ark according to their species.**
- 20** *And Noah built an altar for Yhwh and he took from all the clean livestock and from all the clean birds and he let a burnt offering go up from the altar.*
- 21** *Then Yhwh smelled the appeasing scent and Yhwh said to his heart, “Henceforth, I shall never again curse the soil on account of humanity, even though the formations of the human heart are evil from its youth onward, and henceforth, I shall never again strike at all living things, as I have done.*
- 22** *Still all the days of the earth, sowing and reaping, frost and heat, summer and winter, day and night shall not cease.”*
- 9:1** **Then God blessed Noah and his sons and said to them, “Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth.**
- 2** **And the fear and dread of you will be over all the animals of the earth and over all the flying animals of the heavens; with all that**

- crawls upon the ground and with all the fish of the sea, they are given into your hand.
- 3 Everything that stirs, that is living, shall serve you as nourishment. I give to you everything like the green of the herb.
- 4 Only flesh with its life, its blood, shall you not eat.
- 5 And only your blood, your own shall I claim, from every animal shall I claim it and from the person, from each, their brother, shall I claim the person's life:
- 6 Whoever sheds human blood, their blood will be shed for humanity's sake, for as the image of God did he make humanity.
- 7 You, however, be fruitful and multiply, teem upon the earth and become vast upon it."
- 8 And God said to Noah and to his sons who were with him,
- 9 "But I, behold, I establish now my covenant with you and with your descendants after you
- 10 and with all living beings that are with you, of flying animals, of livestock, and of all the animals of the earth with you, from all that come out of the ark, for all animals of the earth.
- 11 I will thus establish my covenant with you, so that all flesh shall never again be cut off by the waters of the Great Flood, and there shall never again be a Great Flood to destroy the earth."
- 12 And God said, "This is the sign of the covenant that I now make between me and you and all living beings who are with you, for everlasting generations.
- 13 I hereby give my bow into the clouds, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth.
- 14 When I pile clouds up over the earth and the bow appears in the clouds,
- 15 then I shall remember my covenant between me and you and all living beings, with all flesh. And the waters shall never again become a Great Flood to destroy all flesh.
- 16 When the bow is in the clouds, then I shall look upon it and remember an eternal covenant between God and all living beings with all flesh that is upon the earth."
- 17 And God said to Noah, "This is the sign of the covenant that I have established between me and all flesh that is upon the earth."

Analysis: Scholarly Narrator, including later adjustments: Gen 6:5–7a*, 8; 7:1a, 2, 3b–5, 16b, 10a, 12, 17b, 22*, 23*; 8:2b, 6–12, 13b, 20–22; Priestly Writing, including later adjustments: Gen 6:9–22; 7:6–7, 11, 13–16a, 17a*, 18–21, 24; 8:1–2a, 3–5, 13a, 14–19; 9:1–17; Redaction and later adjustments: Gen 6:7aa*["whom I have made"]βγ; 7:1b, 3a, 8–9, 10b, 17a*["40 days"], 22*["breath"], 23a*[from "from human beings to livestock ..."].

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TEXT-CRITICAL AND PHILOLOGICAL NOTES

6:9 תָּמִים (*blameless*): In accordance with the Masoretic markings, תָּמִים opens a second nominal clause and is not an attribute of “man” or “righteous.”

6:13 וְהִנֵּנִי מְשַׁחֲתִים אֶת-הָאָרֶץ (*I will corrupt them with the earth*): The syntax of v. 13b is difficult but possible. The proposed translation understands the suffix of the participle as an accusative object and, with the MT (see Vulg; Pesh; Tg. Onq.; Tg. Ps.-J.), reads the preposition אֶת “with.” See esp. Dillmann, 139; Seebaß, 201, 204; Witte, 1998, 74f. and fn. 104. Also conceivable would be

taking the suffix of the participle as a dative object and reading the אֶת as the definite direct object marker (“And behold, I will corrupt the earth for them”); see Baumgart, 1999, 222, 260. The LXX circumvents the sentence’s difficult construction by reading a syndetically connected definite direct object marker וְאֶת (“I will corrupt them and the earth”). There are sometimes assumptions of haplography that conjecture a מֵאֶת (“I will corrupt them from the earth”); see Westermann, 417. These and other changes (e.g., Gunkel, 143: וְהֵנָּה מְשַׁחֲתִים אֶת־הָאָרֶץ “and they are about to corrupt the earth”) are unnecessary.

6:14 קָנִים (*out of reed* [?]): קָנִים “out of reed” (prefixed as an accusative of material; see Exod 25:29; 29:2 and GKC §117hh) rather than the MT קְנִים “nests.” See Scholarly Exposition II.

6:17 הַמַּבּוּל (*the Great Flood*): On the use of the article, see GKC §126r.

מַיִם (*that is, water*): The appositional מַיִם “water” (GKC §131k) may be an explanatory gloss. Cf. Gen 7:6; 9:11.

7:11 בַּשְּׁבַע־עָשָׂר יוֹם לַחֹדֶשׁ (*on the seventeenth day of the month*): According to the LXX, the Flood begins on the 27th day of the 2nd month and lasts exactly one calendar year. See Scholarly Exposition II.

7:14 כָּל־צִפּוֹר כָּל־כְּנָף (*every bird, everything with wings*): This specification, which is unique within the Priestly Writing (see Ezek 17:23), is missing in the LXX and may be a later gloss. The gloss may be seeking to express that עוֹף indicates not only “flying animals/poultry” but also all kinds of flying animals, including insects (see Lev 11:20f., 23 [there with four legs]; Deut 14:19; Sir 11:3).

7:17 אַרְבָּעִים יוֹם (*forty days*): The LXX adds “and nights,” in accordance with Gen 7:4, 12.

7:22 מִכָּל (– *everything*): See GKC §119w.

7:23 וַיִּמַּח (*Thus, he wiped away*): The active verbal form is consistently confirmed via the ancient versions. The frequent change to a niphal (“and all was wiped away”) was triggered by the redactional connection of the two versions of the Flood narrative, since the reference to Yhwh in v. 16b is no longer clear because of the Priestly passages.

8:3 מִקְצֵה הַמַּשָּׁיִם וּמֵאֵת יוֹם (*After the 150 days had passed*): Since the 150 days are already mentioned in Gen 7:24, this should presumably be read as “at the end of the 150 days.” The reading of the MT, “and after 150 days,” resulted from an incorrect division of the words, מִקְצֵה הַמַּשָּׁיִם (MT) instead of מִקֵּץ הַחֲמִשִּׁים.

8:4 בַּשְּׁבַע־עָשָׂר יוֹם (*on the seventeenth day*): The LXX reads “on the twenty-seventh day,” in line with its harmonization of the chronology (see Scholarly Exposition II).

8:5 הַחֹדֶשׁ הָעֲשִׂירִי (*until the tenth month*): In v. 5, the LXX assumes a chronological sequence and reads “in the eleventh month.”

8:7 אֶת-הָעֹרֵב (*the raven*): On the use of the article here and with the dove in v. 8, see GKC §126r.

יָצֹא וָשׁוּב (*flying to and fro*): See GKC §113s.

8:13 בְּאַחַת וָשָׁשׁ-מֵאוֹת שָׁנָה (*in the 601st year*): The LXX reads “year of Noah’s life” and is aligned with the wording in Gen 7:11.

8:17 כָּל-הַחַיָּה (*All the animals*): The LXX, Pesh, and SP connect v. 17 via a copula. This change is unnecessary. Verse 17 (and v. 19) deliberately sets the animals apart from Noah and his family. The strict differentiation between human and animal resultant from the “reign of terror” casts its shadow here.

חַיָּה (*animals*): In the Priestly Writing, חַיָּה is typically used for “wild animals,” as opposed to בְּהֵמָה “livestock” (see Gen 1:24; 7:14; 8:1). Here, it is used for animals in general. In v. 19 in the present state of the text, the term seems to be limited to quadrupeds. However, it appears as though this verse’s word order has been mixed up, since it separates the crawling animals (רֶמֶשׂ) from their typical relative clause “that crawl” (רֹמֵשׁ). Compare in this regard v. 17, and further Gen 7:14 and the various readings in the ancient translations. It is also possible that, as the text was disturbed, the “livestock” was lost: “All wild animals, all livestock, and all birds and all crawling animals that crawl upon the earth...”

הוֹצֵא (*lead*): See GKC §69v.

8:21 כִּי (*even though*): The כִּי has a concessive meaning and refers back to the announcement that the earth will henceforth never be cursed again. See Baumgart, *Umkehr*, 161f. Cf., e.g., Holzinger, 82f., who understands the כִּי-clause as a later supplement (epexegesis) to “on account of humanity” and translates it as “for.”

9:2 חַיָּה (*animals*): חַיָּה actually refers to wild animals, as opposed to domesticated animals (בְּהֵמָה), but is used here as a collective term for all living animals on the earth, like in v. 5 and in Gen 1:28, 30.

9:5 לְנַפְשָׁתִיכֶם (*your own*): On this translation, see Jenni, 2000, 69.

מִיַּד אִישׁ אָחִיו (*from each, their brother*): The SP and Vulg link the difficult connection through a copula and read “each and their brother,” while the LXX leaves the suffix of אָח “brother” untranslated and simplifies the syntax. If the MT should be maintained as the *lectio difficilior*, then the מִיַּד אִישׁ “from each” stands in apposition to הָאָדָם “the person” and אָחִיו “their brother” stands in apposition to אִישׁ, whose suffix refers to the הָאָדָם. See Witte, 1998, 144.

9:7 וַיִּרְבוּ (*and become vast*): BHS and the text-critical commentary in BHQ take issue with the repetition of the וַיִּרְבוּ “become vast” and suggest, following

a few Greek minuscule manuscripts, a reading of וַיִּרְדּוּ “and rule,” in accordance with Gen 1:28. The reading of the MT is the best attested and most coherent and should be maintained. See Ruppert, 376f.; Seebaß, 204, 226; Witte, 1998, 143 fn. 91; Bosshard-Nepustil, 2005, 117 fn. 30.

9:10 לְכָל חַיַּית הָאָרֶץ (for all animals of the earth): “for all animals of the earth” is missing in the LXX and may be a later addition to the MT.

9:12 אֲשֶׁר (that): The relative clause is in reference to the בְּרִית “covenant.” See Groß, 1978, 106f. Cf. Seebaß, 204, 227.

ESSENTIALS AND PERSPECTIVES

The Flood narrative in Gen 6:5–9:17 marks both the nadir and the turning point of the biblical Primeval History: If, at the beginning, God had created a well-structured living space out of the chaos for a peaceful coexistence of human and animal (Gen 1:1–2:3), what follows now is the decision because of the wickedness and violence of human and animal to plunge the world into chaos and wipe out all life (Gen 6:7, 13). Yet, in the midst of the chaotic flood, Noah’s ark is a “Creation *en miniature*” that is delivered into the new beginning after the Flood. Characteristics of this new beginning are the promise of a permanent preservation of Creation (Gen 8:20–22; 9:8–17) and the modified reiteration of the blessing of multiplication, adapted to the realities of life in the postdiluvian world (Gen 9:1–7). As a countermyth to the Creation account, the Flood narrative displays the necessary consequences that result from the “corruption” of Creation. As the opening of the epoch that reaches into the time of its readers, it also stands for the ultimate overcoming of the Creator God’s fundamental questioning of Creation. In the Priestly Writing, which has also provided the structure to the Primeval History’s final form, the Flood narrative followed the conclusion of the Register of the Generations of Adam (Gen 5:32) as a narrative elaboration of the *toledot* of Noah (Gen 6:9; 9:28f.) The *toledot* of Noah were followed by those of his sons, who, like in the present text, ushered in the postdiluvian world of nations and whose naming at the beginning of the Flood narrative already points forward to a new chapter of human history. In the structure of the Scholarly Narrator’s Primeval History, the Flood narrative followed the Fratricide narrative and the genealogical notices about the descendants of Cain and Enoch (Gen 4), which included a notice of Noah’s birth (Gen 5:28–29*). Like in the Priestly Writing and in the present text, the Flood narrative marks the antithesis to the creation of the world. Yet, unlike these conceptions, the Scholarly Narrator’s Primeval History may have ended with Yhwh’s promise not to afflict the earth again, and especially not to curse it formally,

and to endure the wickedness of humanity and to preserve the blessings of the earth (see Scholarly Exposition II on Gen 8:21f.). This concentration on the themes of “Creation” and “Flood” is well attested for origin myths in the literature of the ancient Near East.¹

“Every science has its hobbies; mythology’s is playing with the myth of the Great Flood.”² The theme of “The Great Flood That Nearly Destroyed All Life” can accordingly be found in many cultures. For understanding the biblical texts, it is of particular interest to look towards Mesopotamia (see Scholarly Exposition II – Tradition below). It is here that the myth of the Great Flood appears for the first time, in the early second millennium BCE. There should be no fundamental doubts about the dependence of the biblical Flood narrative upon the Mesopotamian Flood myth, even probably also on the form of the Mesopotamian tradition that is available to us. Such material is quite alien to ancient Israel and the Hebrew Bible. Unlike in Mesopotamia, a flooding of the entire land is certainly not any sort of formative experience in mountainous Palestine for any tradition or myth. Furthermore, there have always been other aspects present in the southern Levant for addressing chaos’s threat to Creation. Yet, even when the same story is told twice, it is never told in the exact same way both times. The Mesopotamian myth of the Great Flood offers a finely balanced piece of theodicy under the conditions of polytheism; the human experience of contingency is related to the inherently contradictory volitions of the divine assembly. This occurs through the myth describing the progression from an unreal, mythical time to the present, which is characterized by impairments of existence. The biblical reception of the Mesopotamian material also describes the transformation of a “before” state into the present state. At this point, a distinction must be made between the version by the Scholarly Narrator and that of the Priestly Writing. The Scholarly Narrator transposes the contradictory images of the deities from its Mesopotamian predecessor into the one, tension-filled deity Yhwh and narrates the birth of the prophetic image of God through the myth of the God who is able to change himself (see Scholarly Exposition II on Gen 6:5–8 and 8:20–22). In contrast, the Priestly Writing emphasizes the elementary principles of coexistence within a Creation defined by the corruption of all flesh (Gen 9:4–6). At the same time, in the historical situation of theological and political exile and in recourse to the language of doom prophecy (see Scholarly Exposition II on Gen 6:11, 13), it sketches the image of the primeval catastrophe being overcome and emphasizes that the “eternal covenant” (Gen 9:16) made with Noah and his offspring guarantees the

¹ So in the Sumerian Flood Story (Introduction and Translation: “The Deluge,” trans. Samuel N. Kramer (*ANET*, 42–44)) and in the Old Babylonian Epic of Atrahasis.

² Frobenius, 1904, 275 [translation JWR].

continuance of the “very good” Creation (see Scholarly Exposition II on Gen 9:8–17 below).

Only a few texts in the Hebrew Bible, primarily of prophetic provenance, reference the Flood narrative (see Isa 24–27; 34:2–4; 54:9f.; Joel 4:13; Zeph 1:2f.). Particularly impressive is the depiction of the Last Judgment and the destruction of “Babylon” at the End of Days in the “Isaiah Apocalypse” (Isa 24–27), which repeatedly makes explicit references to the Flood narrative (so, e.g., Isa 24:5 with Gen 9:8–17; Isa 24:18 with Gen 7:11; Isa 26:20 with Gen 6:18; 7:1, 7, 13, 16). The coming judgment appears as a return of the Flood, now only instead of Noah and his sons, it is the people of God who are to be saved from God’s act of judgment. Additionally, Noah is seen as the exemplar of righteousness and piety (Ezek 14:14, 20; Sir 44:17f.; Wis 10:4; 2 Pet 2:5; Heb 11:7) who behaves justly in the face of the coming disaster (Matt 24:37–39; Luke 17:20–37). Broad reception of the Flood narrative, however, begins only with the Second Temple period and Hellenistic Judaism (see 1 En. 6–11; Jub 5–6; Genesis Apocryphon [1QapGen ar; 1Q20; DSS 8a]; 4Q252 [DJD XXII, 185–207]; 4Q370 [4QAdmonFlood; DJD XIX, 85–97]). The paraphrases of the biblical texts seek in part to harmonize contradictory statements such as those about chronology. Furthermore, they link the Flood narrative more closely with the traditions about the connection between the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man depicted in Gen 6:1–4. Finally, it is also noteworthy that the Judeo-Hellenistic philosopher Philo and his contemporary, the Judeo-Hellenistic historian Flavius Josephus, both discuss the references to other traditions about the Great Flood (Philo, *Praem.* 23; Josephus, *A.J.* 1.93). The powerful images of the Flood and the lone ark on the storm-tossed waves, like the question of human culpability, have subsequently been taken up widely in Judaism, Christianity, Islam, and thus also in secular culture.³ From the abundance of material, worth mentioning are at least the depiction of Noah and the ark in the Catacombs of Priscilla in Rome, Michelangelo’s fresco in the Sistine Chapel (1512–1515), the poem “Flutender” [“Flood-ender”] by Paul Celan (1967), and Darren Aronofsky’s “Noah” as the most recent film adaptation (2014).

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION I: INTRODUCTION TO EXEGESIS

Structure: Speaking in favor of the widely accepted (although not undisputed) delineation of the Flood narrative as Gen 6:5–9:17 is how Gen 6:1–4 is clearly demarcated from the Flood narrative by its etiological conclusion

³ Martinez 1998; B.B. Schmidt et al. 2014, 227–252.

in Gen 6:4b, and Gen 9:18–29 likewise by the exposition in Gen 9:18f.⁴ Corresponding to this is perhaps the most obvious structural characteristic of the present Flood narrative: its doubled framing via the bipartite prologue in Gen 6:5–8 and 6:9–22 and the likewise-bipartite epilogue in Gen 8:20–22 and 9:1–17, with the prologue describing God’s decision to annihilate humanity together with living nature and subdivided by the *toledot* formula in Gen 6:9. The two parts each contain a justification and an announcement of the annihilation: Gen 6:5–8 is directed inward, depicting Yhwh’s ruminations about the corruption of the earth, while Gen 6:9–22 amounts to an outward communication from God. Corresponding to the bifurcation of the prologue is that of the epilogue, with God’s promise to protect the earth from an event like the Flood thereafter. This promise is described in Gen 8:20–22 from Yhwh’s inside perspective and in Gen 9:1–17 as an outward communication. The first parts of the prologue and epilogue in Gen 6:5–8 and Gen 8:20–22 are respectively connected by the assessments of human nature, which correspond to each other almost verbatim (Gen 6:5–7 and 8:21). Conversely, the second part of the epilogue in Gen 9:1–17 takes up the wording of the announcement of a covenant (Heb. בְּרִית) in the second part of the prologue in Gen 6:9–22 (see 6:18 and 9:9, 11, 17). Additionally, the reformulation of the promise of multiplication found in Gen 9:1, 7 (see Gen 1:28) takes up the judgment of the rampant “life-threatening violence”⁵ on the earth from Gen 6:11, insofar as the commission for humanity to rule over the earth (*dominium terrae*) becomes the announcement of humanity’s reign of terror over its living environment (Gen 9:2).

In contrast, there are difficulties in defining any precise structure for the main part of the Flood narrative in Gen 7:1–8:19, which is enclosed by this twofold framing. There is no chiasmic or concentric structure to be shown,⁶ nor is it possible to transfer all of the structural features, such as the dates or the correspondences between commission and fulfillment, into a coherent structure within the present text. Thus, it will have to be enough that the main part of the Flood narrative is organized through the plot progression in addition to structural features that are each given a different weight.⁷

⁴ Also discussed have been a beginning with Gen 6:1 (Schmidt, 1967, 243 fn. 12; Ruppert, 293) or Gen 6:9 (see, e.g., Jacob, 183) and an end with Gen 8:22 (see, e.g., von Rad, 129–131; Westermann, 457f.) or Gen 9:29 (Jacob, 183).

⁵ Jeremias, 1990, 36 [translation JWR].

⁶ On the difficulties of such attempts, as have been undertaken especially by Cassutto, *Genesis*, 2:30–33; Wenham, 1972; Radday, 1981, and have been repeatedly cited for the literary unity of the Flood narrative, see Emerton, 1987; idem, 1988; Blum, 1990, 283 fn. 208. On the reconstruction of a ring-like structure in Seebaß, 205–207 and a dichotomy after Gen 8:19 in Bosshard-Nepustil, 2005, 27–41, 265, see Gertz, 2006, 46f. fn. 19 und 20.

⁷ For similar, see most recently Baumgart, 1999, 96–98.

More specifically, the following sections can be delineated within the main body of the narrative: I. Gen 7:1–5; II. Gen 7:6–16; III. Gen 7:17–24; IV. Gen 8:1–14; V. Gen 8:15–19. (I) The reannouncement of the coming of the Flood and the command in Gen 7:1–4 to enter the ark, in addition to the summarization in 7:5 of the command that is followed, form with (V.) Gen 8:15–19 an inner framing of the depiction of the Flood. (II) The section begins with a dating of the Flood (v. 6). The focus here is on the notice about the coming of the Flood (vv. 10–12), which is also accompanied by a date. It is flanked by the narration of the entry into the ark on one side (vv. 7–9) and the statement that this entry occurs “on this very day” on the other (vv. 13–16). (III) The description of the Flood is framed by the details concerning the duration of the Flood. The description of the Flood is the only section in which neither Yhwh/God nor Noah are explicitly mentioned. (IV) This section is defined entirely by its content, offering a description of the turn of events. However, by the conclusion of the Flood narrative in Gen 9:15f. taking up the motif of God’s remembrance (Heb. **זכר*) from Gen 8:1, it retrospectively emphasizes the opening to the beginning of the section. The end of the section is marked by the dating in v. 14 and the resumption of divine speech in v. 15. (V) With vv. 16f., the final part of this inner framing draws back on phrases from Gen 7:1b–4. Additionally, Gen 8:15–17 offers literal speech for the first time since Gen 7:1–5.

Formation I – Textual Evidence: The Flood narrative is unusually extensive compared to the other narratives in the Primeval History. Even from a superficial reading, it displays several conspicuous features indicating that the formation of the text took place in multiple stages. The narrative style is peculiarly redundant. Almost all of the narrative features that are essential to the plot appear multiple times and with stylistic and imaginative variations (I). Furthermore, there are factual inconsistencies, some heavier and some lighter (II), as well as differing designations for God (III).

On I: 1. Yhwh/God sees the wickedness of humanity and the corruption of the earth (Gen 6:5 and 6:11f.); 2. Yhwh/God decides upon annihilating humanity and all flesh (Gen 6:7 and 6:13); 3. God/Yhwh announces the coming of a flood (Gen 6:17 and 7:4); 4. God/Yhwh commands Noah to enter the ark with his family (Gen 6:18b and 7:1); 5. God/Yhwh commands the animals to be taken with them (Gen 6:19f. and 7:2) in order for them to be kept alive (Gen 6:20 and 7:3); 6. The Flood comes (Gen 7:10a and 7:11) and the waters rise (Gen 7:17b and 7:18–20); 7. All created beings perish (Gen 7:21 and 7:22f.); 8. The Flood ends (Gen 8:2a and 8:2b); 9. Noah recognizes the end of the Flood, and all leave the ark (Gen 8:6–12, 13b and 8:13a, 15–19); 10. Yhwh/God rules out the possibility of another flood (8:20–22 and 9:8–17). It should be noted that the scholarly lists of the doubled passages differ from one to the next according to the respective analyses. For example: The notices about the people and the animals boarding the ark in Gen 7:7–9 and 7:13–16 and the waters sinking in Gen 8:3a and 8:3b, 5 are commonly seen as doublets. However, the content of this section is coherent in and of itself, and assessments of it as doublets have probably resulted from scholars attempting to identify two complete and essentially similar versions of the Flood narrative.

On II: 1. Noah takes two of every animal with him onto the ark (Gen 6:19f.; 7:15f.) or two of every unclean animal and seven of every clean animal (Gen 7:2); 2. Either all the springs of the great primordial flood *מְהוּם* and the windows of the heavens open up (Gen 7:11; see also 8:2a), or the Flood comes via rainstorm (Gen 7:4, 12; see also 8:2b); 3. Noah learns that he can leave the ark either from sending out a bird (Gen 8:6–12), or by God informing him of such (Gen 8:16f.); 4. The mentions of the length of the Flood are round numbers (seven days or forty days, in Gen 7:4, 10, 12; 8:6, 10, 12), or the Flood is given exact dates (in the years of Noah's life) and lasts much longer (7:6, 11, 13, 24; 8:3b–5, 13a, 14); 5. The mountaintops are visible (Gen 8:5), but the dove does not find anywhere to land (Gen 8:9); 6. There is mention of either Noah and his wife, his sons, and his sons' wives (Gen 6:18; 7:7, 13; 8:6, 18) or Noah and his house more generally (Gen 7:1).

On III: The juxtaposition of the generic term *אֱלֹהִים* ("God" or "divine being"; Gen 6:9, 11, 12, 13, 22; 7:9, 16a; 8:1a, 1b, 15; 9:1, 6, 8, 12, 16, 17) and the divine personal name "Yhwh" (Gen 6:5, 6, 7, 8; 7:1, 5, 16b; 8:20, 21) is not by itself an indication of a literary tension. Nevertheless, given the strict divisions between the passages that use the name of God, "Yhwh" (Gen 2:4–4:26*) and those that use the generic term *אֱלֹהִים* (Gen 1:1–2:3; 5), it is surprising that the two terms for God alternate in the Flood narrative for no apparent reason (so, e.g., "And Noah did according to all that God had commanded him; he did thusly" in Gen 6:22 with "Then Noah did according to all that Yhwh had commanded him" in Gen 7:5). Moreover, the shift between the personal name and the generic term often corresponds to the aforementioned doublets.

The coincidence of nearly all of the building blocks of the Flood narrative being reported in doublets and of all the aforementioned tensions in subject matter, in addition to one and the same subjects being designated by different terms, led to the differentiation between two layers of text even at the beginnings of historical biblical exegesis. Since the seminal analyses of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, there has been a broad consensus concerning the delineation of these two textual layers.⁸ Hermann Gunkel called this, in retrospect quite rightly, "a masterpiece of modern criticism."⁹ This is also true for the attribution of the two identified strata to the two main voices of the biblical Primeval History, the Priestly Writing and the (in the terminology chosen here) Scholarly Narrator.

The Priestly version of the Flood narrative is, in terms of the narrative itself, complete and self-supporting. This has been widely acknowledged, notwithstanding the controversy around the Priestly Writing's literary profile. In regard to the second stratum, the general scholarly opinion is less uniform. Nevertheless, there are still great agreements worth noting in this case,

⁸ Hupfeld, 1853; Schrader, 1863; Budde, 1883, 248–289; Gunkel, 137–140. For the history of research, see Baumgart, 1999, 381–384. For recent discussion, see Gertz, 2006, and there also on the following.

⁹ Gunkel, 138; see already Budde, 1883, 248.

concerning the delineation of the material and its fundamental affiliation with the texts of the Primeval History that are here attributed to the Scholarly Narrator. It is also undisputed that the texts of this stratum cannot be connected together into one seamless account.

Formation II – Discussion: Clarification of the literary findings have come primarily through three models: 1. A redactional connection of the two originally independent versions of the Flood narrative from the Priestly Writing and the Scholarly Narrator (in the terminology chosen here; otherwise “J” or “non-P”) by a third hand;¹⁰ 2. An expansion by Priestly editors of a Flood narrative belonging to an older Primeval History;¹¹ 3. An expansion of a Priestly base text [*Grundschrift*] through post-Priestly editors.¹² The “source model” (1) still represents the majority scholarly opinion. The essential arguments for this position, which is the model supported here, follow naturally from the rejection of the two “supplementary models.”

As for the thesis of a Priestly editing of an older text (2), the Priestly texts in Gen 6:5–9:17 offer a self-contained version of the Flood narrative even according to prominent proponents of this explanation. Therefore, for this part of the text, as with the Creation account in Gen 1:1–2:3, it is assumed that the Priestly editor interwove the Flood narrative of an older Primeval History with his own Flood tradition. Thus, even here, the literary evidence within the Flood narrative is functionally explained by a “source model.”¹³ The evaluation of the Priestly Flood narrative as a part of an editorial layer (in the broadest sense) depends primarily on the assessment that the radical turn from the Creator’s praise in Gen 1:31 to the devastating judgment upon the corruption of Creation in Gen 6:11–13 is only plausible when including the Garden narrative and the Fratricide narrative, which thus presupposes the Scholarly Narrator’s Primeval History.¹⁴ However, the analysis of the ages given for the antediluvian patriarchs in the Register of the Generations of Adam in Gen 5 has shown that the Priestly Writing is very

¹⁰ See Budde, 1883, 248–289; Gunkel, 138–142; von Rad, 116–134; Westermann, 395–398 and more recently Seebaß, 228–231; Levin, 1993, 103–117; Carr, 1996, 48–62; Witte, 1998, 130–146, 171–184; Gertz, 2006. Inspired by Wellhausen, 1905, 7–14, the Flood narrative was held especially by older research (Budde, Holzinger, Gunkel, et al.) to be a later addition into the non-P Primeval History. See more recently Levin, 1993, 103; Carr, 2020, 159–177.

¹¹ See, following Volz, 1933, 140–142, esp. Van Seters, 1992, 160–169; Blum, 1990, 278–285.

¹² See Tuch, 137–186. The Tuch style of the supplementary hypothesis has experienced a renaissance for the Flood narrative (and the entire Primeval History) in Ska, 2009; Kratz, 2005, 256–258; Blenkinsopp, 2002; Bosshard-Nepustil, 2005; Schüle, 2006, 247–354; Arneth, 2007, 43–92, 169–200.

¹³ See Blum, 1990, 282 and fn. 206.

¹⁴ On the history of this argument, see Gertz, 2022^a, 66–69.

familiar with the idea of an increasing corruption of the world, with the end of this process marked by the statement from the narrator of Gen 6:11 and the judgment by God in Gen 6:12. These indications notwithstanding, the Priestly Writing does not seem interested in unfolding a process of decay through the narrative. Rather, it concentrates on the “structural disruption of the order of creation and the order of life”¹⁵ through the mention of, and thereby the defining of, the universal corruption of the earth (see on Gen 6:9–13 below), and so its Flood narrative need not rely on any mention of the “Fall” or the Fratricide narrative. The Priestly Writing thus stands on its own two feet also regarding the transition from the “good” Creation to the corrupted Creation. It can therefore be evaluated quite confidently within the Primeval History as a formerly independent work of literature.

For the thesis of a post-Priestly editing (3), it has above all been pointed out that a Flood narrative reconstructed from the parts of this stratum is incomplete. Moreover, there have been observations about the editorial process and the structure of the present text, in addition to individual phrases that have been classified as post-Priestly (and these are each addressed individually in the Exegesis below). The linchpin of the debate is the question of how to evaluate the absence of a report about the construction of the ark.¹⁶ The construction report is doubtlessly a constitutive element of the Flood narrative. Moreover, the first (preserved) mention of the ark in this stratum bears the definite article (Gen 7:1; cf. Gen 6:14 [P]), which presupposes with some degree of likelihood an earlier introduction of the ark. Within the framework of a source model, it must be assumed that the construction report was omitted during the redactional connection of the two versions. What appears at first glance like a makeshift solution can, however, be well justified. Firstly, a redactionally induced textual omission cannot fundamentally be ruled out. Empirically speaking, a document that is fully reconstructible from a secondary text would in any case be the exception, not the rule. Furthermore, a textual omission can be justified conceptually at this point, and there are references to the missing text that have been preserved: The Priestly instructions in Gen 6:14–16 for constructing the ark correspond with those for constructing the tent sanctuary in Exod 25–31; moreover, the three-staged construction of the ark corresponds to the ordering of the living world unfolded in Gen 1:1–2:3 (see on Gen 6:14–16 below). For this correspondence to have been preserved after combining the two versions, deleting the second construction account could have hardly been avoided.¹⁷ This

¹⁵ Zenger, 1987, 33 [translation JWR].

¹⁶ Further (supposed) gaps are discussed in the Exegesis below. On the problem of the redactional reformation and possible rearrangements, see on Gen 7:6–16 below.

¹⁷ Baumgart, 1999, 416.

assumption is confirmed through the Scholarly Narrator's notice in Gen 8:6 about opening "the window (חַלּוֹן) to the ark that [Noah] had made." This notice unquestionably presupposes a construction report. In the present text, however, the cross-reference "that he had made" has no preceding referent, since the window is not mentioned in the Priestly instructions for building the ark. Therefore, it is relatively certain that the construction report presupposed by Gen 8:6 (SN) is not to be sought in Gen 6:9–22 (P); it may have rather been an omission by the Redaction of a corresponding passage by the Scholarly Narrator. The same goes for the "cover" (מִכְסָּה) in Gen 8:13b (SN), which is likewise unmentioned in the Priestly text. Of course, in the redactional final form, these two architectural elements from the Scholarly Narrator's Flood narrative are to be equated with the "opening" (פֶּתַח) and the "roof" (צֹהַר) from the Priestly instructions (Gen 6:16). Yet, such identifications between the terms are rather complicated and, moreover, quite cumbersome, an indication that this can hardly be original. Even just the absence of a construction report in the Scholarly Narrator's Flood narrative ultimately speaks for, rather than against, the source model.

For the supplementary hypothesis outlined above, it has been further argued that the passages not belonging to the Priestly Writing define the structure of the entire text, i.e., that they were redactionally superimposed upon the Priestly Flood narrative.¹⁸ A look at the prologue and epilogue shows that this assumption, like the counterposition that the structure is defined by the Priestly Writing alone, is untenable. The first prologue and epilogue in Gen 6:5–8 and 8:20–22 are products of the Scholarly Narrator and the second prologue and epilogue in Gen 6:9–22 and 9:1–17 are products of the Priestly Writing. Thus, the prominent opening and closing passages of the Flood narrative are divided between the Scholarly Narrator and the Priestly Writing, making it difficult to claim that the structure is oriented towards *either* the non-Priestly texts *or* the Priestly texts alone. The following observation should be added to this: Generally speaking, the *toledot* formula opens new sections in the text. In the Flood narrative, the Priestly *toledot* formula in Gen 6:9 has been displaced from its position at the beginning by the opening from the Scholarly Narrator. Instead, the *toledot* formula, otherwise used as a heading, serves to signal a break within the bipartite prologue. The structure of the present text clearly overlaps with the structure of the Priestly Writing present within it. The situation is comparable at the end of the Flood narrative: In the epilogue by the Scholarly Narrator, Yhwh promises in Gen 8:21–22 to maintain the existence of Creation. This promise unmistakably harkens back to the prologue in Gen 6:5–8, and its final

¹⁸ Occasionally, an identical thesis is also justified by how the structure of the present text is oriented towards the Priestly Writing. See Schüle, 2006, 259.

section is formulated with a cadence, altogether indicating that this is the climax and – considering the peculiar weight that Hebrew Bible narratives give to endings – the conclusion to a Flood narrative that opened with Gen 6:5–8. However, in the final text, this is followed by Gen 9:1–17, which is a particularly weighty section. It comes from the Priestly Writing and is difficult to separate from the Flood narrative due to its close correspondence to Gen 6:11–22. Thus, in the text’s final shape, “blessing” and “covenant” form the closing act to the Flood narrative, with Yhwh’s promise in Gen 8:21–22 displaced from its seemingly natural position at the end and transformed into an internal caesura. The current structure therefore once again overlaps with the older literary boundaries. This time, however, it is the structure of the Scholarly Narrator’s Flood narrative that has been expanded with the final chord of the Priestly Writing. The structure of the present text is therefore based on two older antecedents, each with its own structuring principles:

	Gen 6:5–8	Gen 6:9f.	Gen 6:11–22	Gen 7:1–8:19	Gen 8:20–22	Gen 9:1–17
SN	Prologue	---	---	Flood	Epilogue	---
P	---	<i>Toledot</i> formula: Opening of the <i>toledot</i> of Noah (until Gen 9:28–29)	God’s speech to Noah before the Flood	Flood (until Gen 8:14); Part I of God’s speech to Noah after the Flood	---	Part II of God’s speech to Noah after the Flood
Final Text	Prologue I (inward)	Prologue II (outward)		Flood	Epilogue I (inward)	Epilogue II (outward)

A structure of Gen 6:5–9:17 that accounts for all the structural features and gives equal weight to all of them is not possible. This also shows that there are different structurings within the present Flood narrative that overlap with one another. Since more recent reworkings tend to follow earlier structures or to expand or clarify them, the evidence here speaks more in favor of the assumption of older antecedents, each with their own structuring principles. Finally, on a factual level, this also applies to the contradictions. They cannot satisfactorily be traced back to the intentions of possible editors but rather attest to how much the author or editor of the present text felt constrained to his antecedents (or “sources”).

Formation III – Conclusion: The layers of the text identified in the analysis can be described as two (nearly) complete versions of the Flood narrative

that were previously transmitted independently of each other, although this need not exclude the possibility of one being familiar with the other. At first glance, the method used here by the Redaction, which was responsible for bringing the two together, seems to deviate from the method used for Gen 1–5, insofar as there, the two main voices of the Primeval History were placed next to each other in closed blocks. However, this compositional technique was not suitable for the Flood narrative, because both versions deal with one and the same single event. Nevertheless, the Redaction did not completely deviate from its previous method, insofar as it presented larger units from the two different versions by setting blocks of text next to each other. Only in the report of the Flood was this done in certain places with quite small chunks, although there, it cannot be ruled out that the Redaction may have partially (re)formulated the text relatively independently based on the other two versions, which also explains any changes in the text order compared to the antecedents (see on Gen 7:6–16 below). Apart from that, corrective additions by the Redaction are limited to only a few sub-verses.

Tradition: Myths about a primeval endangerment of Creation are a universal phenomenon, reflecting in their details very different experiences in very different ways. Often, the threat comes via a large flood that annihilates nearly all life.¹⁹ However, alongside the Flood, there are also attestations of other primeval threats to the “good” Creation that are dependent on local conditions. Thus, the Egyptian “Book of the Heavenly Cow”²⁰ thematizes the reversal of the initial “good” Creation into the present state of the world, telling of the sun god Ra reacting to humanity’s rebellion with a devastating hellfire before ultimately subverting his own decision for humanity’s complete destruction.

There is no all-encompassing answer to the question of possible connections within the origins of the various stories of a great flood. All of their differences notwithstanding, the experiences of the living world in traditional societies show commonalities in many instances. Reflections upon the origin, stability, and endangerment of the living world, which all stem from the threats present within human existence, have often led to similar depictions of a supercatastrophe in these societies. Accordingly, most of the Flood legends outside of ancient Near Eastern and eastern Mediterranean culture share with the biblical Flood narrative only their basic structure. This comes from the “natural circumstances” of an annihilation of (a part of) humanity through a flood and need not be explained through a “genetic” connection, in the sense of the narratives referring to one and the same great event, nor

¹⁹ For the various collections of Flood narratives, see Lang, 1985.

²⁰ Lichtheim, Introduction and Translation, “The Destruction of Mankind,” *COS* 1.24:36–37.

by tracing them back to archetypal structures in the human psyche. Furthermore, it is worth remembering in many cases that the biblical Flood narrative was spread by Christian missionary activity and exerted a strong influence on autochthonous traditions. Therefore, a restriction to a historically and geographically contiguous cultural area is needed for inquiry into the history of both the tradition and its literature.²¹

Even in antiquity, there were discussions about the similarities of the Flood narratives, which by then were already well known. In the first century CE, the Judeo-Hellenistic philosopher Philo of Alexandria was probably the first to identify Noah with the Greek Flood hero Deucalion (Philo, *Praem.* 23). Philo's contemporary Flavius Josephus identified Noah with the hero of the Mesopotamian Flood traditions, through reference to the work of the Babylonian priest Berossos (Josephus, *A.J.* 1.93). Such considerations were taken up by early Christian authors as an apologetic argument for the reliability of the biblical tradition, while to their opponents, the correspondences between the traditions were taken as evidence that the biblical Flood narrative was an unscrupulous falsification of the legend of Deucalion (Celsus of Alexandria, per Origen, *Cels.* 4.41).

The cycle of Greek legends about Deucalion and Pyrrha is of only minor interest for the question of the traditions available to the biblical authors.²² Although it is likely that the Mesopotamian tradition exerted indirect influence on the Greek Flood legend via Asia Minor, there is no evidence for any Greek influence upon the formation of the biblical Flood narrative. The same cannot be said for the relationship between the biblical and Mesopotamian traditions. During the time of Josephus, the Mesopotamian tradition was known only through mediation by Berossos, whose work was known in later periods only through excerpts and citations.²³ However, with the rediscovery of the original cuneiform texts beginning in the nineteenth century, this discussion has gained much broader footing. The earliest Mesopotamian traditions may have been provoked by individual experiences with flood disasters and social unrest triggered by overpopulation, which were then condensed into the myth of the one supercatastrophe of the Great Flood (Sum. *amaru*, lit. "hurricane water," Akk. *abūbum*).²⁴ The first attestation of

²¹ Cf. Westermann, 398–406, who extends comparison to all earlier cultures and recognizes in "the flood... [an] archetype of human catastrophe." For criticism, see Lang, 1985, 612f.

²² On this Greek tradition, see Caduff, 1986.

²³ The texts of the Flood narrative from the *Babyloniaca* can be found in Verbrugghe/Wickersham, 2001, 49–51. In the Flood narrative by Berossos, several traditions run together. See further Dalley, 2013. For this reason, it is methodologically unadvisable to fill "gaps" in the Sumerian Flood Story through recourse to Berossos, as attempted by Wöhrlé, 2013, 330f.

²⁴ See Wilcke, 1999b; Maul, 2007, and each there also on the following.

the Mesopotamian Flood myth comes from the early second millennium BCE, in the form of the third tablet of the Epic of Atrahasis. From that point on, it is present in textual form and as subject matter throughout the history of literature.²⁵ Alongside the Epic of Atrahasis, there are two other known cuneiform versions of the Flood narrative: the Sumerian Flood Story, which is probably somewhat younger, and the eleventh tablet of the Epic of Gilgamesh, which is quite likely an excerpt from the Epic of Atrahasis and presupposes its readers' significant familiarity with the subject. There are also other epics that themselves have a different event as their main subject but link it to the Flood motif, and there is a variety of mentions of the Great Flood in entirely different textual genres. It thus serves as a widespread metaphor for the devastation of a land through military action, while king lists are divided between the rulers before the Flood, who enjoy particularly long lives, and those after the Flood (see above, pp. 229f. on Gen 5). There is evidence of the Epics of Gilgamesh and Atrahasis being known to the Levant (see above, pp. 20f. and fn. 49), and the temporal extent of the extant textual witnesses reaches well into the first millennium BCE – in the case of the Epic of Gilgamesh even into the Hellenistic period.

The structure of the three versions of the Mesopotamian Flood myth corresponds to that of the biblical Flood narrative and its (hypothetical) sources: The divine side decides upon widespread annihilation but allows for certain individuals to be saved. For this reason, a seafaring vessel is built, loaded, and boarded. Immediately thereafter, the devastating Flood breaks loose and the gods/God reign(s). After the Flood ends, the hero offers a sacrifice to the gods/God, at which point the gods/God decide(s) that the narrated disaster will never happen again. Additionally, there are similarities in details that are not tied to the "Flood" theme and point to not only a general knowledge of the material but a direct knowledge of the text. This is true above all for the scene with Noah sending out the birds in Gen 8:6–12 and its parallel in the Epic of Gilgamesh (Gilgm 11.147–156). The fact that the biblical Flood narrative and its sources are dependent upon the Mesopotamian tradition, even just because the original cuneiform documents are considerably older, is beyond any doubt, and also because the subject matter is quite alien to the Hebrew Bible. The flooding of the entire land surely could not have been an experience in mountainous Palestine that would have begotten any tradition or myth. The case is different, however, in the semiarid region of the southern Mesopotamian lowlands, where no rainfed agriculture is possible. Here, agriculture is dependent entirely upon the water from the Euphrates and Tigris and is confronted with the special difficulty of the Taurus Mountains

²⁵ On the differentiation of the individual myth from its respective textual versions, see Burkert, 1982.

of Turkey and the Zagros Mountains of Iran thawing in springtime, reaching the Mesopotamian lowlands only at harvesttime, and then threatening to drown the land. It therefore requires tremendous and well-organized efforts to keep water reserves for cultivating the fields via an elaborate canal system (see merely Atr 1.19–24) and to dam back the destructive force of the flood during harvesttime. Accordingly, everyday documents repeatedly report of floods and storms destroying fields and harvests.²⁶

The Mesopotamian tradition is quite varied. The most striking feature for this is the various names of the Flood hero: Atrahasis, “Exceedingly Wise”; Ziusudra, “Life of Long Days” (also Xisuthrus in Berossos) in the Sumerian Flood Story; Utnapištim, “I Found Life” in the Epic of Gilgamesh. Also, unlike the text of the Epic of Gilgamesh, that of the Epic of Atrahasis was never standardized. Its Neo-Assyrian version can be characterized as a reinterpretation, while fragments found in more recent contexts mainly follow the Old Babylonian version. Nevertheless, all of their differences are outweighed by their similarities, which is why a concise summary can be offered that is focused entirely around the Epic of Atrahasis: In the distant, mythical past – “When gods were man” (Atr 1.1) – a group of lower gods are initially the ones responsible for providing for the high gods. However, after some time, they rebel, and so Enki (Akk. “Ea”), the wise god of the freshwater ocean, and the mother goddess Nintu (Akk. “Belet-ili,” also “Mami”) create humanity to work for the gods (Atr 1.191, 197 [2.70, 74]). Yet, humanity multiplies exceedingly quickly. Their noisiness bothers the king of the gods, Enlil, and interrupts his nap (Atr 1.352–359). Enlil therefore prompts a decision by the assembly of the gods to bring the multiplication of humanity, and thus its noisiness, to an end. After a sequence of increasingly severe plagues fails to make this happen (Atr 1.360ff.; 2.1–7), the gods – and this is where the excerpt from the Epic of Gilgamesh picks up (Gilgm 11.11) – send a great flood (Atr 3.2.48–3.3.23).²⁷ This time, humanity is to be completely annihilated. As with the plagues, Enlil’s divine adversary Enki foils the plan that the gods had agreed upon. Enki is indeed bound to the divine assembly’s decision and also participates in executing it by sending omens of great fortune before the coming of the Flood in order to deceive the people who are destined to perish (Atr 3.1.34; see Gilgm 11.46f., 87f.).²⁸ Nevertheless, he also sends a warning to the hero of the Flood. Enki speaks to a “reed wall” so that Atrahasis can hear the warning about the Flood in a dream (Atr 3.1.15–35) without Enki breaking the silence imposed upon him (see Gilgm 11.196). At his advice, Atrahasis, his family, and individual animals save themselves by boarding a boat (Atr 3.2.32–38 [?];

²⁶ See Wilcke, 1999a.

²⁷ The Sumerian Flood Story also tells of the history before the Deluge, dealing with the creation of human and animal as well as the founding of antediluvian cities. However, the details are unclear. In Berossos, what comes first are the creation of the world, which is reminiscent of Gen 1:1–2:3, and the long reigns of the nine antediluvian kings, who are followed in the tenth position by Xisuthrus, the Flood hero (see above, pg. 229f.).

²⁸ Cf. Wöhrle, 2013, 321–329, who overlooks how Enki is bound to the decision by the divine assembly and is involved in its implementation not only in the Sumerian Flood Story but also in the Epic of Atrahasis (and the Epic of Gilgamesh); this has far-reaching consequences for determining the relationship of the biblical Flood narrative to its Mesopotamian antecedents [*Vorlagen*].

see Gilg. 11.27: “Put on board the boat all living things’ seed!”) Additionally, Gilg. 11.86 reports of Utnapištim taking on board representatives of all the arts, saving the knowledge from the antediluvian era. To the same effect, Berossos notes that Xisuthrus buried clay tablets before the Flood. Ultimately, the absence of offerings moves the gods to relent (Atr 3.4.15–22). Humanity survives, but life is reordered after the Flood (Atr 3.6.46–3.7.11).²⁹ After Atrahasis offers a sacrifice, the mother goddess is summoned to recreate humanity. However, at the same time, a situation is to be prevented in which the people again uncontrollably multiply and their noise again disturbs the divine peace. For this reason, population growth is restrained by sterility, infant mortality, the establishment of a class of childless priestesses, and probably also the limitation of the human lifespan.³⁰ Furthermore, the fate of humanity is to be measured according to their actions (Atr 3.6.25; Gilg. 11.185f.). Ultimately, with the end of the Flood, the relationship among the gods themselves and the relationship of the gods to humanity seems to have been fundamentally clarified: The gods need humanity, and a renewed attempt at annihilating them would be unwise. Also, for this reason, the mother goddess uses a necklace with lapis lazuli shaped like flies to remind herself in the future that she will never again relinquish her humans to annihilation.

The Mesopotamian myth of the Great Flood, in the form of the Epic of Atrahasis, describes the transition from a distant past without humanity to an epoch of unrestrained human multiplication and, ultimately, to the present state, in which there is a stable balance between growth and the factors regulating growth, and which is dominated by a regulated relationship between the gods among themselves and between the gods and humans.³¹ What triggers the Great Flood is the lack of a “balance of powers”³² in the antediluvian world. With the end of the Great Flood, the world receives its final and stable order, whose continuance is guaranteed by the promise that there will be no repetition of the Great Flood (Atr 3.5.46–3.6.4; Gilg. 11.166f.; see also Gen 8:21f.; 9:15). Accordingly, if the myth of the Great Flood describes the circumstances of human life as the result of a transformation from a “before” state into the present state, then to understand the biblical Flood narrative, the question of what kind of transformation it depicts must be asked. This question must be answered for the Priestly Writing and for the Scholarly Narrator separately, even if the two versions complement each other in the present text. In anticipation of Scholarly Exposition II: Exegesis below, it can already be stated here that the Priestly Writing accents the establishing of the first and most elementary rules for protecting life (Gen 9:4–6). It also reacts to the theological and political crisis of the exile,

²⁹ For reconstruction and interpretation of this in parts completely destroyed conclusion, see Wilcke, 1999b, 96–99.

³⁰ The latter considered by Wilcke, 1999b, 97f.; Maul, 2007, 181. The text of the Epic of Atrahasis at the place in question has not been preserved.

³¹ Müller, 1985, 305–308; Gertz, 2007, 512–514.

³² Moran, 1971, 58.

and for this, it takes up the pertinent terminology of doom prophecy in justifying the Great Flood (see on Gen 6:11, 13 below) while also guaranteeing the continuance of the “very good” Creation in the form of an “eternal covenant” (Gen 9:16) beyond any realities of doom (see on Gen 9:8–17 below). In contrast, in his reformulation of this initially “alien” myth, the Scholarly Narrator’s focus is entirely on anchoring his own “image of God” within the primeval era. The Mesopotamian myth provides a finely balanced piece of theology and anthropology in which the human experience of contingency is related to the inherently contradictory volitions of the assembly of the gods. The Scholarly Narrator relocates the conflict among the most important protagonists of the Mesopotamian tradition into the one, highly tension-filled deity Yhwh. In this way, he narrates – without any “monotheistic” gesture seeking to outdo the “polytheistic” archetype – the transformation of Yhwh from a god oriented around the standards of absolute justice to a merciful Creator and sustainer of the incurably evil humanity (see on Gen 6:5–8 and 8:20–22 below).

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION II: EXEGESIS

6:5–8

- 5 *And Yhwh saw that the wickedness of humanity was vast upon the earth, and every formation of the thoughts of its heart was only evil, all the days.*
- 6 *Thus, Yhwh regretted that he had made humanity upon the earth, and it hurt him to his very heart.*
- 7 *And Yhwh said, “I shall destroy humanity, whom I have created, from the surface of the ground, from humanity to livestock, to the crawling animal and the flying animals of the heavens, for I regret that I made them [it].”*
- 8 *Noah, however, found favor in the eyes of Yhwh.*

The first, inwardly directed prologue is largely a product of the Scholarly Narrator, with traces of the redactional connection with the Priestly Flood narrative being found only in v. 7 (see below). The account of how Yhwh comes to the decision to annihilate humanity but save Noah has a clearly defined structure:³³ Verse 5 provides analysis of the situation from Yhwh’s own perspective, describing the wickedness of humanity spatially (“upon

³³ See, e.g., Oberforcher, 1981, 94–100; Witte, 1998, 174–176; Arneth, 2007, 175–179; Janowski, 2015, 61f.

the earth”) and temporally (“all the days”). The depiction of Yhwh’s inner feelings in v. 6 corresponds structurally to v. 5 and underlines the connection between human action and divine reaction:

6:5a	And Yhwh saw that the wickedness of humanity was vast upon the earth	6:6a	Thus, Yhwh regretted that he had made humanity upon the earth,
6:5b	and every formation of the thoughts of its heart was only evil, all the days.	6:6b	and it hurt him to his very heart.

The announcement of the impending annihilation of humanity in v. 7* is in turn closely related to v. 6. Verse 6a and v. 7b form a frame around Yhwh’s pain in v. 6b and his plan for annihilating humanity in v. 7a. This then emphasizes the correspondence between the inner feeling and the announcement of the manifestation of the divine will. At the same time, it makes clear that Yhwh’s pain also refers to the threatened destruction:

Frame: Yhwh’s Regret	6:6a	Thus, Yhwh regretted that he had made humanity upon the earth,
Yhwh’s Feelings	6:6b	and it hurt him to his very heart.
Yhwh’s Feelings	6:7a	And Yhwh said, “I shall destroy humanity... from the surface of the ground...
Frame: Yhwh’s Regret	6:7b	For I regret that I made [it]

The pardoning of Noah in v. 8 opens by mentioning Noah first (an inverted verbal clause with the *waw-adversative*: “Noah, however”) and thus emphatically contrasts with the decision to destroy all humanity in v. 7. The concluding “in the eyes of Yhwh” then ties back to Yhwh’s “seeing” at the beginning of the passage in v. 5a.

6:5

And Yhwh saw that the wickedness of humanity was vast upon the earth, and every formation of the thoughts of its heart was only evil, all the days.

The “deeply pessimistic view of human sinfulness”³⁴ at the beginning of the Flood narrative marks an important difference in the biblical tradition compared to its Mesopotamian archetypes. The biblical Flood is occasioned by the wickedness of humanity, while in the Mesopotamian tradition, human

³⁴ Gunkel, 60.

guilt plays either no role or, at most, an implicit and marginal one, and the Flood is triggered by conflict among the gods and by human vitality and fertility interfering with the gods.³⁵ However, the two biblical versions present the theme of human guilt differently. While the Priestly Writing gives the increase of violence that resulted from the corruption of humans and animals (“all flesh”) as the reason for the Flood (Gen 6:11–13), the Scholarly Narrator is concerned not just with the consequences of human action but with wickedness as an anthropological constant. Thus, v. 5a and v. 5b are interrelated insofar as the former is a general statement about human wickedness and the latter is an anthropological specification of it.³⁶ In the Hebrew Bible, the Hebrew word **לֵב** (or **לִבָּב**), commonly translated as “heart,” only seldomly refers to the bodily organ in an anatomical sense. Rather, the focus lies in its meaning as the innermost part of the human being that determines cognition, understanding, feeling, and will (Deut 29:3; 2 Sam 7:3; Prov 15:14; 16:9, 23).³⁷ Accordingly, v. 5 mentions the formation (**יִצָּר**) of the thoughts (**מַחְשְׁבֹת**) of the heart. The phrase is aimed at both the human designs based in the mind and will as well as the consequences thereof. If **יִצָּר** refers to the aspects of creationary production (see **יִצַּר** q. in Gen 2:7), the plural formation **מַחְשְׁבֹת** describes “the uninterrupted chain of human situational planning, which produces the most diverse of results,”³⁸ those very “formations of the thoughts.” Verse 5b is unmistakably aimed at a fundamental mindset, since it speaks explicitly and in emphatic correspondence of every formation (**כָּל־יִצָּר**) of every time (**כָּל־הַיּוֹם**) being, without exception (particle **רַק** “only”), evil. This damning judgment is thus not limited to the generation before the Flood, as is also evident from the pointed affirmation of the judgment after the Flood (Gen 8:21).³⁹ Within the Hebrew Bible, it is echoed most strongly in the Hellenistic book of Ecclesiastes (so Eccl 8:6: “for the wickedness of humanity weighs heavily upon him”; further Eccl 7:29;

³⁵ For discussion, see Wilcke, 1999b, 86f.; Albertz, 1999. In the reordering of the world, the fate of humanity is to be measured by their actions (Atr 3.6.25; Gilgm 11.185f.). By inference, it may be concluded that this was not the case before the Flood. In view of the totality of the annihilation, the biblical narratives suggest that the guilt of some resulted in the annihilation of all, which is to be avoided through the new rules for the future. This thought, however, is not developed in either the Epic of Atrahasis or the Epic of Gilgamesh, nor is it in line with how the history before the Flood is depicted in both works. Nevertheless, it is quite possible that the passages about the measurement of fate according to guilt helped to inspire the biblical authors concerning their fundamental claims about human guilt.

³⁶ See Arneth, 2007, 177 and fn. 235. Arneth rightly rejects the exclusion of v. 5b by Levin, 1993, 114f., who cites for this a contrast between humanity as a whole (v. 5a) and the individual (v. 5b). Yet, how should features marking the actions of each individual person be described if not as structural features on the individual?

³⁷ See Fabry, 1984; Frevel, 2006.

³⁸ Seybold, 1982, 254 [translation JWR].

³⁹ Cf. Westermann, 409.

9:3; this proximity is sometimes cited as an indication for a late dating of Gen 6:5–8, but it actually says little in this context, since Ecclesiastes draws on the Primeval History in its anthropology and evidently presupposes the present text).

The characterization of human action by the Scholarly Narrator seems quite undifferentiated compared to his psychologically detailed analysis of Cain's fratricide. Even if it should be read within the context of Adam and Eve's transgression of the divine commandment, Cain's fratricide, and Lamech's celebration of violence, it still inevitably raises the question of the extent to which the Scholarly Narrator also does justice to an "Abel" in this. The sweeping, devastating judgment upon the "formation of the thoughts of the heart" is therefore often read as a (secondary) justification of Yhwh's actions. The inclusion of the tradition of a Flood bringing total annihilation called for a declaration of the totality of human wickedness should Yhwh not prove to be exorbitant and capricious.⁴⁰ The fact that the Scholarly Narrator emphasizes the correspondence between human guilt and divine reaction should not be overlooked, but it only partially explains the severity of the judgment. Just as important is its function within the context of the Flood narrative as a whole: Yhwh repeating the judgment at the end of the narrative forms a sharp contrast to his promise that there will be no more floods moving forward. Read from this outcome, the focus of the narrative is about the exclusion of the total annihilation of the postdiluvian world from being an appropriate response from Yhwh to humanity's malevolence. From this perspective, the severity of the judgment is in the service of an all-encompassing guarantee of human existence⁴¹ that is willing to bear even humanity's intrinsic wickedness – which, of course, does not cancel out the anthropological pessimism in Gen 6:5; 8:21.⁴²

6:6

Thus, Yhwh regretted that he had made humanity upon the earth, and it hurt him to his very heart.

From the "seeing" comes "regretting" (*נחם ni. "to regret").⁴³ The statement about Yhwh regretting creating humanity because of its wickedness and wanting to rectify this through the Flood caused interpretive difficulties from early on. The LXX translates *נחם ni. in v. 6 as ἐνθυμέομαι "to reflect

⁴⁰ Ruppert, 316; Levin, 1993, 114f.

⁴¹ See Baumgart, 1999, 151.

⁴² Cf. Baumgart, 1999, 150f. ("fictive character" and "literary idealization" [translations JWR]).

⁴³ On the repentance of God, see Jeremias, 1975; Döhling, 2009; Gertz, 2007, 519–522.

upon” and in v. 7 as θυμῶ “to become angry.” It presumably seemed more appropriate to the translator to describe God’s reaction to human transgression as “anger,” since the talk of regret implies a mutability of God, which has been perceived as problematic.⁴⁴ Likewise, in their retellings, both Josephus and the book of Jubilees avoid talking about God’s regret (Josephus, *A.J.* 1.75; Jub. 5:2–6), while Philo emphatically objects to seeing God deciding to destroy humanity as evidence against the principle of the immutability of God (Philo, *Deus* 20–22). Early rabbinic interpretation also had to grapple with the objection that Gen 6:5–7 displays God’s fickleness and lack of foresight.⁴⁵ Standing in the background of each case is the dispute with a leading conception of ancient religious philosophy: the apathy or immutability of God.⁴⁶ This is connected with the question of whether the talk of God’s regret also involves the idea of God being unpredictable, which would naturally plunge humanity into fear and doubt. For the Hebrew Bible, it is important to recognize in this regard that generally, God’s regret is directed towards a threat of disaster that God is stopped from conducting by the intercession of a prophet or the repentant conversion of the people. Relevant in this context are the first two visions in the book of Amos, in which the prophet, like every other prophet of the ancient Near East, tries to avert the disaster that he has foreseen through intercession (so *נחם pi. in Amos 7:3, 6). The prophet Moses stands in this exact same line of tradition, interceding for his people when threatened with punishment at Sinai following Israel’s apostasy from Yhwh (Exod 32:12, 14). Only in two places is God’s regret directed towards his prior actions, first in Gen 6:6f. and second in 1 Sam 15:11, 35, with the latter in regard to the election of Saul as king. In neither case, however, does God regret his own action; rather, the regret should be seen in each case as related to human action.⁴⁷ It is the divine reaction to a human transgression that precludes it from being allowed to continue. Saul, in the narrator’s view, forfeits his election as king through his behavior. Humanity has used its freedom, as given through the ability to distinguish between “good” and “bad” (Gen 3), for evil. In both cases, however, God’s regret is connected with a new provision for salvation. In 1 Sam 15, this comes through the announcement of the new king, David; incidentally, this is hedged through the (only seemingly) contradictory commentary that Yhwh never regrets of anything (1 Sam 15:29; see also 2 Sam 7:12, 16). In the interplay between Gen 6:6f. and 8:21f., the new provision for salvation comes through Yhwh’s

⁴⁴ Rösel, 1994, 161f.

⁴⁵ Evidence in Jacob, 179.

⁴⁶ See also Janowski, 2015 (with further literature).

⁴⁷ Cf. Döhling, 2009, 131, who identifies behind v. 6 a “discrepancy between the intent of creation and the perception of creation” [translation JWR]. For criticism of this, see Janowski, 2015, 59f.

promise that the permanent malevolence of humanity will never again lead to another Flood. Yhwh thus grants humanity the freedom to act autonomously, even if human action continues to give Yhwh every right to pass judgment again after the Flood. In this respect, God's capacity for regret is, per the Hebrew Bible, the necessary counterpart of his dependability: "*Unchangeable* is God in his faithfulness to Creation but *changeable* because he can abstain from his destructive action and 'turn back' even though human wickedness continues unchanged."⁴⁸ From the canonical perspective, God's capability for regretting his threats of disaster regardless of his punitive claims (e.g., Hos 11:8f.) is anchored in the Flood narrative: Over the course of the narrative, Yhwh overcomes regretting creating humanity, thus learning to endure humanity's unchanging malevolence moving forward and in turn enabling him to turn from his threats of disaster.⁴⁹ In terms of the formation of the Flood narrative, the prologue's talk of God's regret may already presuppose the so-called "doom prophecy" from the classical prophecy of the eighth century BCE.⁵⁰

Coming alongside the regret is Yhwh's profound inner pain (*עצב hithp.). This heartfelt pain shows Yhwh's inner injury caused by humanity's wickedness.⁵¹ Yet, the meaning of the statement is not limited to the emotional intensification of the regret. Rather, the concentric structure of vv. 6f. (see above) and the reference to the heart as the seat of reflection and the formation of the will both suggest that v. 6b was formulated already with the consequences of the repentance in v. 7 in mind:⁵² Yhwh decides upon the Flood out of and with deep pain. For the Scholarly Narrator, Yhwh's inner experience is defined by his hurting on account of the human beings he created and not by his anger at their malevolence, as is the case with the later reception of the Flood narrative and its concerns about theological correctness (see Isa 26:20; 54:8f.).⁵³ The statement of God's pain (*עצב hithp.) clearly refers back to the judgments of the Garden narrative (Gen 3:16, 17) and the birth notice of Noah (Gen 5:29). In both passages, the term "toil/hardship" (עֲצָבוֹן), which comes from the same root, denotes the impairment of existence that humanity experiences because of Adam and Eve's transgression

⁴⁸ Janowski, 2015, 71 [translation JWR; emphasis original].

⁴⁹ See Jeremias, 1975, 27.

⁵⁰ Gertz, 2007, 519–522.

⁵¹ So Oberforcher, 1981, 145; Ruppert, 318; Döhling, 2009, 94, 110–116; Schüle, 2006, 174–177.

⁵² Jeremias, 1975, 25

⁵³ See further Berges, 2004, 311–313. Cf. Schüle, 139, with reference to the use of *עצב hithp. in Gen 34:7. However, the reaction of the sons of Jacob to the rape of their sister Dinah mentions the brothers not only being insulted (*עצב hithp.) but also explicitly becoming enraged (*חרה). It is no coincidence that Gen 6:6b lacks a corresponding notice about God's anger.

of the divine commandment, and for which Noah will comfort humanity (*נחם pi.). Neither the fact that this hope can be fulfilled at all in light of Yhwh's repentance (נחם ni.) and his decision to send the Flood nor how this comes to be is yet in sight at this nadir in the Scholarly Narrator's Primeval History. However, the end of the Flood narrative shows in retrospect that v.8 has already pointed to an answer to this question, through the pardoning of Noah: Yhwh accepts Noah's sacrifice and affirms his preservation of the blessing of the earth regardless of human malevolence (Gen 8:21f.).

6:7

And Yhwh said, "I shall destroy humanity, whom I have created, from the surface of the ground, from humanity to livestock, to the crawling animal and the flying animals of the heavens, for I regret that I made them [it]."

The decision to annihilate the world is formulated as direct divine speech. Like in Yhwh's monologue at the end of the Flood narrative (Gen 8:21f.), no addressee is named. These two key points in the Flood narrative in a way address the readers themselves, thus including them in what happens.⁵⁴ The means through which Yhwh is to destroy humanity at first remains unmentioned, but it is clearly indicated through the verb *מָהַ. It has the concrete meaning of "to wipe off/away" (2 Kgs 21:13; Prov 30:20) and denotes in later theological usage the positive erasure of guilt (Isa 43:25) and the negative erasure of one's name and memory from the heavenly book of those faithful to Yhwh (Exod 32:32f.). Genesis 6:7, on the other hand, still echoes the basic, concrete meaning of the "wiping away" from some sort of surface,⁵⁵ specifically the surface of the earth. Unlike in vv. 5f. and in line with the judgments in Gen 3:17; 4:11f., this verse speaks not of "the earth" (אֶרֶץ) but of "the soil" (אֲדָמָה; here in the phrase "the surface of the ground"), alluding to the intrinsic connection between human (אָדָם) and אֲדָמָה (see Gen 2:7), which is here to be (re)dissolved.

6:8

Noah, however, found favor in the eyes of Yhwh.

The pardoning of Noah marks – as indicated in the change of subject as well as the word order – the turn from the announcement of the total annihilation

⁵⁴ Ruppert, 319.

⁵⁵ Oberforcher, 1981, 319.

of all humanity to the salvation of the one. The common formula “to find mercy in the eyes of [sb.]” (*מצא חן בעיני*) comes from the language of the royal court and is based in both profane and theological usage in relationships of unambiguous superiority and inferiority; the supplicant asks for mercy, and the powerful party grants it to the subordinated party. Worth noting first in v. 8 is the wordplay between “Noah” (*נח*) and “grace” (*חן*). This anagram (*חן/נח*) provides another clue for Noah’s purpose in the Primeval History, in addition to the hopeful explanation of his name in Gen 5:29. Especially striking, however, is the lack of any justification for Yhwh’s decision to be merciful. Even biblical authors found this irritating and were provoked to provide explanations for this. Thus, the Priestly Writing justifies Noah’s salvation through his excellence and piety, unique among his contemporaries (Gen 6:9), after which an editor later thought to add that Noah had been considered by Yhwh to be the only “righteous” person of his generation (Gen 7:1b). However, even this later improvement has not always proved satisfactory, which is why, from antiquity onwards, it has been associated with a “test of faith” in which Noah, against all odds, began building the ark simply at God’s command (see Heb 11:7) and, as a preacher of justice, wanted to lead his contemporaries to repentance (see 2 Pet 2:5). There is no support for such considerations in the Scholarly Narrator’s Flood narrative.⁵⁶ The claims about human malevolence in v. 5 apply to all humanity without exception, and thus also to Noah. Consistent with this, the judgment of humanity at the end of the Flood is confirmed in light of Noah’s sacrifice. Its validity is thus maintained for Noah and his descendants, the postdiluvian humanity. Yhwh’s choice of mercy is not accompanied with rationale for it in the person of the saved individual, which shifts the weight of the statement entirely to Yhwh:⁵⁷ The continuance of the earth is to be safeguarded in perpetuity, as prepared through the salvation of the one and promised after the end of the Flood; this is based entirely in Yhwh and the “victory of Yhwh’s desire for salvation over his justice and righteousness”⁵⁸ as related in the Flood narrative. However, this victory is hard-won and comes at a great price, as shown by the imbalanced juxtaposition of the decision to annihilate humanity and the subsequent choice of mercy, reflecting the roles of the various deities in the Mesopotamian tradition.⁵⁹ Yhwh bears internally the conflict between Enlil, who calls for a Flood in the divine assembly, and Enki, who does not refuse the decision

⁵⁶ Cf. Budde, 1883, 256f. fn. 1, who presumed the missing parts to be in the omitted report of building the ark. Thereafter, Gunkel, 61f., 143 called it “characteristic” that the Priestly Writing had omitted the (hypothesized) test of faith, since it “has no taste for personal piety.”

⁵⁷ See Stoebe, 1971, 590.

⁵⁸ Jeremias, 1975, 38 [translation JWR].

⁵⁹ See further Baumgart, 1999, 419–495.

but undermines it for the sake of humanity's survival. His deep pain echoes the weeping of the mother goddess over the death of her human children (Atr 3.4.4–14; Gilgm 11.117–124) – without the dreadfulness of the divine deed being made any more bearable by the fact that Yhwh, in contrast to the mother goddess, is seemingly aware of its consequences even before the Flood.

In the Scholarly Narrator's Flood narrative, the prologue would have originally been followed by an account of the ark's construction alongside the announcement to Noah, which is all presupposed by the next piece from the Scholarly Narrator, preserved in Gen 7:1–5*. Communication of the reason for the judgment, however, is not necessary, since the Scholarly Narrator leaves all corresponding explanations on the interpretive level of the text (see 8:21–22).⁶⁰ Incidentally, even the Babylonian Flood heroes Atrahasis and Utnapištim never learn why the Flood comes. They are instead, like Noah, content with following the instructions for salvation.

For conceptual reasons, the Redaction removed the Scholarly Narrator's report of the construction (see above) and paired the prologues of the two versions of the Flood narrative together as a purely internal communication and an announcement to Noah, respectively. In this way, it created a coherent opening; only in v. 7 have its efforts for an overarching view led to narrative tensions. The listing of living creatures in v. 7aβγ draws on the Priestly Creation account (Gen 1:24–26) and, with the first element (“from humanity”), does not quite tie in coherently with the previous announcement that humanity is to be wiped out from the earth. It is now extended to animals, although the assignment of guilt had previously been directed only at humanity. The concluding reference to Creation may have originally referred to humanity (כִּי־עָשִׂיתִיהוּ “that I made *it*”), like in v. 6a, which was then swapped by the Redaction with the inserted enumeration through a plural suffix (כִּי־עָשִׂיתֶם “that I made *them*”).⁶¹ Moreover, the announcement of the annihilation of humanity was offset from the listing of all living creatures by another reference to the creation of humanity. This also took place with recourse to the Priestly Creation account (*ברא; see Gen 1:27). Through these additions, the Redaction brought an essential statement from the Priestly Flood narrative into the first inner prologue, since the Flood, according to the Priestly Writing,

⁶⁰ It could be still be argued that, in the sense of the supplementary model, the Redactor wanted the divine speech in Gen 6:13–21 (P) to be understood as the communication of the divine judgment from Gen 6:5–8, but this cannot be the case for Gen 8:21–22 and Gen 9:17. At the level of the present text, Noah merely learns of the divine guarantee of survival and is spared God's bitter insight into human nature. This privilege belongs only to God, the narrator, and the readers. Why should this have been different on the level of the Scholarly Narrator's work? Cf. Bosshard-Nepustil, 2005, 53.

⁶¹ See Budde, 1883, 251f.

was not only brought about by human malevolence but also through the corruption of all flesh (Gen 6:12f.). In addition, the juxtaposition of the creation-ary statements with *ברא “to create” and *עשה “to make/do” result in a cross-reference to the conclusion of the Priestly Creation account (Gen 1:31 [P]) and the redactional opening to the Garden narrative (Gen 2:4a [R]; Gen 2:4b [SN]), further emphasizing the connection between Creation and Flood, myth and antimyth.

6:9–22

- 9 *These are the generations of Noah. Noah was a righteous man; he was blameless in his generations. Noah walked with God.*
- 10 *And Noah fathered three sons: Shem, Ham, and Japheth.*
- 11 *And the earth was corrupted before God, and the earth was filled with violence.*
- 12 *And God saw the earth, and behold, it was corrupt, for all flesh had corrupted its way upon the earth.*
- 13 *Then God said to Noah, “The end of all flesh has come before me, for the earth is full of violence because of them. And behold, I will corrupt them with the earth.*
- 14 *Make for yourself an ark out of gofer wood. You shall make the ark out of reed [?] and you shall coat it inside and out with pitch.*
- 15 *And thus shall you make it: 300 cubits is the length of the ark, 50 cubits its width and 30 cubits its height.*
- 16 *You shall make a roof [?] for the ark and after a cubit, you shall stop it upwards [?], and you shall install an opening of the ark on its side; you shall make a lower, a second, and a third [story].*
- 17 *And I, behold, I am about to let the Great Flood, that is, water, come over the earth in order to corrupt all flesh under the heavens that has the breath of life in it; all that is upon the earth will perish.*
- 18 *With you, however, I shall establish my covenant, and you shall go into the ark, you and your sons and your wife and the wives of your sons with you.*
- 19 *From all living beings, from all flesh, you shall bring two of each into the ark to survive with you; they shall be male and female.*
- 20 *From the flying animals according to their kind, from the livestock according to their kind, from all crawling animals of the ground according to their kind. Two of each shall come to you to survive.*
- 21 *You, however: Take from all that can be eaten and collect it with you, so that it can serve as food for you and for them.”*
- 22 *And Noah did according to all that God had commanded him; he did thusly.*

The second, outwardly directed prologue comes from the Priestly Writing. In it, the section originally followed Gen 5:32.⁶² Its heading arranges the following events within the “*toledot*/generations of Noah” (v. 9aα, 10). The characterization of Noah as righteous and blameless (v. 9aβb) disrupts the genealogical schema, thus creating a point of connection with the Flood narrative, since the notice’s breaking of the schema suggests that a story is about to unfold. In the Priestly Writing, Gen 6:9–10 and Gen 9:28–29 formed a frame around the Flood narrative. The body of the Priestly Flood narrative is structured into four parts. It opens with a rather dense description of the causes of the Flood (Gen 6:11–12), followed by God’s speech to Noah with instructions for building the ark and the promise of the covenant. This part is concluded with a notice of fulfillment (Gen 6:13–22). Following this is the description of God’s actions during the Flood (Gen 7:6–8:14), framed by chronological details (Gen 7:6, 11; 8:13f.). The conclusion is formed by a speech by God to Noah after the Flood (Gen *8:15–9:17), which has multiple parts and is subdivided by a short side note about leaving the ark, which itself draws on the exposition about the causes of the Flood and the promise of the covenant.⁶³ In the present text, this structure has only partially been retained amid the redactional connection with the Scholarly Narrator’s Flood narrative. The placement of Gen 6:5–8 [SN] at the beginning displaced the *toledot* formula from its typical position as a heading and demoted it to serving as a subheading. Thus, the opening of the Priestly Flood narrative has become the second part of a bipartite prologue that both recounts the reasons for Yhwh choosing to be merciful and also reports of the divine decision and its consequences being communicated to the Flood hero. This situation is comparable to the end of the Flood narrative. There, the insertion of the Scholarly Narrator’s epilogue (Gen 8:20–22) interrupts the continuous Priestly report of God’s speech to Noah after the Flood.

6:9–10

- 9 *These are the generations of Noah. Noah was a righteous man; he was blameless in his generations. Noah walked with God.*
 10 *And Noah fathered three sons: Shem, Ham, and Japheth.*

The characterization of Noah as “righteous” (צַדִּיק) and “blameless” (תָּמִים) and his way of life as in accordance with God (“Noah walked with God”), which has been inserted into the genealogical schema, marks at the very

⁶² For a similar position of contact between two *toledot*, see Gen 11:26f. and Gertz, 2022^a, 78–80.

⁶³ Zenger, 1987, 108–113, 201.

beginning a fundamental difference in the Priestly Flood narrative from the Mesopotamian tradition as well as from the Scholarly Narrator's Flood narrative. In contrast to the Mesopotamian tradition, the Priestly Writing also attributes the coming of the Flood to a culpable corruption of the world. Whereas the Scholarly Narrator, along the exact same lines as the Mesopotamian tradition, provides no moral justification for the salvation of the Flood hero, the Priestly Writing – and, in its wake, also the present text (see Gen 7:1b [R]) – establishes right at the very beginning Noah's moral integrity, which distinguishes him from his contemporaries and on which the survival of living Creation hinges. This characterization of Noah coming before the mention of the corruption of the world shows already how important this idea was for the Priestly Writing. The term צַדִּיק,⁶⁴ whose translation into the English "righteous" is inadequate, signifies behavior defined by faithfulness to the orderings of the community. Noah – alongside Job and Daniel – is also described in Ezek 14:14 as צַדִּיק. This reference, which draws on earlier tradition and may accord with the Priestly Writing in this regard, alludes to Noah once being able to save even his sons through his righteousness, which would no longer be possible even for him (and Daniel and Job) in Ezekiel's time given the overwhelming guilt of the land (see Ezek 14:16, 18, 20). For תָּמִים, reference is often made to a cultic context, since the expression serves in the Priestly Writing as a technical term for the flawlessness of a sacrificial animal (see, e.g., Lev 9:2f.; 22:19, 21; 23:12). However, the assumption of this specific use being transferred to Noah's cultic and moral integrity is unnecessary,⁶⁵ since תָּמִים is frequently attested exactly in connection with the "walking" metaphor for denoting a blameless way of life (see Gen 17:1 [P], and further Ezek 28:15; Ps 15:2; 18:33; 101:2, 6; Prov 11:5; 28:18). According to the separation in the Masoretic accenting (see the Text-critical and Philological Note on v. 9 above), the Priestly Writing first highlights Noah's loyalty to the community (צַדִּיק) and then emphasizes his blameless way of life (תָּמִים) compared to "his generations." This is the only attestation of the phrase "in his generations" (בְּדֹרֹתָיו) in the Hebrew Bible. Priestly literature, in the broadest sense, uses the suffixed plural form elsewhere only with the preposition לְ "for" for designating the progression of offspring from generation to generation (see, e.g., Gen 17:7, 9, 12), while the Hebrew Bible expresses contemporaneity with the singular (so "[this] generation" in Gen 7:1; Exod 1:6; Num 32:13; Deut 1:35; Jer 2:31). This striking

⁶⁴ The only instance in the Priestly Writing of צַדִּיק being in a section influenced by the thinking of prophetic literature is no sufficient reason to connect the word with a later scribal adjustment [*Fortschreibung*]. Furthermore, its absence in the parallel verse of Gen 17:1 can be explained without assuming that it was added later in Gen 6:9. Cf. Levin, 1993, 114; Gertz, 2006, 51f.

⁶⁵ Cf. Gunkel, 143; Ruppert, 323; Westermann, 414.

phrase may have been formulated in view of the break in epochs marked by the Flood, emphasizing Noah's incomparable integrity among the generations both before and after.⁶⁶ The formulation "Noah walked with God" (*הלך hitp. + אֵת־הָאֱלֹהִים; v. 9b) points in a similar direction, echoing the similarly phrased judgment about Enoch (Gen 5:22, 24) and later resonating in the corresponding call of Abraham. There, however, as is typical within the Hebrew Bible, it speaks of walking "*before* God" (*הלך hitp. + לִפְנֵי; Gen 17:1). The formulation, consistent with the judgment about Enoch, proclaims Noah to be a worthy successor of Enoch, who is also set apart from his contemporaries. The taking up of Enoch that follows this judgment may even be compared to the judgment about and salvation of Noah, since both are saved from a (untimely) death at the hands of the Flood. The slight variation compared to Abraham and everyone thereafter who trusts in God can probably be explained by the fact that after the Flood, the immediacy of contact with God exists only to a limited extent.⁶⁷ Along the exact same lines, even Abraham is not judged as "righteous" (צַדִּיק) or "blameless" (תָּמִים) but is merely called upon to live a blameless (תָּמִים) way of life (Gen 17:1). This characterization of Noah is formulated in clear contrast to the subsequent judgment of the state of the world, according to which "all flesh had corrupted its way upon the earth." This corruption is founded in the rampant increase in violence and the destruction of the basic order of Creation (see Gen 6:11f.). Against this background, Noah, who is a faithful person of integrity towards God and his fellow human beings, who walks with God, and whom God commissions to lead the pairs of animals into the ark (Gen 6:19f.), is the one who fulfills the commission to rule over the earth according to Gen 1:28 and is proven to be the protector of Creation and the representative of God. In this respect, Noah embodies the "ideal type of Priestly anthropology."⁶⁸

6:11–12

- 11 *And the earth was corrupted before God, and the earth was filled with violence.*
 12 *And God saw the earth, and behold, it was corrupt, for all flesh had corrupted its way upon the earth.*

The presentation of the cause for the Flood transfers the attention from Noah to the state of the earth. The fact that the exemplarily pious Noah is

⁶⁶ See Jacob, 267.

⁶⁷ von Rad, 126; Blum, 1990, 293.

⁶⁸ See Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 241 [translation JWR].

contrasted with the corruption of the earth – the living space ordered by God – and not firstly with the behavior of his contemporaries is emphasized by the redundant narrative style. Like Noah previously, the earth is mentioned four times. The statement about the corruption of the earth is likewise presented four times, through the assertion of the state of the earth by the narrator (v. 11a), God’s own judgment of it (v. 12a), and repetitions of each with slight variations (vv. 11b, 12b) for the sake of clarification. The narrator describes the state reached as “corrupted” (*שחת ni. perf.), which gives in quite general terms the consequences of destructive behavior. The reference “before God” underscores the severity of the corruption,⁶⁹ which is explained by the narrator as the earth having been full of violence (חמס). The semantic range of this word, which is a central term for doom prophecy in the Hebrew Bible, reaches from economic exploitation (so Amos 3:10) and social humiliation (so Gen 16:5) to the consequences of false testimony (so Exod 23:1; Deut 19:16) and to physical assault, including the shedding of blood (so Gen 49:5; Judg 9:24; Ezek 7:23). Verse 11b also has these forms of both individual and societal violence in view. Moreover, the expression is especially intensified through God’s following judgment over the state of the earth: Verse 12a is clearly formulated to allude to the approval formula in Gen 1:31, with which God designates his entire work of creation as “very good.”⁷⁰ From the “And God saw everything that he had made, and behold, it was very good” now comes “And God saw the earth, and behold, it was corrupt.” Against the background of this contrasting resumptive repetition of the Creation account, it is clear that the statement “the earth is full (*מלא ni.) of violence” should be seen as an allusion to the blessing of multiplication, “fill (*מלא q. imp.) the earth” in Gen 1:28a. Like the allusion to the approval formula, this indicates the perversion of the original Creation: “The original creation blessing is perverted, and this becomes evident to God through the [earth].”⁷¹ The deeper cause of this perversion is illuminated through the following rationale for the divine judgment, according to which “all flesh” (*כל-בשר) has corrupted its way on the earth (v. 12b). This stands in parallel to the narrator’s assessment of the excess of violence on the earth (v. 11b), with each of the two verses guiding the reading of the other: The corruption of the earth consists in how the earth is full of violence through the action of all flesh (v. 13aβ). As unmistakably shown by the other uses in the Priestly Flood narrative, the phrase “all flesh” means

⁶⁹ See Arneth, 2007, 54 and fn. 125.

⁷⁰ See, among many others, already Procksch, 469.

⁷¹ Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 242 [translation JWR], with reference to Oberforcher, 1981, 413.

not only humanity but the animals as well (with the exception of fish):⁷² In Gen 6:13, 17; 7:21; 9:11, 15, the phrase refers to the victims of the Flood, i.e., the human beings (who are still mentioned as a separate group in Gen 7:21) as well as the land animals and birds, who all require the “breath of life” (Gen 6:17) according to the Hebrew Bible understanding. In Gen 6:19; 7:15f.; 8:17, the “all flesh” refers to the pairs of animals brought by Noah into the ark, and according to Gen 9:15–17 to the addressees of the covenant, which explicitly also includes the animal world. For Gen 6:12, this means that human and animal together bear responsibility for the corruption of the earth and, thus, for the coming of the Flood. In contrast to the Scholarly Narrator’s Flood narrative, the responsibility therefore does not lie in humanity alone. This corresponds to the fact that the Priestly Writing also explicitly names the animals as targeted by the decision for annihilation (Gen 6:17), while the Scholarly Narrator depicts their death as collateral damage (Gen 6:7, also Gen 7:4, 22). For the Priestly Writing, this kind of view, which still quite naïvely allows the animal world to suffer on account of humanity’s habitual wickedness, no longer seems compatible with God’s righteousness, and so it extrapolates the parties at fault for the catastrophe based on its victims: When God brings annihilation over the earth in a universal catastrophe (*שחית hi.; Gen 6:13; see Gen 6:17), rather than acting exorbitantly, he allows the annihilation to fall back onto those who initiated it (see v. 13b). This includes the animals, thus greatly increasing their significance compared to both the Mesopotamian tradition and the Scholarly Narrator’s Flood narrative. The end of the Flood narrative involves both contrasting cross-references to the Creation account and the modification of the original multiplication blessing from Gen 1:28; emerging from this is what signifies for Priestly Writing the violence brought about by “all flesh” and the reason for the corruption of the earth. According to Gen 1:29f., which follows the first blessing of multiplication, God assigns various plants as food to the land animals and birds, thus barring both humans and animals from the act of killing for purposes of nourishment. Genesis 9:1–7 repeats the blessing of multiplication from Gen 1:28 but places it under the auspices of humanity’s reign of terror over the animal world. Thus, this henceforth permits a regulated killing for food, while bloodguilt is demanded for the killing of a human being, whether by human or by animal (see Exod 21:28–32).

⁷² See H.-J. Stipp, 1999, and there also on the following, as well as on the fish (and the rest of the aquatic animals) who, with one exception (Lev 11:11), do not fall under “all flesh” in Priestly literature and are likewise unmentioned in the “nonviolent” allocation of food in Gen 1:29f. In any case, since they are not affected by a flood, they play no role in the Priestly argumentation.

In this way, the Flood changes the evaluation of killing for food. The comparison between the before and after clearly points to the ending: The violence with which human and animal filled the earth and which brought about the coming of the Flood is the uncontrolled and exorbitant killing by all living beings on the earth, thus perverting the original order of Creation. In this sense, we can also speak of a special responsibility of humanity, who, in its tacit approval of carnivorous animals, has not lived up to its commission to rule over the earth.

6:13–16

- 13** *Then God said to Noah, “The end of all flesh has come before me, for the earth is full of violence because of them. And behold, I will corrupt them with the earth.*
- 14** *Make for yourself an ark out of gofer wood. You shall make the ark out of reed [?] and you shall coat it inside and out with pitch.*
- 15** *And thus shall you make it: 300 cubits is the length of the ark, 50 cubits its width and 30 cubits its height.*
- 16** *You shall make a roof [?] for the ark and after a cubit, you shall stop it upwards [?], and you shall install an opening of the ark on its side; you shall make a lower, a second, and a third [story].*

God’s speech to Noah is structured into two parts. The first part begins with the communication of God’s judgment of the state of the world (v. 13a) and his announcement of the divine intervention (v. 13b). This is followed by the instructions for constructing the ark (vv. 14–16). Even the very choice of the key term “violence” (חַמָּסָה; vv. 11, 13), which is otherwise unattested in the Priestly Writing, shows the influence of doom prophecy upon the Priestly Writing in its description of the state of the world. God’s assessment that “The end (אַחֵרֶת) of all flesh has come before me (בְּפָנַי)” confirms this impression. This is a quotation from Amos 8:2 mediated by Ezek 7:2–6.⁷³ The two prophetic references are related to the downfall of the people of Israel/Judah and Jerusalem. The similarities are unmistakable and, moreover, are limited to Gen 6:13 and these two prophetic references (but see further Jer 51:13; Hab 2:3). Consequently, the phrasing of Gen 6:13 should have and must have evoked in the Priestly Writing’s intended audience an association with the interpretation of their own exilic existence through doom prophecy.

Amos 8:2: “The end has come [אַחֵרֶת אָבָה] upon my people, Israel.”

⁷³ See Zimmerli, 1969, 169f.; Smend, 1986.

Ezek 7:2–6*, 23b: “Thus says the Lord Yhwh to the Land of Israel: ‘[The] end [has come]^{LXX}, the end has come [בָּא הַקֵּץ] upon the four ends of the earth! Now, the end is upon you... [the] end has come, the end has come, the end [הַקֵּץ] is presumably an orthographic variant of [הַקֵּץ] upon you; see, it has come! ... For the land is full of bloodguilt and the city is full of violence [הַמָּס]!’”

Gen 6:13: “Then God said to Noah, ‘The end of all flesh [קֵץ כָּל-בָּשָׂר] has come before me [בָּא], for the earth is full of violence [הַמָּס] because of them. And behold, I will corrupt them with the earth.’”

However, the Priestly Writing did project the prophetic announcement as the “end of all flesh” back into primeval times and establish its ultimate defeat through God’s promise of maintaining existence after the Flood. In this way, it gave the prophetic announcement of “the end” a worldwide dimension while, at the same time, considerably relativizing the prophetic interpretation of the exile as an experience of the end times (see Lam 4:18).⁷⁴ The striking phrase “The end of all flesh has come before me” is explicable only as a quotation and allusion, and the exact meaning of the phrase is disputed. The classic view is that it concerns God’s “decree of destruction.”⁷⁵ Thus, the NRSV translates it as, “I have determined to make an end of all flesh.” However, speaking against this is that *בוא + לְפָנַי + suff. literally means “to come before [sb.]” (see Num 27:17; 1 Sam 18:16; Ps 79:11; 88:3; 100:2) and that the use for a decision that has been taken has no analogy; a formulation with the verbs *כלה “to be decided” (1 Sam 20:7, 9; 25:17; Est 7:7), *יעץ “to decide” (Isa 14:24), or *הרץ “to determine” (Isa 10:22) would be expected instead. The decisive factor, however, is the structure of vv. 11–13.⁷⁶ Following the description of the present state of the earth in v. 11 and God’s observation of and judgment upon this condition in v. 12 is God’s corresponding communication to Noah in v. 13a: All flesh has reached its end because it has corrupted the earth as a living space, and thus its own basis of life, through violence. Only in v. 13b does God announce his imminent intervention, which is signaled by a change in tense (*futurum instans*). Through the already corrupted earth (*שחת ni.; v. 11, 12a), God will corrupt (*שחת hi.; v. 13b) human and animal, who are responsible for the corruption (*שחת hi.; v. 12b).⁷⁷

The instructions for building the ark pose significant philological difficulties. They also provide no technically complete construction plan, but they do follow a recognizable logic. First, the text gives the material (v. 14),

⁷⁴ Smend, 1986, 157f.

⁷⁵ Smend, 1986, 156 and fn. 14, citing Johann Adam Osiander (*Commentarius in Pentateuchum*, 1676: “decretum est mihi”) among others as a precursor of the current translation. For the more recent commentaries, see Westermann, 417f.; Ruppert, 325f.

⁷⁶ See further Steck, 1991, 297f.

⁷⁷ See Seebaß, 210; Baumgart, 1999, 225; Schüle, 2006, 263.

and then the dimensions (v. 15), followed by details for the construction of the ark (v. 16a) and its internal layout (v. 16b) that are important for understanding the narrative.⁷⁸ Noah's vessel is not called a "ship" by the Priestly Writing and the Scholarly Narrator but is reduced to its form as תִּבְיָה "box" (elsewhere only Exod 2:3, 5 for Moses's small basket; the English word "ark" is derived from the Latin translation as *arca*). The ark is to be built of "gofer wood," which is mentioned only here; the actual type of wood is unknown. Even the LXX gives no further information and speaks simply of "wood." The following details are also unclear. The Masoretic text reads קָנִים, which is the plural of קָן "nest" and is attested in this form only here. It corresponds to the LXX's νοσιστά and is typically interpreted as an expression for chambers. However, this detail concerning interior construction comes too early, and the repeated suggestion of rearranging it to come after v. 16a⁷⁹ remains speculative so long as the origin of the present state of the text cannot be plausibly explained. On the other hand, the vocalization proposed here, קָנִים, the plural form of קָנָה "reed," would correspond to ancient shipbuilding, since waterlogged reeds were used to seal the joints between larger timbers.⁸⁰ The ark is then to be coated (*כַּפֵּר) with pitch (כָּפָר) from the outside and inside. This is the only attestation in the Hebrew Bible of כָּפָר (elsewhere חָמַר; see Gen 11:3; 14:10; Exod 2:3) and is reminiscent of the Akkadian *kupru* "bitumen," which was also used in shipbuilding and is likewise also attested in the Mesopotamian tradition of the Great Flood myth (see Atr 3.1.33; Gilg. 11.55, 66). The specifications given for the measurements yield a cuboid. The length of a cubit (אַמָּה) was approx. 45 cm, which results in dimensions of approx. 135 m × 17.5 m × 13.5 m. When instead using the Egyptian cubit of approx. 52 cm, which the Hebrew Bible sometimes notes as a peculiarity (Ezek 40:5ff.; 43:13), the dimensions would have been approx. 156 m × 26 m × 15.6 m. Some of the specifications given about the details of the ark's construction are virtually incomprehensible. The word translated here as "roof," צֹהַר, is the third hapax legomenon within the building instructions. Some of the ancient translations understood this word as "window" (Vulg; see also Tg. Onq. "light"), but this translation was probably deduced from the back reference "the window [חִלּוֹן] that he had made" (Gen 8:6 [SN]). Speaking in favor of the translation as "roof" is the Akkadian *ṣēru* "back / upper side" (also Arabic *ṣahr* "back / surface / ship deck") and the structure of the ark being a micro-cosmos that is naturally in need of an equivalent to the heavenly firmament, since during the Great Flood, the latter

⁷⁸ Jacob, 187.

⁷⁹ So, e.g., Gunkel, 143f.

⁸⁰ See Ullendorff, 1954; Strömberg-Krantz, 1982, 171–173; Day, 2013, 113–122.

does not keep the primordial floodwaters away from the earth and from the passengers on the ark (Gen 7:11). The note “after a cubit, you shall stop it upwards” is utterly puzzling. It may be indicative of a slight slope in the roof (so Rashi). The door on the side is specifically mentioned because it is important for Noah, his family, and the animals to go in and out and, because of the roof (?), the ark cannot be loaded from the top as was typical of ships in antiquity. The ark has three stories, corresponding to the Priestly conception of the structure of the world.

The building instructions are reminiscent of those in the Priestly Writing for the tent sanctuary, the only other “building” described in the Pentateuch.⁸¹ The instructions are given with similar wording (impt. of *עשה “to make/do” + ל with the personal suffix + object) and each directly from God (Gen 6:13a, 14a; Exod 25:1, 8a). Both “buildings” are residences (Gen 6:18–20; Exod 25:8b), with an elongated shape like the Jerusalem temple, partially of wood, and covered on top (see Exod 26). The ark is ten times as long as the tent sanctuary, and its floors are each just as high. The notice in Exod 39:42 about the tent sanctuary being built is likewise reminiscent of the same notice for the ark in Gen 6:22. There are further compositional and conceptional similarities alongside these correspondences. The uses of the buildings are each embedded within the making of a covenant (Gen 6:18; 9:8–17; Exod 29:45f. via Exod 6:4–7 and the Abrahamic covenant in Gen 17:7–8). The end of the Flood falls on the first day of the first month (Gen 8:13a [P]), corresponding to the date of when the tent sanctuary is first pitched (Exod 40:2, 17). Additionally, there is the respective reference to the Priestly Creation account (see above, pp. 89f. on Gen 2:1–3). Finally, it should also be considered that the connection between the temple and the Flood vessel was already existent in the Mesopotamian tradition.⁸² Thus, Utnapištim’s vessel, with its 60 m × 60 m × 60 m dimensions and its seven floors (Gilg 11.58–63), is also more reminiscent of the ideal spatial conception of a temple, which represents the cosmos, than of a (seaworthy) ship.

6:17–21

- 17** *And I, behold, I am about to let the Great Flood, that is, water, come over the earth in order to corrupt all flesh under the heavens that has the breath of life in it; all that is upon the earth will perish.*
- 18** *With you, however, I shall establish my covenant, and you shall go into the ark, you and your sons and your wife and the wives of your sons with you.*
- 19** *From all living beings, from all flesh, you shall bring two of each into the ark to survive with you; they shall be male and female.*

⁸¹ For the fundamental aspects, see Jacob, 187–194; Zenger, 1987, 174f.; Pola, 1995, 286–290, 367; Baumgart, 1999, 531–542.

⁸² Baumgart, 1999, 506–526.

- 20** *From the flying animals according to their kind, from the livestock according to their kind, from all crawling animals of the ground according to their kind. Two of each shall come to you to survive.*
- 21** *You, however: Take from all that can be eaten and collect it with you, so that it can serve as food for you and for them."*

The second part of God's speech begins in v. 17 by repeating the announcement of the coming annihilation from v. 13. Both verses largely correspond to each other, although v. 17 merely gives concrete form to the imminent destruction (*futurum instans*, like in v. 13) as the Great Flood (מבול). The term מבול is a thematic word throughout the Priestly Flood narrative (Gen 7:6, 7, 17; 9:11, 15, 28; see the summary of the events under the heading מבול in the Priestly dating in Gen 10:1, 32; 11:10). Outside of the redactional use in Gen 7:10b, the only other attestation in the Hebrew Bible is in Ps 29:10. There, corresponding to the spatial conception of the Priestly Writing, it describes the heavenly ocean located above the heavenly firmament, over which Yhwh is then enthroned according to Ps 29. Its waters are to come upon the earth and annihilate all flesh under the heavens that needs air to breathe. This draws on Gen 1:9, where the gathering of the waters "under the heavens" brings forth land and, thus, the living space for humanity, birds, and land animals. The water retakes possession of this living space, with the notices "over the earth" and "upon the earth" in v. 17 comprising the threat and describing the extension of the water across the horizontal plane, while "under the heavens" deals with the vertical extension. At first glance, it may appear as though the floodwaters fill up the entire living space like an aquarium, with the world being pushed back into the chaos from before its creation. However, this is clearly not the case. The heavenly firmament remains intact. It is not destroyed but merely opens its "hatches" (unmentioned in Gen 1), just as the springs of the deep also open (see Gen 7:11 [P]). Even if, during the Flood, the waters overtake the high mountaintops by 15 cubits (so Gen 7:19f. [P]), there is still room for the ark. Thus, it does not come to a complete elimination of space, and the waters do not mix themselves back into the primordial chaos from before the creation of the world (Gen 1:2 [P]). Accordingly, the end of the Flood is not described as a new Creation but as a purely technical process in which the waters are "turned off," so to speak (see Gen 8:1, 2a [P]). The Great Flood thus results from a partial and temporary elimination of Creation but does not plunge the world back into the state before it was created.⁸³

Standing in sharp contrast to the second announcement of the coming annihilation of "all that is upon the earth" (v. 17b) is God's promise to

⁸³ See Schmidt, 1973, 105f. and fn. 7; Steck, 1981, 146 fn. 586. Cf., e.g., Gunkel, 78, 145f.

establish a covenant (בְּרִית) with Noah (v. 18). With it, God imposes his own commitment upon himself to save Noah and, with him, life on earth. This content of the covenant can be inferred from what follows; it emphasizes the command for Noah to go into the ark together with his wife, his sons and daughters-in-law, and one male and one female representative of each kind of animal on earth (vv. 18b–20). The covenant, made exclusively with Noah, is for the preservation of life on earth and is thus what enables the making of another covenant at the end of the Flood in Gen 9:9f. with Noah, his descendants, the animals that are saved, and their descendants. In this respect, the covenant with Noah before the Flood and the covenant with the survivors and their descendants after the Flood cannot be seen as one covenant, but they are clearly related to each other. The list of the animal species taken into the ark, which is repeated with slight variations throughout the course of the Flood narrative (Gen 7:14–16, 21; 8:19; 9:2f., 10), unmistakably draws on the Creation account: It is important that representatives of all previously created species are saved into the postdiluvian world, as is unequivocally shown by the two mentions of Noah needing to preserve the lives of all the animals taken in (vv. 19, 20). The following command to collect and load vegetable food (v. 21) also draws on the Creation account. Only one pair of each animal is to be taken, in order to ensure the survival of the species (vv. 19, 20). Accordingly, while on the ark, both animal and human feed solely on the plants that Noah also brought into the ark, in accordance with the assignment of food in Gen 1:29f. Only after the Flood does this change with the allowance of meat consumption, which was identified before the Flood as violence and the cause of the corruption of the earth (see Gen 6:11–13). Even just the example of food shows quite nicely how the Priestly Writing is not so much interested in the realities of what it reports. Rather, all of the reported details concern theologically relevant cross-references in its content, with which it emphasizes the continuity and discontinuity between the antediluvian and postdiluvian worlds as well as the advent of the catastrophe and the lasting overcoming of it. This is also confirmed through the notice of Noah following these commands, which is formulated extremely economically compared to the Mesopotamian tradition. Everything that the Mesopotamian tradition seeks to report about the construction, the organization of the craftsmen, and the deception of curious contemporaries could have also been narrated for Noah but is never mentioned. Instead, God's command is followed by a notice of the commands being carried out that is typical of the Priestly Writing (so Exod 40:16!). Noah, the exemplar of righteousness and blamelessness, obeys – nothing more needs to be said.

In the Priestly Writing, what originally followed was the dating of the Flood and the entry into the ark, described in detail in Gen 7:6–7, 11, 13–16a.

7:1–5

- 1 *And Yhwh said to Noah, “Go, you and your whole house into the ark, for I have seen you as righteous before me in this generation.*
- 2 *From all clean livestock, take with you seven of each, a male and its mate, and from the livestock that is not clean, two, a male and its mate,*
- 3 *[also from the flying animals of the heavens, seven of each, male and female,] in order to secure offspring on the entire earth.*
- 4 *For after seven days, I shall bring rain upon the earth forty days and forty nights, and I shall wipe away all that exists, which I have made, from the surface of the ground.”*
- 5 *Then Noah did according to all that Yhwh had commanded him.*

The core of this section comes from the Scholarly Narrator, while the notice about Noah’s righteousness in v. 1b and the bringing of the birds in v. 3a stem from the Redaction. The recourse to the Priestly characterization of Noah in v. 1b (צַדִּיק; see Gen 6:9) interrupts the chiastically formulated command to board the ark (v. 1a) and to take the animals on board (v. 2). Furthermore, this command has its own proper justification through the statement about the purpose of the ark and the reference to the Great Flood in vv. 3a, 4. Moreover, the reference to Noah’s righteousness dulls the assertion in Gen 6:8 that Noah was allowed to survive solely because he “found favor in the eyes of Yhwh” with no reason given for this favor.⁸⁴ This, then, also indicates the intention of the addition: balancing the idea of preservation due to Yhwh’s grace (Gen 6:8 [SN]) and preservation due to personal piety (6:9 [P]).⁸⁵ Thereafter, the Redaction omitted the Scholarly Narrator’s instructions for building the ark, which it presupposes in v. 1a, in favor of the Priestly version (see Formation above). Whether v. 3a is also a product of the Redaction or of a different glossator is impossible to answer. This sub-verse can be identified as a later addition even just from the “also” (גַּם), which is not used in the other listings of the animal world. Analogous to the later addition of the animal series in Gen 6:7*, the flying animals were also added here, with the Redactor taking up the number “seven” from the immediately preceding context but orienting himself towards the Priestly Writing with the wording “male and female” (זָכָר וּנְקֵבָה; see Gen 1:27; 5:2; 6:19; 7:9, 16). The gloss was prompted by the mention of birds during the sacrifice (Gen 8:20), while

⁸⁴ See Levin, 1993, 114; Witte, 1998, 76 and fn. 110. Also independent of the theory of a Yahwist, Levin’s reference to Gen 18:3; 19:19; Exod 34:9 should have settled the argument about Gen 6:8, without the justification given by the Priestly Writing, being “bulky” in its context and Gen 6:8 therefore being evaluated as an expansion of the Priestly Writing. So, e.g., Bosshard-Nepustil, 2005, 67f.

⁸⁵ Following Levin, 1993, 114; Witte, 1998, 76.

the Scholarly Narrator was primarily concerned with the animal world more generally surviving alongside humanity, which is why he did not mention birds specifically.⁸⁶ The SP then concluded based on the number “seven” in v. 3a that, analogous to v. 2, these must be clean animals, and it supplemented the text accordingly (“and from the *clean* flying animals of the heavens, seven of each, male and female”). This, in turn, led to the difficulty that unclean birds, such as the raven (see Gen 8:6), would have never come onto the ark to begin with, thus prompting the LXX also to expand the text accordingly (“also from the *clean* flying animals of the heavens, seven of each, male and female, and from the *not-clean flying animals of the heavens, two of each, male and female*”). These additions may not be particularly weighty in their content, but they show quite nicely the working method of ancient scriptural interpretation and transmission, whose beginnings reach back even to the formation of the biblical texts themselves, as v. 3a already shows. Such editorial adjustments are the result of exegetical efforts and were to be understood as explicating the supposed meaning – in this case, necessarily taking birds onto the ark from Gen 8:20.

In the present text, the section combines with Gen 8:15–19 to form an internal frame around the depiction of the Flood. In spite of the careful work of the Redaction, the connection of the two versions of the Flood narrative has led to some tensions precisely because of this section. Since, according to v. 4, Noah follows the earlier command to board the ark with the animals, the inconsistency comes in the connection with the Priestly Writing: The boarding of the ark is again prepared for in detail in Gen 7:7–9 and then presented in Gen 7:15. There are further inconsistencies regarding both the distinction between clean and unclean animals as well as chronology. For Noah’s sacrifice, the Scholarly Narrator wanted more animals suitable for sacrifice available on the ark so that their survival is not immediately endangered once more right after the Great Flood because of Noah’s sacrifice. Conversely, the Priestly Writing makes no mention of the sacrifice present in the Mesopotamian tradition (see Atr 3.5.34f.; Gilgm 11.157–163), since in its conception, the sacrificial cult is established only at Sinai; it limits itself only to the aspect of the survival of all species of animals. Now, to the chronology: Verse 4a begins the mentions of days in which, after an initial period of seven days, the Flood begins and extends over forty days of rain and an equally long period of waiting it out, following two periods of seven days, the earth drying up, and Noah venturing out of the ark (see Gen 7:10a, 12; 8:6, 10, 12 [SN] and 7:17* [R]). This sequence clearly distinguishes itself from the

⁸⁶ See already Budde, 1883, 257f. and further Gunkel, 62; Westermann, 428; Seebaß, 213; Baumgart, 1999, 412. Additionally, Levin, 1993, 111 and Witte, 1998, 76 judge v. 3b to be redactional as well.

Priestly chronology, which reckons with a clearly longer duration of the Flood and is characterized by precise dates, even if they are difficult to understand (see on Gen 7:11 below). For the early notice of Noah entering the ark, as well as the insertion of the chronological details, no convincing reasons can be given for why an editor would have caused these tensions – unless bound to earlier material like in the conception of a source model.⁸⁷ For the distinction between clean and unclean animals, it could of course be argued that this was the concern of an editor of the Priestly Writing, but this differentiation could have also been added directly into the text of the Priestly Writing without any trouble and without causing problems in its coherence (see only Gen 7:8* [R]).

7:1a

And Yhwh said to Noah, “Go, you and your whole house into the ark,

In the Scholarly Narrator’s Flood narrative, what comes after the (assumed but no longer preserved) instructions for building the ark is the command for entering it. Unlike in the precise listing of Noah’s family members in the Priestly Writing, here, only “Noah and his house” are mentioned. This coheres with the larger conception of the Scholarly Narrator: Unlike the Priestly Writing, he has no interest in the differentiation of Noah’s descendants. Instead, he concentrates entirely on the person of Noah and mentions here only what he thinks to be necessary for humanity’s survival.

7:2, 3b

- 2** *From all clean livestock, take with you seven of each, a male and its mate, and from the livestock that is not clean, two, a male and its mate,*
3b *in order to secure offspring on the entire earth.*

Like the other Flood heroes, Noah is to bring aboard “from all livestock” in order to ensure the survival of all the fauna of the earth (also Gilgm 11.86). The differentiation into clean and unclean animals is predefined through the sacrifice at the end of the Great Flood (Gen 8:20). This differentiation into animals suitable for sacrifice and those not usable for it has a long tradition in (not only) the ancient Near East and is certainly not dependent upon the Priestly purity laws, especially since the Priestly technical term “unclean” (טמא [*טמא]) would be expected instead of the “not clean.” The expression

⁸⁷ Cf. Bosshard-Nepustil, 2005, 62–66, 62, who speaks of “ad-hoc additions to the basic P layer” [translation JWR]. On this “ad-hoc hypothesis,” see Gertz, 2006, 49–51.

“a male and its mate,” which concludes both statements about the animals in v. 2, is slightly reminiscent of formulations in the Garden narrative (see Gen 2:22f.) but is not otherwise attested. The formulation is a further indication that the author is not dependent upon P. As shown by the redactional “male and female” in v. 3a, which is typical for the Priestly Writing and is also used in Gen 6:19, the Redaction did not change earlier wordings without reason for doing so.⁸⁸ The reference to the purpose of the ark – ensuring the survival of life on earth (v. 3b) – forms the contrast to the following announcement of the Great Flood. Again, the differences from the parallel in P are striking (לְחַיֹּת וְרַע “in order to secure offspring” in v. 3b [SN] vs. לְחַיִּיתָ “to survive” in Gen 6:19, 20 [P]).

7:4–5

- 4 *For after seven days, I shall bring rain upon the earth forty days and forty nights, and I shall wipe away all that exists, which I have made, from the surface of the ground.”*
 5 *Then Noah did according to all that Yhwh had commanded him.*

The Scholarly Narrator understands the Flood as having resulted from a continuous forty days of rain and knows nothing about the springs of the deep and the heavenly hatches breaking open (Gen 7:11 [P]). Should this be a redactional preparation for the Priestly description of the Flood, some sort of corresponding formulation would be expected. There may be an echo of the Mesopotamian tradition in the seven-day period before the rains come, as it attests to a seven-day length of the Flood (see Atr 3.1.36f.; 4.24f.; Gilg 11.144–148). However, the number “seven” can be sufficiently explained otherwise, by the prominence that it held across the ancient Near East in cultic contexts and for the periodization of time. Similar can be said of the forty-day length. As tenfold the number “four,” which in turn represents the whole of the cosmos (see, e.g., above on Gen 2:10–14 and the four rivers of the Garden), the number “forty” stands for completeness. One generation lasts forty years; correspondingly, the (unknown) lengths of the reigns of David and Solomon are also each set at forty years (2 Sam 5:4; 1 Kgs 2:11; 11:42), as is the period of the wilderness wanderings (e.g., Deut 2:7; 8:4). Moses spends forty days and forty nights atop Mount Sinai (Exod 24:18; 34:28; Deut 9:9, 11, 25; 10:10); Elijah spends forty days and nights trekking to the Mountain of God (1 Kgs 19:8), and Jesus spends forty days in the desert (Matt 4:2 and parallels). Through the phrases “I shall

⁸⁸ Cf. Arnoth, 2007, 194 and fn. 285, who sees in “a male and its mate” a necessary specification of “male and female,” which, however, has “created a dilemma” [translation JWR].

wipe away [*מחה]... from the surface of the ground” and “which I have made [*עשה],” v. 4 refers back to the Scholarly Narrator’s prologue (Gen 6:7). Insofar as it concerns the consequences of God’s actions and not the correspondence between guilt and punishment, and unlike in Gen 6:7, this has not only humanity in view but the entire work of Creation (“all that exists”). Here too does the Scholarly Narrator use his own formulation without recourse to the expressions in the Priestly Writing, which would be expected for redactional activity.⁸⁹ The formulation in v. 4b is often interpreted as Noah only now learning of the threat of the Great Flood.⁹⁰ This is possible, but because it assumes a textual omission, it cannot be decided with any certainty. Verse 5 is a short notice of Noah following Yhwh’s commands, which makes the search for a report of going into the ark by the Scholarly Narrator unnecessary.⁹¹ Because of the proximity to Gen 6:22 (P), it is also worth considering that the verse may have been reshaped by the Redaction in order to parallel the two divine speeches in Gen 6:13–22 and 7:1–5. However, this assumption is not necessary, either. The narrative thread by the Scholarly Narrator is taken back up in Gen 7:16b, 10a, 12.

7:6–16

- 6 *Noah was 600 years old when the Great Flood came – waters upon the earth.*
- 7 *And Noah went, and his sons and his wife and the wives of his sons with him, into the ark, from before the waters of the Great Flood.*
- 8 *From the clean livestock and from the livestock that was not clean, and from the flying animals, and from all that crawls upon the ground,*
- 9 *two of each went into the ark to Noah, male and female, as God had commanded Noah.*
- 10 *When the seven days were over, then the waters of the Great Flood were upon the earth.*
- 11 *In the year in which Noah’s lifetime numbered 600 years, in the second month, on the seventeenth day of the month, on this day, all the springs of the great primordial flood burst forth and the hatches of the heavens opened up.*
- 12 *Then came rain upon the earth, forty days and forty nights.*
- 13 *On this very day, Noah went into the ark, as did Shem and Ham and Japheth, the sons of Noah, and Noah’s wife and the three wives of his sons with them,*

⁸⁹ Cf. Arnoeth, 2007, 195.

⁹⁰ So already Budde, 1883, 256, who sees here the motif of a test of faith.

⁹¹ Following Levin, 1993, 112; Witte, 1998, 178. Cf., e.g., Kratz, 2005, 256f., who identifies here another gap within the non-Priestly text.

- 14 *they and all wild animals according to their kind and all livestock according to their kind and all crawling animals that crawl upon the earth according to their kind, and all flying animals according to their kind [every bird, everything with wings].*
- 15 *And they went into the ark to Noah, two of each from all flesh that has the breath of life in it.*
- 16 *And those that went in: A male and a female from all flesh, they went in, as God had commanded him. And Yhwh shut [it] behind him.*

The essentials of the description of the entry into the ark (vv. 7–9, 13–16) and the coming of the Flood (vv. 10–12) are based in the Priestly Writing (vv. 6–7, 11, 13–16a). The Redaction was responsible for the remarks about the animals (vv. 8–9) and the chronology (vv. 10, 12) that account for the depiction by the Scholarly Narrator in Gen 7:1–5. It is difficult to determine whether the Redaction repurposed material from the Scholarly Narrator’s Flood narrative in vv. 10, 12 or whether it formulated these verses independently based on Gen 7:4. Speaking *prima facie* in favor of the second alternative is that the notice about Yhwh closing the ark in v. 16b connects well to the notice in Gen 7:5. However, the chronological details from vv. 10a, 12 also connect well to the announcement of the Great Flood in Gen 7:4 and would, in this case, be missing from the Scholarly Narrator’s Flood narrative. For this reason, it is likely that the Redaction actually used such “spolia” here. Since v. 16b uses the divine name “Yhwh” immediately following the “as God had commanded him” in v. 16a for no apparent reason and for the first time since Gen 7:5, it is unlikely that the notice came from the Redaction. It should rather be considered that it was taken from its original position behind v. 5 in order to conclude the section about the entry into the ark that was reworked by the Redaction.

7:6–7

- 6 *Noah was 600 years old when the Great Flood came – waters upon the earth.*
- 7 *And Noah went, and his sons and his wife and the wives of his sons with him, into the ark, from before the waters of the Great Flood.*

In the Priestly narrative of the Great Flood, v. 6 was the heading for the middle section, the depiction of the Flood, which lasts until Gen 8:14. In the present text, this structure has been maintained with slight variations, insofar as the depiction of the Flood is now more extensive because of the integration of the Scholarly Narrator’s version and now has a stronger internal structure. The initial “Noah” in v. 6 marks the beginning of a new section. The statement

about Noah being 600 years old during the Flood is in line with the statement about Noah's age at the fathering of Shem in Gen 5:32 (P). It is then taken up in the statement about how long he lives after the Flood and the age he reaches in Gen 9:28f. (P). The wording of v. 6b refers back to the announcement of the Flood in Gen 6:17 (P). Verse 7 continues with the remark about Noah and his family boarding the ark. This formulation corresponds verbatim to Gen 6:18b β (P), while the phrase "before the waters of the Great Flood" comes from Gen 6:17 (P; see also Gen 9:11 [P]). Both speak clearly against the widespread assumption that v. 7 is the non-Priestly version of the entry into the ark.⁹² The reasons given for this assumption are, firstly, the consideration already rejected (see on v. 5 above) that this version must have also contained a corresponding notice and, secondly, that v. 7 should be considered a doublet of vv. 11–16a.⁹³ However, v. 7 can be understood quite well as a narrative introduction to vv. 13–16a that is clearly still related to the heading through the emphasized "before the waters of the Great Flood." In contrast, vv. 11, 13–16a provide a detailed account of the entering into the ark following the exact dating of the beginning of the Flood in v. 11. The closing formulae in vv. 9b and 16a then relate the introduction and the occurrence to one another.

7:8–9

- 8 *From the clean livestock and from the livestock that was not clean,*
 and from the flying animals, and from all that crawls upon the ground,
 9 *two of each went into the ark to Noah, male and female, as God had*
 commanded Noah.

This redactional passage about the animals going into the ark attempts to smooth out the differentiation between clean and unclean animals in the Scholarly Narrator's version and the Priestly conception of the animals going into the ark in pairs.⁹⁴ Verse 8 mentions the birds and the crawling animals over and above Gen 7:2 and in accordance with the Priestly lists of animals. Verse 9 largely corresponds to v. 15, which is indisputably part of the basic Priestly Writing material.

Since, in contrast to the livestock and birds, the introductory particle מִן "from" is missing for the crawling animals, some consider v. 8 to be literarily uneven. This is then partially understood as v. 8f. belonging to the Priestly Writing, with the beginning of the list of animals having fallen victim to a redactional reworking in

⁹² Following Ruppert, 342; Witte, 1998, 136.

⁹³ See Budde, 1883, 258; Gunkel, 63.

⁹⁴ Budde, 1883, 260; Westermann, 431; Ruppert, 292; Seebaß, 215, 230; Witte, 1998, 77.

light of Gen 7:2.⁹⁵ This is doubtful, however, because the formulation כל אֲשֶׁר + part. (‘‘all that crawls upon the ground’’) differs from Priestly usage in several respects. In this context, relative clauses are always formed with a verbal form (see, alongside Gen 9:2; Lev 20:25, also Gen 1:21) and the phrase עַל־הָאֲדָמָה (‘‘upon the ground’’) is not attested in the Priestly Writing. Rather, for the Priestly Writing, כל + part. עַל הָאָרֶץ + רִמַּשׁ (‘‘all that crawls upon the earth’’; see Gen 7:14; 8:19 and further Gen 1:26, 28, 30; 7:21; 8:17) would be expected. This suggests that the Redactor formulated his ‘‘mixed text’’ following the examples of the Scholarly Narrator (see Gen 7:2) and the Priestly Writing (see Gen 7:15).

7:10

When the seven days were over, then the waters of the Great Flood were upon the earth.

In accordance with Gen 7:4, the Scholarly Narrator’s version tells of forty days of continuous rain (v. 12) beginning after the conclusion of seven days (v. 10a). After it stops, Noah waits another forty days (Gen 8:6) before sending out a dove for the first time and then two more times, each seven days apart, until he knows that the Flood is over (Gen 8:8–12; Gen 8:7 and the sending out of the raven are a later addition; see on Gen 8:6–12 below). These details are not reconcilable with the Priestly chronology, which is why the Redaction explained the forty days of continuous rain as one partial aspect of the waters of the heavenly ocean crashing to the earth by placing v. 12 after the Priestly notice about the coming of the Great Flood in v. 11. Traces of this differentiation have been left in v. 10. Like in Gen 7:4, the seven-day period also applies to the onset of the catastrophe, but unlike in its original context from the Scholarly Narrator, it no longer speaks of rain but instead, in accordance with the Priestly Writing, of the coming of the waters of the Great Flood (see 6:17; 7:6b, 7). This thus leads to the dramatic account of the Flood breaking loose in v. 11.

7:11–16

- 11 *In the year in which Noah’s lifetime numbered 600 years, in the second month, on the seventeenth day of the month, on this day, all the springs of the great primordial flood burst forth and the hatches of the heavens opened up.*
- 12 *Then came rain upon the earth, forty days and forty nights.*
- 13 *On this very day, Noah went into the ark, as did Shem and Ham and Japheth, the sons of Noah, and Noah’s wife and the three wives of his sons with them,*

⁹⁵ Arneth, 2007, 64f.

- 14 *they and all wild animals according to their kind and all livestock according to their kind and all crawling animals that crawl upon the earth according to their kind, and all flying animals according to their kind [every bird, everything with wings].*
- 15 *And they went into the ark to Noah, two of each from all flesh that has the breath of life in it.*
- 16 *And those that went in: A male and a female from all flesh, they went in, as God had commanded him. And Yhwh shut [it] behind him.*

Verse 11 picks back up the thread from the Priestly Writing, which dates the beginning of the Flood to precisely the seventeenth day of the second month in the 600th year of Noah's life. Thus, accordingly, Noah was 599 years old when the Flood arrived. This statement may seem to contradict v. 6, according to which Noah was 600 years old during the Flood. The alleged contradiction is resolved, however, when including the information about the end of the Flood being in the 601st year of Noah's life (Gen 8:13) and then understanding v. 6 as a heading to the entire sequence of events for the Flood.⁹⁶

The synchronization of Gen 7:6 with Gen 7:11; 8:13 is still the easiest problem to solve that is posed by the Flood narrative's chronology.⁹⁷ The smooth integration of the Scholarly Narrator's "round" numbers into the exact dating system of the Priestly Writing was also quite successful, with some harmonizing tendencies: The seven-day period before the coming of the catastrophe (Gen 7:4, 10a) lies outside all of the Priestly Writing's calculations. Above all, the forty days of rain, which is the catastrophe itself according to Gen 7:4 (SN), is explained through the sequence of Gen 7:11 (P) and Gen 7:12 (SN) as a phase within the Great Flood. Similar can be said for the statement that Noah lets seven days pass in each case before sending the dove out to fly for the second and third times (Gen 8:10, 12).

However, the numbers in the Priestly Writing do cause problems, both on the level of the Priestly Writing when read by itself as well as on the level of the present text. The exact dating of the beginning of the Flood to the seventeenth day of the second month of the six-hundredth year of Noah's life is continued in Gen 8:4 (the ark making landfall on the 600th day of the seventh month), 8:5 (the mountaintops becoming visible on the first day of the tenth month), 8:13 (the Flood ending on the first day of the first month of the following year) and 8:13 (the earth becoming dry again on the twenty-seventh day of the second month). This series is connected via Gen 8:3f. with the declaration that the waters rise for 150 days and then begin to sink (Gen 7:24; 8:3). What is the problem here? According to Gen 7:11 and 8:13, the Flood lasts one calendar year and ten days, or eleven days when counting

⁹⁶ Following Witte, 1998, 115, 134. Cf. Ruppert, 299.

⁹⁷ An overview of the various proposed solutions and their problems is provided by Baumgart, 1999, 64–67, while the most important arguments can be found in Dillmann, 129–131 and Holzinger, 76f., 83f. On the various calendars and the widely assumed calendar change in the Neo-Assyrian/Neo-Babylonian period, see Albani, 2006, 137f.

inclusively. Since the Hebrew Bible never specifically states how long a year is and is familiar with multiple calendars, it is unclear how many days the Flood lasted. However, the striking information of one calendar year and ten or eleven days suggests that it has in mind a lunar year with 354 days and ten or eleven additional days thereafter. This results in the Flood lasting 364 or 365 days. Both are conceivable for the Priestly Writing. The 364 days correspond to the Sabbath calendar, which is later attested in Qumran texts, Enochic literature, and the book of Jubilees, while the 365 days corresponds to the solar year (see Enoch's age at the time he is taken up according to Gen 5:23) and the lunisolar calendar (lunar year + epact). Why the Priestly Writing did not base its datings on just the lunisolar calendar or a 364-day calendar, so that the 364/365 days during the Flood would have actually lasted a full calendar year, cannot be said with any certainty. The concurrent use of multiple calendar systems is, in any case, not unique and may have corresponded to set customs. Furthermore, the Priestly Writing may have wanted to give an archaic flavor to its narrative and therefore took the lunar calendar as its basis. Whatever the case may be, in the later transmission of the text, the calendar question was harmonized and the beginning of the Flood was dated to the twenty-seventh day of the second month (LXX, furthermore moving the ark's landfall in Gen 8:4 to the twenty-seventh day of the seventh month, in alignment with Gen 7:11^{LXX}; 8:14, so that the climax of the Flood is reached after exactly five months of thirty days each) or the end date to the sixteenth or seventeenth day of the second month (4Q252 2.1–3 [DJD XXII, 185–207]; see Jub. 5:23, 31). However, these are clearly later efforts at harmonization.⁹⁸

This situation is complicated even more by the period of 150 days (Gen 8:3) being given for the first five months between the seventeenth day of the second month (Gen 7:11) and the seventeenth day of the seventh month (Gen 8:4). This assumes month lengths of thirty days and fits with neither the Sabbath calendar nor the lunisolar (or lunar) calendar. According to the Sabbath calendar, two “leap months” of thirty-one days would have to fall within the period in question, while the lunisolar and lunar calendars alternate between full months of thirty days and hollow months of twenty-nine days. To avoid resorting to the improbable assumption that the Priestly Writing made use of round numbers here (150 instead of 152 or 147/48 days), a schematic calendar would need to be assumed, with 360 days and possibly five leap days, as is attested during the time of the Priestly Writing in Egypt, Mesopotamia, and Persia. According to this, the dating would be oriented around a lunar annual calendar, while the length of the Flood would be based on a lunisolar calendar or a Sabbath year and the length of the months calculated according to a schematic calendar. However, the 150 days in Gen 7:24; 8:3b, which cause by far the most difficulties, can be removed from the present context without leaving any large gaps. Actually, if anything, the counting of the days is superfluous when including these dates, and Gen 7:24 seems out of place in the present context as well as when the Priestly Writing is read on its own.⁹⁹ Thus, it should be considered that a later glossator may have placed a calculation according to the schematic calendar

⁹⁸ For discussion, see Rösel, 1998. Cf. Hendel, 1995; idem, 1998, 54f.

⁹⁹ See Holzinger, 77, who assigns both verses to the Redaction, as well as Levin, 1993, 111, who sees it as an addition to the Priestly Writing. The latter may be correct, since the two verses were placed like a frame around the turning point on the level of the Priestly Flood narrative in Gen *7:6–8:14, which is not taken up in the structure of the present text.

of 360 days (twelve months with lengths of thirty days each) + five leap days over the Priestly Writing's chronology, with not specifically addressing the problem of leap days, as is also the case elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible. This gloss would have been made based on the correct assumption of a 364/365-day Flood. The textual correction in the LXX and in the book of Jubilees is then entirely in line with this. However, all of this remains quite uncertain, since there are no clear literary-critical indications, and every potential date calculation must struggle with uncertainties. Thus, restraint is appropriate here.

Even less can be said about the motives for the dating in the Priestly Writing. The beginning of the Flood in the second month could fall in autumn, and thus with the beginning of the rainy season. This, of course, presupposes that the Priestly Writing was intentionally archaizing and reckoned with "pre-Mosaic" conditions: The Priestly Writing otherwise begins counting the months in the spring, but this is seen as a new arrangement set by Moses (Exod 12:2). For the surprising choice of the seventeenth day of the second month, of all days, reference is often made to the round numbers in Gen 7:4. In total, they add up to 47 days, which has been interpreted as the Priestly Writing assuming a forty-day period of construction for the ark and a seven-day period before the beginning of the Flood. If these 47 days were to begin on the first day of the first month, the resultant date is the seventeenth day of the second month. In some reconstructions of the formation history of the Flood narrative, this calculation is seen as proof of the narrative's literary unity¹⁰⁰ or as evidence for Gen 7:11 (P) being dependent upon Gen 7:4 (non-P).¹⁰¹ Yet, given the numerous tensions in the Flood narrative, its literary unity certainly cannot be supported by such calculations, which stand on shaky ground themselves. The Priestly Writing being familiar with the non-Priestly version cannot be considered improbable from the outset, but it is also true here that considerations of chronology are a tenuous basis. Why should the Priestly Writing follow its predecessor in this detail of all things, but then ultimately decide on an entirely different system? The fact that no place talks about a forty-day construction period shows how highly speculative and, at closer glance, unfitting to the text the calculation with the 7 + 40 days is. Rather, the forty days are counted by the Redaction in 7:12 to the period of time that *begins* on the seventeenth day of the second month, meaning that they presuppose the completion of the ark. The Priestly Writing's motives remain opaque. At best, it can be said that the Priestly Writing wanted to bring the end of the Flood into connection with the first day of the new year.

After the dates, v. 11 describes the coming of the Great Flood. The verse refers back to the announcement in Gen 6:17 but more clearly emphasizes the cosmic dimensions, with the Priestly Writing taking up the conceptual content of the Creation account and its related traditions. The primordial flood (תְּהוֹם; Gen 1:2), which has become the subterranean ocean through divine

¹⁰⁰ See Cassuto 2:43, or Jacob, 233.

¹⁰¹ See Lemche, 1980; Blum, 1990, 283 fn. 207. Also Kratz, 2005, 235f., who adopts this argumentation but assumes for the Flood narrative a basic Priestly text [*Grundschrift*] and a post-Priestly editing and sees the chronological data as a whole as later, post-Priestly additions. In this case, even Gen 7:4 would be an addition to the Priestly Writing, which for its part then inspired even later editors to add the dating in Gen 7:11 and all those related to it.

creational action and, in its regulated form, now waters the land and makes it fertile (see Amos 7:4; Ezek 31:4, 15; Ps 78:15; Job 38:30), begins to surge upward unrestrained. At the same time, the waters of the heavenly ocean (מֵי הַמַּבּוּל) crash down upon the earth through openings in the heavenly vault (אֲרֻבַּת הַשָּׁמַיִם; see further 2 Kgs 7:2, 19; Isa 24:18; Mal 3:10), so that the separation of the waters through the heavenly firmament is partially removed (see Gen 1:6–8). The following notice about the forty days of rain comes from the Scholarly Narrator's version and has been inserted by the Redaction between v. 11 and v. 13 for explicating the coming of the Flood in order to balance between the differing conceptions. Not only does it fall behind v. 11 in terms of the cosmic dimension; it also interrupts the temporal sequence of v. 11 ("on this day") and v. 13 ("on this very day"). The description of the entry into the ark in vv. 13ff. is unmistakably related to the earlier Priestly context. The names of the sons of Noah (v. 13), which are attested only in Priestly texts, refer to the *toledot* in Gen 6:9a, 10. The differentiation of the animal world (v. 14) takes up the wording from the corresponding command in Gen 6:19–20, with the sequence now moving not from general ("all flesh") to specific ("according to their kind") but vice versa.¹⁰² The conclusion forms a short summation that refers to God's command (v. 16a; see also Gen 6:22) and underscores the entirely peculiar character of the entry into the ark: "On the same day in which the Flood begins, Noah goes into the box with his family and, on the same day, also the uncouth animals – possibly in an orderly procession, with the people at the front... remarkably unconcerned about the possibility and probability of what is happening."¹⁰³ In the Priestly Writing, the entry into the ark was originally followed by the description in v. 17* of the Flood taking place. The Redaction expanded the conclusion by inserting the detail from the Scholarly Narrator's version about Yhwh closing the ark behind Noah amid the erupting chaos (v. 16b), which is now in a quite suitable place. In the Mesopotamian tradition, the Flood heroes do this themselves (Atr 3.2.51f.; Gilg 11.94). This touching note is reminiscent of individual features of the Garden narrative, such as Yhwh taking an evening stroll in the garden or furnishing Adam and Eve with clothing. In the Scholarly Narrator's Flood narrative, this may have followed immediately after v. 5: "7:5 Then Noah did according to all that Yhwh had commanded him. 16b And Yhwh shut [it] behind him. 10a When the seven days were over, 12a then came rain upon the earth, forty days and forty nights." Of course, this reconstruction, like every other construction of the precursors of the present text, remains a hypothesis. The present version of

¹⁰² Witte, 1998, 137.

¹⁰³ Holzinger, 71 [translation JWR].

the text comes from the Redaction, but it is quite probable that it was written based on formulations from the Scholarly Narrator's Flood narrative.

7:17–24

- 17 *And the Great Flood was upon the earth for forty days, and the waters became strong and lifted up the ark, and it was high above the earth.*
- 18 *And the waters became mighty and very vast upon the earth, and the ark went upon the waters.*
- 19 *And the waters were exceedingly mighty upon the earth. And all high mountains that are under the heavens were covered.*
- 20 *The waters were mighty fifteen more cubits upwards, so that the mountains were covered.*
- 21 *Then all flesh died that crawls upon the earth, of flying animals, of livestock, of wild animals, and of all teeming creatures that teem upon the earth, and also all human beings.*
- 22 *Everything that had the breath of the spirit of life in its nose died – everything that lived on dry land.*
- 23 *Thus, he wiped away all that existed that was on the surface of the ground, from human beings to livestock to crawling animals to the flying animals of the heavens, and they were wiped away from the earth. Noah alone remained, and those who were with him in the ark.*
- 24 *And the waters became mighty upon the earth, 150 days.*

The description of the Flood and the journey of the ark, framed by the chronological notices, is strikingly short. It is based fundamentally on the Priestly version, whose heading in v. 17a was expanded by the Redaction to forty days (LXX: “forty days and nights”) following Gen 7:4, 12.¹⁰⁴ The notices about the waters rising in v. 17b on the one hand and vv. 18–20 on the other should probably be understood as doublets.¹⁰⁵ The present text can be described somewhat forcefully as having a three-staged process in which the ark, built on land, rises up from the ground (v. 17b) and floats freely (v. 18), until the waters ultimately cover even the mountaintops (v. 19), so

¹⁰⁴ So, e.g., already Budde, 1883, 203f.; Holzinger, 72; Gunkel, 146, and more recently Ruppert, 292, 347; Witte, 1998, 137.

¹⁰⁵ See, among many, Holzinger, 72; Ruppert, 347, also Arneth, 2007, 197, who, however, wants to distinguish between the rising of the ark (v. 17b) and its journey on the water (v. 18b) for the purposes of his supplementary hypothesis. The Redactor may indeed have conceived of it as such. However, the wording of v. 17b rather speaks against this having been the original understanding of v. 17, especially since v. 18a, when taken by itself, also describes the conditions of why the ark was able to sail on the water, thus repeating the statement of v. 17b. Cf. Witte, 1998, 138f., who ascribes vv. 17–22 as a whole to the Priestly Writing, with the exception of two smaller glosses.

that the waters rise fifteen cubits above the highest peak. The description in vv. 18–20 is shaped through the thematic term “to be(come) mighty/powerful” (*גבר in vv. 18, 19, 20). The notice that the waters overtake the highest mountaintop by fifteen cubits clearly shows that it is oriented around the Priestly instructions for building the ark. The fifteen cubits correspond to half the height of the ark and, therefore, its probable load draught,¹⁰⁶ since the ark touches ground as soon as the waters begin to sink (Gen 8:4 [P]). The narrative style of the Priestly Writing is redundant, which underlines the magnitude of the catastrophe while clearly also showing the long extent of it, seeing as the ark only runs aground atop Mount Ararat after five months, and it takes another two and a half months before the mountaintops are visible (Gen 8:4f.). Verse 18b formulates the waters rising somewhat differently (*רבה; “to be(come) strong”) and significantly more succinctly. This partial verse connects well with the notice about the closing of the ark and can thus be assigned to the Scholarly Narrator. Verses 21 and 22 depict the consequence: the death of all life on earth. After the statement that “all flesh” passed away, the list of the Flood’s victims in v. 21 begins with the crawling animals and ends with humanity. It is quite obvious that this structure was intended to become more intense as it goes on. The formulations take up the Priestly announcement of the Flood (Gen 6:17, 19f.) and, like them, refer back to the Creation account (Gen 1:24–26). The subsequent statement about the death of all life on earth forms a doublet with the previous death notice and, with the phrase “everything that has the breath of life in its nose” (כל אֲשֶׁר נְשָׁמָת ... חַיִּים בָּאָפִיּוֹ), refers back to the Garden narrative (Gen 2:7). Of course, this statement also applies to the land animals (see v. 22b), although the recourse to the creation of humanity makes clear that the Scholarly Narrator, in line with his prologue to the Flood narrative, was concerned first and foremost with the destruction of the guilty human race, while the deaths of the land animals are depicted instead as collateral damage. In the present version of v. 22, the wording has been adapted to fit the Priestly רוּחַ חַיִּים (see Gen 6:17; 7:15). The composite phrase “the breath of the spirit of life” obviously comes from the Redaction.¹⁰⁷ Next, the summarizing remark in v. 23* about the consequences of the Flood comes from the Scholarly Narrator. With the striking phrase “all that existed” (כָּל־הַיְּקוּמִים), it refers back to the announcement of the destruction in Gen 7:4. The description of the divine act of destruction with the verb “to wipe away” (*מחה) takes up not only Gen 7:4 but also Gen 6:7. The subject of the sentence is Yhwh, who is mentioned for the last time in v. 16b. The strong focus on Noah is particularly

¹⁰⁶ Gunkel, 146.

¹⁰⁷ See Holzinger, 81. Even the LXX already stumbled over the wording and simplified it to match Gen 2:7 (!) (πνοήν ζῶντος).

noticeable when compared to the Priestly Writing. Noah's family and the animals are grouped together in the relative clause "those who were with him in the ark." The Redaction prefaced this succinct notice with the listing "from human beings to livestock to crawling animals to the flying animals of the heavens," which is reminiscent of the Priestly Writing and integrated it by again taking up the verb "to wipe away." The section concludes by telling of how long the waters spent rising, which is clearly linked to the text of the Priestly Writing through the thematic word *גבר* "to be(come) mighty/powerful." It seems doubtful, however, that it actually belonged to the Priestly base material. The verse seems out of place in its present context and cannot be synchronized with the dates in the Priestly Writing (see above on Gen 7:11 and the chronology).

8:1–14

- 1 *Then God thought about Noah and all the wild animals and all the livestock that were with him in the ark, and God let a wind blow over the earth, and the waters sank down.*
- 2 *Then the springs of the primordial flood and the windows of the heavens were closed. And the rains from the heavens ceased.*
- 3 *Then the waters receded from the earth, gradually but steadily. [After the 150 days had passed, the waters decreased.]*
- 4 *And the ark came on the seventeenth day of the seventh month to rest upon the mountains of Ararat.*
- 5 *And the waters steadily decreased until the tenth month. In the tenth month, on the first of the month, the peaks of the mountains became visible.*
- 6 *And after forty days had passed, Noah opened the window of the ark that he had made.*
- 7 *And he let out the raven, and it flew out, flying to and fro until the waters had dried away from the earth.*
- 8 *And he sent the dove away from him in order to see if the waters had gone back from the surface of the ground.*
- 9 *But the dove did not find a resting place for the sole of its feet, so it returned into the ark to him, because there was still water upon the whole earth. Then he stretched out his hand and took it and brought it back with him into the ark.*
- 10 *Then he waited another seven days, then he sent the dove out from the ark again.*
- 11 *And the dove came back to him at evening time, and behold, a fresh leaf from an olive tree was in his beak. Then Noah knew that the waters had lessened upon the earth.*

- 12 *Then he waited another seven days, then he sent the dove out, and it did not return to him again.*
- 13 *And it came to pass in the 601st year, in the first month, on the first of the month, that the waters had dried away from the earth. And Noah removed the cover of the ark and he looked, and behold, the surface of the ground was dry.*
- 14 *And in the second month, on the twenty-seventh day of the month, the earth was dry.*

God's remembrance introduces the turning point in the narrative. The end of the section is marked through a new date in v. 14 and the introduction of the divine speech after the Flood in v. 15. The section is structured into two parts: After God's remembrance, vv. 1–5 describe how the waters are held back and how the rains stop, at which point the water level drops and the ark hits land. In v. 6, the scene changes. For the first time, the events upon the ark are brought into view. The first part is based predominantly on the Flood narrative of the Priestly Writing. Only in v. 2b did the Redaction add the stopping of the rain, in the style of its compilation of the description from the beginning of the Flood in Gen 7:11, 12. This is probably a passage from the Scholarly Narrator's version, like in Gen 7:12. The second part of the section, on the other hand, which includes the scene of sending out the birds (vv. 6–12) that is told in a completely different manner, is based on the Scholarly Narrator's version. Also coming from it is the notice in v. 13b about the cover of the ark being lifted off, which is similar stylistically and terminologically in how it describes Noah's action. The Redaction was responsible for placing it in its present position; the Redactor may have wanted to fill in the period between the two dates in v. 13a and v. 14, which come from the Priestly Writing, with some narrative material.

8:1–2

- 1 *Then God thought about Noah and all the wild animals and all the livestock that were with him in the ark, and God let a wind blow over the earth, and the waters sank down.*
- 2 *Then the springs of the primordial flood and the windows of the heavens were closed. And the rains from the heavens ceased.*

God's remembrance initiates the turning point from death to life. Both in the Priestly Writing and in the present text, it marks both the narrative and the compositional apex of the Flood narrative. The phrase "Then God thought about Noah..." gives the impression that God had not been following the fate of the ark and its passengers very closely since the coming of the Flood and only after a period of detachment concerned himself again with Noah

and his fate. This conception of the transcendent God only occasionally turning to human beings is reminiscent of the Priestly prologue, according to which God becomes aware of the corruption of the earth only after looking at it again (according to Gen 1:31).¹⁰⁸ It can also be found in the description of God's reaction to the Israelites suffering under Egyptian oppression (Exod 2:22aβb, 24 [P]; see also Gen 19:29 [P]) and is transferred into a theology of the presence of God only in the promise of God dwelling within his people, Israel, as is characteristic of the Priestly texts about the sanctuary (Exod 6:7; 25:8–9; 29:43–46). The talk of God's remembrance is taken up in Gen 9:15f. in the context of the covenant made with Noah and the descendants of all the survivors. In this way, the turning point of the Flood narrative comes to stand in a referential context with the epilogue and prologue (see Gen 6:18) of the Priestly Flood narrative. In a quite similar way, the turning point of the Priestly Exodus narrative is introduced by the mention of God remembering his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob (Exod 2:24; 6:5). God's establishment of the covenant with Noah in Gen 6:18 thus allows for the possibility of his salvatory remembrance in Gen 8:1. Nevertheless, the term "covenant" does not appear at the latter point. This may have been because the covenant in Gen 6:18 is made exclusively with Noah, although the remembrance in v. 1 is explicitly directed to the other passengers on the ark as well. Across the Hebrew Bible, God's remembrance can be found frequently in the context of lamenting or answered petitions (see, e.g., Gen 30:22; Judg 16:28; 1 Sam 1:11, 19; Jer 15:15; Ps 9:12f.; 74:1–3; 106:4f.; 115:12; see further Jer 31:20; Ps 8:4–6), with it "[denoting] no mere memory-based reference but an act of the deity caring for the person who is in distress."¹⁰⁹ Accordingly, surrender of the supplicant to the powers of death is designated as God having "forgotten" them (see Ps 13:2; Lam 5:20).

God's attention, which is based in his remembrance, is expressed according to v. 1b by sending the wind that drives away the water masses. This wind sent from God (רוּחַ) could be a reference back to the spirit of God wafting over the waters of the primordial flood in the description of the world before Creation (רוּחַ אֱלֹהִים; Gen 1:2b).¹¹⁰ The turning point of the Flood narrative and the beginning of the acts of creation are thus paralleled in a way, even if the Flood only partially and temporarily undoes Creation and v. 1 does not involve a "new Creation." Verse 2a also emphasizes the cosmic dimension and forms the counterpart to Gen 7:11. The closing of the heavenly hatches and the springs of the primordial flood would be expected to come before the spirit of God receding the waters. However, this sequence, which may

¹⁰⁸ So also Schüle, 2006, 265.

¹⁰⁹ Schottroff, 1967, 183–201, 201 [translation JWR]. See further Janowski, 2007.

¹¹⁰ Schüle, 2006, 265.

at first seem inconsistent, resulted from the focus on God's remembrance and his actions decided in it. The consequences of the divine intervention – the closing of both the springs of the primordial flood and the hatches of the heavens are described only afterwards. The Scholarly Narrator, whose notice about the rains stopping was inserted at this point by the Redaction analogous to Gen 7:11, 12, did not specifically address the turning point, since the rains are limited from the outset to forty days (Gen 7:4).¹¹¹

8:3–5

- 3 *Then the waters receded from the earth, gradually but steadily. [After the 150 days had passed, the waters decreased.]*
- 4 *And the ark came on the seventeenth day of the seventh month to rest upon the mountains of Ararat.*
- 5 *And the waters steadily decreased until the tenth month. In the tenth month, on the first of the month, the peaks of the mountains became visible.*

Verse 3a begins the depiction of the waters sinking down. This sub-verse is typically attributed to a non-Priestly version of the Flood narrative,¹¹² but the construction (inf. abs. of *הלך “to go” + inf. abs. of *שוב “to yield”) corresponds to that of the Priestly Writing in v. 5 (inf. abs. of *הלך “to go” + inf. abs. of *חסר “to sink”). Here, like there, the construction expresses that the water gradually but steadily decreases “from the earth” (מֵעַל הָאָרֶץ; v. 3a) as a result of the wind “over the earth” (עַל-הָאָרֶץ; v. 1b). This redundant narrative style reflects the similarly redundant description of the rising of the waters in Gen 7:18–20. The exact dates given are in line with Gen 7:11. Exactly five months after the beginning of the Flood, on the seventeenth day of the seventh month, the ark touches land. According to v. 3b, this is also the day in which the waters begin to sink down. Clearly presupposed in this calculation is the ark, thirty cubits high, having a load draught of fifteen cubits and floating right above the highest mountains (see Gen 7:19f.), whose peaks then become visible on the first day of the tenth month.

From the beginning, the ark's landing site being located “upon the mountains of Ararat” has preoccupied readings of the passage beyond measure, seducing them to many a speculation.¹¹³ However, even just the plural “mountains” suggests that

¹¹¹ Cf. Schüle, 2006, 271, who sees the absence of a notice corresponding to Gen 8:1 as the decisive indication that the “postulate of a second source” [translation JWR] cannot be sustained.

¹¹² See Budde, 1883, 268; Gunkel, 64; more recently Ruppert, 354; Levin, 1993, 108; Seebaß, 230. For assignment to the Priestly Writing, see Ska, 2009, 46f.; Witte, 1998, 139.

¹¹³ See on the following Jericke, 2016 with extensive bibliography.

the Priestly Writing could not or would not provide any exact details: For the Priestly Writing, the sign for remembering the Flood is God's bow in the clouds and not the remnants of the ark or where it landed.¹¹⁴ In the Hebrew Bible, Ararat (אַרְרָט) denotes a country (in addition to Gen 8:4, see also 2 Kgs 19:37; Isa 37:38; Jer 51:27), specifically *Urartu*, which is attested in cuneiform documents and lies in eastern Asia Minor on the northern border of Assyria. Its heartland largely corresponds to the later Armenia, which is why, in the late third century CE, Eusebius of Caesarea identified Ararat as Armenia. Already in the Hellenistic period, there was a noticeable tendency to identify a specific mountain in Armenia as the landing place of the ark. Flavius Josephus, who is one of those who spoke of a mountain in Armenia, also noted in this context that Berossos mentioned remains of the ark of Xisuthrus on the "mountains of the Cordyaeans" in Armenia, to which apotropaic effects were attributed in Babylonia (Josephus, *A.J.* 1.92f.). The mention of the "mountains of the Cordyaeans" points to the country of Corduene (Γορδηνή), which is mentioned by several ancient authors as the mountainous country between Armenia and Mesopotamia lying around Lake Van. This identification is also found in the Targums and the Peshitta, according to which the ark touched ground on the "mountains of Cardu." Despite some dissenting voices who, like Eusebius and Jerome, adhered to the biblical idea of Ararat as a country name following the literal sense of Gen 8:4, the name "Ararat" came over the course of later interpretation to be associated with the idea of a single mountain to be found in Armenia. Since the Middle Ages, Ararat, which became "Mount Ararat," has been identified with the highest peak of the Armenian highlands. The peak of Great Ararat (Büyük Aǵrı Dağı), which is over 5000 m high, visible from very far off, and always covered in snow, is located 140 km northeast of Lake Van in the east of modern-day Turkey and immediately on the borders with Armenia and Iran. Alongside other local traditions, and following Berossos, the Targums, and the Peshitta, the mountain of Cudi Dağı, which stands a good 2000 m high on the border with Syria and Iraq in modern-day Turkey, has also been considered to be the mountain on which the Flood hero's ship made landfall. On one of its peaks are the remains of a monastery built in the fourth century CE in honor of Noah's ark. The mountain is also considered by the Quran to be the ark's landing place (Surah 11:44).

8:6–12

- 6 *And after forty days had passed, Noah opened the window of the ark that he had made.*
- 7 *And he let out the raven, and it flew out, flying to and fro until the waters had dried away from the earth.*
- 8 *And he sent the dove away from him in order to see if the waters had gone back from the surface of the ground.*
- 9 *But the dove did not find a resting place for the sole of its feet, so it returned into the ark to him, because there was still water upon the*

¹¹⁴ Ruppert, 356.

- whole earth. Then he stretched out his hand and took it and brought it back with him into the ark.*
- 10** *Then he waited another seven days, then he sent the dove out from the ark again.*
- 11** *And the dove came back to him at evening time, and behold, a fresh leaf from an olive tree was in his beak. Then Noah knew that the waters had lessened upon the earth.*
- 12** *Then he waited another seven days, then he sent the dove out, and it did not return to him again.*

The text introduces the bird scene by giving a date that takes up Gen 7:4, 12. After forty days of continuous rain, Noah waits another forty days before he opens the window of the ark. As already explained above (see Formation), the mention of the window that Noah built is indicative of a construction report having been in the Scholarly Narrator's Flood narrative that was lost when it was connected with the Priestly Writing. Unlike the pious Noah of the Priestly Writing, who is depicted as lacking any initiative of his own, the Scholarly Narrator's Noah attempts to find out through an experiment with a bird whether or not the catastrophe has come to an end. The scene has a close parallel in the Epic of Gilgamesh. There, Utnapištim first sends out a dove, then a swallow, and finally a raven. When the raven does not return, the Flood hero, like any experienced ship captain in antiquity, recognizes that the bird had found land (Gilgm 11.147–156): “The seventh day when it came, // I brought out a dove, I let it loose: // off went the dove but when it returned, // there was no place to land, so back it came to me. // I brought out a swallow, I let it loose: // off went the swallow but then it returned, // there was no place to land, so back it came to me. // I brought out a raven, I let it loose: off went the raven, it saw the waters receding, // finding food, *bowing and bobbing*, it did not come back to me.” The scene is also found in Berossos, except with the species unspecified and several birds being sent out during each of the three attempts. According to Gen 8:6–12, Noah initially releases a raven (v. 7) before he, like Gilgamesh, makes three further attempts, each time with a dove (vv. 8–12). However, the mention of the raven may not have belonged to the original text. Sending it out “until the waters had dried away from the earth” anticipates the reasoning for sending out the dove in v. 8b and serves no function in its context. The LXX recognized this problem and expanded v. 7f. accordingly: “And he let out the raven *in order to see if the waters had gone back* [see v. 8b], and it went out and did not return until the waters had dried away from the earth. And he sent *after it* the dove away from him in order to see if the waters had gone back from the surface of the ground.” Since the raven flies restlessly to and fro according

to the original version of the text without giving Noah the information that he desires, its flight is aimed at the continuation in vv. 8–12.¹¹⁵ This therefore rules out the possibility that it could be a Priestly parallel to vv. 8–12.¹¹⁶ Rather, it is a later addition that has been prepended to the four verses. However, the reasons that led to its insertion can be only left to speculation. Should the mention of the raven have been inspired by the Epic of Gilgamesh, then the editor responsible for the addition may have been interested in creating a contrast of “unclean raven” (see Lev 11:15; Deut 14:14) – “clean dove” (Lev 1:14). Compared to its Mesopotamian predecessor, the Scholarly Narrator’s version is distinguished by a few endearing details that are reminiscent of the Garden narrative: The dove finds no resting place (הָנוּחַ) and returns to Noah (נֹחַ), who stretches out his hand in order to take the dove back on board; the second time, it brings a freshly plucked – that is, not fished up – olive leaf, thus announcing to Noah the upcoming end of the wait and the new beginning of vegetation. The symbolic power of these images has no rival.

8:13–14

- 13** *And it came to pass in the 601st year, in the first month, on the first of the month, that the waters had dried away from the earth. And Noah removed the cover of the ark and he looked, and behold, the surface of the ground was dry.*
- 14** *And in the second month, on the twenty-seventh day of the month, the earth was dry.*

The section ends with a twofold dating that, in its structure, is reminiscent of the beginning of the Priestly depiction of the Flood in Gen 7:6.¹¹⁷ In the Priestly Flood narrative, the two dates frame the report of the Flood. In its content, the sequence of vv. 13a and 14 should be understood such that the earth was free of water on New Year’s Day and that nearly two months later, the ground was dry and could thus be walked upon again. The two dates have resulted from overriding chronological interests. Obviously, the Flood is best ended on New Year’s Day, while the second date probably resulted from the synchronization of a lunar calendar with a Flood lasting 364 or 365 days (see on Gen 7:11–16 and on the chronology above). Even the Redaction may have already been bothered by the immediate sequence of vv. 13a and 14. In any case, between the two dates, it inserted a notice from the Scholarly

¹¹⁵ Witte, 1998, 140.

¹¹⁶ So von Rad, 90, 96 and now again Schüle, 2006, 251, 266, who, within the framework of a supplementary hypothesis, assigns Gen 8:7 to the Priestly base layer and Gen 8:8–12 to a non-P and post-P supplementary layer.

¹¹⁷ Arneith, 2007, 67.

Narrator's version according to which Noah, after the successful bird experiment, removes the canopy-cover of the ark to prove to himself that the Flood has ended (v. 13b). The expression *מִכְסֵּה*, from a root *כסה "to cover," otherwise designates the covering made of skins or furs that is placed over the tent sanctuary according to the Priestly sanctuary texts (Exod 26:14; 35:11; 36:19; 39:34; 40:19; Num 3:25; 4:8, 10, 11, 12, 25). In Ezek 27:7, the expression denotes the deck of a ship or a sail stretched over the cabin.¹¹⁸ It is probably a technical term from seafaring and shipbuilding.

In the Priestly version and in the present text, the dates for the waters drying away and the ground drying up are followed in Gen 8:15–19 by the divine command to leave the ark as well as the description of leaving it. A corresponding report by the Scholarly Narrator has not been preserved. Why this fell out can only be left to speculation.¹¹⁹ In any case, it is not essential to the Scholarly Narrator's version. With the remark that Noah removed the ark's canopy, enough is said to lead to the scene of the construction of the altar in Gen 8:20.

8:15–19

- 15** *Then God said to Noah,*
16 *"Go out of the ark, you and your wife and your sons and the wives of your sons with you.*
17 *All the animals that are with you, all flesh, of flying animals and of livestock and of all crawling animals that crawl upon the earth, lead them out with you; they shall teem upon the earth and be fruitful and become vast upon the earth."*
18 *Then Noah went out, and his sons and his wife and the wives of his sons with him.*
19 *All living beings, all crawling animals and all flying animals, all that crawls upon the earth, they went out of the ark according to their species.*

This section comes entirely from the Priestly Writing. In the Priestly Flood narrative, Genesis 8:15 began a series of speeches by God coming after the account of the Flood and lasting through Gen 9:17. It is interrupted merely by one short notice about everyone leaving the ark and concludes with two long divine speeches (Gen 9:1–7; 9:8–17) to Noah and his sons in which the post-diluvian world is reordered anew. In the present text, the Scholarly Narrator's epilogue in Gen 8:20–22 follows the Priestly notice of everyone leaving the

¹¹⁸ Instead of *מִכְסֵּה* (from *מִכְסֵּה*, another noun formation from the root *כסה) it should probably be read as *מִכְסֵּה*.

¹¹⁹ So, e.g., Gunkel, 65.

ark, so that the depiction of leaving the ark in Gen 8:15–19 now forms with Gen 7:1–4 an inner frame around the account of the Flood, and so that the two epilogues are more clearly dissociated from the depiction of the Flood.

Unlike in the Scholarly Narrator's version, Noah waits on God's command to leave the ark, which he then follows faithfully. The scene gives the impression of this happening quite orderly: Noah and his family go out first, then the animals follow "according to their species" (לְמִשְׁפַּחֹתֵיהֶם) instead of the uncommon plural of מִין from the typical לְמִינָה "according to their kind"). Standing at the center of the passage/at the end of the first part of the divine speech is the instruction for the animals leaving the ark to multiply. This unmistakably takes up the blessing of multiplication in Gen 1:22 (see also Gen 1:28). As has been noted several times, the Priestly Writing emphasizes the close links between Creation and Flood while at the same time knowing how to distinguish between the two in a clear manner. Thus, the differences from the texts referenced in Gen 1 should be noted in this case as well. They are due to the fact that, through the Flood, the general conditions of life on earth have been permanently changed, tipping the scales against the animals: Unlike in Gen 1:22 (and also Gen 1:28), this is not a blessing of multiplication,¹²⁰ which is reserved for Noah and his sons (see Gen 9:1, 7) and is connected with the establishment of humanity's "reign of terror" over the animal world (Gen 9:2). This also explains why the repopulation of the earth by birds, livestock, and crawling animals is treated separately from that by human beings. The antagonism between humanity and the animal world begins already with leaving the ark. For this reason, no call to "fill the earth" comparable to Gen 1:22, 28 (see Gen 9:1) is mentioned at this point. There might, like already in Gen 1:24f. with the creation of the land animals, be a resonance here of the thought that the population of (land) animals multiplying rampantly and unchecked has a negative effect upon the wellbeing of the humans who share living space with them (see Lev 26:22).¹²¹

8:20–22

- 20** *And Noah built an altar for Yhwh and he took from all the clean livestock and from all the clean birds and he let a burnt offering go up from the altar.*
- 21** *Then Yhwh smelled the appeasing scent and Yhwh said to his heart, "Henceforth, I shall never again curse the soil on account of humanity, even though the formations of the human heart are evil from its*

¹²⁰ Mosis, 1994, 196f. and fn. 9 correctly emphasized this, contra Westermann, 451, 455, who, amid an exuberance of blessing theology, saw a universal blessing over all creatures despite the allowance of killing animals in Gen 9:1, 7.

¹²¹ Schellenberg, 2011, 47.

youth onward, and henceforth, I shall never again strike at all living things, as I have done.

- 22** *Still all the days of the earth, sowing and reaping, frost and heat, summer and winter, day and night shall not cease."*

The first, inwardly directed epilogue of the Flood narrative comes from the Scholarly Narrator and in its structure resembles his prologue in Gen 6:5–8: Yhwh's realization of what is happening (v. 21a α_1 ; see Gen 6:5f.) is followed by Yhwh giving a speech (vv. 21a α_2 –21b; see Gen 6:7*) and a depersonalized statement of mercy (v. 22; see Gen 6:8). The plot follows the Mesopotamian tradition, integral for which is the Flood hero offering a sacrifice after being saved from the floodwaters (Atr 3.5.30–38; Gilgm 11:157–171). Conversely, this is missing in the Priestly version for conceptual reasons, since for its author, the sacrificial cult is established only at Sinai. According to the Epic of Gilgamesh, Utnapištim initially sacrifices to the space represented by the four winds, as it was the only thing that was still reliable for him.¹²² This is followed by a sacrifice for the gods, who have not received any sacrifice since the beginning of the Flood and are therefore starving, making it clear how much they are dependent upon being supplied by humanity, which was created for this purpose. Accordingly, the Flood was a very short-sighted enterprise, since the gods harmed themselves in carrying it out (see Gilgm 11.169f.). Nevertheless, it contributes to the balance of the postdiluvian world, since the gods have recognized that they are just as dependent upon humanity as humanity is, in turn, dependent upon the gods: The sweet aroma of the sacrifice (Gilgm 11.161f.) appeases the gods, whose fury Utnapištim and the other passengers on the ark have just escaped, while at the same time freeing them from a real predicament. A striking expression of the shared fate of the gods and humanity is the motif of the "flies." The gods gather over the sacrifice like flies, while after the Flood, the mother goddess puts on a necklace with flies of lapis lazuli in order to remind herself of the death of her human children, who were carried off by the Flood like flies.¹²³

The Scholarly Narrator accents his narrative differently and resolves the interdependence between gods and humans unilaterally. The Flood is not triggered by Yhwh's short-sighted anger against humanity but because Yhwh holds people accountable for the principles of their action (see Gen 6:5–7).¹²⁴ There is no talk of Yhwh inflicting harm upon himself or being dependent upon humanity. Humanity is the only thing in focus, with its survival depending entirely on preservation through the action of the Creator God. The exact

¹²² See Maul, 2014, 188 on Gilgm 11.157f.

¹²³ See Wilcke, 1999^b, 94f.

¹²⁴ Grätz, 2012, 152.

function of the sacrifice motif, inherited from the earlier tradition, in this context is difficult to determine. It is unmistakably an especially precious sacrifice, since Noah presents as a burnt offering specimens from all (!) species considered to be suitable for sacrifice. There is no evidence in the text for the occasionally supported view that the sacrifice was for an atonement of the cursed earth.¹²⁵ Rather, it should be thought of as a thanksgiving offering for the salvation from the Flood.¹²⁶ This would be the conventional conclusion to a narrative about saving the protagonist. However, the problem with this interpretation is that the presentation of the sacrifice is closely related syntactically to Yhwh's promise in v. 21f. and, thus, to the future. In the Scholarly Narrator's version, it is only the sacrifice's scent that calls Yhwh back onto the scene. The expression *ריח ניחוח*, which is otherwise encountered only as a set phrase in Priestly sacrificial texts (see, e.g., Exod 29:18, 25, 41; Lev 1:9, 13; on Yhwh smelling the sacrifice, see also 1 Sam 26:19; Amos 5:21; Lev 26:31), is often understood as a "lovely smell" as emanates from a succulent dish, following the LXX (ὁσμή εὐωδίας "fragrant offering") and the "sweet aroma" of the sacrifice in the Epic of Gilgamesh. However, the Hebrew *ניחוח* also encompasses the aspect of being soothing/pleasing (see Akk. *nāḥu/nuḥḥu* + *libbu* "to soothe the heart"). For this reason, the sacrifice is also seen as a motive for Yhwh to relent from his destructive actions because of the "pleasing scent."¹²⁷ The positioning of the sacrificial scene at the transition from the Flood to the promise of continued existence for the earth can also be cited for this understanding. Admittedly, the punishment has already taken place, and the pardoning of Noah (Gen 6:8) at least already prepares for Yhwh changing his mind, so it is not possible to speak of an "atonement" in the proper sense. Noah's offering thus possesses features of the thanksgiving offering and the atonement offering, without being identifiable with either of the two sacrifice types: Noah's successful attempt to make contact with Yhwh again is an offering of its own particular kind.¹²⁸ For the offering depicted in the Epic of Gilgamesh, it is assumed that this reflects a cultic event annually celebrating the rebirth of the world after the Flood.¹²⁹ A cultic context of this kind could also be presumed for Gen 8:20–22, but this remains quite uncertain.¹³⁰

Yhwh's reaction to the offering obviously refers back to the prologue in Gen 6:5–8. This is also already the case for the introduction of Yhwh's

¹²⁵ Procksch, 69.

¹²⁶ Cassuto 2:117f.; Westermann, 453.

¹²⁷ See Eberhart, 2002, 369–371.

¹²⁸ See further Schenker, 2003.

¹²⁹ See Maul, 2014, on Gilgm 11.157–171.

¹³⁰ See Grätz, 2012, 151–153 for corresponding considerations on the situating of the non-P Flood narrative in the first Jerusalem temple.

speech, insofar as it uses the idiomatic expression “to say to one’s heart [אָל־לִבּוֹ]” for this soliloquy, which alludes to the phrase “it hurt him to his very heart” (אָל־לִבּוֹ) from Gen 6:6. In the prologue, the phrase allows insight into Yhwh’s innermost stirrings and shows how, in the face of humanity’s wickedness, he reaches the decision to bring about the Flood. In the epilogue, the sentence is aimed at Yhwh’s reflections, evoked by the appeasing scent of the sacrifice, on the consequences of the Flood for himself. This recourse to the prologue shows itself particularly clearly in the statement “the formations of the human heart are evil from its youth onward” (v. 21a_β; see Gen 6:5). The wording differs slightly from that of the prologue, but this leaves no doubt that the divine judgment about the nature of humanity has not changed even in the face of the Flood. It therefore speaks of the “formations of the heart” and no longer of “every formation of the thoughts of its heart.” Thus, the creationary aspect of human reflection comes somewhat more strongly into the foreground, but this means just as little a tightening or softening of the judgment as does the closer definition of the temporal aspect through “from its youth onward” instead of through “all the days.”¹³¹ If anything, it remains to be considered that the explicit reference to “every” formation from Gen 6:5 has been omitted with respect to the preceding act of sacrifice.

Moreover, Yhwh’s speech also refers back to the Garden narrative. The announcement in v. 21a_α to never again curse the ground/soil (אָדָמָה) on account of humanity (אָדָם) is not only in line with the other statements about the intrinsic relationship between humanity and the soil, as can also be found in the prologue of the Flood narrative (see Gen 6:7*); it is also a clear reminiscence of the cursing of the soil in the judgments from the Garden narrative (see Gen 3:17). Why the Scholarly Narrator chose the semantically similar *קָלַל pi. for “to curse” instead of the *אָרַר from Gen 3:17 (see also Gen 5:29) is worth expounding upon separately. First, it remains to be stated that the epilogue decidedly takes up the first inward prologue of the Flood narrative in addition to the Garden narrative. This corresponds to the twofold literary function of Gen 8:20–22 in the Scholarly Narrator’s work as a conclusion to (1) the Flood narrative and (2) the Primeval History as a whole.¹³²

(1) Like all myths of the primordial beginnings, the Scholarly Narrator’s Flood narrative is to be understood starting from its outcome. The key to understanding the narrative lies in the connection of the promise that a catastrophe like the Flood will never again be repeated to the largely verbatim and, in its substance, unchanged repetition of the initial judgment about human

¹³¹ Cf. Baumgart, 1999, 160, 170–173. See further the criticism in Arneth, 2007, 187. In contrast, Witte, 1998, 180f., 250f. recognizes a generalization and intensification influenced by Gen 9:2ff. (P).

¹³² Following Witte, 1998, 182.

nature. This is obviously about both designating humanity as punishable while also guaranteeing a continuance of the present world as much as possible, with the guarantee able to bear the essential wickedness of humanity. The initial causal connection between human wickedness and the Great Flood as a punishment that is considered to be an appropriate response leads to a crisis that nearly results in the total destruction of all that had been created. This crisis is averted, the previous causal connection of general guilt and the judgment of the world is dissolved (v. 21), and in its place comes the solemn guarantee of the earth's continued existence (v. 22) – which, of course, does not mean that Yhwh has any desire to be indifferent to human guilt moving forward. The epilogue explicitly states that human action and Yhwh's evaluation of it have not changed, but what has changed is Yhwh's reaction to these actions. Even considering only this, the Scholarly Narrator does describe God as changing,¹³³ telling of a transformation completely in the mythical narrative style of its Mesopotamian predecessors. However, here, unlike in the Epic of Atrahasis, it is not about “various stations ‘overcome’” in the formation of the present world.”¹³⁴ Rather, the Flood narrative defines the nature of God by describing how Yhwh became the God who was able to overcome his “regret” of creating humanity.

(2) For the understanding of the epilogue as the conclusion to the Scholarly Narrator's Primeval History, Yhwh's announcement about not wanting to curse the soil in the future on account of humanity proves to be decisive. The reference to Gen 3:17 mediated by Gen 5:29* should not be overlooked, even though *קלל pi. was chosen for “to curse” in v. 21 instead of the *ארר like in Gen 3:17; 5:29:

Gen 3:17: “And to the Human, he said, ‘Because you listened to the voice of your Woman and ate from the tree that I commanded of you, “You shall not eat from it” – cursed is the soil on your account; under hardship shall you eat from it all the days of your life.’”

Gen 5:29: “And he called his name ‘Noah,’ saying, ‘This one will bring us comfort from our work and from the toil of our hands because of the soil, which Yhwh has cursed.’”

Gen 8:21*: “Henceforth, I shall never again curse the soil on account of humanity.”

In each case, the object of Yhwh's action described in Gen 3:17 and excluded for the future in Gen 8:21 is the soil (אֲדָמָה), with the action taking place “on account of humanity” (בְּעֵבוּר הָאָדָם) or “on account of you” (בְּעֵבוּר + suff.). It has been concluded from this that “at this point, Yhwh no longer wants to regard the earth as being under this curse – and, naturally, this

¹³³ Perlitt, 1970, 392.

¹³⁴ Stolz, 2004, 34 [translation JWR].

means needing to treat it. He no longer wants to deal with it like he was having to do from the time when he placed his curse upon it. The curse should not be in effect any longer; it is rescinded.”¹³⁵ However, this interpretation cannot work, because Gen 3:14–19 describes the ambiguity of the present living conditions as a consequence of an impairment of existence reaching into the present of the authors and their readers as well as into our own present.¹³⁶ Nor does it adequately account for the deliberate change from *אָרֶר in Gen 3:17; 5:29 to *קָלַל in Gen 8:21. The announcement of the soil being henceforth no longer cursed on humanity’s account is formulated with another verb because the impairment of existence provoked through the curse in Gen 3:17 applies just as much now as before. Thus, at the end of his Primeval History, the Scholarly Narrator is concerned with ruling out a future continuation of the curse narrative on humanity’s account.¹³⁷ This is also the comfort for the cursed earth that is announced in the naming of Noah (Gen 5:29).

Following Yhwh communicating through two parallel sets of sentences what he henceforth intends never to do again (in each case, a negation לֹא + 1st pers. sg. of יָסַף hi. “to continue” + עוֹד “still/again” + inf. cstr. with prep. לְ) is the positively formulated promise in v. 22 of protecting the continuation of existence. This opens with the temporal adverb עוֹד “yet,” emphasizing the contrast with Yhwh’s cursing of the soil and smiting of the earth, which has by now been ruled out for the future. Already from early on, the phrase “Still all the days of the earth” had led to the question of whether this also refers to a “restriction of all that had been created,”¹³⁸ but the focus of the verse lies rather in the duration and recurrence of the fundamental rhythms of life. The pairs “sowing and reaping” and “summer and winter,” mentioned first and third, respectively, designate the seasonal changes of the year, while the pair “day and night” mentioned at the end refers to the rhythm of the day. It is unclear whether the pair “frost and heat” mentioned second refers to the cool of the night and the heat of the day (see חֶם הַיּוֹם “heat of the day” in Gen 18:1; 1 Sam 11:11; 2 Sam 4:5). If so, then the yearly and daily rhythms alternate in the passage. If חֶם “heat” means summer (see Jer 17:8; Job 24:19), then the first three pairs are about the steady changing of the seasons, and only the fourth pair is about the course of the day. Whatever the case may be, the meaning of the promise is clear: The state of the

¹³⁵ Rendtorff, 1961, 72 [translation JWR]. See already Procksch, 69 and now also Levin, 1993, 108 (with reference to Riehm, 1885, 780).

¹³⁶ Steck, 1971, 532f. According to Steck (see also Westermann, 455), Gen 8:21 therefore refers only to the Flood. However, the clear references to Gen 3:17 (and 5:29) speak against this.

¹³⁷ See Crüsemann, 1981, 24. Similarly Baumgart, 1999, 153–162.

¹³⁸ Zimmerli, 295 [translation JWR]. See already Ibn Ezra, *ad. loc.*, and for discussion, see Schorch, 2014, 371–383.

fundamental temporal order is a perpetual act of mercy for not only Noah but the entire postdiluvian humanity. The steady rhythm of the days and seasons attests to Yhwh's mercy, who makes his sun rise over evil and good and brings rain over just and unjust (Matt 5:45). This maxim-like conclusion is self-contained both compositionally and conceptually, but with Gen 2:4b, it forms a frame around the Scholarly Narrator's Primeval History.¹³⁹ Communication to Noah is "not to be expected" after these solemn rhythms with which the Scholarly Narrator's Flood narrative "fades wonderfully away."¹⁴⁰

9:1–17

- 1 *Then God blessed Noah and his sons and said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth.*
- 2 *And the fear and dread of you will be over all the animals of the earth and over all the flying animals of the heavens; with all that crawls upon the ground and with all the fish of the sea, they are given into your hand.*
- 3 *Everything that stirs, that is living, shall serve you as nourishment. I give to you everything like the green of the herb.*
- 4 *Only flesh with its life, its blood, shall you not eat.*
- 5 *And only your blood, your own shall I claim, from every animal shall I claim it and from the person, from each, their brother, shall I claim the person's life:*
- 6 *Whoever sheds human blood, their blood will be shed for humanity's sake, for as the image of God did he make humanity.*
- 7 *You, however, be fruitful and multiply, teem upon the earth and become vast upon it."*
- 8 *And God said to Noah and to his sons who were with him,*
- 9 *"But I, behold, I establish now my covenant with you and with your descendants after you*
- 10 *and with all living beings that are with you, of flying animals, of livestock, and of all the animals of the earth with you, from all that come out of the ark, for all animals of the earth.*
- 11 *I will thus establish my covenant with you, so that all flesh shall never again be cut off by the waters of the Great Flood, and there shall never again be a Great Flood to destroy the earth."*
- 12 *And God said, "This is the sign of the covenant that I now make between me and you and all living beings who are with you, for everlasting generations.*

¹³⁹ See Witte, 1998, 184f.; Uehlinger, 1990, 339f., and already Rendtorff, 1961, 74.

¹⁴⁰ Gunkel, 66.

- 13 *I hereby give my bow into the clouds, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth.*
- 14 *When I pile clouds up over the earth and the bow appears in the clouds,*
- 15 *then I shall remember my covenant between me and you and all living beings, with all flesh. And the waters shall never again become a Great Flood to destroy all flesh.*
- 16 *When the bow is in the clouds, then I shall look upon it and remember an eternal covenant between God and all living beings with all flesh that is upon the earth."*
- 17 *And God said to Noah, "This is the sign of the covenant that I have established between me and all flesh that is upon the earth."*

The second, outwardly directed epilogue comes from the Priestly Writing. Its partially redundant style and the multitude of supposedly unrelated themes have often led to the assumption of literary growth within the Priestly tradition. This is possible, but it can hardly be proven in detail.

Within Gen 9:1–7, vv. 1–3 are unanimously considered part of the basic material of the Priestly Writing.¹⁴¹ Verses 4–6 are often understood as a later addition,¹⁴² while v. 4 is sometimes included as part of the basic material and v. 7 is seen as a redactional resumptive repetition of v. 1.¹⁴³ However, the reasons of content and style given for this cannot bear the burden of proof imposed upon them.¹⁴⁴ Concerning the conceptional considerations on the character of the Priestly Writing that have been raised, the assumption that the Priestly Writing originally offered only a historical narrative and that all "legal" passages were the product of inner- and post-Priestly additions can be considered obsolete. Even the reference to the Priestly conception of the cult having been founded only in Mosaic times at Sinai is not a sufficient argument for considering the prohibition against consuming blood in v. 4 to be out of place and, therefore, redactional. Like the structuring of Creation around the Sabbath, the prohibition against consuming blood is one of the fundamental orders that are then implemented cultically for Israel with the foundation of the Sabbath and the institution of sacrificial service. In other words: Just as the Sabbath presupposes the structure of the world, which itself is given well before the foundation of the Sabbath for Israel, so do the relevant cult regulations also presuppose the understanding of blood as "life force." Not only is this inherited by the cult; it also requires special handling of the blood when killing animals for food even before the establishment of the cult. There has also been an argument raised that, linguistically, *בָּשָׂר* in v. 4 means "meat," while in the Priestly Flood narrative, it denotes human and animal life. Nevertheless, the semantic range of the term encompasses both meanings, which are

¹⁴¹ Only Levin, 1993, 111, sees the entire speech as a later addition. He reduces the original epilogue to the Priestly Flood narrative to Gen 9:8–9, 11aβb.

¹⁴² McEvenue, 1971, 67–71; Zenger, 1987, 105–107; Rütterswörden, 1993, 131f.

¹⁴³ Mosis, 1994.

¹⁴⁴ Steck, 1997^a, 122f.; Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 248–252. See there also on what follows.

further marked by the distinction between בָּשָׂר “flesh” (see Gen 17:11; Exod 12:8 [P]) and כָּל-בָּשָׂר “all flesh.” For the redactional character of vv. 5f., it is often raised that Gen 9:1–7 is otherwise about the relationship between human and animal, while vv. 5f. are aimed more generally at the protection of human life. Some see it to be particularly conspicuous that v. 2 emphasizes human hegemony over the animals while v. 5 is based on animals posing a threat to humanity. However, there is no factual contradiction to be seen in this. God’s declaration that the animals will live in fear and dread of humanity does not in any way mean that animals cannot be a danger to humanity. Rather, the opposite is true. Verses 5f. take up the theme of v. 2 but deepen it through the aspect of the endangerment of human life. In this context – connected through the word “blood” – the killing of human beings by other humans is logically also addressed, which is critical for establishing an order for dealing with violence. The fact that v. 6 speaks of God in the third person even within the divine speech can be explained by the phrase צֶלֶם אֱלֹהִים “image of God” taken up from Gen 1:27, because this requires speaking of God in the third person. Moreover, what *is* conspicuous, and possibly an indication for later literary growth, is the sequence of וְאָדָם ... וְחַיָּה as an introduction to v. 4 and vv. 5f. This suggests that v. 4 and vv. 5f. should be read as a single unit. This has led to problems, since v. 4 uses וְאָדָם “only” to qualify v. 3, while וְחַיָּה “and only” in v. 5 should not be understood in the same qualifying manner but functions rather adversatively. In v. 5b, the אָחִיו “their brother” interrupts the series of the threefold מִיָּד “from” and is probably a later addition, maybe even alluding to the Fratricide narrative in Gen 4 and emphasizing that all murder is fratricide.

In Gen 9:8–17, v. 16 seems like later fill. The verse repeats what has been said previously and, with the wording of the “covenant between God and all living beings,” breaks from the linguistic style of divine speech, which otherwise speaks consistently of “my covenant” or “the covenant between me and...” Additionally, there is another small terminological shift. In v. 15, “all living beings” (כָּל-נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה) refers to only the animals, since Noah is mentioned earlier (“you”), while in v. 16, it refers to human and animal – otherwise, the conclusion to the covenant according to v. 16 would refer exclusively to the animals.

In the Priestly Flood narrative, this section continues the divine speech that follows the depiction of the Flood, which was divided into two main parts by the notice of everyone leaving the ark in Gen 8:18–19. However, in the present text, it has the function of communicating Yhwh’s promise from Gen 8:20–22 of the earth’s continued existence, which to this point was known only to the readers, and of solemnly confirming it to Noah and his sons by the making of the covenant. Furthermore, the passage presents God’s order for the postdiluvian world. Thus, like the Scholarly Narrator’s epilogue, it is oriented entirely around the significance of the Flood for the present day of both the authors and their intended audience, with the two epilogues coming to stand in competition with each other, notwithstanding the well-conceived redactional arrangement. The Redaction followed the Priestly Flood narrative for the finale of its version, insofar as the Priestly epilogue occupies the final position in the present text and goes into much greater detail about the conditions of the postdiluvian world.

The section is divided into two speeches, each of which ends with its beginning being taken back up again at its end, in only slightly modified form (Gen 9:1 and 7; Gen 9:8f. and 17). In contrast to the preceding divine speech, these are not directed at Noah alone but also at his sons, since they are each about the continuance of the human race, which stems from Noah. The post-diluvian order of Creation under the auspices of the violence that has come into the world is unfolded in the first speech. The second speech is dedicated to the establishment of God's eternal covenant with the living beings of his Creation. Through this bipartite division, the stipulations for a regulated handling of violence are separated from the promise for the earth's continuous existence: The promise of the covenant is in effect regardless of the observance of the previously issued regulations.

9:1–7

- 1 *Then God blessed Noah and his sons and said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth.*
- 2 *And the fear and dread of you will be over all the animals of the earth and over all the flying animals of the heavens; with all that crawls upon the ground and with all the fish of the sea, they are given into your hand.*
- 3 *Everything that stirs, that is living, shall serve you as nourishment. I give to you everything like the green of the herb.*
- 4 *Only flesh with its life, its blood, shall you not eat.*
- 5 *And only your blood, your own shall I claim, from every animal shall I claim it and from the person, from each, their brother, shall I claim the person's life:*
- 6 *Whoever sheds human blood, their blood will be shed for humanity's sake, for as the image of God did he make humanity.*
- 7 *You, however, be fruitful and multiply, teem upon the earth and become vast upon it."*

The first speech unmistakably draws on the Priestly Creation account, and more specifically on the blessing and the commission for humanity to rule over the earth as well as the allocations of food for humanity and the animals in Gen 1:29–30. Two basic types of interpretation can be distinguished among evaluations of this situation: The first emphasizes both the continuity with Gen 1:28–30 regarding humanity's relationship to its fellow creatures as well as the idea of the restitution of the creationary order under altered conditions,¹⁴⁵ while the other focuses on its discontinuity with

¹⁴⁵ See Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 248–270.

Gen 1:28–30.¹⁴⁶ The second alternative is more convincing, as it recognizes a strict dividing line between the original Creation on the one hand and the lived realities of the authors and their audience on the other, following its predecessor in the Mesopotamian Flood tradition. The experience of violence among creatures is part of this postdiluvian reality of life up to the present. Such is not foreseen in the original order of the “very good” Creation (Gen 1:31), but the detailed allocation of exclusively vegetable food to human and animal (Gen 1:29–30) could not prevent the emergence of violence, which ran so rampant that it brought the world to the brink of total annihilation (Gen 6:11–13). Violence is not eliminated from the world through the Great Flood, but it is subjected to regulations in response to the experience that violence is part of the reality of life. Thus, the world can exist despite violence; however, this comes at the high price of the distinction between tolerated violence of humanity towards animals (and of animals among each other) and violence towards humans, which is to be punished individually.

The first blessing of multiplication is contextually given to “man and woman” (see Gen 1:28), while its renewal in v. 1 is addressed only to men. This corresponds to the patrilineal structure of the Table of Nations in Gen 10 and the genealogy in Gen 11:10ff. (see also Gen 5), in which the blessing of multiplication begins to be realized. However, more important for understanding the passage is the anthropocentric perspective: The blessing is given only to humanity and not to the animals (see Gen 8:15–17). The stipulations of the postdiluvian order are a blessing for humanity but a horror for the animals. Accordingly, violence is addressed only in terms of human perpetrators and victims. The killing of animals by animals remains unmentioned (cf. Ps 104:21). For the postdiluvian order, it is taken for granted and is no longer considered to be an act of violence that could initiate a new Great Flood.

In comparison with the blessing of multiplication in Gen 1:28, it is further conspicuous that humanity taking the earth into its possession is not mentioned, since this is still in force. The only thing that has changed is humanity’s relationship to the animals – and fundamentally so. Appearing in place of humanity’s empowerment to rule over its fellow creatures is their fear and terror before humanity. It is important for understanding this new order that the reformulation uses war language as a metaphor. The spreading of fear and terror takes up, with its language slightly modified, the concept of the “divine terror” with which Yhwh drives away Israel’s enemies during the conquest of the land (see Deut 2:24f.; 11:25; instead of פֶּחַד “terror” in

¹⁴⁶ See Schellenberg, 2011, 60–68.

Deut 2:25; 11:25, the synonymous *תָּה* is used in Gen 9:2. The noun is only otherwise attested in Job 41:25, with the corresponding verb in 1 Sam 2:4; Jer 46:5). Resonating in the promise that the animals of the land, sea, and air are “given into the hands” of humanity is the formulation of divine oracles promising success in war (e.g., Judg 4:7, 14; 7:2), which, according to the larger ancient Near Eastern war ideology, means the complete transfer of ownership of the enemies into Israel’s power of control (see Neh 9:24: “The inhabitants of the land... you have given them into their hands... for them to do with them as they please”). Verse 2 thus describes the relationship between human and animal as a state of war in which God has already established humanity as the victor, which of course does not mean that the threat that animals pose to humanity has been *de facto* overcome (see v. 5). In place of hegemony by the royal human being, which has positive connotations in Gen 1:28, is the establishment of war and the victor’s power of control. The order of peace in the original Creation, which was *de facto* terminated by the humans and animals, is thus abolished by the Creator God in favor of an order of violence.

Verse 3a instantiates the transfer of animals into humanity’s control through its right to kill animals for food. This is sometimes understood to mean that the permission to kill animals is tied back to obtaining food, but it should still be noted here that the allowance for meat as food is not formulated (at least, explicitly) as limiting human violence upon animals to this purpose.¹⁴⁷ The killing of animals for other reasons, such as in fending off predators or pests, for sacrificial purposes, or in demonstrating royal power through hunting, is not seen as a problem. This is in view just as little as modern concepts of animal protection. Of course, it is also true that vv. 2–3 are certainly not aimed at allowing for the extermination of animal species.¹⁴⁸ Such an understanding can hardly be reconciled with the fact that, according to Gen 9:8–17, all animals are included in God’s eternal covenant.¹⁴⁹

Verse 3b compares meat with the “green of the herb” that, according to Gen 1:30, is assigned to animals as food, while humanity receives the seed-bearing trees as food. The aim of this comparison is not exactly clear. Does humanity also receive herbs as food, which were once reserved for animals?¹⁵⁰ Or will meat be abundant “like the green of the herb” (for the simile “as

¹⁴⁷ See Schellenberg, 2011, 65. Cf. Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 262.

¹⁴⁸ The modern-day extinction of animal species has reached proportions that would have been beyond human imagination for ancient authors. Nevertheless, the phenomenon was not unheard-of. The lion, so significant in iconography, disappeared from Palestine as early as the thirteenth century BCE, and the Syrian elephant was eradicated as early as the eighth century BCE.

¹⁴⁹ See Janowski, 2012, 517.

¹⁵⁰ This being the majority opinion.

numerous as the herb,” see Job 5:25; Ps 72:16; 92:8; Deut 32:2; Mic 5:6; Prov 19:12)?¹⁵¹ Reality may have rather corresponded to the first alternative. The plants available as human food in ancient Israel, as in the present, were not limited to seed-bearing trees. Moreover, meat was expensive to produce in antiquity and not available in abundance. In any case, by releasing meat for consumption, as opposed to the original intention of all creatures being vegetarians, the Creator God is making a concession to the violent tendencies of humanity (and other predators).

Verses 4–6 set important limits around what was previously mandated. Verse 4 formulates a restriction on the release of killing for the sake of food and forbids the consumption of blood, in which life force is found (see Lev 17:11: “for the life of flesh is the blood”; see also Lev 17:14; Deut 12:23). In the context of v. 3, the difficult wording of the prohibition “Only flesh with its life, its blood, shall you not eat” is aimed less at the ritual aspect of the prohibition and more primarily at the life (נֶפֶשׁ) of the animal, which has just been released as food. Unlike in Lev 3:17; 7:26; 17:10f., 14, or Deut 12:23–25, this does not say that blood cannot be consumed, only flesh that still has blood as its life force. Thus, the emphasis is on animal meat¹⁵² only being allowed for consumption once it no longer contains the life force from its blood.¹⁵³ The reason for this specification may lie in the fact that earlier, in v. 3, the animals released for consumption are designated as “living.”¹⁵⁴ This raises the question of how to deal with the “life” of these animals, as killing them for food always involves life, which is considered taboo and sacrosanct.¹⁵⁵ The prohibition therefore comes out of the respect of life, “serv[ing] the permanent realization that life comes from the Creator and requires limiting human action, even with all power and discretion of control.”¹⁵⁶ In practice, this naturally results in the cultic provisions for handling blood and for slaughtering, as has always been emphasized in the reception of Gen 9:4.¹⁵⁷

¹⁵¹ See Baumgart, 1999, 307f. as a representative of the minority opinion.

¹⁵² In v. 4, בֶּשָׂר designates (like in Lev 17:10f., 14; Deut 12:23) fully concretely the edible part of an animal corpse. See Millard, 2001, 102, in distinction to the rabbinic view that the בֶּשָׂר in v. 4 is part of a still-living animal.

¹⁵³ See Schellenberg, 2011, 64.

¹⁵⁴ The relative clause “that is living” may, for its part, emphasize that animals are killed first for the purposes of food, and so human beings do not eat carrion (see Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 261 fn. 636, with reference to Exod 22:30; Lev 11:40; 17:15; 22:8). Rabbinic tradition elaborates on the connection with Gen 9:4 by regarding v. 4 as the justification for the Noachide prohibition against eating part of a still-living animal. See further Millard, 2001, 99–107.

¹⁵⁵ See von Rad, 131f.; Baumgart, 1999, 311.

¹⁵⁶ Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 264 [translation JWR].

¹⁵⁷ Cf. Westermann, 465; Ruppert, 385, who detach Gen 9:4 from the relevant cultic legal provisions and understand it such that the prohibition, after the allowance for meat consumption, seeks to oppose bloodlust, or killing for the sake of killing.

Verses 5–6 fall under the overall theme of “shedding human blood.” The introductory **וְאִם** “And only” closely connects v. 5 with v. 4 and its opening **וְאִם** “only.” The wording, which is not very smooth, must be understood such that the following v. 5 qualifies the handling of the life force in blood that is described in v. 4. This reading is strengthened by the emphatic inclusion of the two terms **דָּם** “blood” and **נֶפֶשׁ** “life” from v. 4 at the beginning of v. 5. If, up to this point, the focus has been on animal blood in connection with the release of killing animals for food, it has now become about human blood being violently shed by animals or humans. Both possibilities are considered to be acts of violence, and God takes responsibility for sanctioning them both. The leading position of animals killing human beings, which can hardly constitute the majority of cases, takes up the content of v. 2 and resulted from the entire passage being oriented around defining the relationship between human and animal. The killing of animals by humans, which had already been negotiated, was considered an act of violence even before the new regulations and now prepares the way for the discussion of the killing of human beings by other humans. The spilling of human blood is part of reality and, for this reason alone, must be included when ordering the handling of violence. The importance of this topic for the authors is shown in the emphatic naming of the perpetrators upon whom the violently shed blood is to be claimed. In terms of its form, the first link, “from the person,” would have sufficed. The following “from each [individual]” underscores that the claim is made independent of the race, gender, class, or ethnicity of the perpetrator. The **אָחִיו** “their brother,” which is probably a later addition, emphasizes that each murder is a murder among siblings.¹⁵⁸ No less emphatic is the threefold “I shall claim [your blood],” once as a preamble and then the other two times in reference to the respective perpetrators. The takes up the idea of the unconditional appreciation of life from v. 3 and underscores how much violent bloodshed affects the sovereignty of the Creator God and must therefore inevitably provoke a reaction from him.

Verse 6, which is formulated in grammatic parallelism (*parallelismus membrorum*), continues the high tone with a tripartite chiasm: **שָׁפַךְ** “shed” – **דָּם** “blood” – **בְּאָדָם** “human” // **בְּאָדָם** “human” – **דָּמוֹ** “blood” – **שָׁפַךְ** “shed.” The controversial and decisive aspect for understanding the statement is how to translate the preposition **בְּ** in **בְּאָדָם**. This decides whether the verse sets up humanity as the executor of the death penalty or whether it is making a fundamental claim about murderers forfeiting their lives. The classic view holds along the lines of the first alternative that it is a *beth instrumenti* (“instrumental *beth*”) and that the following provision should be translated

¹⁵⁸ See already Jacob, 246f. Cf. Gunkel, 149: **אִישׁ אָחִיו** “is a fixed idiom for ‘one another’.”

as “by man shall his blood be shed” (KJV).¹⁵⁹ The subsequent recourse to humanity being “as the image of God” in v. 6b would then be understood as both securing the inviolability of human life and justifying the postdiluvian extension of humanity’s function as ruler over the earth through authorizing it to execute the death penalty.¹⁶⁰ However, there are several rather strong arguments that have been raised against this view and instead speak in favor of the *beth* being a *beth pretii* (“*beth* of price”) that indicates the reason for the guilt and, like in the translation proposed here, should be rendered as “on account of humanity/for humanity’s sake.”¹⁶¹

1. The strict chiasm speaks in favor of אָדָם “person/human” in the preceding clause not designating any entity different from in the following provision. In both cases, אָדָם is meant as the victim. 2. Across the Hebrew Bible, אָדָם never otherwise means “through humanity/the human being.” 3. The precept formulated in v. 6 is reminiscent of *lex talionis* formulae, which typically connect deed and consequence through תַּחַת “in place of” (see Exod 21:23–25; Lev 24:19f.), although Deut 19:21 formulates the equivalent with a *beth pretii* (see also 2 Sam 3:27). 4. The LXX translates it quite freely but appears likewise to understand it as a *beth pretii*: “Whoever spills the blood of a human, for its blood [ἀντὶ τοῦ αἵματος αὐτοῦ] will [blood] be shed.” ἀντὶ means “for, for the sake of, because,” and not “through,” and also functions in Deut 19:21 as the equivalent translation for the *beth pretii*. 5. Verse 5 emphasizes that God himself demands the bloodguilt, which is why it seems that v. 6 does not commit itself to the fulfillment of this demand through humanity – unless Gen 9:6 is understood as providing the beginning to the installment of human authority as the “executor of the direct divine will.”¹⁶²

Whoever kills a human being incurs bloodguilt and must answer with their blood for that person’s sake. The “how?” remains open in the present aphorism, which has probably come from earlier tradition (see also Matt 26:52). Verse 6b justifies this precept with reference to humanity having been created as the image of God. As in Gen 1:26f., this concerns humanity’s special position among all the created beings. In the context of the regulation of violence after the Flood, this is instantiated along the same lines as v. 5 as the inviolability of human life beyond all distinctions of race, gender, class, or ethnicity. When a human being is killed, God himself is directly involved, since every human being is his image. For this reason, God himself claims the blood of the perpetrator. The allowance of killing animals does not legitimate

¹⁵⁹ Jacob, 246; von Rad, 132f.; Westermann, 468 and more recently Steck, 1997^a, 128; Stipp, 2001, 138; Schüle, 2006, 253; Janowski, 2012, 516.

¹⁶⁰ Steck, 1997^a, 129.

¹⁶¹ For the fundamental aspects, see Ernst, 1990, with reference to HS §106e. See further Jenni, 1992, 154; Seebaß, 204; Neumann-Gorsolke, 2004, 251; Arndt, 2007, 72 fn. 177; Schellenberg, 2011, 61.

¹⁶² von Rad, 133. Similarly Jacob, 246: “The judgment... is the representation of God, who lets those die who, as murders, are no longer an image of God” [translation JWR].

the killing of human beings; this transformation of the *dominium terrae* into a reign of terror over the animals does not authorize violent authority among human beings. This is “the quintessence taking up Gen 1:28 and its context in a new situation.”¹⁶³ But how does Gen 9:5f. relate to the death penalty, which legal texts of the Hebrew Bible impose upon humans (see Exod 21:12; Deut 19:12) and animals (Exod 21:28–32) for deliberately killing human beings? This is also taken out of the general prohibition against killing when translated as “on account of humanity,” since the perpetrator is threatened with a fate corresponding to the deed. The death penalty is thus allowed as a possibility but not demanded as obligatory. The divine judgment is not in need of any human assistance (v. 5).¹⁶⁴

Verse 7 returns to the beginning of the first speech with the emphasized “you” (pl.). The quadripartite chain of imperatives is structured into two sequences whose two respective sub-units are connected through the conjunction “and” and, moreover, conclude with the same imperative to “become vast/numerous.”¹⁶⁵ This emphatic reference to multiplication is meant to bring to mind the initial situation of the near-complete annihilation of humanity by the Flood.

9:8–17

- 8 *And God said to Noah and to his sons who were with him,*
- 9 *“But I, behold, I establish now my covenant with you and with*
 your descendants after you
- 10 *and with all living beings that are with you, of flying animals, of*
 livestock, and of all the animals of the earth with you, from all that
 come out of the ark, for all animals of the earth.
- 11 *I will thus establish my covenant with you, so that all flesh shall*
 never again be cut off by the waters of the Great Flood, and there
 shall never again be a Great Flood to destroy the earth.”
- 12 *And God said, “This is the sign of the covenant that I now make*
 between me and you and all living beings who are with you, for
 everlasting generations.
- 13 *I hereby give my bow into the clouds, and it shall be a sign of*
 the covenant between me and the earth.
- 14 *When I pile clouds up over the earth and the bow appears in the*
 clouds,

¹⁶³ Ebach, 1986, 45 [translation JWR].

¹⁶⁴ Schnocks, 2014, 85f.

¹⁶⁵ See Arneth, 2007, 73.

- 15 *then I shall remember my covenant between me and you and all living beings, with all flesh. And the waters shall never again become a Great Flood to destroy all flesh.*
- 16 *When the bow is in the clouds, then I shall look upon it and remember an eternal covenant between God and all living beings with all flesh that is upon the earth.”*
- 17 *And God said to Noah, “This is the sign of the covenant that I have established between me and all flesh that is upon the earth.”*

The subject of the second speech is the covenant that God makes with all living beings (with exception of the sea dwellers), which contains the promise never again to bring another Flood. The speech is structured through the threefold “And God said” (vv. 8, 12, 17). Numerous repetitions make it sometimes difficult to follow the text’s train of thought, and they also speak at first glance in favor of the present passage having been formed over multiple stages. However, the evidence for this is difficult, except for v. 16. The redundant manner of speech can be read as an expression of a “great solemnity”¹⁶⁶ with which the Priestly Writing introduces the divine covenant and concludes the Flood narrative.

In the first section of the speech (vv. 8–11), God announces to Noah and his sons the imminent establishment of a covenant (*futurum instans* in v. 10; continuation with *w-qatal-x* in v. 11).¹⁶⁷ This covenant applies to Noah as well as his descendants, thus already foreshadowing the later eternal guarantee (vv. 12b, 16b), and to all animals who were with Noah on the ark and who had already been commissioned to multiply themselves when they came out of the ark (Gen 8:17). The content of the covenant itself is provided in v. 11: God’s promise never again to abandon the earth and all life upon it to annihilation via flood and to remember this over and over through the sign of the covenant. Although this covenant differs from the covenant that God promised to Noah immediately before the Flood in its addressees, content, and duration, the two are clearly related to each other. The covenant promised to Noah before the Flood prefigures the eternal covenant made with all of the survivors and their descendants: The sequence presented in the Flood narrative of the establishment of the covenant (Gen 6:18) and God’s turn to salvation amid the catastrophe due to his remembrance (Gen 8:1) serves as the pledge that even in the future, God will act just like the Flood narrative tells of him acting.¹⁶⁸ Moreover, within the Priestly Writing, the covenant points ahead to the covenant with Abraham, which differs in its

¹⁶⁶ Gunkel, 150.

¹⁶⁷ Groß, 1998, 51. See also *ibid.*, 47–52, and also on the following.

¹⁶⁸ Baumgart, 1999, 343f.

content but nevertheless has an analogous structure: God “establishes” the covenant (vv. 9, 11, 17 and Gen 17:7) or “makes” it (v. 12 and Gen 17:2). The covenant is an “eternal covenant” (v. 16 and Gen 17:7) and “my covenant” (vv. 9, 11 and Gen 17:2, 4, 7, 9, 13f.) guaranteed through God remembering it (vv. 15f. and Exod 2:24; 6:5 with reference to Gen 17). A “sign of the covenant” is assigned to it as well (vv. 12, 13, 17 and Gen 17:11). The most important feature that they share, however, is how neither covenant is tied to any condition for its unbreakability. This is also evident in the structure of Gen 9:1–17. The provisions in Gen 9:1–7 are set while already having the reality of their transgression in mind (see merely v. 5f.). Since the newly ordered world in Gen 9:1–7 is, by its very nature, no different or better than the one annihilated during the Great Flood, the promise of the covenant in Gen 9:8–17 is given without any link back to what had previously been said.

The second section of the speech (vv. 12–16) revolves around the sign of the covenant and the implementation of the covenant “[through] the establishment of the sign.”¹⁶⁹ The sequence “participle – verb form” in vv. 12 and 13 (נָתַתִּי and *x-qatal* נָתַתִּי) signals simultaneity, i.e., the situation in the sentence comes into being as it is spoken.¹⁷⁰ In other words, the actual making of the covenant takes place in vv. 12f., specifically as God hangs his bow (קֶשֶׁף) in the clouds as a sign of the covenant. The passage clearly thinks of קֶשֶׁף as a rainbow (see Ezek 1:28): “When it so thunders as to strike the fear of a repeated Flood, the rainbow appears thereafter in the sky as the sun, and mercy, bursts through again.”¹⁷¹ However, the symbolism is not limited to the natural phenomenon of a rainbow.¹⁷² In most of its appearances in the Hebrew Bible, the term קֶשֶׁף bears militaristic connotations and signifies the weapon of an archer. The attribution of the bow to God, marked through the possessive suffix (so “my bow”), implies that this is a divine weapon as attested elsewhere across the ancient Near East.¹⁷³ It has been suggested that the weapon symbolized by the rainbow signifies God’s constant warlike readiness to intervene on behalf of his Creation against the forces of chaos in order to prevent another Flood.¹⁷⁴ However, this interpretation does not fit very well with the Flood narrative. The forces of chaos are not mentioned at all when the Flood comes, which is why the warlike God must instead prevent himself from bringing another Flood.¹⁷⁵ This speaks for the alternative

¹⁶⁹ Arneth, 2007, 87 [translation JWR].

¹⁷⁰ Rüterswörden, 1993, 137.

¹⁷¹ Wellhausen, 1905, 311 fn. 1 [translation JWR].

¹⁷² Cf. Jacob, 256; Westermann, 473.

¹⁷³ See already Wellhausen, 1905, 311 fn. 1; Gunkel, 150f. as well as the discussion in Zenger, 1987, 124–131; Rüterswörden, 1993, 131–154.

¹⁷⁴ Zenger, 1987, 131.

¹⁷⁵ Rüterswörden, 1993, 131–154, and there also on the following.

interpretation in which God's bow in Gen 9:12–16 does not symbolize God's triumph over the forces of chaos or the annihilated earth but reminds him of his desire for peace. Accordingly, the statement "I hereby give my bow into the clouds" (v. 13) should be understood as a promise that God has laid down the deadly weapon that he used against humanity and will remember this in the future when the rainbow appears. Thus, it must concern a bow that is not ready to fire. At first, this may seem surprising given the curvature of a rainbow, which may impulsively evoke the memory of a toy bow from one's childhood, but it becomes plausible when taking a look at the history of the weapon. Following the type from weapon technology contemporary to the text, the rainbow-like bow is a composite bow with several layers joined together; it boasts a strong curve when at rest but becomes almost straight when readied. When not in use, such bows were stored without string, curved into a semicircular arc reminiscent of the arc of a rainbow. In short, the bow symbolizes not God's readiness for war but his desire to set weapons aside forever.

Verse 17, which opens with another introduction of speech, relates back to the making of the covenant and forms an *inclusio* with v. 9. In the Priestly Writing, the *toledot* of Noah end with Gen 9:18a, 19(?), 28–29. In the present text, the Priestly conclusion is broken up by the narrative of Noah the winegrower, which comes entirely from the Redaction.

THE SONS OF NOAH – THE SIN OF HAM AND
THE CURSE OF CANAAN

- 9:18a** And the sons of Noah who came out of the ark were Shem, Ham, and Japheth.
- 18b** And Ham, he was the father of Canaan.
- 19** **These three are the sons of Noah, and from them the whole earth was populated.**
- 20** And Noah, the fieldworker, began and planted a vineyard.
- 21** And he drank from the wine and became drunk and exposed himself in the midst of his tent.
- 22** And Ham, the father of Canaan, saw his father's shame. And he told this to his two brothers outside.
- 23** Then Shem and Japheth took^[sing.] the cloak and laid^[pl.] [it] on both their shoulders, and they walked backwards and they covered their father's shame; their faces stayed facing backwards, and they did not see their father's shame.
- 24** And Noah awoke from his wine, and he realized what his youngest son had done to him.
- 25** And he said: "Cursed be Canaan – servant of servants shall he be for his brothers."
- 26** And he said, "Blessed be Yhwh, the God of Shem – and Canaan shall be their servant.
- 27** Wide space may God create for Japheth, and he shall dwell in the tents of Shem – and Canaan shall be their servant.
- 28** **And Noah lived 350 years after the Flood.**
- 29** **Thus, the total lifetime of Noah was 950 years, and then he died.**

Analysis: Priestly Writing: Gen 9:18a, 28–29; Redaction: Gen 9:18b, 20–27. The assignment of v. 19 to either the Priestly Writing or the Redaction remains uncertain.

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TEXT-CRITICAL AND PHILOLOGICAL NOTES

9:20 אִישׁ הָאֲדָמָה (*fieldworker*): “Fieldworker” stands in apposition to Noah. The “beginning” refers to viticulture. See Dillmann, 159; Holzinger, 90; cf. *GKC* §120b.

9:26 עֲבָדָם לָמוֹ (*their servant*): The poetic form לָמוֹ (לְ with the 3rd pers. plur. suffix) is difficult. The LXX reads a singular in v. 26b (for him = Shem) and a plural in v. 27b. *GKC* §103f. Note 2 maintains that לָמוֹ can also stand for לוֹ “for him” but for Gen 9:26f. assumes a plural that references a collective. Most likely, לָמוֹ refers to “his brothers” in v. 25, thus creating a nice refrain. This reference is clear, since vv. 26b, 27 take up the “servant” from v. 25.

ESSENTIALS AND PERSPECTIVES

The section, typically titled “Noah’s Blessings and Curses,” differs significantly from its context in its narrative style. At the center stands the tale of Noah’s drunkenness and the differing reactions of his sons Shem, Ham, and Japheth, resulting in Noah’s blessing of Shem and Japheth and his cursing

of Ham's son Canaan. Despite its far-reaching consequences, the narrative is formulated quite economically. The incidents surrounding Noah's drunkenness are more insinuated than described. Ham's actual offense remains unnamed despite prompting a harsh and intergenerational reaction. Nor does the narrative give any reason *prima facie* for Canaan, Ham's youngest son, being cursed for the actions of his father. Moreover, the reflections and dialogues that give the other narratives in the biblical Primeval History their theological depth are absent. The narrative's incorporation into its present context is also striking. The episode is related to the Flood narrative in its exposition (vv. 18f.) and conclusion (vv. 28f.) but functions like an appendix to the epilogue of the Flood narrative (Gen 8:20–22; 9:1–17). At the same time, the exposition explicitly points ahead to the Table of Nations in the following chapter (v. 19). In short, Gen 9:18–29 can be characterized as an interlude, given the narrative movements, which are detailed only economically, and the specifically thematized reference to the events before and after it.

The passage, which usually stands in the shadow of the more prominent texts of the Primeval History, displays several tricky problems concerning its formation. It had classically been assigned to the Yahwist, but there has since been a clear tendency towards a post-Priestly attribution. The dating to the postexilic period inherent in this attribution also helps in better understanding the content of the passage: The claim of Canaan being cursed from generation to generation provides a primordial justification for the strict separation of "Israel" from "Canaan." Conceptually, this belongs within the era of the postexilic "Restoration" and the demand by the book of Ezra for the Judeans to separate themselves from the "foreign women," whom they took as wives "from the people of the land," as well as the children that they had with them.

There have been horrendous consequences of certain interpretations of this passage throughout history. Despite the lack of any mention in the Hebrew Bible itself, it was claimed early on that the ill-reputed "Ham" was the ancestor of all people with black skin. Given the cross-cultural phenomenon of "Othering," in which the "Other," such as in terms of skin color, is seen as inferior to a self-defined norm, and the fact that the Primeval History had been authored and handed down mostly by people not of color, Ham became an easy target for a pejorative etiology of black skin. Through his offense against Noah, he was already of bad repute in the Hebrew Bible and, moreover, was considered the father of Kush, the inhabitants of Nubia, the land to the south of Egypt. In further reception, this aspect took on a life of its own – to great calamitous effect. According to a tradition transmitted by the rabbis and taken up by Islamic historians, Ham was punished with black skin because he slept with his wife on the ark despite a divine prohibition of such

(Gen. Rab. 36.7). Emerging in later interpretations, in first Islamic and then Christian contexts, was the idea of a double curse on Ham and his descendants. In this, they were given both black skin color and (rather than only Canaan, as per Gen 9:25) eternal existence as slaves. This became especially prominent in the time around the American Civil War (1861–1865), during which it served as a supposedly biblical foundation for slavery.¹ The so-called “Curse of Ham” is also ever-present in the current debate about racism in the United States – whether as a continued “rationalization” or as evidence of the biblical tradition’s complicity in slavery and its consequences.²

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION I: INTRODUCTION TO EXEGESIS

Structure: The exact delineation is a matter of debate. The Masoretes treated Gen 9:18–29 as one meaningful unit, which the Leningrad Codex indicates by a space between Gen 9:17 and 9:18 as well as a blank line between Gen 9:29 and 10:1. However, the clear reference to the Flood narrative in vv. 18f. is sometimes cited against this understanding.³ In any case, it is more important for the structure of the present text that v. 18 introduces the characters who appear in what follows and therefore must belong to the exposition of this narrative. Moreover, v. 19 introduces the fundamental perspective about the different “peoples” that is important for the blessings and curses in vv. 25–27.⁴ Verse 19 likewise necessarily presupposes v. 18. The affiliation of vv. 28f. is sometimes questioned, since the notice about Noah’s lifespan after the Flood, the age to which he lives, and his death comprise the end of the story of Noah.⁵ Although this observation is correct, the two verses should not be separated in the present text. In principle, the narrative could end already with the blessings and curses in vv. 25–27, but it would then lack any conclusion.⁶ In the present text, vv. 28f. conclude the story of Noah, the final act of which concerns the events in question about Noah and his sons. With the *toledot* formula in Gen 10:1, a new unit begins.

Given the references to the Great Flood, the exposition in vv. 18f. and the conclusion in vv. 28f. form a frame around the main part of the narrative.⁷ Formally, this is structured into a narrative section in vv. 20–24 and the blessings and curses in vv. 25–27.

¹ See Haynes, 2002; Goldenberg, 2017; Gertz, 2021.

² See Goldenberg, 1997.

³ Gunkel, 79; Vervenne, 1995^b; Schüle, 2006, 355f.

⁴ Hieke, 2003, 94.

⁵ Baumgart, 1999, 98; Vervenne, 1995^b, 44; Arneth, 2007, 47f.

⁶ Seebaß, 243, 250.

⁷ For a detailed structural analysis, see Vervenne, 1995^b, 44–48.

Formation: The disputes about how to define the passage already indicate a divide in its formation history between the exposition and the conclusion on the one side and the main part of the narrative on the other. Also indicative of this are the differences in details regarding the genealogical position of Ham in v. 18 and v. 24. With the sequence of “Shem – Ham – Japheth,” the exposition presupposes that Ham is the middle son (v. 18a; see Gen 5:32; 6:10; 7:13; 10:1;⁸ 1 Chr 1:4). In contrast, the main section has him as Noah’s youngest son (v. 24). Furthermore, Ham is emphatically mentioned twice as the father of Canaan (v. 18b; 22a). This in turn draws attention to Canaan, who is cursed on account of his father and appears in the blessings and curses as a brother of Shem and Japheth (vv. 25, 26, 27). These observations can be interpreted to show that v. 18 and vv. 20–27 could not have stemmed from the same hand and that it was only Ham’s secondary identification as the father of Canaan that gave the entire section its focus on Canaan.⁹ Furthermore, it is important to consider that the narrative in vv. 20–27 is dependent upon the exposition in vv. 18f. Without the introduction of the characters and the presentation of the familial relationships, the statement “to his two brothers” (v. 22) and the mention of the two brothers by name (v. 23) would both be quite surprising.¹⁰ For this reason, vv. 20–27 should be understood as an addition to vv. 18a, 19 that was connected via v. 18b. The literary-historical classification of the addition hinges on how v. 18a is understood. Like the concluding note in v. 28f., v. 18a belongs to the Priestly Writing.¹¹

The assignment of vv. 28f. to the Priestly Writing is undisputed. Conversely, v. 18a is generally attributed to the non-Priestly (“Yahwistic”) stratum. The reasons given for this are, however, weak: “The verses prove to be Yahwistic, as they would be completely superfluous in the *Grundschrift* [i.e., the Priestly Writing – JCG] since it has already listed the sons of Noah by name several times. In J, however, they have not yet been mentioned and are therefore necessary, if it knew them as well.”¹² This final point, however, is exactly the problem, since, with the exception of 1 Chr 1:4, all other attestations for the order “Shem, Ham, and Japheth” come from the Priestly Writing (Gen 5:32; 6:10; 7:13; 10:1). It is only for Gen 9:18 that a “Yahwistic” origin is supposed, i.e., for the very verse whose genealogical content is in tension with the following narrative, which is also supposedly “Yahwistic.” This observation corresponds to the fact that, as opposed to the Priestly version of

⁸ In Gen 10:1, 2ff., the genealogy is presented in reverse order, since the account ends with the descendants of the firstborn, Shem. However, this does not change Ham’s middle position.

⁹ See Gertz, 2010, 81–95 for a detailed justification and discussion of the literature, and also for the following.

¹⁰ See Baumgart, 1999, 385.

¹¹ Thus, with some older and some more recent studies against the majority opinion, which holds these verses to have come from the “Yahwist.” See Nöldeke, 1869, 13, 143; Blenkinsopp, 1992, 85; Witte, 1998, 100–102; Arndt, 2007, 46, 51f.

¹² Budde, 1883, 302f. [translation JWR].

the Flood narrative, that of the Scholarly Narrator speaks never of the sons of Noah and only of his whole house (Gen 7:1). Moreover, according to the typical source-critical assignment of Gen 10*, the “Yahwist” never mentions Ham at all and mentions Japheth only indirectly (Gen 10:21). On the other hand, speaking decidedly *for* a Priestly authorship of Gen 9:18a is the fact that the verse, together with vv. 28f., forms the back part of a frame to the Priestly Flood narrative. Without v. 18a., every reference at the end of the genealogy of Noah to the upcoming *toledot* (cf. Gen 10:1) would, completely uncharacteristically, be missing. Therefore, in the context of the Priestly Writing, v. 18 is anything but “superfluous.”

More difficult, however, is the classification of v. 19, which scholars have consistently attributed to the same author as v. 18(a). Verse 19 without a doubt presupposes v. 18(a). However, a redactional origin cannot be ruled out. The question hinges on the understanding of *נפץ “to split, scatter” in v. 19. In similar contexts, the Priestly Writing uses *פרד “to separate, divide” (Gen 10:5, 32), while the non-Priestly (“Yahwistic”) texts use *פוצ “to shatter, scatter” (Gen 10:18; 11:4, 8, 9). Since *נפץ is a secondary form of *פוצ, it is often cited as evidence for the “Yahwistic” origins of v. 19 as well.¹³ However, there are semantic differences between the supposedly “Yahwistic” evidence that have been used to counter this argument: Genesis 9:19 uses *נפץ without any value judgment, just like how the Priestly Writing uses *פרד, while *פוצ in Gen 11:4, 8, 9 has clearly negative connotations.¹⁴ Additionally, like the Priestly Table of Nations in Gen 10*, Gen 9:19 describes the emergence of a world of nations as a natural process, using the sons of Noah as its subject. Conversely, Gen 11:8, 9 is about the consequences of divine intervention and takes Yhwh as its subject. Unfortunately, there are still slight difficulties in this argumentation as well. The vast majority of the time, *פרד and *פוצ also bear negative connotations.¹⁵ Where people groups are concerned, they are typically used for flight in the face of a military defeat or being scattered into exile (cf. *נפץ in Isa 33:3). Therefore, the possibility that v. 19 came from the Redaction cannot be completely ruled out. In this case, the Redaction would be raising a slight but earliest possible objection to the Priestly Table of Nations, contesting the peaceful picture of how a world of nations emerged and thereby looking ahead to the Tower of Babel.

Should Gen 9:18a and possibly v. 19 belong to the Priestly Writing, then Gen 9:18–29 is, in its present form, a post-Priestly addition to the events of Noah’s life.¹⁶ In addition to vv. 20–27, v. 18b also comes from the Redaction. If v. 19 is from the Priestly Writing, then the Redaction reordered an earlier chiasm in vv. 18a, 19 into the present structure, which is concentric around v. 18b. Otherwise, it would have incorporated v. 18b into the chiastic resumptive

¹³ See already Dillmann, 159; Holzinger, 89f.

¹⁴ Witte, 1998, 101.

¹⁵ See further the considerations in Schüle, 2006, 311–314, who assigns the verse to the Priestly Writing but assumes that the Priestly Writing deliberately reinterpreted an earlier term.

¹⁶ So, within the framework of vastly different models for the redaction history of Gen 1–11, e.g., Witte, 1998, 102–105; de Pury, 2005; Schüle, Prolog, 355–367; Arneth, 2007, 200–210; Gertz, 2010, 81–95. Vervenne, 1995^b, 52–54 assigns the episode to the Priestly Composition.

repetition of v. 18a through v. 19 (see Scholarly Exposition II on vv. 18–19 below). Whatever the case may be, the Redaction emphasizes the identification of Ham as the father of Canaan, thus showing from the outset that it is a story about Canaan and anchoring the tense relationship between Israel (Shem) and Canaan within the days of old.

The expansion of the genealogical notice about the sons of Noah into an entire story ultimately cursing Canaan has resulted in a few curiosities, but these need not prompt further literary-critical investigation. The oft-discussed statement in v. 24 in which Ham is not the middle son, as usual, but the youngest son is based on the Priestly notice that Canaan is the youngest son of Ham (cf. Gen 10:6). The rest can be explained quite simply: Should the desired demotion of Canaan to being the servant of *all* peoples be grounded in a single primeval event, then because of the genealogical continuity, this must be placed after the Flood but still in Noah’s lifetime and before the diffusion of Noah’s sons into the various peoples of the earth. In this respect, Gen 9:18a, (19,) 28f. is the only possible place for such an addition. Due to the pre-existing Priestly genealogy, the Redaction could only speak of Canaan indirectly, which is why Ham’s transgression had to become the cause for the curse of Canaan. The necessary connection between the “fall” of Ham and the curse of Canaan’s progeny is provided by the simple statement of the deed of the youngest son falling on his youngest offspring.¹⁷

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION II: EXEGESIS

9:18–19

- 18a** *And the sons of Noah who came out of the ark were Shem, Ham, and Japheth.*
18b *And Ham, he was the father of Canaan.*
19 *These three are the sons of Noah, and from them the whole earth was populated.*

The exposition seamlessly follows the Flood narrative and, through v. 19, prepares for the narrative to widen into the history of the “nations.” The structure follows a concentric pattern. Verse 19a takes up v. 18a and reverses its order: The emphatically preceding “These three” summarizes the listing of the sons of Noah at the end of v. 18a, while the following “the sons of Noah” repeats the beginning of v. 18a. This chiasmic structure frames and emphasizes the explanatory “And Ham, he was the father of Canaan” in v. 18b.¹⁸

¹⁷ See Seebaß, 244.

¹⁸ See Witte, 1998, 100; Ameth, 2007, 50, 202.

Corresponding to the emphatic introduction of Canaan is the no-less-emphasized phrase “Ham, the father of Canaan” at the beginning of the description of the offense (v. 22) and the threefold mention of Canaan in the blessings and curses (vv. 25, 26, 27) at the climax of the narrative. Verse 18b thus provides the theme of the narrative, which should be read primarily as a story about Canaan, its absent but ever-present main character. Verse 19 gives a special tone to the theme of the “nations” by designating the sons of Noah as “these three” (cf. Gen 6:10 [P]). It introduces the idea widely developed in the Table of Nations of the familial bond between all of the peoples of the world and, moreover, emphasizes their humble beginnings in which the blessing of multiplication in Gen 9:1 begins to be realized.¹⁹

9:20–21

20 *And Noah, the fieldworker, began and planted a vineyard.*

21 *And he drank from the wine and became drunk and exposed himself in the midst of his tent.*

The phrasing of v. 20 is difficult. Should “And he began” (וַיֵּהָל) refer to “fieldworker” (אִישׁ הָאֲדָמָה), it would need to be translated as “And he began to be a fieldworker.” In this case, however, the article in אֲדָמָה would need to be deleted. Should it refer to the beginnings of viticulture, as in the translation chosen here, an infinitive would be expected (so, e.g., Gen 4:26). Contrary to what might be assumed, אִישׁ הָאֲדָמָה – literally “the man of the soil” – is not a technical term for a farmer or winemaker. Rather, the phrase, not found anywhere else in the Hebrew Bible, takes up the word אֲדָמָה “soil” from the Garden narrative, where it denotes humanity’s origins and sphere of activity (Gen 2:5, 6, 7, 9, 19; 3:17, 19, 23; 4:3, 10, 11, 12, 14; also 5:29). If Adam is from his origins and by his fate literally the “man of the soil,” Noah is characterized in this way as a “new Adam” after the restoration of Creation.²⁰ Noah’s planting (נָטַע) of a vineyard is reminiscent in this context of Yhwh once planting a garden (Gen 2:8). The notice about the introduction of viticulture into human civilization is often associated with the emergence of various cultural achievements described in Gen 2–4,²¹ with reference to a shared basic sentiment depicting the “noblest of all cultural heritage” rather ambivalently.²² However, this ambivalence lies not in the emergent beginnings of civilization, as in Gen 2–4, but in the cultural outcomes that are not part of Gen 2–4. In addition, the formulations of the

¹⁹ Jacob, 259.

²⁰ See Tomasino, 1992, 129.

²¹ So recently Schüle, 2006, 357f.

²² Jacob, 268; Schüle, 2006, 357 [translation JWR].

notices about the history of civilization in Gen 4:20–22 and those of Gen 9:20 differ from each other quite significantly.²³ Conversely, the milestones in human development marked by the verb *חָלַל hi. “to begin” (Gen 6:1; 10:8; 11:6; also 4:26 ho.; all R) show a certain closeness to one another. As in Gen 6:1, the milestone here is accompanied by the crossing of a sexual boundary.²⁴ Its function in the narrative notwithstanding – the introduction of viticulture prepares for its subsequent consequences – the planting of a vineyard immediately following the Flood narrative also signals an end to the judgment (so also 2 Kgs 19:29 // Isa 37:30; Isa 65:21; Jer 31:5; Ezek 28:26; Amos 9:14; Ps 107:37).²⁵ This symbolism corresponds to the constantly positive evaluation of wine in the Hebrew Bible. Wine is part of any proper meal, whether in everyday life or for special occasions (Gen 27:25; Judg 19:19; Isa 22:13), it gladdens the human heart (Ps 104:15), and it makes “gods and mortals happy” (Judg 9:13). The introduction of viticulture and the first enjoyment of wine is followed by the first instance of intoxication in human history. The account is concise and abstains from any moral judgment. Noah’s intoxication is his own private affair and brings harm to no one. Noah retreats to his tent, where he exposes himself. This move initially underscores Noah’s claim to privacy but also foreshadows the complications to come.

9:22–24

- 22 *And Ham, the father of Canaan, saw his father’s shame. And he told this to his two brothers outside.*
- 23 *Then Shem and Japheth took^[sing.] the cloak and laid^[pl.] [it] on both their shoulders, and they walked backwards and they covered their father’s shame; their faces stayed facing backwards, and they did not see their father’s shame.*
- 24 *And Noah awoke from his wine, and he realized what his youngest son had done to him.*

The climax of the plot comes from the sons’ various reactions to their drunken father as well as his harsh response. Ham sees his father’s shame and mocks it to his brothers, but they react with respect and cover their father without looking at him. Noah in turn curses Ham’s son Canaan and blesses Shem and Japheth. This theme of “blessing and curse” clearly shows that Noah’s sons and his grandson, Canaan, should be understood less as family members

²³ Following Witte, 1998, 102. On the theory first proposed by Budde, 1883, 306f., according to which this is the comfort announced in Gen 5:29, see pp. 236f. on Gen 5:28–31.

²⁴ See Witte, 1998, 102.

²⁵ Arnoeth, 2007, 204.

than as representatives of people groups. Ham, the father of Canaan, is contrasted with Shem, the ancestor of Israel (Gen 11:10–26), and Japheth. There is also a subtle distinction made between the two brothers who are blessed, with the singular verb in “Then Shem and Japheth took^[sing.]” at the beginning of v. 23 before the plural continuation “and they laid^[pl.]” indicating that the initiative lay with Shem, since he is named first.²⁶

Yet, what exactly was Ham’s offense that caused such a harsh, intergenerational reaction? How could Noah “know” that Ham had “seen” him naked while he slept? Interpretations have often understood the open-ended phrase “what he had done to him [אֲשֶׁר-עָשָׂה-לִּי]” as a literary gap inviting the reader to infer what happened from supposed allusions in the text. The various attempts to fill the supposed gap²⁷ have focused on the idiomatic meaning of the expressions “seeing [*רָאָה] the shame [עֲרֹוּת]” (see also Lev 20:17) and “uncovering [*גִּלָּה] the shame” (see Lev 18:6–19; Lev 20:11, 19, 20, 21) in the sense of “having sexual intercourse.” This is also likely because of how well attested the connection between alcohol consumption and sexuality is in the Hebrew Bible and ancient Near Eastern literature at large, and how readily “vineyard” motifs are used in sexual contexts (e.g., Song 1:6, 14; 2:15).²⁸ Especially prominent in this context is the story of Lot’s daughters, who intoxicate their father in order to become pregnant by him (Gen 19:30–38). The offense has therefore been understood as incest with Noah’s (unmentioned!) wife, which Lev 20:11 terms “uncovering the father’s shame,”²⁹ or as incestuous homosexual abuse of Noah by Ham;³⁰ the rabbis already considered the possibility of Ham castrating or raping his father.³¹ However, such attempts at specifying the deed fit poorly to the context, which, as shown by the juxtaposition in the brothers’ behaviors, puts special emphasis on Ham telling his brothers.³² Furthermore, in Lev 18 and 20, the “seeing” of the shame is a reciprocal act and “the father’s shame” is something that is “uncovered,” while Gen 9:22 speaks only of Ham “seeing” his father’s shame. It can be said without any doubt that the present text concerns Noah exposing himself while intoxicated and, thus, unconsciously. Ham is not even accused of intoxicating his father in order to “see his shame” (cf. Hab 2:15). Nevertheless, the reference to the incest prohibitions in the book of Leviticus and the sexual connotations of the passage’s vocabulary leads in the right

²⁶ Jacob, 261.

²⁷ See the overviews in Vervenne, 1995^b, 34f.; Gertz, 2021.

²⁸ Dubach, 2009, 214–225.

²⁹ Bassett, 1971. See similarly already Gen. Rab. 36.4 and TestRub 3.11–15. In its interpretation of Gen 35:22, TestRub 3.11–15 notes, alluding to Gen 9:18–27, that Reuben found Jacob’s concubine sleeping naked and intoxicated in the tent. See further Opferkuch, 2017, 281–305.

³⁰ Nissinen, 1998, 52f.

³¹ See the evidence and discussion in Opferkuch, 2017, 289–291.

³² Schüle, 2006, 357.

direction. Ham's offense is rooted in seeing his father's shame (v. 22a) and then talking about it in front of his brothers (v. 22b).³³ Contrasting with this disrespectful behavior is the behavior of his two older brothers. They honor their father, with the definition of "honor" in this context clearly guided by what can be found in Lev 18 and 20.³⁴ Consequently, Ham's offense is centered around a question of shame and honor. If exposing someone's shame is a violation of that person's dignity and integrity,³⁵ then Ham's real offense is his lack of discretion. Ham tells his brothers about the incident, thus publicizing it and dishonoring his father.³⁶ In this context, "even the suggestion surrounding the talk of the father's nakedness" is enough.³⁷ What the social conventions demand, on the other hand, is very nicely shown in the notice from the Epic of Aqhat that is repeatedly cited in this context. It speaks of a son who "takes [his father's] hand when he is drunk, who carries him when he is full of wine" (*KTU* 1.17.1.30f.).

The special flavor of the incident comes from its terminological proximity to the incest prohibitions in the book of Leviticus, which are followed by a warning to Israel in Lev 20:22f. (see also Lev 18:3) noting that the previous inhabitants of the land, i.e., the Canaanites, will lose their land because of such transgressions.³⁸ In the minds of its literate addressees, the incident should have and must have evoked the stereotypical portrayal of the Canaanites, since, in this respect, the biblical tradition never "puts anything past them," so to speak. This, like the blessings and curses that follow, brings about a new tone in the biblical Primeval History: The episode may seem at first glance like a narrative realization of humanity's lasting proclivity to do evil, formulated in the epilogue to the Great Flood. However, on closer examination, it clearly stands out from its preceding context in how it turns the anthropological claims of the Flood narrative into judgments upon definable social entities, dividing humanity according to blessings and curses. The consequence of this is how the general claim about humanity's proclivity for doing evil is reduced to a single act whose consequence is the cursed existence of Canaan. In this way, the stereotypical portrayal of the Canaanites in most texts of the Hebrew Bible receives its primeval historical grounding.

³³ There are often speculations that the adult Ham would have had his own tent and went into his father's tent without permission. See recently again Seebaß, 246. This is possible but is not in the text – even if only because it would distract from the actual offense. Contrarily, Budde, 1883, 310 (followed by Gunkel, 79; von Rad, 136f.; Ruppert, 410), seeing the offense as testifying to a childish immaturity, continued, "The father in the tent; the children, as is proper, outside, probably thought to be playing" [translation JWR].

³⁴ See Vervenne, 1995^b, 50.

³⁵ See Neumann, 2006.

³⁶ Westermann, 489.

³⁷ Schüle, 2006, 357 [translation JWR].

³⁸ Arneth, 2007, 206f.

9:25–27

- 25** *And he said: “Cursed be Canaan – servant of servants shall he be for his brothers.”*
- 26** *And he said, “Blessed be Yhwh, the God of Shem – and Canaan shall be their servant.*
- 27** *Wide space may God create for Japheth, and he shall dwell in the tents of Shem – and Canaan shall be their servant.*

Verses 25–27 offer blessings and curses and can again be divided into two subunits. The curse against Canaan, introduced with “And he said” and the following participle (אָרֵר “cursed”), is contrasted with the corresponding blessings of Shem and Japheth, likewise introduced with “And he said” and a following participle (בָּרַךְ “blessed”). The speeches addressed to the two brothers who acted appropriately should thus be understood as a single unit, regardless of any internal differentiation. This is underscored by the identical postscript “and Canaan shall be their servant,” which takes up the phrasing of the curse, “servant of servants shall he be for his brothers.” Nevertheless, because of the close parallels between the first two speeches, it cannot be ruled out that the curse of Canaan and the blessing of Shem were based on older material taken up by the author of the narrative and expanded to include a blessing of Japheth.³⁹ In any case, Japheth’s blessing cannot have ever been absent from the present text,⁴⁰ since the narrative begins and ends with three brothers.

Like his brother Shem, Japheth behaves with respect towards his father and is also necessarily a recipient of the blessing. However, there is also a subtle difference between the two. While Shem’s blessing speaks of “Yhwh, the God of Shem,” Japheth’s blessing uses the generic term אֱלֹהִים “God.” This prefigures the rather recent distinction between the worshippers of Yhwh (Shem), the God-fearers (Japheth), and the godless (Canaan).⁴¹ The name “Japheth” is explained etymologically through the blessing “May God create space” (hi. of פָּתַח “to widen”), which, together with the statement about Japheth dwelling in Shem’s tents (see Ps 78:55; Hab 1:6), anchors the presence of dominant elements of northern populations living in Palestine already within primeval times. A more precise attribution is difficult due to the vague geographic conceptions concerning Japheth in Gen 10. Scholars often mention – depending on their respective understandings of the text’s

³⁹ So Witte, 1998, 102–105.

⁴⁰ Cf. Levin, 1993, 120.

⁴¹ Witte, 1998, 104.

literary history – the Philistines,⁴² the Phoenicians,⁴³ the Persians,⁴⁴ or the Greeks.⁴⁵ Speaking against an identification with the Philistines and Phoenicians is how in Gen 10:14, 15f., the Redaction attributes them to Canaan and therefore to Ham. Conversely, the Persians (Madaï) and Greeks (Javan) are mentioned in the Table of Nations as sons of Japheth (Gen 10:2). Should they be identified with the Greeks, this would seem to be related to the Greek dominance in the Levant from after the campaign of Alexander the Great (334–330 BCE); should they be identified with the Persians, it would seemingly be related to Achaemenid rule, which ended with Alexander. Since v. 27 only mentions their common ancestor Japheth, the text does not allow any resolution to this question. Both possibilities fit well with the text's assignment to the post-Priestly Redaction advocated here; basic considerations about the origin of the Pentateuch make the identification with the Persians seem more likely.

The distinction between the worshippers of Yhwh, the God-fearers, and the godless should be read as a counter-conception to the Priestly conception of the one God who is worshipped by all people and whose true name will be revealed incrementally, first only to Abraham and his successors. There is also another clear correction of the Priestly conception in how the text differentiates between the sons of Noah according to blessing/curse immediately after God's universal blessing to Noah and his sons (Gen 9:1–17). The curse for the wicked deed, explicitly characterized as a hereditary curse, permanently excludes Canaan from the brotherly relationship of humanity that the Priestly Writing implies in Gen 9:18a and unveils in the Table of Nations.⁴⁶ As discussed above, because of the parameters of the Priestly Writing, Canaan could only be mentioned indirectly, which is why he (in addition to his descendants) was cursed for the deed of his father. Somewhat different is a reading attested already at Qumran and later widely adopted, according to which Canaan was cursed because God had blessed Noah and his sons as they left the ark (Gen 9:1), meaning that Noah could not curse one of his sons directly (see 4Q252 2.5–7 [4QCommentary on Genesis; DJD XXII, 185–207]; see Gen. Rab. 36.7; Justin, *Dial.* 139; Ephrem, *Comm. Gen.*). According to another reading interpreting the deed as Ham castrating his father, Noah cursed Ham's fourth son because Ham ruined Noah's desire for a fourth son

⁴² See already Wellhausen, 1899, 15. See further von Rad, 138, as well as Ruppert, 414f., who points to the expansion of the Philistine city-states' sphere of influence under Neo-Assyrian hegemony after 701 BCE.

⁴³ Budde, 1883, 315–320; Holzinger, 91–101.

⁴⁴ So already b.Yoma 9b, 10a. See also Schüle, 2006, 367.

⁴⁵ See Witte, 1998, 315–320.

⁴⁶ de Pury, 2005, 503f.

of his own (Tg. Ps.-J.; b.Sanh. 70a; Gen. Rab. 36.7). In “The Cave of Treasures,” a collection of apocryphal writings from the early Syriac Church, the question of why Canaan was cursed is justified by the fact that Noah knew that Canaan “renewed... the deeds of the tribe of Cain the murderer, so that he went and made flutes and lyres into which the demons entered and dwelt within them” (Cav. Tr. 21). Going in a similar direction is the idea that Canaan, unlike his well-behaved brothers, resembled his father in his wickedness, which is why Noah did not curse Ham and, thus, all of the Hamites (Ephrem, *Comm. Gen.*). Others have justified the cursing of Canaan by the fact that he and his father Ham had sexually assaulted Noah (PRE 23), with the sexual assault itself being attributed to Canaan, with Ham (judged less harshly) neglecting to help (Ibn Ezra). Functionally, these explanations change little: The narrative is ultimately about the cursing of Canaan and providing a primeval explanation for why the Canaanites turned out as the biblical authors envisioned them. In addition, the curse dispossesses Canaan, who, according to the Priestly depiction, is entitled to land (Gen 10:15–19) in which Israel lives (initially) as a stranger (Gen 17:8). It thus justifies the biblical narrative, according to which Israel was later able to eradicate the Canaanites to a large extent and take possession of their land (see also Jub. 10:29–34).⁴⁷

9:28–29

28 *And Noah lived 350 years after the Flood.*

29 *Thus, the total lifetime of Noah was 950 years, and then he died.*

The conclusion of the passage comes from the Priestly Writing. With its mention of the Flood, it takes up the chronology of the exposition in v. 18a. The dating “after the Flood” is noteworthy: It is otherwise found only in Gen 10:1, 32; 11:10 and establishes a point of reference for an emergence of the nations that is anchored in a “history of events.” This perspective was already implied in v. 19, although whether this verse belongs to the Priestly Writing is uncertain. In any case, it comes into view for the Priestly Writing here at the very latest. Moreover, the notice about the years of Noah’s life after the Flood and his total lifetime accords with the information about Noah’s age from Gen 5:32. Thus, the end of the “*toledot*/generations of Noah” connects all the way back to their beginnings (Gen 6:9a, 10).

⁴⁷ The book of Joshua’s exilic/postexilic depiction of the conquest of the land and the execution of the ban, which has a Deuteronomistic flavor, makes no reference to the cursing of Canaan in Gen 9. The connection between the curse and the expulsion is made only in postbiblical texts. This is another indication that the present shape of Gen 9:18–28 is a result of the Primeval History’s more recent editorial additions.

THE TABLE OF NATIONS

- 10:1** And these are the generations of the sons of Noah, Shem, Ham, and Japheth. Sons were born to them after the Flood.
- 2** The sons of Japheth: Gomer and Magog and Madai and Javan and Tubal and Meshech and Tiras.
- 3** And the sons of Gomer: Ashkenaz and Riphath and Togarmah.
- 4** And the sons of Javan: Elishah and Tarshish, the Kittaeans and the Rodanites.
- 5** From these, the islands of the nations branched out in their lands, each according to their language, according to their clans, in their nations.
- 6** And the sons of Ham: Cush and Mizraim and Put and Canaan.
- 7** And the sons of Cush: Seba and Havilah and Sabtah and Ragmah and Sabtechah. And the sons of Ragmah: Sheba and Dedan.
- 8** And Cush fathered Nimrod. He was the first hero on the earth.
- 9** He was a hero of the hunt before Yhwh. Therefore, it is said, “Like Nimrod – a hero of the hunt before Yhwh.”
- 10** And the beginning of his kingdom was Babel and Erech and Akkad, and they all were in the land of Shinar.
- 11** From this land, he went out to Assur, and he built Nineveh and the city squares and Calah,
- 12** and Resen between Nineveh and Calah; that is the great city.
- 13** And Mizraim fathered the Ludites and the Anamites and the Lehabites and the Naphtuhites.
- 14** And the Pathrusites and the Casluhites, whence came the Philistines, and the Caphtorites.
- 15** And Canaan fathered Sidon, his firstborn, and Heth
- 16** and the Jebusite and the Amorite and the Girgashite
- 17** and the Hivite and the Arkite and the Sinite
- 18** and the Arvadite and the Zemarite and the Hamathite. But later, the clans of the Canaanites scattered themselves.
- 19** And the territory of the Canaanites reached from Sidon, towards Gerar, as far as Gaza, towards Sodom and Gomorrah and Admah and Zeboiim, as far as Lasha.
- 20** These are the sons of Ham according to their clans, their languages, in their lands, in their nations.

- 21 And also to Shem, the father of all the sons of Eber, the older brother of Japheth, [children] were born.
- 22 **The sons of Shem: Elam and Assur and Arpachshad and Lud and Aram.**
- 23 **And the sons of Aram: Uz and Hul and Gether and Mash.**
- 24 And Arpachshad fathered Shelah, and Shelah fathered Eber.
- 25 And to Eber, two sons were born. The name of the one was Peleg, for in his time, humanity was scattered, and the name of his brother was Joktan.
- 26 And Joktan fathered Almodad and Sheleph and Hazarmaveth and Jerah
- 27 and Hadoram and Uzal and Diklah
- 28 and Obal and Abimael and Sheba
- 29 and Ophir and Havilah and Jobab. All these are the sons of Joktan.
- 30 And the territory in which they lived reached from Mesha, towards Sephar, as far as the eastern mountains.
- 31 **These are the sons of Shem according to their clans, according to their languages, in their lands, according to their nations.**
- 32 **These are the clans of the sons of Noah, according to their generations in their nations, and from them, all the nations on the earth branched out after the Flood.**

Analysis: Priestly Writing in Gen 10:1–7, 20, 22–23, 31–32; Redaction and later additions in Gen 10:8–19, 21, 24–30.

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TEXT-CRITICAL AND PHILOLOGICAL NOTES

10:1 וַיִּוְלְדוּ לָהֶם בָּנִים (*Sons were born to them*): For the use of the imperf. cons., see *GKC* §111h and Gen 22:24.

10:4 דְּדָנִים (*Rodanites*): See the SP; LXX; 1Chr 1:7. MT: “Dodanites,” probably a misreading of the *reš* ר (Rodan) as *dalet* ד (Dodan).

10:10 וְכָלָנָה (*and they all*): Here, the MT reads the toponym “Calneh.” Originally, the text would have read וְכָלָנָה “and they all.” See Albright, 1944.

10:11 אַשּׁוּר (*to Assur*): An accusative of direction; see *GKC* §118d–f. The subject of v. 11f. is Nimrod (explicitly so in Tg. Ps.-J.). The LXX reads differently, with Assur understood, like in v. 22, as a personal name and taken as the subject of the sentence: “Out of that land came Assur, and he built Nineveh ...”

רְחֹבֹת עִיר (*city squares*): The expression רְחֹבֹת עִיר is more commonly understood as the name of a city (“Rehoboth-Ir”). However, even the plain Hebrew phrasing seems to clearly denote, as elsewhere, the “squares and streets of the city” – in this case, those of Nineveh (Judg 19:15, 17; 2 Chr 32:6; Est 4:6; 6:9, 11; Song 3:2; Lam 2:12; Zech 8:5).

10:21 הַגָּדוֹל אָחִי יָפֶת הַגָּדוֹל (*the older brother of Japheth*): The LXX takes הַגָּדוֹל “the older/bigger” as referring to Japheth, translating it as ἀδελφῷ Ἰαφεθ τοῦ μείζονος “the brother of Japheth the elder.” The LXX thus carries the notion of the younger son in each case being the bearer of the promise, as with the later ancestors of Israel. See also parts of rabbinic interpretation and, more recently, Hensel, 2011, 75f. However, the MT should be understood as agreeing with Gen 5:32; 9:18; 10:1 with הַגָּדוֹל being in apposition to אָחִי “brother.”

10:22 The LXX mentions another son, Καϊνάν, after “and Aram.” See Scholarly Exposition II.

10:25 הָאָדָם (*humanity*): Lit. “the world/earth.” Tg. Neof. reads here the more illustrative “all inhabitants of the earth” like in Gen 11:1.

10:32 הַגּוֹיִם (*the nations*): The LXX and SP read “the islands of the nations” like in v. 5.

ESSENTIALS AND PERSPECTIVES

The Table of Nations in Gen 10:1–32 provides a genealogical and geographical overview of the descendants of the sons of Noah, who are thought to be the patriarchs of the nations of the earth. Within the Primeval History, the Table of Nations marks a turning of the epochs: If the preceding story of Noah ends with a notice about how long he lived after the end of the Flood (אָחֵר הַמִּבּוּל; Gen 9:28) and his death (Gen 9:29), the opening and closing of the Table of Nations take up verbatim the reference to the end of the Flood (Gen 10:1, 32), found again in the context of the birth of Shem’s first son

(Gen 11:10). In this way, the Table of Nations in Gen 10:1–32 and the genealogy of Shem in Gen 11:10–26, in addition to the intervening Tower of Babel narrative in Gen 11:1–9, are combined into their own separate section within the Primeval History. This serves as a transition from the sons of Noah, born before the Flood, to Terah, the father of Abraham – “between the eras,” so to speak.¹ Its overarching theme is the division of the unified humanity into the postdiluvian world of nations, including the beginnings of the history of Israel leading to Abraham and his descendants. In this, there is a threefold narrative interest that is expressed: “The narrators acknowledge at this point, when they conclude the history of primitive humanity and turn to the ancestors of Israel, the scholarly requirement to say something about the origins of the nations, the esthetic requirement to conclude the primal history distinctly, and not least, the religious requirement to make clear the election of Israel from the multitudes of nations.”²

The core of the Table of Nations comes from the Priestly Writing (see Scholarly Exposition I). The Priestly Writing depicts the differentiated unity of the world of nations known to it through the kinship bonds of the individual patriarchs. They are all children, grandchildren, and great-grandchildren of Noah and his three sons. This idea may seem naïve, but it could very well be primarily a form of representation bound to a genealogical thinking but less concerned with personal history than ordering the diverse elements of the manifold whole.³ This can be seen in how the genealogy unmistakably only provides examples, elaborating the lines of only some ancestors and the lines in the final clauses for the sons of Japheth, Ham, and Shem and for the Table of Nations as a whole, which emphasize this systemization similar to the “according to their kind” in the Priestly Creation account. In this respect, it is justifiable to speak of an early concept of ethnology and geography. Like the previous structuring of the world through the categories of space and time as well as the taxonomy of animate and inanimate nature, it testifies to a spirit of intellectuality concerned with comprehending the world as a whole through experience and shared by its authors with the contemporary educated elite of the eastern Mediterranean. Thus, notwithstanding this erudition having found a very individual form of expression in the Table of Nations (like in the Creation account),⁴ there is a comparable interest in ethno-geographic

¹ See Witte, 1998, 48f. [translation JWR].

² Gunkel, 88.

³ See, e.g., Westermann, 503; Hieke, 2014, 24.

⁴ Research has often emphasized that “the table of the nations is unique and has no parallel either inside or outside the Old Testament” (Westermann, 501; see Crüsemann, 1998, 187; Witte, 2011, Punkt 4; Hieke, 2014, 30f.). This is correct, and applies also to Gen 1, regarding both genre and specific elaboration of the content. It does not apply, however, for the underlying empirical understanding of the world that emerged in the eastern Mediterranean between

classification that is also observable elsewhere. The use of “secondary toponyms” and the division of the world into three regions corresponds to conventions of Greek authors known from the middle of the first millennium BCE.⁵ An oft-mentioned literary analogy that turns out to be rather distant on closer examination is the “Catalogue of Women,” an anonymous appendix to Hesiod’s *Theogony* probably written in the late seventh or early sixth century BCE.⁶ It is a list of Greek myths and mythical figures, each placed in various genealogical contexts starting from a matriarch. In this way, they also provide a geographical description of the area of the Mediterranean known to the Greeks. The basic interest in an ethno-geographical survey of the world is attested not only by the distant explorations noted in Herodotus and others but also by ancient Near Eastern and Greek cartography.⁷ The (lost) world maps of Anaximander of Miletus (ca. 610/609–547/546 BCE) and Hecataeus of Miletus (ca. 560–480 BCE) as well as the “Babylonian World Map” dating back to the late eighth century BCE should be emphasized in particular, in light of the proximity to the Ionian natural philosophers and the leading scientific knowledge from Babylon contemporary with and already observable in Gen 1.⁸ The Priestly Writing may have taken the geographic material from lists of trading partners, such as the trade list in Ezek 27⁹ mediated by the Phoenicians, or country lists as can be found in the Behistun Inscription by the Achaemenid king Darius I (522–486 BCE): “Darius the king proclaims: These are the peoples/countries who obey me; by the favour of Auramazda, I was their king: Persia, Elam, Babylonia, Assyria, Arabia, Egypt, those of the sea, Lydia, Ionia, Media, Armenia, Cappadocia, Parthia, Drangiana, Areia, Chorasmia, Bactria, Sogdiana, Gandara, Scythia (Saca), Sattagydia, Arachosia, Maka; in all twenty-three peoples/countries... they brought me ‘tribute’; what was said to them by me, whether by night or by day, that they did... by the favour of Auramazda, these peoples respected my law.”¹⁰ Such lists

the eighth and sixth centuries BCE and found individualized yet comparable forms of expression in the various cultures. On the place of the Priestly Writing in the scientific cultures of the eastern Mediterranean, see Gertz, 2009^a, esp. 149ff.

⁵ See Jericke, 2013, 73, with reference to the division of the world into the three continents of Libya, Asia, and Europe, referenced with criticism in Herodotus (*Hist.* 4.42).

⁶ See the summary of the discussion in Hirschberger, 2004, 42–51. On the relationship to Gen 10, see Hess, 1989, 251–253; Darshan, 2013. Text and translation: Hesiod, *Cat.* 40–291.

⁷ See Wittke et al., 2012, 4–9 (with further literature).

⁸ See *ibid.*, 4f. and Horowitz, 2011, 20–42 for the “Babylonian World Map.”

⁹ See Saur, 2008, 66–71.197–237.

¹⁰ Introduction and Translation: “Darius’ Account of His Seizure of the Throne,” (Khurt, *Sources*, 1.5A:141–143;§6–8). The list, which was also known via, e.g., Aramaic papyrus copies from the Jewish colony on the island of Elephantine in the Nile, can be found in a similar form in a monumental inscription from the southern entrance to the Persian royal palace in Persepolis, while a large relief on the eastern stairway to the audience hall shows the king receiving the representatives from all the lands of his empire, who approach him in a long procession

and records would have already existed at the Jerusalem royal court. It can therefore be assumed that the authors of the Priestly Writing had access to such material, which inherently cannot be dated any more precisely. In any case, the overall concept of a “Table of Nations” included in the Primeval History dates back to the Persian period.

Occasionally, the Persians’ absence in the Table of Nations is cited against this dating. However, the Persians are referenced in the mention of “Madai,” the son of Japheth and the progenitor of the Medes (v. 2; see also Isa 13:17; 21:2). Whether the omission of the פָּרֶס “Persian” attested elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible (see Ezek 27:10) expresses a cautious reservation against Achaemenid imperial hegemony¹¹ is difficult to judge. In any case, it is striking that the Priestly Writing does not have any reference to a king. Additionally, the Table of Nations is not organized around Israel, which is mentioned only in its broader context, or around any other political or cultic center. This also clearly differentiates it from the Achaemenid monumental inscriptions. Their arrangement of the nations within the Persian empire is concentric, with the great king who is assigned rule over the nations by the divine will standing at the imaginary center. According to Herodotus, this arrangement is also associated with a clear value judgment: “They honour most of all those who dwell nearest them, next those who are next farthest removed, and so going ever onwards they assign honour by this rule; those who dwell farthest off they hold least honourable of all; for they deem themselves to be in all regards by far the best of all men, the rest to have but a proportionate claim to merit, till those who dwell farthest away have least merit of all” (Herodotus, *Hist.* 1.134). In contrast, the Priestly Writing depicts the ideal of a peacefully differentiated world of equally respected nations in which the blessing of multiplication given to Noah and his sons is fulfilled (Gen 9:1) and in which all existing nations belong to the humanity created by God (Gen 1:26f.). Thus, the Priestly Writing vehemently contradicts the ethnocentric, and partially xenophobic, tendency perceptible in ancient depictions of the nations and elsewhere, in order to provide a strict distinction between the members of its own people and those of foreign peoples. Similarly, there are also no power relations that (yet) come into play.

The Table of Nations of the Priestly Writing has been expanded at several points. Differences in form and style indicate that the editing did not happen all at once (see Scholarly Exposition I). In part, it probably involved merely adding geographic or ethnographic information. However, there was also an

from the south and can be distinguished by their costumes and the gifts that they bring with them. See Koch, 1992, 78–162. Introduction and Translation: “Persian Supremacy in the Empire (DPe)” (Khurt, *Sources*, 3.11A: 469–476, 486–587).

¹¹ Schüle, 2006, 373.

interest in addressing aspects of political authority (Gen 10:8–12), which was omitted in the Priestly Table of Nations for conceptual reasons. The realpolitik experience of (foreign) domination and power is attributed to the sons of Ham, including Israel's "archenemies" Mizraim/Egypt and Canaan. Thus, the editors are in agreement with the disparagement of the descendants of Ham in the narrative of Noah and his sons in Gen 9:18–29. Consequently, the listing of the sons of Canaan in Gen 10:15–18 is based on the list in Josh 3:10 of the previous inhabitants of the land who are to be expelled.

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION I: INTRODUCTION TO EXEGESIS

Structure: The heading "*Toledot*/Generations of the Sons of Noah, Shem, Ham, and Japheth" clearly delineates the beginning of the Table of Nations from the story of Noah. Verse 32 takes up the heading ("sons of Noah," "*toledot*/generations," "after the Flood") and marks a colophonic conclusion to it in relation to the following Tower of Babel narrative. This, in turn, is meant to be read as a retrospective unfolding of the notice about the emergence of the nations after the Flood (v. 32b). The order of the sons, Shem – Ham – Japheth, is known from Gen 5:32; 6:10; 7:13; 9:18a (all P). The use of the segmented genealogy in vv. 2ff., however, then reverses the order. It begins with the youngest son, since it is designed as a continuation and is aimed at the firstborn, Shem, whose genealogy is presented in Gen 11:10–26 (P) with regard to Abraham's ancestors. At the same time, there is a rough geographic order of the world that emerges, set from a Judeo-Palestinian perspective and progressing from the outermost fringes in the north, northwest, and northeast (Japheth), through the south (Ham, with justifiable exception of Canaan; see below on v. 6), to the center (Shem). A division of the languages of the world into three families (August Ludwig von Schlözer [1735–1809]; Johann Ludwig Krapf [1810–1881]), which was taken from Gen 10 and is linguistically outdated, plays no role here, since the diversity of languages in Gen 10 serves as a distinguishing characteristic not between but within the people groups.¹²

The sections about the three sons (1. Japheth in vv. 2–5; 2. Ham in vv. 6–20; 3. Shem in vv. 21–31) each have their own heading (vv. 2, 6, 21f.) and a functionally identical closing, although their assortments of the key phrases "in their lands," "according to their languages," "according to their clans," "in/according to their nations" (vv. 5, 20, 31) can differ.

¹² See Hölscher, 1949, 45 fn. 1.

The headings and closings give structure to the diversity of the world and, at the same time, show “how the ethnic, geographic, linguistic, and familial diversity of humanity developed out of the three larger groups of peoples.”¹³ The Table of Nations thus presents an exemplary completeness. The respective closings suggest a complete listing of the peoples, but the aforementioned phrases, similar to the summary “according to their kind” in the Priestly Creation account (Gen 1:11, 12, 21, 24, 25), primarily emphasize the systematizing aspect of the listings. They thus indicate that “in its details, the outline is a richer one.”¹⁴ The genealogical presentation is, in principle, also open to further differentiations. It is therefore not surprising that the lines of some of the ancestors (“grandsons of Noah”) are not broken down any further. Thus, in light of the progression of the genealogies in the book of Genesis and the narrative plot, the nations coming from Abraham are missing from the descendants of Shem.

The number of the nations listed varies between 70 and 72 nations, depending on the source text and counting method. The number 70 signalizes completeness and is repeatedly attested across the Hebrew Bible for the size of groups of people (Judg 8:30; 2 Kgs 10:1). Especially prominent is the use of the number 70 for the descendants of Jacob in Egypt (Gen 46:27; Exod 1:5; Deut 10:22), which was associated early on with the number of the peoples in Gen 10. Thus, the MT reads in Deut 32:8: “When the Most High assigned the nations [גוֹיִם] their inheritance, when he separated the peoples from each other [*פרד; see Gen 10:32], he set the boundaries of the peoples [עַמִּים] according to the number of the sons of Israel [בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל].” From this perspective, the macrocosm of the world of nations corresponds with the microcosm of the people of Israel.¹⁵ However, such considerations have already been present within (innerbiblical) interpretations of the Table of Nations throughout history: Firstly, the number of nations in Gen 10 comes only at the end of an editorial process with at least two stages, which is why it is unlikely that it came about as “according to [any] plan.”¹⁶ Secondly, the allusion in Deut 32:8 to Gen 10 is the result of a dogmatic correction that came late in the chapter’s textual history. The original reading of Deut 32:8 was “the number of the sons of God [בְּנֵי אֱלֹהִים]” and was changed, possibly motivated by Gen 10, into the “the number of the sons of Israel [בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל]” of the Masoretic Text (the LXX offers κατὰ ἀριθμὸν ἀγγέλων θεοῦ and seems to have read בְּנֵי אֱלֹהִים from its original Hebrew predecessor; this reading is confirmed by 4QDeut¹ [DJD XIV, 75–91, 90]).

Formation: There is a broad consensus that two layers can be distinguished in Gen 10:1–32.¹⁷ This assessment is based on the following observations concerning its style and content: (1.) The structure of the Table of Nations

¹³ Hieke, 2003, 107 [translation JWR].

¹⁴ Dillmann, 170 [translation JWR].

¹⁵ See Tg. Ps.-J. and Rashi on Deut 32:8. See further Jacob, 295f.; Millard, 2001, 57f.

¹⁶ Dillmann, 170 [translation JWR].

¹⁷ But with clear reservations most recently in Hieke, 2003, 99–107; Jericke, 2015.

is characterized by a nominal listing of individual people (“[And] the sons of P.N.: P.N.₁ and P.N.₂...”). Together with the frame verses, they form a coherent textual unit (vv. 1–7, 20, 22f., 31f.). In addition to these, there are also genealogical notices that are consistently formulated as verbal clauses (“P.N. fathered/became the father of P.N.₁, P.N.₂...; *דל q./q. pass.) and contribute further narrative material (vv. 8–19, 21, 24–30). (2.) The nominal listing almost exclusively provides personal names and “secondary toponyms,” i.e., place names used in Gen 10 as the names of people, nations, or tribes.¹⁸ Only in v. 4b, which is probably a later addition, do names of actual people groups appear. These names agree quite closely with the list of the Phoenician city of Tyre’s trade relationships in Ezek 27. In the other schema, however, only a few personal names and secondary toponyms appear, and it instead generally gives genuine names of people groups (or demonyms in vv. 16–18), as well as “primary toponyms” (i.e., place names clearly recognizable as such from their literary context) in the description of Nimrod’s rule and the borders of Canaanite territory. The names used in the narrative passages show only a very minor correspondence with Ezek 27. (3.) The combination of the two basic genealogical schemata is stylistically striking and has led to some of the names being duplicated. For Mizraim (vv. 6, 13), Canaan (vv. 6, 15), and Arpachshad (vv. 22, 24), this does not cause any functional difficulties. More significant is Assur being used in the narrative passages in the context of the sons of Ham as a primary toponym (v. 11: “he went to Assur [Assyria]”), while it serves a secondary toponym in the nominal listing, with Assur being one of the sons of Shem (v. 22). Finally, the fact that Havilah and Seba are listed among both the sons of Ham (v. 7) and the sons of Shem (vv. 28f.) can hardly be attributed to the work of a single hand. There are also conceptual differences connected with the double mention of Cush. In the nominal listing, it probably signifies the regions south of Egypt (v. 6), while “Cush” in the narrative passages shows a clear affinity to Mesopotamia, which in turn belongs to Shem according to the nominal listing (see on v. 8 below). Furthermore, v. 21 is a duplication of the partial heading in v. 22, and the remarks in vv. 24f. anticipate the beginning of the genealogy of Shem in Gen 11:10–26. (4.) Finally, the multiple literary layers can be seen in how the Table of Nations only works cartographically when isolating just the nominal listing.¹⁹

¹⁸ For differentiating between “primary” and “secondary” toponyms in Gen 10, see Jericke, 2015. The LXX accounts for the “personalization” of the toponyms by transliterating them rather than translating them with the common Greek toponyms, as is usually done. Thus, it gives Μεσραιμ for Mizraim rather than the typical Αἴγυπτος (Egypt) or Αἰγύπτιος (Egyptian).

¹⁹ On the problem itself, see Witte, 2011, pt. 2; Jericke, 2015. For an illustration (and its problems), see Hölscher, 1949, 45–47; Zwickel, 2013, 97.

The schema in Gen 10:1–7, 20, 22f., 31f., characterized by the nominal listings, comes from the Priestly Writing. Its features include the *toledot* formula, the names of the three sons of Noah, which are only attested in Priestly texts (Gen 5:32; 6:10; 7:13; 9:18a), the proximity of the closing statements in vv. 5, 20, 31 to the systematizing formula “according to their kind” in the Priestly Creation account (Gen 1:11, 12, 21, 24, 25), and the seamless connection to the preceding Priestly passages (Gen 9:1–18a, 19[?], 28–29). There are also conceptual considerations: The Priestly Writing mentions the three sons of Noah with a conspicuous frequency, which would be expected for showing their significance for postdiluvian humanity. The Priestly genealogy of Shem in Gen 11:10–26 does not do this, but the Table of Nations in Gen 10* does.²⁰ A look at the new version of the blessing of multiplication after the Flood may shed more light on this.²¹ Through the genealogy in Gen 5, the Priestly Writing unfolds the effect of the blessing in Gen 1:28. The Table of Nations functions in the same way regarding the repetition of the blessing of multiplication after the Flood in Gen 9:1. Since the renewed blessing applies to Noah and his three sons, from whom all nations of the earth come (Gen 9:1, 19), it could not come into effect exclusively for the line of the sons of Shem. For this, the blessing required instead the universalistic perspective of the Table of Nations, both of which stand in accordance with the assertions about the creation of humanity in the Priestly Creation account. Incidentally, the insight into the conceptual connection between the creation of humanity, their blessing for multiplication, and the Table of Nations was even put into the mouth of the Apostle to the Nations, Paul, by the author of the Acts of the Apostles: “From one person he created the entire human race to inhabit all the reaches of the earth. he set fixed times for them and the boundaries of their dwellings” (Acts 17:26).

Within the Priestly text, v. 4b is a later addition that may have led to a reformulation of v. 5a (see on Gen 10:2–5 below).

Recently, there have been a few isolated objections to the traditional assignment of Gen 10:1–7, 20, 22–23, 31–32 to the Priestly Writing: “In Gen 10, more recent interpretation since Schrader [*Studien zur Urgeschichte*, 1863] has consistently been led down the wrong path by the final redaction: The *toledot* schema in v. 1 and v. 32 does not belong to the Priestly Writing but rather imitates it in order to incorporate the Jehovistic text of vv. 2–31*.”²² The following justifications are given for this assertion: The framing in v. 1 and v. 32, as well as the nominal style, are atypical for the Priestly Writing; the sequence of the sons of Noah in vv. 2ff. differs from that of the Priestly Writing in 5:32, *passim*; the listing of the sons of Shem in

²⁰ See Dillmann, 163.

²¹ See Crüsemann, 1998, 193; Witte, 2011, pt. 4; Hieke, 2014, 33.

²² Levin, 1993, 121–126 (quotation *ibid.*, 124 [translation JWR]). Followed, developing the arguments therein, by Carr, 1996, 99–101; Kratz, 2005, 237.

vv. 22–24, 32 is a doublet of the Priestly genealogy of Shem in 11:10ff. However, the following should be considered in this regard: There are correspondences in framing and nominal style with the Priestly genealogies of Esau and Ishmael in Gen 25:12–18; 36. Moreover, the differences can be adequately explained by how Gen 10, unlike Gen 5 and 11:10ff., offers a segmentary genealogy. The progression of vv. 2ff.* from the descendants of the youngest son, Japheth, through those of the middle son, Ham, to those of Noah's firstborn son, Shem, is not based on a conception different from that of the Priestly Writing. Rather, the younger lines coming first is due to the Priestly context, which focuses its progression on the descendants of Shem (Gen 11:10–26 [P]). As already seen, this also applies to the present shape of Gen 10:1–11:26, except that here, the narrative unfolding of the emergence of the nations (Gen 10:32b [P]) up through the Tower of Babel narrative (Gen 11:1–9 [non-P]) has led to the most important line of the sons of Shem already being named in the Table of Nations with the redactional supplement of v. 24f. (comp. with Gen 11:10–17). This thereby addresses the evaluation of vv. 22–24, 32 as a doublet, which is based rather substantially on v. 24 and overlooks how the verse does not fit to the nominal listing and should be assigned to another hand. Apart from v. 24, it cannot be a doublet already because of how Gen 10* is about all descendants of the sons of Noah and, therefore, also about all the sons of Shem. However, the linear genealogy in Gen 11:10ff. leading to the “sons of Terah” is only interested in Shem's son Arpachshad and his descendants. They are therefore left out in vv. 22, 23 and, consequently, are enumerated in a conceptually consistent manner only in Gen 11:10ff.

The classification of the schema characterized by verbal clauses in Gen 10:8–19, 21, 24–30 and the related question of the origins of the Table of Nation's present shape are currently the subject of a controversial debate. It is commonly attributed to another source within the biblical Primeval History (the “Yahwist” of the Documentary Hypothesis), which was connected to the Priestly narrative thread by a redactor.²³ Speaking against this solution is the fragmentary nature of the “Yahwistic” narrative thread,²⁴ and it also fails to identify an appropriate connection within the “Yahwistic” text for the first “Yahwistic” fragment in v. 8. Moreover, the “Yahwistic” fragments do not result in a coherent text, as the presumed transition from v. 21 to v. 24 clearly shows. Now, it cannot be ruled out that a redactor connected two source writings, using one as a basis and expanding it with only fragments of the other. However, it is more probable that the non-Priestly portions were designed from the outset as a supplement to the basic Priestly material of Gen 10*. Speaking for this assumption is how the genealogical notes, formulated as verbal clauses, are syntactically and functionally well connected

²³ For the fundamental aspects, see Wellhausen, 1899, 4–6 and Gunkel, 85f., and more recently Seebaß, 129.

²⁴ This is conceded unanimously by supporters of the Documentary Hypothesis. Cf. Tengström, 1982, 22f.; Van Seters, 1992, 174–187; Levin, 1993, 121–126, who, based on a clearly deviating determination of the “Yahwistic” texts, assume an original Yahwistic layer with Priestly and post-Priestly additions.

to the preexisting Priestly context.²⁵ The interest of the redactor(s) that led to their supplementation of the Priestly Table of Nations as well as the question of whether the redactors were able to draw on preexisting material are both discussed in the Exegesis below.

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION II: EXEGESIS

10:1

And these are the generations of the sons of Noah, Shem, Ham, and Japheth. Sons were born to them after the Flood.

The heading places the Table of Nations within the series of the *toledot*/generations. The placement of the apposition “Shem, Ham, and Japheth” after the “sons of Noah” (v. 1a) and the continuation of the heading with a narration (v. 1b) is striking in its language. This may have been due to the Priestly Writing having incorporated an earlier list (“The Sons of Noah: Shem, Ham, and Japheth”) into the *toledot* schema, taking up as usual the preceding (Priestly) context with the mention of Noah and the end of the Flood (see Gen 9:28).²⁶ It should also be kept in mind that Gen 10, unlike Gen 5 and 11, is segmentary from the outset. In Gen 5 and 11, as in all other instances of the *toledot* formula, the eponymous ancestor is a single person, indicating the genealogical connection of the following members. The Table of Nations, on the other hand, concerns itself not with the *toledot*/generations of a single person but of those of the three ancestors of all nations, with the genealogical connection indicated by their prefixed designation as the “sons of Noah.” The interest in depicting how the first generation of descendants was not born until after the Flood is clearly recognizable (so 10:32; 11:10). The explication in v. 1b serves to emphasize this. With the closing in v. 32, v. 1 is connected not only by each of the concluding “after the Flood” phrases but also by the chiasmic taking up of the “*toledot*/generations of the sons of Noah” with the “the clans of the sons of Noah, according to their *toledot*/generations.”

²⁵ See Witte, 1998, 100–114; idem, 2011, pt. 2; Arnoeth, 2007, 211–220; Knohl, 2008, 47f.; Bühner, 2017, 11–13.

²⁶ Weimar, 1974, 193 (for this assumption, see also Knauf, 1989, 61–65, who reckons with the inclusion of a geographic list from the Jerusalem scribal school of the seventh century BCE). Conversely, Budde, 1910 surmises the textual omission being due to haplography: “These are the *toledot* of the sons of Noah. The sons of Noah were...”

10:2–5

- 2 *The sons of Japheth: Gomer and Magog and Madai and Javan and Tubal and Meshech and Tiras.*
- 3 *And the sons of Gomer: Ashkenaz and Riphath and Togarmah.*
- 4 *And the sons of Javan: Elishah and Tarshish, the Kittaeans and the Rodanites.*
- 5 *From these, the islands of the nations branched out in their lands, each according to their language, according to their clans, in their nations.*

Japheth (for explanation of the name, see on Gen 5:32 above) has seven sons. Further sons are mentioned for two, Gomer and Javan. All of the uncertainties in the identification and explanation of the names notwithstanding, these are the ancestors of people groups who, from the Judeo-Palestinian perspective, were from the outermost edges of the known world. Their settlement area stretches like a semicircle around the territory of the sons of Ham and Shem, extending from the northern coast of the Black Sea and the Iranian highlands through Greece to Tarshish, located in the western extremities of the Mediterranean.

The Sons of Japheth (v. 2; P):

Gomer (גֹּמֶר)²⁷ is mentioned elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible only in the repetition of the Table of Nations in 1 Chr 1:4–23 (v. 5f.) and in Ezek 38:6. In the latter, it designates a territory belonging to the allies of Gog of Magog, who, according to Ezek 38:2, also rules over the regions of Meshech and Tubal. Since these names in Gen 10 are all descendants of Japheth, it can be assumed that the same entity is meant in each case. The name “Gomer” is attested in cuneiform texts from the first millennium BCE as *Gimirrai* and in Greek as the Κιμμέριοι/Cimmerians (see Herodotus, *Hist.* 4.11f.). Originally from the region north of the Black Sea (so the *Crimean Peninsula*), the Cimmerians first advanced into Urartu (Armenia) and, after clashes with the Assyrians, moved onward to the western coast of Asia Minor and settled in central Anatolia (Cappadocia), where they disappear from the historical record sometime around the middle of the first millennium BCE.

Magog (מָגוֹג) may possibly be derived from the Akkadian *māt Gūgi* “Land of Gyges.” Gyges is the first documented king of Lydia in western Asia Minor, who ruled there in the seventh century BCE but was defeated by the Cimmerians. He probably stands behind the apocalyptic figure of “Gog of Magog.” The toponyms “Tubal” and “Meshech” (see below), which lie in the domain of Gog of Magog in Ezek 38:2f.; 39:1, point to eastern Asia Minor.

Madai (מָדַי) is frequently attested in the Hebrew Bible, referring to the Medes (Isa 13:17) and the territories inhabited by them (Isa 21:2). The Medes appear in

²⁷ For the identification of the toponyms and names of people groups, see the entries in odb (2016), with a thorough discussion of the proposals for its identification, further evidence and source texts, extensive bibliography, and cartographic classification.

the northeast of the Assyrian Empire in the territory of modern-day Iran in the ninth century BCE and are frequently mentioned in cuneiform texts as *Mādā* from the time of Shalmaneser III (858–824 BCE). They conquered Assur in 614 BCE and participated in the destruction of Nineveh in 612 BCE. For a time, Medes and Persians lived under Median domination until the Achaemenid king and founder of the Persian empire Cyrus II, “Cyrus the Great” (559–530 BCE), overthrew his overlord and (according to Herodotus) maternal grandfather, the Median king Astyages around 550 BCE. The Table of Nations’ lack of any mention of the Persians, in contrast to the Medes, has been explained in various ways. As mentioned above, some interpret it as a restrained criticism of Achaemenid hegemonic claims. Others see the *terminus ante quem* for the (present) outline of the Table of Nations in the Persian supersession of Median rule, which must have been manifested for the authors of the Priestly Writing at the latest with the conquest of Babylon by Cyrus the Great in 539 BCE.²⁸ This latter argument is not compelling, since the Hebrew Bible repeatedly names and identifies both peoples in tight connection with each other (see Dan 5:28; 6:9, 13, 16; 8:20; Est 1:3, 14, 18f.; 10:2) or refers to Persian kings and their troops as “Medes.” Thus, in the context of the conquest of Babylon, the oracles against the nations in Isa 13 and Jer 51 speak of a victory by the Medes (Isa 13:17; Jer 51:11, 28; see also Isa 21:2; further “Darius [the son of Xerxes from the lineage of] the Mede[s]” in Dan 6:1; 9:1).²⁹ Therefore, in the Hebrew Bible, the Medes can stand (also) for the Persians.³⁰

Javan (יָוָן) denotes, like the Greek Ἰωνία and Ἰωνες, initially the region of Ionia or its inhabitants on the coast of Asia Minor and its offshore islands. The Ionians were the first Greeks with whom the ancient Near Eastern cultures came into contact, which is why, in the Hebrew Bible as well as cuneiform literature, their name ultimately served as a designation for all Greeks. Accordingly, the LXX translates it as Ἑλλάς (“Hellas; Greece”; Isa 66:19; Ezek 27:13) or as the tribal name Ἑλλήνοι (“Hellenes, Greeks”; Joel 4:6; Zech 9:13; Dan 8:21; 10:20; 11:2). Like in the Phoenician trade list in Ezek 27, Javan is named in connection with Tubal and Meshech (Ezek 27:13). This may have been a set phrase, indicated at least by the joint naming of the three areas in the inscriptions of Sargon II (722–705 BCE).

Tubal (תּוּבַל) and Meshech (מֶשֶׁח) are typically mentioned together in the Hebrew Bible (Ezek 27:13; 32:26; 38:2f.; 39:1; Isa 66:19^{LXX}; exceptionally Tubal alone in Isa 66:19^{MT} and Meshech alone in Ps 120:5). Both names are equivalent to the tribal confederations and subsequent vassals *Tabalū* and *Mušku* mentioned in Assyrian royal inscriptions. In Greek sources, the peoples are called “Tibareni” (Τιβάρηνοι) and “Moschoi” (Μοσχοί). Both are to be found in the area of the former Hittite Empire, Tubal/the Tibareni on the southern coast of the Black Sea and Meshech/the Moschoi probably in Phrygia in the central Anatolian hill country. Ezekiel 27:13 mentions that Meshech and Tubal trade in copper tools as well as in slaves.

Tiras (תִּירָס) is, outside of 1 Chr 1:5, not mentioned again in the Hebrew Bible, and we lack any relevant cuneiform sources. Generally, Tiras is identified with the Tyrsenians/Tyrrhenians (Τυρσηνοί/Tυρρηνοί) mentioned in Greek sources, who

²⁸ Seebaß, 267.

²⁹ It obviously cannot be ruled out that the pronouncement in Isa 13 (without the later statements about the Last Judgment) referring to Babylon was written already before 539 BCE. In addition to the conquest by the Medes, there is a second historical inaccuracy speaking in favor of this: As opposed to what is pronounced, the conquerors took Babylon without a fight.

³⁰ See Hölscher, 1949, 54, with reference to the same identification in the Greek authors.

were from northwestern Asia Minor and islands in the northern Aegean. Josephus connects Tiras with Thrace, located in northeastern Greece and on the western coast of the Black Sea (Josephus, *A.J.* 1.125).

The Sons of Gomer (v. 3; P):

Ashkenaz (אַשְׁכְּנַז) is, outside of 1 Chr 1:6, only mentioned elsewhere in Jer 51:27, where he is counted among the “enemies from the north” (v. 48) alongside Ararat (Akkadian *Uratu*/Armenia) and Minni (Manneans; Akkadian *Mannāya*/south of Lake Urmia in modern-day northeastern Iran). Like Gomer and Ashkenaz in Gen 10, *Gimirrai* and *Aškuza* as well as *Mannāya* and *Aškuza* appear together in cuneiform texts, and Cimmerians and Scythians in Greek sources, which makes an identification with the Scythians possible. The Scythians first settled on the northern coast of the Black Sea and pushed the Cimmerians southward. The LXX refrains from an identification and transliterates the name.

Riphat (רִפְתָּה) is attested neither elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible nor in cuneiform sources. No identification is possible; Josephus identifies them with the Paphlagonians settling on the Black Sea between Pontus and Bithynia (Josephus, *A.J.* 1.126). This would fit the geographical picture of Gomer and his descendants, but this is completely uncertain.

Togarmah (תּוֹגַרְמָה) is also placed alongside Gomer in Ezek 38:6 (“Beth-togarmah”), while in the Phoenician trade list from Ezek 27 (“Beth-togarmah”), the name is mentioned immediately after the trio of Javan, Tubal, and Meshech (v. 13f.). An identification with the Hittite *Tagarma* and the Assyrian *Til-Garimmu* is conceivable. Hittite texts of the second millennium BCE speak of a country, while in Neo-Assyrian times, *Til-Garimmu* is attested only as a city name. Its exact location is unclear; Assyrian texts point to an area east of or in Tubal/*Tabalū*. An alternative interpretation difficult from both philological and historical-geographical perspectives has suggested a personal name behind “Togarmah” due to the expression “House of Togarmah” in Ezek 38:6 and proposed an equation with the Cimmerian chief Tugdamme (Gk. Λύγδαμης), who brought it to some fame in the seventh century BCE because of his military campaigns before he was defeated by the Assyrians under Assurbanipal.³¹

The Sons of Javan (v. 4; P with editing in v. 4b):

Elishah (אֵלִישָׁה) is, outside of 1 Chr 1:7, attested in Ezek 27:7 and can be identified with some certainty with Cyprus, which is called *Alashiya* in cuneiform texts of the second millennium BCE.

Tarshish (תַּרְשִׁישׁ) is generally equated with the toponym Tartessos/Ταρτησσός, a Phoenician/Punic trading settlement located in southwestern Spain in the Guadalquivir estuary mentioned multiple times in Greek literature (Herodotus, *Hist.* 1.163; 4.152, 192). A Neo-Assyrian inscription from the time of Esarhaddon (681–669 BCE) names, from east to west, the kings of Cyprus and Greece as far as Tarshish (*Tarsisi*), thus marking Tarshish as the westernmost colony of the Phoenicians, who cooperated with the Assyrians. Quite similarly, Gen 10 probably seeks to cover as wide of a sweep as possible. This also fits the Hebrew Bible usage, in which Tarshish often denotes a distant land (Isa 23:6, 10; 66:19; Jer 10:9; Jon 1:3; 4:2) and ocean-faring ships suitable for long-distance trade are known as “ships of Tarshish” (1 Kgs 10:22; 22:49;

³¹ Lipiński, 1990, 50. On Tugdamme, see A. Kuhrt, 1990.

Isa 2:16; Ezek 27:25), which only later in 2 Chr 9:21 means “ships to Tarshish.” The trade list in Ezek 27, on the other hand, has in mind quite concretely the colony settled from Tyre in southwestern Spain, since the ores mentioned in Ezek 27:12 – silver, iron, tin, and lead – were mined in Tarshish/Tartessos.

Kittaeans (כְּתִיִּים) and Rodanites (רֹדָנִיִּים) are, in contrast to the other names of the Priestly Table of Nations, not secondary toponyms but ethnonyms. Thus, the phrases “land of the Kittaeans” (Isa 23:1) and “islands of the Kittaeans” (Jer 2:10; Ezek 27:6) define the general landscape descriptors “land” and “islands” by their inhabitants. The lands and islands of the Kittaeans are closely associated with seafaring and are repeatedly mentioned as the starting or ending points of ship expeditions (Num 24:24; Isa 23:1, 12; Jer 2:10; Dan 11:30). This points to the island realm of the eastern Mediterranean and the adjacent coastal areas, more specifically to the city of Kition, modern-day Larnaca, on Cyprus. The references in the Hebrew Bible, however, probably indicate not only the inhabitants of the city but all of Cyprus and the neighboring Mediterranean islands and nearby coasts (“islands of the Kittaeans”; “land of the Kittaeans”). In the Hellenistic period, the scope of the term was expanded, with the Macedonian coast also being considered part of the land of the Kittaeans (1 Macc 1:1) or the Kittaeans representing a kind of eschatological power without any precise designation of origin (Dan 11:30; Num 24:24). Finally, the Hebrew כְּתִיִּים can also refer to the Romans, as the great power ruling over the eastern Mediterranean (so 1QpHab 2,12 [DSS VI/b, 162f.]; Dan 11:30^{LXX}). The Rodanites, or “sons of Rodan,” – otherwise mentioned only in 1 Chr 1:7 and Ezek 27:15^{LXX} – refer to the inhabitants of the island of Rhodes. Since Cyprus (Elishah) is already named among the sons of Javan, the names of the two peoples, the Kittaeans and the Rodanites, are probably an explanatory addition to “Elishah and Tarshish.” The כְּתִיִּים is a case of a term common in other Hebrew Bible narrative contexts being used that refers quite generally to the hegemonic relations of the eastern Mediterranean world without a concrete location (Cyprus) being connected to it.

The conclusion to the sons of Japheth (v. 5; P), like that of Ham (v. 20; P) and Shem (v. 31; P), contains the elements “in their lands,” “according to their languages,” “according to their clans,” and “according to their nations.” However, the order of the first three differs. Meanwhile, even more striking is that it does not begin like the other two closings, with “These are the sons of Japheth,” but with “From these, the islands of the nations branched out.” In view of this, it is often noted that the expression “islands of the nations” and thus the closing as a whole cannot refer to all of the sons of Japheth since it only fits the geographic conditions of Javan and his descendants. The text of v. 5 would have therefore been adjusted several times, and a supposedly lost “These are the sons of Japheth” would have been supplemented after “From these, the islands of the nations branched out,” with the “islands of the nations” clearly referring to the sons of Javan in v. 4.³² Others reckon with an editor replacing an original “These are the sons of Japheth” with the current beginning of the conclusion, resulting from the addition of v. 4b.

³² Gunkel, 152f.; Westermann, 508.

This would have been intended to emphasize the Greeks as the apex of the sons of Japheth.³³ How one evaluates these suggestions is related to how one understands the phrase “islands of the nations” (אֲיִל הַגּוֹיִם) and what it refers to. The expression אֲיִל/יָם often denotes the islands of the Mediterranean, but it can also include the islands of the Persian Gulf or the Indian Ocean (Isa 11:11; Est 10:1). However, alongside connections such as “islands in/of the sea” (Isa 11:11; 24:15), there are also several occurrences in which the expression is a more general designation of the coastal region (so Isa 20:6) or quite distant overseas areas (so Jer 25:22; 31:10). The latter corresponds to how אֲיִל can be used in parallel with “the ends of the earth” (Isa 41:5; see also Isa 49:1; 66:19). From the Judeo-Palestinian perspective, this applies – with the possible exception of the Medes – to all peoples and regions classified under the sons of Japheth.³⁴ Consequently, the phrase can be used “functionally, structurally, and terminologically”³⁵ to refer to the entirety of the “sons of Japheth.”

Remaining to be discussed is why the Priestly Writing chose a different formulation from vv. 20 and 31. One suggestion stems from the notice that the “islands of the nations” branched out (*פרד ni.) from the sons of Japheth. The verb *פרד is also found in the overall conclusion of the Table of Nations in v. 32, but it refers there to all the nations of the earth, who have descended from the “clans of the sons of Noah.” Like the concluding formulae for Japheth, Ham, and Shem, this makes clear that in principle, the Table of Nations seeks to be exhaustive, but it does not demonstrate this in all of its details. This is certainly the case for the “lateborn” peoples such as Israel and its “Abrahamic” brother nations (Gen 17; 25:1–4), who are not mentioned in the Table of Nations. The same is probably true for the nations who were simply unknown to the authors but whose existence they could still assume. Since the areas represented by the “sons of Japheth” were largely *terra incognita* for the Priestly Writing, it made sense to include all other distant peoples among the sons of Japheth. This is what the “islands of the nations” represents. The LXX recognized this link and expanded “peoples” (הַגּוֹיִם = τὰ ἔθνη) in v. 32 to “islands of the nations” (νησοὶ τῶν ἔθνων, as in v. 5), so that the expression circumscribes the entire world known at that time. The universal orientation of the expression “islands of the nations” is evidenced by the only other instance of the phrase, in Zeph 2:11, where it designates the inhabitants of the farthest reaches of the world.

The sequencing of the stock phrases “in their lands,” “according to their languages,” and “according to their clans,” as well as the concluding “in

³³ Seebaß, 257. This suggestion is first found in Olshausen, 1870, 380–409, 383.

³⁴ See Horowitz, 1990.

³⁵ Witte, 1998, 109 [translation JWR].

their nations” that summarizes the series, has an almost definitional character. It expresses a concept of what unites larger associations into the whole of a people and distinguishes them from others.³⁶ Building upon the familial structures of the families and clans, this involves common languages, settled territories, and their populations. The genealogical presentation notwithstanding, the togetherness is based not only on kinship relations but also cultural achievements as well as economic and political conditions. The close connection between culture, territory, and population that is addressed here may have been inspired by Persian imperial ideology, which used a similarly broad term for the ruled “peoples” (*dahyu*).³⁷

10:6–20

- 6 *And the sons of Ham: Cush and Mizraim and Put and Canaan.*
- 7 *And the sons of Cush: Seba and Havilah and Sabtah and Ragmah and Sabtechah. And the sons of Ragmah: Sheba and Dedan.*
- 8 *And Cush fathered Nimrod. He was the first hero on the earth.*
- 9 *He was a hero of the hunt before Yhwh. Therefore, it is said, “Like Nimrod – a hero of the hunt before Yhwh.”*
- 10 *And the beginning of his kingdom was Babel and Erech and Akkad, and they all were in the land of Shinar.*
- 11 *From this land, he went out to Assur, and he built Nineveh and the city squares and Calah,*
- 12 *and Resen between Nineveh and Calah; that is the great city.*
- 13 *And Mizraim fathered the Ludites and the Anamites and the Lehabites and the Naphtuhites.*
- 14 *And the Pathrusites and the Casluhites, whence came the Philistines, and the Caphtorites.*
- 15 *And Canaan fathered Sidon, his firstborn, and Heth*
- 16 *and the Jebusite and the Amorite and the Girgashite*
- 17 *and the Hivite and the Arkite and the Sinite*
- 18 *and the Arvadite and the Zemarite and the Hamathite. But later, the clans of the Canaanites scattered themselves.*
- 19 *And the territory of the Canaanites reached from Sidon, towards Gerar, as far as Gaza, towards Sodom and Gomorrah and Admah and Zeboiim, as far as Lasha.*
- 20 *These are the sons of Ham according to their clans, their languages, in their lands, in their nations.*

³⁶ Westermann, 509.

³⁷ See Lecoq, 1990.

Ham (for explanation of the name, see on Gen 5:32 above) has four sons. Further sons are mentioned for three, Cush, Mizraim, and Canaan, and for Cush in one case also a grandson. It should be noted that the Priestly Writing only mentions descendants for Cush, with his son Nimrod having come from non-Priestly editing. The summarizing conclusion in v. 20 corresponds to the closings for Japheth and Shem in vv. 5 and 31. In the Priestly Table of Nations, the sons of Ham are the eponyms of nations who, from the Judeo-Palestinian perspective, come from the westernmost and southwesternmost edges of the known world. All of the uncertainties in locating them notwithstanding, their territory includes modern-day Libya in the west, the Nile from Egypt to the modern-day Sudan and Ethiopia as well as the Arabian Peninsula from the Gulf of Aqaba to the Gulf of Aden. Only the placement of Canaan lies outside of this geographical frame. It corresponds to the political and geographical situation from the second half of the second millennium BCE, in which Canaan was controlled by the Egyptians, but is rooted above all in ideological grounds insofar as it already introduces the common Hebrew Bible distinction between “Israel” and “Canaan” into the Table of Nations (see below on Canaan).

The non-Priestly additions in vv. 8–19 shift the geographical coordinates. Since the Nimrod episode is clearly set in Mesopotamia, the sons of Ham are associated through the addition with an area that, according to the Priestly Writing, is the home of the sons of Shem (so Assur and Arpachshad/Babylon in v. 22). Moreover, the eleven sons of Canaan clearly shift the focus to the Levant.

The Sons of Ham (v. 6; P):

Cush (כּוּשׁ), in the Hebrew Bible as well as in the hieroglyphic and cuneiform texts from the third to first millennia BCE, denotes the land of Nubia, south of Egypt. According to Ezek 29:10, the border between Mizraim/Egypt and Cush/Nubia lies at Syene/Aswan south of the First Cataract. Today, its area is largely part of the territory of the Sudan, while parts belong to Ethiopia. It is both striking but also completely appropriate for a biblical text that the Priestly Writing places Cush at the beginning of a series with Mizraim (Egypt), Put (Libya), and Canaan (the Levant). In this sequence, Cush marks the extreme southwest. For discussion of Cush in v. 8, see below.

Mizraim (מִצְרַיִם) is, with over 600 uses, the second most common toponym in the Hebrew Bible. Its identification with Egypt, divided into Upper Egypt and Lower Egypt, is beyond dispute.

Put (פּוּט)³⁸ is, almost without exception (Ezek 27:10), mentioned in the Hebrew Bible alongside Cush (Jer 46:9; Ezek 30:5; 38:5; Nah 3:9). Moreover, in Nah 3:9, Put is mentioned in the context of Egypt and is paralleled with the “Lubim” (Libyans), a collective designation for the peoples of North Africa west of Lower Egypt and

³⁸ See Görg, 2002.

alongside whom Put participated in Egyptian mercenary service (see also Ezek 30:5). Ancient texts and commentators have therefore associated Put with Libya (LXX: Λίβυες/Libyan), but in some cases understood it as designating more distant areas in North Africa, as far as Mauritania (Josephus, *A.J.* 1.132). Hieroglyphically, the expression “land of the *Pjt*-people” is attested as an alternative name for Libya, and the “land of *Putul/Putāya*” in cuneiform texts also points in this direction. The identification of Put with the “land of gold” of Punt in modern-day Somalia, which has also been considered, has not proven viable.

Canaan (כְּנָעַן), according to cuneiform and Egyptian texts from the second half of the second millennium BCE, refers to the southern part of the Syro-Palestinian land bridge controlled by Egypt. The Egyptian “province of Canaan,” with Gaza as its administrative center, reached from Byblos to the eastern border of Egypt. In the Hebrew Bible, the “land of Canaan” is the land promised to Israel and divided among its tribes after the conquest, from the northern Lebanon mountains in the north to the “brook of Egypt” in the south and the Jordan in the east. Canaan not being counted among the sons of Shem like the ancestors of the later “Israel” but being counted instead, like Egypt, to Ham, reflects the political conditions of the second half of the second millennium BCE. Nevertheless, this assignment need not be based on “a very old tradition.”³⁹ According to the historical picture of the Hebrew Bible, which the Priestly Writing shares, Israel arrives from the outside to the land of Canaan, where the ancestors of Israel had already sojourned as strangers (Gen 17:8; P). The Israel of the Hebrew Bible is thus, according to its own self-perception, clearly distinct from the autochthonous population of the promised land. For this reason, the Priestly Writing logically assigns Canaan to the sons of Ham and the ancestors of the later Israel to the sons of Shem, even though, historically speaking, this Israel actually emerged from Canaan.

The Sons of Cush (v. 7a; P):

Seba (סְבָא) is, outside of 1 Chr 1:9, also mentioned alongside Cush and Egypt in Isa 43:3 and Isa 45:14 (pl. סְבָאִים as the name of a people), which speaks for a location in northeast Africa. The only other attestation is in Ps 72:10, which names Seba alongside Sheba (שָׁבָא), who is mentioned in v. 7 as the grandson of Cush and the son of Ragmah and then is found again in a non-Priestly addition among the descendants of Shem as a son of Joktan. Therefore, contrary to what scholars have more often proposed,⁴⁰ at least the authors of v. 7 probably did not equate Seba with Sheba. Josephus (*A.J.* 2.249) suggests an equation with an Ethiopian royal city, the later Meroë. This fits quite well with the thought that Seba was a colony of the Sabaeans in Ethiopia.⁴¹

Havilah (חֲוִילָה) refers to the “land of sand” in the western part of the Arabian Peninsula and the coastline opposite it across the Red Sea (for its location, see on Gen 2:10–14 above).

Sabtah (סַבְתָּא) and Sabtechah (סַבְתְּכָא) are mentioned elsewhere only in the repetition of the Table of Nations in 1 Chr 1:9. An identification for them is completely unclear. Sabtah is often equated with Šabwa (Gk. Σάββαθα), the capital of the South Arabian kingdom of *Ḥaḍramaut* in the region of modern-day Yemen. There is an

³⁹ Westermann, 511.

⁴⁰ See Hölscher, 1949, 48.

⁴¹ See Knauf, 1989, 62f. and fn. 298.

appealing hypothesis that Sabtechah should be associated with Pharaoh Shabataka (707–690 BCE) of the 25th (Nubian) Dynasty.⁴²

Ragmah (רַגְמָה) is, outside of 1 Chr 1:9, also mentioned in Ezek 27:22, appearing alongside Sheba – a son of Ragmah according to v. 7 – as a trading partner of Tyre. The Hebrew letter *ʾayin* probably corresponds to the Semitic *ḡ* (see LXX 1 Chr 1:9: Ρεγμα; Ezek 27:22: Ραγμα). This, as well as the connection to Sheba and the trading goods of balsam, precious stones, and gold mentioned in Ezek 27:22, speaks in favor of an identification with the locality of *Rgmt^m* known from an Old South Arabian (Minaean) inscription. The town, located in the *Naḡrān* oasis on the modern-day border between Saudi Arabia and Yemen, was an important station in ancient times on the Incense Route, which led from *Mārib*, the capital of the Sabaean empire (Sheba), through Dedan – the second son of Ragmah according to v. 7 – to the Mediterranean.

The Sons of Ragmah (v. 7b; P):

Sheba (שֶׁבָּא) is frequently attested across the Hebrew Bible and can be equated without a shadow of a doubt with the South Arabian “Kingdom of Saba” in modern-day Yemen. Saba’ had close cultural and economic contacts to regions in East Africa, as far as the Ethiopian highlands. It appears as a regional power in the seventh and sixth centuries BCE and is mentioned in Neo-Assyrian inscriptions from the time of Tiglath-Pileser III (745–726 BCE). The Hebrew Bible texts, especially the story of the visit by the Queen of Sheba in 1 Kgs 10, convey the rather legendary image of a wealthy kingdom far to the south that trades in exotic goods (balsam, precious stones, gold, frankincense; see 1 Kgs 10:2; Isa 60:6; Jer 6:20; Ezek 27:22), as also mentioned in Assyrian texts as tribute from the Sabaeans. In the non-Priestly addition of Gen 10:26–29, Sheba is assigned to the sons of Shem alongside his brother Havilah – who is his uncle according to v. 7 – through Joktan. Genesis 25:1–4 places the brothers Sheba and Dedan among the descendants of Abraham and his third wife, Keturah (“The one who smells of incense”).

Dedan (דֶּדָן) was an oasis city in the northwest of the Arabian Peninsula (modern *el-ʿUlā*) on the border with Edom (Ezek 25:13). Located on the Incense Route, Dedan was a center of long-distance caravan trade beginning in the eighth century BCE (see also Isa 21:13) and was under Sabaean control until the fifth century BCE. The latter also explains the genealogical connection of Sheba and Dedan in the Table of Nations and in Gen 25:1–4.

10:8–12

- 8 *And Cush fathered Nimrod. He was the first hero on the earth.*
- 9 *He was a hero of the hunt before Yhwh. Therefore, it is said, “Like Nimrod – a hero of the hunt before Yhwh.”*
- 10 *And the beginning of his kingdom was Babel and Erech and Akkad, and they all were in the land of Shinar.*
- 11 *From this land, he went out to Assur, and he built Nineveh and the city squares and Calah,*

⁴² Procksch, 488.

12 *and Resen between Nineveh and Calah; that is the great city.*

Although the genealogical representation of the world of nations had already reached the grandchildren of Cush, v. 8 turns back and gives a notice about Cush having begotten Nimrod. The short story about Nimrod and the beginnings of his kingship, into which a proverb was later incorporated (v. 9), fits well with the syntax of the Priestly listing of the sons and grandsons of Cush but was written by a different hand. Even apart from stylistic peculiarities, this is also evident in the different geographic conceptions for the ethnic groups. The place names in v. 10f. all point to Mesopotamia, which is assigned not to Ham but to Shem in the Priestly Table of Nations.

Babel (בָּבֶל)/Babylon was, from the second millennium BCE, the political and cultic center of southern Mesopotamia. Erech (אֶרֶךְ) is consistently identified with Uruk (*al-Warkā*), located about 200 km southeast of Babel/Babylon. Uruk was one of the largest and oldest cities in Babylonia and was settled from the fifth millennium BCE to the fourth century CE. Akkad (אַכַּד) traces its origins back to its legendary foundation by Sargon I and was the center of the Akkadian empire until the late second millennium BCE. The exact location of the city is unknown, but it presumably lies north of Babylon. Additionally, “Akkad” is also documented as a name for the northern Babylonian countryside. The three cities are all located in southern Mesopotamia, for which the term “land of Shinar” (שִׁנְעָר) is used (see Gen 11:2; 14:1, 9; Jos 7:21; Isa 11:11; Zech 5:11; Dan 1:2), which is also attested in cuneiform texts from the second millennium BCE as *Šanḫar*, referring to Babylonia. The choice of the archaizing “Shinar/*Šanḫar*” instead of the more recent (and presumably contemporary) “land of the Chaldeans” (Akk. *māt kaldī*; see also Gen 11:28, 31; 15:7) is due to the narrative’s “primeval” stylization. The cities listed thereafter are located in the core of the Assyrian empire, also known elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible as Assur (אַשּׁוּר). Located on the left bank of the Tigris across from the modern-day city of Mosul, Nineveh (נִינְוָה) became the capital of the Assyrian empire under Sennacherib (705–681 BCE), until the fall of the empire with the conquest of Nineveh in 612 BCE. Nineveh’s long literary afterlife can be seen in the legendary narratives in the books of Jonah, Tobit, and Judith, all of which were written after the fall of the city. Calah (כַּלְחָה) is known from Neo-Assyrian texts as *Kalḫu*, a city on the Tigris about 30 km southeast of Nineveh, which was promoted to “residential city” status under Assurbanipal II (883–859 BCE). The modern-day ruins are called “*Nimrūd*,” which is a modern reference to the biblical tradition. The specification “that is the great city” (v. 12b) is often labeled a gloss that was brought into the text at the wrong place, because of Nineveh having the same designation in the book of Jonah (Jon 1:2; 3:2; 4:11; cf. Jer 22:8: Jerusalem). Although this is possible, it is not completely convincing; no mutual influence between Gen 10 and Jonah can otherwise be shown. Moreover, the characterization as a “great city” is also incredibly appropriate for the residential city of Calah.⁴³ Resen (רֶסֶן) has not yet been able to

⁴³ Seebaß, 260. However, in this case, the more detailed designation would be better positioned after the first mention of Calah in v. 11.

be located.⁴⁴ The toponym may possibly be connected with the Akkadian *risnu* “canal.” In this case, Resen would refer to an irrigation system between Nineveh and Calah (v. 12a). There have been repeated suggestions to identify it with the Neo-Assyrian residential city of *Dur-Šarrukin*, “The Fortress of Sargon,” based on the assumption that an original *dr srgn* = *Dur-Šarrukin* could have changed to רֶסֶן = רֶסֶן through the transmissional process. This identification has certain pragmatic elements of the text against it: The foundation of the city is attributed to Nimrod, which does not fit well with the mention of a city whose founder, Sargon, is immortalized in its name.⁴⁵ Moreover, *Dur-Šarrukin* was not located between Niniveh and Calah but north of the two cities.

Style and geographic conceptions of ethnic groups aside, the short narrative about Nimrod also differs from the Priestly Table of Nations (and the other additions) in how it offers no further genealogical material but instead a cultural etiology. Accordingly, the toponyms do not represent the ancestors of certain nations or countries; instead, they constitute a listing of city foundations. The subject of the etiology is the beginnings of kingship and, thus, of political rule in the world – synonymous here with the ancient Near East. These beginnings are to be found in southern Mesopotamia, and this conception fits quite well with the self-perception of the rulers there, which the biblical authors learned to share through centuries of experience as vassals of the great Mesopotamian empires. Similarly, the characterization of the king as a hero, heroic hunter, and city builder matches the self-portrayal of Mesopotamian kings, which certainly also left its mark on the royal courts of the periphery, such as that of Jerusalem. On top of all this, the sequence of the place names from the beginnings in Babel, Uruk, and Akkad and the transition to Assyria reads like a small compendium of the history of Mesopotamia – even if, historically speaking, the order of the cities in the land of Shinar is wrong. It is therefore not surprising that there have been repeated attempts to identify a concrete Mesopotamian antecedent behind the figure of Nimrod, who is not documented in cuneiform texts. Suggestions have included the Sumerian/Babylonian hunting and war god Ninurta⁴⁶ and the Babylonian god-king Marduk.⁴⁷ Yet, although Nimrod is a hero, he is no god. Moreover, the claimed philological connections between the biblical name and those of the gods are problematic.⁴⁸ This is also true for the legendary and historical kings otherwise suggested in the debate, such as Gilgamesh,⁴⁹ Sargon I,⁵⁰

⁴⁴ See van der Toorn/van der Horst, 1990, 5f.

⁴⁵ See Bühner, 2017, 6.

⁴⁶ van der Toorn/van der Horst, 1990, 9–16.

⁴⁷ Lipiński, 1966, 78.

⁴⁸ So also van der Toorn/van der Horst, 1990, 9, 14.

⁴⁹ See Seebach, 259; Witte, 1998, 109 fn. 120.

⁵⁰ See Knohl, 2008, 49, 51f.

or Pharaoh Amenhotep III (*Neb-maat-re*).⁵¹ Furthermore, the correspondences between the few details of the biblical narrative and the transmitted deeds of the alleged antecedents are, when examined individually, quite vague. Thus, rather than a concrete ruler, legendary figure, or deity, Nimrod is a general reference to the royal ideology of the ancient Near East, particularly the understanding of royal activity as the revival of divine, mythical events of primeval times.⁵² Nimrod, comparable to Gilgamesh, is the prototypical Mesopotamian ruler “whose proverbial achievements in city-building and heroic hunting have inscribed him into collective memory.”⁵³

“Nimrod” was most likely chosen as the name of this prototypical Mesopotamian ruler because it had a foreign, “Babylonian” effect on the readers of that time. At the same time, the name “Nimrod” can easily be connected with the Hebrew verb *מרד “to rebel.”⁵⁴ The earliest readers would have heard the meaning “Let us rebel” in the name of the supposed Babylonian king, thus declaring Nimrod as the prototypical rebel.⁵⁵ Against whom could the first and, by then, only king rebel, other than against God and his ordering of the world of nations?⁵⁶ Accordingly, even ancient interpretations saw the “rebel” Nimrod in light of the following story about the construction of the Tower of Babel and identified him as the builder of the tower, which was seen as an expression of human hubris (Josephus, *A.J.* 1.113–114). This linkage cannot be dismissed, at least on the literary level of the text’s final form, as shown by the shared location of both texts in the land of Shinar and the shared motifs of “beginnings” (*הלל hi.) and urban construction. The distinctive reception of Mesopotamian royal self-representation is thus refracted ironically and critically,⁵⁷ placing even their institution of kingship in a critical light as well. Finally, this also explains why the episode was placed in the genealogy of the sons of Ham despite the geographic conceptions of the ethnic groups in its context: The editor wanted to introduce the dimension of political domination into the (in this respect) idealizing

⁵¹ von Rad, 146, with reference to the Akkadian name “Nimmuris” from the Amarna Letters.

⁵² On this aspect of royal ideology, see Maul, 1998, 71–77.

⁵³ Bühner, 2017, 10 [translation JWR].

⁵⁴ See Budde, 1883, 394; Dillmann, 184; Witte, 1998, 259f. and fn. 46.

⁵⁵ Tg. Ps.-J. explains Gen 10:8 as follows: “Cush fathered Nimrod. He was the first hero on the earth in sin and in rebellion before [Yhwh].” See further Tg. Neof. on Gen 10:8f.; b.Pesah. 94b; b.’Erub. 53a; Gen. Rab. XXIII.7 and further Smelik, 2011, 272–274, and van der Toorn/van der Horst, 1990, 16–29 (there also on the traces of a positive reception of Nimrod).

⁵⁶ This is overlooked by Bühner, 2017, 15f., who argues against the name, derived from *מרד, having any negative connotations, with reference to a positive/neutral use in the few verses that evaluate the rebellion of the Judahite kings against their Assyrian overlords positively (2 Kgs 18:7, 20; Isa 36:5).

⁵⁷ See Hendel, 2005, 31.

Table of Nations of the Priestly Writing, but Mesopotamian kingship, under which the states of Israel and Judah suffered for centuries, was not to be introduced under the genealogy of the sons of Shem and thus, according to Gen 11:10–26, also that of the ancestors of Israel. The realpolitik of domination and violence was attributed to the sons of Ham, whose sons Mizraim/Egypt and Canaan were already among the “archenemies” of Israel.⁵⁸ Thus, the short narrative of Nimrod falls in line with the degradation of Canaan in the narrative of Noah and his sons in Gen 9:18–29 and in the subsequent listing of the sons of Canaan in vv. 15–18, which is based on the list from Josh 3:10 of the previous inhabitants of the land who are to be expelled. The only other appearance of Nimrod in the Hebrew Bible further expands the negative, critical reading: Micah 5:5, dating to the Hellenistic period, parallels Nimrod with Assyria and uses both as “codes for a later, oppressive domination... virtually ‘appearing [as an] antidivine empire’.”⁵⁹

With the conceptual assignment of Nimrod to the sons of Ham, considerations about a “Mesopotamian Cush” in v. 8 become superfluous. The editor did not mistakenly identify either the Mesopotamian city of Kish,⁶⁰ from which kingship began after the Flood according to Mesopotamian tradition, or the Kassites (*Kaššû*) from the Zagros Mountains east of Mesopotamia⁶¹ with Nubian Cush. This genuinely “biblical” narrative, like all other attestations of the toponym “Cush” in the Hebrew Bible, refers to Nubia and its inhabitants.

Verse 9 is usually regarded as a later expansion of the Nimrod story, as it takes up the new theme of hunting, falls out of the narrative framework with the quotation of a proverb, and also interrupts the context of v. 8 and v. 10f.⁶² Although such an evaluation is possible, it is not certain. Hunting was a typical field of activity for Mesopotamian kings, especially from the Neo-Assyrian empire, and was a fixed theme within royal ideology. Neo-Assyrian depictions show the great king standing on his chariot or on his throne stool, with a bow and arrow slaying lions that had been delivered in cages. The superiority of the king thus demonstrates his ability to subdue the danger posed by wild animals. Standing in the background of this is the ideology of the king as the powerful hero protecting the world order from chaos, which is symbolized by the animals. Thus, functionally, the characterization of Nimrod as the mighty hunter takes up the self-description of Mesopotamian kings to which v. 8 alludes, with the phrase “before Yhwh” establishing the universalistic claim that even Mesopotamian kings operate within Yhwh’s realm of activity. The close functional connection between v. 9a and v. 8b can be

⁵⁸ See Witte, 1998, 274; idem, 2011, pt. 4; Knohl, 2008, 48f.; Bühner, 2017, 18.

⁵⁹ Jeremias, 2007, 187 [translation JWR], citing Greßmann, 1929, 252.

⁶⁰ See Levin, 2002; Kvanvig, 2011, 418.

⁶¹ See Ruppert, 445, and recently again Dietrich, 2001, 313f.

⁶² According to Seebaß, 259, this has been “common knowledge” since Dillmann, 185.

shown by the language of the two, with the former serving as a second apposition with the same opening “he was” (הוּא־הָיָה) placed without a conjunction next to v. 8b and clarifying it by declaring the first “hero” (גִּבּוֹר) to be the “hero of the hunt” (גִּבּוֹר־צֹיֵד). The connection of v. 10 to v. 9a is neither better nor worse than its connection to v. 8b. Only the quotation of a proverb in v. 9b interrupts the narrative flow, insofar as it is clearly marked by the “Therefore, it is said” as commentary by the narrator (see also Num 21:14, 27; 1 Sam 19:24; 2 Sam 5:8), which, moreover, distracts from the theme of the narrative, which is heavily focused on the beginnings of kingship. The proverb takes up the phrase known from v. 9a, “a hero of the hunt before Yhwh.” Therefore, it stands to reason *prima facie* that the entire verse was crafted from a traditional proverb that was inserted in a manner contextually appropriate and skillful in its use of language.⁶³ However, the supposed proverb is completely connected to its context and has no word or thought that goes beyond it (as is not the case in Num 21:14, 27; 1 Sam 19:24; 2 Sam 5:8). This suggests that, rather than a traditional proverb, this is a context-sensitive addition. If v. 9 thus cannot be evidence for a folk tradition about Nimrod independent of Gen 10:8, 10–11, then both the name and figure of Nimrod might have come from the editor of the Table of Nations himself.

10:13–14

- 13 *And Mizraim fathered the Ludites and the Anamites and the Lehabites and the Naphtuhites.*
 14 *And the Pathrusites and the Casluhites, whence came the Philistines, and the Caphortites.*

A new section of the extensive additions to the sons of Ham begins with the sons of Mizraim. The list, designed as a pure genealogy according to the pattern “P.N. fathered P.N.” (יִלְד *אֶת), is conspicuous in how Mizraim/Egypt, who is introduced as a person (see v. 6), does not father further ancestors as is typical but immediately fathers entire peoples. The list is presumably intended to contribute further ethnological and geographical information. To the extent that the peoples can be clearly identified, they belong in a wider sense to the political or geographical sphere of Egypt. It should be noted that, with the Philistines, another enemy of Israel is counted among the descendants of Ham.

The Sons of Mizraim/Egypt (vv. 13–14; non-P/R)

The Ludites (לִּיּוּדִים) are mentioned in Jer 46:9 and Ezek 30:5 together with Cush and Put, which points to Egypt. However, it is difficult to determine the relationship

⁶³ Westermann, 516.

to Lud (לוד), counted among the sons of Shem in v. 22. If one does not want to reckon with two different entities, then the Ludites are the inhabitants of Lud, which should still most likely be identified with the Lydia of Asia Minor. The connection to Egypt could be in how Lydian mercenaries are attested in Egyptian sources as early as the seventh century BCE. The Anamites (עַנְמִיּוֹת) are an ethnic group that has yet to be identified.⁶⁴ If the Lehabites (לֶהָבִיּוֹת) are to be equated with the Lubim (לִיבִיּוֹת; Nah 3:9; Dan 11:43; 2 Chr 12:3; 16:8), then they would be the Libyans. However, the distinction from Put, who is mentioned as a son of Ham in v. 6, remains unclear. The Naphtuhites (נַפְתֻּחִיּוֹת) are usually located in the Nile Delta or in Lower Egypt more generally. A connection with the Egyptian *n' ptah* (“people of Ptah”) or *n(w)t ptah* (“city of Ptah”) is also conceivable.⁶⁵ The Pathrusites (פְּתֻרְסִיּוֹת) are the inhabitants of Upper Egypt, often referred to as “Patros” (see Isa 11:11; Jer 44:1, 15; Ezek 29:14; 30:14), which is differentiated from Mizraim/Egypt as its own part of the country.⁶⁶ For the otherwise unattested Casluhites (כַּסְלֻחִיּוֹת), no convincing identification has yet been proposed.⁶⁷ Tg. Ps.-J. thinks of the inhabitants of the Pentapolis of Cyrenaica, a region in eastern Libya. This sounds plausible geographically but is a result of contextualized speculation. The Caphtorites (כַּפְתֻּרִיּוֹת) are the inhabitants of the island of Crete (כַּפְתֹּר; Deut 2:23; Jer 47:4; Amos 9:7). According to Amos 9:7 and Jer 47:4, Crete is the original home of the Philistines. The note attached to the Casluhites, “whence came the Philistines,” may therefore be an informed gloss on the Caphtorites that slipped into the wrong place. The gloss also sought to make mention of the Philistines, who are known especially from the narratives in the books of Judges and Samuel as rather dangerous enemies of Israel.⁶⁸

10:15–19

- 15** *And Canaan fathered Sidon, his firstborn, and Heth*
16 *and the Jebusite and the Amorite and the Girgashite*
17 *and the Hivite and the Arkite and the Sinite*
18 *and the Arvadite and the Zemarite and the Hamathite. But later, the*
clans of the Canaanites scattered themselves.
19 *And the territory of the Canaanites reached from Sidon, towards Gerar,*
as far as Gaza, towards Sodom and Gomorrah and Admah and Zeboiim,
as far as Lasha.

The section about the sons of Canaan is another genealogical notice that is a later addition, formulated according to the pattern “PN fathered PN” (יִלְדָּ *אֶת). The first two sons are individuals (v. 15; “secondary toponyms”), while in what follows, peoples are listed as descendants (vv. 16–17). Following this

⁶⁴ On the futile attempts to identify it, see Hess, 1992^a.

⁶⁵ See Görg, 1995.

⁶⁶ See Görg, 2001.

⁶⁷ See Hess, 1992^b.

⁶⁸ For a different view, see Rendsburg, 1987, who sees a twofold migration of the Philistines to Palestine from the Nile Delta (Casluhites: Gen 10:14) und via Crete (Amos 9:7).

is the transition from the fictive ancestor Canaan to the Canaanites (v. 18b: “clans of the Canaanites”), which is then followed in v. 19 by a geographical description of the Canaanites’ settlement area. The stylistic and functional diversity is best explained by the fact that it takes up various other material. Thus, the enumeration of the Jebusites, Amorites, Girgashites, and Hivites is evocative of the Deuteronomic lists of the former inhabitants of the land promised to Israel by Yhwh (Deut 7:1; Josh 3:10; 24:11). However, there, the Hittites (Heth) and the Canaanites are included in the list of the former inhabitants of the land, while here, they are placed before the other peoples genealogically and appear as individuals. This could be an indication that the mention of Canaan and Heth prompted the inclusion of the typical list of the former inhabitants at this point. The Arkites, Sinites, Arvadites, Zemarites, and Hamathites, on the other hand, never appear in the Deuteronomic lists. They are all demonyms of northern Phoenician cities and the Middle Syrian city of Hamath on the Orontes, which suggests a corresponding list of trading partners. However, since such lists generally give toponyms (so Ezek 27), it appears that the toponyms were changed into demonyms like the peoples mentioned previously. The peoples of the Phoenician and Syrian city-states are assigned to Sidon, the ancestor of the Phoenician trading city of the same name, while the former inhabitants of the land are assigned to Heth, the ancestor of the Hittites whom the Hebrew Bible likewise lists among the former inhabitants. The fact that Sidon is explicitly named as the firstborn is probably an indication that the authors gave the Phoenicians preference over the peoples who, according to the Hebrew Bible picture, compete with Israel for the land.⁶⁹ Verse 19 outlines the territory of the Canaanites via a series of toponyms, with Sidon, mentioned first, taking the name of Canaan’s firstborn son. The first three toponyms follow the Mediterranean coast from southern Lebanon to the border with Egypt and delineate the territory of the Canaanites to the west. Sodom, Gomorrah, Admah, and Zebaiim are located according to the Hebrew Bible narratives (Gen 14; 19) in the Jordan Valley, in the area of the Dead Sea. They mark the southern and eastern borders. Lasha is mentioned last and is the only mention of such in the Hebrew Bible. Since the description of the western border runs from north (Sidon) to south (Gaza), a course from south (Sodom) to north (Lasha) can be presumed for the eastern border, so that Lasha, together with Sidon, marks the northern border.

The Sons of Canaan (vv. 15–18; non-P/R):

Sidon (צִידוֹן) lies north of Tyre in modern-day Lebanon. According to v. 19, this major Phoenician trading city marks the northern border of the territory of the Canaanites.

⁶⁹ Seebaß, 261.

Heth (חֶת) is the ancestor of the Hittites. Historically, the Hittites were first associated with the Hittite Empire, which in the second millennium BCE expanded from Anatolia to Syria, where the name survived the fall of the empire. Thus, Neo-Assyrian sources initially referred to the former domain of the Hittites in Syria as the “land of *Hatti*.” After the conquest of the Late Hittite states in the eighth century BCE, the term expanded to include all of Syria-Palestine. In accordance with this expansion of the term, the Hebrew Bible counts the Hittites among the former inhabitants of the land, which does not exclude the possibility that some texts locate them in northern Syria. If the list of peoples in Gen 10:16–18 is a later addition, then “Heth” in Gen 10:15 originally represented only the land’s former inhabitants. The closest parallel to this is Josh 1:4, a very late insertion referring to the promised land as “all the land of the Hittites.”

The Jebusites (יְבוּסִי) are, in the Hebrew Bible understanding, the (former) inhabitants of Jerusalem and its environs (Josh 15:63; 18:16; 2 Sam 5:6).

The Amorites (אַמֹּרִי) serve in Deuteronomistic literature as a collective term for the former inhabitants of the promised land. They are modeled in this regard after the *Amurru* attested in Neo-Assyrian texts. If, in the second millennium BCE, the expression designated the “western lands” in northern Syria from the Mesopotamian perspective and, later, also the political entity in this region, then in the eighth century BCE, it became a code for the “westerners” as far as the Negev and is basically interchangeable with *Hatti*.

The Gergashites (גֵּרְגָּשִׁי) and the Hivites (חִי) are not attested outside of the Hebrew Bible. If they are not imaginary names, which sound unknown and ancient and thus emphasize the diversity among the former inhabitants of the land, then they would conceivably be the inhabitants of limited regions in Palestine, although this cannot be specified any further.

The Arkites (עֲרֻקִי) are the inhabitants of the city of *Arqā*, modern *Tell 'Arqa*, which is attested in cuneiform texts and lies north of Tripoli in modern-day Lebanon.

The Sinites (סִינִי) are the inhabitants of a *Šianu* in modern-day Syria attested in cuneiform texts, whose prince is listed in Assyrian sources as a member of an anti-Assyrian coalition alongside, among others, Ahab of Israel and the rulers of Arwad, Hamath, and *Arqā* for the Battle of Qarqar on the Orontes (853 BCE).

The Arvadites (אַרְוָדִי) are the inhabitants of the Phoenician island and port city of Arwad in modern-day Syria.

The Zemarites (זִמְרִי) are the inhabitants of the city of *Šimirra* between Arwad and Tripoli attested in cuneiform texts.

The Hamathites (חֲמַתִּי) are the inhabitants of the city of Hamath (Heb. חֲמַת), lying on the Orontes in modern-day Syria, which was the capital of an Aramean principality.

The Territory of the Canaanites (v. 19; non-P/R):

Gerar (גֵּרָר) is mentioned multiple times in the Hebrew Bible. Verse 19 connects Gerar with Gaza, with the syntactically difficult phrase “towards” (בְּאַחֲרָה; lit. “your coming”) suggesting a location in the southern hinterlands of Gaza. According to Gen 20:1, Gerar lies in the northwestern Negev and, according to Gen 26, is one of the territories claimed by the Philistines, although this was disputed. Gaza (עֲזָה), in the area of the modern city of the same name, lies on the route to Egypt and was the first city reached from there in Palestine. The city was the administrative seat of the Egyptian province of Canaan from the fifteenth to twelfth centuries BCE.

Sodom (סְדֹמָה), Gomorrah (עֲמֹרָה), Admah (אֲדָמָה) und Zeboiim (צִבְיִים) are, alongside the city of Zoar not mentioned here, the cities that, according to Gen 14 (a quite recent chapter), were attacked by four kings from Mesopotamia. This story, which paints Abraham as a patriarch more powerful in every respect than even the mightiest of his day, is no more historical than the story about the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah in Gen 18–19. The few topographical references in the texts indicate that the cities were imagined to be in the Jordan Valley. Early Bronze Age sites on the southeastern coast of the Dead Sea whose remains were still visible in the first millennium BCE may have been the impetus for the (etiological) legend of the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah and the entire region southeast of the Dead Sea. Its mention in the description of the borders in v. 19 is the result of scribal geography that connects the Canaanites in passing with Sodom and Gomorrah, the symbol of sin and divine judgment.

Lasha (לָשָׁא) possibly marks the northern border of Canaan. In this case, it may be a secondary form of “Laish”/“Leshem” and would be identified with Dan/Tell el-Qādī at the source of the Jordan River.

The list of the sons of Ham has experienced the most extensive additions in the Table of Nations. It must remain open whether or not the additions in Gen 10:8–12, 13–15, 16–19 were the product of a single hand. The differences in form speak quite against this. For Gen 10:9b, 16–18, it is still worth entertaining the idea that the additions themselves underwent further editing. Whatever the case may be, all additions share in the degradation of Ham and his descendants rooted in the story of Noah and his sons.

10:21–31

- 21 *And also to Shem, the father of all the sons of Eber, the older brother of Japheth, [children] were born.*
- 22 *The sons of Shem: Elam and Assur and Arpachshad and Lud and Aram.*
- 23 *And the sons of Aram: Uz and Hul and Gether and Mash.*
- 24 *And Arpachshad fathered Shelah, and Shelah fathered Eber.*
- 25 *And to Eber, two sons were born. The name of the one was Peleg, for in his time, humanity was scattered, and the name of his brother was Joktan.*
- 26 *And Joktan fathered Almodad and Sheleph and Hazarmaveth and Jerah*
- 27 *and Hadoram and Uzal and Diklah*
- 28 *and Obal and Abimael and Sheba*
- 29 *and Ophir and Havilah and Jobab. All these are the sons of Joktan.*
- 30 *And the territory in which they lived reached from Mesha, towards Sephar, as far as the eastern mountains.*
- 31 *These are the sons of Shem according to their clans, according to their languages, in their lands, according to their nations.*

Shem (for explanation of the name, see on Gen 5:32 above) has five sons. Further sons are mentioned for two, Aram and Arpachshad, and for Arpachshad also grandchildren, great-grandchildren, and great-great-grandchildren. The Priestly Writing only mentions the sons of Aram in the Table of Nations, while the descendants of Arpachshad follow only in the genealogy of Shem in Gen 11:10–26 (their mention in the Table of Nations comes from the Redaction; see below). The summarizing conclusion in v. 31 corresponds to its parallels with Japheth and Ham in vv. 5, 20. In the Priestly Table of Nations, the sons of Shem are eponyms for people groups who are surrounded by the sons of Japheth and Ham and come from the region of Syria-Mesopotamia.

The Sons of Shem (v. 22; P):

Elam (עֵלָם) is the ancient name of a region and political entity east of Babylonia and on the northeastern coast of the Persian Gulf, with the city of Susa as its center. Elam reached the height of its power in the second millennium BCE. The Hebrew Bible appears to be limited to unclear conceptions of Elam. Here, it represents the easternmost of the powers struggling for dominance in Mesopotamia and, thus, the ancient Near East. Elamite cannot be associated with any known language and, in any case, is not a “Semitic” language.

Assur (אַשּׁוּר) does not, in the Hebrew Bible, with the possible exception of Gen 2:14, refer to the city of the same name but always the heartland of the Assyrian empire in modern-day northern Iraq. Unlike in the Nimrod narrative, which is a later addition, Assur is used here as a secondary toponym designating the ancestor of Assyria.

Arpachshad (אַרְפַּכְשָׁד) is, according to Gen 11:11, the firstborn son of Shem and the ancestor of Terah and Abraham. The fact that Arpachshad appears third in the Table of Nations is due to the geographic arrangement of the sons of Shem, although the ordering principle is not entirely clear because of the uncertainties around identifying Lud and the vastness of the territory settled by the Arameans. The meaning and origin of the name is debated. It is probably another secondary toponym alongside Elam, Assur, Lud (?), and Aram. The second half of the word seems to be clearly connected with the demonym *Kašdīm* “Chaldean” (see Josephus, *A.J.* 1.144; Jub. 9:4). The first part could be explained with a root *אַרַף whence the Arabic *ʾurfa* “border” comes. The name would then mean “border/territory of the Chaldeans.”⁷⁰ Speaking in favor of this meaning is how the territory of the Chaldeans is considered to be Abraham’s homeland (Gen 11:28). In the context of the Table of Nations, it could be a coded name for Babylon, whom the Priestly Writing wanted to avoid naming among the direct ancestors of Abraham given the consistently negative image of the city in the Hebrew Bible.⁷¹

The mention of Lud (לֹדִי) is difficult in the context of the sons of Shem, who are otherwise located in Mesopotamia and Syria, since Lud is most likely the Lydia of Asia Minor, whose mention would be expected among the sons of Japheth instead (see above, pg. 372 on Magog in v. 2 and pg. 385f. on v. 13).

⁷⁰ See Simons, 1959, § 24.

⁷¹ Seebaß, 263.

Aram (אַרַם) is a group of peoples who first appear in inscriptions at the end of the second millennium BCE and who succeeded the Hittites in northern Syria, spreading southward as far as the Sea of Galilee from the tenth and ninth centuries BCE. Of the small Aramean states, Aram-Damascus long competed fiercely with Israel militarily. The religious center of the Arameans was Haran, located in northwestern Mesopotamia and mentioned repeatedly in the Abraham story (see Gen 11:26–28). The spread of the Arameans into the region of Mesopotamia is reflected in the Hebrew Bible by the designation “Aram Naharaim” (אַרַם נַהֲרַיִם), or “Aram of the Two Rivers,” as a name for Mesopotamia (Gen 24:10; Deut 23:5; Judg 3:8; Ps 60:2; 1 Chr 19:6).

The Sons of Aram (v. 23; P):

Uz (עוֹץ) is the name of a region presumably in northwestern Arabia (Jer 25:20; Job 1:1; Lam 4:21) that the Hebrew Bible connects with either Aram (Gen 10:23; 22:21) or Edom (Gen 36:28: “These are the sons of Dishan: Uz and Aran [!]”).

Hul (חֻל) is attested only here and in 1 Chr 1:17. This unknown toponym or personal name is identified by Josephus with the Armenians (Josephus, *A.J.* 1.145).

Gether (גֶּתֶר) is also a toponym or personal name attested only here and in 1 Chr 1:17, and it is otherwise unknown. Josephus understands it as Bactria, north of Hindu Kush (Josephus, *A.J.* 1.145), which was part of the Achaemenid and later Seleucid dominions. Like the identification of Hul with Armenia, this hardly fits with Aram but could possibly be related to the reading from the so-called “War Scroll” from Qumran. It reads “Togar” (תוֹגַר) instead of Gether; this could have been caused by a simple interchanging of letters or may have been based on the equation with the Tocharians mentioned by classical authors who, according to the geographer Strabo, took part in the conquest of the Greco-Bactrian Kingdom in the second century BCE. An alternative interpretation connects Gether with Geshur (2 Sam 13f.), which would fit better with Aram.⁷²

Mash (מֶשֶׁח) is attested in the Hebrew Bible only here. The repetition of the Table of Nations in 1 Chr 1:17 lists another “Meshech,” alongside the son of Japheth of the same name (see Gen 10:2), instead of “Mash.” The LXX also assumes that the names were equivalent (Μοσχο). However, the Anatolian Meshech can hardly be connected with the Aramean-settled regions in the first millennium BCE.

10:21, 24–30

- 21** *And also to Shem, the father of all the sons of Eber, the older brother of Japheth, [children] were born.*
- 24** *And Arpachshad fathered Shelah, and Shelah fathered Eber.*
- 25** *And to Eber, two sons were born. The name of the one was Peleg, for in his time, humanity was scattered, and the name of his brother was Joktan.*

⁷² See Schücking-Jungblut, 2017.

- 26** *And Joktan fathered Almodad and Sheleph and Hazarmaveth and Jerah*
27 *and Hadoram and Uzal and Diklah*
28 *and Obal and Abimael and Sheba*
29 *and Ophir and Havilah and Jobab. All these are the sons of Joktan.*
30 *And the territory in which they lived reached from Mesha, towards*
 Sephar, as far as the eastern mountains.

The genealogical notice about the descendants of Arpachshad, formulated as verbal phrases following the pattern “P.N. fathered P.N.” (יָלַד *אָת), comes from a post-Priestly addition. Unlike the names of the other descendants of Shem, Ham, and Japheth (with the exception of Nimrod), the names Shelah, Eber, Peleg (for the meaning of the name, see on Gen 11:12–17 below), and Joktan are quite probably real personal names that are also (with the exception of Joktan) presented in this order in the Priestly genealogy of Shem in Gen 11:10–26. The reason for the duplication is elucidated through the explanation of Peleg (פֶּלֶג) as an etymologizing wordplay “for in his time, humanity was scattered (*פֶּלַג ni.)” in v. 25. It has no counterpart in Gen 11:10–26 and prepares for the unfolding of the nations coming into being (Gen 10:32b [P]) through the Tower of Babel narrative (Gen 11:1–9 [non-P]). For this reason, the foreshadowing ends with Peleg and the generation during which the wordplay and etymology locates the events reported in Gen 11:1–9. Moreover, the most important line of the descendants of Shem would probably also need to be mentioned in the Table of Nations, since this is separated in the present literary context from its original continuation with the genealogy of Shem in Gen 11:10–26.

The introduction to the sons of Shem in v. 21 points in the same direction and was added later to the Priestly heading. It was formulated from the outset with v. 22 in mind, as is already evident from the lack of a subject for “were born” (*יָלַד q. pass.). As the quite similar formulation in Gen 4:26 shows (“And a son was also born to Seth”; see also 10:25), v. 21 presupposes the conceptual addition of “sons” in v. 22.⁷³ The reason for the doubling, which seems awkward at first glance, is the notice in v. 21 of Shem being the father of all the sons of Eber. According to Gen 10:24, Shem is the great-grandfather of Eber and thus the great-great-grandfather of Eber’s sons. Therefore, “father” in v. 21 needs to be understood as the “progenitor” of the descendants of Eber. His line among the sons of Shem is afforded such prominence from the outset because Eber (עֶבֶר), in contrast to Gen 11:14, is understood as the ancestor of the Hebrews (עִבְרִיִּים), the designation of the Israelites for and by strangers.⁷⁴ The following clarification in v. 21 that

⁷³ The use of יָלַד q. pass. without a subject is found only here. See Skinner, 218f.

⁷⁴ Jacob, 290.

Shem is the older brother of Japheth could be related to the later polemic that Jewish culture is older than that of the Greeks. A mention of the middle brother, Ham, is unnecessary at this point, since according to Gen 9:18–29 he is “out of the picture” anyway.

The list of the thirteen sons of Peleg’s “little” (Heb. קֵטָן) brother Joktan (קֵטָן; possibly from a root *קטן “to be small”)⁷⁵ presupposes the addition about the sons of Arpachshad, and it may be an even more recent insertion. Insofar as the names can be identified geographically, they point to the region of southern Arabia. The summarizing notice about their home regions in v. 30, on the other hand, is of no further assistance. Identifications of the toponyms in v. 30 are uncertain throughout, and the possibilities considered here are solely due to the attempt to locate them within the area of the Arabian Peninsula: The toponym “Mesha” (מֶשָׁא) appears in the Hebrew Bible only here. A conceivable connection is a port city on the southern Arabian coast of the Red Sea called Μουσᾶ by Ptolemy (*Geogr.* 8.22, 6) and Muza by Pliny the Elder (*Nat.* 6.104). The location of Sephar (סֶפָר) is unclear. The reference to “the eastern mountains” (הַר הַקְּדָם) is too general to be of any help in locating it. Nevertheless, according to Gen 25:6, the sons of Abraham and his concubines, including the sons of Keturah (see on v. 7b above, under “Sheba”), settle in Arabia, called אֶרֶץ קֶדֶם “the east country.”

The Sons of Joktan (vv. 26–29; non-P/R):

Almodad (אַלְמוֹדָד) is mentioned elsewhere only in 1 Chr 1:20. Should the transliteration of the name in the LXX be followed (Ελμωδαδ), it would mean “God is [a/my] friend.” The Masoretic vocalization suggests a connection with the Arabic *‘āl* “family, clan,” here the clan of *Mōdād*. Similar-sounding names of Sabaeen tribes point to the south of the Arabian Peninsula in the area of modern-day Yemen.⁷⁶

Sheleph (שֶׁלֶף) is also mentioned elsewhere only in 1 Chr 1:20 and is associated with South Arabian tribal names such as *Sulaf*, *Salif*, *Silf*, and the like.⁷⁷

Hazarmaveth (הַצִּרְמָוֶת) is, alongside Sheba, one of the few names among the sons of Joktan that can be identified with certainty. It is to be identified with the South Arabian kingdom of *Hadramaut*, and its capital *Ṣabwa*. *Hadramaut* gained economic and political significance through its control of the regions where incense was grown and as the starting point of the Incense Route.

Jerah (יֶרָח) is attested as a tribal name or toponym only here and in 1 Chr 1:20. A Sabaeen inscription from the seventh century BCE mentions a place *wṛḥn*, which

⁷⁵ The more commonly made connection with *el-qahṭān*, the Arabic designation for the inhabitants of the southern part of the Arabian Peninsula, is fitting but difficult to justify. See Simons, 1959, §136. The note about Joktan being considered by Arab authors to be the progenitor of “true Arabs” means little, since it is part of the history of the biblical text only after its composition: “In the century and a half after Muhammed’s death, Muslim scholars worked out entire genealogies of the Arab tribes and connected them with the genealogies of the Bible” (Watt/Welch, 1980, 124 [translation JWR]).

⁷⁶ See Müller, 1992^a.

⁷⁷ Dillmann, 198f.

may be equivalent to the later *Warāḥ* in the southwest of modern-day Yemen. The Hebrew form of the tribal name is identical to the word for “moon, month” (יָרֵחַ), and its background may be in the great significance of the moon god of the Old South Arabian pantheon.⁷⁸

Hadoram (הָדוֹרָם) should probably be identified with the *dwr̥m* mentioned in Sabaeen inscriptions, *Dauram*, which lies northwest of *Ṣanʿāʿ*, the capital of modern-day Yemen. The Hebrew form of the name probably comes from an adaption of the homonymous personal name (see 1 Chr 18:10; 2 Chr 10:18).⁷⁹

Uzal (אֻזַּל) is, outside of the Table of Nations and its repetition in 1 Chr 1:21, also attested in the list of trading partners of Tyre in Ezek 27:19. According to Arab tradition, *ʿUzāl* is the pre-Islamic name for *Ṣanʿāʿ*, the capital of modern-day Yemen.

Diklah (דִּקְלָה) is mentioned only here and in 1 Chr 1:21. Generally, the name has been explained in connection with the Syrian *deqlā*, the Mishnaic Hebrew דִּקְלָה, and the Mandaean *diqla* “date (palm)” and interpreted as the name for a palm-rich area in South Arabia. The exact location is unknown.

Obal (עֹבָל) is attested in the Hebrew Bible only here (and the name is missing in the LXX). Conceivably, the place could be connected with the South Arabian *ʿUḇāl* between *Hudayda* and *Ṣanʿāʿ* and the tribe *Banū ʿUḇāl*, both of which point to the area of modern-day Yemen. The spelling עֹבָל in 1 Chr 1:22, like the עֵיבָל of the SP, may have been inspired by the Edomite personal name mentioned in Gen 36:23; 1 Chr 1:40 or the homonymous name of the mountain near Shechem.⁸⁰

Abimael (אַבִּימֶלֶךְ) is attested only here and in 1 Chr 1:22. No satisfactory identification has yet been made. The construction of the name can be explained as “(My) Father is God” (אב “father” + encl. part. מֶלֶךְ + אל “God”).

Sheba (שֶׁבָּא), like Havilah (חָוִילָה), is listed in v. 7 (P) among the sons of Ham (for a location, see there and on Gen 2:10–14). For Havilah, the two different genealogical classifications may be explainable by how Havilah should be located on the two opposite coasts of the Red Sea, so that it can be split into an African (Ham) and an Arab (Joktan) Havilah. The mention of Sheba would have then been prompted by the other names pointing to the region of South Arabia. Where Ophir is mentioned, the legendary Sheba must follow.

Ophir (אֹפִיר) is, in the Hebrew Bible representation, the homeland of the most expensive of trade goods, such as exotic animals, precious woods and stones, and gold (1 Kgs 10:11, 22). They were transported by sea to Ezion-Geber on the northern end of the Gulf of *ʿAqaba*, which supports, like the genealogical connection with the kingdom of the Sabaeans, an (approximate) location in southwestern Arabia or on the Horn of Africa. If Ophir was primarily a trade center for goods coming from East Africa and South Arabia, not all of the products mentioned need have come from there – with the exception of gold, since Ophir is also a quality designation for a particular kind of gold (Ps 45:10; 1 Chr 29:4; *HAe* 1.229f.).

Jobab (יֹבָב) is attested as a toponym or tribal name only here and in 1 Chr 1:23. Additionally, Jobab can also be found as the name of a king of Edom (Gen 36:33f.), a Canaanite king of Madon (Josh 11:1), and a Benjaminite clan in Moab (1 Chr 8:9). Like the other “sons of Joktan,” the Jobab in Gen 10:29 is probably a South Arabian tribe. The name may come from a root *יבב or *יבב “to shout”: “The god D.N. triumphs.”

⁷⁸ See Müller, 1992^c.

⁷⁹ See Müller, 1992^b.

⁸⁰ See Müller, 1992^d.

10:32

These are the clans of the sons of Noah, according to their generations in their nations, and from them, all the nations on the earth branched out after the Flood.

With the colophonic conclusion to the Table of Nations, the Priestly Writing harkens back to the heading in v. 1 and the intervening closings to Japheth, Ham, and Shem in vv. 5, 20, 31. The phrase “according to their generations/*toledot*” highlights how they are each unfolded in their own segments (see also Exod 6:19).⁸¹ Another reference to the Flood (also in v. 1) emphasizes that the Table of Nations marks a caesura in the Priestly Primeval History and in the present text. After the world of nations emerges, the account increasingly focuses on the history leading through Abraham to Israel. In the Priestly Writing, the genealogy of the descendants of Shem follows. In the final form of the Primeval History, the story of the Tower of Babel is included as a narrative telling of the dispersion of the peoples.

⁸¹ See Hieke, 2003, 30.

THE TOWER OF BABEL

- 11:1** Once, all humanity had one language and all the same words.
2 And it came to pass as they set out eastward that they found a plain in the land of Shinar and settled there.
3 And they said, one to their neighbor: “Come, let us form bricks and fire them.” And the brick served them as stone and bitumen served them as mortar.
4 Then, they said, “Come, let us build ourselves a city and a tower whose top is in the heavens, and let us make a name for ourselves, lest we be scattered over the entire earth!”
5 Then, Yhwh came down to see the city and the tower that the Sons of Man had built.
6 And Yhwh said, “See! One people and one language for them all. And this is [only] the beginning of their acting. But now, nothing will be impossible for them from whatever they intend to do.
7 Come, let us go down and confuse their language there, so that no one understands the language of their neighbor!”
8 Then Yhwh scattered them from there over the entire earth, and they thus stopped building the city.
9 Therefore, its name was called “Babel,” because there Yhwh jumbled the language of all humanity. And from there, Yhwh scattered them over the entire earth.

Analysis: The entire section comes from the Redaction.

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TEXT-CRITICAL AND PHILOLOGICAL NOTES

11:1 וַיְהִי (Once, [it] had): The LXX does not translate the introductory וַיְהִי with the usual καὶ ἐγένετο “and it came to pass” but instead understands it, like the majority of modern Bible translations, as the predicate to כָּל־הָאָרֶץ, with the masc. וַיְהִי referring either to the masc. כָּל (so Uehlinger 1990, 33) or to the fem. הָאָרֶץ (so Jacob, 297): καὶ ἥν πᾶσα ἡ γῆ χεῖλος ἔν “and all the world had/was of one tongue.” However, it is more likely an opening that characterizes what follows as happening in the past. See Skinner, 224.

הָאָרֶץ (humanity): Literally “world.” Tg. Neof. reads here and in v. 9aβ (there also Tg. Ps.-J.) a clarifying “all the inhabitants of the earth,” while the MT provides the original reading, carefully distinguishing between כָּל־הָאָרֶץ “all the world” = “all humanity” (see vv. 1, 9aβ) and כָּל־הָאָרֶץ עַל־פָּנֶי “the whole earth” = “the inhabited earth” (see vv. 4b, 8a, 9b).

אֵת (same): “Like adjectives, the cardinal numbers 1 and 2 agree with whatever is being counted.” HS §83a [translation JWR].

דְּבָרֵיהֶם (words): The LXX adds “to them all,” corresponding to Yhwh’s speech in v. 6.

11:2 מִקְדָּם (eastward): The preposition מִן, like in Gen 13:11 (“then Lot set off eastward”; see Gen 3:24; Zech 14:4; Jon 4:5) indicates the direction

of travel. See, e.g., Tuch, 273; Dillmann, 205; Holzinger, 110; Jacob, 297; Witte, 1998, 92 and fn. 59. However, most interpretations follow the ancient versions (besides Jub. 10:19) and translate it as “from the east.”

אֶרֶץ שִׁנְעָר (*the land of Shinar*): Instead of the very well-attested “land of Shinar,” Tg. Onq., Tg. Ps.-J., and Tg. Neof. read “in the land of Babel” in anticipation of the name etiology in v. 9.

11:5 **אֲשֶׁר בָּנוּ בְנֵי הָאָדָם** (*that the Sons of Man had built*): This relative clause is generally translated as “that the Sons of Man built.” However, the sequence of the relative pronoun (אֲשֶׁר) and the verb in *qatal* (בָּנוּ) describes an action that has already been completed (see *GKC* § 106f.). The difficulty lies in how v. 8 seems to assume that the construction had not yet been completed. A typical explanation was offered by Dillmann, 206 [translation JWR]: “in order to inspect the work, meaning, to the extent that the Sons of Man had built it (it had not yet been finished; v. 8).” Another solution was proposed by Vanderhooft, 2020, 44–49, according to which v. 5 refers to the tower, which is already completed, and which is found in the city, which is still under construction; Yhwh subsequently prevents the completion of the city (v. 8), and the tower ceases to be of any practical use. Accordingly, this would be why v. 8 mentions only the city.

11:8 **הָעִיר** (*the city*): The LXX and the SP provide a harmonizing reading with v. 5 (see also v. 4) and add the tower in addition to the *nota accusativi*. The MT reading (also Tg. Onq.; Tg. Ps.-J.; Tg. Neof., and Vulg) should be preferred since it is better attested, shorter, and more difficult in its context.

ESSENTIALS AND PERSPECTIVES

The Tower of Babel is, next to the Temple of Solomon, perhaps the most famous example of architecture in the Hebrew Bible. The image of a tower reaching to the heavens has been deeply inscribed into cultural memory. The tower has become a popular subject of visual art, the most famous work undoubtedly being Pieter Bruegel the Elder’s transfer of the tower into the 16th-century Netherlands (1563). In light of its impact and consequences, it is easy to overlook how there is little mention of the tower in Gen 11:1–9, and even then, only incidentally. The tower is mentioned twice and only in connection with the city. Humanity, living in a mythical unity, decides to build both “tower and city” to protect themselves from being scattered all over the world. Yet, the building project fails, as is explicitly stated (only) for the city. It is implicitly assumed that the people also stop work on the tower, but this is not actually mentioned. Nothing is said about the destruction of

the tower, although this is often read into the text. The tower and its fate are obviously not the focus of the narrative; it is merely a particularly symbolic motif.

The Tower of Babel narrative is a relatively independent, self-contained unit. The conclusion of the preceding *toledot* of the sons of Noah (Gen 10:31f.) and the opening of the following *toledot* of Shem (Gen 11:10) each explicitly mention the Flood as a historical reference point. This creates the impression of a chronological *déjà vu* that removes the Tower narrative from the chronological and generational sequence of the preceding and subsequent genealogies of humanity after the Flood. The Tower narrative thus stands at a peculiar remove from the temporal structure of its context as well as from its narrative sequence. This allowed for the narrator to unfold both the cause and the exact circumstances of the diversification and spread of peoples and languages (see Gen 10:20, 31), first mentioned in Gen 9:19 and then established in the Table of Nations in Gen 10.¹ Hence, although the Tower of Babel narrative itself is not part of the Priestly texts of the Primeval History, it is closely connected to the Priestly Table of Nations in the present state of the text.

What is indicated by the positioning of the narrative within its primeval context is also confirmed in its details: The focus of the narrative is humanity's evolution from living in one place and speaking one language to no longer understanding each other and being scattered throughout the world. Thus, the narrative ends with an etiological notice that associates the name of the city with the intermingling of language while at the same time identifying the city as the starting point for the dispersal of humankind (Gen 11:9). In contrast, the Tower of Babel itself is a subordinate motif. The people undertake its construction in order to preserve their unity, which they fear losing. However, interpretations have repeatedly emphasized throughout history that the arrogant human aspiration for self-glory is behind the plan to build a structure that reaches to the heavens. The cavalier tone should not be underestimated; nevertheless, it should be noted that the building of the tower is subordinated to the people's attempt at avoiding dispersal. It is only God's reaction to the construction that draws attention to the fact that humanity, with their present project, presumes to challenge the distance between them and God (Gen 11:6; cf. Job 42:2). This occurs unintentionally and out of an existential fear. Thus, the narrative again gives the impression that God is primarily concerned with preserving the boundary between the divine and human spheres. The tower is a symbol of humanity's ability and inclination to transgress boundaries and God's efforts to put a stop to it.

¹ So already Tuch, 266; Dillmann, 202.

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION I: INTRODUCTION TO EXEGESIS

Structure: The exposition in v. 1 concisely communicates the background information that is needed in order to understand the narrative but cannot be deduced from its context. The narrative begins in earnest with v. 2, and it concludes in v. 9 with an etiology recounting, in reverse order, the motifs from the exposition and the beginning of the narrative. The events are located on the Plain of Shinar, which is identified as Babel (Babylon). The justification for the naming of the city takes up the theme from the exposition of all humanity having one language (v. 9a); at the same time, it announces the reversal of the initial situation through the events described (v. 9b). There is a notable bipartite division within this framework, with vv. (2) 3–4 being guided by human action and speech and vv. 6–8 by the speech and action of Yhwh. The transition comes in v. 5, which for the first time reports of Yhwh's action and explicitly places it in a context alongside the action of the humans. There are numerous internal cross-references identifiable within this basic structure. This has often been interpreted as indicating a concentric structure, but none of the various models are able to cover the entire text.² It therefore seems more appropriate to speak of parallels without any strict concentricity:³

1. Establishment of humanity's one language (v. 1) and the loss thereof (v. 9aβ)
2. "[they] settled there" (v. 2b) – "from there, Yhwh scattered them" (v. 9b)
3. "they said, one to their neighbor" (v. 3a) – "so that no one understands the language of their neighbor" (v. 7b)
4. The people's decision to make building materials (v. 3a), formulated with הָבָה "Come!" and the cohortative plural, being taken up in the wording of the decision to build the city and the tower (v. 4)
5. The decision to build city and tower (v. 4) then having its counterpart in the decision by Yhwh to intervene in what is happening (v. 7a), also formulated with הָבָה "Come!" and the cohortative plural
6. The decisions by humanity and Yhwh each being accompanied by a declaration of their intent (v. 4b and v. 7b)
7. The people's plan for the top of the tower to reach to the heavens (v. 4a) corresponding with the notice of Yhwh coming down to see the structure (v. 5a)
8. The counterpart of humanity's objective not to be scattered (v. 4b) being the report of Yhwh scattering them (v. 8a)

² See esp. Kikaweda, 1974 and recently Arneth, 2007, 221, as well as the presentation and critique in Uehlinger, 1990, 296–301.

³ Seebaß, 274.

The fact that the parallel structure does not seem schematic is due to an interesting unevenness in the relationship of the announcements and the descriptions of actions. On the one hand, of the actions that are announced in a speech, none are actually described as they happen. On the other hand, each action that is actually described lacks a corresponding announcement. The execution of the announced actions is obviously assumed without being specifically noted and without causing irritations when reading. In this way, the narrative becomes denser, revealing a linguistic artistry that goes beyond mere symmetry.

Formation: Despite its elaborate structure and linguistic artistry, the literary unity of the Tower of Babel narrative has repeatedly been put to question. This has led to quite different reconstructions of its origins.⁴ The stumbling block has been how the jumbling of languages and the dispersal of the peoples, with their respective etiologies, stand side-by-side in v. 9a and v. 9b. This was initially interpreted as an indication that a narrative about the city and a separate narrative about the tower were combined only secondarily.⁵ However, since neither of the two reconstructed versions offer a coherent text, the source-critical explanation does not withstand criticism. Instead, it is widely assumed that a base layer has been reworked,⁶ with the dispersal motif generally considered to have been added later.⁷ Presumably, both the source-critical and the redactional models are based on the estimate that a short narrative cannot possibly have two basic motifs. Yet, these motifs should not be seen as in opposition to each other: If v. 8a (the dispersal motif) is written off as redactional, then any account of Yhwh's action is missing in the Tower narrative. If v. 7b (the jumbling of languages) is discarded, then the narrative would lack the expression of Yhwh's intentions. The latter would be conspicuous because its counterpart, the people's expression of their intentions, would still be in the text (v. 4b; dispersal motif!). Furthermore, the textual observations mentioned above cannot bear the weight of the various redactional theses, which are addressed individually in the commentary below. The fact that there are two basic motifs recognizable

⁴ For detailed discussion, see Gertz, 2009^b, 18–24, and further van der Kooij, 2006, 1–7.

⁵ Gunkel, 94–99: The city narrative with the speech-jumbling at Babel in vv. 1, 3a, 4a₁ [until “city”], 4b, 5 [only “city”], 6a₁, 7, 8b, 9a; the tower narrative with the “tower construction of Piz” (free formulation from פִּיז “to scatter” in V. 9b): vv. 2, 3b, 4a₂ [from “tower”], 4b, 5 [without “city”], 6a₂, 8a, 9b). For criticism of Gunkel, see Cassuto, 2:236; Seybold, 1976, 456–458.

⁶ See Seybold, 1976, 453–479; Uehlinger, 1990, 305–343 and *passim*; Levin, 1993, 127–132; Witte, 1998, 87–99; Kratz, 2005, 255f. For its literary unity, see Weisman, 1998, 41f.; recently also Seebaß, 274, 283f.

⁷ Cf. Levin, 1993, 127, 132; Kratz, 2005, 256, who see the speech-jumbling motif as secondary.

in the Tower narrative is in no way contested in the assumption of a literary unity. To the contrary, the author of Gen 11:1–9 combined the motifs of dispersal and language-jumbling for the sake of the narrative. The origin of the jumbling motif may possibly be found in a poem mocking Babylon that has been identified, quite optimistically, in vv. 2* [only *וַיְהִי בְּאֶרֶץ שְׁנֵעַר*], 4a, 5a, 8b (?), 9aa.⁸ However, this assumption is hardly verifiable. At best, isolating the motif allows the outlines of such a tradition to be identified.⁹ For the dispersal motif, on the other hand, it seems likely that the author of Gen 11:1–9 adopted it from the present literary context (cf. Gen 9:19; 10:31–32).

Dating: Historical classification of the Tower narrative is closely connected with the question of the formation of the biblical Primeval History. Scholars have repeatedly approached Gen 11:1–9 as the conclusion of a formerly independent non-P Primeval History.¹⁰ This assumption, however, is quite unlikely. An etiology of humanity's basic living conditions written in Judah or Israel or within the Babylonian diaspora would hardly have ended by naming the city "Babel" and with an open-ended dispersal of humanity into the world. The *Babyloniaca* of Berossos (ca. 340–270 BCE), a priest of Marduk concerned with Babylon's reputation in the Hellenistic world, has repeatedly been mentioned in reference to this. However, it actually shows how problematic it is to assume a narrative work reaching only through Gen 11:9: Berossos's final notice tells of the reconstruction of his hometown, destroyed by the Flood at the behest of the gods!¹¹ The biblical narrative lacks any such notice; instead, it is followed by the election of Abraham (Gen 12:1–3). For the Babylonian patriot Berossos, the reconstruction of Babylon marks a new beginning after the catastrophe. Conversely, for the biblical authors, the new beginning starts only with Abraham leaving Mesopotamia and the promise to him about becoming a people and taking over the land. Without this, a Judean Primeval History including the Tower narrative would lack a coherent perspective. This, at least, is a convincing aspect of Gerhard von Rad's popular thesis, according to which the goal of the Primeval History of the "Yahwist" is the call of Abraham in Gen 12:1–3.¹²

The Tower narrative was thus written for a literary work that was already aware of the connection between the Primeval History and the Ancestral History. A more precise classification is rooted in the Tower narrative's

⁸ Witte, 1998, 87–99.

⁹ See Grossmann, 2017, 372f.: "The final product is the result of intensive redaction, to the extent that the reader cannot categorically distinguish between the two layers."

¹⁰ See Carr, 1996, 235–240; Blum, 2002, 439f.

¹¹ Verbrugghe/Wickersham, 2001, 50.

¹² von Rad, 23, 154, 158–161.

cross-references to the Priestly Writing and the Primeval History of the Scholarly Narrator: The thematic references to the Scholarly Narrator's Primeval History are unmistakable. The theme addressed in the Tower narrative of the progress of human civilization (cf. v. 3f.) and the problematization thereof (v. 6) is a leitmotif throughout the genealogy of Cain's descendants and the great heroes of early human civilization. The fact that the genealogy reports the foundation of the first city, like in the Tower narrative (cf. Gen 4:17), is not contradictory within the course of the story, since the city founded in Gen 4 and all other cities probably perished in the Flood. The motif of the demarcation of the divine and the human spheres ties into the Garden narrative, which is (also) about determining humanity's relationship to God. Admittedly, the explicit cross-references refer to passages that have been labeled as secondary. Genesis 11:6 clearly takes up Gen 3:22, which is a redactional verse; the mention of בְּנֵי הָאָדָם "Sons of Man" in Gen 11:5 echoes the בָּנוֹת הָאָדָם "Daughters of Man" and the בְּנֵי הָאֱלֹהִים "Sons of the Gods" from the added episode about the union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man in Gen 6:1–4, to which there are further close thematic connections. Accordingly, the Tower narrative does not belong to the basic material of the Scholarly Narrator's Primeval History. The relationship to the Priestly Writing, however, is more difficult to determine. Here, the context is important more than anything: As a flashback about the origins and dispersal of the peoples of the world, the Tower narrative could have only been inserted as a concluding notice about the postdiluvian emergence of the various peoples (Gen 10:32 [P]) before the focus on the descendants of Shem, son of Noah (Gen 11:10 [P]).¹³ The inclusion of the presumably Priestly, but possibly even post-Priestly notice about the distribution/ancestry (נִפְצָה of נִפְצָה q., a variant form of פִּזָּן) of all humanity (כָּל-הָאָרֶץ) in Gen 9:19 within the motif of the dispersal (*פִּזָּן q.; vv. 4b, 8a, 9b) of all humanity (כָּל-הָאָרֶץ; vv. 1, 9a) is a linguistic indication of this.¹⁴ The late ("post-Priestly") classification of the text resulting from these considerations is supported by the functional similarity of Yhwh's reflection in v. 6 to Job's confession in Job 42:2. In any case, the recognizable historical references do not contradict its classification as a relatively recent text within the Hebrew Bible. The putative allusions to building measures and associated global power claims of the great Neo-Babylonian kings merely mark the *terminus post quem*. The narrative is set within Primeval History and can therefore also paradigmatically take up an event that has long since been embedded into cultural memory and in which Babylon had become frequently used as a cipher (cf. Dan 4:26f.).

¹³ See in further detail Gertz, 2009^b, 25–28; Hieke, 2003, 109f.

¹⁴ So already correctly Dillmann, 202, contra Budde, 1883, 377f.

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION II: EXEGESIS

11:1–2

- 1 *Once, all humanity had one language and all the same words.*
 2 *And it came to pass as they set out eastward that they found a plain
 in the land of Shinar and settled there.*

The Tower narrative's introduction has again and again prompted literary-critical response, since both v. 1 and v. 2 open with וַיְהִי "once/and it came to pass." In the source model, independent narrative beginnings are identified in each of the two verses.¹⁵ In redactional explanations, v. 1, which is usually considered odd because of its syntax, and the corresponding etiology of the city name "Babel" in v. 9a are regarded as secondary, integrating the narrative into its present context.¹⁶ However, there should not be too much weight put on the doubled וַיְהִי, since its function differs in each instance. In v. 1, as elsewhere, it opens a nominal clause describing the starting point of the narrative (which is in the past). In v. 2, it serves as the typical introduction to narrative action.¹⁷ Another argument against an exclusion of v. 1 is that the suffix in בְּנִסְעָם "as they set out" in v. 2 would then lack its referent.¹⁸ A narrative beginning without precisely naming the subject is highly unlikely, especially since the elimination of v. 1 creates a connective problem: It is obvious that Gen 11:2 cannot have followed directly after Gen 10:32. It cannot have followed immediately after Gen 10:25 or 10:31, either, or else the Tower narrative would report only of the descendants of Shem (Gen 10:31) or his great-grandson Eber (Gen 10:25), which would obviously contradict the intention of the story.

The exposition in v. 1 describes an action shared by all humanity (כָּל־הָאָדָם), who also appear as the subject of the following verses. Thus, the Tower narrative shows itself to be a myth about primeval times, which of course does not exclude the possibility for contemporary historical allusions. The initial situation is described with the singular phrase "one language and all the same words" (שָׂפָה אֶחָת וּדְבָרִים אֶחָדִים). In contexts concerning language, the expression שָׂפָה "lip" usually denotes speech and the ability to speak (e.g., Exod 6:12, 30; Job 12:20), but it can also refer to a specific language (cf. Isa 19:18 "language of Canaan"). In contrast to the לָשׁוֹן "tongue/language"

¹⁵ First by Gunkel, 94–95.

¹⁶ Seybold, 1976, 458f. On the syntax of v. 1, see the Text-critical and Philological Note above.

¹⁷ Following Uehlinger, 1990, 312. See also Skinner, 224.

¹⁸ Cassuto, 2:236.

usually used in individual idioms (e.g., Gen 10:5, 20. 31), **שָׁפָה אֶחָת וּדְבָרִים** emphasizes the intention shared among the speakers as expressed in the shared building project (cf. vv. 3–4) and watched by Yhwh with concern (cf. v. 6). Nevertheless, the narrative is also about the different languages. The connection between the expression “all the same words,” probably referring to a common vocabulary, and “all humanity” as its subject, leaves no doubt that the narrative is set in an era when the differentiation into peoples and languages has not yet taken place. At the end of the narrative, this initial situation is reversed: Yhwh mixes the language (**שָׁפָה**) of all humanity (v. 9a) and scatters the people over the entire earth (v. 9b). In this respect, the Tower narrative also aims at explaining the differentiation of humanity into peoples and languages. This has repeatedly prompted the search for an original, shared human language as well as linguistic and philosophical reflections on the “Adamic language” (Walter Benjamin). Yet, even if the author would have presupposed that Adam and Eve (like God) spoke Hebrew in the Garden, such considerations play at best an ancillary role in the Tower narrative, which, like every origin myth, should be understood starting with its end result and the realities described there. The realities in the narrative are characterized by the diversity of languages and the dissolution of the united human community. Within the Tower narrative, these conditions are evaluated as a limitation of humanity and its capabilities, which is a “loss” by any definition. A distant analogy can be found in the Sumerian epic “Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta” from the early second millennium BCE. Here, the “monolingualism of humanity” symbolizes the ideal state of primeval times, in which humanity had no enemies and knew neither fear nor terror. It seems that only the intervention by the god Enki ended this state. Admittedly, the reasons for this, presumably a rivalry between the gods Enlil and Enki, remain quite unclear. For this reason alone, the text, which is quite difficult to understand, should not be approached as a “Sumerian version of the Tower of Babel narrative.”¹⁹

According to Christoph Uehlinger, **שָׁפָה אֶחָת**, like the other “dominant motifs [...] of constructing ‘city and citadel,’ of ‘name-making,’ and presumably also the characterization of the builders as ‘one people’ should be interpreted against Neo-Assyrian rhetoric of world domination.”²⁰ According to this reading, the expression “one speech” denotes the claim of the Neo-Assyrian kings that all the world obeyed their command. This is related to the thesis that political and theological reflections on Sargon II (720–705 BCE) and the unfinished expansion of his residence at

¹⁹ Text and translation of the relevant passage in Mittermayer, 2009, 57–61. On the (controversial) discussion, see *ibid.*, as well as Uehlinger, 1990, 410–434.

²⁰ Uehlinger, 1990, 512 [translation JWR].

Dur-Šarrukin (“The Fortress of Sargon”; modern-day Khorsabad in northern Iraq), dating to the Neo-Assyrian period, form the basis of the narrative (vv. 1a, 3aα, 4aβγδ, 5–7, 8b). According to Uehlinger, this formerly independent narrative was the Judean perspective on the inglorious end of the Northern Kingdom of Israel’s ultimate conqueror and his lofty building project – in which (conscripted) workers from all over the world were forced under “one speech,” meaning a single command. An inscription from Sargon II, referring to such construction work, says: “Subjects from the four (cardinal directions, each with their) foreign language, speech without harmony... that I captured with my wrathful scepter at the behest of Aššur, my lord, I let one speech be spoken [lit. “set a mouth”] and let them take up residence in it [i.e., in Dur-Šarrukin].”²¹ In the Neo-Babylonian period, the anti-Assyrian narrative would have then been transformed into a critique of Babylon’s claim to world domination (vv. 1b, 3aβγ, 3b, 4a [“and they said”], 9a). Further editing then would have integrated the narrative into the (pre-Priestly) Primeval History (v. 2), thus transforming a narrative that reflected upon and criticized concrete events of its own time into an episode within the Primeval History. This thesis is fascinating and has rich material roots, but there are serious flaws regarding both methodology and content: The reference points in the text – “Babel” in the “land of Shinar” (vv. 2, 9a) and the primeval horizon of the one humanity (vv. 1f., 9) – are replaced by points of reference outside of the narrative (Sargon II; Dur-Šarrukin), establishing a reading of it that is based entirely on texts from its historical context and that simultaneously requires reducing the content of the text quite considerably.²² In any case, the narrative tendencies do not support such a political/theological reading:²³ From the point of view of Yhwh (or the text), it is not specifically the “one speech” that is problematic, as in Uehlinger’s reading as a critique of hegemonic rule, but the limitless nature of human action (v. 6). This is symbolized by the construction project, building both the city as well as its tower that reaches to the heavens (v. 4). Furthermore, in the Neo-Assyrian rhetoric of world domination, the king must impose “one mouth” (*pû ištēn*) upon the peoples, while the אֶתְּ פֶה אֶחָד of Gen 11:1 is an unquestioned, (primeval) unproblematic presupposition of the narrative until the city and the tower are constructed.²⁴ Moreover, the expected translation of the Akkadian *pû ištēn* into Hebrew would be פֶּה אֶחָד (so Josh 9:2), which would have certainly facilitated ancient understandings of the presumed political and theological claims.²⁵ Finally, Gen 11:1–9 lacks any allusion to the supposed militaristic/hegemonic background of world domination, which is why any interpretation concerning a critique of global hegemony must arduously read kingship, the *conditio sine qua non* of such interpretations, into the text.²⁶ Nevertheless, there is no question that the motif of the “one speech” signals less any actual linguistic fact of a shared primeval language and more an idea of order in which humanity’s unity is expressed through a common language.

²¹ Uehlinger, 1990, 471 [translation JWR from German].

²² See also Witte, 1998, 94 fn. 71: “interpretational model foreign to the text” [translation JWR].

²³ The valuable observations by Boyd, 2019 on Neo-Assyrian rhetoric and the statement that the motif of “one language” and the “possibilities of human action” are also connected in Neo-Assyrian rhetoric do not argue against this assessment.

²⁴ See similarly Schüle, 2006, 412.

²⁵ Seebaß, 281.

²⁶ So also Seebaß, 281, 285.

The one humanity settles on a plain in the land of Shinar, which from the perspective of Jerusalem is “in the east” (cf. v. 2a). According to Gen 10:10, this region includes the cities of Erech (Uruk) and Akkad in addition to Babel (Babylon; v. 9a), therefore meaning that the region in question is the southern part of Mesopotamia, belonging to the city of Babylon.²⁷ As in the cuneiform texts, which use *bābili* “Babylon” exclusively for the city into the Neo-Babylonian period, the narrative distinguishes between the city and the region. In Gen 11:2, this distinction is explained by the fact that the city is not founded and identified until the end of the narrative. As mentioned above, the writers of Gen 10:10 and 11:2 resort to the older name of the region, *Šanḥar*, rather than *māt Kaldi* “land of the Chaldeans,” which was more common in the first millennium BCE. This “ancient scholarly term”²⁸ underscores the primeval character of the narrative.

11:3

And they said, one to their neighbor: “Come, let us form bricks and fire them.” And the brick served them as stone and bitumen served them as mortar.

As if to prove that the state of linguistic unison was the ideal, the people’s speech begins with a twofold *figura etymologica*: “Come, let us form bricks [נִלְבְּנָה לְבִנִּים] and fire them [וְנִשְׂרָפָה לְשִׂרְפָּה]” (v. 3a). The latter probably refers to the firing of mudbrick, giving them a glazed-like surface. This is followed by a notice of their building technique, according to which the (fired) bricks were used instead of stones and bitumen served as mortar. The word-play of the similar-sounding words חֵמֶר “bitumen” and חֹמֶר “mortar” once again underscores the motif of “one language and all the same words.” The construction notice, which has a close functional parallel in Herodotus’s account of Babylon (Herodotus, *Hist.* 1.179.1–2), also gives the narrative a foreign, Babylonian-esque feel by communicating a cultural feature to its readers. Although air-dried mudbricks were also known in ancient Israel, the burning of bricks seems to have been just as unusual as the use of bitumen for masonry work. Bitumen, which occurs naturally around the Dead Sea (Gen 14:10), was actually used for waterproofing (e.g., Exod 2:3), and large buildings especially in the Judean and Samarian highlands were built primarily of (hewn) stones. As with the use of the uncommon place name “Shinar,” the author of this very elaborate narrative was not stingy in utilizing

²⁷ Jericke, 2016.

²⁸ Uehlinger, 1990, 562 [translation JWR].

the assets of a learned education. As a result, v. 3b may contain an indication for the dating of the narrative. Should the tower mentioned in v. 4 be identified with the stepped temple (ziggurat) Etemenanki in Babylon, then the construction notice for the Tower of Babel narrative leads to the conclusion that its historical context was either the Neo-Assyrian or Neo-Babylonian period at the earliest.²⁹ This oldest stepped temple in Babylon was, in fact, a mudbrick structure reinforced by horizontal inlays of reed mats that was later enclosed by a mudbrick mantle. Only at its final phase of expansion was it then enclosed by a baked-brick mantle, which happened during the reign of the Neo-Assyrian king Esarhaddon at the very earliest (681–669 BCE). It is possible that this occurred in connection with extensive renovation work in Babylon, necessitated by the destruction of the city and its temple district in 689 BCE by Esarhaddon's predecessor, Sennacherib, to the rest of the world's horror (or gloating). However, this dating of the baked-brick mantle is not completely reliable, because it does not completely fit with the statements of the later building inscriptions of the Neo-Babylonian kings Nabopolassar (626–605 BCE) and Nebuchadnezzar II (605–562 BCE). The inscriptions report the (re)founding of the ziggurat under Nabopolassar and the completion of its construction under his son Nebuchadnezzar. In any case, it is very likely that the stepped temple was refurbished with a mudbrick mantle by the Neo-Assyrian kings and was only later given the baked-brick mantle by their Neo-Babylonian successors, when it was also expanded into the largest ziggurat of its time. Should "city and tower" (v. 4) be identified with the city of Babylon and its famous stepped temple Etemenanki – as the narrative certainly suggests (cf. v. 9) – then the construction notice about the baked-brick mantle points to the Neo-Babylonian period as the *terminus post quem* for the Tower of Babel narrative or its underlying tradition: "One can imagine what feelings Etemenanki aroused among the Jews exiled to Babylon, which, especially in its unfinished state, must have given the impression of a building reaching toward the heavens. This was the most fitting image to be entered into the primeval history of humanity as a parable of arrogance and its punishment by God."³⁰

²⁹ On the analysis of the findings from the excavation and the cuneiforms sources, see Schmid, 1995; Uehlinger, 1990, 220–227. On the analysis of the findings for a possible dating of v. 3, see *ibid.*, 371f., 551–558. Uehlinger assigns the verse to his "Babel *relecture*."

³⁰ Schmid, 1995, 148 [translation JWR]. Levin, 1993, 127–131 supposes the narrative's historical background to be in the destruction (attested in at least contemporary polemics) of the Babylonian ziggurat by the Persian king Xerxes in 482 BCE; cf. Witte 1998, 320–323, who sees the failed reconstruction attempt by Alexander the Great as the historical background. See the discussion of each in Gerhards, 2013, 295–297.

11:4

Then, they said, "Come, let us build ourselves a city and a tower whose top is in the heavens, and let us make a name for ourselves, lest we be scattered over the entire earth!"

The second part of the speech, again a reflexive invocation ("let *us*") introduced with הִבָּהּ "Come!", reports the decision to build "city and tower" (v. 4aα) and states the purpose for this undertaking (v. 4aβb). It has been repeatedly noted that the sequence of v. 3 and v. 4 contradicts a "natural narrative" that would first report the decision to build and only thereafter report the making of the building materials.³¹ However, this does not sufficiently consider the tension built throughout the narrative: Yhwh reacts directly to the construction of the city and the tower rather than to a method of construction common in Mesopotamia (see v. 5), which is why the decision to build the tower and the justification for this must immediately precede God's speech. The construction is referred to as a "city and tower" (vv. 4, 5). This combination initially evokes a city and its higher citadel (see Judg 9:46f., 49).³² From very early on, reception of the text focused on the tower, which, in light of archaeological discoveries, is identified as a stepped temple typical of ancient Mesopotamia. The aforementioned identification with the ziggurat Etemenanki in Babylon, which has been quite common in readings of the narrative, is supported by the imagery of a building reaching up to the heavens (v. 4a), in addition to the etiology of the name in v. 9a.³³ This is well attested in building inscriptions of the ancient Near East, such as in an inscription by Nabopolassar dedicated to the reconstruction of Etemenanki: "At that time my lord Marduk commanded me in regard to Etemenanki – the ziggurat of Babylon, which before my time had become dilapidated and was close to collapse –, to establish its foundation on the breast of the underworld, in order to make its top compete (in height) with the heavens" (1.28–36); "I made them form clay bricks without number and cast baked bricks like innumerable raindrops. I made the Arahtu carry asphalt and bitumen like a mighty flood." (2.1–8).³⁴ However, against the interpretive concentration on the "Tower of Babel," it must be said that this is

³¹ So Westermann, 545.

³² See Uehlinger, 1990, 372–378.

³³ Contra Uehlinger, 1990, 378–380, who understands the use to be a hyperbolic description of an impressive citadel (see also Deut 1:28), although already Dillmann, 206 argued that this does not fit with the course of events.

³⁴ Translation from "The Etemenanki Inscription, Babylon" (C31:77–92; Da Riva, 2013, 88).

certainly not the main motif of the narrative. This is already evident from the combination of the tower with the city and its absence in v. 8, which, due to the transition to the etiology of the name, mentions only the city. In addition, the Hebrew term *מִגְדָּל* “tower,” usually used for fortress towers, lacks any religious connotation. This speaks against the repeatedly expressed assumption that the narrative is primarily (!) about a devaluation of this specific religious building and about the (polemical) debate surrounding the theological conception connected with it (cf. Isa 14:13f.).³⁵ The focus is not so much on recognizable historical references as it is on the narrated world. It must therefore be asked: What exactly are humanity’s intentions in the narrative concerning the tower and what exact fears does the construction provoke in Yhwh? Humanity wants to “make a name for itself” (v. 4aβ) with the construction reaching up to the heavens (v. 4aα) and to protect itself (v. 4b) from being scattered over the whole earth (with the phrase *עַל-פְּנֵי כָל-הָאָרֶץ* “over the entire earth” creating a nuanced link to the phrase *כָּל-הָאָדָם* “all humanity” in v. 1, 9aβ).³⁶

The “name-making” motif (v. 4aβ) is often seen as a later addition because of the *פֶּן* “lest” in v. 4b. This connection to v. 4aβ is considered problematic because v. 4b is directly related to the decision to build the city and the tower.³⁷ A more direct connection between v. 4aα and v. 4b is undoubtedly possible (“Come, let us build ourselves a city and a tower whose top is in the heavens... so that we will not be scattered over the whole earth.”). However, the present text is also coherent as it stands when taking into account the connection between building activity and the name of the builder, as is widely documented (not only!) across the ancient Near East.

The communal construction results in the builders being identified with the name set by the building (so Sir 40:19). This creates the desired cohesion and prevents the feared dispersal. Preserving the unity of humanity is the goal and purpose of building the city and tower.³⁸ Furthermore, it must still be considered whether an arrogant pursuit of self-glorification by humanity is actually the root of the plan to build a structure reaching into the heavens.³⁹ It can be argued in support of this classic interpretation that in the Hebrew Bible, with one further exception (2 Sam 8:13), God is otherwise always

³⁵ This restriction holds for the narrative in its present form within the context of the biblical Primeval History. For a possible antecedent (cf. Scholarly Exposition I), this may have looked quite different. For a subversive polemical reading, see Grossman, 2017; further Zgoll, 2012, 31f.

³⁶ Differently Uehlinger, 1990, 308, who, like many others, recognizes a “disturbance of the semantic coherence” [translation JWR].

³⁷ Westermann, 547; Seybold, 457f. and fn. 15.

³⁸ Cf. Seebaß, 278.

³⁹ Cf. von Rad, 149 (“titanism”); Barth, 1951, 349–366 (“hubris”); Witte, 1998, 228, 253–255.

the subject of the phrase “to make a name.” This is the case whether in mostly hymnic texts praising God, who glorifies himself through his salvific deeds (e.g., Isa 63:12, 14; Jer 32:20; Dan 9:15; Neh 9:10), or in God’s promises of a great name to Abraham (Gen 12:2) or David (2 Sam 7:9). Against this background, the way that humanity calls upon itself in v. 4a β can also be read as an expression of hubris. In the context of Primeval History, it also evokes the “men of renown” (Gen 6:4). Although these do not have a clearly negative connotation, they are spoken of with some wariness.⁴⁰ Finally, for a critical reading of the “name” motif, it can be argued that the narrative takes up the motif again with an ironic twist at its end: Humanity has not succeeded in completing the construction and making a name for itself, and the city has instead been given the name “Babel” in memory of the jumbling of languages (v. 9a). Therefore, it cannot be denied that there is a haughty undertone to the people’s resolve. Nevertheless, it must be emphasized that the “name-making” is subordinate to the efforts to prevent dispersal. The people’s speech emphasizes how they fear losing their unity. It is only Yhwh’s reaction to the construction that draws attention to how, with the project, the people presume to question the distance between humanity and God. When following the course of the narrative, this happens rather unintentionally and out of existential dread. The author had astutely perceived that, psychologically, fear and the craving of recognition are two sides of the same coin.⁴¹

11:5–7

- 5 *Then, Yhwh came down to see the city and the tower that the Sons of Man had built.*
- 6 *And Yhwh said, “See! One people and one language for them all. And this is [only] the beginning of their acting. But now, nothing will be impossible for them from whatever they intend to do.*
- 7 *Come, let us go down and confuse their language there, so that no one understands the language of their neighbor!”*

Humanity’s decision to build the city and the tower is followed immediately by Yhwh’s reaction to this. Strictly speaking, an “indispensable” report about the construction activity itself is missing, but it is presupposed in Yhwh’s deliberations. What results is a “point of great ambiguity where the imagination of the readers/listeners can run wild.”⁴² The concise narrative style,

⁴⁰ So Witte, 1998, 253; Kratz, 2005, 254.

⁴¹ von Rad, 149; Seebaß, 273f. On this motif, see Zgoll, 2003; Radner, 2005.

⁴² Berges, 1994, 44 [translation JWR].

reporting either only the announcement or only the execution of an undertaking, should also be considered in the case of Yhwh's descent in both v. 5 and v. 7. In light of v. 6, vv. 5–7 presuppose either Yhwh going back up or – less likely – a staggered descent, but neither are mentioned. This has repeatedly been attributed to a textual omission or later editorial activity. Yet, this would involve the editor creating a supposedly “intolerable” inconsistency that would have been easily avoidable. As in the case of the missing-but-still-presupposed building report, this speaks for the omission having been intended from the outset: The omission of a presumably cumbersome report about Yhwh going back up allowed Yhwh's reflections upon the human activity to be placed at the center, framed by the two descent reports in vv. 5, 7. Furthermore, it could also be that the doubled reporting of Yhwh's descent was meant to caricature humanity's endeavor to build a tower reaching to the heavens.⁴³

11:5

Then, Yhwh came down to see the city and the tower that the Sons of Man had built.

Even though Yhwh must come down to look at the construction work (v. 5a), he still becomes concerned because of it. The Greek Apocalypse of Baruch from the second century CE reports that the builders brought a hand drill with them to see if the sky was made of clay, copper, or iron (3 Bar. 3:6–8), which may seem naïve, but only at first glance. Rather, this retelling of the biblical text has recognized quite correctly that from Yhwh's point of view, the enterprise involves a trespassing of boundaries. The problem can already be seen in the choice of בְּנֵי־הָאָדָם “Sons of Man” instead of the כָּל־הָאָרֶץ “all the world” (vv. 1, 9a) that the narrative otherwise uses for humanity. The former expression is used in the Primeval History only in Yhwh's response to the construction of the tower. The conception standing behind the term is evidenced from the similar בָּנוֹת הָאָדָם “Daughters of Man,” used alongside the בְּנֵי־הָאֱלֹהִים “Sons of the Gods” in Gen 6:2, 4. If the episode of the union of the Sons of the Gods and the Daughters of Man is about the possible consequences of trespassing the sexual boundary between the divine and human spheres, then with the construction of the city and the tower, Yhwh recognizes the danger of the בְּנֵי־הָאָדָם crossing the boundary both spatially and in terms of creationary possibilities.

⁴³ On the ironic tone of the narrative, see Jacob, 299f.; Seybold, 1976, 467; Weisman, 1998, 39–50; cf. with criticism Wellhausen, 1905, 305.

11:6

And Yhwh said, “See! One people and one language for them all. And this is [only] the beginning of their acting. But now, nothing will be impossible for them from whatever they intend to do.

Yhwh’s contemplation upon humanity’s activity, framed by the two descent reports, elaborates on this thought. In terms of both language and content, it stands in alignment with Gen 3:22.⁴⁴ In both cases, the הֵן “see,” which is extremely rare in divine speeches (otherwise only in Deut 31:14), begins Yhwh’s consideration of the situation. In the Garden narrative, it concerns humanity’s newfound capacity for knowledge; in the Tower narrative, it focuses on humanity’s capacity for action made possible only through unification (“One people and one language”), first manifested in the decision to build the city and the tower. The possible consequences are each introduced with וְעַתָּה “But now.” The Garden narrative is about Yhwh’s fear that humanity, who has become knowledgeable like a god, might also reach for the Tree of Life, thereby overcoming the boundary of death and becoming divine in this respect as well. The Tower narrative is about the anxious recognition that, should the enterprise be successful, there would no longer be any limits to humanity’s planning and creating: “But now, nothing will be impossible for them [*בצר ni. + מן + suff.] from whatever they intend to do [*זמם].” The fact that this would indeed trespass a boundary between divine and human activity can be seen in the nearest parallel to v. 6b in the Hebrew Bible, Job 42:2.⁴⁵ What v. 6b addresses as a possible consequence for human action in Yhwh’s view of the construction project comes out of Job’s mouth as a recognition of God’s omnipotence and his own creatureliness: “I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose [*זמם] of yours can be thwarted [*בצר ni. + מן + suff.].” Of course, the talk of “the beginning of their acting” in v. 6 shows that it is merely a *possibility* for humanity, just as in the reaching for the Tree of Life. In both cases, it is this alone that moves Yhwh to act preventatively, and quite selfishly, for the preservation of his own superiority, which also lends a tragic side to the people’s fate.

11:7

Come, let us go down and confuse their language there, so that no one understands the language of their neighbor!”

Yhwh decides to limit humanity in its creative possibilities by confusing its language. The divine decision is formulated in the plural, like in Gen 1:26,

⁴⁴ So already Wellhausen, 1899, 11f.

⁴⁵ See further Witte, 1998, 255; Schüle, 2006, 397.

so this seems to have been made in the assembly of the heavenly beings (see also Gen 3:22). Like the incorporation of the הָבֵה “Come!” from vv. 3, 4, the collective “we” again underscores the delineation of the divine sphere apart from the humans and their counsel. The verb בָּלַל “to mix” is mainly used in the Hebrew Bible for mixing dough with oil (e.g., Exod 29:2; Lev 2:4f.). The expression was doubtlessly chosen for Gen 11:7 because it sounds similar to the name “Babel” (v. 9a). At the same time, the onomatopoeic word vividly describes how a clear language in which everyone can communicate with everyone else (v. 3; אִישׁ אֶל-רֵעֵהוּ) becomes a mishmash in which no one can understand what anyone else says (לֹא יִשְׁמְעוּ אִישׁ שְׁפֹת רֵעֵהוּ). The unmistakable references in Yhwh’s speech back to the people’s decision clearly show that the “jumbling of speech” is not an end to itself. Rather, it serves to render the tower and city construction impossible and to undermine the goal of the project, the preservation of human unity. In this way, it is intended to prevent the limitlessness of human action that is symbolized by the construction and enabled by their unity.

11:8

Then Yhwh scattered them from there over the entire earth, and they thus stopped building the city.

The execution of the divine decision is not reported, but the narrative takes for granted that it occurs. Here again, there is a “place of great ambiguity” that has long been filled with representations of Yhwh’s destruction of the (half-finished) tower. Yet, there is nothing about any of this in the biblical text; it only conveys the consequences of the divine intervention: From the location of the incident, humanity is scattered over the entire earth (v. 8a; cf. v. 4b) and ceases construction (v. 8b; cf. v. 4a). The fact that the scattering is reported first, before the end of the construction that chronologically precedes it, has repeatedly led to classifications of v. 8a as an editorial addition.⁴⁶ However, the two sub-verses are sequenced as such for both compositional and narratological reasons: Like earlier with humanity’s decision to use the construction project to prevent themselves from being scattered, the thwarted unity of humanity is the focus of the divine countermeasures and is therefore mentioned first. Henceforth, due to the dispersal, not everything is possible for humanity. This also applies to the building project, whose failure becomes a symbol of humanity’s lost unity and ability to do whatever it sets out to do. Verse 8b is formulated in connection with the following

⁴⁶ See Seybold, 1976, 458 and fn. 16.

etiology of the city name “Babel” (v. 9a), which is why only the city is mentioned from the “city and tower” pair (vv. 4a, 5a).⁴⁷

11:9

Therefore, its name was called “Babel,” because there Yhwh jumbled the language of all humanity. And from there, Yhwh scattered them over the entire earth.

Introduced with the עַל־כֵּן “therefore” typical of etiological notices, v. 9a takes up the naming motif from humanity’s decision (v. 4aβ) and the verb בָּלַל “to jumble” from God’s decision (v. 7). The city in the land of Shinar (v. 2), initially nameless, is identified with the city of Babel, while “Babel” in turn becomes synonymous with language confusion. This is a folk etymology seeking to explain the name of the foreign city through a similar-sounding word from the narrator’s mother tongue, with a story to match. Unlike the Akkadian meaning of the name (which is also known to the Hebrew Bible), *Bābīlīm bītāt ilānīm rabūtūtīm* “Babylon: Home of the Great Gods” (EnEl 5.129; cf. Gen 28:17: “House of God”/ “Gate of Heaven”), the connection with בָּלַל has an inherently derisive undertone. The Tower narrative ends by stating that from this place, Yhwh scatters humanity over the entire earth (v. 9b). With this notice, the Tower narrative is shown to be an explication of the origin of the peoples and their languages, already mentioned in the Table of Nations (Gen 10:5, 20, 31), from the single family of Noah and his descendants (Gen 9:19). At the same time, the concluding notice about the scattering of humanity provides a justification for the following focus on the descendants of Shem and, ultimately, Abraham. With the Tower narrative, the one unified humanity has become the multitude of peoples and, thus, the world into which Abraham enters. In this respect, this final narrative in the Primeval History is both its epilogue and the prologue to the narrative about the ancestors of Israel. The motif of “name-making” is often brought up in this context.⁴⁸ However, the phrasing of the promise of a great name to Abraham (Gen 12:2) and that of humanity’s decision to make a name for itself (Gen 11:4) are too different to be able to claim any deliberate contrast here. At best, it is an implicit connection of vocabulary. More relevant are the allusions scattered throughout the Tower narrative to the beginning of

⁴⁷ According to Vanderhooft, 2020, 44–49, the formulation can be explained by how only the city was never finished because of the divine intervention. Cf. the Text-critical and Philological Note on v. 5.

⁴⁸ See Berges, 1994, 51–53.

the Exodus narrative:⁴⁹ Verse 3b overlaps terminologically with Exod 1:14a (mudbricks, bitumen); the linguistic construction of the reflexive invocation in v. 4 (cohortative pl. and the negative formulation of the goal) is attested elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible only with Pharaoh's speech in Exod 1:10, with God still thwarting the objective in both cases. God's descent in vv. 5, 7 is clearly reminiscent of Exod 3:8. These allusions allow the attentive reader to recognize an exemplaric anticipation of the exodus in Abraham's departure from Mesopotamia.

⁴⁹ See Schüle, 2006, 406f.

THE GENERATIONS OF SHEM

- 11:10** These are the generations of Shem. Shem was 100 years old, and he fathered Arpachshad, two years after the Flood.
- 11** And Shem lived 500 years after fathering Arpachshad, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 12** And Arpachshad lived 35 years, and he fathered Shelah.
- 13** And Arpachshad lived 403 years after fathering Shelah, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 14** And Shelah lived 30 years, and he fathered Eber.
- 15** And Shelah lived 403 years after fathering Eber, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 16** And Eber lived 34 years, and he fathered Peleg.
- 17** And Eber lived 430 years after fathering Peleg, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 18** And Peleg lived 30 years, and he fathered Reu.
- 19** And Peleg lived 209 years after fathering Reu, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 20** And Reu lived 32 years, and he fathered Serug.
- 21** And Reu lived 207 years after fathering Serug, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 22** And Serug lived 30 years, and he fathered Nahor.
- 23** And Serug lived 200 years after fathering Nahor, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 24** And Nahor lived 29 years, and he fathered Terah.
- 25** And Nahor lived 119 years after fathering Terah, and he fathered sons and daughters.
- 26** And Terah lived 70 years, and he fathered Abraham, Nahor, and Haran.

Analysis: Gen 11:10–26 as a whole comes from the Priestly Writing.

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TEXT-CRITICAL AND PHILOLOGICAL NOTES

11:11 The LXX and SP adjust Gen 11 to the pattern from Gen 5. Both provide a death notice, as with the following patriarchs through Nahor. The SP also gives the total age.

11:12 חָמֵשׁ וּשְׁלִשִּׁים שָׁנָה (35 years): As in Gen 5, the ages in the MT, SP, and LXX differ significantly. From Arpachshad to Serug, the SP and LXX increase the age at the fathering of the firstborn by 100 years, and Nahor's age by 50 years. The SP then reduces the remaining lifetime accordingly, by either 100 or 50 years, while the LXX leaves the remaining lifetime unchanged. The remaining lifetimes provided by the LXX of 430 years for Arpachshad, 330 years for Shelah, and 129 years for Nahor are presumably based on a misreading of the MT, whose numbers are supported by the SP. See Rösel, 1994, 223. Only with the statement of Eber's remaining lifetime does it seem that the LXX with 370 years (cf. SP: 270 years) may have priority over the MT's 430 years. By increasing the age at fathering, the SP's chronology is increased by 650 years, and because of the insertion of another generation (see below on Καϊναν), the LXX's chronology is increased by 780 years (in each case with reference to the Flood and differing dates for it; see on Gen 5:1–32 above). This may have been done to avoid Noah living into the time of Abraham and Shem into the time of Jacob, as in the MT. The present translation follows the MT. For the justifications for the priority of the ages in the MT, see Rösel, 1994, 132–134.

According to the LXX, Arpachshad (Αρφαξάδ) had a son named Καϊναν, who was in turn the father of Shelah (Σαλα; see Gen 10:24^{LXX}). Genesis 10:22^{LXX} mentions a Καϊναν as the son of Shem (Σημ). Traces of this additional generation can also be found in Jub. 8:1–5; Luk 3:35f. This may have been added in order to reach the number ten, as in Gen 5.

ESSENTIALS AND PERSPECTIVES

The genealogy of the descendants of Shem continues the Register of the Generations of Adam from Gen 5. Like its antediluvian counterpart in Gen 5, it proceeds through father and firstborn son. Like Gen 5, it then branches out into a segmented genealogy in the final link by naming the three sons of Terah. With the fathering of Abram, Nahor, and Haran, the Primeval History is closed and the history of the ancestors of Israel is opened. Its first section, the narratives about Abram/Abraham and Sarai/Sarah, is arranged in the present literary form of Genesis under the Priestly heading of the *toledot*/generations of Terah (Gen 11:27).

Beginning with Gen 11:10–26, the genealogies focus on leading to Israel. Genesis 5 presents the history of the unified antediluvian humanity, and the Table of Nations in Gen 10 reveals the descent of the nations of the world from the three sons of Noah. Conversely, of the three sons of Noah named in the conclusion of the *toledot*/generations of Adam and whose descendants are enumerated in the Table of Nations, only Shem and the descendants of his firstborn are mentioned in Gen 11:10–26. This focus is found again in the transition to the *toledot*/generations of Terah in Gen 11:26f. Of the three sons of Terah mentioned at the end of the genealogy of Shem, the main focus as the narrative progresses is on Abram. Thus, the genealogical line of the three sons of Noah, from whom the nations of the world descend (see Gen 9:19[?]; 10:32), leads through Shem, Terah, Abraham, and Isaac to Jacob/Israel and his sons, the forefathers of the tribes of Israel.

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION I: INTRODUCTION TO EXEGESIS

The genealogy of the descendants of Shem comes from the Priestly Writing. In the Priestly version of the Primeval History, it originally followed directly after the conclusion to the Table of Nations in Gen 10:32 and resumed the thread following the sons of Shem. Notwithstanding the close similarities in form to Gen 5, there are differences that should also be noted. According to the MT, the genealogy of Shem is only nine generations instead of ten. Furthermore, each case lacks figures for the total age as well as a death notice. The reasons for these deviations can only be left to speculation. As the ten-generation version in one area of the tradition shows, the text had been worked and reworked under different standards over a very long time, which is also indicated by the different ages given by the MT, SP, and LXX. The possibility of the Priestly Writing wanting to mark the “transition from the primeval story to the history of the patriarchs” with the absence of the tenth link is quite uncertain.¹

SCHOLARLY EXPOSITION II: EXEGESIS

11:10–11

- 10** *These are the generations of Shem. Shem was 100 years old, and he fathered Arpachshad, two years after the Flood.*
- 11** *And Shem lived 500 years after fathering Arpachshad, and he fathered sons and daughters.*

¹ Westermann, 560.

Shem is 100 years old when he fathers his firstborn son. In contrast, except for Terah at 70 years old, the following patriarchs are between 29 and 35 years old when they father their firstborn sons. This could be understood as an indication that Shem was still partaking in the life force of the antediluvian generations who were close to Creation, while the lifespans of the postdiluvian generations gradually begin to reach the experiential horizon of the authors. According to the genealogical structure in Gen 5 and 11:10–26, Arpachshad is Shem's firstborn. His place in Gen 10:22 as the third of the five sons of Shem is explainable through the geographical arrangement of Elam, Assur, Arpachshad, Lud, and Aram (for this and the explanation of the name, see on Gen 10:22 above). The note about Arpachshad being fathered "two years after the Flood" does not fit well with the other chronological details of the Priestly Writing. According to Gen 5:32, Noah fathers his sons Shem, Ham, and Japheth at 500 years old. According to Gen 7:11, the Flood begins in Noah's 600th year, lasting one year and ending in his 601st year according to Gen 8:13. Thus, Noah is 599 years old at the beginning of the Flood and 600 years old when it ends. Accordingly, Shem is 99 years old at the beginning of the Flood and 100 years when it ends. Yet, given the "two years after the Flood," he should already be 102 years old instead of the 100 years given in v. 10.

However, there are some ambiguities in this calculation. The dual form שְׁנַיִם is commonly translated as "two years," but it can also mean "in the second year," which is how the LXX understands it (δευτέρου ἔτους). Additionally, the age at the time of fathering does not necessarily refer to the year of birth. The Priestly Writing knew to differentiate between fathering (*לד hi.) and birth, as is evident from Abraham's question when he is 99 years old about how a son could be born to someone who is 100 years old (*ילד ni. Gen 17:1, 17). If there is also a distinction to be made between fathering and birth in the Priestly genealogies in Gen 5, then Shem is 99 years old at the end of the Flood and may have still been 100 years old in the "second year after the Flood." The calculation would also be more coherent if the "after the Flood" could refer to the beginning of the flooding.² Yet, the "after the Flood" in the calculation of Noah's lifetime in Gen 9:28 speaks against this possibility. Here, it clearly refers to the end of the Flood, as it would otherwise make the calculation incorrect.

It is entirely possible that the chronological difficulties, like the unevenness in Gen 5:1–3, resulted from the Priestly Writing having written certain narrative elements within a predefined "Book of the *Toledot*" (see above, on Gen 5:1–3). This leads to the question of why the Priestly Writing, which is otherwise so exact concerning chronological matters, included such vague

² So, e.g., Witte, 1998, 116.

figures at the beginning of the genealogy of Shem. It may have been due to the repeated blessing of multiplication in Gen 9:1.³ In the Priestly Writing, the firstborn of Shem marks a new beginning for postdiluvian humanity, which is why his conception is clearly dated with respect to the time after the renewed blessing. With Arpachshad, a new era begins.

11:12–17

- 12** *And Arpachshad lived 35 years, and he fathered Shelah.*
13 *And Arpachshad lived 403 years after fathering Shelah, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
14 *And Shelah lived 30 years, and he fathered Eber.*
15 *And Shelah lived 403 years after fathering Eber, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
16 *And Eber lived 34 years, and he fathered Peleg.*
17 *And Eber lived 430 years after fathering Peleg, and he fathered sons and daughters.*

The notices about Arpachschad and his son Shelah each begin as an inverted verbal clause with the name of the patriarch placed first in the sentence syntax. Thus, for no apparent reason, they deviate from the pattern established in Gen 5, which resumes with Eber and his son, Peleg. The name “Shelah” (שֵׁלָח) is either a shorted form of the name “Methushelah” (Eng. “Methuselah”; see Gen 5:25–27) or is derived from the root *שִׁלַּח “to send” with the meaning “[The god D.N.] has sent [the child].” The name “Eber” (עֵבֶר) is attested as a personal name in multiple places across the Hebrew Bible (Neh 12:20; 1 Chr 5:13; 8:12, 22). It seems to have come from the root *עָבַר “to cross over,” possibly alluding to the related Akkadian toponym *eber nāri* “Beyond the River [Euphrates].” The connection with the ethnonym “Hebrews” (עִבְרִיִּים) implied in the post-Priestly editing of the Table of Nations (Gen 10:21) is absent in the genealogy of Shem. The meaning of the name “Peleg” (פֶּלֶג) is unclear. Genesis 10:25 (R) explains the name through an etymological wordplay with the verb *פָּלַג “to divide” and connects this with the Tower of Babel. However, the name’s connection with the Tower of Babel narrative is secondary, already evident from the latter’s use of the verb *פָּרַץ “to scatter” rather than *פָּלַג ni. “to be divided.” However, the derivation from the root *פָּלַג itself, which is also the root of the word פֶּלֶא “canal, ditch,” could still be correct.

³ Ruppert, 522.

11:18–25

- 18** *And Peleg lived 30 years, and he fathered Reu.*
19 *And Peleg lived 209 years after fathering Reu, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
20 *And Reu lived 32 years, and he fathered Serug.*
21 *And Reu lived 207 years after fathering Serug, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
22 *And Serug lived 30 years, and he fathered Nahor.*
23 *And Serug lived 200 years after fathering Nahor, and he fathered sons and daughters.*
24 *And Nahor lived 29 years, and he fathered Terah.*
25 *And Nahor lived 119 years after fathering Terah, and he fathered sons and daughters.*

Across the whole Hebrew Bible, the name “Reu” (רֵעֹ) is found only here and in the parallel account of the genealogies from Gen 5 and 11 in Chronicles (1 Chr 1:25). The meaning is unclear. It may be a short form of the name “Reuel” (רֵעֹאֵל), “friend [רֵעַ] of God” or “friend [of the child] is God,” the name of Moses’s father-in-law (Exod 2:18; Num 10:29) and one of the sons of Esau (Gen 36:4, 10, 13, 17). Serug (שְׂרֹוג), Nahor (נָחוֹר), and Terah (תְּרָח) are probably personal names taken from place names, all of which indicate the area around the northern Mesopotamian city of Haran/Ḥaran (חָרָן, the Hebrew form of the Akkadian *Ḥarrānu(m)*; today Altınbaşak in Turkey, located near the border with Syria).⁴ Serug is unanimously identified with *Sarûgi* (modern Suruç in southeastern Turkey), located halfway between Haran and the Euphrates, and the place name is attested in cuneiform texts from the 7th century BCE. The source of “Terah” is likely *Til ša Turāḫi*, located northeast of Haran and also mentioned in Neo-Assyrian sources. “Nahor,” which is the name of both Abraham’s grandfather (Gen 11:24) and his brother (Gen 11:26–27; 22:20, 23; 24:15; Josh 24:2), seems to come from *Til-Naḥiri*, also located near Haran – even if it is so far only attested in older texts, such as the Old Babylonian letters from Mari in the 18th century BCE, which mention an administrative center *Na-ḫu-ur*. The mention of the city of Nahor in Gen 24 also points to the area around Haran in northern Mesopotamia (see Gen 24:10).

11:26

And Terah lived 70 years, and he fathered Abraham, Nahor, and Haran.

⁴ Hess, 1993, 86–89.

Terah and his three sons, Abram, Nahor, and Haran, are the counterparts to Noah and his three sons in Gen 5:32. If the fathering of Shem, Ham, and Japheth mark the transition from the unified antediluvian humanity to the postdiluvian world of various nations, then the kinship system in the following ancestral history of Israel is already present in Abram, Nahor, and Haran at the conclusion of the Primeval History: Abram is the father of Isaac and Ishmael (Gen 16; 21), Ammon and Moab come from Haran's son, Lot, and Rebecca, the granddaughter of Nahor the Aramean, becomes an ancestor of all of the tribes of Israel as the mother of Jacob (Gen 22:20–23; 24). In many biblical translations, the name “Haran” (הָרָן; see also 1 Chr 23:9) is often transliterated in the same way as the city הָרָן (Haran/*Haran*) mentioned in Gen 11:31f. Because of the difference in the initial phoneme, however, the two names should be differentiated from each other. Neither a scribal mistake from ה (he) to ח (chet) in block Aramaic script nor an ad-hoc formation from the place name are likely possibilities. A derivation from the common Semitic word *har* “mountain” and the name ending *-ānu* is conceivable.⁵ In this case, it would be a short form of a name meaning “[My] god D.N. is a mountain.” The name “Abram” (“Abraham”) is a sentence name, common in Semitic languages, with the elements אָב “father” and the verb רוּם* “to be exalted”: “The [divine] father is exalted.” The Hebrew Bible explains the change from “Abram” to “Abraham” through Abraham (אַבְרָהָם) becoming the “father of a multitude” (אָב הַרְמוֹן) of peoples (Gen 17:4f. [P]) This is a so-called “folk etymology,” in which the additional syllable הֶם is interpreted as a play on the word הֶמוֹן “roar” or “multitude.”

⁵ Hess, 1993, 92–94.

